



me before you



AND

after you



jojo
moyes



Jojo Moyes

ME BEFORE YOU AND AFTER YOU



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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Jojo Moyes is a novelist and a journalist. She worked at the *Independent* for ten years before leaving to write full time. Her previous novels have all been critically acclaimed and include *The Last Letter from Your Lover*, *Ship of Brides*, *Foreign Fruit* and, most recently, *The Girl You Left Behind*. She lives in Essex with her husband and their three children.

THE NUMBER ONE BESTSELLER



jojo moyes



me
before
you

Now
A MAJOR
MOTION
PICTURE

Jojo Moyes

ME BEFORE YOU



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To Charles, with love

Prologue

2007

When he emerges from the bathroom she is awake, propped up against the pillows and flicking through the travel brochures that were beside his bed. She is wearing one of his T-shirts, and her long hair is tousled in a way that prompts reflexive thoughts of the previous night. He stands there, enjoying the brief flashback, rubbing the water from his hair with a towel.

She looks up from a brochure and pouts. She is probably slightly too old to pout, but they've been going out a short enough time for it still to be cute.

'Do we really *have* to do something that involves trekking up mountains, or hanging over ravines? It's our first proper holiday together, and there is literally not one single trip in these that doesn't involve either throwing yourself off something or –' she pretends to shudder '– wearing *fleece*.'

She throws them down on the bed, stretches her caramel-coloured arms above her head. Her voice is husky, testament to their missed hours of sleep. 'How about a luxury spa in Bali? We could lie around on the sand ... spend hours being pampered ... long relaxing nights ... '

'I can't do those sorts of holidays. I need to be doing something.'

'Like throwing yourself out of aeroplanes.'

'Don't knock it till you've tried it.'

She pulls a face. 'If it's all the same to you, I think I'll stick with knocking it.'

His shirt is faintly damp against his skin. He runs a comb through his hair and switches on his mobile phone, wincing at the list of messages that immediately pushes its way through on to the little screen.

'Right,' he says. 'Got to go. Help yourself to breakfast.' He leans over the bed to kiss her. She smells warm and perfumed and deeply sexy. He inhales the scent from the back of her hair, and briefly loses his train of

thought as she wraps her arms around his neck, pulling him down towards the bed.

‘Are we still going away this weekend?’

He extricates himself reluctantly. ‘Depends what happens on this deal. It’s all a bit up in the air at the moment. There’s still a possibility I might have to be in New York. Nice dinner somewhere Thursday, either way? Your choice of restaurant.’ His motorbike leathers are on the back of the door, and he reaches for them.

She narrows her eyes. ‘Dinner. With or without Mr BlackBerry?’

‘What?’

‘Mr BlackBerry makes me feel like Miss Gooseberry.’ The pout again. ‘I feel like there’s always a third person vying for your attention.’

‘I’ll turn it on to silent.’

‘Will Traynor!’ she scolds. ‘You must have some time when you can switch off.’

‘I turned it off last night, didn’t I?’

‘Only under extreme duress.’

He grins. ‘Is that what we’re calling it now?’ He pulls on his leathers. And Lissa’s hold on his imagination is finally broken. He throws his motorbike jacket over his arm, and blows her a kiss as he leaves.

There are twenty-two messages on his BlackBerry, the first of which came in from New York at 3.42am. Some legal problem. He takes the lift down to the underground car park, trying to update himself with the night’s events.

‘Morning, Mr Traynor.’

The security guard steps out of his cubicle. It’s weatherproof, even though down here there is no weather to be protected from. Will sometimes wonders what he does down here in the small hours, staring at the closed-circuit television and the glossy bumpers of £60,000 cars that never get dirty.

He shoulders his way into his leather jacket. ‘What’s it like out there, Mick?’

‘Terrible. Raining cats and dogs.’

Will stops. ‘Really? Not weather for the bike?’

Mick shakes his head. ‘No, sir. Not unless you’ve got an inflatable attachment. Or a death wish.’

Will stares at his bike, then peels himself out of his leathers. No matter what Lissa thinks, he is not a man who believes in taking unnecessary risks. He unlocks the top box of his bike and places the leathers inside, locking it and throwing the keys at Mick, who catches them neatly with one hand.

‘Stick those through my door, will you?’

‘No problem. You want me to call a taxi for you?’

‘No. No point both of us getting wet.’

Mick presses the button to open the automatic grille and Will steps out, lifting a hand in thanks. The early morning is dark and thunderous around him, the Central London traffic already dense and slow despite the fact that it is barely half past seven. He pulls his collar up around his neck and strides down the street towards the junction, from where he is most likely to hail a taxi. The roads are slick with water, the grey light shining on the mirrored pavement.

He curses inwardly as he spies the other suited people standing on the edge of the kerb. Since when did the whole of London begin getting up so early? Everyone has had the same idea.

He is wondering where best to position himself when his phone rings. It is Rupert.

‘I’m on my way in. Just trying to get a cab.’ He catches sight of a taxi with an orange light approaching on the other side of the road, and begins to stride towards it, hoping nobody else has seen. A bus roars past, followed by a lorry whose brakes squeal, deafening him to Rupert’s words. ‘Can’t hear you, Rupe,’ he yells against the noise of the traffic. ‘You’ll have to say that again.’ Briefly marooned on the island, the traffic flowing past him like a current, he can see the orange light glowing, holds up his free hand, hoping that the driver can see him through the heavy rain.

‘You need to call Jeff in New York. He’s still up, waiting for you. We were trying to get you last night.’

‘What’s the problem?’

‘Legal hitch. Two clauses they’re stalling on under section ... signature ... papers ...’ His voice is drowned out by a passing car, its tyres hissing in the wet.

‘I didn’t catch that.’

The taxi has seen him. It is slowing, sending a fine spray of water as it slows on the opposite side of the road. He spies the man further along whose brief sprint slows in disappointment as he sees Will must get there

before him. He feels a sneaking sense of triumph. 'Look, get Cally to have the paperwork on my desk,' he yells. 'I'll be there in ten minutes.'

He glances both ways then ducks his head as he runs the last few steps across the road towards the cab, the word 'Blackfriars' already on his lips. The rain is seeping down the gap between his collar and his shirt. He will be soaked by the time he reaches the office, even walking this short distance. He may have to send his secretary out for another shirt.

'And we need to get this due diligence thing worked out before Martin gets in –'

He glances up at the screeching sound, the rude blare of a horn. He sees the side of the glossy black taxi in front of him, the driver already winding down his window, and at the edge of his field of vision something he can't quite make out, something coming towards him at an impossible speed.

He turns towards it, and in that split second he realizes that he is in its path, that there is no way he is going to be able to get out of its way. His hand opens in surprise, letting the BlackBerry fall to the ground. He hears a shout, which may be his own. The last thing he sees is a leather glove, a face under a helmet, the shock in the man's eyes mirroring his own. There is an explosion as everything fragments.

And then there is nothing.



1

2009

There are 158 footsteps between the bus stop and home, but it can stretch to 180 if you aren't in a hurry, like maybe if you're wearing platform shoes. Or shoes you bought from a charity shop that have butterflies on the toes but never quite grip the heel at the back, thereby explaining why they were a knock-down £1.99. I turned the corner into our street (68 steps), and could just see the house – a four-bedroomed semi in a row of other three- and four-bedroomed semis. Dad's car was outside, which meant he had not yet left for work.

Behind me, the sun was setting behind Stortfold Castle, its dark shadow sliding down the hill like melting wax to overtake me. When I was a child we used to make our elongated shadows have gun battles, our street the O. K. Corral. On a different sort of day, I could have told you all the things that had happened to me on this route: where Dad taught me to ride a bike without stabilizers; where Mrs Doherty with the lopsided wig used to make us Welsh cakes; where Treena stuck her hand into a hedge when she was eleven and disturbed a wasp's nest and we ran screaming all the way back to the castle.

Thomas's tricycle was upturned on the path and, closing the gate behind me, I dragged it under the porch and opened the door. The warmth hit me with the force of an air bag; Mum is a martyr to the cold and keeps the heating on all year round. Dad is always opening windows, complaining

that she'd bankrupt the lot of us. He says our heating bills are larger than the GDP of a small African country.

'That you, love?'

'Yup.' I hung my jacket on the peg, where it fought for space amongst the others.

'Which you? Lou? Treena?'

'Lou.'

I peered round the living-room door. Dad was face down on the sofa, his arm thrust deep between the cushions, as if they had swallowed his limb whole. Thomas, my five-year-old nephew, was on his haunches, watching him intently.

'Lego.' Dad turned his face towards me, puce from exertion. 'Why they have to make the damned pieces so small I don't know. Have you seen Obi-Wan Kenobi's left arm?'

'It was on top of the DVD player. I think he swapped Obi's arms with Indiana Jones's.'

'Well, apparently now Obi can't possibly have beige arms. We have to have the black arms.'

'I wouldn't worry. Doesn't Darth Vader chop his arm off in episode two?' I pointed at my cheek so that Thomas would kiss it. 'Where's Mum?'

'Upstairs. How about that? A two-pound piece!'

I looked up, just able to hear the familiar creak of the ironing board. Josie Clark, my mother, never sat down. It was a point of honour. She had been known to stand on an outside ladder painting the windows, occasionally pausing to wave, while the rest of us ate a roast dinner.

'Will you have a go at finding this bloody arm for me? He's had me looking for half an hour and I've got to get ready for work.'

'Are you on nights?'

'Yeah. It's half five.'

I glanced at the clock. 'Actually, it's half four.'

He extracted his arm from the cushions and squinted at his watch. 'Then what are you doing home so early?'

I shook my head vaguely, as if I might have misunderstood the question, and walked into the kitchen.

Granddad was sitting in his chair by the kitchen window, studying a sudoku. The health visitor had told us it would be good for his concentration, help his focus after the strokes. I suspected I was the only

one to notice he simply filled out all the boxes with whatever number came to mind.

‘Hey, Granddad.’

He looked up and smiled.

‘You want a cup of tea?’

He shook his head, and partially opened his mouth.

‘Cold drink?’

He nodded.

I opened the fridge door. ‘There’s no apple juice.’ Apple juice, I remembered now, was too expensive. ‘Ribena?’

He shook his head.

‘Water?’

He nodded, murmured something that could have been a thank you as I handed him the glass.

My mother walked into the room, bearing a huge basket of neatly folded laundry. ‘Are these yours?’ She brandished a pair of socks.

‘Treena’s, I think.’

‘I thought so. Odd colour. I think they must have got in with Daddy’s plum pyjamas. You’re back early. Are you going somewhere?’

‘No.’ I filled a glass with tap water and drank it.

‘Is Patrick coming round later? He rang here earlier. Did you have your mobile off?’

‘Mm.’

‘He said he’s after booking your holiday. Your father says he saw something on the television about it. Where is it you liked? Ipsos? Kalypsos?’

‘Skiathos.’

‘That’s the one. You want to check your hotel very carefully. Do it on the internet. He and Daddy watched something on the news at lunchtime. Apparently they’re building sites, half of those budget deals, and you wouldn’t know until you got there. Daddy, would you like a cup of tea? Did Lou not offer you one?’ She put the kettle on then glanced up at me. It’s possible she had finally noticed I wasn’t saying anything. ‘Are you all right, love? You look awfully pale.’

She reached out a hand and felt my forehead, as if I were much younger than twenty-six.

‘I don’t think we’re going on holiday.’

My mother's hand stilled. Her gaze had that X-ray thing that it had held since I was a kid. 'Are you and Pat having some problems?'

'Mum, I –'

'I'm not trying to interfere. It's just, you've been together an awful long time. It's only natural if things get a bit sticky every now and then. I mean, me and your father we –'

'I lost my job.'

My voice cut into the silence. The words hung there, searing themselves on the little room long after the sound had died away.

'You what?'

'Frank's shutting down the cafe. From tomorrow.' I held out a hand with the slightly damp envelope I had gripped in shock the entire journey home. All 180 steps from the bus stop. 'He's given me my three months' money.'

The day had started like any other day. Everyone I knew hated Monday mornings, but I never minded them. I liked arriving early at The Buttered Bun, firing up the huge tea urn in the corner, bringing in the crates of milk and bread from the backyard and chatting to Frank as we prepared to open.

I liked the fuggy bacon-scented warmth of the cafe, the little bursts of cool air as the door opened and closed, the low murmur of conversation and, when quiet, Frank's radio singing tinnily to itself in the corner. It wasn't a fashionable place – its walls were covered in scenes from the castle up on the hill, the tables still sported Formica tops, and the menu hadn't altered since I started, apart from a few changes to the chocolate bar selection and the addition of chocolate brownies and muffins to the iced bun tray.

But most of all I liked the customers. I liked Kev and Angelo, the plumbers, who came in most mornings and teased Frank about where his meat might have come from. I liked the Dandelion Lady, nicknamed for her shock of white hair, who ate one egg and chips from Monday to Thursday and sat reading the complimentary newspapers and drinking her way through two cups of tea. I always made an effort to chat with her. I suspected it might be the only conversation the old woman got all day.

I liked the tourists, who stopped on their walk up and down from the castle, the shrieking schoolchildren, who stopped by after school, the regulars from the offices across the road, and Nina and Cherie, the hairdressers, who knew the calorie count of every single item The Buttered

Bun had to offer. Even the annoying customers, like the red-haired woman who ran the toyshop and disputed her change at least once a week, didn't trouble me.

I watched relationships begin and end across those tables, children transferred between divorcees, the guilty relief of those parents who couldn't face cooking, and the secret pleasure of pensioners at a fried breakfast. All human life came through, and most of them shared a few words with me, trading jokes or comments over the mugs of steaming tea. Dad always said he never knew what was going to come out of my mouth next, but in the cafe it didn't matter.

Frank liked me. He was quiet by nature, and said having me there kept the place lively. It was a bit like being a barmaid, but without the hassle of drunks.

And then that afternoon, after the lunchtime rush had ended, and with the place briefly empty, Frank, wiping his hands on his apron, had come out from behind the hotplate and turned the little Closed sign to face the street.

'Now now, Frank, I've told you before. Extras are not included in the minimum wage.' Frank was, as Dad put it, as queer as a blue gnu. I looked up.

He wasn't smiling.

'Uh-oh. I didn't put salt in the sugar cellars again, did I?'

He was twisting a tea towel between his two hands and looked more uncomfortable than I had ever seen him. I wondered, briefly, whether someone had complained about me. And then he motioned to me to sit down.

'Sorry, Louisa,' he said, after he had told me. 'But I'm going back to Australia. My Dad's not too good, and it looks like the castle is definitely going to start doing its own refreshments. The writing's on the wall.'

I think I sat there with my mouth actually hanging open. And then Frank had handed me the envelope, and answered my next question before it left my lips. 'I know we never had, you know, a formal contract or anything, but I wanted to look after you. There's three months' money in there. We close tomorrow.'

'Three months!' Dad exploded, as my mother thrust a cup of sweet tea into my hands. 'Well, that's big of him, given she's worked like a ruddy Trojan in that place for the last six years.'

‘Bernard.’ Mum shot him a warning look, nodding towards Thomas. My parents minded him after school every day until Treena finished work.

‘What the hell is she supposed to do now? He could have given her more than a day’s bloody notice.’

‘Well ... she’ll just have to get another job.’

‘There are no bloody jobs, Josie. You know that as well as I do. We’re in the middle of a bloody recession.’

Mum shut her eyes for a moment, as if composing herself before she spoke. ‘She’s a bright girl. She’ll find herself something. She’s got a solid employment record, hasn’t she? Frank will give her a good reference.’

‘Oh, fecking marvellous ... “Louisa Clark is very good at buttering toast, and a dab hand with the old teapot.”’

‘Thanks for the vote of confidence, Dad.’

‘I’m just saying.’

I knew the real reason for Dad’s anxiety. They relied on my wages. Treena earned next to nothing at the flower shop. Mum couldn’t work, as she had to look after Granddad, and Granddad’s pension amounted to almost nothing. Dad lived in a constant state of anxiety about his job at the furniture factory. His boss had been muttering about possible redundancies for months. There were murmurings at home about debts and the juggling of credit cards. Dad had had his car written off by an uninsured driver two years previously, and somehow this had been enough for the whole teetering edifice that was my parents’ finances to finally collapse. My modest wages had been a little bedrock of housekeeping money, enough to help see the family through from week to week.

‘Let’s not get ahead of ourselves. She can head down to the Job Centre tomorrow and see what’s on offer. She’s got enough to get by for now.’ They spoke as if I weren’t there. ‘And she’s smart. You’re smart, aren’t you, love? Perhaps she could do a typing course. Go into office work.’

I sat there, as my parents discussed what other jobs my limited qualifications might entitle me to. Factory work, machinist, roll butterer. For the first time that afternoon I wanted to cry. Thomas watched me with big, round eyes, and silently handed me half a soggy biscuit.

‘Thanks, Tommo,’ I mouthed silently, and ate it.

He was down at the athletics club, as I had known he would be. Mondays to Thursdays, regular as a station timetable, Patrick was there in the gym or

running in circles around the floodlit track. I made my way down the steps, hugging myself against the cold, and walked slowly out on to the track, waving as he came close enough to see who it was.

‘Run with me,’ he puffed, as he got closer. His breath came in pale clouds. ‘I’ve got four laps to go.’

I hesitated just a moment, and then began to run alongside him. It was the only way I was going to get any kind of conversation out of him. I was wearing my pink trainers with the turquoise laces, the only shoes I could possibly run in.

I had spent the day at home, trying to be useful. I’m guessing it was about an hour before I started to get under my mother’s feet. Mum and Granddad had their routines, and having me there interrupted them. Dad was asleep, as he was on nights this month, and not to be disturbed. I tidied my room, then sat and watched television with the sound down and when I remembered, periodically, why I was at home in the middle of the day I had felt an actual brief pain in my chest.

‘I wasn’t expecting you.’

‘I got fed up at home. I thought maybe we could do something.’

He looked sideways at me. There was a fine film of sweat on his face.

‘The sooner you get another job, babe, the better.’

‘It’s all of twenty-four hours since I lost the last one. Am I allowed to just be a bit miserable and floppy? You know, just for today?’

‘But you’ve got to look at the positive side. You knew you couldn’t stay at that place forever. You want to move upwards, onwards.’ Patrick had been named Stortfold Young Entrepreneur of the Year two years previously, and had not yet quite recovered from the honour. He had since acquired a business partner, Ginger Pete, offering personal training to clients over a 40-mile area, and two liveried vans on the HP. He also had a whiteboard in his office, on which he liked to scrawl his projected turnover with thick black markers, working and reworking the figures until they met with his satisfaction. I was never entirely sure that they bore any resemblance to real life.

‘Being made redundant can change people’s lives, Lou.’ He glanced at his watch, checking his lap time. ‘What do you want to do? You could retrain. I’m sure they do a grant for people like you.’

‘People like me?’

‘People looking for a new opportunity. What do you want to be? You could be a beautician. You’re pretty enough.’ He nudged me as we ran, as if I should be grateful for the compliment.

‘You know my beauty routine. Soap, water, the odd paper bag.’

Patrick was beginning to look exasperated.

I was starting to lag behind. I hate running. I hated him for not slowing down.

‘Look ... shop assistant. Secretary. Estate agent. I don’t know ... there must be something you want to do.’

But there wasn’t. I had liked it in the cafe. I liked knowing everything there was to know about The Buttered Bun, and hearing about the lives of the people who came through it. I had felt comfortable there.

‘You can’t mope around, babe. Got to get over it. All the best entrepreneurs fight their way back from rock bottom. Jeffrey Archer did it. So did Richard Branson.’ He tapped my arm, trying to get me to keep up.

‘I doubt if Jeffrey Archer ever got made redundant from toasting teacakes.’ I was out of breath. And I was wearing the wrong bra. I slowed, dropped my hands down on to my knees.

He turned, running backwards, his voice carrying on the still, cold air. ‘But if he had ... I’m just saying. Sleep on it, put on a smart suit and head down to the Job Centre. Or I’ll train you up to work with me, if you like. You know there’s money in it. And don’t worry about the holiday. I’ll pay.’

I smiled at him.

He blew a kiss and his voice echoed across the empty stadium. ‘You can pay me back when you’re back on your feet.’

I made my first claim for Jobseeker’s Allowance. I attended a 45-minute interview, and a group interview, where I sat with a group of twenty or so mismatched men and women, half of whom wore the same slightly stunned expression I suspected I did, and the other half the blank, uninterested faces of people who had been here too many times before. I wore what my Dad deemed my ‘civilian’ clothes.

As a result of these efforts, I had endured a brief stint filling in on a night shift at a chicken processing factory (it had given me nightmares for weeks), and two days at a training session as a Home Energy Adviser. I had realized pretty quickly that I was essentially being instructed to befuddle old people into switching energy suppliers, and told Syed, my personal

‘adviser’ that I couldn’t do it. He had been insistent that I continue, so I had listed some of the practices that they had asked me to employ, at which point he had gone a bit quiet and suggested we (it was always ‘we’ even though it was pretty obvious that one of us *had* a job) try something else.

I did two weeks at a fast food chain. The hours were okay, I could cope with the fact that the uniform made my hair static, but I found it impossible to stick to the ‘appropriate responses’ script, with its ‘How can I help you today?’ and its ‘Would you like large fries with that?’ I had been let go after one of the doughnut girls caught me debating the varying merits of the free toys with a four-year-old. What can I say? She was a smart four-year-old. I also thought the Sleeping Beauties were sappy.

Now I sat at my fourth interview as Syed scanned through the touch screen for further employment ‘opportunities’. Even Syed, who wore the grimly cheerful demeanour of someone who had shoehorned the most unlikely candidates into a job, was starting to sound a little weary.

‘Um ... Have you ever considered joining the entertainment industry?’

‘What, as in pantomime dame?’

‘Actually, no. But there is an opening for a pole dancer. Several, in fact.’

I raised an eyebrow. ‘Please tell me you are kidding.’

‘It’s thirty hours a week on a self-employed basis. I believe the tips are good.’

‘Please, please tell me you have not just advised me to get a job that involves parading around in front of strangers in my underwear.’

‘You said you were good with people. And you seem to like ... theatrical ... clothing.’ He glanced at my tights, which were green and glittery. I had thought they would cheer me up. Thomas had hummed the theme tune from *The Little Mermaid* at me for almost the whole of breakfast.

Syed tapped something into his keyboard. ‘How about “adult chat line supervisor”?’

I stared at him.

He shrugged. ‘You said you liked talking to people.’

‘No. And no to semi-nude bar staff. Or masseuse. Or webcam operator. Come on, Syed. There must be something I can do that wouldn’t actually give my dad a heart attack.’

This appeared to stump him. ‘There’s not much left outside flexi-hour retail opportunities.’

‘Night-time shelf stacking?’ I had been here enough times now to speak their language.

‘There’s a waiting list. Parents tend to go for it, because it suits the school hours,’ he said apologetically. He studied the screen again. ‘So we’re really left with care assistant.’

‘Wiping old people’s bottoms.’

‘I’m afraid, Louisa, you’re not qualified for much else. If you wanted to retrain, I’d be happy to point you in the right direction. There are plenty of courses at the adult education centre.’

‘But we’ve been through this, Syed. If I do that, I lose my Jobseeker money, right?’

‘If you’re not available for work, yes.’

We sat there in silence for a moment. I gazed at the doors, where two burly security men stood. I wondered if they had got the job through the Job Centre.

‘I’m not good with old people, Syed. My granddad lives at home since he had his strokes, and I can’t cope with him.’

‘Ah. So you have some experience of caring.’

‘Not really. My mum does everything for him.’

‘Would your mum like a job?’

‘Funny.’

‘I’m not being funny.’

‘And leave me looking after my granddad? No thanks. That’s from him, as well as me, by the way. Haven’t you got anything in any cafes?’

‘I don’t think there are enough cafes left to guarantee you employment, Louisa. We could try Kentucky Fried Chicken. You might get on better there.’

‘Because I’d get so much more out of offering a Bargain Bucket than a Chicken McNugget? I don’t think so.’

‘Well, then perhaps we’ll have to look further afield.’

‘There are only four buses to and from our town. You know that. And I know you said I should look into the tourist bus, but I rang the station and it stops at 5pm. Plus it’s twice as expensive as the normal bus.’

Syed sat back in his seat. ‘At this point in proceedings, Louisa, I really need to make the point that as a fit and able person, in order to continue qualifying for your allowance, you need –’

‘– to show that I’m trying to get a job. I know.’

How could I explain to this man how much I wanted to work? Did he have the slightest idea how much I missed my old job? Unemployment had been a concept, something droningly referred to on the news in relation to shipyards or car factories. I had never considered that you might miss a job like you missed a limb – a constant, reflexive thing. I hadn't thought that as well as the obvious fears about money, and your future, losing your job would make you feel inadequate, and a bit useless. That it would be harder to get up in the morning than when you were rudely shocked into consciousness by the alarm. That you might miss the people you worked with, no matter how little you had in common with them. Or even that you might find yourself searching for familiar faces as you walked the high street. The first time I had seen the Dandelion Lady wandering past the shops, looking as aimless as I felt, I had fought the urge to go and give her a hug.

Syed's voice broke into my reverie. 'Aha. Now this might work.'

I tried to peer round at the screen.

'Just come in. This very minute. Care assistant position.'

'I told you I was no good with –'

'It's not old people. It's a ... a private position. To help in someone's house, and the address is less than two miles from your home. "Care and companionship for a disabled man." Can you drive?'

'Yes. But would I have to wipe his –'

'No bottom wiping required, as far as I can tell.' He scanned the screen. 'He's a ... a quadriplegic. He needs someone in the daylight hours to help feed and assist. Often in these jobs it's a case of being there when they want to go out somewhere, helping with basic stuff that they can't do themselves. Oh. It's good money. Quite a lot more than the minimum wage.'

'That's probably because it involves bottom wiping.'

'I'll ring them to confirm the absence of bottom wiping. But if that's the case, you'll go along for the interview?'

He said it like it was a question.

But we both knew the answer.

I sighed, and gathered up my bag ready for the trip home.

'Jesus Christ,' said my father. 'Can you imagine? If it wasn't punishment enough ending up in a ruddy wheelchair, then you get our Lou turning up to keep you company.'

‘Bernard!’ my mother scolded.

Behind me, Granddad was laughing into his mug of tea.



2

I am not thick. I'd just like to get that out of the way at this point. But it's quite hard not to feel a bit deficient in the Department of Brain Cells, growing up next to a younger sister who was not just moved up a year into my class, but then to the year above.

Everything that is sensible, or smart, Katrina did first, despite being eighteen months younger than me. Every book I ever read she had read first, every fact I mentioned at the dinner table she already knew. She is the only person I know who actually likes exams. Sometimes I think I dress the way I do because the one thing Treena can't do is put clothes together. She's a pullover and jeans kind of a girl. Her idea of smart is ironing the jeans first.

My father calls me a 'character', because I tend to say the first thing that pops into my head. He says I'm like my Aunt Lily, who I never knew. It's a bit weird, constantly being compared to someone you've never met. I would come downstairs in purple boots, and Dad would nod at Mum and say, 'D'you remember Aunt Lily and her purple boots, eh?' and Mum would cluck and start laughing as if at some secret joke. My mother calls me 'individual', which is her polite way of not quite understanding the way I dress.

But apart from a brief period in my teens, I never wanted to look like Treena, or any of the girls at school; I preferred boys' clothes till I was about fourteen, and now tend to please myself – depending on what mood I am in on the day. There's no point me trying to look conventional. I am

small, dark-haired and, according to my dad, have the face of an elf. That's not as in 'elfin beauty'. I am not plain, but I don't think anyone is ever going to call me beautiful. I don't have that graceful thing going on. Patrick calls me gorgeous when he wants to get his leg over, but he's fairly transparent like that. We've known each other for coming up to seven years.

I was twenty-six years old and I wasn't really sure what I was. Up until I lost my job I hadn't even given it any thought. I supposed I would probably marry Patrick, knock out a few kids, live a few streets away from where I had always lived. Apart from an exotic taste in clothes, and the fact that I'm a bit short, there's not a lot separating me from anyone you might pass in the street. You probably wouldn't look at me twice. An ordinary girl, leading an ordinary life. It actually suited me fine.

'You must wear a suit to an interview,' Mum had insisted. 'Everyone's far too casual these days.'

'Because wearing pinstripes will be vital if I'm spoon-feeding a geriatric.'

'Don't be smart.'

'I can't afford to buy a suit. What if I don't get the job?'

'You can wear mine, and I'll iron you a nice blouse, and just for once don't wear your hair up in those –' she gestured to my hair, which was normally twisted into two dark knots on each side of my head '– Princess Leia things. Just try to look like a normal person.'

I knew better than to argue with my mother. And I could tell Dad had been instructed not to comment on my outfit as I walked out of the house, my gait awkward in the too-tight skirt.

'Bye love,' he said, the corners of his mouth twitching. 'Good luck now. You look very ... businesslike.'

The embarrassing thing was not that I was wearing my mother's suit, or that it was in a cut last fashionable in the late 1980s, but that it was actually a tiny bit small for me. I felt the waistband cutting into my midriff, and pulled the double-breasted jacket across. As Dad says of Mum, there's more fat on a kirby grip.

I sat through the short bus journey feeling faintly sick. I had never had a proper job interview. I had joined The Buttered Bun after Treena bet me that I couldn't get a job in a day. I had walked in and simply asked Frank if

he needed a spare pair of hands. It had been his first day open and he had looked almost blinded by gratitude.

Now, looking back, I couldn't even remember having a discussion with him about money. He suggested a weekly wage, I agreed, and once a year he told me he'd upped it a bit, usually by a little more than I would have asked for.

What did people ask in interviews anyway? And what if they asked me to do something practical with this old man, to feed him or bath him or something? Syed had said there was a male carer who covered his 'intimate needs' (I shuddered at the phrase). The secondary carer's job was, he said, 'a little unclear at this point'. I pictured myself wiping drool from the old man's mouth, maybe asking loudly, 'DID HE WANT A CUP OF TEA?'

When Granddad had first begun his recovery from his strokes he hadn't been able to do anything for himself. Mum had done it all. 'Your mother is a saint,' Dad said, which I took to mean that she wiped his bum without running screaming from the house. I was pretty sure nobody had ever described me as such. I cut Granddad's food up for him and made him cups of tea but as for anything else, I wasn't sure I was made of the right ingredients.

Granta House was on the other side of Stortfold Castle, close to the medieval walls, on the long unpaved stretch that comprised only four houses and the National Trust shop, bang in the middle of the tourist area. I had passed this house a million times in my life without ever actually properly seeing it. Now, walking past the car park and the miniature railway, both of which were empty and as bleak as only a summer attraction can look in February, I saw it was bigger than I had imagined, red brick with a double front, the kind of house you saw in old copies of *Country Life* while waiting at the doctor's.

I walked up the long drive, trying not to think about whether anybody was watching out of the window. Walking up a long drive puts you at a disadvantage; it automatically makes you feel inferior. I was just contemplating whether to actually tug at my forelock, when the door opened and I jumped.

A woman, not much older than me, stepped out into the porch. She was wearing white slacks and a medical-looking tunic and carried a coat and a folder under her arm. As she passed me she gave a polite smile.

‘And thank you so much for coming,’ a voice said, from inside. ‘We’ll be in touch. Ah.’ A woman’s face appeared, middle-aged but beautiful, under expensive precision-cut hair. She was wearing a trouser suit that I guessed cost more than my dad earned in a month.

‘You must be Miss Clark.’

‘Louisa.’ I shot out a hand, as my mother had impressed upon me to do. The young people never offered up a hand these days, my parents had agreed. In the old days you wouldn’t have dreamt of a ‘hiya’ or, worse, an air kiss. This woman did not look like she would have welcomed an air kiss.

‘Right. Yes. Do come in.’ She withdrew her hand from mine as soon as humanly possible, but I felt her eyes linger upon me, as if she were already assessing me.

‘Would you like to come through? We’ll talk in the drawing room. My name is Camilla Traynor.’ She seemed weary, as if she had uttered the same words many times that day already.

I followed her through to a huge room with floor to ceiling French windows. Heavy curtains draped elegantly from fat mahogany curtain poles, and the floors were carpeted with intricately decorated Persian rugs. It smelt of beeswax and antique furniture. There were little elegant side tables everywhere, their burnished surfaces covered with ornamental boxes. I wondered briefly where on earth the Traynors put their cups of tea.

‘So you have come via the Job Centre advertisement, is that right? Do sit down.’

While she flicked through her folder of papers, I gazed surreptitiously around the room. I had thought the house might be a bit like a care home, all hoists and wipe-clean surfaces. But this was like one of those scarily expensive hotels, steeped in old money, with well-loved things that looked valuable in their own right. There were silver-framed photographs on a sideboard, but they were too far away for me to make out the faces. As she scanned her pages, I shifted in my seat, to try to get a better look.

And it was then that I heard it – the unmistakable sound of stitches ripping. I glanced down to see the two pieces of material that joined at the side of my right leg had torn apart, sending frayed pieces of silk thread shooting upwards in an ungainly fringe. I felt my face flood with colour.

‘So ... Miss Clark ... do you have any experience with quadriplegia?’

I turned to face Mrs Traynor, wriggling so that my jacket covered as much of the skirt as possible.

‘No.’

‘Have you been a carer for long?’

‘Um ... I’ve never actually done it,’ I said, adding, as if I could hear Syed’s voice in my ear, ‘but I’m sure I could learn.’

‘Do you know what a quadriplegic is?’

I faltered. ‘When ... you’re stuck in a wheelchair?’

‘I suppose that’s one way of putting it. There are varying degrees, but in this case we are talking about complete loss of use of the legs, and very limited use of the hands and arms. Would that bother you?’

‘Well, not as much as it would bother him, obviously.’ I raised a smile, but Mrs Traynor’s face was expressionless. ‘Sorry – I didn’t mean –’

‘Can you drive, Miss Clark?’

‘Yes.’

‘Clean licence?’

I nodded.

Camilla Traynor ticked something on her list.

The rip was growing. I could see it creeping inexorably up my thigh. At this rate, by the time I stood up I would look like a Vegas showgirl.

‘Are you all right?’ Mrs Traynor was gazing at me.

‘I’m just a little warm. Do you mind if I take my jacket off?’ Before she could say anything, I wrenched the jacket off in one fluid motion and tied it around my waist, obscuring the split in the skirt. ‘So hot,’ I said, smiling at her, ‘coming in from outside. You know.’

There was the faintest pause, and then Mrs Traynor looked back at her folder. ‘How old are you?’

‘I’m twenty-six.’

‘And you were in your previous job for six years.’

‘Yes. You should have a copy of my reference.’

‘Mm ...’ Mrs Traynor held it up and squinted. ‘Your previous employer says you are a “warm, chatty and life-enhancing presence”.’

‘Yes, I paid him.’

That poker face again.

Oh hell, I thought.

It was as if I were being studied. Not necessarily in a good way. My mother’s shirt felt suddenly cheap, the synthetic threads shining in the thin

light. I should just have worn my plainest trousers and a shirt. Anything but this suit.

‘So why are you leaving this job, where you are clearly so well regarded?’

‘Frank – the owner – sold the cafe. It’s the one at the bottom of the castle. The Buttered Bun. Was,’ I corrected myself. ‘I would have been happy to stay.’

Mrs Traynor nodded, either because she didn’t feel the need to say anything further about it, or because she too would have been happy for me to stay there.

‘And what exactly do you want to do with your life?’

‘I’m sorry?’

‘Do you have aspirations for a career? Would this be a stepping stone to something else? Do you have a professional dream that you wish to pursue?’

I looked at her blankly.

Was this some kind of trick question?

‘I ... I haven’t really thought that far. Since I lost my job. I just –’ I swallowed. ‘I just want to work again.’

It sounded feeble. What kind of person came to an interview without even knowing what she wanted to do? Mrs Traynor’s expression suggested she thought the same thing.

She put down her pen. ‘So, Miss Clark, why should I employ you instead of, say, the previous candidate, who has several years’ experience with quadriplegics?’

I looked at her. ‘Um ... honestly? I don’t know.’ This met with silence, so I added, ‘I guess that would be your call.’

‘You can’t give me a *single reason* why I should employ you?’

My mother’s face suddenly swam into view. The thought of going home with a ruined suit and another interview failure was beyond me. And this job paid more than £9 an hour.

I sat up a bit. ‘Well ... I’m a fast learner, I’m never ill, I only live on the other side of the castle, and I’m stronger than I look ... probably strong enough to help move your husband around –’

‘My husband? It’s not my husband you’d be working with. It’s my son.’

‘Your son?’ I blinked. ‘Um ... I’m not afraid of hard work. I’m good at dealing with all sorts of people and ... and I make a mean cup of tea.’ I

began to blather into the silence. The thought of it being her son had thrown me. 'I mean, my dad seems to think that's not the greatest reference. But in my experience there's not much that can't be fixed by a decent cup of tea ...'

There was something a bit strange about the way Mrs Traynor was looking at me.

'Sorry,' I spluttered, as I realized what I had said. 'I'm not suggesting the thing ... the paraplegia ... quadriplegia ... with ... your son ... could be solved by a cup of tea.'

'I should tell you, Miss Clark, that this is not a permanent contract. It would be for a maximum of six months. That is why the salary is ... commensurate. We wanted to attract the right person.'

'Believe me, when you've done shifts at a chicken processing factory, working in Guantánamo Bay for six months looks attractive.' *Oh, shut up, Louisa.* I bit my lip.

But Mrs Traynor seemed oblivious. She closed her file. 'My son – Will – was injured in a road accident almost two years ago. He requires twenty-four-hour care, the majority of which is provided by a trained nurse. I have recently returned to work, and the carer would be required to be here throughout the day to keep him company, help him with food and drink, generally provide an extra pair of hands, and make sure that he comes to no harm.' Camilla Traynor looked down at her lap. 'It is of the utmost importance that Will has someone here who understands that responsibility.'

Everything she said, even the way she emphasized her words, seemed to hint at some stupidity on my part.

'I can see that.' I began to gather up my bag.

'So would you like the job?'

It was so unexpected that at first I thought I had heard her wrong. 'Sorry?'

'We would need you to start as soon as possible. Payment will be weekly.'

I was briefly lost for words. 'You'd rather have me instead of –' I began.

'The hours are quite lengthy – 8am till 5pm, sometimes later. There is no lunch break as such, although when Nathan, his daily nurse, comes in at lunchtime to attend to him, there should be a free half an hour.'

'You wouldn't need anything ... medical?'

‘Will has all the medical care we can offer him. What we want for him is somebody robust ... and upbeat. His life is ... complicated, and it is important that he is encouraged to –’ She broke off, her gaze fixed on something outside the French windows. Finally, she turned back to me. ‘Well, let’s just say that his mental welfare is as important to us as his physical welfare. Do you understand?’

‘I think so. Would I ... wear a uniform?’

‘No. Definitely no uniform.’ She glanced at my legs. ‘Although you might want to wear ... something a bit less revealing.’

I glanced down to where my jacket had shifted, revealing a generous expanse of bare thigh. ‘It ... I’m sorry. It ripped. It’s not actually mine.’

But Mrs Traynor no longer appeared to be listening. ‘I’ll explain what needs doing when you start. Will is not the easiest person to be around at the moment, Miss Clark. This job is going to be about mental attitude as much as any ... professional skills you might have. So. We will see you tomorrow?’

‘Tomorrow? You don’t want ... you don’t want me to meet him?’

‘Will is not having a good day. I think it’s best that we start afresh then.’

I stood up, realizing Mrs Traynor was already waiting to see me out.

‘Yes,’ I said, tugging Mum’s jacket across me. ‘Um. Thank you. I’ll see you at eight o’clock tomorrow.’

Mum was spooning potatoes on to Dad’s plate. She put two on, he parried, lifting a third and fourth from the serving dish. She blocked him, steering them back on to the serving dish, finally rapping him on the knuckles with the serving spoon when he made for them again. Around the little table sat my parents, my sister and Thomas, my granddad, and Patrick – who always came for dinner on Wednesdays.

‘Daddy,’ Mum said to Granddad. ‘Would you like someone to cut your meat? Treena, will you cut Daddy’s meat?’

Treena leant across and began slicing at Granddad’s plate with deft strokes. On the other side she had already done the same for Thomas.

‘So how messed up is this man, Lou?’

‘Can’t be up to much if they’re willing to let our daughter loose on him,’ Bernard remarked. Behind me, the television was on so that Dad and Patrick could watch the football. Every now and then they would stop,

peering round me, their mouths stopping mid-chew as they watched some pass or near miss.

‘I think it’s a great opportunity. She’ll be working in one of the big houses. For a good family. Are they posh, love?’

In our street ‘posh’ could mean anyone who hadn’t got a family member in possession of an ASBO.

‘I suppose so.’

‘Hope you’ve practised your curtsy.’ Dad grinned.

‘Did you actually meet him?’ Treena leant across to stop Thomas elbowing his juice on to the floor. ‘The crippled man? What was he like?’

‘I meet him tomorrow.’

‘Weird, though. You’ll be spending all day every day with him. Nine hours. You’ll see him more than you see Patrick.’

‘That’s not hard,’ I said.

Patrick, across the table, pretended he couldn’t hear me.

‘Still, you won’t have to worry about the old sexual harassment, eh?’ Dad said.

‘Bernard!’ said my mother, sharply.

‘I’m only saying what everyone’s thinking. Probably the best boss you could find for your girlfriend, eh, Patrick?’

Across the table, Patrick smiled. He was busy refusing potatoes, despite Mum’s best efforts. He was having a non-carb month, ready for a marathon in early March.

‘You know, I was thinking, will you have to learn sign language? I mean, if he can’t communicate, how will you know what he wants?’

‘She didn’t say he couldn’t talk, Mum.’ I couldn’t actually remember *what* Mrs Traynor had said. I was still vaguely in shock at actually having been given a job.

‘Maybe he talks through one of those devices. Like that scientist bloke. The one on *The Simpsons*.’

‘Bugger,’ said Thomas.

‘Nope,’ said Bernard.

‘Stephen Hawking,’ said Patrick.

‘That’s you, that is,’ Mum said, looking accusingly from Thomas to Dad. She could cut steak with that look. ‘Teaching him bad language.’

‘It is not. I don’t know where he’s getting it from.’

‘Bugger,’ said Thomas, looking directly at his grandfather.

Treena made a face. 'I think it would freak me out, if he talked through one of those voice boxes. Can you imagine? *Get-me-a-drink-of-water*,' she mimicked.

Bright – but not bright enough not to get herself up the duff, as Dad occasionally muttered. She had been the first member of our family to go to university, until Thomas's arrival had caused her to drop out during her final year. Mum and Dad still held out hopes that one day she would bring the family a fortune. Or possibly work in a place with a reception desk that didn't have a security screen around it. Either would do.

'Why would being in a wheelchair mean he had to speak like a Dalek?' I said.

'But you're going to have to get up close and personal to him. At the very least you'll have to wipe his mouth and give him drinks and stuff.'

'So? It's hardly rocket science.'

'Says the woman who used to put Thomas's nappy on inside out.'

'That was once.'

'Twice. And you only changed him three times.'

I helped myself to green beans, trying to look more sanguine than I felt.

But even as I had ridden the bus home, the same thoughts had already started buzzing around my head. What would we talk about? What if he just stared at me, head lolling, all day? Would I be freaked out? What if I couldn't understand what it was he wanted? I was legendarily bad at caring for things; we no longer had houseplants at home, or pets, after the disasters that were the hamster, the stick insects and Randolph the goldfish. And how often was that stiff mother of his going to be around? I didn't like the thought of being watched all the time. Mrs Traynor seemed like the kind of woman whose gaze turned capable hands into fingers and thumbs.

'Patrick, what do you think of it all, then?'

Patrick took a long slug of water, and shrugged.

Outside, the rain beat on the windowpanes, just audible over the clatter of plates and cutlery.

'It's good money, Bernard. Better than working nights at the chicken factory, anyway.'

There was a general murmur of agreement around the table.

'Well, it comes to something when the best you can all say about my new career is that it's better than hauling chicken carcasses around the inside of an aircraft hangar,' I said.

‘Well, you could always get fit in the meantime and go and do some of your personal training stuff with Patrick here.’

‘Get fit. Thanks, Dad.’ I had been about to reach for another potato, and now changed my mind.

‘Well, why not?’ Mum looked as if she might actually sit down – everyone paused briefly, but no, she was up again, helping Granddad to some gravy. ‘It might be worth bearing in mind for the future. You’ve certainly got the gift of the gab.’

‘She has the gift of the flab.’ Dad snorted.

‘I’ve just *got* myself a job,’ I said. ‘Paying more than the last one too, if you don’t mind.’

‘But it is only temporary,’ Patrick interjected. ‘Your Dad’s right. You might want to start getting in shape while you do it. You could be a good personal trainer, if you put in a bit of effort.’

‘I don’t *want* to be a personal trainer. I don’t fancy ... all that ... bouncing.’ I mouthed an insult at Patrick, who grinned.

‘What Lou wants is a job where she can put her feet up and watch daytime telly while feeding old Ironside there through a straw,’ said Treena.

‘Yes. Because rearranging limp dahlias into buckets of water requires so much physical and mental effort, doesn’t it, Treen?’

‘We’re teasing you, love.’ Dad raised his mug of tea. ‘It’s great that you’ve got a job. We’re proud of you already. And I bet you, once you slide those feet of yours under the table at the big house those buggers won’t want to get rid of you.’

‘Bugger,’ said Thomas.

‘Not me,’ said Dad, chewing, before Mum could say a thing.



3

‘This is the annexe. It used to be stables, but we realized it would suit Will rather better than the house as it’s all on one floor. This is the spare room so that Nathan can stay over if necessary. We needed someone quite often in the early days.’

Mrs Traynor walked briskly down the corridor, gesturing from one doorway to the other, without looking back, her high heels clacking on the flagstones. There seemed to be an expectation that I would keep up.

‘The keys to the car are here. I’ve put you on our insurance. I’m trusting the details you gave me were correct. Nathan should be able to show you how the ramp works. All you have to do is help Will position properly and the vehicle will do the rest. Although ... he’s not desperately keen to go anywhere at the moment.’

‘It is a bit chilly out,’ I said.

Mrs Traynor didn’t seem to hear me.

‘You can make yourself tea and coffee in the kitchen. I keep the cupboards stocked. The bathroom is through here –’

She opened the door and I stared at the white metal and plastic hoist that crouched over the bath. There was an open wet area under the shower, with a folded wheelchair beside it. In the corner a glass-fronted cabinet revealed neat stacks of shrink-wrapped bales. I couldn’t see what they were from here, but it all gave off a faint scent of disinfectant.

Mrs Traynor closed the door, and turned briefly to face me. ‘I should reiterate, it is very important that Will has someone with him all the time. A

previous carer disappeared for several hours once to get her car fixed, and Will ... injured himself in her absence.' She swallowed, as if still traumatized by the memory.

'I won't go anywhere.'

'Of course you will need ... comfort breaks. I just want to make it clear that he can't be left for periods longer than, say, ten or fifteen minutes. If something unavoidable comes up either ring the intercom, as my husband, Steven, may be home, or call my mobile number. If you do need to take any time off, I would appreciate as much notice as possible. It is not always easy finding cover.'

'No.'

Mrs Traynor opened the hall cupboard. She spoke like someone reciting a well-rehearsed speech.

I wondered briefly how many carers there had been before me.

'If Will is occupied, then it would be helpful if you could do some basic housekeeping. Wash bedding, run a vacuum cleaner around, that sort of thing. The cleaning equipment is under the sink. He may not want you around him all the time. You and he will have to work out your level of interaction for yourselves.'

Mrs Traynor looked at my clothes, as if for the first time. I was wearing the very shaggy waistcoat thing that Dad says makes me look like an emu. I tried to smile. It seemed like an effort.

'Obviously I would hope that you could ... get on with each other. It would be nice if he could think of you as a friend rather than a paid professional.'

'Right. What does he ... um ... like to do?'

'He watches films. Sometimes he listens to the radio, or to music. He has one of those digital things. If you position it near his hand, he can usually manipulate it himself. He has some movement in his fingers, although he finds it hard to grip.'

I felt myself brightening. If he liked music and films, surely we could find some common ground? I had a sudden picture of myself and this man laughing at some Hollywood comedy, me running the Hoover around the bedroom while he listened to his music. Perhaps this was going to be okay. Perhaps we might end up as friends. I had never had a disabled friend before – only Treen's friend David, who was deaf, but would put you in a headlock if you suggested that meant disabled.

‘Do you have any questions?’

‘No.’

‘Then let’s go and introduce you.’ She glanced at her watch. ‘Nathan should have finished dressing him now.’

We hesitated outside the door and Mrs Traynor knocked. ‘Are you in there? I have Miss Clark to meet you, Will.’

There was no answer.

‘Will? Nathan?’

A broad New Zealand accent. ‘He’s decent, Mrs T.’

She pushed open the door. The annexe’s living room was deceptively large, and one wall consisted entirely of glass doors that looked out over open countryside. A wood burner glowed quietly in the corner, and a low beige sofa faced a huge flat-screen television, its seats covered by a wool throw. The mood of the room was tasteful, and peaceful – a Scandinavian bachelor pad.

In the centre of the room stood a black wheelchair, its seat and back cushioned by sheepskin. A solidly built man in white collarless scrubs was crouching down, adjusting a man’s feet on the footrests of the wheelchair. As we stepped into the room, the man in the wheelchair looked up from under shaggy, unkempt hair. His eyes met mine and after a pause, he let out a bloodcurdling groan. Then his mouth twisted, and he let out another unearthly cry.

I felt his mother stiffen.

‘Will, stop it!’

He didn’t even glance towards her. Another prehistoric sound emerged from somewhere near his chest. It was a terrible, agonizing noise. I tried not to flinch. The man was grimacing, his head tilted and sunk into his shoulders as he stared at me through contorted features. He looked grotesque, and vaguely angry. I realized that where I held my bag, my knuckles had turned white.

‘Will! Please.’ There was a faint note of hysteria in his mother’s voice. ‘Please, don’t do this.’

Oh God, I thought. *I’m not up to this*. I swallowed, hard. The man was still staring at me. He seemed to be waiting for me to do something.

‘I – I’m Lou.’ My voice, uncharacteristically tremulous, broke into the silence. I wondered, briefly, whether to hold out a hand and then,

remembering that he wouldn't be able to take it, gave a feeble wave instead. 'Short for Louisa.'

Then to my astonishment his features cleared, and his head straightened on his shoulders.

Will Traynor gazed at me steadily, the faintest of smiles flickering across his face. 'Good morning, Miss Clark,' he said. 'I hear you're my latest minder.'

Nathan had finished adjusting the footrests. He shook his head as he stood up. 'You are a bad man, Mr T. Very bad.' He grinned, and held out a broad hand, which I shook limply. Nathan exuded an air of unflappability. 'I'm afraid you just got Will's best Christy Brown impression. You'll get used to him. His bark is worse than his bite.'

Mrs Traynor was holding the cross at her neck with slim white fingers. She moved it backwards and forwards along its thin gold chain, a nervous habit. Her face was rigid. 'I'll leave you all to get on. You can call through using the intercom if you need any help. Nathan will talk you through Will's routines, and his equipment.'

'I'm here, mother. You don't have to talk across me. My brain isn't paralysed. Yet.'

'Yes, well, if you're going to be foul, Will, I think it's best if Miss Clark does talk directly to Nathan.' His mother wouldn't look at him as she spoke, I noticed. She kept her gaze about ten feet away on the floor. 'I'm working from home today. So I'll pop in at lunchtime, Miss Clark.'

'Okay.' My voice emerged as a squawk.

Mrs Traynor disappeared. We were silent while we listened to her clipped footsteps disappearing down the hall towards the main house.

Then Nathan broke the silence. 'You mind if I go and talk Miss Clark through your meds, Will? You want the television? Some music?'

'Radio Four please, Nathan.'

'Sure thing.'

We walked through to the kitchen.

'You not had much experience with quadriplegics, Mrs T says?'

'No.'

'Okay. I'll keep it fairly simple for today. There's a folder here that tells you pretty much everything you need to know about Will's routines, and all his emergency numbers. I'd advise you to read it, if you get a spare moment. I'm guessing you'll have a few.'

Nathan took a key from his belt and opened a locked cabinet, which was packed full of boxes and small plastic canisters of medication. 'Right. This lot is mostly my bag, but you do need to know where everything is in case of emergencies. There's a timetable there on the wall so you can see what he has when on a daily basis. Any extras you give him you mark in there –' he pointed '– but you're best to clear anything through Mrs T, at least at this stage.'

'I didn't realize I was going to have to handle drugs.'

'It's not hard. He mostly knows what he needs. But he might need a little help getting them down. We tend to use this beaker here. Or you can crush them with this pestle and mortar and put them in a drink.'

I picked up one of the labels. I wasn't sure I had ever seen so many drugs outside a pharmacy.

'Okay. So he has two meds for blood pressure, this to lower it at bedtime, this one to raise it when he gets out of bed. These he needs fairly often to control his muscular spasms – you will need to give him one mid-morning, and again at mid-afternoon. He doesn't find those too hard to swallow, because they're the little coated ones. These are for bladder spasms, and these here are for acid reflux. He sometimes needs these after eating if he gets uncomfortable. This is his antihistamine for the morning, and these are his nasal sprays, but I mostly do those last thing before I leave, so you shouldn't have to worry. He can have paracetamol if he's in pain, and he does have the odd sleeping pill, but these tend to make him more irritable in the daytime, so we try to restrict them.

'These –' he held up another bottle '– are the antibiotics he has every two weeks for his catheter change. I do those unless I'm away, in which case I'll leave clear instructions. They're pretty strong. There are the boxes of rubber gloves, if you need to clean him up at all. There's also cream there if he gets sore, but he's been pretty good since we got the air mattress.'

As I stood there, he reached into his pocket and handed another key to me. 'This is the spare,' he said. 'Not to be given to anyone else. Not even Will, okay? Guard it with your life.'

'It's a lot to remember.' I swallowed.

'It's all written down. All you need to remember for today are his anti-spasm meds. Those ones. There's my mobile number if you need to call me. I'm studying when I'm not here, so I'd rather not be called too often but feel free till you feel confident.'

I stared at the folder in front of me. It felt like I was about to sit an exam I hadn't prepared for. 'What if he needs ... to go to the loo?' I thought of the hoist. 'I'm not sure I could, you know, lift him.' I tried not to let my face betray my panic.

Nathan shook his head. 'You don't need to do any of that. His catheter takes care of that. I'll be in at lunchtime to change it all. You're not here for the physical stuff.'

'What am I here for?'

Nathan studied the floor before he looked at me. 'Try to cheer him up a little? He's ... he's a little cranky. Understandable, given ... the circumstances. But you're going to have to have a fairly thick skin. That little skit this morning is his way of getting you off balance.'

'Is this why the pay is so good?'

'Oh yes. No such thing as a free lunch, eh?' Nathan clapped me on the shoulder. I felt my body reverberate with it. 'Ah, he's all right. You don't have to pussyfoot around him.' He hesitated. 'I like him.'

He said it like he might be the only person who did.

I followed him back into the living room. Will Traynor's chair had moved to the window, and he had his back to us and was staring out, listening to something on the radio.

'That's me done, Will. You want anything before I go?'

'No. Thank you, Nathan.'

'I'll leave you in Miss Clark's capable hands, then. See you lunchtime, mate.'

I watched the affable helper putting on his jacket with a rising sense of panic.

'Have fun, you guys.' Nathan winked at me, and then he was gone.

I stood in the middle of the room, hands thrust in my pockets, unsure what to do. Will Traynor continued to stare out of the window as if I weren't there.

'Would you like me to make you a cup of tea?' I said, finally, when the silence became unbearable.

'Ah. Yes. The girl who makes tea for a living. I wondered how long it would be before you wanted to show off your skills. No. No, thank you.'

'Coffee, then?'

'No hot beverages for me, just now, Miss Clark.'

'You can call me Lou.'

‘Will it help?’

I blinked, my mouth opening briefly. I closed it. Dad always said it made me look more stupid than I actually was. ‘Well ... can I get you anything?’

He turned to look at me. His jaw was covered in several weeks of stubble, and his eyes were unreadable. He turned away.

‘I’ll –’ I cast around the room. ‘I’ll see if there’s any washing, then.’

I walked out of the room, my heart thumping. From the safety of the kitchen I pulled out my mobile phone and thumped out a message to my sister.

This is awful. He hates me.

The reply came back within seconds.

You have only been there an hour,
you wuss! M & D really
worried about money. Just get a grip
& think of hourly rate. X

I snapped my mobile phone shut, and blew out my cheeks. I went through the laundry basket in the bathroom, managing to raise a paltry quarter load of washing, and spent some minutes checking the instructions to the machine. I didn’t want to mis-programme it or do anything which might prompt Will or Mrs Traynor to look at me like I was stupid again. I started the washing machine and stood there, trying to work out what else I could legitimately do. I pulled the vacuum cleaner from the hall cupboard and ran it up and down the corridor and into the two bedrooms, thinking all the while that if my parents could see me they would have insisted on taking a commemorative photograph. The spare bedroom was almost empty, like a hotel room. I suspected Nathan did not stay over often. I thought I probably couldn’t blame him.

I hesitated outside Will Traynor’s bedroom, then reasoned that it needed vacuuming just like anywhere else. There was a built-in shelf unit along one side, upon which sat around twenty framed photographs.

As I vacuumed around the bed, I allowed myself a quick peek at them. There was a man bungee jumping from a cliff, his arms outstretched like a statue of Christ. There was a man who might have been Will in what looked like jungle, and him again in the midst of a group of drunken friends. The men wore bow ties and dinner jackets and had their arms around each other’s shoulders.

There he was on a ski slope, beside a girl with dark glasses and long blonde hair. I stooped, to get a better view of him in his ski goggles. He was clean-shaven in the photograph, and even in the bright light his face had that expensive sheen to it that moneyed people get through going on holiday three times a year. He had broad, muscular shoulders visible even through his ski jacket. I put the photograph carefully back on the table and continued to vacuum around the back of the bed. Finally, I turned the vacuum cleaner off, and began to wind the cord up. As I reached down to unplug it, I caught a movement in the corner of my eye and jumped, letting out a small shriek. Will Traynor was in the doorway, watching me.

‘Courchevel. Two and a half years ago.’

I blushed. ‘I’m sorry. I was just –’

‘You were just looking at my photographs. Wondering how awful it must be to live like that and then turn into a cripple.’

‘No.’ I blushed even more furiously.

‘The rest of my photographs are in the bottom drawer if you find yourself overcome with curiosity again,’ he said.

And then with a low hum the wheelchair turned to the right, and he disappeared.

The morning sagged and decided to last for several years. I couldn’t remember the last time minutes and hours stretched so interminably. I tried to find as many jobs to occupy myself as I could, and went into the living room as seldom as possible, knowing I was being cowardly, but not really caring.

At eleven I brought Will Traynor a beaker of water and his anti-spasm medication, as Nathan had requested. I placed the pill on his tongue and then offered him the beaker, as Nathan had instructed me. It was pale, opaque plastic, the kind of thing Thomas had used, except without Bob the Builder on the sides. He swallowed with some effort, and then signalled to me that I should leave him alone.

I dusted some shelves that didn’t really need dusting, and contemplated cleaning some windows. Around me the annexe was silent, apart from the low hum of the television in the living room where he sat. I didn’t feel confident enough to put on a music station in the kitchen. I had a feeling he would have something cutting to say about my choice in music.

At twelve thirty, Nathan arrived, bringing with him the cold air of outside, and a raised eyebrow. 'All okay?' he said.

I had rarely been so happy to see someone in my life. 'Fine.'

'Great. You can take a half-hour now. Me and Mr T have a few things we attend to at this point in the day.'

I almost ran for my coat. I hadn't planned on going out for lunch, but I was almost faint with relief at getting out of that house. I pulled up my collar, stuck my handbag on my shoulder, and set off at a brisk walk down the drive, as if I had somewhere I actually wanted to go. In fact, I just walked around the surrounding streets for half an hour, breathing hot clouds of breath into my tightly wrapped scarf.

There were no cafes at this end of town, now that The Buttered Bun was closed. The castle was deserted. The nearest eating place was a gastropub, the kind of place where I doubted I could afford a drink, let alone a quick lunch. All the cars in the car park were huge and expensive with recent number plates.

I stood in the castle car park, making sure I was out of view of Granta House, and dialled my sister's number. 'Hey.'

'You know I can't talk at work. You haven't walked out, have you?'

'No. I just needed to hear a friendly voice.'

'Is he that bad?'

'Treen, he *hates* me. He looks at me like I'm something the cat dragged in. And he doesn't even drink tea. I'm hiding from him.'

'I can't believe I'm hearing this.'

'What?'

'Just talk to him, for crying out loud. Of course he's miserable. He's stuck in a bloody wheelchair. And you're probably being useless. Just talk to him. Get to know him. What's the worst that can happen?'

'I don't know ... I don't know if I can stick it.'

'I'm not telling Mum you're giving up your job after half a day. They won't give you any benefits, Lou. You can't do this. We can't afford for you to do this.'

She was right. I realized I hated my sister.

There was a brief silence. Treen's voice turned uncharacteristically conciliatory. This was really worrying. It meant she knew I did actually have the worst job in the world. 'Look,' she said. 'It's just six months. Just do the six months, have something useful on your CV and you can get a job

you actually like. And hey – look at it this way, at least it's not working nights at the chicken factory, right?'

'Nights at the chicken factory would feel like a holiday compared with –'
'I'm going now, Lou. I'll see you later.'

'So would you like to go somewhere this afternoon? We could drive somewhere if you like.'

Nathan had been gone for almost half an hour. I had spun out the washing of the tea mugs as long as humanly possible, and I thought that if I spent one more hour in this silent house my head might explode.

He turned his head towards me. 'Where did you have in mind?'

'I don't know. Just a drive in the country?' I was doing this thing I sometimes do of pretending I'm Treena. She is one of those people who are completely calm and competent, and as a result no one ever messes with her. I sounded, to my own ears, professional and upbeat.

'The country,' he said, as if considering it. 'And what would we see. Some trees? Some sky?'

'I don't know. What do you normally do?'

'I don't *do* anything, Miss Clark. I can't do anything any more. I sit. I just about exist.'

'Well,' I said, 'I was told that you have a car that's adapted for wheelchair use?'

'And you're worried that it will stop working if it doesn't get used every day?'

'No, but I –'

'Are you telling me I should go out?'

'I just thought –'

'You thought a little drive would be good for me? A breath of fresh air?'

'I'm just trying to –'

'Miss Clark, my life is not going to be significantly improved by a drive around Stortfold's country lanes.' He turned away.

His head had sunk into his shoulders and I wondered whether he was comfortable. It didn't seem to be the time to ask him. We sat in silence.

'Do you want me to bring you your computer?'

'Why, have you thought of a good quadriplegic support group I could join? Quads R Us? The Tin Wheel Club?'

I took a deep breath, trying to make my voice sound confident. 'Okay ... well ... seeing as we're going to spend all this time in each other's company perhaps we could get to know something about each other —'

There was something about his face then that made me falter. He was staring straight ahead at the wall, a tic moving in his jaw.

'It's just ... it's quite a long time to spend with someone. All day,' I continued. 'Perhaps if you could tell me a little of what you want to do, what you like, then I can ... make sure things are as you like them?'

This time the silence was painful. I heard my voice slowly swallowed by it, and couldn't work out what to do with my hands. Treena and her competent manner had evaporated.

Finally, the wheelchair hummed and he turned slowly to face me.

'Here's what I know about you, Miss Clark. My mother says you're chatty.' He said it like it was an affliction. 'Can we strike a deal? Whereby you are very *un*-chatty around me?'

I swallowed, feeling my face flame.

'Fine,' I said, when I could speak again. 'I'll be in the kitchen. If you want anything just call me.'

'You can't give up already.'

I was lying sideways on my bed with my legs stretched up the wall, like I did when I was a teenager. I had been up here since supper, which was unusual for me. Since Thomas was born, he and Treena had moved into the bigger room, and I was in the box room, which was small enough to make you feel claustrophobic should you sit in it for more than half an hour at a time.

But I didn't want to sit downstairs with Mum and Granddad because Mum kept looking at me anxiously and saying things like 'It will get better, love' and 'No job is great on the first day' – as if she'd had a ruddy job in the last twenty years. It was making me feel guilty. And I hadn't even done anything.

'I didn't say I was giving up.'

Treena had barged in without knocking, as she did every day, even though I always had to knock quietly on her room, in case Thomas was sleeping.

'And I could have been naked. You could at least shout first.'

‘I’ve seen worse. Mum thinks you’re going to hand in your notice.’

I slid my legs sideways down the wall and pushed myself up to a seated position.

‘Oh God, Treen. It’s worse than I thought. He is so miserable.’

‘He can’t move. Of course he’s miserable.’

‘No, but he’s sarcastic and mean with it. Every time I say something or suggest something he looks at me like I’m stupid, or says something that makes me feel about two years old.’

‘You probably did say something stupid. You just need to get used to each other.’

‘I really didn’t. I was so careful. I hardly said anything except “Would you like to go out for a drive?” or “Would you like a cup of tea?”.’

‘Well, maybe he’s like that with everyone at the start, until he knows whether you’re going to stick around. I bet they get through loads of helpers.’

‘He didn’t even want me in the same room as him. I don’t think I can stick it, Katrina. I really don’t. Honest – if you’d been there you would understand.’

Treena said nothing then, just looked at me for a while. She got up and glanced out of the door, as if checking whether there was anybody on the landing.

‘I’m thinking of going back to college,’ she said, finally.

It took my brain a few seconds to register this change of tack.

‘Oh my God,’ I said. ‘But –’

‘I’m going to take a loan to pay for the fees. But I can get some special grant too, because of having Thomas, and the university is offering me reduced rates because they ...’ She shrugged, a little embarrassed. ‘They say they think I could excel. Someone’s dropped out of the business studies course, so they can take me for the beginning of the next term.’

‘What about Thomas?’

‘There’s a nursery on campus. We can stay there in a subsidized flat in halls in the week, and come back here most weekends.’

‘Oh.’

I could feel her watching me. I didn’t know what to do with my face.

‘I’m really desperate to use my brain again. Doing the flowers is doing my head in. I want to learn. I want to improve myself. And I’m sick of my hands always being freezing cold from the water.’

We both stared at her hands, which were pink tinged, even in the tropical warmth of our house.

‘But –’

‘Yup. I won’t be working, Lou. I won’t be able to give Mum anything. I might ... I might even need a bit of help from them.’ This time she looked quite uncomfortable. Her expression, when she glanced up at me, was almost apologetic.

Downstairs Mum was laughing at something on the television. We could hear her exclaiming to Granddad. She often explained the plot of the show to him, even though we told her all the time she didn’t need to. I couldn’t speak. The significance of my sister’s words sank in slowly but inexorably. I felt like a Mafia victim must do, watching the concrete setting slowly around their ankles.

‘I really need to do this, Lou. I want more for Thomas, more for both of us. The only way I’ll get anywhere is by going back to college. I haven’t got a Patrick. I’m not sure I’ll ever have a Patrick, given that nobody’s been remotely interested since I had Thomas. I need to do the best I can by myself.’

When I didn’t say anything, she added, ‘For me and Thomas.’

I nodded.

‘Lou? Please?’

I had never seen my sister look like that before. It made me feel really uncomfortable. I lifted my head, and raised a smile. My voice, when it emerged, didn’t even sound like my own.

‘Well, like you say. It’s just a matter of getting used to him. It’s bound to be difficult in the first few days, isn’t it?’



4

Two weeks passed and with them emerged a routine of sorts. Every morning I would arrive at Granta House at eight, call out that I was there and then, after Nathan had finished helping Will dress, listen carefully while he told me what I needed to know about Will's meds – or, more importantly, his mood.

After Nathan had left I would programme the radio or television for Will, dispense his pills, sometimes crushing them with the little marble pestle and mortar. Usually, after ten minutes or so he would make it clear that he was weary of my presence. At this point I would eke out the little annexe's domestic tasks, washing tea towels that weren't dirty, or using random vacuum attachments to clean tiny bits of skirting or window sill, religiously popping my head round the door every fifteen minutes as Mrs Traynor had instructed. When I did, he would be sitting in his chair looking out into the bleak garden.

Later I might take him a drink of water, or one of the calorie-filled drinks that were supposed to keep his weight up and looked like pastel-coloured wallpaper paste, or give him his food. He could move his hands a little, but not his arm, so he had to be fed forkful by forkful. This was the worst part of the day; it seemed wrong, somehow, spoon-feeding a grown man, and my embarrassment made me clumsy and awkward. Will hated it so much he wouldn't even meet my eye while I was doing it.

And then shortly before one, Nathan would arrive and I would grab my coat and disappear to walk the streets, sometimes eating my lunch in the

bus shelter outside the castle. It was cold and I probably looked pathetic perched there eating my sandwiches, but I didn't care. I couldn't spend a whole day in that house.

In the afternoon I would put a film on – Will had a membership of a DVD club and new films arrived by post every day – but he never invited me to watch with him, so I'd usually go and sit in the kitchen or in the spare room. I started bringing in a book or magazine, but I felt oddly guilty not actually working, and I could never quite concentrate on the words. Occasionally, at the end of the day, Mrs Traynor would pop in – although she never said much to me, other than 'Everything all right?' to which the only acceptable answer seemed to be 'Yes'.

She would ask Will if he wanted anything, occasionally suggest something he might like to do tomorrow – some outing, or some friend who had asked after him – and he would almost always answer dismissively, if not with downright rudeness. She would look pained, run her fingers up and down that little gold chain, and disappear again.

His father, a well-padded, gentle-looking man, usually came in as I was leaving. He was the kind of man you might see watching cricket in a Panama hat, and had apparently overseen the management of the castle since retiring from his well-paid job in the city. I suspected this was like a benign landowner digging in the odd potato just 'to keep his hand in'. He finished every day at 5pm promptly and would sit and watch television with Will. Sometimes I heard him making some remark about whatever was on the news as I left.

I got to study Will Traynor up close, in those first couple of weeks. I saw that he seemed determined not to look anything like the man he had been; he had let his light-brown hair grow into a shapeless mess, his stubble crawl across his jaw. His grey eyes were lined with exhaustion, or the effect of constant discomfort (Nathan said he was rarely comfortable). They bore the hollow look of someone who was always a few steps removed from the world around him. Sometimes I wondered if it was a defence mechanism, whether the only way to cope with his life was to pretend it wasn't him it was happening to.

I wanted to feel sorry for him. I really did. I thought he was the saddest person I had ever met, in those moments when I glimpsed him staring out of the window. And as the days went by and I realized that his condition was not just a matter of being stuck in that chair, of the loss of physical freedom,

but a never-ending litany of indignities and health problems, of risks and discomforts, I decided that if I were Will, I would probably be pretty miserable too.

But oh Lord, he was vile to me. Everything I said, he had a sharp answer for. If I asked him if he was warm enough, he would retort that he was quite capable of letting me know if he needed another blanket. If I asked if the vacuum cleaner was too noisy for him – I hadn't wanted to interrupt his film – he asked me why, had I worked out a way to make it run silently? When I fed him, he complained that the food was too hot or too cold, or that I had brought the next forkful up to his mouth before he had finished the last. He had the ability to twist almost anything I said or did so that I seemed stupid.

During those first two weeks, I got quite good at keeping my face completely blank, and I would turn away and disappear into the other room and just say as little to him as I possibly could. I started to hate him, and I'm sure he knew it.

I hadn't realized it was possible to miss my old job more than I already did. I missed Frank, and the way he actually looked pleased to see me when I arrived in the morning. I missed the customers, their company, and the easy chatter that swelled and dipped gently like a benign sea around me. This house, beautiful and expensive as it was, was as still and silent as a morgue. *Six months*, I repeated under my breath, when it felt unbearable. *Six months*.

And then on the Thursday, just as I was mixing Will's mid-morning, high-calorie drink, I heard Mrs Traynor's voice in the hall. Except this time there were other voices too. I waited, the fork stilled in my hand. I could just make out a woman's voice, young, well-spoken, and a man's.

Mrs Traynor appeared in the kitchen doorway, and I tried to look busy, whisking briskly at the beaker.

'Is that made up with 60:40 water and milk?' she asked, peering at the drink.

'Yes. It's the strawberry one.'

'Will's friends have come to see him. It would probably be best if you –'

'I've got lots of things I should be doing in here,' I said. I was actually quite relieved that I would be spared his company for an hour or so. I screwed the lid on to the beaker. 'Would your guests like some tea or coffee?'

She looked almost surprised. 'Yes. That would be very kind. Coffee. I think I'll ... '

She seemed even more tense than usual, her eyes darting towards the corridor, from where we could hear the low murmur of voices. I guessed that Will didn't get many visitors.

'I think ... I'll leave them all to it.' She gazed out into the corridor, her thoughts apparently far away. 'Rupert. It's Rupert, his old friend from work,' she said, suddenly turning towards me.

I got the feeling that this was in some way momentous, and that she needed to share it with someone, even if it was just me.

'And Alicia. They were ... very close ... for a bit. Tea would be lovely. Thank you, Miss Clark.'

I hesitated a moment before I opened the door, leaning against it with my hip so that I could balance the tray in my hands.

'Mrs Traynor said you might like some coffee,' I said as I entered, placing the tray on the low table. As I placed Will's beaker in the holder of his chair, turning the straw so that he only needed to adjust his head position to reach it, I sneaked a look at his visitors.

It was the woman I noticed first. Long-legged and blonde-haired, with pale caramel skin, she was the kind of woman who makes me wonder if humans really are all the same species. She looked like a human racehorse. I had seen these women occasionally; they were usually bouncing up the hill to the castle, clutching small Boden-clad children, and when they came into the cafe their voices would carry, crystal clear and unselfconscious, as they asked, 'Harry, darling, would you like a coffee? Shall I see if they can do you a macchiato?' This was definitely a macchiato woman. Everything about her smelt of money, of entitlement and a life lived as if through the pages of a glossy magazine.

Then I looked at her more closely and realized with a jolt that a) she was the woman in Will's skiing photograph, and b) she looked really, really uncomfortable.

She had kissed Will on the cheek and was now stepping backwards, smiling awkwardly. She was wearing a brown shearling gilet, the kind of thing that would have made me look like a yeti, and a pale-grey cashmere scarf around her neck, which she began to fiddle with, as if she couldn't decide whether to unwrap herself or not.

‘You look well,’ she said to him. ‘Really. You’ve ... grown your hair a bit.’

Will didn’t say a thing. He was just looking at her, his expression as unreadable as ever. I felt a fleeting gratitude that it wasn’t just me he looked at like that.

‘New chair, eh?’ The man tapped the back of Will’s chair, chin compressed, nodding in approval as if he were admiring a top-of-the-range sports car. ‘Looks ... pretty smart. Very ... high tech.’

I didn’t know what to do. I stood there for a moment, shifting from one foot to another, until Will’s voice broke into the silence.

‘Louisa, would you mind putting some more logs on the fire? I think it needs building up a bit.’

It was the first time he had used my Christian name.

‘Sure,’ I said.

I busied myself by the log burner, stoking the fire and sorting through the basket for logs of the right size.

‘Gosh, it’s cold outside,’ the woman said. ‘Nice to have a proper fire.’

I opened the door of the wood burner, prodding at the glowing logs with the poker.

‘It’s a good few degrees colder here than London.’

‘Yes, definitely,’ the man agreed.

‘I was thinking of getting a wood burner at home. Apparently they’re much more efficient than an open fire.’ Alicia stooped a little to inspect this one, as if she’d never actually seen one before.

‘Yes, I’ve heard that,’ said the man.

‘I must look into it. One of those things you mean to do and then ... ’ she tailed off. ‘Lovely coffee,’ she added, after a pause.

‘So – what have you been up to, Will?’ The man’s voice held a kind of forced joviality to it.

‘Not very much, funnily enough.’

‘But the physio and stuff. Is it all coming on? Any ... improvement?’

‘I don’t think I’ll be skiing any time soon, Rupert,’ Will said, his voice dripping with sarcasm.

I almost smiled to myself. This was the Will I knew. I began brushing ash from the hearth. I had the feeling that they were all watching me. The silence felt loaded. I wondered briefly whether the label was sticking out of my jumper and fought the urge to check.

‘So ... ’ Will said finally. ‘To what do I owe this pleasure? It’s been ... eight months?’

‘Oh, I know. I’m sorry. It’s been ... I’ve been awfully busy. I have a new job over in Chelsea. Managing Sasha Goldstein’s boutique. Do you remember Sasha? I’ve been doing a lot of weekend work too. It gets terribly busy on Saturdays. Very hard to get time off.’ Alicia’s voice had become brittle. ‘I did ring a couple of times. Did your mother tell you?’

‘Things have been pretty manic at Lewins. You ... you know what it’s like, Will. We’ve got a new partner. Chap from New York. Bains. Dan Bains. You come up against him at all?’

‘No.’

‘Bloody man seems to work twenty-four hours a day and expects everyone else to do the same.’ You could hear the man’s palpable relief at having found a topic he was comfortable with. ‘You know the old Yank work ethic – no more long lunches, no smutty jokes – Will, I tell you. The whole atmosphere of the place has changed.’

‘Really.’

‘Oh God, yes. Presenteeism writ large. Sometimes I feel like I daren’t leave my chair.’

All the air seemed to disappear from the room in a vacuumed rush. Someone coughed.

I stood up, and wiped my hands on my jeans. ‘I’ll ... I’m just going to fetch some more logs,’ I muttered, in Will’s general direction.

And I picked up the basket and fled.

It was freezing outside, but I lingered out there, killing time while I selected pieces of wood. I was trying to calculate whether it was preferable to lose the odd finger to frostbite rather than put myself back into that room. But it was just too cold and my index finger, which I use for sewing stuff, went blue first and finally I had to admit defeat. I hauled the wood as slowly as possible, letting myself in to the annexe, and walked slowly back down the corridor. As I approached the living room I heard the woman’s voice, weaving its way through the slightly open door.

‘Actually, Will, there is another reason for us coming here,’ she was saying. ‘We ... have some news.’

I hesitated by the door, the log basket braced between my hands.

‘I thought – well, we thought – that it would only be right to let you know ... but, well, here’s the thing. Rupert and I are getting married.’

I stood very still, calculating whether I could turn round without being heard.

The woman continued, lamely. 'Look, I know this is probably a bit of a shock to you. Actually, it was rather a shock to me. We – it – well, it only really started a long time after ... '

My arms had begun to ache. I glanced down at the basket, trying to work out what to do.

'Well, you know you and I ... we ... '

Another weighty silence.

'Will, please say something.'

'Congratulations,' he said finally.

'I know what you're thinking. But neither of us meant for this to happen. Really. For an awful long time we were just friends. Friends who were concerned about you. It's just that Rupert was the most terrific support to me after your accident –'

'Big of him.'

'Please don't be like this. This is so awful. I have absolutely dreaded telling you. We both have.'

'Evidently,' Will said flatly.

Rupert's voice broke in. 'Look, we're only telling you because we both care about you. We didn't want you to hear it from someone else. But, you know, life goes on. You must know that. It's been two years, after all.'

There was silence. I realized I did not want to listen to any more, and started to move softly away from the door, grunting slightly with the effort. But Rupert's voice, when it came again, had grown in volume so that I could still hear him.

'Come on, man. I know it must be terribly hard ... all this. But if you care for Lissa at all, you must want her to have a good life.'

'Say something, Will. Please.'

I could picture his face. I could see that look of his that managed to be both unreadable and to convey a kind of distant contempt.

'Congratulations,' he said, finally. 'I'm sure you'll both be very happy.'

Alicia started to protest then – something indistinct – but was interrupted by Rupert. 'Come on, Lissa. I think we should leave. Will, it's not like we came here expecting your blessing. It was a courtesy. Lissa thought – well, we both just thought – you should know. Sorry, old chap. I ... I do hope

things improve for you and I hope you do want to stay in touch when things ... you know ... when things settle down a bit.'

I heard footsteps, and stooped over the basket of logs, as if I had only just come in. I heard them in the corridor and then Alicia appeared in front of me. Her eyes were red-rimmed, as if she were about to cry.

'Can I use the bathroom?' she said, her voice thick and choked.

I slowly lifted a finger and pointed mutely in its direction.

She looked at me hard then, and I realized that what I felt probably showed on my face. I have never been much good at hiding my feelings.

'I know what you're thinking,' she said, after a pause. 'But I did try. I really tried. For months. And he just pushed me away.' Her jaw was rigid, her expression oddly furious. 'He actually didn't want me here. He made that very clear.'

She seemed to be waiting for me to say something.

'It's really none of my business,' I said, eventually.

We both stood facing each other.

'You know, you can only actually help someone who wants to be helped,' she said.

And then she was gone.

I waited a couple of minutes, listening for the sound of their car disappearing down the drive, and then I went into the kitchen. I stood there and boiled the kettle even though I didn't want a cup of tea. I flicked through a magazine that I had already read. Finally, I went back into the corridor and, with a grunt, picked up the log basket and hauled it into the living room, bumping it slightly on the door before I entered so that Will would know I was coming.

'I was wondering if you wanted me to –' I began.

But there was nobody there.

The room was empty.

It was then that I heard the crash. I ran out into the corridor just in time to hear another, followed by the sound of splintering glass. It was coming from Will's bedroom. *Oh God, please don't let him have hurt himself.* I panicked – Mrs Traynor's warning drilled through my head. I had left him for more than fifteen minutes.

I ran down the corridor, slid to a halt in the doorway and stood, both hands gripping the door frame. Will was in the middle of the room, upright in his chair, a walking stick balanced across the armrests, so that it jutted

eighteen inches to his left – a jousting stick. There was not a single photograph left on the long shelves; the expensive frames lay in pieces all over the floor, the carpet studded with glittering shards of glass. His lap was dusted with bits of glass and splintered wood frames. I took in the scene of destruction, feeling my heart rate slowly subside as I grasped that he was unhurt. Will was breathing hard, as if whatever he had done had cost him some effort.

His chair turned, crunching slightly on the glass. His eyes met mine. They were infinitely weary. They dared me to offer him sympathy.

I looked down at his lap, and then at the floor around him. I could just make out the picture of him and Alicia, her face now obscured by a bent silver frame, amongst the other casualties.

I swallowed, staring at it, and slowly lifted my eyes to his. Those few seconds were the longest I could remember.

‘Can that thing get a puncture?’ I said, finally, nodding at his wheelchair. ‘Because I have no idea where I would put the jack.’

His eyes widened. Just for a moment, I thought I had really blown it. But the faintest flicker of a smile passed across his face.

‘Look, don’t move,’ I said. ‘I’ll get the vacuum cleaner.’

I heard the walking stick drop to the floor. As I left the room, I thought I might have heard him say sorry.

The Kings Head was always busy on a Thursday evening, and in the corner of the snug it was even busier. I sat squashed between Patrick and a man whose name appeared to be the Rutter, staring periodically at the horse brasses pinned to the oak beams above my head and the photographs of the castle that punctuated the joists, and tried to look even vaguely interested in the talk around me, which seemed to revolve chiefly around body fat ratios and carb loading.

I had always thought the fortnightly meetings of the Hailsbury Triathlon Terrors must be a publican’s worst nightmare. I was the only one drinking alcohol, and my solitary packet of crisps sat crumpled and empty on the table. Everyone else sipped at mineral water, or checked the sweetener ratios on their Diet Cokes. When they, finally, ordered food there wouldn’t be a salad that was allowed to brush a leaf against a full-fat dressing, or a piece of chicken that still sported its skin. I often ordered chips, just so that I could watch them all pretend they didn’t want one.

‘Phil hit the wall about forty miles in. He said he actually heard voices. Feet like lead. He had that zombie face, you know?’

‘I got some of those new Japanese balancing trainers fitted. Shaved fifteen minutes off my ten-mile timings.’

‘Don’t travel with a soft bike bag. Nigel arrived at tricamp with it looking like a ruddy coat hanger.’

I couldn’t say I enjoyed the Triathlon Terrors’ gatherings, but what with my increased hours and Patrick’s training timetable it was one of the few times I could be guaranteed to see him. He sat beside me, muscular thighs clad in shorts despite the extreme cold outside. It was a badge of honour among the members of the club to wear as few clothes as possible. The men were wiry, brandishing obscure and expensive sports layers that boasted extra ‘wicking’ properties, or lighter-than-air bodyweights. They were called Scud or Trig, and flexed bits of body at each other, displaying injuries or alleged muscle growth. The girls wore no make-up, and had the ruddy complexions of those who thought nothing of jogging for miles through icy conditions. They looked at me with faint distaste – or perhaps even incomprehension – no doubt weighing up my fat to muscle ratio and finding it wanting.

‘It was awful,’ I told Patrick, wondering whether I could order cheesecake without them all giving me the Death Stare. ‘His girlfriend and his best friend.’

‘You can’t blame her,’ he said. ‘Are you really telling me you’d stick around if I was paralysed from the neck down?’

‘Of course I would.’

‘No, you wouldn’t. And I wouldn’t expect you to.’

‘Well, I would.’

‘But I wouldn’t want you there. I wouldn’t want someone staying with me out of pity.’

‘Who says it would be pity? You’d still be the same person underneath.’

‘No, I wouldn’t. I wouldn’t be anything like the same person.’ He wrinkled his nose. ‘I wouldn’t want to live. Relying on other people for every little thing. Having strangers wipe your arse –’

A man with a shaved head thrust his head between us. ‘Pat,’ he said, ‘have you tried that new gel drink? Had one explode in my backpack last week. Never seen anything like it.’

‘Can’t say I have, Trig. Give me a banana and a Lucozade any day.’

‘Dazzer had a Diet Coke when he was doing Norseman. Sickened it all up at three thousand feet. God, we laughed.’

I raised a weak smile.

Shaven-headed man disappeared and Patrick turned back to me, apparently still pondering Will’s fate. ‘Jesus. Think of all the things you couldn’t do ... ’ He shook his head. ‘No more running, no more cycling.’ He looked at me as if it had just occurred to him. ‘No more sex.’

‘Of course you could have sex. It’s just that the woman would have to get on top.’

‘We’d be stuffed, then.’

‘Funny.’

‘Besides, if you’re paralysed from the neck down I’m guessing the ... um ... equipment doesn’t work as it should.’

I thought of Alicia. *I did try*, she said. *I really tried. For months.*

‘I’m sure it does with some people. Anyway, there must be a way around these things if you ... think imaginatively.’

‘Hah.’ Patrick took a sip of his water. ‘You’ll have to ask him tomorrow. Look, you said he’s horrible. Perhaps he was horrible before his accident. Perhaps that’s the real reason she dumped him. Have you thought of that?’

‘I don’t know ... ’ I thought of the photograph. ‘They looked like they were really happy together.’ Then again, what did a photograph prove? I had a framed photograph at home where I was beaming at Patrick like he had just pulled me from a burning building, yet in reality I had just called him an ‘utter dick’ and he had responded with a hearty, ‘Oh, piss off!’

Patrick had lost interest. ‘Hey, Jim ... Jim, did you take a look at that new lightweight bike? Any good?’

I let him change the subject, thinking about what Alicia had said. I could well imagine Will pushing her away. But surely if you loved someone it was your job to stick with them? To help them through the depression? In sickness and in health, and all that?

‘Another drink?’

‘Vodka tonic. *Slimline* tonic,’ I said, as he raised an eyebrow.

Patrick shrugged and headed to the bar.

I had started to feel a little guilty about the way we were discussing my employer. Especially when I realized that he probably endured it all the time. It was almost impossible not to speculate about the more intimate aspects of his life. I tuned out. There was talk of a training weekend in

Spain. I was only listening with half an ear, until Patrick reappeared at my side and nudged me.

‘Fancy it?’

‘What?’

‘Weekend in Spain. Instead of the Greek holiday. You could put your feet up by the pool if you don’t fancy the forty-mile bike ride. We could get cheap flights. Six weeks’ time. Now you’re rolling in it ...’

I thought of Mrs Traynor. ‘I don’t know ... I’m not sure they’re going to be keen on me taking time off so soon.’

‘You mind if I go, then? I really fancy getting some altitude training in. I’m thinking about doing the big one.’

‘The big what?’

‘Triathlon. The Xtreme Viking. Sixty miles on a bike, thirty miles on foot, and a nice long swim in sub-zero Nordic seas.’

The Viking was spoken about with reverence, those who had competed bearing their injuries like veterans of some distant and particularly brutal war. He was almost smacking his lips with anticipation. I looked at my boyfriend and wondered if he was actually an alien. I thought briefly that I had preferred him when he worked in telesales and couldn’t pass a petrol station without stocking up on Mars Bars.

‘You’re going to do it?’

‘Why not? I’ve never been fitter.’

I thought of all that extra training – the endless conversations about weight and distance, fitness and endurance. It was hard enough getting Patrick’s attention these days at the best of times.

‘You could do it with me,’ he said, although we both knew he didn’t believe it.

‘I’ll leave you to it,’ I said. ‘Sure. Go for it,’ I said.

And I ordered the cheesecake.

If I had thought the events of the previous day would create a thaw back at Granta House, I was wrong.

I greeted Will with a broad smile and a cheery hello, and he didn’t even bother to look round from the window.

‘Not a good day,’ Nathan murmured, as he shouldered his way into his coat.

It was a filthy, low-cloud sort of a morning, where the rain spat meanly against the windows and it was hard to imagine the sun coming out ever again. Even I felt glum on a day like this. It wasn't really a surprise that Will should be worse. I began to work my way through the morning's chores, telling myself all the while that it didn't matter. You didn't have to like your employer anyway, did you? Lots of people didn't. I thought of Treena's boss, a taut-faced serial divorcee who monitored how many times my sister went to the loo and had been known to make barbed comments if she considered her to have exceeded reasonable bladder activity. And besides, I had already done two weeks here. That meant there were only five months and thirteen working days to go.

The photographs were stacked carefully in the bottom drawer, where I had placed them the previous day, and now, crouched on the floor, I began laying them out and sorting through them, assessing which frames I might be able to fix. I am quite good at fixing things. Besides, I thought it might be quite a useful way of killing time.

I had been doing this for about ten minutes when the discreet hum of the motorized wheelchair alerted me to Will's arrival.

He sat there in the doorway, looking at me. There were dark shadows under his eyes. Sometimes, Nathan told me, he barely slept at all. I didn't want to think how it would feel, to lie trapped in a bed you couldn't get out of with only dark thoughts to keep you company through the small hours.

'I thought I'd see if I could fix any of these frames,' I said, holding one up. It was the picture of him bungee jumping. I tried to look cheerful. *He needs someone upbeat, someone positive.*

'Why?'

I blinked. 'Well ... I think some of these can be saved. I brought some wood glue with me, if you're happy for me to have a go at them. Or if you want to replace them I can pop into town during my lunch break and see if I can find some more. Or we could both go, if you fancied a trip out ... '

'Who told you to start fixing them?'

His stare was unflinching.

Uh-oh, I thought. 'I ... I was just trying to help.'

'You wanted to fix what I did yesterday.'

'I –'

'Do you know what, Louisa? It would be nice – just for once – if someone paid attention to what I wanted. Me smashing those photographs

was not an accident. It was not an attempt at radical interior design. It was because I actually don't want to look at them.'

I got to my feet. 'I'm sorry. I didn't think that –'

'You thought you knew best. Everyone thinks they know what I need. *Let's put the bloody photos back together. Give the poor invalid something to look at.* I don't want to have those bloody pictures staring at me every time I'm stuck in my bed until someone comes and bloody well gets me out again. Okay? Do you think you can get your head around that?'

I swallowed. 'I wasn't going to fix the one of Alicia – I'm not that stupid ... I just thought that in a while you might feel –'

'Oh Christ ...' He turned away from me, his voice scathing. 'Spare me the psychological therapy. Just go and read your bloody gossip magazines or whatever it is you do when you're not making tea.'

My cheeks were aflame. I watched him manoeuvre in the narrow hallway, and my voice emerged even before I knew what I was doing.

'You don't have to behave like an arse.'

The words rang out in the still air.

The wheelchair stopped. There was a long pause, and then he reversed and turned slowly, so that he was facing me, his hand on the little joystick.

'What?'

I faced him, my heart thumping. 'Your friends got the shitty treatment. Fine. They probably deserved it. But I'm just here day after day trying to do the best job I can. So I would really appreciate it if you didn't make my life as unpleasant as you do everyone else's.'

Will's eyes widened a little. There was a beat before he spoke again. 'And what if I told you I didn't want you here?'

'I'm not employed by you. I'm employed by your mother. And unless she tells me she doesn't want me here any more I'm staying. Not because I particularly care about you, or like this stupid job or want to change your life one way or another, but because I need the money. Okay? I really need the money.'

Will Traynor's expression hadn't outwardly changed much but I thought I saw astonishment in there, as if he were unused to anyone disagreeing with him.

Oh hell, I thought, as the reality of what I had just done began to sink in. *I've really blown it this time.*

But Will just stared at me for a bit and, when I didn't look away, he let out a small breath, as if about to say something unpleasant.

'Fair enough,' he said, and he turned the wheelchair round. 'Just put the photographs in the bottom drawer, will you? All of them.'

And with a low hum, he was gone.



5

The thing about being catapulted into a whole new life – or at least, shoved up so hard against someone else’s life that you might as well have your face pressed against their window – is that it forces you to rethink your idea of who you are. Or how you might seem to other people.

To my parents, I had in four short weeks become just a few degrees more interesting. I was now the conduit to a different world. My mother, in particular, asked me daily questions about Granta House and its domestic habits in the manner of a zoologist forensically examining some strange new creature and its habitat. ‘Does Mrs Traynor use linen napkins at every meal?’ she would ask, or ‘Do you think they vacuum every day, like we do?’ or, ‘What do they do with their potatoes?’

She sent me off in the mornings with strict instructions to find out what brand of loo roll they used, or whether the sheets were a polycotton mix. It was a source of great disappointment to her that most of the time I couldn’t actually remember. My mother was secretly convinced that posh people lived like pigs – ever since I had told her, aged six, of a well-spoken school friend whose mother wouldn’t let us play in their front room ‘because we’d disturb the dust’.

When I came home to report that, yes, the dog was definitely allowed to eat in the kitchen, or that, no, the Traynors didn’t scrub their front step every day as my mother did, she would purse her lips, glance sideways at my father and nod with quiet satisfaction, as if I had just confirmed everything she’d suspected about the slovenly ways of the upper classes.

Their dependence on my income, or perhaps the fact that they knew I didn't really like my job, meant that I also received a little more respect within the house. This didn't actually translate to much – in my Dad's case, it meant that he had stopped calling me 'lardarse' and, in my mother's, that there was usually a mug of tea waiting for me when I came home.

To Patrick, and to my sister, I was no different – still the butt of jokes, the recipient of hugs or kisses or sulks. I felt no different. I still looked the same, still dressed, according to Treen, like I had had a wrestling match in a charity shop.

I had no idea what most of the inhabitants of Granta House thought of me. Will was unreadable. To Nathan, I suspected I was just the latest in a long line of hired carers. He was friendly enough, but a bit semi-detached. I got the feeling he wasn't convinced I was going to be there for long. Mr Traynor nodded at me politely when we passed in the hall, occasionally asking me how the traffic was, or whether I had settled in all right. I'm not sure he would have recognized me if he'd been introduced to me in another setting.

But to Mrs Traynor – oh Lord – to Mrs Traynor I was apparently the stupidest and most irresponsible person on the planet.

It had started with the photo frames. Nothing in that house escaped Mrs Traynor's notice, and I should have known that the smashing of the frames would qualify as a seismic event. She quizzed me as to exactly how long I had left Will alone, what had prompted it, how swiftly I had cleared the mess up. She didn't actually criticize me – she was too genteel even to raise her voice – but the way she blinked slowly at my responses, her little *hmm-hmm*, as I spoke, told me everything I needed to know. It came as no surprise when Nathan told me she was a magistrate.

She thought it might be a good idea if I didn't leave Will for so long next time, no matter how awkward the situation, *hmm*? She thought perhaps the next time I dusted I could make sure things weren't close enough to the edge so that they might accidentally get knocked to the floor, *hmm*? (She seemed to prefer to believe that it had been an accident.) She made me feel like a first-class eejit, and consequently I became a first-class eejit around her. She always arrived just when I had dropped something on the floor, or was struggling with the cooker dial, or she would be standing in the hallway looking mildly irritated as I stepped back in from collecting logs outside, as if I had been gone much longer than I actually had.

Weirdly, her attitude got to me more than Will's rudeness. A couple of times I had even been tempted to ask her outright whether there was something wrong. *You said that you were hiring me for my attitude rather than my professional skills*, I wanted to say. *Well, here I am, being cheery every ruddy day. Being robust, just as you wanted. So what's your problem?*

But Camilla Traynor was not the kind of woman you could have said that to. And besides, I got the feeling nobody in that house ever said anything direct to anyone else.

'Lily, our last girl, had rather a clever habit of using that pan for two vegetables at once,' meant *You're making too much mess*.

'Perhaps you'd like a cup of tea, Will,' actually meant *I have no idea what to say to you*.

'I think I've got some paperwork that needs sorting out,' meant *You're being rude, and I'm going to leave the room*.

All pronounced with that slightly pained expression, and the slender fingers running up and down the chain with the crucifix. She was so held in, so restrained. She made my own mother look like Amy Winehouse. I smiled politely, pretended I hadn't noticed, and did the job I was paid to do.

Or at least, I tried.

'Why the hell are you trying to sneak carrots on to my fork?'

I glanced down at the plate. I had been watching the female television presenter and wondering what my hair would look like dyed the same colour.

'Uh? I didn't.'

'You did. You mashed them up and tried to hide them in the gravy. I saw you.'

I blushed. He was right. I was sitting feeding Will, while both of us vaguely watched the lunchtime news. The meal was roast beef with mashed potato. His mother had told me to put three sorts of vegetables on the plate, even though he had said quite clearly that he didn't want vegetables that day. I don't think there was a meal that I was instructed to prepare that wasn't nutritionally balanced to within an inch of its life.

'Why are you trying to sneak carrots into me?'

'I'm not.'

'So there are no carrots on that?'

I gazed at the tiny pieces of orange. 'Well ... okay ... '

He was waiting, eyebrows raised.

‘Um ... I suppose I thought vegetables would be good for you?’

It was part deference to Mrs Traynor, part force of habit. I was so used to feeding Thomas, whose vegetables had to be mashed to a paste and hidden under mounds of potato, or secreted in bits of pasta. Every fragment we got past him felt like a little victory.

‘Let me get this straight. You think a teaspoon of carrot would improve my quality of life?’

It was pretty stupid when he put it like that. But I had learnt it was important not to look cowed by anything Will said or did.

‘I take your point,’ I said evenly. ‘I won’t do it again.’

And then, out of nowhere, Will Traynor laughed. It exploded out of him in a gasp, as if it were entirely unexpected.

‘For Christ’s sake,’ he shook his head.

I stared at him.

‘What the hell else have you been sneaking into my food? You’ll be telling me to open the tunnel so that Mr Train can deliver some mushy Brussel sprouts to the red bloody station next.’

I considered this for a minute. ‘No,’ I said, straight-faced. ‘I deal only with Mr Fork. Mr Fork does not look like a train.’

Thomas had told me so, very firmly, some months previously.

‘Did my mother put you up to this?’

‘No. Look, Will, I’m sorry. I just ... wasn’t thinking.’

‘Like that’s unusual.’

‘All right, all right. I’ll take the bloody carrots off, if they really upset you so much.’

‘It’s not the bloody carrots that upset me. It’s having them sneaked into my food by a madwoman who addresses the cutlery as Mr and Mrs Fork.’

‘It was a joke. Look, let me take the carrots and –’

He turned away from me. ‘I don’t want anything else. Just do me a cup of tea.’ He called out after me as I left the room, ‘And don’t try and sneak a bloody courgette into it.’

Nathan walked in as I was finishing the dishes. ‘He’s in a good mood,’ he said, as I handed him a mug.

‘Is he?’ I was eating my sandwiches in the kitchen. It was bitterly cold outside, and somehow the house hadn’t felt quite as unfriendly lately.

‘He says you’re trying to poison him. But he said it – you know – in a good way.’

I felt weirdly pleased by this information.

‘Yes ... well ... ’ I said, trying to hide it. ‘Give me time.’

‘He’s talking a bit more too. We’ve had weeks where he would hardly say a thing, but he’s definitely up for a bit of a chat the last few days.’

I thought of Will telling me if I didn’t stop bloody whistling he’d be forced to run me over. ‘I think his definition of chatty and mine are a bit different.’

‘Well, we had a bit of a chat about the cricket. And I gotta tell you –’ Nathan dropped his voice ‘– Mrs T asked me a week or so back if I thought you were doing okay. I said I thought you were very professional, but I knew that wasn’t what she meant. Then yesterday she came in and told me she’d heard you guys laughing.’

I thought back to the previous evening. ‘He was laughing *at* me,’ I said. Will had found it hilarious that I didn’t know what pesto was. I had told him supper was ‘the pasta in the green gravy’.

‘Ah, she doesn’t care about that. It’s just been a long time since he laughed at anything.’

It was true. Will and I seemed to have found an easier way of being around each other. It revolved mainly around him being rude to me, and me occasionally being rude back. He told me I did something badly, and I told him if it really mattered to him then he could ask me nicely. He swore at me, or called me a pain in the backside, and I told him he should try being without this particular pain in the backside and see how far it got him. It was a bit forced but it seemed to work for both of us. Sometimes it even seemed like a relief to him that there was someone prepared to be rude to him, to contradict him or tell him he was being horrible. I got the feeling that everyone had tiptoed around him since his accident – apart from perhaps Nathan, who Will seemed to treat with an automatic respect, and who was probably impervious to any of his sharper comments anyway. Nathan was like an armoured vehicle in human form.

‘You just make sure you’re the butt of more of his jokes, okay?’

I put my mug in the sink. ‘I don’t think that’s going to be a problem.’

The other big change, apart from atmospheric conditions inside the house, was that Will didn’t ask me to leave him alone quite as often, and a couple of afternoons had even asked me if I wanted to stay and watch a film with him. I hadn’t minded too much when it was *The Terminator* – even though I have seen all the Terminator films – but when he showed me the

French film with subtitles, I took a quick look at the cover and said I thought I'd probably give it a miss.

'Why?'

I shrugged. 'I don't like films with subtitles.'

'That's like saying you don't like films with actors in them. Don't be ridiculous. What is it you don't like? The fact that you're required to read something as well as watch something?'

'I just don't really like foreign films.'

'Everything after *Local Bloody Hero* has been a foreign film. D'you think Hollywood is a suburb of Birmingham?'

'Funny.'

He couldn't believe it when I admitted I'd never actually watched a film with subtitles. But my parents tended to stake ownership of the remote control in the evenings, and Patrick would be about as likely to watch a foreign film as he would be to suggest we take night classes in crochet. The multiplex in our nearest town only showed the latest shoot'em ups or romantic comedies and was so infested with catcalling kids in hoodies that most people around the town rarely bothered.

'You have to watch this film, Louisa. In fact, I order you to watch this film.' Will moved his chair back, and nodded towards the armchair. 'There. You sit there. Don't move until it's over. Never watched a foreign film. For Christ's sake,' he muttered.

It was an old film, about a hunchback who inherits a house in the French countryside, and Will said it was based on a famous book, but I can't say I'd ever heard of it. I spent the first twenty minutes feeling a bit fidgety, irritated by the subtitles and wondering if Will was going to get shirty if I told him I needed the loo.

And then something happened. I stopped thinking about how hard it was listening and reading at the same time, forgot Will's pill timetable, and whether Mrs Traynor would think I was slacking, and I started to get anxious about the poor man and his family, who were being tricked by unscrupulous neighbours. By the time Hunchback Man died, I was sobbing silently, snot running into my sleeve.

'So,' Will said, appearing at my side. He glanced at me slyly. 'You didn't enjoy that at all.'

I looked up and found to my surprise that it was dark outside. 'You're going to gloat now, aren't you?' I muttered, reaching for the box of tissues.

‘A bit. I’m just amazed that you can have reached the ripe old age of – what was it?’

‘Twenty-six.’

‘Twenty-six, and never have watched a film with subtitles.’ He watched me mop my eyes.

I glanced down at the tissue and realized I had no mascara left. ‘I hadn’t realized it was compulsory,’ I grumbled.

‘Okay. So what do you do with yourself, Louisa Clark, if you don’t watch films?’

I balled my tissue in my fist. ‘You want to know what I do when I’m not here?’

‘You were the one who wanted us to get to know each other. So come on, tell me about yourself.’

He had this way of talking where you could never quite be sure that he wasn’t mocking you. I was waiting for the pay-off. ‘Why?’ I said. ‘Why do you want to know all of a sudden?’

‘Oh, for Christ’s sake. It’s hardly a state secret, your social life, is it?’ He had begun to look irritated.

‘I don’t know ...’ I said. ‘I go for a drink at the pub. I watch a bit of telly. I go and watch my boyfriend when he does his running. Nothing unusual.’

‘You watch your boyfriend running.’

‘Yes.’

‘But you don’t run yourself.’

‘No. I’m not really –’ I glanced down at my chest ‘– built for it.’

That made him smile.

‘And what else?’

‘What do you mean, what else?’

‘Hobbies? Travelling? Places you like to go?’

He was beginning to sound like my old careers teacher.

I tried to think. ‘I don’t really have any hobbies. I read a bit. I like clothes.’

‘Handy,’ he said, dryly.

‘You asked. I’m not really a hobby person.’ My voice had become strangely defensive. ‘I don’t do much, okay? I work and then I go home.’

‘Where do you live?’

‘On the other side of the castle. Renfrew Road.’

He looked blank. Of course he did. There was little human traffic between the two sides of the castle. 'It's off the dual carriageway. Near the McDonald's.'

He nodded, although I'm not sure he really knew where I was talking about.

'Holidays?'

'I've been to Spain, with Patrick. My boyfriend,' I added. 'When I was a kid we only really went to Dorset. Or Tenby. My aunt lives in Tenby.'

'And what do you want?'

'What do I want what?'

'From your life?'

I blinked. 'That's a bit deep, isn't it?'

'Only generally. I'm not asking you to psychoanalyse yourself. I'm just asking, what do you want? Get married? Pop out some ankle biters? Dream career? Travel the world?'

There was a long pause.

I think I knew my answer would disappoint him even before I said the words aloud. 'I don't know. I've never really thought about it.'

On Friday we went to the hospital. I'm glad I hadn't known about Will's appointment before I arrived that morning, as I would have lain awake all night fretting about having to drive him there. I can drive, yes. But I say I can drive in the same way that I say I can speak French. Yes, I took the relevant exam and passed. But I haven't used that particular skill more than once a year since I did so. The thought of loading Will and his chair into the adapted minivan and carting him safely to and from the next town filled me with utter terror.

For weeks I had wished that my working day involved some escape from that house. Now I would have done anything just to stay indoors. I located his hospital card amongst the folders of stuff to do with his health – great fat binders divided into 'transport', 'insurance', 'living with disability' and 'appointments'. I grabbed the card and checked that it had today's date. A little bit of me was hoping that Will had been wrong.

'Is your mother coming?'

'No. She doesn't come to my appointments.'

I couldn't hide my surprise. I had thought she would want to oversee every aspect of his treatment.

‘She used to,’ Will said. ‘Now we have an agreement.’

‘Is Nathan coming?’

I was kneeling in front of him. I had been so nervous that I had dropped some of his lunch down his lap and was now trying in vain to mop it up, so that a good patch of his trousers was sopping wet. Will hadn’t said anything, except to tell me to please stop apologizing, but it hadn’t helped my general sense of jitteriness.

‘Why?’

‘No reason.’ I didn’t want him to know how fearful I felt. I had spent much of that morning – time I usually spent cleaning – reading and rereading the instruction manual for the chairlift but I was still dreading the moment when I was solely responsible for lifting him two feet into the air.

‘Come on, Clark. What’s the problem?’

‘Okay. I just ... I just thought it would be easier first time if there was someone else there who knew the ropes.’

‘As opposed to me,’ he said.

‘That’s not what I meant.’

‘Because I can’t possibly be expected to know anything about my own care?’

‘Do you operate the chairlift?’ I said, baldly. ‘You can tell me exactly what to do, can you?’

He watched me, his gaze level. If he had been spoiling for a fight, he appeared to change his mind. ‘Fair point. Yes, he’s coming. He’s a useful extra pair of hands. Plus I thought you’d work yourself into less of a state if you had him there.’

‘I’m not in a state,’ I protested.

‘Evidently.’ He glanced down at his lap, which I was still mopping with a cloth. I had got the pasta sauce off, but he was soaked. ‘So, am I going as an incontinent?’

‘I’m not finished.’ I plugged in the hairdryer and directed the nozzle towards his crotch.

As the hot air blasted on to his trousers he raised his eyebrows.

‘Yes, well,’ I said. ‘It’s not exactly what I expected to be doing on a Friday afternoon either.’

‘You really are tense, aren’t you?’

I could feel him studying me.

‘Oh, lighten up, Clark. I’m the one having scalding hot air directed at my genitals.’

I didn’t respond. I heard his voice over the roar of the hairdryer.

‘Come on, what’s the worst that could happen – I end up in a wheelchair?’

It may sound stupid, but I couldn’t help but laugh. It was the closest Will had come to actually trying to make me feel better.

The car looked like a normal people carrier from outside, but when the rear passenger door was unlocked a ramp descended from the side and lowered to the ground. With Nathan looking on, I guided Will’s outside chair (he had a separate one for travelling) squarely on to the ramp, checked the electrical lock-down brake, and programmed it to slowly lift him up into the car. Nathan slid into the other passenger seat, belted him and secured the wheels. Trying to stop my hands from trembling, I released the handbrake and drove slowly down the drive towards the hospital.

Away from home, Will appeared to shrink a little. It was chilly outside, and Nathan and I had bundled him up into his scarf and thick coat, but still he grew quieter, his jaw set, somehow diminished by the greater space of his surroundings. Every time I looked into my rear-view mirror (which was often – I was terrified even with Nathan there that somehow the chair would break loose from its moorings) he was gazing out of the window, his expression impenetrable. Even when I stalled or braked too hard, which I did several times, he just winced a little and waited while I sorted myself out.

By the time we reached the hospital I had actually broken out into a fine sweat. I drove around the hospital car park three times, too afraid to reverse into any but the largest of spaces, until I could sense that the two men were beginning to lose patience. Then, finally, I lowered the ramp and Nathan helped Will’s chair out on to the tarmac.

‘Good job,’ Nathan said, clapping me on the back as he let himself out, but I found it hard to believe it had been.

There are things you don’t notice until you accompany someone with a wheelchair. One is how rubbish most pavements are, pockmarked with badly patched holes, or just plain uneven. Walking slowly next to Will as he wheeled himself along, I noticed how every uneven slab caused him to jolt painfully, or how often he had to steer carefully round some potential

obstacle. Nathan pretended not to notice, but I saw him watching too. Will just looked grim-faced and resolute.

The other thing is how inconsiderate most drivers are. They park up against the cutouts on the pavement, or so close together that there is no way for a wheelchair to actually cross the road. I was shocked, a couple of times even tempted to leave some rude note tucked into a windscreen wiper, but Nathan and Will seemed used to it. Nathan pointed out a suitable crossing place and, each of us flanking Will, we finally crossed.

Will had not said a single word since leaving the house.

The hospital itself was a gleaming low-rise building, the immaculate reception area more like that of some modernistic hotel, perhaps testament to private insurance. I held back as Will told the receptionist his name, and then followed him and Nathan down a long corridor. Nathan was carrying a huge backpack that contained anything that Will might be likely to need during his short visit, from beakers to spare clothes. He had packed it in front of me that morning, detailing every possible eventuality. 'I guess it's a good thing we don't have to do this too often,' he had said, catching my appalled expression.

I didn't follow him into the appointment. Nathan and I sat on the comfortable chairs outside the consultant's room. There was no hospital smell, and there were fresh flowers in a vase on the windowsill. Not just any old flowers, either. Huge exotic things that I didn't know the name of, artfully arranged in minimalist clumps.

'What are they doing in there?' I said after we had been there half an hour.

Nathan looked up from his book. 'It's just his six-month check-up.'

'What, to see if he's getting any better?'

Nathan put his book down. 'He's not getting any better. It's a spinal cord injury.'

'But you do physio and stuff with him.'

'That's to try and keep his physical condition up – to stop him atrophying and his bones demineralizing, his legs pooling, that kind of thing.'

When he spoke again, his voice was gentle, as if he thought he might disappoint me. 'He's not going to walk again, Louisa. That only happens in Hollywood movies. All we're doing is trying to keep him out of pain, and keep up whatever range of movement he has.'

‘Does he do this stuff for you? The physio stuff? He doesn’t seem to want to do anything that I suggest.’

Nathan wrinkled his nose. ‘He does it, but I don’t think his heart’s in it. When I first came, he was pretty determined. He’d come pretty far in rehab, but after a year with no improvement I think he found it pretty tough to keep believing it was worth it.’

‘Do you think he should keep trying?’

Nathan stared at the floor. ‘Honestly? He’s a C5/6 quadriplegic. That means nothing works below about here ...’ He placed a hand on the upper part of his chest. ‘They haven’t worked out how to fix a spinal cord yet.’

I stared at the door, thinking about Will’s face as we drove along in the winter sunshine, the beaming face of the man on the skiing holiday. ‘There are all sorts of medical advances taking place, though, right? I mean ... somewhere like this ... they must be working on stuff all the time.’

‘It’s a pretty good hospital,’ he said evenly.

‘Where there’s life, and all that?’

Nathan looked at me, then back at his book. ‘Sure,’ he said.

I went to get a coffee at a quarter to three, on Nathan’s say so. He said these appointments could go on for some time, and that he would hold the fort until I got back. I dawdled a little in the reception area, flicking through the magazines in the newsagent’s, lingering over chocolate bars.

Perhaps predictably, I got lost trying to find my way back to the corridor and had to ask several nurses where I should go, two of whom didn’t even know. When I got there, the coffee cooling in my hand, the corridor was empty. As I drew closer, I could see the consultant’s door was ajar. I hesitated outside, but I could hear Mrs Traynor’s voice in my ears all the time now, criticizing me for leaving him. I had done it again.

‘So we’ll see you in three months’ time, Mr Traynor,’ a voice was saying. ‘I’ve adjusted those anti-spasm meds and I’ll make sure someone calls you with the results of the tests. Probably Monday.’

I heard Will’s voice. ‘Can I get these from the pharmacy downstairs?’

‘Yes. Here. They should be able to give you some more of those too.’

A woman’s voice. ‘Shall I take that folder?’

I realized they must be about to leave. I knocked, and someone called for me to come in. Two sets of eyes swivelled towards me.

‘I’m sorry,’ said the consultant, rising from his chair. ‘I thought you were the physio.’

‘I’m Will’s ... helper,’ I said, hanging on to the door. Will was braced forward in his chair as Nathan pulled down his shirt. ‘Sorry – I thought you were done.’

‘Just give us a minute, will you, Louisa?’ Will’s voice cut into the room.

Muttering my apologies I backed out, my face burning.

It wasn’t the sight of Will’s uncovered body that had shocked me, slim and scarred as it was. It wasn’t the vaguely irritated look of the consultant, the same sort of look as Mrs Traynor gave me day after day – a look that made me realize I was still the same blundering eejit, even if I did earn a higher hourly rate.

No, it was the livid red lines scoring Will’s wrists, the long, jagged scars that couldn’t be disguised, no matter how swiftly Nathan pulled down Will’s sleeves.



6

The snow came so suddenly that I left home under a bright blue sky and not half an hour later I was headed past a castle that looked like a cake decoration, surrounded by a layer of thick white icing.

I trudged up the drive, my footsteps muffled and my toes already numb, shivering under my too-thin Chinese silk coat. A whirl of thick white flakes emerged from an iron-grey infinity, almost obscuring Granta House, blotting out sound, and slowing the world to an unnatural pace. Beyond the neatly trimmed hedge cars drove past with a newfound caution, pedestrians slipped and squealed on the pavements. I pulled my scarf up over my nose and wished I had worn something more suitable than ballet pumps and a velvet minidress.

To my surprise it wasn't Nathan who opened the door, but Will's father.

'He's in bed,' he said, glancing up from under the porch. 'He's not too good. I was just wondering whether to call the doctor.'

'Where's Nathan?'

'Morning off. Of course, it would be today. Bloody agency nurse came and went in six seconds flat. If this snow keeps on I'm not sure what we'll do later.' He shrugged, as if these things couldn't be helped, and disappeared back down the corridor, apparently relieved that he no longer had to be responsible. 'You know what he needs, yes?' he called over his shoulder.

I took off my coat and shoes and, as I knew Mrs Traynor was in court (she marked her dates on a diary in Will's kitchen), I put my wet socks over

a radiator to dry. A pair of Will's were in the clean-washing basket, so I put them on. They looked comically large on me but it was heaven to have warm, dry feet. Will didn't respond when I called out, so after a while I made him up a drink, knocked quietly and poked my head round the door. In the dim light I could just make out the shape under the duvet. He was fast asleep.

I took a step backwards, closed the door behind me, and began working my way through the morning's tasks.

My mother seemed to glean an almost physical satisfaction from a well-ordered house. I had been vacuuming and cleaning daily for a month now, and I still couldn't see the attraction. I suspected there would never be a point in my life when I wouldn't prefer somebody else to do it.

But on a day like today, when Will was confined to bed, and the world seemed to have stilled outside, I could also see there was a kind of meditative pleasure in working my way from one end of the annexe to the other. While I dusted and polished, I took the radio from room to room with me, keeping the volume low so that I didn't disturb Will. Periodically I poked my head round the door, just to see that he was breathing, and it was only when we got to one o'clock and he still hadn't woken up that I started to feel a little anxious.

I filled the log basket, noting that several inches of snow had now settled. I made Will a fresh drink, and then knocked. When I knocked again, I did so loudly.

'Yes?' His voice was hoarse, as if I had woken him.

'It's me.' When he didn't respond, I said, 'Louisa. Am I okay to come in?'

'I'm hardly doing the Dance of the Seven Veils.'

The room was shadowed, the curtains still drawn. I walked in, letting my eyes adjust to the light. Will was on one side, one arm bent in front of him as if to prop himself up, as he had been before when I looked in. Sometimes it was easy to forget he would not be able to turn over by himself. His hair stuck up on one side, and a duvet was tucked neatly around him. The smell of warm, unwashed male filled the room – not unpleasant, but still a little startling as part of a working day.

'What can I do? Do you want your drink?'

'I need to change position.'

I put the drink down on a chest of drawers, and walked over to the bed.
'What ... what do you want me to do?'

He swallowed carefully, as if it were painful. 'Lift and turn me, then raise the back of the bed. Here ...' He nodded for me to come closer. 'Put your arms under mine, link your hands behind my back and then pull back. Keep your backside on the bed and that way you shouldn't strain your lower back.'

I couldn't pretend this wasn't a bit weird. I reached around him, the scent of him filling my nostrils, his skin warm against mine. I could not have been in any closer unless I had begun nibbling on his ear. The thought made me mildly hysterical, and I struggled to keep myself together.

'What?'

'Nothing.' I took a breath, linked my hands, and adjusted my position until I felt I had him securely. He was broader than I had expected, somehow heavier. And then, on a count of three, I pulled back.

'Jesus,' he exclaimed, into my shoulder.

'What?' I nearly dropped him.

'Your hands are bloody freezing.'

'Yes. Well, if you bothered to get out of bed, you'd know that it's actually snowing outside.'

I was half joking, but now I realized his skin was hot under his T-shirt – an intense heat that seemed to come from deep within him. He groaned slightly as I adjusted him against the pillow, and I tried to make my movements as slow and gentle as possible. He pointed out the remote control device that would bring his head and shoulders up. 'Not too much, though,' he murmured. 'A bit dizzy.'

I turned on the bedside light, ignoring his vague protest, so that I could see his face. 'Will – are you okay?' I had to say it twice before he answered me.

'Not my best day.'

'Do you need painkillers?'

'Yes ... strong ones.'

'Maybe some paracetamol?'

He lay back against the cool pillow with a sigh.

I gave him the beaker, watched him swallow.

'Thank you,' he said afterwards, and I felt suddenly uneasy.

Will never thanked me for anything.

He closed his eyes, and for a while I just stood in the doorway and watched him, his chest rising and falling under his T-shirt, his mouth slightly open. His breathing was shallow, and perhaps a little more laboured than on other days. But I had never seen him out of his chair, and I wasn't sure whether it was something to do with the pressure of lying down.

'Go,' he muttered.

I left.

I read my magazine, lifting my head only to watch the snow settle thickly around the house, creeping up the window sills in powdery landscapes. Mum sent me a text message at 12.30pm, telling me that my father couldn't get the car down the road. 'Don't set out for home without ringing us first,' she instructed. I wasn't sure what she thought she was going to do – send Dad out with a sledge and a St Bernard?

I listened to the local news on the radio, the motorway snarl-ups, train stoppages and temporary school closures that the unexpected blizzard had brought with it. I went back into Will's room, and looked at him again. I didn't like his colour. He was pale, high points of something bright on each cheek.

'Will?' I said softly.

He didn't stir.

'Will?'

I began to feel the faint stirrings of panic. I said his name twice more, loudly. There was no response. Finally, I leant over him. There was no obvious movement in his face, nothing I could see in his chest. His breath. I should be able to feel his breath. I put my face down close to his, trying to detect an out breath. When I couldn't, I reached out a hand and touched his face gently.

He flinched, his eyes snapping open, just inches from my own.

'I'm sorry,' I said, jumping back.

He blinked, glancing around the room, as if he had been somewhere far from home.

'It's Lou,' I said, when I wasn't sure if he had recognized me.

His expression was one of mild exasperation. 'I know.'

'Do you want some soup?'

'No. Thank you.' He closed his eyes.

'More painkillers?'

There was a faint sheen of sweat on his cheekbone. I put my hand out, his duvet felt vaguely hot and sweaty. It made me nervous.

‘Is there something I should be doing? I mean, if Nathan can’t get here?’

‘No ... I’m fine,’ he murmured, and closed his eyes again.

I went through the folder, trying to work out if I was missing something. I opened the medical cabinet, the boxes of rubber gloves and gauze dressings, and realized I had no idea at all what I should do with any of it. I rang the intercom to speak to Will’s father, but the ringing sound disappeared into an empty house. I could hear it echoing beyond the annexe door.

I was about to ring Mrs Traynor when the back door opened, and Nathan stepped in, wrapped in layers of bulky clothing, a woollen scarf and hat almost obscuring his head. He brought with him a whoosh of cold air and a light flurry of snow.

‘Hey,’ he said, shaking the snow off his boots and slamming the door behind him.

It felt like the house had suddenly woken from a dreamlike state.

‘Oh, thank God you’re here,’ I said. ‘He’s not well. He’s been asleep most of the morning and he’s hardly drunk anything. I didn’t know what to do.’

Nathan shrugged off his coat. ‘Had to walk all the way here. The buses have stopped running.’

I set about making him some tea, as he went to check on Will.

He reappeared before the kettle had even finished boiling. ‘He’s burning up,’ he said. ‘How long has he been like this?’

‘All morning. I did think he was hot, but he said he just wanted to sleep.’

‘Jesus. All morning? Didn’t you know he can’t regulate his own temperature?’ He pushed past me and began rummaging around in the medicine cabinet. ‘Antibiotics. The strong ones.’ He held up a jar and emptied one into the pestle and mortar, grinding it furiously.

I hovered behind him. ‘I gave him a paracetamol.’

‘Might as well have given him an Opal Fruit.’

‘I didn’t know. Nobody said. I’ve been wrapping him up.’

‘It’s in the bloody folder. Look, Will doesn’t sweat like we do. In fact he doesn’t sweat at all from the point of his injury downwards. It means if he gets a slight chill his temperature gauge goes haywire. Go find the fan. We’ll move that in there until he cools down. And a damp towel, to put

around the back of his neck. We won't be able to get him to a doctor until the snow stops. Bloody agency nurse. They should have picked this up in the morning.'

Nathan was crosser than I'd ever seen him. He was no longer really even talking to me.

I ran for the fan.

It took almost forty minutes for Will's temperature to return to an acceptable level. While we waited for the extra-strong fever medication to take effect, I placed a towel over his forehead and another around his neck, as Nathan instructed. We stripped him down, covered his chest with a fine cotton sheet, and set the fan to play over it. Without sleeves, the scars on his arms were clearly exposed. We all pretended I couldn't see them.

Will endured all this attention in near silence, answering Nathan's questions with a yes or no, so indistinct sometimes that I wasn't sure if he knew what he was saying. I realized, now I could see him in the light, that he looked really, properly ill and I felt terrible for having failed to grasp it. I said sorry until Nathan told me it had become irritating.

'Right,' he said. 'You need to watch what I'm doing. It's possible you may need to do this alone later.'

I didn't feel I could protest. But I found it hard not to feel squeamish as Nathan peeled down the waist of Will's pyjama bottoms, revealing a pale strip of bare stomach, and carefully removed the gauze dressing around the little tube in his abdomen, cleaning it gently and replacing the dressing. He showed me how to change the bag on the bed, explained why it must always be lower than Will's body, and I was surprised at how matter-of-fact I was about walking out of the room with the pouch of warm fluid. I was glad that Will wasn't really watching me – not just because he would have made some sharp comment, but because I felt that me witnessing some part of this intimate routine would in some way have embarrassed him too.

'And that's it,' Nathan said. Finally, an hour later, Will lay dozing, lying on fresh cotton sheets and looking, if not exactly well, then not scarily ill.

'Let him sleep. But wake him after a couple of hours and make sure you get the best part of a beaker of fluids into him. More fever meds at five, okay? His temperature will probably shoot up again in the last hour, but nothing more before five.'

I scribbled everything down on a notepad. I was afraid of getting anything wrong.

‘Now you’re going to need to repeat what we just did, this evening. You’re okay with that?’ Nathan wrapped himself up like an Inuit and headed out into the snow. ‘Just read the folder. And don’t panic. Any problems, you just call me. I’ll talk you through it all. I’ll get back here again if I really have to.’

I stayed in Will’s room after Nathan left. I was too afraid not to. In the corner was an old leather armchair with a reading light, perhaps dating from Will’s previous life, and I curled up on it with a book of short stories that I had pulled from the bookcase.

It was strangely peaceful in that room. Through the crack in the curtains I could see the outside world, blanketed in white, still and beautiful. Inside it was warm and silent, only the odd tick and hiss of the central heating to interrupt my thoughts. I read, and occasionally I glanced up and checked Will sleeping peacefully and I realized that there had never been a point in my life before where I had just sat in silence and done nothing. You don’t grow up used to silence in a house like mine, with its never-ending vacuuming, television blaring, and shrieking. During the rare moments that the television was off, Dad would put on his old Elvis records and play them at full blast. A cafe too is a constant buzz of noise and clatter.

Here, I could hear my thoughts. I could almost hear my heartbeat. I realized, to my surprise, that I quite liked it.

At five, my mobile phone signalled a text message. Will stirred, and I leapt out of the chair, anxious to get it before it disturbed him.

No trains. Is there any chance you could stay over tonight?

Nathan cannot do it. Camilla Traynor.

I didn’t really think about it before I typed back.

No problem.

I rang my parents and told them that I would stay over. My mother sounded relieved. When I told her I was going to get paid for sleeping over, she sounded overjoyed.

‘Did you hear that, Bernard?’ she said, her hand half over the phone. ‘They’re paying her to sleep now.’

I could hear my father’s exclamation. ‘Praise the Lord. She’s found her dream career.’

I sent a text message to Patrick, telling him that I had been asked to stay at work and I would ring him later. The message came back within seconds.

Going cross-country snow running tonight.

Good practice for Norway! X P.

I wondered how it was possible for someone to get so excited at the thought of jogging through sub-zero temperatures in a vest and pants.

Will slept. I cooked myself some food, and defrosted some soup in case he wanted some later. I got the log fire going in case he felt well enough to go into the living room. I read another of the short stories and wondered how long it was since I had bought myself a book. I had loved reading as a child, but I couldn't remember reading anything except magazines since. Treen was the reader. It was almost as if by picking up a book I felt like I was invading her patch. I thought about her and Thomas disappearing to university and realized I still didn't know whether it made me feel happy or sad – or something a bit complicated in between.

Nathan rang at seven. He seemed relieved that I was staying over.

'I couldn't raise Mr Traynor. I even rang their landline number, but it went straight through to answerphone.'

'Yeah. Well. He'll be gone.'

'Gone?'

I felt a sudden instinctive panic at the idea that it would be just Will and me in the house all night. I was afraid of getting something fundamental wrong again, of jeopardizing Will's health. 'Should I call Mrs Traynor, then?'

There was a short silence on the other end of the phone. 'No. Best not.'

'But –'

'Look, Lou, he often ... he often goes somewhere else when Mrs T stays over in town.'

It took me a minute or two to grasp what he was saying.

'Oh.'

'It's just good that you're there, that's all. If you're sure Will's looking better, I'll be back first thing in the morning.'

There are normal hours, and then there are invalid hours, where time stalls and slips, where life – real life – seems to exist at one remove. I watched some television, ate, and cleared up the kitchen, drifting around the annexe in silence. Finally, I let myself back into Will's room.

He stirred as I closed the door, half lifting his head. 'What time is it, Clark?' His voice was slightly muffled by the pillow.

'Quarter past eight.'

He let his head drop, and digested this. 'Can I have a drink?'

There was no sharpness to him now, no edge. It was as if being ill had finally made him vulnerable. I gave him a drink, and turned on the bedside light. I perched on the side of his bed, and felt his forehead, as my mother might have done when I was a child. He was still a little warm, but nothing like he had been.

'Cool hands.'

'You complained about them earlier.'

'Did I?' He sounded genuinely surprised.

'Would you like some soup?'

'No.'

'Are you comfortable?'

I never knew how much discomfort he was in, but I suspected it was more than he let on.

'The other side would be good. Just roll me. I don't need to sit up.'

I climbed across the bed and moved him over, as gently as I could. He no longer radiated a sinister heat, just the ordinary warmth of a body that had spent time under a duvet.

'Can I do anything else?'

'Shouldn't you be heading home?'

'It's okay,' I said. 'I'm staying over.'

Outside, the last of the light had long been extinguished. The snow was still falling. Where it caught the porch glow through the window it was bathed in a pale-gold, melancholy light. We sat there in peaceful silence, watching its hypnotic fall.

'Can I ask you something?' I said, finally. I could see his hands on top of the sheet. It seemed so strange that they should look so ordinary, so strong, and yet be so useless.

'I suspect you're going to.'

'What happened?' I kept wondering about the marks on his wrists. It was the one question I couldn't ask directly.

He opened one eye. 'How did I get like this?'

When I nodded, he closed his eyes again. 'Motorbike accident. Not mine. I was an innocent pedestrian.'

‘I thought it would be skiing or bungee jumping or something.’

‘Everyone does. God’s little joke. I was crossing the road outside my home. Not this place,’ he said. ‘My London home.’

I stared at the books in his bookshelf. Among the novels, the well-thumbed Penguin paperbacks, were business titles: *Corporate Law*, *TakeOver*, directories of names I did not recognize.

‘And there was no way you could carry on with your job?’

‘No. Nor the apartment, the holidays, the life ... I believe you met my ex-girlfriend.’ The break in his voice couldn’t disguise the bitterness. ‘But I should apparently be grateful, as for some time they didn’t think I was going to live at all.’

‘Do you hate it? Living here, I mean?’

‘Yes.’

‘Is there any way you might be able to live in London again?’

‘Not like this, no.’

‘But you might improve. I mean, Nathan said there are loads of advances in this kind of injury.’

Will closed his eyes again.

I waited, and then I adjusted the pillow behind his head, and the duvet around his chest. ‘Sorry,’ I said, sitting upright. ‘If I ask too many questions. Do you want me to leave?’

‘No. Stay for a bit. Talk to me.’ He swallowed. His eyes opened again and his gaze slid up to mine. He looked unbearably tired. ‘Tell me something good.’

I hesitated a moment, then I leant back against the pillows beside him. We sat there in the near dark, watching the briefly illuminated flakes of snow disappear into the black night.

‘You know ... I used to say that to my Dad,’ I said, finally. ‘But if I told you what he used to say back, you’d think I was insane.’

‘More than I do?’

‘When I had a nightmare or was sad or frightened about something, he used to sing me ...’ I started to laugh. ‘Oh ... I can’t.’

‘Go on.’

‘He used to sing me the “Molahonkey Song”.’

‘The what?’

‘The “Molahonkey Song”. I used to think everyone knew it.’

‘Trust me, Clark,’ he murmured, ‘I am a Molahonkey virgin.’

I took a deep breath, closed my eyes and began to sing.

I wi-li-lished I li-li-lived in Molahonkey la-la-land
The la-la-land where I-li-li was bo-lo-lo-lo-lo-lo-lorn
So I-li-li could play-la-lay my o-lo-lold banjo-lo-lo
My o-lo-lold ban-jo-lo-lo won't go-lo-lo-lo-lo-lo-lo.

‘Jesus Christ.’

I took another breath.

I too-lo-look it to-lo-lo the me-le-lender's sho-lo-lop to
See-lee-lee what they-le-ley could do-lo-lo-lo-lo-lo-lo
They sai-lai-laid to me-le-le your stri-li-lings are sho-lo-lot
They're no-lo-lo more u-lu-luse to you-lo-lo-lo-lo-lo-loo.

There was a short silence.

‘You are insane. Your whole family is insane.’

‘But it worked.’

‘And you are a God-awful singer. I hope your dad was better.’

‘I think what you meant to say was, “Thank you, Miss Clark, for attempting to entertain me.”’

‘I suppose it makes about as much sense as most of the psychotherapeutic help I’ve received. Okay, Clark,’ he said, ‘tell me something else. Something that doesn’t involve singing.’

I thought for a bit.

‘Um ... okay, well ... you were looking at my shoes the other day?’

‘Hard not to.’

‘Well, my mum can date my unusual shoe thing back to when I was three. She bought me a pair of bright-turquoise glittery wellies – they were quite unusual back then – kids used to just have those green ones, or maybe red if you were lucky. And she said from the day she brought them home I refused to take them off. I wore them to bed, in the bath, to nursery all through the summer. My favourite outfit was those glitter boots and my bumblebee tights.’

‘Bumblebee tights?’

‘Black and yellow stripes.’

‘Gorgeous.’

‘That’s a bit harsh.’

‘Well, it’s true. They sound revolting.’

‘They might sound revolting to you, but astonishingly, Will Traynor, not all girls get dressed just to please men.’

‘Bullshit.’

‘No, it’s not.’

‘Everything women do is with men in mind. Everything anyone does is with sex in mind. Haven’t you read *The Red Queen*?’

‘I have no idea what you’re talking about. But I can assure you I’m not sitting on your bed singing the “Molahonkey Song” because I’m trying to get my leg over. And when I was three, I just really, really liked having stripy legs.’

I realized that the anxiety that had held me in its grip all day was slowly ebbing away with every one of Will’s comments. I was no longer in sole charge of a poorly quadriplegic. It was just me, sitting next to a particularly sarcastic bloke, having a chat.

‘So come on, then, what happened to these gorgeous glittery wellies?’

‘She had to throw them away. I got terrible athlete’s foot.’

‘Delightful.’

‘And she threw the tights away too.’

‘Why?’

‘I never found out. But it broke my heart. I have never found a pair of tights I loved like that again. They don’t do them any more. Or if they do, they don’t make them for grown women.’

‘Strange, that.’

‘Oh, you can mock. Didn’t you ever love anything that much?’

I could barely see him now, the room shrouded in the near dark. I could have turned the overhead light on, but something stopped me. And almost as soon as I realized what I had said, I wished I hadn’t.

‘Yes,’ he said, quietly. ‘Yes, I did.’

We talked a bit longer, and then Will nodded off. I lay there, watching him breathe, and occasionally wondering what he would say if he woke up and found me staring at him, at his too-long hair and tired eyes and scraggy beginnings of a beard. But I couldn’t move. The hours had become surreal, an island out of time. I was the only other person in the house, and I was still afraid to leave him.

Shortly after eleven, I saw he had begun to sweat again, his breathing becoming shallower, and I woke him and made him take some fever medication. He didn’t talk, except to murmur his thanks. I changed his top sheet and his pillowcase, and then, when he finally slept again, I lay down a foot away from him and, a long time later, I slept too.

I woke to the sound of my name. I was in a classroom, asleep on my desk, and the teacher was rapping a blackboard, repeating my name again and again. I knew I should be paying attention, knew that the teacher would see this slumber as an act of subversion, but I could not raise my head from the desk.

‘Louisa.’

‘Mmmhghh.’

‘Louisa.’

The desk was awfully soft. I opened my eyes. The words were being spoken over my head, hissed, but with great emphasis. *Louisa*.

I was in bed. I blinked, letting my eyes focus, then looked up to find Camilla Traynor standing over me. She wore a heavy wool coat and her handbag was slung over her shoulder.

‘Louisa.’

I pushed myself upright with a start. Beside me, Will was asleep under the covers, his mouth slightly open, his elbow bent at right angles in front of him. Light seeped in through the window; telling of a cold, bright morning.

‘Uh.’

‘What are you doing?’

I felt as if I had been caught doing something awful. I rubbed at my face, trying to gather my thoughts. Why was I in here? What could I tell her?

‘What are you doing in Will’s bed?’

‘Will ... ’ I said, quietly. ‘Will wasn’t well ... I just thought I should keep an eye –’

‘What do you mean, he wasn’t well? Look, come out into the hall.’ She strode out of the room, evidently waiting for me to catch her up.

I followed, trying to straighten my clothes. I had a horrible feeling my make-up was smeared all over my face.

She closed Will’s bedroom door behind me.

I stood in front of her, trying to smooth my hair as I gathered my thoughts. ‘Will had a temperature. Nathan got it down when he came, but I didn’t know about this regulating thing and I wanted to keep an eye on him ... he said I should keep an eye on him ... ’ My voice sounded thick, unformed. I wasn’t entirely sure I was making coherent sentences.

‘Why didn’t you call me? If he was ill you should have called me immediately. Or Mr Traynor.’

It was as if my synapses had suddenly snapped together. *Mr Traynor. Oh Lord.* I glanced up at the clock. It was a quarter to eight.

‘I didn’t ... Nathan seemed to ... ’

‘Look, Louisa. It’s really not rocket science. If Will was ill enough for you to sleep in his room then that is something you should have contacted me about.’

‘Yes.’

I blinked, staring at the ground.

‘I don’t understand why you didn’t call. Did you attempt to call Mr Traynor?’

Nathan said not to say anything.

‘I –’

At that moment the door to the annexe opened, and Mr Traynor stood there, a newspaper folded under his arm. ‘You made it back!’ he said to his wife, brushing snowflakes from his shoulders. ‘I’ve just fought my way up the road to get a newspaper and some milk. Roads are absolutely treacherous. I had to go the long way to Hansford Corner, to avoid the ice patches.’

She looked at him and I wondered for a moment whether she was registering the fact that he was wearing the same shirt and jumper as the previous day.

‘Did you know Will had been ill in the night?’

He looked straight at me. I dropped my gaze to my feet. I wasn’t sure I had ever felt more uncomfortable.

‘Did you try to call me, Louisa? I’m sorry – I didn’t hear a thing. I suspect that intercom’s on the blink. There have been a few occasions lately where I’ve missed it. And I wasn’t feeling too good myself last night. Out like a light.’

I was still wearing Will’s socks. I stared at them, wondering if Mrs Traynor was going to judge me for that too.

But she seemed distracted. ‘It’s been a long journey home. I think ... I’ll leave you to it. But if anything like this happens again, you call me immediately. Do you understand?’

I didn’t want to look at Mr Traynor. ‘Yes,’ I said, and disappeared into the kitchen.



7

Spring arrived overnight, as if winter, like some unwanted guest, had abruptly shrugged its way into its coat and vanished, without saying goodbye. Everything became greener, the roads bathed in watery sunshine, the air suddenly balmy. There were hints of something floral and welcoming in the air, birdsong the gentle backdrop to the day.

I didn't notice any of it. I had stayed at Patrick's house the evening before. It was the first time I had seen him for almost a week due to his enhanced training schedule, but having spent forty minutes in the bath with half a pack of bath salts, he was so exhausted he could barely talk to me. I had begun stroking his back, in a rare attempt at seduction, and he had murmured that he was really too tired, his hand flicking as if he were swatting me away. I was still awake and staring at his ceiling discontentedly four hours later.

Patrick and I had met while I was doing the only other job I have ever held, that of trainee at The Cutting Edge, Hailsbury's only unisex hairdresser's. He walked in while Samantha, the proprietor, was busy, asking for a number four. I gave him what he described afterwards as the worst haircut not only that he had ever had, but the worst haircut in the history of mankind. Three months later, realizing that a love of fiddling with my own hair did not necessarily mean that I was cut out to do anyone else's, I left and got the job at the cafe with Frank.

When we started going out, Patrick had been working in sales and his favourite things could have been listed as beer, garage chocolate, talking

about sport and sex (doing, not talking about), in that order. A good night out for us would probably comprise all four. He was ordinary-looking rather than handsome, and his bum was podgier than mine, but I liked it. I liked the solidity of him, the way he felt when I wrapped myself around him. His dad was dead and I liked the way he acted towards his mother; protective and solicitous. And his four brothers and sisters were like the Waltons. They actually seemed to like each other. The first time we went out on a date, a little voice in my head said: *This man will never hurt you*, and nothing he had done in the seven years since had led me to doubt it.

And then he turned into Marathon Man.

Patrick's stomach no longer gave when I nestled into him; it was a hard, unforgiving thing, like a sideboard, and he was prone to pulling up his shirt and hitting it with things, to prove quite how hard it was. His face was planed, and weathered from his time spent constantly outdoors. His thighs were solid muscle. That would have been quite sexy in itself, had he actually wanted to have sex. But we were down to about twice a month, and I wasn't the kind to ask.

It was as if the fitter he got, the more obsessed by his own shape he became, the less interested he was in mine. I asked him a couple of times if he didn't fancy me any more, but he seemed pretty definite. 'You're gorgeous,' he would say. 'I'm just shattered. Anyway, I don't want you to lose weight. The girls at the club – you couldn't make one decent boob out of all of theirs put together.' I wanted to ask how exactly he had come to work out this complex equation, but it was basically a nice thing to say so I let it go.

I wanted to be interested in what he did, I really did. I went to the triathlon club nights, I tried to chat to the other girls. But I soon realized I was an anomaly – there were no girlfriends like me – everyone else in the club was single, or involved with someone equally physically impressive. The couples pushed each other on workouts, planned weekends in spandex shorts and carried pictures of each other in their wallets completing triathlons hand in hand, or smugly comparing joint medals. It was unspeakable.

'I don't know what you're complaining about,' my sister said when I told her. 'I've had sex once since I had Thomas.'

'What? Who with?'

‘Oh, some bloke who came in for a Vibrant Hand-Tied,’ she said. ‘I just wanted to make sure I still could.’

And then, when my jaw dropped, ‘Oh, don’t look like that. It wasn’t during working hours. And they were funeral flowers. If they had been wife flowers, of course I wouldn’t have touched him with a gladioli.’

It’s not that I was some kind of sex maniac – we’d been together a long time, after all. It’s just that some perverse bit of me had begun to question my own attractiveness.

Patrick had never minded the fact that I dressed ‘inventively’, as he put it. But what if he hadn’t been entirely truthful? Patrick’s job, his whole social life now revolved around the control of flesh – taming it, reducing it, honing it. What if, faced with those tight little tracksuited bottoms, my own suddenly seemed wanting? What if my curves, which I had always thought of as pleasantly voluptuous, now seemed doughy to his exacting eyes?

These were the thoughts that were still humming messily around my head as Mrs Traynor came in and pretty much ordered Will and me to go outside. ‘I’ve asked the cleaners to come and do a special spring clean, so I thought perhaps you could enjoy the nice weather while they’re all in there.’

Will’s eyes met mine with the faintest lift of his eyebrows. ‘It’s not really a request, is it, Mother?’

‘I just think it would be good if you took some air,’ she said. ‘The ramp is in place. Perhaps, Louisa, you might take some tea out there with you?’

It wasn’t an entirely unreasonable suggestion. The garden was beautiful. It was as if with the slight lifting of temperatures everything had suddenly decided to look a little bit greener. Daffodils had emerged as if from nowhere, their yellowing bulbs hinting at the flowers to come. Buds burst from brown branches, perennials forcing their way tentatively through the dark, claggy soil. I opened the doors and we went outside, Will keeping his chair on the York stone path. He gestured towards a cast-iron bench with a cushion on it, and I sat there for some time, our faces lifted to the weak sunshine, listening to the sparrows squabbling in the hedgerow.

‘What’s up with you?’

‘What do you mean?’

‘You’re quiet.’

‘You said you wanted me to be quiet.’

‘Not this quiet. It alarms me.’

‘I’m all right,’ I said. And then, ‘It’s just boyfriend stuff, if you really want to know.’

‘Ah,’ he said. ‘Running Man.’

I opened my eyes, just to see if he was mocking me.

‘What’s the matter?’ he said. ‘Come on, tell Uncle Will.’

‘No.’

‘My mother is going to have the cleaners running around like lunatics in there for at least another hour. You’re going to have to talk about something.’

I pushed myself upright, and turned to face him. His house chair had a control button that elevated his seat so that he could address people at head height. He didn’t often use it, as it frequently made him dizzy, but it was working now. I actually had to look up at him.

I pulled my coat around me, and squinted at him. ‘Go on, then, what do you want to know?’

‘How long have you two been together?’ he said.

‘Bit over six years.’

He looked surprised. ‘That’s a long time.’

‘Yes,’ I said. ‘Well.’

I leant over and adjusted a rug across him. It was deceptive, the sunshine – it promised more than it could actually deliver. I thought of Patrick, up at 6.30 sharp this morning to go for his morning run. Perhaps I should take up running, so that we would become one of those Lycra-clad couples. Perhaps I should buy frilly underwear and look up sex tips online. I knew I would do neither.

‘What does he do?’

‘He’s a personal trainer.’

‘Hence the running.’

‘Hence the running.’

‘What’s he like? In three words, if it makes you uncomfortable.’

I thought about it. ‘Positive. Loyal. Obsessed with body fat ratios.’

‘That’s seven words.’

‘Then you got four for free. So what was she like?’

‘Who?’

‘Alicia?’ I looked at him like he had looked at me, directly. He took a deep breath and gazed upwards to a large plane tree. His hair fell down into his eyes and I fought the urge to push it to one side for him.

‘Gorgeous. Sexy. High maintenance. Surprisingly insecure.’

‘What does she have to be insecure about?’ The words left my mouth before I could help myself.

He looked almost amused. ‘You’d be surprised,’ he said. ‘Girls like Lissa trade on their looks for so long they don’t think they have anything else. Actually, I’m being unfair. She’s good with stuff. Things – clothes, interiors. She can make things look beautiful.’

I fought the urge to say anyone could make things look beautiful if they had a wallet as deep as a diamond mine.

‘She could move a few things around in a room, and it would look completely different. I never could work out how she did it.’ He nodded towards the house. ‘She did this annexe, when I first moved in.’

I found myself reviewing the perfectly designed living room. I realized my admiration of it was suddenly slightly less uncomplicated than it had been.

‘How long were you with her?’

‘Eight, nine months.’

‘Not that long.’

‘Long for me.’

‘How did you meet?’

‘Dinner party. A really awful dinner party. You?’

‘Hairdresser’s. I was one. He was my client.’

‘Hah. You were his something extra for the weekend.’

I must have looked blank because he shook his head and said softly, ‘Never mind.’

Inside, we could hear the dull drone of the vacuum cleaner. There were four women in the cleaning company, all wearing matching housecoats. I had wondered what they would find to do for two hours in the little annexe.

‘Do you miss her?’

I could hear them talking amongst themselves. Someone had opened a window, and occasional bursts of laughter filtered out into the thin air.

Will seemed to be watching something in the far-off distance. ‘I used to.’ He turned to me, his voice matter-of-fact. ‘But I’ve been thinking about it, and I’ve decided that she and Rupert are a good match.’

I nodded. ‘They’ll have a ridiculous wedding, pop out an ankle biter or two, as you put it, buy a place in the country, and he’ll be shagging his secretary within five years,’ I said.

‘You’re probably right.’

I was warming to my theme now. ‘And she will be a little bit cross with him all the time without really knowing why and bitch about him at really awful dinner parties to the embarrassment of their friends, and he won’t want to leave because he’ll be scared of all the alimony.’

Will turned to look at me.

‘And they will have sex once every six weeks and he will adore his children while doing bugger all to actually help look after them. And she will have perfect hair but get this kind of pinched face –’ I narrowed my mouth ‘– through never saying what she actually means, and start an insane Pilates habit or maybe buy a dog or a horse and develop a crush on her riding instructor. And he will take up jogging when he hits forty, and maybe buy a Harley-Davidson, which she will despise, and every day he will go to work and look at all the young men in his office and listen in bars to who they pulled at the weekend or where they went on a jolly and feel like somehow – and he will never be quite sure how – he got suckered.’

I turned.

Will was staring at me.

‘Sorry,’ I said, after a moment. ‘I don’t really know where that came from.’

‘I’m starting to feel just the tiniest bit sorry for Running Man.’

‘Oh, it’s not him,’ I said. ‘It’s working at a cafe for years. You see and hear everything. Patterns, in people’s behaviour. You’d be amazed at what goes on.’

‘Is that why you’ve never got married?’

I blinked. ‘I suppose so.’

I didn’t want to say I had never actually been asked.

It may sound as though we didn’t do much. But, in truth, the days with Will were subtly different – depending on his mood and, more importantly, how much pain he was in. Some days I would arrive and I could see from the set of his jaw that he didn’t want to talk to me – or to anyone – and, noting this, I would busy myself around the annexe, trying to anticipate his needs so that I didn’t have to bother him by asking.

There were all sorts of things that caused him pain. There were the general aches that came with loss of muscle – there was so much less holding him up, despite Nathan’s best attempts at physio. There was

stomach pain from digestive problems, shoulder pain, pain from bladder infections – an inevitability, apparently, despite everyone’s best efforts. He had a stomach ulcer from taking too many painkillers early on in his recovery, when he apparently popped them like Tic Tacs.

Occasionally, there were pressure sores, from being seated in the same position for too long. A couple of times Will was confined to bed, just to let them heal, but he hated being prone. He would lie there listening to the radio, his eyes glittering with barely suppressed rage. Will also got headaches – a side effect, I thought, of his anger and frustration. He had so much mental energy, and nothing to take it out on. It had to build up somewhere.

But the most debilitating was a burning sensation in his hands and feet; relentless, pulsing, it would leave him unable to focus on anything else. I would prepare a bowl of cold water and soak them, or wrap cold flannels around them, hoping to ease his discomfort. A stringy muscle would flicker in his jaw and occasionally he would just seem to disappear, as if the only way he could cope with the sensation was to absent himself from his own body. I had become surprisingly used to the physical requirements of Will’s life. It seemed unfair that despite the fact he could not use them, or feel them, his extremities should cause him so much discomfort.

Despite all this, Will did not complain. This was why it had taken me weeks to notice he suffered at all. Now, I could decipher the strained look around his eyes, the silences, the way he seemed to retreat inside his own skin. He would ask, simply, ‘Could you get the cold water, Louisa?’ or ‘I think it might be time for some painkillers.’ Sometimes he was in so much pain that his face actually leached colour, turning to pale putty. Those were the worst days.

But on other days we tolerated each other quite well. He didn’t seem mortally offended when I talked to him, as he had at the start. Today appeared to be a pain-free day. When Mrs Traynor came out to tell us that the cleaners would be another twenty minutes, I made us both another drink and we took a slow stroll around the garden, Will sticking to the path and me watching my satin pumps darken in the damp grass.

‘Interesting choice of footwear,’ Will said.

They were emerald green. I had found them in a charity shop. Patrick said they made me look like a leprechaun drag queen.

‘You know, you don’t dress like someone from round here. I quite look forward to seeing what insane combination you’re going to turn up in next.’

‘So how should “someone from round here” dress?’

He steered a little to the left to avoid a bit of branch on the path. ‘Fleece. Or, if you’re my mother’s set, something from Jaeger or Whistles.’ He looked at me. ‘So where did you pick up your exotic tastes? Where else have you lived?’

‘I haven’t.’

‘What, you’ve only ever lived here? Where have you worked?’

‘Only here.’ I turned and looked at him, crossing my arms over my chest defensively. ‘So? What’s so weird about that?’

‘It’s such a small town. So limiting. And it’s all about the castle.’ We paused on the path and stared at it, rising up in the distance on its weird, dome-like hill, as perfect as if it had been drawn by a child. ‘I always think this is the kind of place that people come back to. When they’ve got tired of everything else. Or when they don’t have enough imagination to go anywhere else.’

‘Thanks.’

‘There’s nothing *wrong* with it per se. But ... Christ. It’s not exactly dynamic, is it? Not exactly full of ideas or interesting people or opportunities. Round here they think it’s subversive if the tourist shop starts selling place mats with a different view of the miniature railway.’

I couldn’t help but laugh. There had been an article in the local newspaper the previous week on exactly that topic.

‘You’re twenty-six years old, Clark. You should be out there, claiming the world as your own, getting in trouble in bars, showing off your strange wardrobe to dodgy men ... ’

‘I’m happy here,’ I said.

‘Well, you shouldn’t be.’

‘You like telling people what they should be doing, don’t you?’

‘Only when I know I’m right,’ he said. ‘Can you adjust my drink? I can’t quite reach it.’

I twisted his straw round so that he could reach it more easily and waited while he took a drink. The faint cold had turned the tips of his ears pink.

He grimaced. ‘Jesus, for a girl who made tea for a living you make a terrible cup.’

‘You’re just used to lesbian tea,’ I said. ‘All that lapsang souchong herbal stuff.’

‘Lesbian tea!’ He almost choked. ‘Well, it’s better than this stair varnish. Christ. You could stand a spoon up in that.’

‘So even my tea is wrong.’ I sat down on the bench in front of him. ‘So how is it okay for you to offer an opinion on every single thing I say or do, and yet nobody else gets to say anything at all?’

‘Go on, then, Louisa Clark. Give me your opinions.’

‘On you?’

He gave a theatrical sigh. ‘Do I have a choice?’

‘You could cut your hair. It makes you look like some kind of vagrant.’

‘Now you sound like my mother.’

‘Well, you do look bloody awful. You could shave, at least. Isn’t all that facial hair starting to get itchy?’

He gave me a sideways look.

‘It is, isn’t it? I knew it. Okay – this afternoon I am going to take it all off.’

‘Oh no.’

‘Yes. You asked me for my opinion. This is my answer. You don’t have to do anything.’

‘What if I say no?’

‘I might do it anyway. If it gets any longer I’ll be picking bits of food out of it. And, frankly, if that happens I’ll have to sue you for undue distress in the workplace.’

He smiled then, as if I had amused him. It might sound a bit sad, but Will’s smiles were so rare that prompting one made me feel a bit light-headed with pride.

‘Here, Clark,’ he said. ‘Do me a favour?’

‘What?’

‘Scratch my ear for me, will you? It’s driving me nuts.’

‘If I do you’ll let me cut your hair? Just a bit of a trim?’

‘Don’t push your luck.’

‘Shush. Don’t make me nervous. I’m not great with scissors.’

I found the razors and some shaving foam in the bathroom cabinet, tucked well back behind the packets of wipes and cotton wool, as if they hadn’t been used in some time. I made him come into the bathroom, filled a sink

with warm water, got him to tilt his headrest back a little and then placed a hot flannel over his chin.

‘What is this? You’re going to be a barbershop? What’s the flannel for?’

‘I don’t know,’ I confessed. ‘It’s what they do in the films. It’s like the hot water and towels when someone has a baby.’

I couldn’t see his mouth, but his eyes creased with faint mirth. I wanted to keep them like that. I wanted him to be happy – for his face to lose that haunted, watchful look. I gabbled. I told jokes. I started to hum. Anything to prolong the moment before he looked grim again.

I rolled up my sleeves and began to lather the shaving foam over his chin, all the way up to his ears. Then I hesitated, the blade over his chin. ‘Is this the moment to tell you I’ve only ever done legs before?’

He closed his eyes, and settled back. I began to scrape gently at his skin with the blade, the silence broken only by the splash as I rinsed the razor in the basinful of water. I worked in silence, studying Will Traynor’s face as I went, the lines that ran to the corners of his mouth, lines that seemed prematurely deep for his age. I smoothed his hair from the side of his face and saw the telltale tracks of stitches, perhaps from his accident. I saw the mauve shadows that told of nights and nights of lost sleep, the furrow between his brows that spoke of silent pain. A warm sweetness rose from his skin, the scent of the shaving cream, and something that was peculiar to Will himself, discreet and expensive. His face began to emerge and I could see how easy it must have been for him to attract someone like Alicia.

I worked slowly and carefully, encouraged by the fact that he seemed briefly at peace. The thought flashed by that the only time anyone ever touched Will was for some medical or therapeutic procedure, and so I let my fingers rest lightly upon his skin, trying to make the movements as far from the dehumanized briskness that characterized Nathan’s and the doctor’s interactions with him as possible.

It was a curiously intimate thing, this shaving of Will. I realized as I continued that I had assumed his wheelchair would be a barrier; that his disability would prevent any kind of sensual aspect from creeping in. Weirdly, it wasn’t working like that. It was impossible to be this close to someone, to feel their skin tauten under your fingertips, to breathe in the air that they breathed out, to have their face only inches from yours, without feeling a little unbalanced. By the time I reached his other ear I had begun to feel awkward, as if I had overstepped an invisible mark.

Perhaps Will was able to read the subtle changes in my pressure on his skin; perhaps he was just more attuned to the moods of the people around him. But he opened his eyes, and I found them looking into mine.

There was a short pause, and then he said, straight-faced, 'Please don't tell me you've shaved off my eyebrows.'

'Only the one,' I said. I rinsed the blade, hoping that the colour would have drained from my cheeks by the time I turned round. 'Right,' I said, finally. 'Have you had enough? Won't Nathan be here in a bit?'

'What about my hair?' he said.

'You really want me to cut it?'

'You might as well.'

'I thought you didn't trust me.'

He shrugged, as far as he could. It was the smallest movement of his shoulders. 'If it will stop you moaning at me for a couple of weeks I figure it's a small price to pay.'

'Oh my God, your mum is going to be so delighted,' I said, wiping a stray dab of shaving cream.

'Yes, well, we won't let that put us off.'

We cut his hair in the living room. I lit the fire, we put on a film – an American thriller – and I placed a towel around his shoulders. I had warned Will that I was a bit rusty, but added that it couldn't look worse than it did already.

'Thanks for that,' he said.

I set to work, letting his hair slide through my fingers, trying to remember the few basics I had learnt. Will, watching the film, seemed relaxed and almost content. Occasionally he told me something about the film – what else the lead actor had starred in, where he had first seen it – and I made a vaguely interested noise (like I do with Thomas when he presents me with his toys), even though all my attention was actually focused on not mucking up his hair. Finally, I had the worst of it off, and whipped round in front of him to see how he looked.

'Well?' Will paused the DVD.

I straightened up. 'I'm not sure I like seeing this much of your face. It's a bit unnerving.'

'Feels cold,' he observed, moving his head from left to right, as if testing the feel of it.

‘Hold on,’ I said. ‘I’ll get two mirrors. Then you can see it properly. But don’t move. There’s still a bit of tidying up to be done. Possibly an ear to slice.’

I was in the bedroom, going through his drawers in search of a small mirror, when I heard the door. Two sets of brisk footsteps, Mrs Traynor’s voice, lifted, anxious.

‘Georgina, please don’t.’

The door to the living room was wrenched open. I grabbed the mirror and ran out of the room. I had no intention of being found absent again. Mrs Traynor was standing in the living-room doorway, both hands raised to her mouth, apparently witnessing some unseen confrontation.

‘You are the most selfish man I ever met!’ a young woman was shouting. ‘I can’t believe this, Will. You were selfish then and you’re worse now.’

‘Georgina.’ Mrs Traynor’s gaze flicked towards me as I approached. ‘Please, stop.’

I walked into the room behind her. Will, the towel around his shoulders, hair in soft brown fronds at the wheels of his chair, was facing a young woman. She had long dark hair, pinned into a messy knot at the back of her head. Her skin was tanned, and she was wearing expensively distressed jeans and suede boots. Like Alicia, her features were beautiful and regular, her teeth the astonishing white of a toothpaste commercial. I knew they were because, her face puce with anger, she was still hissing at him. ‘I can’t believe it. I can’t believe you would even think of it. What do you –’

‘*Please.* Georgina.’ Mrs Traynor’s voice lifted sharply. ‘This is not the time.’

Will, his face impassive, was staring straight ahead of him at some unseen point.

‘Um ... Will? Do you need any help?’ I said, quietly.

‘Who are you?’ she said, whipping round. It was then that I saw her eyes were filled with tears.

‘Georgina,’ Will said. ‘Meet Louisa Clark, my paid companion and shockingly inventive hairdresser. Louisa, meet my sister, Georgina. She appears to have flown all the way from Australia to shriek at me.’

‘Don’t be facile,’ Georgina said. ‘Mummy told me. She’s told me *everything*.’

Nobody moved.

‘Shall I give you a minute?’ I said.

‘That would be a good idea.’ Mrs Traynor’s knuckles were white on the arm of the sofa.

I slid out of the room.

‘In fact, Louisa, perhaps now would be a good time to take your lunch break.’

It was going to be a bus shelter kind of a day. I grabbed my sandwiches from the kitchen, climbed into my coat and set off down the back path.

As I left, I could hear Georgina Traynor’s voice lifting inside the house. ‘Has it ever occurred to you, Will, that believe it or not, this might not be *just* about you?’

When I returned, exactly half an hour later, the house was silent. Nathan was washing up a mug in the kitchen sink.

He turned as he saw me. ‘How you doing?’

‘Has she gone?’

‘Who?’

‘The sister?’

He glanced behind him. ‘Ah. That who it was? Yeah, she’s gone. Just skidding off in her car when I got here. Some sort of family row, was it?’

‘I don’t know,’ I said. ‘I was in the middle of cutting Will’s hair and this woman came in and just started having a go at him. I assumed it was another girlfriend.’

Nathan shrugged.

I realized he would not be interested in the personal minutiae of Will’s life, even if he knew.

‘He’s a bit quiet, though. Nice work with the shave, by the way. Good to get him out from behind all that shrubbery.’

I walked back into the living room. Will was sitting staring at the television, which was still paused at the exact moment I had left it.

‘Do you want me to turn this back on?’ I said.

He didn’t seem to hear me for a minute. His head was sunk in his shoulders, the earlier relaxed expression replaced by a veil. Will was closed off again, locked behind something I couldn’t penetrate.

He blinked, as if he had only just noticed me there. ‘Sure,’ he said.

I was carrying a basket of washing down the hall when I heard them. The annexe door was slightly ajar and the voices of Mrs Traynor and her

daughter carried down the long corridor, the sound coming in muted waves. Will's sister was sobbing quietly, all fury gone from her voice now. She sounded almost childlike.

'There must be something they can do. Some medical advance. Can't you take him to America? Things are always improving in America.'

'Your father keeps a very close eye on all the developments. But no, darling, there is nothing ... concrete.'

'He's so ... different now. It's like he's determined not to see the good in anything.'

'He's been like that since the start, George. I think it's just that you didn't see him apart from when you flew home. Back then, I think he was still ... determined. Back then, he was sure that something would change.'

I felt a little uncomfortable listening in on such a private conversation. But the odd tenor drew me closer. I found myself walking softly towards the door, my socked feet making no sound on the floor.

'Look, Daddy and I didn't tell you. We didn't want to upset you. But he tried ...' she struggled over the words. 'Will tried to ... he tried to kill himself.'

'What?'

'Daddy found him. Back in January. It was ... it was terrible.'

Even though this only really confirmed what I had guessed, I felt all the blood drain from me. I heard a muffled cry, a whispered reassurance. There was another long silence. And then Georgina, her voice thick with grief, spoke again.

'The girl ... ?'

'Yes. Louisa is here to make sure nothing like that happens again.'

I stopped. At the other end of the corridor, from the bathroom, I could hear Nathan and Will talking in a low murmur, comfortably oblivious to the conversation that was going on just a few feet away. I took a step closer to the door. I suppose I had known it since I caught sight of the scars on his wrists. It made sense of everything, after all – Mrs Traynor's anxiety that I shouldn't leave Will alone for very long, his antipathy to having me there, the fact that for large stretches of time I didn't feel like I was doing anything useful at all. I had been babysitting. I hadn't known it, but Will had, and he had hated me for it.

I reached for the handle of the door, preparing to close it gently. I wondered what Nathan knew. I wondered whether Will was happier now. I

realized I felt, selfishly, a faint relief that it hadn't been me Will objected to, just the fact that I – that anyone – had been employed to watch over him. My thoughts hummed so busily that I almost missed the next snatch of conversation.

'You can't let him do this, Mum. You have to stop him.'

'It's not our choice, darling.'

'But it is. It is – if he's asking you to be part of it,' Georgina protested. The handle stilled in my hand.

'I can't believe you're even agreeing to it. What about your religion? What about everything you've done? What was the point in you even bloody saving him the last time?'

Mrs Traynor's voice was deliberately calm. 'That's not fair.'

'But you've said you'll take him. What does –'

'Do you think for a moment that if I said I refuse, he wouldn't ask someone else?'

'But Dignitas? It's just wrong. I know it's hard for him, but it will destroy you and Daddy. I know it. Think of how you would feel! Think of the publicity! Your job! Both your reputations! *He* must know it. It's a selfish thing to even ask. How can he? How can he do this? How can *you* do this?' She began to sob again.

'George ...'

'Don't look at me like that. I do care about him, Mummy. I do. He's my brother and I love him. But I can't bear it. I can't bear even the thought of it. He's wrong to ask, and you're wrong to consider it. And it's not just his own life he will destroy if you go ahead with this.'

I took a step back from the window. The blood thumped so loudly in my ears that I almost didn't hear Mrs Traynor's response.

'Six months, George. He promised to give me six months. Now. I don't want you to mention this again, and certainly not in front of anyone else. And we must ...' She took a deep breath. 'We must just pray very hard that something happens in that time to change his mind.'



8

Camilla

I never set out to help kill my son.

Even reading the words seems odd – like something you might see in a tabloid newspaper, or one of those awful magazines that the cleaner always has poking out of her handbag, full of women whose daughters ran off with their cheating partners, tales of amazing weight loss and two-headed babies.

I was not the kind of person this happened to. Or at least, I thought I wasn't. My life was a fairly structured one – an ordinary one, by modern standards. I had been married for almost thirty-seven years, I raised two children, I kept my career, helped out at the school, the PTA, and joined the bench once the children didn't need me any more.

I had been a magistrate for almost eleven years now. I watched the whole of human life come through my court: the hopeless waifs who couldn't get themselves together sufficiently even to make a court appointment on time; the repeat offenders; the angry, hard-faced young men and exhausted, debt-ridden mothers. It's quite hard to stay calm and understanding when you see the same faces, the same mistakes made again and again. I could sometimes hear the impatience in my tone. It could be oddly dispiriting, the blank refusal of humankind to even attempt to function responsibly.

And our little town, despite the beauty of the castle, our many Grade II listed buildings, our picturesque country lanes, was far from immune to it. Our Regency squares held cider-drinking teenagers, our thatched cottages

muffled the sounds of husbands beating their wives and children.

Sometimes I felt like King Canute, making vain pronouncements in the face of a tide of chaos and creeping devastation. But I loved my job. I did it because I believe in order, in a moral code. I believe that there is a right and a wrong, unfashionable as that view might be.

I got through the tougher days because of my garden. As the children grew it had become a bit of an obsession of mine. I could give you the Latin name of almost any plant you cared to point at. The funny thing was, I didn't even do Latin at school – mine was a rather minor public school for girls where the focus was on cooking and embroidery, things that would help us become good wives – but the thing about those plant names is that they do stick in your head. I only ever needed to hear one once to remember it forever: *Helleborus niger*, *Eremurus stenophyllus*, *Athyrium niponicum*. I can repeat those with a fluency I never had at school.

They say you only really appreciate a garden once you reach a certain age, and I suppose there is a truth in that. It's probably something to do with the great circle of life. There seems to be something miraculous about seeing the relentless optimism of new growth after the bleakness of winter, a kind of joy in the difference every year, the way nature chooses to show off different parts of the garden to its full advantage. There have been times – the times when my marriage proved to be somewhat more populated than I had anticipated – when it has been a refuge, times when it has been a joy.

There have even been times when it was, frankly, a pain. There is nothing more disappointing than creating a new border only to see it fail to flourish, or to watch a row of beautiful alliums destroyed overnight by some slimy culprit. But even when I complained about the time, the effort involved in caring for it, the way my joints protested at an afternoon spent weeding, or my fingernails never looked quite clean, I loved it. I loved the sensual pleasures of being outside, the smell of it, the feel of the earth under my fingers, the satisfaction of seeing things living, glowing, captivated by their own temporary beauty.

After Will's accident I didn't garden for a year. It wasn't just the time, although the endless hours spent at hospital, the time spent toing and froing in the car, the meetings – oh God, the meetings – took up so much of it. I took six months' compassionate leave from work and there was still not enough of it.

It was that I could suddenly see no point. I paid a gardener to come and keep the garden tidy, and I don't think I gave it anything but the most cursory of looks for the best part of a year.

It was only when we brought Will back home, once the annexe was adapted and ready, that I could see a point in making it beautiful again. I needed to give my son something to look at. I needed to tell him, silently, that things might change, grow or fail, but that life did go on. That we were all part of some great cycle, some pattern that it was only God's purpose to understand. I couldn't say that to him, of course – Will and I have never been able to say much to each other – but I wanted to show him. A silent promise, if you like, that there was a bigger picture, a brighter future.

Steven was poking at the log fire. He manoeuvred the remaining half-burnt logs expertly with a poker, sending glowing sparks up the chimney, then dropped a new log on to the middle. He stood back, as he always did, watching with quiet satisfaction as the flames took hold, and dusted his hands on his corduroy trousers. He turned as I entered the room. I held out a glass.

'Thank you. Is George coming down?'

'Apparently not.'

'What's she doing?'

'Watching television upstairs. She doesn't want company. I did ask.'

'She'll come round. She's probably jet-lagged.'

'I hope so, Steven. She's not very happy with us at the moment.'

We stood in silence, watching the fire. Around us the room was dark and still, the windowpanes rattling gently as they were buffeted by the wind and rain.

'Filthy night.'

'Yes.'

The dog padded into the room and, with a sigh, flopped down in front of the fire, gazing up adoringly at us both from her prone position.

'So what do you think?' he said. 'This haircut business.'

'I don't know. I'd like to think it's a good sign.'

'This Louisa's a bit of a character, isn't she?'

I saw the way my husband smiled to himself. *Not her too*, I found myself thinking, and then squashed the thought.

'Yes. Yes, I suppose she is.'

‘Do you think she’s the right one?’

I took a sip of my drink before answering. Two fingers of gin, a slice of lemon and a lot of tonic. ‘Who knows?’ I said. ‘I don’t think I have the faintest idea what is right and wrong any more.’

‘He likes her. I’m sure he likes her. We were talking while watching the news the other night, and he mentioned her twice. He hasn’t done that before.’

‘Yes. Well. I wouldn’t get your hopes up.’

‘Do you have to?’

Steven turned from the fire. I could see him studying me, perhaps conscious of the new lines around my eyes, the way my mouth seemed set these days into a thin line of anxiety. He looked at the little gold cross, now ever present around my neck. I didn’t like it when he looked at me like that. I could never escape the feeling that I was being compared to someone else.

‘I’m just being realistic.’

‘You sound ... you sound like you’re already expecting it to happen.’

‘I know my son.’

‘Our son.’

‘Yes. Our son.’ More my son, I found myself thinking. *You were never really there for him. Not emotionally. You were just the absence he was always striving to impress.*

‘He’ll change his mind,’ Steven said. ‘There’s still a long way to go.’

We stood there. I took a long sip of my drink, the ice cold against the warmth given out by the fire.

‘I keep thinking ... ’ I said, staring into the hearth. ‘I still keep thinking that I’m missing something.’

My husband was still watching me. I could feel his gaze on me, but I couldn’t meet it. Perhaps he might have reached out to me then. But I think we had probably gone too far for that.

He took a sip of his drink. ‘You can only do what you can do, darling.’

‘I’m well aware of that. But it’s not really enough, is it?’

He turned back to the fire, poking unnecessarily at a log until I turned and quietly left the room.

As he had known I would.

When Will first told me what he wanted, he had to tell me twice, as I was quite sure I could not have heard him correctly the first time. I stayed quite

calm when I realized what it was he was proposing, and then I told him he was being ridiculous and I walked straight out of the room. It's an unfair advantage, being able to walk away from a man in a wheelchair. There are two steps between the annexe and the main house, and without Nathan's help he could not traverse them. I shut the door of the annexe and I stood in my own hallway with the calmly spoken words of my son still ringing in my ears.

I'm not sure I moved for half an hour.

He refused to let it go. Being Will, he always had to have the last word. He repeated his request every time I went in to see him until I almost had to persuade myself to go in each day. *I don't want to live like this, Mother. This is not the life I chose. There is no prospect of my recovery, hence it is a perfectly reasonable request to ask to end it in a manner I see fit.* I heard him and could well imagine what he had been like in those business meetings, the career that had made him rich and arrogant. He was a man who was used to being heard, after all. He couldn't bear it that in some way I had the power to dictate his future, that I had somehow become *mother* again.

It took his attempt to make me agree. It's not that my religion forbade it – although the prospect of Will being consigned to hell through his own desperation was a terrible one. (I chose to believe that God, a benign God, would understand our sufferings and forgive us our trespasses.)

It's just that the thing you never understand about being a mother, until you are one, is that it is not the grown man – the galumphing, unshaven, stinking, opinionated offspring – you see before you, with his parking tickets and unpolished shoes and complicated love life. You see all the people he has ever been all rolled up into one.

I looked at Will and I saw the baby I held in my arms, dewily besotted, unable to believe that I had created another human being. I saw the toddler, reaching for my hand, the schoolboy weeping tears of fury after being bullied by some other child. I saw the vulnerabilities, the love, the history. That's what he was asking me to extinguish – the small child as well as the man – all that love, all that history.

And then on 22 January, a day when I was stuck in court with a relentless roll call of shoplifters and uninsured drivers, of weeping angry ex-partners, Steven walked into the annexe and found our son almost unconscious, his head lolling by his armrest, a sea of dark, sticky blood pooling around his

wheels. He had located a rusty nail, barely half an inch emerging from some hurriedly finished woodwork in the back lobby, and, pressing his wrist against it, had reversed backwards and forwards until his flesh was sliced to ribbons. I cannot to this day imagine the determination that kept him going, even though he must have been half delirious from the pain. The doctors said he was less than twenty minutes from death.

It was not, they observed with exquisite understatement, *a cry for help*.

When they told me at the hospital that Will would live, I walked outside into my garden and I raged. I raged at God, at nature, at whatever fate had brought our family to such depths. Now I look back and I must have seemed quite mad. I stood in my garden that cold evening and I hurled my large brandy twenty feet into the *Euonymus compactus* and I screamed, so that my voice broke the air, bouncing off the castle walls and echoing into the distance. I was so furious, you see, that all around me were things that could move and bend and grow and reproduce, and my son – my vital, charismatic, beautiful boy – was just this *thing*. Immobile, wilted, bloodied, suffering. Their beauty seemed like an obscenity. I screamed and I screamed and I swore – words I didn't know I knew – until Steven came out and stood, his hand resting on my shoulder, waiting until he could be sure that I would be silent again.

He didn't understand, you see. He hadn't worked it out yet. That Will would try again. That our lives would have to be spent in a state of constant vigilance, waiting for the next time, waiting to see what horror he would inflict upon himself. We would have to see the world through his eyes – the potential poisons, the sharp objects, the inventiveness with which he could finish the job that damned motorcyclist had started. Our lives had to shrink to fit around the potential for that one act. And he had the advantage – he had nothing else to think about, you see?

Two weeks later, I told Will, 'Yes.'

Of course I did.

What else could I have done?



9

I didn't sleep that night. I lay awake in the little box room, gazing up at the ceiling and carefully reconstructing the last two months based on what I now knew. It was as if everything had shifted, fragmented and settled in some other place, into a pattern I barely recognized.

I felt duped, the dim-witted accessory who hadn't known what was going on. I felt they must have laughed privately at my attempts to feed Will vegetables, or cut his hair – little things to make him feel better. What had been the point, after all?

I ran over and over the conversation I had heard, trying to interpret it in some alternative way, trying to convince myself that I had misunderstood what they had said. But Dignitas wasn't exactly somewhere you went for a mini-break. I couldn't believe Camilla Traynor could contemplate doing that to her son. Yes, I had thought her cold, and yes, awkward around him. It was hard to imagine her cuddling him, as my mother had cuddled us – fiercely, joyously – until we wriggled away, begging to be let go. If I'm honest, I just thought it was how the upper classes were with their children. I had just read Will's copy of *Love in a Cold Climate*, after all. But to actively, to voluntarily play a part in her own son's death?

With hindsight her behaviour seemed even colder, her actions imbued with some sinister intent. I was angry with her and angry with Will. Angry with them for letting me engage in a facade. I was angry for all the times I had sat and thought about how to make things better for him, how to make him comfortable, or happy. When I was not angry, I was sad. I would recall

the slight break in her voice as she tried to comfort Georgina, and feel a great sadness for her. She was, I knew, in an impossible position.

But mostly I felt filled with horror. I was haunted by what I now knew. How could you live each day knowing that you were simply whiling away the days until your own death? How could this man whose skin I had felt that morning under my fingers – warm, and alive – choose to just extinguish himself? How could it be that, with everyone's consent, in six months' time that same skin would be decaying under the ground?

I couldn't tell anyone. That was almost the worst bit. I was now complicit in the Traynors' secret. Sick and listless, I rang Patrick to say I wasn't feeling well and was going to stay home. No problem, he was doing a 10k, he said. He probably wouldn't be through at the athletics club until after nine anyway. I'd see him on Saturday. He sounded distracted, as if his mind were already elsewhere, further along some mythical track.

I refused supper. I lay in bed until my thoughts darkened and solidified to the point where I couldn't bear the weight of them, and at eight thirty I came back downstairs and sat silently watching television, perched on the other side of Granddad, who was the only person in our family guaranteed not to ask me a question. He sat in his favourite armchair and stared at the screen with glassy-eyed intensity. I was never sure whether he was watching, or whether his mind was somewhere else entirely.

'Are you sure I can't get you something, love?' Mum appeared at my side with a cup of tea. There was nothing in our family that couldn't be improved by a cup of tea, allegedly.

'No. Not hungry, thanks.'

I saw the way she glanced at Dad. I knew that later on there would be private mutterings that the Traynors were working me too hard, that the strain of looking after such an invalid was proving too much. I knew they would blame themselves for encouraging me to take the job.

I would have to let them think they were right.

Paradoxically, the following day Will was on good form – unusually talkative, opinionated, belligerent. He talked, possibly more than he had talked on any previous day. It was as if he wanted to spar with me, and was disappointed when I wouldn't play.

'So when are you going to finish this hatchet job, then?'

I had been tidying the living room. I looked up from plumping the sofa cushions. 'What?'

'My hair. I'm only half done. I look like one of those Victorian orphans. Or some Hoxton eejit.' He turned his head so that I could better see my handiwork. 'Unless this is one of your alternative style statements.'

'You want me to keep cutting?'

'Well, it seemed to keep you happy. And it would be nice not to look like I belong in an asylum.'

I fetched a towel and scissors in silence.

'Nathan is definitely happier now I apparently look like a bloke,' he said. 'Although he did point out that, having restored my face to its former state, I will now need shaving every day.'

'Oh,' I said.

'You don't mind, do you? Weekends I'll just have to put up with designer stubble.'

I couldn't talk to him. I found it difficult even to meet his eye. It was like finding out your boyfriend had been unfaithful. I felt, weirdly, as if he had betrayed me.

'Clark?'

'Hmm?'

'You're having another unnervingly quiet day. What happened to "chatty to the point of vaguely irritating?"'

'Sorry,' I said.

'Running Man again? What's he done now? He hasn't gone and run off, has he?'

'No.' I took a soft slice of Will's hair between my index and middle fingers and lifted the blades of the scissors to trim what lay exposed above them. They stilled in my hand. How would they do it? Would they give him an injection? Was it medicine? Or did they just leave you in a room with a load of razors?

'You look tired. I wasn't going to say anything when you came in, but – hell – you look terrible.'

'Oh.'

How did they assist someone who couldn't move their own limbs? I found myself gazing down at his wrists, which were always covered by long sleeves. I had assumed for weeks that this was because he felt the cold more than we did. Another lie.

‘Clark?’

‘Yes?’

I was glad I was behind him. I didn’t want him to see my face.

He hesitated. Where the back of his neck had been covered by hair, it was even paler than the rest of his skin. It looked soft and white and oddly vulnerable.

‘Look, I’m sorry about my sister. She was ... she was very upset, but it didn’t give her the right to be rude. She’s a bit direct sometimes. Doesn’t know how much she rubs people up the wrong way.’ He paused. ‘It’s why she likes living in Australia, I think.’

‘You mean, they tell each other the truth?’

‘What?’

‘Nothing. Lift your head up, please.’

I snipped and combed, working my way methodically around his head until every single hair was chopped or trimmed and all that remained was a fine sprinkling around his feet.

It all became clear to me by the end of the day. While Will was watching television with his father, I took a sheet of A4 paper from the printer and a pen from the jar by the kitchen window and wrote down what I wanted to say. I folded the paper, found an envelope, and left it on the kitchen table, addressed to his mother.

When I left for the evening, Will and his father were talking. Actually, Will was laughing. I paused in the hallway, my bag over my shoulder, listening. Why would he laugh? What could possibly provoke mirth given that he had just a matter of weeks before he took his own life?

‘I’m off,’ I called through the doorway, and started walking.

‘Hey, Clark –’ he began, but I had already closed the door behind me.

I spent the short bus ride trying to work out what I was going to tell my parents. They would be furious that I had left what they would see as a perfectly suitable and well-paid job. After her initial shock my mother would look pained and defend me, suggesting that it had all been too much. My father would probably ask why I couldn’t be more like my sister. He often did, even though I was not the one who ruined her life by getting pregnant and having to rely on the rest of the family for financial support and babysitting. You weren’t allowed to say anything like that in our house because, according to my mother, it was like implying that Thomas wasn’t a

blessing. And all babies were God's blessing, even those who said *bugger* quite a lot, and whose presence meant that half the potential wage earners in our family couldn't actually go and get a decent job.

I would not be able to tell them the truth. I knew I owed Will and his family nothing, but I wouldn't inflict the curious gaze of the neighbourhood on him.

All these thoughts tumbled around my head as I got off the bus and walked down the hill. And then I got to the corner of our road and heard the shouting, felt the slight vibration in the air, and it was all briefly forgotten.

A small crowd had gathered around our house. I picked up my pace, afraid that something had happened, but then I saw my parents on the porch, peering up, and realized it wasn't our house at all. It was just the latest in a long series of small wars that characterized our neighbours' marriage.

That Richard Grisham was not the most faithful of husbands was hardly news in our street. But judging by the scene in his front garden, it might have been to his wife.

'You must have thought I was bloody stupid. She was wearing your T-shirt! The one I had made for you for your birthday!'

'Baby ... Dymrna ... it's not what you think.'

'I went in for your bloody Scotch eggs! And there she was, wearing it! Bold as brass! And I don't even *like* Scotch eggs!'

I slowed my pace, pushing my way through the small crowd until I was able to get to our gate, watching as Richard ducked to avoid a DVD player. Next came a pair of shoes.

'How long have they been at it?'

My mother, her apron tucked neatly around her waist, unfolded her arms and glanced down at her watch. 'It's a good three-quarters of an hour. Bernard, would you say it's a good three-quarters of an hour?'

'Depends if you time it from when she threw the clothes out or when he came back and found them.'

'I'd say when he came home.'

Dad considered this. 'Then it's really closer to half an hour. She got a good lot out of the window in the first fifteen minutes, though.'

'Your dad says if she really does kick him out this time he's going to put in a bid for Richard's Black and Decker.'

The crowd had grown, and Dympna Grisham showed no sign of letting up. If anything, she seemed encouraged by the increasing size of her audience.

‘You can take her your filthy books,’ she yelled, hurling a shower of magazines out of the window.

These prompted a small cheer among the crowd.

‘See if she likes you sitting in the loo with *those* for half of Sunday afternoon, eh?’ She disappeared inside, and then reappeared at the window, hauling the contents of a laundry basket down on to what remained of the lawn. ‘And your filthy undercrackers. See if she thinks you’re such a – what was it? – *hot stud* when she’s washing those for you every day!’

Richard was vainly scooping up armfuls of his stuff as it landed on the grass. He was yelling something up at the window, but against the general noise and catcalls it was hard to make it out. As if briefly admitting defeat, he pushed his way through the crowd, unlocked his car, hauled an armful of his belongings on to the rear seat, and shoved the car door shut. Oddly, whereas his CD collection and video games had been quite popular, no one made a move on his dirty laundry.

Crash. There was a brief hush as his stereo met the path.

He looked up in disbelief. ‘You crazy bitch!’

‘You’re shagging that disease-ridden cross-eyed troll from the garage, and *I’m* the crazy bitch?’

My mother turned to my father. ‘Would you like a cup of tea, Bernard? I think it’s turning a little chilly.’

My dad didn’t take his eyes off next door. ‘That would be great, love. Thank you.’

It was as my mother went indoors that I noticed the car. It was so unexpected that at first I didn’t recognize it – Mrs Traynor’s Mercedes, navy blue, low-slung and discreet. She pulled up, peering out at the scene on the pavement, and hesitated a moment before she climbed out. She stood, staring at the various houses, perhaps checking the numbers. And then she saw me.

I slid out from the porch and was down the path before Dad could ask where I was going. Mrs Traynor stood to the side of the crowd, gazing at the chaos like Marie Antoinette viewing a load of rioting peasants.

‘Domestic dispute,’ I said.

She looked away, as if almost embarrassed to have been caught looking. 'I see.'

'It's a fairly constructive one by their standards. They've been going to marriage guidance.'

Her elegant wool suit, pearls and expensive hair were enough to mark her out in our street, among the sweatpants and cheap fabrics in bright, chain-store colours. She appeared rigid, worse than the morning she had come home to find me sleeping in Will's room. I registered in some distant part of my mind that I was not going to miss Camilla Traynor.

'I was wondering if you and I could have a little talk.' She had to lift her voice to be heard over the cheering.

Mrs Grisham was now throwing out Richard's fine wines. Every exploding bottle was greeted with squeals of delight and another heartfelt outburst of pleading from Mr Grisham. A river of red wine ran through the feet of the crowd and into the gutter.

I glanced over at the crowd and then behind me at the house. I could not imagine bringing Mrs Traynor into our front room, with its litter of toy trains, Granddad snoring mutely in front of the television, Mum spraying air-freshener around to hide the smell of Dad's socks, and Thomas popping by to murmur *bugger* at the new guest.

'Um ... it's not a great time.'

'Perhaps we could talk in my car? Look, just five minutes, Louisa. Surely you owe us that.'

A couple of my neighbours glanced in my direction as I climbed into the car. I was lucky that the Grishams were the hot news of the evening, or I might have been the topic of conversation. In our street, if you climbed into an expensive car it meant you had either pulled a footballer or were being arrested by plain-clothes police.

The doors closed with an expensive, muted clunk and suddenly there was silence. The car smelt of leather, and there was nothing in it apart from me and Mrs Traynor. No sweet wrappers, mud, lost toys or perfumed dangly things to disguise the smell of the carton of milk that had been dropped in there three months earlier.

'I thought you and Will got on well.' She spoke as if addressing someone straight ahead of her. When I didn't speak, she said, 'Is there a problem with the money?'

'No.'

‘Do you need a longer lunch break? I am conscious that it’s rather short. I could ask Nathan if he would –’

‘It’s not the hours. Or the money.’

‘Then –’

‘I don’t really want to –’

‘Look, you cannot hand in your notice with immediate effect and expect me not even to ask what on earth’s the matter.’

I took a deep breath. ‘I overheard you. You and your daughter. Last night. And I don’t want to ... I don’t want to be part of it.’

‘Ah.’

We sat in silence. Mr Grisham was now trying to bash his way in through the front door, and Mrs Grisham was busy hurling anything she could locate through the window down on to his head. The choice of projectile missiles – loo roll, tampon boxes, toilet brush, shampoo bottles – suggested she was now in the bathroom.

‘Please, don’t leave,’ Mrs Traynor said, quietly. ‘Will is comfortable with you. More so than he’s been for some time. I ... it would be very hard for us to replicate that with someone else.’

‘But you’re ... you’re going to take him to that place where people commit suicide. Dignitas.’

‘No. I am going to do everything I can to ensure he doesn’t do that.’

‘Like what – praying?’

She gave me what my mother would have termed an ‘old-fashioned’ look. ‘You must know by now that if Will decides to make himself unreachable, there is little anybody can do about it.’

‘I worked it all out,’ I said. ‘I’m basically there just to make sure he doesn’t cheat and do it before his six months are up. That’s it, isn’t it?’

‘No. That’s not it.’

‘Which is why you didn’t care about my qualifications.’

‘I thought you were bright and cheerful and different. You didn’t look like a nurse. You didn’t behave ... like any of the others. I thought ... I thought you might cheer him up. And you do – you *do* cheer him up, Louisa. Seeing him without that awful beard yesterday ... you seem to be one of the few people who are able to get through to him.’

The bedding came out of the window. It came down in a ball, the sheets extending themselves briefly and gracefully before they hit the ground. Two

children picked one up and began running around the little garden with it over their heads.

‘Don’t you think it would have been fair to mention that I was basically on suicide watch?’

The sigh Camilla Traynor gave was the sound of someone forced to explain something politely to an imbecile. I wondered if she knew that everything she said made the other person feel like an idiot. I wondered if it was something she’d actually cultivated deliberately. I didn’t think I could ever manage to make someone feel inferior.

‘That might have been the case when we first met you ... but I’m confident Will is going to stick to his word. He has promised me six months, and that’s what I’ll get. We need this time, Louisa. We need this time to give him the idea of there being some *possibility*. I was hoping it might plant the idea that there is a life he could enjoy, even if it wasn’t the life he had planned.’

‘But it’s all lies. You’ve lied to me and you’re all lying to each other.’

She didn’t seem to hear me. She turned to face me, pulling a chequebook from her handbag, a pen ready in her hand.

‘Look, what do you want? I will double your money. Tell me how much you want.’

‘I don’t want your money.’

‘A car. Some benefits. Bonuses –’

‘No –’

‘Then ... what can I do that might change your mind?’

‘I’m sorry. I just don’t –’

I made to get out of the car. Her hand shot out. It sat there on my arm, strange and radioactive. We both stared at it.

‘You signed a contract, Miss Clark,’ she said. ‘You signed a contract where you promised to work for us for six months. By my calculations you have only done two. I am simply requiring you to fulfil your contractual obligations.’

Her voice had become brittle. I looked down at Mrs Traynor’s hand and saw that it was trembling.

She swallowed. ‘Please.’

My parents were watching from the porch. I could see them, mugs poised in their hands, the only two people facing away from the theatre next door.

They turned away awkwardly when they saw that I had noticed them. Dad, I realized, was wearing the tartan slippers with the paint splodges.

I pushed the handle of the door. 'Mrs Traynor, I really can't sit by and watch ... it's too weird. I don't want to be part of this.'

'Just think about it. Tomorrow is Good Friday – I'll tell Will you have a family commitment if you really just need some time. Take the Bank Holiday weekend to think about it. But please. Come back. Come back and help him.'

I walked back into the house without looking back. I sat in the living room, staring at the television while my parents followed me in, exchanged glances and pretended not to be watching me.

It was almost eleven minutes before I finally heard Mrs Traynor's car start up and drive away.

My sister confronted me within five minutes of arriving home, thundering up the stairs and throwing open the door of my room.

'Yes, do come in,' I said. I was lying on the bed, my legs stretched up the wall, staring at the ceiling. I was wearing tights and blue sequinned shorts, which now looped unattractively around the tops of my legs.

Katrina stood in the doorway. 'Is it true?'

'That Dymrna Grisham has finally thrown out her cheating no-good philandering husband and –'

'Don't be smart. About your job.'

I traced the pattern of the wallpaper with my big toe. 'Yes, I handed in my notice. Yes, I know Mum and Dad are not too happy about it. Yes, yes, yes to whatever it is you're going to throw at me.'

She closed the door carefully behind her, then sat down heavily on the end of my bed and swore lustily. 'I don't bloody believe you.'

She shoved my legs so that I slid down the wall, ending up almost lying on the bed. I pushed myself upright. 'Ow.'

Her face was puce. 'I don't believe you. Mum's in bits downstairs. Dad's pretending not to be, but he is too. What are they supposed to do about money? You know Dad's already panicking about work. Why the hell would you throw away a perfectly good job?'

'Don't lecture me, Treen.'

'Well, someone's got to! You're never going to get anything like that money anywhere else. And how's it going to look on your CV?'

‘Oh, don’t pretend this is about anything other than you and what you want.’

‘What?’

‘You don’t care what I do, as long as you can still go and resurrect your high-flying career. You just need me there propping up the family funds and providing the bloody childcare. Sod everyone else.’ I knew I sounded mean and nasty but I couldn’t help myself. It was my sister’s plight that had got us into this mess, after all. Years of resentment began to ooze out of me.

‘We’ve all got to stick at jobs we hate just so that little Katrina can fulfil her bloody ambitions.’

‘It is not *about* me.’

‘No?’

‘No, it’s about you not being able to stick at the one decent job you’ve been offered in months.’

‘You know *nothing* about my job, okay?’

‘I know it paid well above the minimum wage. Which is all I need to know about it.’

‘Not everything in life is about the money, you know.’

‘Yes? You go downstairs and tell Mum and Dad that.’

‘Don’t you dare bloody lecture me about money when you haven’t paid a sodding thing towards this house for years.’

‘You know I can’t afford much because of Thomas.’

I began to shove my sister out of the door. I can’t remember the last time I actually laid a hand on her, but right then I wanted to punch someone quite badly and I was afraid of what I would do if she stayed there in front of me.

‘Just piss off, Treen. Okay? Just piss off and leave me alone.’

I slammed the door in my sister’s face. And when I finally heard her walking slowly back down the stairs, I chose not to think about what she would say to my parents, about the way they would all treat this as further evidence of my catastrophic inability to do anything of any worth. I chose not to think about Syed at the Job Centre and how I would explain my reasons for leaving this most well paid of menial jobs. I chose not to think about the chicken factory and how somewhere, deep within its bowels, there was probably a set of plastic overalls, and a hygiene cap with my name still on it.

I lay back and I thought about Will. I thought about his anger and his sadness. I thought about what his mother had said – that I was one of the

only people able to get through to him. I thought about him trying not to laugh at the 'Molahonkey Song' on a night when the snow drifted gold past the window. I thought about the warm skin and soft hair and hands of someone living, someone who was far cleverer and funnier than I would ever be and who still couldn't see a better future than to obliterate himself. And finally, my head pressed into the pillow, I cried, because my life suddenly seemed so much darker and more complicated than I could ever have imagined, and I wished I could go back, back to when my biggest worry was whether Frank and I had ordered in enough Chelsea buns.

There was a knock on the door.

I blew my nose. 'Piss off, Katrina.'

'I'm sorry.'

I stared at the door.

Her voice was muffled, as if her lips were close up to the keyhole. 'I've got wine. Look, let me in for God's sake, or Mum will hear me. I've got two Bob the Builder mugs stuck up my jumper, and you know how she gets about us drinking upstairs.'

I climbed off the bed and opened the door.

She glanced up at my tear-stained face, and swiftly closed the bedroom door behind her. 'Okay,' she said, wrenching off the screw top and pouring me a mug of wine, 'what really happened?'

I looked at my sister hard. 'You mustn't tell anyone what I'm about to tell you. Not Dad. Especially not Mum.'

Then I told her.

I had to tell someone

There were many ways in which I disliked my sister. A few years ago I could have shown you whole scribbled lists I had written on that very topic. I hated her for the fact that she got thick, straight hair, while mine breaks off if it grows beyond my shoulders. I hated her for the fact that you can never tell her anything that she doesn't already know. I hated the fact that for my whole school career teachers insisted on telling me in hushed tones how bright she was, as if her brilliance wouldn't mean that by default I lived in a permanent shadow. I hated her for the fact that at the age of twenty-six I lived in a box room in a semi-detached house just so she could have her illegitimate son in with her in the bigger bedroom. But every now and then I was very glad indeed that she was my sister.

Because Katrina didn't shriek in horror. She didn't look shocked, or insist that I tell Mum and Dad. She didn't once tell me I'd done the wrong thing by walking away.

She took a huge swig of her drink. 'Jeez.'

'Exactly.'

'It's legal as well. It's not as if they can stop him.'

'I know.'

'Fuck. I can't even get my head around it.'

We had downed two glasses just in the telling of it, and I could feel the heat rising in my cheeks. 'I hate the thought of leaving him. But I can't be part of this, Treen. I can't.'

'Mmm.' She was thinking. My sister actually has a 'thinking face'. It makes people wait before speaking to her. Dad says my thinking face makes it look like I want to go to the loo.

'I don't know what to do,' I said.

She looked up at me, her face suddenly brightening. 'It's simple.'

'Simple.'

She poured us another glass each. 'Oops. We seem to have finished this already. Yes. Simple. They've got money, right?'

'I don't want their money. She offered me a raise. It's not the point.'

'Shut up. Not for you, idiot girl. They'll have their own money. And he's probably got a shedload of insurance from the accident. Well, you tell them that you want a budget and then you use that money, and you use the – what was it? – four months you've got left. And you change Will Traynor's mind.'

'What?'

'You change his mind. You said he spends most of his time indoors, right? Well, start with something small, then once you've got him out and about again, you think of every fabulous thing you could do for him, everything that might make him want to live – adventures, foreign travel, swimming with dolphins, whatever – and then you do it. I can help you. I'll look things up on the internet at the library. I bet we could come up with some brilliant things for him to do. Things that would really make him happy.'

I stared at her.

'Katrina –'

'Yeah. I know.' She grinned, as I started to smile. 'I'm a fucking genius.'



10

They looked a bit surprised. Actually, that's an understatement. Mrs Traynor looked stunned, and then a bit disconcerted, and then her whole face closed off. Her daughter, curled up next to her on the sofa, just glowered – the kind of face Mum used to warn me would stick in place if the wind changed. It wasn't quite the enthusiastic response I'd been hoping for.

'But what is it you actually want to do?'

'I don't know yet. My sister is good at researching stuff. She's trying to find out what's possible for quadriplegics. But I really wanted to find out from you whether you would be willing to go with it.'

We were in their drawing room. It was the same room I had been interviewed in, except this time Mrs Traynor and her daughter were perched on the sofa, their slobbery old dog between them. Mr Traynor was standing by the fire. I was wearing my French peasant's jacket in indigo denim, a minidress and a pair of army boots. With hindsight, I realized, I could have picked a more professional-looking uniform in which to outline my plan.

'Let me get this straight.' Camilla Traynor leant forward. 'You want to take Will away from this house.'

'Yes.'

'And take him on a series of "adventures".' She said it like I was suggesting performing amateur keyhole surgery on him.

'Yes. Like I said, I'm not sure what's possible yet. But it's about just getting him out and about, widening his horizons. There may be some local

things we could do at first, and then hopefully something further afield before too long.'

'Are you talking about going abroad?'

'Abroad ... ?' I blinked. 'I was thinking more about maybe getting him to the pub. Or to a show, just for starters.'

'Will has barely left this house in two years, apart from hospital appointments.'

'Well, yes ... I thought I'd try and persuade him otherwise.'

'And you would, of course, go on all these adventures with him,' Georgina Traynor said.

'Look. It's nothing extraordinary. I'm really talking about just getting him out of the house, to start with. A walk around the castle, or a visit to the pub. If we end up swimming with dolphins in Florida, then that's lovely. But really I just wanted to get him out of the house and thinking about something else.' I didn't add that the mere thought of driving to the hospital in sole charge of Will was still enough to bring me out in a cold sweat. The thought of taking him abroad felt as likely as me running a marathon.

'I think it's a splendid idea,' Mr Traynor said. 'I think it would be marvellous to get Will out and about. You know it can't have been good for him staring at the four walls day in and day out.'

'We have tried to get him out, Steven,' Mrs Traynor said. 'It's not as if we've left him in there to rot. I've tried again and again.'

'I know that, darling, but we haven't been terribly successful, have we? If Louisa here can think up things that Will is prepared to try, then that can only be a good thing, surely?'

'Yes, well, "prepared to try" being the operative phrase.'

'It's just an idea,' I said. I felt suddenly irritated. I could see what she was thinking. 'If you don't want me to do it ... '

'... you'll leave?' She looked straight at me.

I didn't look away. She didn't frighten me any more. Because I knew now she was no better than me. She was a woman who could sit back and let her son die right in front of her.

'Yes, I probably will.'

'So it's blackmail.'

'Georgina!'

'Well, let's not beat around the bush here, Daddy.'

I sat up a little straighter. 'No. Not blackmail. It's about what I'm prepared to be part of. I can't sit by and just quietly wait out the time until ... Will ... well ... ' My voice tailed off.

We all stared at our cups of tea.

'Like I said,' Mr Traynor said firmly. 'I think it's a very good idea. If you can get Will to agree to it, I can't see that there's any harm at all. I'd love the idea of him going on holiday. Just ... just let us know what you need us to do.'

'I've got an idea.' Mrs Traynor put a hand on her daughter's shoulder. 'Perhaps you could go on holiday with them, Georgina.'

'Fine by me,' I said. It was. Because my chances of getting Will away on holiday were about the same as me competing on *Mastermind*.

Georgina Traynor shifted uncomfortably in her seat. 'I can't. You know I start my new job in two weeks. I won't be able to come over to England again for a bit once I've started.'

'You're going back to Australia?'

'Don't sound so surprised. I did tell you this was just a visit.'

'I just thought that ... given ... given recent events, you might want to stay here a bit longer.' Camilla Traynor stared at her daughter in a way she never stared at Will, no matter how rude he was to her.

'It's a really good job, Mummy. It's the one I've been working towards for the last two years.' She glanced over at her father. 'I can't put my whole life on hold just because of Will's mental state.'

There was a long silence.

'This isn't fair. If it was me in the chair, would you have asked Will to put all his plans on hold?'

Mrs Traynor didn't look at her daughter. I glanced down at my list, reading and rereading the first paragraph.

'I have a life too, you know.' It came out like a protest.

'Let's discuss this some other time.' Mr Traynor's hand landed on his daughter's shoulder and squeezed it gently.

'Yes, let's.' Mrs Traynor began to shuffle the papers in front of her. 'Right, then. I propose we do it like this. I want to know everything you are planning,' she said, looking up at me. 'I want to do the costings and, if possible, I'd like a schedule so that I can try and plan some time off to come along with you. I have some unused holiday entitlement left that I can –'

'No.'

We all turned to look at Mr Traynor. He was stroking the dog's head and his expression was gentle, but his voice was firm. 'No. I don't think you should go, Camilla. Will should be allowed to do this by himself.'

'Will can't do it by himself, Steven. There is an awful lot that needs to be considered when Will goes anywhere. It's complicated. I don't think we can really leave it to –'

'No, darling,' he repeated. 'Nathan can help, and Louisa can manage just fine.'

'But –'

'Will needs to be allowed to feel like a man. That is not going to be possible if his mother – or his sister, for that matter – is always on hand.'

I felt briefly sorry for Mrs Traynor then. She still wore that haughty look of hers, but I could see underneath that she seemed a little lost, as if she couldn't quite understand what her husband was doing. Her hand went to her necklace.

'I will make sure he's safe,' I said. 'And I will let you know everything we're planning on doing, well in advance.'

Her jaw was so rigid that a little muscle was visible just underneath her cheekbone. I wondered if she actually hated me then.

'I want Will to want to live too,' I said, finally.

'We do understand that,' Mr Traynor said. 'And we do appreciate your determination. And discretion.' I wondered whether that word was in relation to Will, or something else entirely, and then he stood up and I realized that it was my signal to leave. Georgina and her mother still sat on the sofa, saying nothing. I got the feeling there was going to be a whole lot more conversation once I was out of the room.

'Right, then,' I said. 'I'll draw you up the paperwork as soon as I've worked it all out in my head. It will be soon. We haven't much ... '

Mr Traynor patted my shoulder.

'I know. Just let us know what you come up with,' he said.

Treena was blowing on her hands, her feet moving involuntarily up and down, as if marching on the spot. She was wearing my dark-green beret, which, annoyingly, looked much better on her than it did on me. She leant over and pointed at the list she had just pulled from her pocket, and handed it to me.

‘You’re probably going to have to scratch number three, or at least put that off until it gets warmer.’

I checked the list. ‘Quadriplegic basketball? I’m not even sure if he likes basketball.’

‘That’s not the point. Bloody hell, it’s cold up here.’ She pulled the beret lower over her ears. ‘The point is, it will give him a chance to see what’s possible. He can see that there are other people just as badly off as him who are doing sports and things.’

‘I’m not sure. He can’t even lift a cup. I think these people must be paraplegic. I can’t see that you could throw a ball without the use of your arms.’

‘You’re missing the point. He doesn’t have to actually *do* anything, but it’s about widening his horizons, right? We’re letting him see what other handicapped people are doing.’

‘If you say so.’

A low murmur rose in the crowd. The runners had been sighted, some distance away. If I went on to tiptoes, I could just make them out, probably two miles away, down in the valley, a small block of bobbing white dots forcing their way through the cold along a damp, grey road. I glanced at my watch. We had been standing here on the brow of the aptly named Windy Hill for almost forty minutes, and I could no longer feel my feet.

‘I’ve looked up what’s local and, if you didn’t want to drive too far, there’s a match at the sports centre in a couple of weeks. He could even have a bet on the result.’

‘Betting?’

‘That way he could get a bit involved without even having to play. Oh look, there they are. How long do you think they’ll take to get to us?’

We stood by the finish. Above our heads a tarpaulin banner announcing the ‘Spring Triathlon Finish Line’ flapped wanly in the stiff breeze.

‘Dunno. Twenty minutes? Longer? I’ve got an emergency Mars Bar if you want to share.’ I reached into my pocket. It was impossible to stop the list flapping with only one hand. ‘So what else did you come up with?’

‘You said you wanted to go further afield, right?’ She pointed at my fingers. ‘You’ve given yourself the bigger bit.’

‘Take this bit then. I think the family think I’m free-loading.’

‘What, because you want to take him on a few crummy days out? Jesus. They should be grateful someone’s making the effort. It’s not like they are.’

Treena took the other piece of Mars Bar. ‘Anyway. Number five, I think it is. There’s a computer course that he could do. They put a thing on their head with, like, a stick on it, and they nod their head to touch the keyboard. There are loads of quadriplegic groups online. He could make lots of new friends that way. It would mean he doesn’t always have to actually leave the house. I even spoke to a couple on the chatrooms. They seemed nice. Quite –’ she shrugged ‘– *normal*.’

We ate our Mars Bar halves in silence, watching as the group of miserable-looking runners drew closer. I couldn’t see Patrick. I never could. He had the kind of face that became instantly invisible in crowds.

She pointed at the bit of paper.

‘Anyway, head for the cultural section. There’s a concert specially for people with disabilities here. You said he’s cultured, right? Well, he could just sit there and be transported by the music. That’s meant to take you out of yourself, right? Derek with the moustache, at work, told me about it. He said it can get noisy because of the really disabled people who yell a bit, but I’m sure he’d still enjoy it.’

I wrinkled my nose. ‘I don’t know, Treen –’

‘You’re just frightened because I said “culture”. You only have to sit there with him. And not rustle your crisp packet. Or, if you fancied something a bit saucier ...’ She grinned at me. ‘There’s a strip club. You could take him to London for that.’

‘Take my employer to watch a stripper?’

‘Well, you say you do everything else for him – all the cleaning and feeding and stuff. I can’t see why you wouldn’t just sit by him while he gets a stiffy.’

‘Treena!’

‘Well, he must miss it. You could even buy him a lap dance.’

Several people around us in the crowd swivelled their heads. My sister was laughing. She could talk about sex like that. Like it was some kind of recreational activity. Like it didn’t matter.

‘And then on the other side, there are the bigger trips. Don’t know what you fancied, but you could do wine tasting in the Loire ... that’s not too far for starters.’

‘Can quadriplegics get drunk?’

‘I don’t know. Ask him.’

I frowned at the list. 'So ... I'll go back and tell the Traynors that I'm going to get their suicidal quadriplegic son drunk, spend their money on strippers and lap dancers, and then trundle him off to the Disability Olympics –'

Treena snatched the list back from me. 'Well, I don't see *you* coming up with anything more bloody inspirational.'

'I just thought ... I don't know.' I rubbed at my nose. 'I'm feeling a bit daunted, to be honest. I have trouble even persuading him to go into the garden.'

'Well, that's hardly the attitude, is it? Oh, look. Here they come. We'd better smile.'

We pushed our way through to the front of the crowd and began to cheer. It was quite hard coming up with the required amount of motivating noise when you could barely move your lips with cold.

I saw Patrick then, his head down in a sea of straining bodies, his face glistening with sweat, every sinew of his neck stretched and his face anguished as if he were enduring some kind of torture. That same face would be completely illuminated as soon as he crossed the finish, as if it were only by plumbing some personal depths that he could achieve a high. He didn't see me.

'Go, Patrick!' I yelled, weakly.

And he flashed by, towards the finishing line.

Treena didn't talk to me for two days after I failed to show the required enthusiasm for her 'To Do' list. My parents didn't notice; they were just overjoyed to hear that I had decided not to leave my job. Management had called a series of meetings at the furniture factory for the end of that week, and Dad was convinced that he would be among those made redundant. Nobody had yet survived the cull over the age of forty.

'We're very grateful for your housekeeping, love,' Mum said, so often that it made me feel a bit uncomfortable.

It was a funny week. Treena began packing for her course, and each day I had to sneak upstairs to go through the bags she had already packed to see which of my possessions she planned to take with her. Most of my clothes were safe, but so far I had recovered a hairdryer, my fake Prada sunglasses and my favourite washbag with the lemons on it. If I confronted her over

any of it, she would just shrug and say, 'Well, you never use it,' as if that were entirely the point.

That was Treena all over. She felt entitled. Even though Thomas had come along, she had never quite lost that sense of being the baby of the family – the deep-rooted feeling that the whole world actually did revolve around her. When we had been little and she had thrown a huge strop because she wanted something of mine, Mum would plead with me to 'just let her have it', if only for some peace in the house. Nearly twenty years on, nothing had really changed. We had to babysit Thomas so that Treena could still go out, feed him so that Treena didn't have to worry, buy her extra-nice presents at birthdays and Christmas 'because Thomas means she often goes without'. Well, she could go without my bloody lemons washbag. I stuck a note on my door which read: 'My stuff is MINE. GO AWAY.' Treena ripped it off and told Mum I was the biggest child she had ever met and that Thomas had more maturity in his little finger than I did.

But it got me thinking. One evening, after Treena had gone out to her night class, I sat in the kitchen while Mum sorted Dad's shirts ready for ironing.

'Mum ... '

'Yes, love.'

'Do you think I could move into Treena's room once she's gone?'

Mum paused, a half-folded shirt pressed to her chest. 'I don't know. I hadn't really thought about it.'

'I mean, if she and Thomas are not going to be here, it's only fair that I should be allowed a proper-sized bedroom. It seems silly, it sitting empty, if they're going off to college.'

Mum nodded, and placed the shirt carefully in the laundry basket. 'I suppose you're right.'

'And by rights, that room should have been mine, what with me being the elder and all. It's only because she had Thomas that she got it at all.'

She could see the sense in it. 'That's true. I'll talk to Treena about it,' she said.

I suppose with hindsight it would have been a good idea to mention it to my sister first.

Three hours later she came bursting into the living room with a face like thunder.

'Would you jump in my grave so quickly?'

Granddad jerked awake in his chair, his hand reflexively clasped to his chest.

I looked up from the television. 'What are you talking about?'

'Where are me and Thomas supposed to go at weekends? We can't both fit in the box room. There's not even enough room in there for two beds.'

'Exactly. And I've been stuck in there for five years.' The knowledge that I was ever so slightly in the wrong made me sound pricklier than I had intended.

'You can't take my room. It's not fair.'

'You're not even going to be in it!'

'But I need it! There's no way me and Thomas can fit in the box room. Dad, tell her!'

Dad's chin descended to somewhere deep in his collar, his arms folded across his chest. He hated it when we fought, and tended to leave it to Mum to sort out. 'Turn it down a bit, girls,' he said.

Granddad shook his head, as if we were all incomprehensible to him. Granddad shook his head at an awful lot these days.

'I don't believe you. No wonder you were so keen to help me leave.'

'What? So you begging me to keep my job so that I can help you out financially is now part of my sinister plan, is it?'

'You're so two-faced.'

'Katrina, calm down.' Mum appeared in the doorway, her rubber gloves dripping foamy water on to the living-room carpet. 'We can talk about this calmly. I don't want you getting Granddad all wound up.'

Katrina's face had gone blotchy, the way it did when she was small and she didn't get what she wanted. 'She actually wants me to go. That's what this is. She can't wait for me to go, because she's jealous that I'm actually doing something with my life. So she just wants to make it difficult for me to come home again.'

'There's no guarantee you're even going to be coming home at the weekends,' I yelled, stung. 'I need a bedroom, not a cupboard, and you've had the best room the whole time, just because you were dumb enough to get yourself up the duff.'

'Louisa!' said Mum.

'Yes, well, if you weren't so thick that you can't even get a proper job, you could have got your own bloody place. You're old enough. Or what's

the matter? You've finally figured out that Patrick is never going to ask you?'

'That's it!' Dad's roar broke into the silence. 'I've heard enough! Treena, go into the kitchen. Lou, sit down and shut up. I've got enough stress in my life without having to listen to you caterwauling at each other.'

'If you think I'm helping you now with your stupid list, you've got another thing coming,' Treena hissed at me, as Mum manhandled her out of the door.

'Good. I didn't want your help anyway, *freeloader*,' I said, and then ducked as Dad threw a copy of the *Radio Times* at my head.

On Saturday morning I went to the library. I think I probably hadn't been in there since I was at school – quite possibly out of fear that they would remember the Judy Blume I had lost in Year 7, and that a clammy, official hand would reach out as I passed through its Victorian pillared doors, demanding £3,853 in fines.

It wasn't what I remembered. Half the books seemed to have been replaced by CDs and DVDs, great bookshelves full of audiobooks, and even stands of greetings cards. And it was not silent. The sound of singing and clapping filtered through from the children's book corner, where some kind of mother and baby group was in full swing. People read magazines and chatted quietly. The section where old men used to fall asleep over the free newspapers had disappeared, replaced by a large oval table with computers dotted around the perimeter. I sat down gingerly at one of these, hoping that nobody was watching. Computers, like books, are my sister's thing. Luckily, they seemed to have anticipated the sheer terror felt by people like me. A librarian stopped by my table, and handed me a card and a laminated sheet with instructions on it. She didn't stand over my shoulder, just murmured that she would be at the desk if I needed any further help, and then it was just me and a chair with a wonky castor and the blank screen.

The only computer I have had any contact with in years is Patrick's. He only really uses it to download fitness plans, or to order sports technique books from Amazon. If there is other stuff he does on there, I don't really want to know about it. But I followed the librarian's instructions, double-checking every stage as I completed it. And, astonishingly, it worked. It didn't just work, but it was *easy*.

Four hours later I had the beginnings of my list.

And nobody mentioned the Judy Blume. Mind you, that was probably because I had used my sister's library card.

On the way home I nipped in to the stationer's and bought a calendar. It wasn't one of the month-to-view kind, the ones you flip over to reveal a fresh picture of Justin Timberlake or mountain ponies. It was a wall calendar – the sort you might find in an office, with staff holiday entitlement marked on it in permanent pen. I bought it with the brisk efficiency of someone who liked nothing better than to immerse herself in administrative tasks.

In my little room at home, I opened it out, pinned it carefully to the back of my door and marked the date when I had started at the Traynors', way back at the beginning of February. Then I counted forward, and marked the date – 12 August – now barely four months ahead. I took a step back and stared at it for a while, trying to make the little black ring bear some of the weight of what it heralded. And as I stared, I began to realize what I was taking on.

I would have to fill those little white rectangles with a lifetime of things that could generate happiness, contentment, satisfaction or pleasure. I would have to fill them with every good experience I could summon up for a man whose powerless arms and legs meant he could no longer make them happen by himself. I had just under four months' worth of printed rectangles to pack out with days out, trips away, visitors, lunches and concerts. I had to come up with all the practical ways to make them happen, and do enough research to make sure that they didn't fail.

And then I had to convince Will to actually do them.

I stared at my calendar, the pen stilled in my hand. This little patch of laminated paper suddenly bore a whole heap of responsibility.

I had a hundred and seventeen days in which to convince Will Traynor that he had a reason to live.



11

There are places where the changing seasons are marked by migrating birds, or the ebb and flow of tides. Here, in our little town, it was the return of the tourists. At first, a tentative trickle, stepping off trains or out of cars in brightly coloured waterproof coats, clutching their guidebooks and National Trust membership; then, as the air warmed, and the season crept forwards, disgorged alongside the belch and hiss of their coaches, clogging up the high street, Americans, Japanese and packs of foreign schoolchildren were dotted around the perimeter of the castle.

In the winter months little stayed open. The wealthier shop owners took advantage of the long bleak months to disappear to holiday homes abroad, while the more determined hosted Christmas events, capitalizing on occasional carol concerts in the grounds, or festive craft fairs. But then as the temperatures slid higher, the castle car parks would become studded with vehicles, the local pubs chalk up an increase in requests for a ploughman's lunch and, within a few sunny Sundays, we had morphed again from being a sleepy market town into a traditional English tourist destination.

I walked up the hill, dodging this season's hovering early few as they clutched their neoprene bumbags and well-thumbed tourist guides, their cameras already poised to capture mementoes of the castle in spring. I smiled at a few, paused to take photographs of others with proffered cameras. Some locals complained about the tourist season – the traffic jams, the overwhelmed public toilets, the demands for strange comestibles in The

Buttered Bun cafe ('You don't do sushi? Not even hand roll?'). But I didn't. I liked the breath of foreign air, the close-up glimpses of lives far removed from my own. I liked to hear the accents and work out where their owners came from, to study the clothes of people who had never seen a Next catalogue or bought a five-pack of knickers at Marks and Spencer's.

'You look cheerful,' Will said, as I dropped my bag in the hallway. He said it as if it were almost an affront.

'That's because it's today.'

'What is?'

'Our outing. We're taking Nathan to see the horse racing.'

Will and Nathan looked at each other. I almost laughed. I had been so relieved at the sight of the weather; once I saw the sun, I knew everything was going to be all right.

'Horse racing?'

'Yup. Flat racing at –' I pulled my notepad from my pocket '– Longfield. If we leave now we can be there in time for the third race. And I have five pounds each way on Man Oh Man, so we'd better get a move on.'

'Horse racing.'

'Yes. Nathan's never been.'

In honour of the occasion I was wearing my blue quilted minidress, with the scarf with horse bits around the edge knotted at my neck, and a pair of leather riding boots.

Will studied me carefully, then reversed his chair and swerved so that he could better see his male carer. 'This is a long-held desire of yours, is it, Nathan?'

I gave Nathan a warning glare.

'Yiss,' he said, and broke out a smile. 'Yes, it is. Let's head for the gee-gees.'

I had primed him, of course. I had rung him on Friday and asked him which day I could borrow him for. The Traynors had agreed to pay his extra hours (Will's sister had left for Australia, and I think they wanted to be sure that someone 'sensible' was going to accompany me) but I hadn't been sure until Sunday what it actually was we were going to do. This seemed the ideal start – a nice day out, less than half an hour's drive away.

'And what if I say I don't want to go?'

'Then you owe me forty pounds,' I said.

'Forty pounds? How do you work that out?'

‘My winnings. Five pounds each way at eight to one.’ I shrugged. ‘Man Oh Man’s a sure thing.’

I seemed to have got him off balance.

Nathan clapped his hands on to his knees. ‘Sounds great. Nice day for it too,’ he said. ‘You want me to pack some lunch?’

‘Nah,’ I said. ‘There’s a nice restaurant. When my horse comes in, lunch is on me.’

‘You’ve been racing often, then?’ Will said.

And then before he could say anything else, we had bundled him into his coat and I ran outside to reverse the car.

I had it all planned, you see. We would arrive at the racecourse on a beautiful sunny day. There would be burnished, stick-legged thoroughbreds, their jockeys in billowing bright silks, careening past. Perhaps a brass band or two. The stands would be full of cheering people, and we would find a space from which to wave our winning betting slips. Will’s competitive streak would kick in and he would be unable to resist calculating the odds and making sure he won more than either Nathan or me. I had worked it all out. And then, when we had had enough of watching the horses, we would go to the well-reviewed racecourse restaurant and have a slap-up meal.

I should have listened to my father. ‘Want to know the true definition of the triumph of hope over experience?’ he would say. ‘Plan a fun family day out.’

It started with the car park. We drove there without incident, me now a little more confident that I wasn’t going to tip Will over if I went faster than 15 mph. I had looked up the directions at the library, and kept up a cheerful banter almost the whole way there, commenting on the beautiful blue sky, the countryside, the lack of traffic. There were no queues to enter the racecourse, which was, admittedly, a little less grand than I had expected, and the car park was clearly marked.

But nobody had warned me it was on grass, and grass that had been driven over for much of a wet winter at that. We backed into a space (not hard, as it was only half full) and almost as soon as the ramp was down Nathan looked worried.

‘It’s too soft,’ he said. ‘He’s going to sink.’

I glanced over at the stands. ‘Surely, if we can get him on to that pathway we’ll be okay?’

‘It weighs a ton, this chair,’ he said. ‘And that’s forty feet away.’

‘Oh, come on. They must build these chairs to withstand a bit of soft ground.’

I backed Will’s chair down carefully and then watched as the wheels sank several inches into the mud.

Will said nothing. He looked uncomfortable, and had been silent for much of the half-hour drive. We stood beside him, fiddling with his controls. A breeze had picked up, and Will’s cheeks grew pink.

‘Come on,’ I said. ‘We’ll do it manually. I’m sure we can manage to get there between us.’

We tilted Will backwards. I took one handle and Nathan took the other and we dragged the chair towards the path. It was slow progress, not least because I had to keep stopping because my arms hurt and my pristine boots grew thick with dirt. When we finally made it to the pathway, Will’s blanket had half slipped off him and had somehow got caught up in his wheels, leaving one corner torn and muddy.

‘Don’t worry,’ Will said, dryly. ‘It’s only cashmere.’

I ignored him. ‘*Right*. We’ve made it. Now for the fun bit.’

Ah yes. The fun bit. Who thought it would be a good idea for racecourses to have turnstiles? It was hardly as if they needed crowd control, surely? It’s not as if there were crowds of chanting racehorse fans, threatening riots if Charlie’s Darling didn’t make it back in third, rioting stable-girls who needed penning in and keeping out. We looked at the turnstile, and then back at Will’s chair, and then Nathan and I looked at each other.

Nathan stepped over to the ticket office and explained our plight to the woman inside. She tilted her head to look at Will, then pointed us towards the far end of the stand.

‘The disabled entrance is over there,’ she said.

She said *disabled* like someone entering a diction contest. It was a good 200 yards away. By the time we finally made it over there the blue skies had disappeared abruptly, replaced by a sudden squall. Naturally, I hadn’t brought an umbrella. I kept up a relentless, cheerful commentary about how funny this was and how ridiculous, and even to my ears I had begun to sound brittle and irritating.

‘Clark,’ said Will, finally. ‘Just chill out, okay? You’re being exhausting.’

We bought tickets for the stands, and then, almost faint with relief at finally having got there, I wheeled Will out to a sheltered area just to the

side of the main stand. While Nathan sorted out Will's drink, I had some time to look at our fellow racegoers.

It was actually quite pleasant at the base of the stands, despite the occasional spit of rain. Above us, on a glass-fronted balcony, men in suits proffered champagne glasses to women in wedding outfits. They looked warm and cosy, and I suspected that was the Premier Area, listed next to some stratospheric price on the board in the ticket kiosk. They wore little badges on red thread, marking them out as special. I wondered briefly if it was possible to colour our blue ones a different shade, but decided that being the only people with a wheelchair would probably make us a little conspicuous.

Beside us, dotted along the stands and clutching polystyrene cups of coffee and hip flasks, were men in tweedy suits and women in smart padded coats. They looked a little more everyday, and their little badges were blue too. I suspected that many of them were trainers and grooms, or horsey people of some sort. Down at the front, by little whiteboards, stood the tic-tac men, their arms waving in some strange semaphore that I couldn't understand. They scribbled up new combinations of figures, and scrubbed them out again with the base of their sleeves.

And then, like some parody of a class system, around the parade ring stood a group of men in striped polo shirts, who clutched beer cans and who seemed to be on some kind of outing. Their shaved heads suggested some kind of military service. Periodically they would break out into song, or begin some noisy, physical altercation, ramming each other with blunt heads or wrapping their arms around each other's necks. As I passed to go to the loo, they catcalled me in my short skirt (I appeared to be the only person in the whole of the stands in a skirt) and I flipped them the finger behind my back. And then they lost interest as seven or eight horses began skirting around each other, eased into the stands with workmanlike skill, all preparing for the next race.

And then I jumped as around us the small crowd roared into life and the horses bolted from the starting gate. I stood and watched them go, suddenly transfixed, unable to suppress a flurry of excitement at the tails suddenly streaming out behind them, the frantic efforts of the brightly coloured men atop them, all jostling for position. When the winner crossed the finishing line it was almost impossible not to cheer.

We watched the Sisterwood Cup, and then the Maiden Stakes, and Nathan won six pounds on a small each-way bet. Will declined to bet. He watched each race, but he was silent, his head retracted into the high collar of his jacket. I thought perhaps he had been indoors so long that it was bound to all feel a little weird for him, and I decided I was simply not going to acknowledge it.

‘I think that’s your race, the Hempworth Cup,’ Nathan said, glancing up at the screen. ‘Who did you say your money was on? Man Oh Man?’ He grinned. ‘I never knew how much more fun betting is when you’re actually watching the horses.’

‘You know, I didn’t tell you this, but I’ve never been racing before either,’ I told Nathan.

‘You’re kidding me.’

‘I’ve never even been on a horse. My mum is terrified of them. Wouldn’t even take me to the stables.’

‘My sister’s got two, just outside Christchurch. She treats them like babies. All her money goes on them.’ He shrugged. ‘And she isn’t even going to *eat* them at the end of it.’

Will’s voice filtered up towards us. ‘So how many races will it take to ensure we’ve fulfilled your long-held ambitions?’

‘Don’t be grumpy. They say you should try everything once,’ I said.

‘I think horse racing falls into the “except incest and morris dancing” category.’

‘You’re the one always telling me to widen my horizons. You’re loving it,’ I said. ‘And don’t pretend otherwise.’

And then they were off. Man Oh Man was in purple silks with a yellow diamond. I watched him flatten out around the white rail, the horse’s head extended, the jockey’s legs pumping, arms flailing backwards and forwards up the horse’s neck.

‘Go on, mate!’ Nathan had got into it, despite himself. His fists were clenched, his eyes fixed on the blurred group of animals speeding around the far side of the track.

‘Go on, Man Oh Man!’ I yelled. ‘We’ve got a steak dinner riding on you!’ I watched him vainly trying to make ground, his nostrils dilated, his ears back against his head. My own heart lurched into my mouth. And then, as they reached the final furlong, my yelling began to die away. ‘All right, a coffee,’ I said. ‘I’ll settle for a coffee?’

Around me the stands had erupted into shouting and screaming. A girl was bouncing up and down two seats along from us, her voice hoarse with screeching. I found I was bouncing on my toes. And then I looked down and saw that Will's eyes were closed, a faint furrow separating his brows. I tore my attention from the track, and knelt down.

'Are you okay, Will?' I said, moving close to him. 'Do you need something?' I had to yell to make myself heard over the din.

'Scotch,' he said. 'Large one.'

I stared at him, and he lifted his eyes to mine. He looked utterly fed up.

'Let's get some lunch,' I said to Nathan.

Man Oh Man, that four-legged imposter, flashed past the finishing line a miserable sixth. There was another cheer, and the announcer's voice came over the tannoy: *Ladies and gentlemen, an emphatic win there from Love Be A Lady, there in first place, followed by Winter Sun, and Barney Rubble two lengths behind in third place.*

I pushed Will's chair through the oblivious groups of people, deliberately bashing into heels when they failed to react to my second request.

We were just at the lift when I heard Will's voice. 'So, Clark, does this mean you owe me forty pounds?'

The restaurant had been refurbished, the food now under the auspices of a television chef whose face appeared on posters around the racecourse. I had looked up the menu beforehand.

'The signature dish is duck in orange sauce,' I told the two men. 'It's Seventies retro, apparently.'

'Like your outfit,' said Will.

Out of the cold, and away from the crowds, he appeared to have cheered up a little. He had begun to look around him, instead of retreating back into his solitary world. My stomach began to rumble, already anticipating a good, hot lunch. Will's mother had given us eighty pounds as a 'float'. I had decided I would pay for my food myself, and show her the receipt, and as a result had no fears at all that I was going to order myself whatever I fancied on the menu – retro roast duck, or otherwise.

'You like going out to eat, Nathan?' I said.

'I'm more of a beer and takeaway man myself,' Nathan said. 'Happy to come today, though.'

'When did you last go out for a meal, Will?' I said.

He and Nathan looked at each other. 'Not while I've been there,' Nathan said.

'Strangely, I'm not overly fond of being spoon-fed in front of strangers.'

'Then we'll get a table where we can face you away from the room,' I said. I had anticipated this one. 'And if there are any celebrities there, that will be your loss.'

'Because celebrities are thick on the ground at a muddy minor racecourse in March.'

'You're not going to spoil this for me, Will Traynor,' I said, as the lift doors opened. 'The last time I ate out anywhere was a birthday party for four-year-olds at Hailsbury's only indoor bowling alley, and there wasn't a thing there that wasn't covered in batter. Including the children.'

We wheeled our way along the carpeted corridor. The restaurant ran along one side, behind a glass wall, and I could see there were plenty of free tables. My stomach began to rumble in anticipation.

'Hello,' I said, stepping up to the reception area. 'I'd like a table for three, please.' *Please don't look at Will*, I told the woman silently. *Don't make him feel awkward. It's important that he enjoys this.*

'Badge, please,' she said.

'Sorry?'

'Your Premier Area badge?'

I looked at her blankly.

'This restaurant is for Premier badge holders only.'

I glanced behind me at Will and Nathan. They couldn't hear me, but stood, expectantly, waiting. Nathan was helping remove Will's coat.

'Um ... I didn't know we couldn't eat anywhere we wanted. We have the blue badges.'

She smiled. 'Sorry,' she said. 'Only Premier badge holders. It does say so on all our promotional material.'

I took a deep breath. 'Okay. Are there any other restaurants?'

'I'm afraid the Weighing Room, our relaxed dining area, is being refurbished right now, but there are stalls along the stands where you can get something to eat.' She saw my face fall, and added, 'The Pig In A Poke is pretty good. You get a hog roast in a bun. They do apple sauce too.'

'A stall.'

'Yes.'

I leant in towards her. 'Please,' I said. 'We've come a long way, and my friend there isn't good in the cold. Is there any way at all that we could get a table in here? We just really need to get him into the warm. It's really important that he has a good day.'

She wrinkled her nose. 'I'm really sorry,' she said. 'It's more than my job's worth to override the rules. But there is a disabled seating area downstairs that you can shut the doors on. You can't see the course from there, but it's quite snug. It's got heaters and everything. You could eat in there.'

I stared at her. I could feel the tension creeping upwards from my shins. I thought I might have gone completely rigid.

I studied her name badge. 'Sharon,' I said. 'You haven't even begun to fill your tables. Surely it would be better to have more people eating than leaving half these tables empty? Just because of some arcane class-based regulation in a rule book?'

Her smile glinted under the recessed lighting. 'Madam, I have explained the situation to you. If we relaxed the rules for you, we'd have to do it for everyone.'

'But it makes no sense,' I said. 'It's a wet Monday lunchtime. You have empty tables. We want to buy a meal. A properly expensive meal, with napkins and everything. We don't want to eat pork rolls and sit in a cloakroom with no view, no matter how snug.'

Other diners had begun to turn in their seats, curious about the altercation by the door. I could see Will looking embarrassed now. He and Nathan had worked out something was going wrong.

'Then I'm afraid you should have bought a Premier Area badge.'

'Okay.' I reached for my handbag, and began to rifle through, searching for my purse. 'How much is a Premier Area badge?' Tissues, old bus tickets and one of Thomas's Hot Wheels toy cars flew out. I no longer cared. I was going to get Will his posh lunch in a restaurant. 'Here. How much? Another ten? Twenty?' I thrust a fistful of notes at her.

She looked down at my hand. 'I'm sorry, Madam, we don't sell badges here. This is a restaurant. You'll have to go back to the ticket office.'

'The one that's all the way over the other side of the racecourse.'

'Yes.'

We stared at each other.

Will's voice broke in. 'Louisa, let's go.'

I felt my eyes suddenly brim with tears. ‘No,’ I said. ‘This is ridiculous. We’ve come all this way. You stay here and I’ll go and get us all Premier Area badges. And then we will have our meal.’

‘Louisa, I’m not hungry.’

‘We’ll be fine once we’ve eaten. We can watch the horses and everything. It will be fine.’

Nathan stepped forward and laid a hand on my arm. ‘Louisa, I think Will really just wants to go home.’

We were now the focus of the whole restaurant. The gaze of the diners swept over us and travelled past me to Will, where they clouded with faint pity or distaste. I felt that for him. I felt like an utter failure. I looked up at the woman, who did at least have the grace to look slightly embarrassed now that Will had actually spoken.

‘Well, thank you,’ I said to her. ‘Thanks for being so fucking accommodating.’

‘Clark –’ Will’s voice carried a warning.

‘So glad that you are so flexible. I’ll certainly recommend you to everyone I know.’

‘Louisa!’

I grabbed my bag and thrust it under my arm.

‘You’ve forgotten your little car,’ she called, as I swept through the door that Nathan held open for me.

‘Why, does that need a bloody badge too?’ I said, and followed them into the lift.

We descended in silence. I spent most of the short lift journey trying to stop my hands from shaking with rage.

When we reached the bottom concourse, Nathan murmured, ‘I think we should probably get something from one of these stalls, you know. It’s been a few hours now since we ate anything.’ He glanced down at Will, so I knew who it was he was really referring to.

‘Fine,’ I said, brightly. I took a little breath. ‘I love a bit of crackling. Let’s go to the old hog roast.’

We ordered three buns with pork, crackling and apple sauce, and sheltered under the striped awning while we ate them. I sat down on a small dustbin, so that I could be at the same level as Will, and helped him to manageable bites of meat, shredding it with my fingers where necessary. The two women who served behind the counter pretended not to look at us.

I could see them monitoring Will out of the corners of their eyes, periodically muttering to each other when they thought we weren't looking. *Poor man*, I could practically hear them saying. *What a terrible way to live*. I gave them a hard stare, daring them to look at him like that. I tried not to think too hard about what Will must be feeling.

The rain had stopped, but the windswept course felt suddenly bleak, its brown and green surface littered with discarded betting slips, its horizon flat and empty. The car park had thinned out with the rain, and in the distance we could just hear the distorted sound of the tannoy as some other race thundered past.

'I think maybe we should head back,' Nathan said, wiping his mouth. 'I mean, it was nice and all, but best to miss the traffic, eh?'

'Fine,' I said. I screwed up my paper napkin, and threw it into the bin. Will waved away the last third of his roll.

'Didn't he like it?' said the woman, as Nathan began to wheel him away across the grass.

'I don't know. Perhaps he would have liked it better if it hadn't come with a side order of rubberneck,' I said, and chucked the remnants hard into the bin.

But getting to the car and back up the ramp was easier said than done. In the few hours that we had spent at the racecourse, the arrivals and departures meant that the car park had turned into a sea of mud. Even with Nathan's impressive might, and my best shoulder, we couldn't get the chair even halfway across the grass to the car. His wheels skidded and whined, unable to get the purchase to make it up that last couple of inches. Mine and Nathan's feet slithered in the mud, which worked its way up the sides of our shoes.

'It's not going to happen,' said Will.

I had refused to listen to him. I couldn't bear the idea that this was how our day was going to end.

'I think we're going to need some help,' Nathan said. 'I can't even get the chair back on to the path. It's stuck.'

Will let out an audible sigh. He looked about as fed up as I had ever seen him.

'I could lift you into the front seat, Will, if I tilt it back a little. And then Louisa and I could see if we could get the chair in afterwards.'

Will's voice emerged through gritted teeth. 'I am not ending today with a fireman's lift.'

'Sorry, mate,' Nathan said. 'But Lou and I are not going to manage this alone. Here, Lou, you're prettier than I am. Go and collar a few extra pairs of arms, will you?'

Will closed his eyes, set his jaw and I ran towards the stands.

I would not have believed so many people could turn down a cry for help when it involved a wheelchair stuck in mud, especially as the cry did come from a girl in a miniskirt and flashing her most endearing smile. I am not usually good with strangers, but desperation made me fearless. I walked from group to group of racegoers in the grandstand, asking if they could just spare me a few minutes' help. They looked at me and my clothes as if I were plotting some kind of trap.

'It's for a man in a wheelchair,' I said. 'He's a bit stuck.'

'We're just waiting on the next race,' they said. Or, 'Sorry.' Or, 'It'll have to wait till after the two thirty. We have a monkey on this one.'

I even thought about collaring a jockey or two. But as I got close to the enclosure, I saw that they were even smaller than I was.

By the time I got to the parade ring I was incandescent with suppressed rage. I suspect I was snarling at people then, not smiling. And there, finally, joy of joys, were the lads in striped polo shirts. The back of their shirts referred to 'Marky's Last Stand' and they clutched cans of Pilsner and Tennent's Extra. Their accents suggested they were from somewhere in the north-east, and I was pretty sure that they had not had any significant break from alcohol for the last twenty-four hours. They cheered as I approached, and I fought the urge to give them the finger again.

'Gissa smile, sweetheart. It's Marky's stag weekend,' one slurred, slamming a ham-sized hand on to my shoulder.

'It's Monday.' I tried not to flinch as I peeled it off.

'You're joking. Monday already?' He reeled backwards. 'Well, you should give him a kiss, like.'

'Actually,' I said. 'I've come over to ask you for help.'

'Ah'll give you any help you need, pet.' This was accompanied by a lascivious wink.

His mates swayed gently around him like aquatic plants.

'No, really. I need you to help my friend. Over in the car park.'

‘Ah’m sorry, ah’m not sure ah’m in any fit state to help youse, pet.’

‘Hey up. Next race is up, Marky. You got money on this? I think I’ve got money on this.’

They turned back towards the track, already losing interest. I looked over my shoulder at the car park, seeing the hunched figure of Will, Nathan pulling vainly at the handles of his chair. I pictured myself returning home to tell Will’s parents that we had left Will’s super-expensive chair in a car park. And then I saw the tattoo.

‘He’s a soldier,’ I said, loudly. ‘Ex-soldier.’

One by one they turned round.

‘He was injured. In Iraq. All we wanted to do was get him a nice day out. But nobody will help us.’ As I spoke the words, I felt my eyes welling up with tears.

‘A vet? You’re kidding us. Where is he?’

‘In the car park. I’ve asked lots of people, but they just don’t want to help.’

It seemed to take a minute or two for them to digest what I’d said. But then they looked at each other in amazement.

‘C’mon, lads. We’re not having that.’ They swayed after me in a wayward trail. I could hear them exclaiming between themselves, muttering. ‘Bloody civvies ... no idea what it’s like ... ’

When we reached them, Nathan was standing by Will, whose head had sunk deep into the collar of his coat with cold, even as Nathan covered his shoulders with another blanket.

‘These very nice gentlemen have offered to help us,’ I said.

Nathan was staring at the cans of lager. I had to admit that you’d have had to look quite hard to see a suit of armour in any of them.

‘Where do youse want to get him to?’ said one.

The others stood around Will, nodding their hellos. One offered him a beer, apparently unable to grasp that Will could not pick it up.

Nathan motioned to our car. ‘Back in the car, ultimately. But to do that we need to get him over to the stand, and then reverse the car back to him.’

‘You don’t need to do that,’ said one, clapping Nathan on the back. ‘We can take him to your car, can’t we, lads?’

There was a chorus of agreement. They began to position themselves around Will’s chair.

I shifted uncomfortably. 'I don't know ... that's a long way for you to carry him,' I ventured. 'And the chair's very heavy.'

They were howlingly drunk. Some of them could barely hang on to their cans of drink. One thrust his can of Tennent's into my hand.

'Don't you worry, pet. Anything for a fellow soldier, isn't that right, lads?'

'We wouldn't leave you there, mate. We never leave a man down, do we?'

I saw Nathan's face and shook my head furiously at his quizzical expression. Will seemed unlikely to say anything. He just looked grim, and then, as the men clustered around his chair, and with a shout, hoisted it up between them, vaguely alarmed.

'What regiment, pet?'

I tried to smile, trawling my memory for names. 'Rifles ... ' I said. 'Eleventh rifles.'

'I don't know the eleventh rifles,' said another.

'It's a new regiment,' I stuttered. 'Top secret. Based in Iraq.'

Their trainers slid in the mud, and I felt my heart lurch. Will's chair was hoisted several inches off the ground, like some kind of sedan. Nathan was running for Will's bag, unlocking the car ahead of us.

'Did those boys train over in Catterick?'

'That's the one,' I said, and then changed the subject. 'So – which one of you is getting married?'

We had exchanged numbers by the time I finally got rid of Marky and his mates. They had a whip-round, offering us almost forty pounds towards Will's rehabilitation fund, and only stopped insisting when I told them we would be happiest if they would have a drink on us instead. I had to kiss each and every one of them. I was nearly dizzy with fumes by the time I had finished. I continued to wave at them as they disappeared back to the stand, and Nathan sounded the horn to get me into the car.

'They were helpful, weren't they?' I said, brightly, as I turned the ignition.

'The tall one dropped his entire beer down my right leg,' said Will. 'I smell like a brewery.'

'I don't believe this,' said Nathan, as I finally pulled out towards the main entrance. 'Look. There's a whole disabled parking section right there, by the stand. And it's all on tarmac.'

Will didn't say much of anything for the rest of the day. He bid Nathan goodbye when we dropped him home, and then grew silent as I negotiated the road up to the castle, which had thinned out now the temperature had dropped again, and finally I parked up outside the annexe.

I lowered Will's chair, got him inside, and made him a warm drink. I changed his shoes and trousers, put the beer-stained ones in the washing machine, and got the fire going so that he would warm up. I put the television on, and drew the curtains so that the room grew cosy around us – perhaps cosier for the time spent out in the cold air. But it was only when I sat in the living room with him, sipping my tea, that I realized he wasn't talking – not out of exhaustion, or because he wanted to watch the television. He just wasn't talking to me.

'Is ... something the matter?' I said, when he failed to respond to my third comment about the local news.

'You tell me, Clark.'

'What?'

'Well, you know everything else there is to know about me. You tell me.'

I stared at him. 'I'm sorry,' I said, finally. 'I know today didn't turn out quite like I planned. But it was just meant to be a nice outing. I actually thought you'd enjoy it.'

I didn't add that he was being determinedly grumpy, that he had no idea what I had gone through just to get him to try to enjoy himself, that he hadn't even tried to have a good time. I didn't tell him that if he'd let me buy the stupid badges we might have had a nice lunch and all the other stuff might have been forgotten.

'That's my point.'

'What?'

'Oh, you're no different from the rest of them.'

'What does that mean?'

'If you'd bothered to ask me, Clark. If you'd bothered to consult me just once about this so-called fun outing of ours, I could have told you. I hate horses, and horse racing. Always have. But you didn't bother to ask me. You decided what you thought you'd like me to do, and you went ahead and did it. You did what everyone else did. You decided for me.'

I swallowed.

'I didn't mean to –'

'But you did.'

He turned his chair away from me and, after a couple more minutes of silence, I realized I had been dismissed.



12

I can tell you the exact day I stopped being fearless.

It was almost seven years ago, in the last lazy, heat-slurred days of July, when the narrow streets around the castle were thick with tourists, and the air filled with the sound of their meandering footsteps and the chimes of the ever-present ice cream vans that lined the top of the hill.

My grandmother had died a month previously after a long illness, and that summer was veiled in a thin layer of sadness; it gently smothered everything we did, muting mine and my sister's tendencies to the dramatic, and cancelling our usual summer routines of brief holidays and days out. My mother stood most days at her washing-up bowl, her back rigid with the effort of trying to suppress her tears, while Dad disappeared to work each morning with a grimly determined expression, returning hours later shiny-faced from the heat and unable to speak before he had cracked open a beer. My sister was home from her first year at university, her head already somewhere far from our small town. I was twenty and would meet Patrick in less than three months. We were enjoying one of those rare summers of utter freedom – no financial responsibility, no debts, no time owing to anybody. I had a seasonal job and all the hours in the world to practise my make-up, put on heels that made my father wince, and just generally work out who I was.

I dressed normally, in those days. Or, I should say, I dressed like the other girls in town – long hair, flicked over the shoulder, indigo jeans, T-shirts tight enough to show off our tiny waists and high breasts. We spent hours

perfecting our lipgloss, and the exact shade of a smokey eye. We looked good in anything, but spent hours complaining about non-existent cellulite and invisible flaws in our skin.

And I had ideas. Things I wanted to do. One of the boys I knew at school had taken a round-the-world trip and come back somehow removed and unknowable, like he wasn't the same scuffed eleven-year-old who used to blow spit bubbles during double French. I had booked a cheap flight to Australia on a whim, and was trying to find someone who might come with me. I liked the exoticism his travels gave him, the unknownness. He had blown in with the soft breezes of a wider world, and it was weirdly seductive. Everyone here knew everything about me, after all. And with a sister like mine, I was never allowed to forget any of it.

It was a Friday, and I had spent the day working as a car park attendant with a group of girls I had known at school, steering visitors to a craft fair held in the grounds of the castle. The whole day was punctuated with laughter, with fizzy drinks guzzled under a hot sun, the sky blue, light glinting off the battlements. I don't think there was a single tourist who didn't smile at me that day. People find it very hard not to smile at a group of cheerful, giggling girls. We were paid £30, and the organizers were so pleased with the turnout that they gave us an extra fiver each. We celebrated by getting drunk with some boys who had been working on the far car park by the visitor centre. They were well spoken, sporting rugby shirts and floppy hair. One was called Ed, two of them were at university – I still can't remember where – and they were working for holiday money too. They were flush with cash at the end of a whole week of stewarding, and when our money ran out they were happy to buy drinks for giddy local girls who flicked their hair and sat on each other's laps and shrieked and joked and called them posh. They spoke a different language; they talked of gap years and summers spent in South America, and the backpacker trail in Thailand and who was going to try for an internship abroad. While we listened, and drank, I remember my sister stopping by the beer garden where we lay sprawled on the grass. She was wearing the world's oldest hoody and no make-up, and I'd forgotten I was meant to be meeting her. I told her to tell Mum and Dad I'd be back sometime after I was thirty. For some reason I found this hysterically funny. She had lifted her eyebrows, and stalked off like I was the most irritating person ever born.

When the Red Lion closed we all went and sat in the centre of the castle maze. Someone managed to scramble over the gates and, after much colliding and giggling, we all found our way to the middle and drank strong cider while someone passed around a joint. I remember staring up at the stars, feeling myself disappear into their infinite depths, as the ground gently swayed and lurched around me like the deck of a huge ship. Someone was playing a guitar, and I had a pair of pink satin high heels on which I kicked into the long grass and never went back for. I thought I probably ruled the universe.

It was about half an hour before I realized the other girls had gone.

My sister found me, there in the centre of the maze, sometime later, long after the stars had been obscured by the night clouds. As I said, she's pretty smart. Smarter than me, anyway.

She's the only person I ever knew who could find her way out of the maze safely.

'This will make you laugh. I've joined the library.'

Will was over by his CD collection. He swivelled the chair round, and waited while I put his drink in his cup holder. 'Really? What are you reading?'

'Oh, nothing sensible. You wouldn't like it. Just boy-meets-girl stuff. But I'm enjoying it.'

'You were reading my Flannery O'Connor the other day.' He took a sip of his drink. 'When I was ill.'

'The short stories? I can't believe you noticed that.'

'I couldn't help but notice. You left the book out on the side. I can't pick it up.'

'Ah.'

'So don't read rubbish. Take the O'Connor stories home. Read them instead.'

I was about to say no, and then I realized I didn't really know why I was refusing. 'All right. I'll bring them back as soon as I've finished.'

'Put some music on for me, Clark?'

'What do you want?'

He told me, nodding at its rough location, and I flicked through until I found it.

‘I have a friend who plays lead violin in the Albert Symphonia. He called to say he’s playing near here next week. This piece of music. Do you know it?’

‘I don’t know anything about classical music. I mean, sometimes my dad accidentally tunes into Classic FM, but –’

‘You’ve never been to a concert?’

‘No.’

He looked genuinely shocked.

‘Well, I did go to see Westlife once. But I’m not sure if that counts. It was my sister’s choice. Oh, and I was meant to go see Robbie Williams on my twenty-second birthday, but I got food poisoning.’

Will gave me one of his looks – the kind of looks that suggest I may actually have been locked up in somebody’s cellar for several years.

‘You should go. He’s offered me tickets. This will be really good. Take your mother.’

I laughed and shook my head. ‘I don’t think so. My mum doesn’t really go out. And it’s not my cup of tea.’

‘Like films with subtitles weren’t your cup of tea?’

I frowned at him. ‘I’m not your project, Will. This isn’t *My Fair Lady*.’

‘*Pygmalion*.’

‘What?’

‘The play you’re referring to. It’s *Pygmalion*. *My Fair Lady* is just its bastard offspring.’

I glared at him. It didn’t work. I put the CD on. When I turned round he was still shaking his head.

‘You’re the most terrible snob, Clark.’

‘What? *Me*?’

‘You cut yourself off from all sorts of experiences because you tell yourself you are “not that sort of person”.’

‘But, I’m not.’

‘How do you know? You’ve done nothing, been nowhere. How do you have the faintest idea what kind of person you are?’

How could someone like him have the slightest clue what it felt like to be me? I felt almost cross with him for wilfully not getting it.

‘Go on. Open your mind.’

‘No.’

‘Why?’

‘Because I’d be uncomfortable. I feel like ... I feel like they’d know.’

‘Who? Know what?’

‘Everyone else would know, that I didn’t belong.’

‘How do you think I feel?’

We looked at each other.

‘Clark, every single place I go to now people look at me like I don’t belong.’

We sat in silence as the music started. Will’s father was on the telephone in his hall, and the sound of muffled laughter carried through it into the annexe, as if from a long way away. *The disabled entrance is over there*, the woman at the racecourse had said. As if he were a different species.

I stared at the CD cover. ‘I’ll go if you come with me.’

‘But you won’t go on your own.’

‘Not a chance.’

We sat there, while he digested this. ‘Jesus, you’re a pain in the arse.’

‘So you keep telling me.’

I made no plans this time. I expected nothing. I was just quietly hopeful that, after the racing debacle, Will was still prepared to leave the annexe. His friend, the violinist, sent us the promised free tickets, with an information leaflet on the venue attached. It was forty minutes’ drive away. I did my homework, checked the location of the disabled parking, rang the venue beforehand to assess the best way to get Will’s chair to his seat. They would seat us at the front, with me on a folding chair beside Will.

‘It’s actually the best place to be,’ the woman in the box office said, cheerfully. ‘You somehow get more of an impact when you’re right in the pit near the orchestra. I’ve often been tempted to sit there myself.’

She even asked if I would like someone to meet us in the car park, to help us to our seats. Afraid that Will would feel too conspicuous, I thanked her and said no.

As the evening approached, I don’t know who grew more nervous about it, Will or me. I felt the failure of our last outing keenly, and Mrs Traynor didn’t help, coming in and out of the annexe fourteen times to confirm where and when it would be taking place and what exactly we would be doing.

Will’s evening routine took some time, she said. She needed to ensure someone was there to help. Nathan had other plans. Mr Traynor was

apparently out for the evening. 'It's an hour and a half minimum,' she said.

'And it's incredibly tedious,' Will said.

I realized he was looking for an excuse not to go. 'I'll do it,' I said. 'If Will tells me what to do. I don't mind staying to help.' I said it almost before I realized what I was agreeing to.

'Well, that's something for us both to look forward to,' Will said grumpily, after his mother had left. 'You get a good view of my backside, and I get a bed bath from someone who falls over at the sight of naked flesh.'

'I do not fall over at the sight of naked flesh.'

'Clark, I've never seen anyone more uncomfortable with a human body than you. You act like it's something radioactive.'

'Let your mum do it, then,' I snapped back.

'Yes, because that makes the whole idea of going out so much more attractive.'

And then there was the wardrobe problem. I didn't know what to wear.

I had worn the wrong thing to the races. How could I be sure I wouldn't do so again? I asked Will what would be best, and he looked at me as if I were mad. 'The lights will be down,' he explained. 'Nobody will be looking at you. They'll be focused on the music.'

'You know *nothing* about women,' I said.

I brought four different outfits to work with me in the end, hauling them all on to the bus in my Dad's ancient suit carrier. It was the only way I could convince myself to go at all.

Nathan arrived for the teatime shift at 5.30pm, and while he saw to Will I disappeared into the bathroom to get ready. First I put on what I thought of as my 'artistic' outfit, a green smock dress with huge amber beads stitched into it. I imagined the kind of people who went to concerts might be quite arty and flamboyant. Will and Nathan both stared at me as I entered the living room.

'No,' said Will, flatly.

'That looks like something my mum would wear,' said Nathan.

'You never told me your mum was Nana Mouskouri,' Will said.

I could hear them both chuckling as I disappeared back into the bathroom.

The second outfit was a very severe black dress, cut on the bias and stitched with white collar and cuffs, which I had made myself. It looked, I

thought, both chic and Parisian.

‘You look like you’re about to serve the ice creams,’ Will said.

‘Aw, mate, but you’d make a great maid,’ Nathan said, approvingly. ‘Feel free to wear that one in the daytime. Really.’

‘You’ll be asking her to dust the skirting next.’

‘It is a bit dusty, now you mention it.’

‘You,’ I said, ‘are both going to get Mr Muscle in your tea tomorrow.’

I discarded outfit number three – a pair of yellow wide-legged trousers – already anticipating Will’s Rupert Bear references, and instead put on my fourth option, a vintage dress in dark-red satin. It was made for a more frugal generation and I always had to say a secret prayer that the zip would make it up past my waist, but it gave me the outline of a 1950s starlet, and it was a ‘results’ dress, one of those outfits you couldn’t help but feel good in. I put a silver bolero over my shoulders, tied a grey silk scarf around my neck, to cover up my cleavage, applied some matching lipstick, and then stepped into the living room.

‘*Ka-pow*,’ said Nathan, admiringly.

Will’s eyes travelled up and down my dress. It was only then that I realized he had changed into a shirt and suit jacket. Clean-shaven, and with his trimmed hair, he looked surprisingly handsome. I couldn’t help but smile at the sight of him. It wasn’t so much how he looked; it was the fact that he had made the effort.

‘That’s the one,’ he said. His voice was expressionless and oddly measured. And as I reached down to adjust my neckline, he said, ‘But lose the jacket.’

He was right. I had known it wasn’t quite right. I took it off, folded it carefully and laid it on the back of the chair.

‘And the scarf.’

My hand shot to my neck. ‘The scarf? Why?’

‘It doesn’t go. And you look like you’re trying to hide something behind it.’

‘But I’m ... well, I’m all cleavage otherwise.’

‘So?’ he shrugged. ‘Look, Clark, if you’re going to wear a dress like that you need to wear it with confidence. You need to fill it mentally as well as physically.’

‘Only you, Will Traynor, could tell a woman how to wear a bloody dress.’

But I took the scarf off.

Nathan went to pack Will's bag. I was working out what I could add about how patronizing he was, when I turned and saw that he was still looking at me.

'You look great, Clark,' he said, quietly. 'Really.'

With ordinary people – what Camilla Traynor would probably call 'working-class' people – I had observed a few basic routines, as far as Will was concerned. Most would stare. A few might smile sympathetically, express sympathy, or ask me in a kind of stage whisper what had happened. I was often tempted to respond, 'Unfortunate falling-out with MI6,' just to see their reaction, but I never did.

Here's the thing about middle-class people. They pretend not to look, but they do. They were too polite to actually stare. Instead, they did this weird thing of catching sight of Will in their field of vision and then determinedly *not* looking at him. Until he'd gone past, at which point their gaze would flicker towards him, even while they remained in conversation with someone else. They wouldn't talk about him, though. Because that would be rude.

As we moved through the foyer of the Symphony Hall, where clusters of smart people stood with handbags and programmes in one hand, gin and tonics in the other, I saw this response pass through them in a gentle ripple which followed us to the stalls. I don't know if Will noticed it. Sometimes I thought the only way he could deal with it was to pretend he could see none of it.

We sat down, the only two people at the front in the centre block of seats. To our right there was another man in a wheelchair, chatting cheerfully to two women who flanked him. I watched them, hoping that Will would notice them too. But he stared ahead, his head dipped into his shoulders, as if he were trying to become invisible.

This isn't going to work, a little voice said.

'Do you need anything?' I whispered.

'No,' he shook his head. He swallowed. 'Actually, yes. Something's digging into my collar.'

I leant over and ran my finger around the inside of it; a nylon tag had been left inside. I pulled at it, hoping to snap it, but it proved stubbornly resistant.

‘New shirt. Is it really troubling you?’

‘No. I just thought I’d bring it up for fun.’

‘Do we have any scissors in the bag?’

‘I don’t know, Clark. Believe it or not, I rarely pack it myself.’

There were no scissors. I glanced behind me, where the audience were still settling themselves into their seats, murmuring and scanning their programmes. If Will couldn’t relax and focus on the music, the outing would be wasted. I couldn’t afford a second disaster.

‘Don’t move,’ I said.

‘Why –’

Before he could finish, I leant across, gently peeled his collar from the side of his neck, placed my mouth against it and took the offending tag between my front teeth. It took me a few seconds to bite through it, and I closed my eyes, trying to ignore the scent of clean male, the feel of his skin against mine, the incongruity of what I was doing. And then, finally, I felt it give. I pulled back my head and opened my eyes, triumphant, with the freed tag between my front teeth.

‘Got it!’ I said, pulling the tag from my teeth and flicking it across the seats.

Will stared at me.

‘What?’

I swivelled in my chair to catch those audience members who suddenly seemed to find their programmes absolutely fascinating. Then I turned back to Will.

‘Oh, come on, it’s not as if they’ve never seen a girl nibbling a bloke’s collar before.’

I seemed to have briefly silenced him. Will blinked a couple of times, made as if to shake his head. I noticed with amusement that his neck had coloured a deep red.

I straightened my skirt. ‘Anyway,’ I said, ‘I think we should both just be grateful that it wasn’t in your trousers.’

And then, before he could respond, the orchestra walked out in their dinner jackets and cocktail dresses and the audience hushed. I felt a little flutter of excitement despite myself. I placed my hands together on my lap, sat up in my seat. They began to tune up, and suddenly the auditorium was filled with a single sound – the most alive, three-dimensional thing I had

ever heard. It made the hairs on my skin stand up, my breath catch in my throat.

Will looked sideways at me, his face still carrying the mirth of the last few moments. *Okay*, his expression said. *We're going to enjoy this*.

The conductor stepped up, tapped twice on the rostrum, and a great hush descended. I felt the stillness, the auditorium alive, expectant. Then he brought down his baton and suddenly everything was pure sound. I felt the music like a physical thing; it didn't just sit in my ears, it flowed through me, around me, made my senses vibrate. It made my skin prickle and my palms dampen. Will hadn't described any of it like this. I had thought I might be bored. It was the most beautiful thing I had ever heard.

And it made my imagination do unexpected things; as I sat there, I found myself thinking of things I hadn't thought of for years, old emotions washing over me, new thoughts and ideas being pulled from me as if my perception itself were being stretched out of shape. It was almost too much, but I didn't want it to stop. I wanted to sit there forever. I stole a look at Will. He was rapt, suddenly unselfconscious. I turned away, unexpectedly afraid to look at him. I was afraid of what he might be feeling, the depth of his loss, the extent of his fears. Will Traynor's life had been so far beyond the experiences of mine. Who was I to tell him how he should want to live it?

Will's friend left a note asking us to go backstage and see him afterwards, but Will didn't want to. I urged him once, but I could see from the set of his jaw that he would not be budged. I couldn't blame him. I remembered how his former workmates had looked at him that day – that mixture of pity, revulsion and, somewhere, deep relief that they themselves had somehow escaped this particular stroke of fate. I suspected there were only so many of those sorts of meetings he could stomach.

We waited until the auditorium was empty, then I wheeled him out, down to the car park in the lift, and loaded Will up without incident. I didn't say much; my head was still ringing with the music, and I didn't want it to fade. I kept thinking back to it, the way that Will's friend had been so lost in what he was playing. I hadn't realized that music could unlock things in you, could transport you to somewhere even the composer hadn't predicted. It left an imprint in the air around you, as if you carried its remnants with you

when you went. For some time, as we sat there in the audience, I had completely forgotten Will was even beside me.

We pulled up outside the annexe. In front of us, just visible above the wall, the castle sat, floodlit under the full moon, gazing serenely down from its position on the top of the hill.

‘So you’re not a classical music person.’

I looked into the rear-view mirror. Will was smiling.

‘I didn’t enjoy that in the slightest.’

‘I could tell.’

‘I especially didn’t enjoy that bit near the end, the bit where the violin was singing by itself.’

‘I could see you didn’t like that bit. In fact, I think you had tears in your eyes you hated it so much.’

I grinned back at him. ‘I really loved it,’ I said. ‘I’m not sure I’d like *all* classical music, but I thought that was amazing.’ I rubbed my nose. ‘Thank you. Thank you for taking me.’

We sat in silence, gazing at the castle. Normally, at night, it was bathed in a kind of orange glow from the lights dotted around the fortress wall. But tonight, under a full moon, it seemed flooded in an ethereal blue.

‘What kind of music would they have played there, do you think?’ I said. ‘They must have listened to something.’

‘The castle? Medieval stuff. Lutes, strings. Not my cup of tea, but I’ve got some I can lend you, if you like. You should walk around the castle with it on earphones, if you really wanted the full experience.’

‘Nah. I don’t really go to the castle.’

‘It’s always the way, when you live close by somewhere.’

My answer was non-committal. We sat there a moment longer, listening to the engine tick its way to silence.

‘Right,’ I said, unfastening my belt. ‘We’d better get you in. The evening routine awaits.’

‘Just wait a minute, Clark.’

I turned in my seat. Will’s face was in shadow and I couldn’t quite make it out.

‘Just hold on. Just for a minute.’

‘Are you all right?’ I found my gaze dropping towards his chair, afraid some part of him was pinched, or trapped, that I had got something wrong.

‘I’m fine. I just ... ’

I could see his pale collar, his dark suit jacket a contrast against it.

‘I don’t want to go in just yet. I just want to sit and not have to think about ... ’ He swallowed.

Even in the half-dark it seemed effortful.

‘I just ... want to be a man who has been to a concert with a girl in a red dress. Just for a few minutes more.’

I released the door handle.

‘Sure.’

I closed my eyes and lay my head against the headrest, and we sat there together for a while longer, two people lost in remembered music, half hidden in the shadow of a castle on a moonlit hill.

My sister and I never really talked about what happened that night at the maze. I’m not entirely sure we had the words. She held me for a bit, then spent some time helping me find my clothes, and then searched in vain in the long grass for my shoes until I told her that it really didn’t matter. I wouldn’t have worn them again, anyway. And then we walked home slowly – me in my bare feet, her with her arm linked through mine, even though we hadn’t walked like that since she was in her first year at school and Mum had insisted I never let her go.

When we got home, we stood on the porch and she wiped at my hair and then at my eyes with a damp tissue, and then we unlocked the front door and walked in as if nothing had happened.

Dad was still up, watching some football match. ‘You girls are a bit late,’ he called out. ‘I know it’s a Friday, but still ... ’

‘Okay, Dad,’ we called out, in unison.

Back then, I had the room that is now Granddad’s. I walked swiftly upstairs and, before my sister could say a word, I closed the door behind me.

I chopped all my hair off the following week. I cancelled my plane ticket. I didn’t go out with the girls from my old school again. Mum was too sunk in her own grief to notice, and Dad put any change in mood in our house, and my new habit of locking myself in my bedroom, down to ‘women’s problems’. I had worked out who I was, and it was someone very different from the giggling girl who got drunk with strangers. It was someone who wore nothing that could be construed as suggestive. Clothes that would not appeal to the kind of men who went to the Red Lion, anyway.

Life returned to normal. I took a job at the hairdresser's, then The Buttered Bun and put it all behind me.

I must have walked past the castle five thousand times since that day.
But I have never been to the maze since.



13

Patrick stood on the edge of the track, jogging on the spot, his new Nike T-shirt and shorts sticking slightly to his damp limbs. I had stopped by to say hello and to tell him that I wouldn't be at the Triathlon Terrors meeting at the pub that evening. Nathan was off, and I had stepped in to take over the evening routine.

'That's three meetings you've missed.'

'Is it?' I counted back on my fingers. 'I suppose it is.'

'You'll have to come next week. It's all the travel plans for the Xtreme Viking. And you haven't told me what you want to do for your birthday.' He began to do his stretches, lifting his leg high and pressing his chest to his knee. 'I thought maybe the cinema? I don't want to do a big meal, not while I'm training.'

'Ah. Mum and Dad are planning a special dinner.'

He grabbed at his heel, pointing his knee to the ground.

I couldn't help but notice that his leg was becoming weirdly sinewy.

'It's not exactly a night out, is it?'

'Well, nor is the multiplex. Anyway, I feel like I should, Patrick. Mum's been a bit down.'

Treena had moved out the previous weekend (minus my lemons washbag – I retrieved that the night before she went). Mum was devastated; it was actually worse than when Treena had gone to university the first time around. She missed Thomas like an amputated limb. His toys, which had littered the living-room floor since babyhood, were boxed up and put away.

There were no chocolate fingers or small cartons of drink in the cupboard. She no longer had a reason to walk to the school at 3.15pm, nobody to chat to on the short walk home. It had been the only time Mum ever really spent outside the house. Now she went nowhere at all, apart from the weekly supermarket shop with Dad.

She floated around the house looking a bit lost for three days, then she began spring cleaning with a vigour that frightened even Granddad. He would mouth gummy protests at her as she tried to vacuum under the chair that he was still sitting in, or flick at his shoulders with her duster. Treena had said she wouldn't come home for the first few weeks, just to give Thomas a chance to settle. When she rang each evening, Mum would speak to them and then cry for a full half-hour in her bedroom afterwards.

'You're always working late these days. I feel like I hardly see you.'

'Well, you're always training. Anyway, it's good money, Patrick. I'm hardly going to say no to the overtime.'

He couldn't argue with that.

I was earning more than I had ever earned in my life. I doubled the amount I gave my parents, put some aside into a savings account every month, and I was still left with more than I could spend. Part of it was, I worked so many hours that I was never away from Granta House when the shops were open. The other was, simply, that I didn't really have an appetite for spending. The spare hours I did have I had started to spend in the library, looking things up on the internet.

There was a whole world available to me from that PC, layer upon layer of it, and it had begun to exert a siren call.

It had started with the thank-you letter. A couple of days after the concert, I told Will I thought we should write and thank his friend, the violinist.

'I bought a nice card on the way in,' I said. 'You tell me what you want to say, and I'll write it. I've even brought in my good pen.'

'I don't think so,' Will said.

'What?'

'You heard me.'

'You don't *think* so? That man gave us front of house seats. You said yourself it was fantastic. The least you could do is thank him.'

Will's jaw was fixed, immovable.

I put down my pen. ‘Or are you just so used to people giving you stuff that you don’t feel you have to?’

‘You have no idea, Clark, how frustrating it is to rely on someone else to put your words down for you. The phrase “written on behalf of” is ... humiliating.’

‘Yeah? Well it’s still better than a great big fat nothing,’ I grumbled. ‘*I’m* going to thank him, anyway. I won’t mention your name, if you really want to be an arse about it.’

I wrote the card, and posted it. I said nothing more about it. But that evening, Will’s words still echoing around my head, I found myself diverting into the library and, spying an unused computer, I logged on to the internet. I looked up whether there were any devices that Will could use to do his own writing. Within an hour, I had come up with three – a piece of voice recognition software, another type of software which relied on the blinking of an eye, and, as my sister had mentioned, a tapping device that Will could wear on his head.

He was predictably sniffy about the head device, but he conceded that the voice recognition software might be useful, and within a week we managed, with Nathan’s help, to install it on his computer, setting Will up so that with the computer tray fixed to his chair, he no longer needed someone else to type for him. He was a bit self-conscious about it initially, but after I instructed him to begin everything with, ‘Take a letter, Miss Clark,’ he got over it.

Even Mrs Traynor couldn’t find anything to complain about. ‘If there is any other equipment that you think might be useful,’ she said, her lips still pursed as if she couldn’t quite believe this might have been a straightforwardly good thing, ‘do let us know.’ She eyed Will nervously, as if he might actually be about to wrench it off with his jaw.

Three days later, just as I set off for work, the postman handed me a letter. I opened it on the bus, thinking it might be an early birthday card from some distant cousin. It read, in computerized text:

Dear Clark,

This is to show you that I am not an entirely selfish arse. And I do appreciate your efforts.

Thank you.

Will

I laughed so hard the bus driver asked me if my lottery numbers had come up.

After years spent in that box room, my clothes perched on a rail in the hallway outside, Treena's bedroom felt palatial. The first night I spent in it I spun round with my arms outstretched, just luxuriating in the fact that I couldn't touch both walls simultaneously. I went to the DIY store and bought paint and new blinds, as well as a new bedside light and some shelves, which I assembled myself. It's not that I'm good at that stuff; I guess I just wanted to see if I could do it.

I set about redecorating, painting for an hour a night after I came home from work, and at the end of the week even Dad had to admit I'd done a really good job. He stared for a bit at my cutting in, fingered the blinds that I had put up myself, and put a hand on my shoulder. 'This job has been the making of you, Lou.'

I bought a new duvet cover, a rug and some oversized cushions – just in case anyone ever stopped by, and fancied lounging. Not that anyone did. The calendar went on the back of the new door. Nobody saw it except for me. Nobody else would have known what it meant, anyway.

I did feel a bit bad about the fact that once we had put Thomas's camp bed up next to Treena's in the box room, there wasn't actually any floor space left, but then I rationalized – they didn't even really live here any more. And the box room was somewhere they were only going to sleep. There was no point in the larger room being empty for weeks on end.

I went to work each day, thinking about other places I could take Will. I didn't have any overall plan, I just focused each day on getting him out and about and trying to keep him happy. There were some days – days when his limbs burnt, or when infection claimed him and he lay miserable and feverish in bed – that were harder than others. But on the good days I had managed several times to get him out into the spring sunshine. I knew now that one of the things Will hated most was the pity of strangers, so I drove him to local beauty spots, where for an hour or so it could be just the two of us. I made picnics and we sat out on the edges of fields, just enjoying the breeze and being away from the annexe.

'My boyfriend wants to meet you,' I told him one afternoon, breaking off pieces of cheese and pickle sandwich for him.

I had driven several miles out of town, up on to a hill, and we could see the castle, across the valley opposite, separated from us by fields of lambs.

‘Why?’

‘He wants to know who I’m spending all these late nights with.’

Oddly, I could see he found this quite cheering.

‘Running Man.’

‘I think my parents do too.’

‘I get nervous when a girl says she wants me to meet her parents. How is your mum, anyway?’

‘The same.’

‘Your dad’s job? Any news?’

‘No. Next week, they’re telling him now. Anyway, they said did I want to invite you to my birthday dinner on Friday? All very relaxed. Just family, really. But it’s fine ... I said you wouldn’t want to.’

‘Who says I wouldn’t want to?’

‘You hate strangers. You don’t like eating in front of people. And you don’t like the sound of my boyfriend. It seems like a no-brainer to me.’

I had worked him out now. The best way to get Will to do anything was to tell him you knew he wouldn’t want to. Some obstinate, contrary part of him still couldn’t bear it.

Will chewed for a minute. ‘No. I’ll come to your birthday. It’ll give your mother something to focus on, if nothing else.’

‘Really? Oh God, if I tell her she’ll start polishing and dusting this evening.’

‘Are you sure she’s your biological mother? Isn’t there supposed to be some kind of genetic similarity there? Sandwich please, Clark. And more pickle on the next bit.’

I had been only half joking. Mum went into a complete tailspin at the thought of hosting a quadriplegic. Her hands flew to her face, and then she started rearranging stuff on the dresser, as if he were going to arrive within minutes of me telling her.

‘But what if he needs to go to the loo? We don’t have a downstairs bathroom. I don’t think Daddy would be able to carry him upstairs. I could help ... but I’d feel a bit worried about where to put my hands. Would Patrick do it?’

‘You don’t need to worry about that side of things. Really.’

‘And what about his food? Will he need his pureed? Is there anything he can’t eat?’

‘No, he just needs help picking it up.’

‘Who’s going to do that?’

‘I will. Relax, Mum. He’s nice. You’ll like him.’

And so it was arranged. Nathan would pick Will up and drive him over, and would come by two hours later to take him home again and run through the night-time routine. I had offered, but they both insisted I should ‘let my hair down’ on my birthday. They plainly hadn’t met my parents.

At half past seven on the dot, I opened the door to find Will and Nathan in the front porch. Will was wearing his smart shirt and jacket. I didn’t know whether to be pleased that he had made the effort, or worried that my mum would now spend the first two hours of the night worrying that she hadn’t dressed smartly enough.

‘Hey, you.’

My dad emerged into the hallway behind me. ‘Aha. Was the ramp okay, lads?’ He had spent all afternoon making the particle-board ramp for the outside steps.

Nathan carefully negotiated Will’s chair up and into our narrow hallway. ‘Nice,’ Nathan said, as I closed the door behind him. ‘Very nice. I’ve seen worse in hospitals.’

‘Bernard Clark.’ Dad reached out and shook Nathan’s hand. He held it out towards Will, before snatching it away again with a sudden flush of embarrassment. ‘Bernard. Sorry, um ... I don’t know how to greet a ... I can’t shake your –’ He began to stutter.

‘A curtsy will be fine.’

Dad stared at him and then, when he realized Will was joking, he let out a great laugh of relief. ‘Hah!’ he said, and clapped Will on the shoulder. ‘Yes. Curtsy. Nice one. Hah!’

It broke the ice. Nathan left with a wave and a wink, and I wheeled Will through to the kitchen. Mum, luckily, was holding a casserole dish, which absolved her of the same anxiety.

‘Mum, this is Will. Will, Josephine.’

‘Josie, please.’ She beamed at him, her oven gloves up to her elbows.

‘Lovely to meet you finally, Will.’

‘Pleased to meet you,’ he said. ‘Don’t let me interrupt.’

She put down the dish and her hand went to her hair, always a good sign with my mother. It was a shame she hadn't remembered to take an oven glove off first.

'Sorry,' she said. 'Roast dinner. It's all in the timing, you know.'

'Not really,' Will said. 'I'm not a cook. But I love good food. It's why I have been looking forward to tonight.'

'So ...' Dad opened the fridge. 'How do we do this? Do you have a special beer ... cup, Will?'

If it was Dad, I told Will, he would have had an adapted beer cup before he had a wheelchair.

'Got to get your priorities right,' Dad said. I rummaged in Will's bag until I found his beaker.

'Beer will be fine. Thank you.'

He took a sip and I stood in the kitchen, suddenly conscious of our tiny, shabby house with its 1980s wallpaper and dented kitchen cupboards. Will's home was elegantly furnished, its things sparse and beautiful. Our house looked as if 90 per cent of its contents came from the local pound shop. Thomas's dog-eared paintings covered every spare surface of wall. But if he had noticed, Will said nothing. He and Dad had quickly found a shared point of reference, which turned out to be my general uselessness. I didn't mind. It kept them both happy.

'Did you know, she once drove backwards into a bollard and swore it was the bollard's fault ...'

'You want to see her lowering my ramp. It's like *Ski Sunday* coming out of that car sometimes ...'

Dad burst out laughing.

I left them to it. Mum followed me out, fretting. She put a tray of glasses on to the dining table, then glanced up at the clock. 'Where's Patrick?'

'He was coming straight from training,' I said. 'Perhaps he's been held up.'

'He couldn't put it off just for your birthday? This chicken is going to be spoilt if he's much longer.'

'Mum, it will be fine.'

I waited until she had put the tray down, and then I slid my arms around her and gave her a hug. She was rigid with anxiety. I felt a sudden wave of sympathy for her. It couldn't be easy being my mother.

'Really. It will be fine.'

She let go of me, kissed the top of my head, and brushed her hands down her apron. 'I wish your sister was here. It seems wrong to have a celebration without her.'

Not to me it didn't. Just for once, I was quite enjoying being the focus of attention. It might sound childish, but it was true. I loved having Will and Dad laughing about me. I loved the fact that every element of supper – from roast chicken to chocolate mousse – was my favourite. I liked the fact that I could be who I wanted to be without my sister's voice reminding me of who I had been.

The doorbell rang, and Mum flapped her hands. 'There he is. Lou, why don't you start serving?'

Patrick was still flushed from his exertions at the track. 'Happy birthday, babe,' he said, stooping to kiss me. He smelt of aftershave and deodorant and warm, recently showered skin.

'Best go straight through.' I nodded towards the living room. 'Mum's having a timing meltdown.'

'Oh.' He glanced down at his watch. 'Sorry. Must have lost track of time.'

'Not *your* time, though, eh?'

'What?'

'Nothing.'

Dad had moved the big gateleg table into the living room. He had also, on my instruction, moved one of the sofas to the other wall so that Will would be able to enter the room unobstructed. He manoeuvred his wheelchair to the placing I pointed to, and then elevated himself a little so that he would be the same height as everyone else. I sat on his left, and Patrick sat opposite. He and Will and Granddad nodded their hellos. I had already warned Patrick not to try to shake his hand. Even as I sat down I could feel Will studying Patrick, and I wondered, briefly, whether he would be as charming to my boyfriend as he had been to my parents.

Will inclined his head towards me. 'If you look in the back of the chair, there's a little something for the dinner.'

I leant back and reached my hand downwards into his bag. I pulled it up again, retrieving a bottle of Laurent-Perrier champagne.

'You should always have champagne on your birthday,' he said.

'Oh, look at that,' Mum said, bringing in the plates. 'How lovely! But we have no champagne glasses.'

‘These will be fine,’ Will said.

‘I’ll open it.’ Patrick reached for it, unwound the wire, and placed his thumbs under the cork. He kept glancing over at Will, as if he were not what he had expected at all.

‘If you do that,’ Will observed, ‘it’s going to go everywhere.’ He lifted his arm an inch or so, gesturing vaguely. ‘I find that holding the cork and turning the bottle tends to be a safer bet.’

‘There’s a man who knows his champagne,’ Dad said. ‘There you go, Patrick. Turning the bottle, you say? Well, who knew?’

‘I knew,’ Patrick said. ‘That’s how I was going to do it.’

The champagne was safely popped and poured, and my birthday was toasted.

Granddad called out something that may well have been, ‘Hear, hear.’

I stood up and bowed. I was wearing a 1960s yellow A-line minidress I had got from the charity shop. The woman had thought it might be Biba, although someone had cut the label out.

‘May this be the year our Lou finally grows up,’ Dad said. ‘I was going to say “does something with her life” but it seems like she finally is. I have to say, Will, since she’s had the job with you she’s – well, she’s really come out of herself.’

‘We’re very proud,’ Mum said. ‘And grateful. To you. For employing her, I mean.’

‘Gratitude’s all mine,’ Will said. He glanced sideways at me.

‘To Lou,’ Dad said. ‘And her continued success.’

‘And to absent family members,’ Mum said.

‘Blimey,’ I said. ‘I should have a birthday more often. Most days you all just hurl abuse at me.’

They began to talk, Dad telling some other story against me that made him and Mum laugh out loud. It was good to see them laughing. Dad had looked so worn down these last weeks, and Mum had been hollow-eyed and distracted, as if her real self were always elsewhere. I wanted to savour these moments, of them briefly forgetting their troubles, in shared jokes and familial fondness. Just for a moment, I realized I wouldn’t have minded if Thomas was there. Or Treena, for that matter.

I was so lost in my thoughts that it took a minute to register Patrick’s expression. I was feeding Will as I said something to Granddad, folding a piece of smoked salmon in my fingers and placing it to Will’s lips. It was

such an unthinking part of my daily life now that the intimacy of the gesture only struck me when I saw the shock on Patrick's face.

Will said something to Dad and I stared at Patrick, willing him to stop. On his left, Granddad was picking at his plate with greedy delight, letting out what we called his 'food noises' – little grunts and murmurs of pleasure.

'Delicious salmon,' Will said, to my mother. 'Really lovely flavour.

'Well, it's not something we would have every day,' she said, smiling.

'But we did want to make today special.'

Stop staring, I told Patrick silently.

Finally, he caught my eye and looked away. He looked furious.

I fed Will another piece, and then some bread when I saw him glance at it. I had, I realized in that moment, become so attuned to Will's needs that I barely needed to look at him to work out what he wanted. Patrick, opposite, ate with his head down, cutting the smoked salmon into small pieces and spearing them with his fork. He left his bread.

'So, Patrick,' Will said, perhaps sensing my discomfort. 'Louisa tells me you're a personal trainer. What does that involve?'

I so wished he hadn't asked. Patrick launched into his sales spiel, all about personal motivation and how a fit body made for a healthy mind. Then he segued into his training schedule for the Xtreme Viking – the temperatures of the North Sea, the body fat ratios needed for marathon running, his best times in each discipline. I normally tuned out at this point, but all I could think of now, with Will beside me, was how inappropriate it was. Why couldn't he have just said something vague and left it at that?

'In fact, when Lou said you were coming, I thought I'd take a look at my books and see if there was any physio I could recommend.'

I choked on my champagne. 'It's quite specialist, Patrick. I'm not sure you'd really be the person.'

'I can do specialist. I do sports injuries. I have medical training.'

'This is not a sprained ankle, Pat. Really.'

'There's a man I worked with a couple of years ago had a client who was paraplegic. He's almost fully recovered now, he says. Does triathlons and everything.'

'Fancy,' said my mother.

'He pointed me to this new research in Canada that says muscles can be trained to remember former activity. If you get them working enough, every day, it's like a brain synapse – it can come back. I bet you if we hooked you

up with a really good regime, you could see a difference in your muscle memory. After all, Lou tells me you were quite the action man before.'

'Patrick,' I said loudly. 'You know nothing about it.'

'I was just trying to –'

'Well *don't*. Really.'

The table fell silent. Dad coughed, and excused himself for it. Granddad peered around the table in wary silence.

Mum made as if to offer everyone more bread, and then seemed to change her mind.

When Patrick spoke again, there was a faint air of martyrdom in his tone. 'It's just research that I thought might be helpful. But I'll say no more about it.'

Will looked up and smiled, his face blank, polite. 'I'll certainly bear it in mind.'

I got up to clear the plates, wanting to escape the table. But Mum scolded me, telling me to sit down.

'You're the birthday girl,' she said – as if she ever let anyone else do anything, anyway. 'Bernard. Why don't you go and get the chicken?'

'Ha-ha. Let's hope it's stopped flapping around now, eh?' Dad smiled, his teeth bared in a kind of grimace.

The rest of the meal passed off without incident. My parents, I could see, were completely charmed by Will. Patrick, less so. He and Will barely exchanged another word. Somewhere around the point where Mum served up the roast potatoes – Dad doing his usual thing of trying to steal extras – I stopped worrying. Dad was asking Will all sorts, about his life before, even about the accident, and he seemed comfortable enough to answer him directly. In fact, I learnt a fair bit that he'd never told me. His job, for example, sounded pretty important, even if he played it down. He bought and sold companies and made sure he turned a profit while doing so. It took Dad a few attempts to prise out of him that his idea of profit ran into six or seven figures. I found myself staring at Will, trying to reconcile the man I knew with this ruthless City suit that he now described. Dad told him about the company that was about to take over the furniture factory, and when he said the name Will nodded almost apologetically, and said that yes, he knew of them. Yes, he would probably have gone for it too. The way he said it didn't sound promising for Dad's job.

Mum just cooed at Will, and made a huge fuss of him. I realized, watching her smile, that at some stage during the meal he had just become a smart young man at her table. No wonder Patrick was pissed off.

‘Birthday cake?’ Granddad said, as she began to clear the dishes.

It was so distinct, so surprising, that Dad and I stared at each other in shock. The whole table went quiet.

‘No,’ I walked around the table and kissed him. ‘No, Granddad. Sorry. But it is chocolate mousse. You like that.’

He nodded in approval. My mother was beaming. I don’t think any of us could have had a better present.

The mousse arrived on the table, and with it a large, square present, about the size of a telephone directory, wrapped in tissue.

‘Presents, is it?’ Patrick said. ‘Here. Here’s mine.’ He smiled at me as he placed it in the middle of the table.

I raised a smile back. This was no time to argue, after all.

‘Go on,’ said Dad. ‘Open it.’

I opened theirs first, peeling the paper carefully away so that I didn’t tear it. It was a photograph album, and on every page there was a picture from a year in my life. Me as a baby; me and Treena as solemn, chubby-faced girls; me on my first day at secondary school, all hairclips and oversized skirt. More recently, there was a picture of me and Patrick, the one where I was actually telling him to piss off. And me, dressed in a grey skirt, my first day in my new job. In between the pages were pictures of our family by Thomas, letters that Mum had kept from school trips, my childish handwriting telling of days on the beach, lost ice creams and thieving gulls. I flicked through, and only hesitated briefly when I saw the girl with the long, dark flicked-back hair. I turned the page.

‘Can I see?’ Will said.

‘It’s not been ... the best year,’ Mum told him, as I flicked through the pages in front of him. ‘I mean, we’re fine and everything. But, you know, things being what they are. And then Granddad saw something on the daytime telly about making your own presents, and I thought that was something that would ... you know ... really mean something.’

‘It does, Mum.’ My eyes had filled with tears. ‘I love it. Thank you.’

‘Granddad picked out some of the pictures,’ she said.

‘It’s beautiful,’ said Will.

‘I love it,’ I said again.

The look of utter relief she and Dad exchanged was the saddest thing I have ever seen.

‘Mine next.’ Patrick pushed the little box across the table. I opened it slowly, feeling vaguely panicked for a moment that it might be an engagement ring. I wasn’t ready. I had barely got my head around having my own bedroom. I opened the little box, and there, against the dark-blue velvet, was a thin gold chain with a little star pendant. It was sweet, delicate, and not remotely me. I didn’t wear that kind of jewellery, never had.

I let my eyes rest on it while I worked out what to say. ‘It’s lovely,’ I said, as he leant across the table and fastened it around my neck.

‘Glad you like it,’ Patrick said, and kissed me on the mouth. I swear he’d never kissed me like that in front of my parents before.

Will watched me, his face impassive.

‘Well, I think we should eat pudding now,’ Dad said. ‘Before it gets too hot.’ He laughed out loud at his own joke. The champagne had boosted his spirits immeasurably.

‘There’s something in my bag for you too,’ Will said, quietly. ‘The one on the back of my chair. It’s in orange wrapping.’

I pulled the present from Will’s backpack.

My mother paused, the serving spoon in her hand. ‘You got Lou a present, Will? That’s ever so kind of you. Isn’t that kind of him, Bernard?’

‘It certainly is.’

The wrapping paper had brightly coloured Chinese kimonos on it. I didn’t have to look at it to know I would save it. Perhaps even create something to wear based on it. I removed the ribbon, putting it to one side for later. I opened the paper, and then the tissue paper within it, and there, staring at me was a strangely familiar black and yellow stripe.

I pulled the fabric from the parcel, and in my hands were two pairs of black and yellow tights. Adult-sized, opaque, in a wool so soft that they almost slid through my fingers.

‘I don’t believe it,’ I said. I had started to laugh – a joyous, unexpected thing. ‘Oh my God! Where did you get these?’

‘I had them made. You’ll be happy to know I instructed the woman via my brand-new voice recognition software.’

‘Tights?’ Dad and Patrick said in unison.

‘Only the best pair of tights ever.’

My mother peered at them. 'You know, Louisa, I'm pretty sure you had a pair just like that when you were very little.'

Will and I exchanged a look.

I couldn't stop beaming. 'I want to put them on now,' I said.

'Jesus Christ, she'll look like Max Wall in a beehive,' my father said, shaking his head.

'Ah Bernard, it's her birthday. Sure, she can wear what she wants.'

I ran outside and pulled on a pair in the hallway. I pointed a toe, admiring the silliness of them. I don't think a present had ever made me so happy in my life.

I walked back in. Will let out a small cheer. Granddad banged his hands on the table. Mum and Dad burst out laughing. Patrick just stared.

'I can't even begin to tell you how much I love these,' I said. 'Thank you. Thank you.' I reached out a hand and touched the back of his shoulder. 'Really.'

'There's a card in there too,' he said. 'Open it some other time.'

My parents made a huge fuss of Will when he left.

Dad, who was drunk, kept thanking him for employing me, and made him promise to come back. 'If I lose my job, maybe I'll come over and watch the footie with you one day,' he said.

'I'd like that,' said Will, even though I'd never seen him watch a football match.

My mum pressed some leftover mousse on him, wrapping it in a Tupperware container, 'Seeing as you liked it so much.'

What a gentleman, they would say, for a good hour after he had gone. A real gentleman.

Patrick came out to the hallway, his hands shoved deep in his pockets, as if perhaps to stop the urge to shake Will's own. That was my more generous conclusion.

'Good to meet you, Patrick,' Will said. 'And thank you for the ... advice.'

'Oh, just trying to help my girlfriend get the best out of her job,' he said. 'That's all.' There was a definite emphasis on the word *my*.

'Well, you're a lucky man,' Will said, as Nathan began to steer him out. 'She certainly gives a good bed bath.' He said it so quickly that the door was closed before Patrick even realized what he had said.

‘You never told me you were giving him bed baths.’

We had gone back to Patrick’s house, a new-build flat on the edge of town. It had been marketed as ‘loft living’, even though it overlooked the retail park, and was no more than three floors high.

‘What does that mean – you wash his dick?’

‘I don’t wash his dick.’ I picked up the cleanser that was one of the few things I was allowed to keep at Patrick’s place, and began to clean off my make-up with sweeping strokes.

‘He just said you did.’

‘He’s teasing you. And after you going on and on about how he *used* to be an action man, I don’t blame him.’

‘So what is it you do for him? You’ve obviously not been giving me the full story.’

‘I do wash him, sometimes, but only down to his underwear.’

Patrick’s stare spoke volumes. Finally, he looked away from me, pulled off his socks and hurled them into the laundry basket. ‘Your job isn’t meant to be about this. No medical stuff, it said. No intimate stuff. It wasn’t part of your job description.’ A sudden thought occurred to him. ‘You could sue. Constructive dismissal, I think it is, when they change the terms of your job?’

‘Don’t be ridiculous. And I do it because Nathan can’t always be there, and it’s horrible for Will to have some complete stranger from an agency handling him. And besides, I’m used to it now. It really doesn’t bother me.’

How could I explain to him – how a body can become so familiar to you? I could change Will’s tubes with a deft professionalism, sponge bathe his naked top half without a break in our conversation. I didn’t even balk at Will’s scars now. For a while, all I had been able to see was a potential suicide. Now he was just Will – maddening, mercurial, clever, funny Will – who patronized me and liked to play Professor Higgins to my Eliza Doolittle. His body was just part of the whole package, a thing to be dealt with, at intervals, before we got back to the talking. It had become, I supposed, the least interesting part of him.

‘I just can’t believe ... after all we went through ... how long it took you to let me come anywhere near you ... and here’s some stranger who you’re quite happy to get up close and personal with –’

‘Can we not talk about this tonight, Patrick? It’s my birthday.’

‘I wasn’t the one who started it, with talk of bed baths and whatnot.’

‘Is it because he’s good looking?’ I demanded. ‘Is that it? Would it all be so much easier for you if he looked like – you know – a *proper* vegetable?’

‘So you *do* think he’s good looking.’

I pulled my dress over my head, and began peeling my tights carefully from my legs, the dregs of my good mood finally evaporating. ‘I can’t believe you’re doing this. I can’t believe you’re jealous of him.’

‘I’m not jealous of him.’ His tone was dismissive. ‘How could I be jealous of a cripple?’

Patrick made love to me that night. Perhaps ‘made love’ is stretching it a bit. We had sex, a marathon session in which he seemed determined to show off his athleticism, his strength and vigour. It lasted for hours. If he could have swung me from a chandelier I think he would have done so. It was nice to feel so wanted, to find myself the focus of Patrick’s attention after months of semi-detachment. But a little part of me stayed aloof during the whole thing. I suspected it wasn’t for me, after all. I had worked that out pretty quickly. This little show was for Will’s benefit.

‘How was that, eh?’ He wrapped himself around me afterwards, our skin sticking slightly with perspiration, and kissed my forehead.

‘Great,’ I said.

‘I love you, babe.’

And, satisfied, he rolled off, threw an arm back over his head, and was asleep within minutes.

When sleep still didn’t come, I got out of bed and went downstairs to my bag. I rifled through it, looking for the book of Flannery O’Connor short stories. It was as I pulled them from my bag that the envelope fell out.

I stared at it. Will’s card. I hadn’t opened it at the table. I did so now, feeling an unlikely sponginess at its centre. I slid the card carefully from its envelope, and opened it. Inside were ten crisp £50 notes. I counted them twice, unable to believe what I was seeing. Inside, it read:

Birthday bonus. Don’t fuss. It’s a legal requirement. W.



14

May was a strange month. The newspapers and television were full of headlines about what they termed ‘the right to die’. A woman suffering from a degenerative disease had asked that the law be clarified to protect her husband, should he accompany her to Dignitas when her suffering became too much. A young football player had committed suicide after persuading his parents to take him there. The police were involved. There was to be a debate in the House of Lords.

I watched the news reports and listened to the legal arguments from pro-lifers and esteemed moral philosophers, and didn’t quite know where I stood on any of it. It all seemed weirdly unrelated to Will.

We, in the meantime, had gradually been increasing Will’s outings – and the distance that he was prepared to travel. We had been to the theatre, down the road to see the morris dancers (Will kept a straight face at their bells and hankies, but he had gone slightly pink with the effort), driven one evening to an open-air concert at a nearby stately home (more his thing than mine), and once to the multiplex where, due to inadequate research on my part, we ended up watching a film about a girl with a terminal illness.

But I knew he saw the headlines too. He had begun using the computer more since we got the new software, and he had worked out how to move a mouse by dragging his thumb across a trackpad. This laborious exercise enabled him to read the day’s newspapers online. I brought him in a cup of tea one morning to find him reading about the young football player – a detailed feature about the steps he had gone through to bring about his own

death. He blanked the screen when he realized I was behind him. That small action left me with a lump somewhere high in my chest that took a full half-hour to go away.

I looked up the same piece at the library. I had begun to read newspapers. I had worked out which of their arguments tended to go deeper – that information wasn't always at its most useful boiled down to stark, skeletal facts.

The football player's parents had been savaged by the tabloid newspapers. *How Could They Let Him Die?* screamed the headlines. I couldn't help but feel the same way. Leo McInerney was twenty-four. He had lived with his injury for almost three years, so not much longer than Will. Surely he was too young to decide that there was nothing left to live for? And then I read what Will had read – not an opinion piece, but a carefully researched feature about what had actually taken place in this young man's life. The writer seemed to have had access to his parents.

Leo, they said, had played football since he was three years old. His whole life was football. He had been injured in what they termed a 'million to one' accident when a tackle went wrong. They had tried everything to encourage him, to give him a sense that his life would still hold value. But he had retreated into depression. He was an athlete not just without athleticism, but without even the ability to move or, on occasion, breathe without assistance. He gleaned no pleasure from anything. His life was painful, disrupted by infection, and dependent on the constant ministrations of others. He missed his friends, but refused to see them. He told his girlfriend he wouldn't see her. He told his parents daily that he didn't want to live. He told them that watching other people live even half the life he had planned for himself was unbearable, a kind of torture.

He had tried to commit suicide twice by starving himself until hospitalized, and when returned home had begged his parents to smother him in his sleep. When I read that, I sat in the library and stuck the balls of my hands in my eyes until I could breathe without sobbing.

Dad lost his job. He was pretty brave about it. He came home that afternoon, got changed into a shirt and tie and headed back into town on the next bus, to register at the Job Centre.

He had already decided, he told Mum, that he would apply for anything, despite being a skilled craftsman with years of experience. 'I don't think we

can afford to be picky at the moment,' he said, ignoring Mum's protestations.

But if I had found it hard to get employment, prospects for a 55-year-old man who had only ever held one job were harder. He couldn't even get a job as a warehouseman or a security guard, he said, despairingly, as he returned home from another round of interviews. They would take some unreliable snot-nosed seventeen-year-old because the government would make up their wages, but they wouldn't take a mature man with a proven work record. After a fortnight of rejections, he and Mum admitted they would have to apply for benefits, just to tide them over, and spent their evenings poring over incomprehensible, fifty-page forms which asked how many people used their washing machine, and when was the last time they had left the country (Dad thought it might have been 1988). I put Will's birthday money into the cash tin in the kitchen cupboard. I thought it might make them feel better to know they had a little security.

When I woke up in the morning, it had been pushed back under my door in an envelope.

The tourists came, and the town began to fill. Mr Traynor was around less and less now; his hours lengthened as the visitor numbers to the castle grew. I saw him in town one Thursday afternoon, when I walked home via the dry cleaner's. That wouldn't have been unusual in itself, except for the fact he had his arm around a red-haired woman who clearly wasn't Mrs Traynor. When he saw me he dropped her like a hot potato.

I turned away, pretending to peer into a shop window, unsure if I wanted him to know that I had seen them, and tried very hard not to think about it again.

On the Friday after my dad lost his job, Will received an invitation – a wedding invitation from Alicia and Rupert. Well, strictly speaking, the invitation came from Colonel and Mrs Timothy Dewar, Alicia's parents, inviting Will to celebrate their daughter's marriage to Rupert Freshwell. It arrived in a heavy parchment envelope with a schedule of celebrations, and a fat, folded list of things that people could buy them from stores I had never even heard of.

'She's got some nerve,' I observed, studying the gilt lettering, the gold-edged piece of thick card. 'Want me to throw it?'

'Whatever you want.' Will's whole body was a study in determined indifference.

I stared at the list. ‘What the hell is a couscoussier anyway?’

Perhaps it was something to do with the speed with which he turned away and began busying himself with his computer keyboard. Perhaps it was his tone of voice. But for some reason I didn’t throw it away. I put it carefully into his folder in the kitchen.

Will gave me another book of short stories, one that he’d ordered from Amazon, and a copy of *The Red Queen*. I knew it wasn’t going to be my sort of book at all. ‘It hasn’t even got a story,’ I said, after studying the back cover.

‘So?’ Will replied. ‘Challenge yourself a bit.’

I tried – not because I really had an appetite for genetics – but because I couldn’t bear the thought that Will would go on and on at me if I didn’t. He was like that now. He was actually a bit of a bully. And, really annoyingly, he would quiz me on how much I had read of something, just to make sure I really had.

‘You’re not my teacher,’ I would grumble.

‘Thank God,’ he would reply, with feeling.

This book – which was actually surprisingly readable – was all about a kind of battle for survival. It claimed that women didn’t pick men because they loved them at all. It said that the female of the species would always go for the strongest male, in order to give her offspring the best chance. She couldn’t help herself. It was just the way nature was.

I didn’t agree with this. And I didn’t like the argument. There was an uncomfortable undercurrent to what he was trying to persuade me of. Will was physically weak, damaged, in this author’s eyes. That made him a biological irrelevance. It would have made his life worthless.

He had been going on and on about this for the best part of an afternoon when I butted in. ‘There’s one thing this Matt Ridley bloke hasn’t factored in,’ I said.

Will looked up from his computer screen. ‘Oh yes?’

‘What if the genetically superior male is actually a bit of a dickhead?’

On the third Saturday of May, Treena and Thomas came home. My mother was out of the door and up the garden path before they had made it halfway down the street. Thomas, she swore, clutching him to her, had grown several inches in the time they had been away. He had changed, was so grown-up, looked so much the little man. Treena had cut off her hair and

looked oddly sophisticated. She was wearing a jacket I hadn't seen before, and strappy sandals. I found myself wondering, meanly, where she had found the money.

'So how is it?' I asked, while Mum walked Thomas around the garden, showing him the frogs in the tiny pond. Dad was watching football with Granddad, exclaiming in mild frustration at another supposed missed opportunity.

'Great. Really good. I mean, it's hard not having any help with Thomas, and it did take him a while to settle in at the crèche.' She leant forwards. 'Although you mustn't tell Mum – I told her he was fine.'

'But you like the course.'

Treena's face broke out into a smile. 'It's the best. I can't tell you, Lou, the joy of just using my brain again. I feel like there's been this big chunk of me missing for ages ... and it's like I've found it again. Does that sound wanky?'

I shook my head. I was actually glad for her. I wanted to tell her about the library, and the computers, and what I had done for Will. But I thought this should probably be her moment. We sat on the foldaway chairs, under the tattered sunshade, and sipped at our mugs of tea. Her fingers, I noticed, were all the right colours.

'She misses you,' I said.

'We'll be back most weekends from now on. I just needed ... Lou, it wasn't just about settling Thomas in. I just needed a bit of time to be away from it all. I just wanted time to be a different person.'

She looked a bit like a different person. It was weird. Just a few weeks away from home could rub the familiarity right off someone. I felt like she was on the path to being someone I wasn't quite sure of. I felt, weirdly, as if I were being left behind.

'Mum told me your disabled bloke came to dinner.'

'He's not my disabled bloke. His name's Will.'

'Sorry. Will. So it's going well, then, the old anti-bucket list?'

'So-so. Some trips have been more successful than others.' I told her about the horse racing disaster, and the unexpected triumph of the violin concert. I told her about our picnics, and she laughed when I told her about my birthday dinner.

'Do you think ... ?' I could see her working out the best way to put it.

'Do you think you'll win?'

Like it was some kind of contest.

I pulled a tendril from the honeysuckle and began picking off its leaves. 'I don't know. I think I'm going to need to up my game.' I told her what Mrs Traynor had said to me about going abroad.

'I can't believe you went to a violin concert, though. You, of all people!' 'I liked it.'

She raised an eyebrow.

'No. Really, I did. It was ... emotional.'

She looked at me carefully. 'Mum says he's really nice.'

'He is really nice.'

'And handsome.'

'A spinal injury doesn't mean you turn into Quasimodo.' *Please don't say anything about it being a tragic waste*, I told her silently.

But perhaps my sister was smarter than that. 'Anyway. She was definitely surprised. I think she was prepared for Quasimodo.'

'That's the problem, Treen,' I said, and threw the rest of my tea into the flower bed. 'People always are.'

Mum was cheerful over supper that night. She had cooked lasagne, Treena's favourite, and Thomas was allowed to stay up as a treat. We ate and talked and laughed and talked about safe things, like the football team, and my job, and what Treena's fellow students were like. Mum must have asked Treena a hundred times if she was sure she was managing okay on her own, whether there was anything she needed for Thomas – as if they had anything spare they could have given her. I was glad I had warned Treena about how broke they were. She said no, gracefully and with conviction. It was only afterwards I thought to ask if it was the truth.

That night I was woken at midnight by the sound of crying. It was Thomas, in the box room. I could hear Treena trying to comfort him, to reassure him, the sound of the light going on and off, a bed being rearranged. I lay in the dark, watching the sodium light filter through my blinds on to my newly painted ceiling, and waited for it to stop. But the same thin wail began again at two. This time, I heard Mum padding across the hallway, and murmured conversation. Then, finally, Thomas was silent again.

At four I woke to the sound of my door creaking open. I blinked groggily, turning towards the light. Thomas stood silhouetted against the

doorway, his oversized pyjamas loose around his legs, his comfort blanket half spooled on the floor. I couldn't see his face, but he stood there uncertainly, as if unsure what to do next.

'Come here, Thomas,' I whispered. As he padded towards me, I could see he was still half asleep. His steps were halting, his thumb thrust into his mouth, his treasured blanket clutched to his side. I held the duvet open and he climbed into bed beside me, his tufty head burrowing into the other pillow, and curled up into a foetal ball. I pulled the duvet over him and lay there, gazing at him, marvelling at the certainty and immediacy of his sleep.

'Night, night, sweetheart,' I whispered, and kissed his forehead, and a fat little hand crept out and took a chunk of my T-shirt in its grasp, as if to reassure itself that I couldn't move away.

'What was the best place you've ever visited?'

We were sitting in the shelter, waiting for a sudden squall to stop so that we could walk around the rear gardens of the castle. Will didn't like going to the main area – too many people to gawp at him. But the vegetable gardens were one of its hidden treasures, visited by few. Its secluded orchards and fruit gardens were separated by honeyed pea-shingle paths that Will's chair could negotiate quite happily.

'In terms of what? And what's that?'

I poured some soup from a flask and held it up to his lips. 'Tomato.'

'Okay. Jesus, that's hot. Give me a minute.' He squinted into the distance. 'I climbed Mount Kilimanjaro when I hit thirty. That was pretty incredible.'

'How high?'

'A little over nineteen thousand feet to Uhuru Peak. That said, I pretty much crawled the last thousand or so. The altitude hits you pretty hard.'

'Was it cold?'

'No ... ' he smiled at me. 'It's not like Everest. Not the time of year that I went, anyway.' He gazed off into the distance, briefly lost in his remembrance. 'It was beautiful. The roof of Africa, they call it. When you're up there, it's like you can actually see to the end of the world.'

Will was silent for a moment. I watched him, wondering where he really was. When we had these conversations he became like the boy in my class, the boy who had distanced himself from us by venturing away.

'So where else have you liked?'

‘Trou d’Eau Douce bay, Mauritius. Lovely people, beautiful beaches, great diving. Um ... Tsavo National Park, Kenya, all red earth and wild animals. Yosemite. That’s California. Rock faces so tall your brain can’t quite process the scale of them.’

He told me of a night he’d spent rock climbing, perched on a ledge several hundred feet up, how he’d had to pin himself into his sleeping bag, and attach it to the rock face, because to roll over in his sleep would have been disastrous.

‘You’ve actually just described my worst nightmare, right there.’

‘I like more metropolitan places too. Sydney, I loved. The Northern Territories. Iceland. There’s a place not far from the airport where you can bathe in the volcanic springs. It’s like a strange, nuclear landscape. Oh, and riding across Central China. I went to this place about two days’ ride from the Capital of Sichuan province, and the locals spat at me because they hadn’t seen a white person before.’

‘Is there anywhere you haven’t been?’

He took another sip of soup. ‘North Korea?’ He pondered. ‘Oh, I’ve never been to Disneyland. Will that do? Not even Eurodisney.’

‘I once booked a ticket to Australia. Never went, though.’

He turned to me in surprise.

‘Stuff happened. It’s fine. Perhaps I will go one day.’

‘Not “perhaps”. You’ve got to get away from here, Clark. Promise me you won’t spend the rest of your life stuck around this bloody parody of a place mat.’

‘Promise me? Why?’ I tried to make my voice light. ‘Where are you going?’

‘I just ... can’t bear the thought of you staying around here forever.’ He swallowed. ‘You’re too bright. Too interesting.’ He looked away from me. ‘You only get one life. It’s actually your duty to live it as fully as possible.’

‘Okay,’ I said, carefully. ‘Then tell me where I should go. Where would you go, if you could go anywhere?’

‘Right now?’

‘Right now. And you’re not allowed to say Kilimanjaro. It has to be somewhere I can imagine going myself.’

When Will’s face relaxed, he looked like someone quite different. A smile settled across his face now, his eyes creasing with pleasure. ‘Paris. I

would sit outside a cafe in Le Marais and drink coffee and eat a plate of warm croissants with unsalted butter and strawberry jam.'

'Le Marais?'

'It's a little district in the centre of Paris. It is full of cobbled streets and teetering apartment blocks and gay men and orthodox Jews and women of a certain age who once looked like Brigitte Bardot. It's the only place to stay.'

I turned to face him, lowering my voice. 'We could go,' I said. 'We could do it on the Eurostar. It would be easy. I don't think we'd even need to ask Nathan to come. I've never been to Paris. I'd love to go. Really love to go. Especially with someone who knows his way around. What do you say, Will?'

I could see myself in that cafe. I was there, at that table, maybe admiring a new pair of French shoes, purchased in a chic little boutique, or picking at a pastry with Parisian red fingernails. I could taste the coffee, smell the smoke from the next table's Gauloises.

'No.'

'What?' It took me a moment to drag myself away from that roadside table.

'No.'

'But you just told me –'

'You don't get it, Clark. I don't want to go there in this – this thing.' He gestured at the chair, his voice dropping. 'I want to be in Paris as *me*, the old me. I want to sit in a chair, leaning back, my favourite clothes on, with pretty French girls who pass by giving me the eye just as they would any other man sitting there. Not looking away hurriedly when they realize I'm a man in an overgrown bloody pram.'

'But we could try,' I ventured. 'It needn't be –'

'No. No, we couldn't. Because at the moment I can shut my eyes and know exactly how it feels to be in the Rue des Francs Bourgeois, cigarette in hand, clementine juice in a tall, cold glass in front of me, the smell of someone's steak frites cooking, the sound of a moped in the distance. I know every sensation of it.'

He swallowed. 'The day we go and I'm in this bloody contraption, all those memories, those sensations will be wiped out, erased by the struggle to get behind the table, up and down Parisian kerbs, the taxi drivers who refuse to take us, and the wheelchair bloody power pack that wouldn't charge in a French socket. Okay?'

His voice had hardened. I screwed the top back on the vacuum flask. I examined my shoes quite carefully as I did it, because I didn't want him to see my face.

'Okay,' I said.

'Okay.' Will took a deep breath.

Below us a coach stopped to disgorge another load of visitors outside the castle gates. We watched in silence as they filed out of the vehicle and into the old fortress in a single, obedient line, primed to stare at the ruins of another age.

It's possible he realized I was a bit subdued, because he leant into me a little. And his face softened. 'So, Clark. The rain seems to have stopped. Where shall we go this afternoon. The maze?'

'No.' It came out more quickly than I would have liked, and I caught the look Will gave me.

'You claustrophobic?'

'Something like that.' I began to gather up our things. 'Let's just go back to the house.'

The following weekend, I came down in the middle of the night to fetch some water. I had been having trouble sleeping, and had found that actually getting up was marginally preferable to lying in my bed battling away the swirling mess of my thoughts.

I didn't like being awake at night. I couldn't help but wonder whether Will was awake, on the other side of the castle, and my imagination kept prising my way into his thoughts. It was a dark place to go to.

Here was the truth of it: I was getting nowhere with him. Time was running out. I couldn't even persuade him to take a trip to Paris. And when he told me why, it was hard for me to argue. He had a good reason for turning down almost every single longer trip I suggested to him. And without telling him why I was so anxious to take him, I had little leverage at all.

I was walking past the living room when I heard the sound – a muffled cough, or perhaps an exclamation. I stopped, retraced my steps and stood in the doorway. I pushed gently at the door. On the living-room floor, the sofa cushions arranged into a sort of haphazard bed, lay my parents, under the guest quilt, their heads level with the gas fire. We stared at each other for a moment in the half-light, my glass motionless in my hand.

‘What – what are you doing there?’

My mother pushed herself up on to her elbow. ‘Ssh. Don’t raise your voice. We ...’ she looked at my father. ‘We fancied a change.’

‘What?’

‘We fancied a change.’ My mother glanced at my father for backup.

‘We’ve given Treena our bed,’ Dad said. He was wearing an old blue T-shirt with a rip in the shoulder, and his hair stuck up on one side. ‘She and Thomas, they weren’t getting on too well in the box room. We said they could have ours.’

‘But you can’t sleep down here! You can’t be comfortable like this.’

‘We’re fine, love,’ Dad said. ‘Really.’

And then, as I stood, dumbly struggling to comprehend, he added, ‘It’s only at weekends. And you can’t sleep in that box room. You need your sleep, what with ...’ He swallowed. ‘What with you being the only one of us at work and all.’

My father, the great lump, couldn’t meet my eye.

‘Go on back to bed now, Lou. Go on. We’re fine.’ Mum practically shooed me away.

I walked back up the stairs, my bare feet silent on the carpet, dimly aware of the brief murmured conversation below.

I hesitated outside Mum and Dad’s room, now hearing what I had not heard before – Thomas’s muffled snoring within. Then I walked slowly back across the landing to my own room, and I closed the door carefully behind me. I lay in my oversized bed and stared out of the window at the sodium lights of the street, until dawn – finally, thankfully – brought me a few precious hours of sleep.

There were seventy-nine days left on my calendar. I started to feel anxious again.

And I wasn’t alone.

Mrs Traynor had waited until Nathan was taking care of Will one lunchtime, then asked me to accompany her to the big house. She sat me down in the living room and asked me how I thought things were.

‘Well, we’re going out a lot more,’ I said.

She nodded, as if in agreement.

‘He talks more than he did.’

‘To you, perhaps.’ She gave a half-laugh that wasn’t really a laugh at all. ‘Have you mentioned going abroad to him?’

‘Not yet. I will. It’s just ... you know what he’s like.’

‘I really don’t mind,’ she said, ‘if you want to go somewhere. I know we probably weren’t the most enthusiastic advocates of your idea, but we’ve been talking a lot, and we both agree ...’

We sat there in silence. She had made me coffee in a cup and saucer. I took a sip of it. It always made me feel about sixty, having a saucer balanced on my lap.

‘So – Will tells me he went to your house.’

‘Yes, it was my birthday. My parents were doing a special dinner.’

‘How was he?’

‘Good. Really good. He was really sweet with my mum.’ I couldn’t help but smile when I thought back to it. ‘I mean, she’s a bit sad because my sister and her son moved out. Mum misses them. I think he ... he just wanted to take her mind off it.’

Mrs Traynor looked surprised. ‘That was ... thoughtful of him.’

‘My mum thought so.’

She stirred at her coffee. ‘I can’t remember the last time Will agreed to have supper with us.’

She probed a little more. Never asking a direct question, of course – that wasn’t her way. But I couldn’t give her the answers she wanted. Some days I thought Will was happier – he went out with me without a fuss, he teased me, prodded me mentally, seemed a little more engaged with the world outside the annexe – but what did I really know? With Will I sensed a vast internal hinterland, a world he wouldn’t give me even a glimpse of. These last couple of weeks I’d had the uncomfortable feeling that hinterland was growing.

‘He seems a little happier,’ she said. It sounded almost as if she were trying to reassure herself.

‘I think so.’

‘It has been very –’ her gaze flickered towards me ‘– rewarding, to see him a little more like his old self. I am very well aware that all these improvements are due to you.’

‘Not all of them.’

‘I couldn’t reach him. I couldn’t get anywhere near him.’ She placed her cup and saucer on her knee. ‘He’s a singular person, Will. From the time he

hit adolescence, I always had to fight the feeling that in his eyes I had somehow done something wrong. I've never been quite sure what it was.' She tried to laugh, but it wasn't really a laugh at all, glancing briefly at me and then looking away.

I pretended to sip my coffee, even though there was nothing in my cup.

'Do you get on well with your mother, Louisa?'

'Yes,' I said, then added, 'it's my sister who drives me nuts.'

Mrs Traynor gazed out of the windows, to where her precious garden had begun to bloom, its blossoms a pale and tasteful melding of pinks, mauves and blues.

'We have just two and a half months.' She spoke without turning her head.

I put my coffee cup on the table. I did it carefully, so that it didn't clatter.

'I'm doing my best, Mrs Traynor.'

'I know, Louisa.' She nodded.

I let myself out.

Leo McInerney died on 22 May, in the anonymous room of a flat in Switzerland, wearing his favourite football shirt, with both his parents at his side. His younger brother refused to come, but issued a statement saying that no one could have been more loved, or more supported than his brother. Leo drank the milky solution of lethal barbiturate at 3.47pm and his parents said that within minutes he was in what appeared to be a deep sleep. He was pronounced dead at a little after four o'clock that afternoon by an observer who had witnessed the whole thing, alongside a video camera there to forestall any suggestion of wrongdoing.

'He looked at peace,' his mother was quoted as saying. 'It's the only thing I can hold on to.'

She and Leo's father had been interviewed three times by police and faced the threat of prosecution. Hate mail had been posted to their house. She looked almost twenty years older than her given age. And yet, there was something else in her expression when she spoke; something that, alongside the grief and the anger and the anxiety and exhaustion, told of a deep, deep relief.

'He finally looked like Leo again.'



15

‘So come on, then, Clark. What exciting events have you got planned for this evening?’

We were in the garden. Nathan was doing Will’s physio, gently moving his knees up and down towards his chest, while Will lay on a blanket, his face turned to the sun, his arms spread out as though he was sunbathing. I sat on the grass alongside them and ate my sandwiches. I rarely went out at lunchtime any more.

‘Why?’

‘Curiosity. I’m interested in how you spend your time when you’re not here.’

‘Well ... tonight it’s a quick bout of advanced martial arts, then a helicopter is flying me to Monte Carlo for supper. And then I might take in a cocktail in Cannes on the way home. If you look up at around – ooh – around 2am, I’ll give you a wave on my way over,’ I said. I peeled the two sides of my sandwich apart, checking the filling. ‘I’m probably finishing my book.’

Will glanced up at Nathan. ‘Tenner,’ he said, grinning.

Nathan reached into his pocket. ‘Every time,’ he said.

I stared at them. ‘Every time what?’ I said, as Nathan put the money into Will’s hand.

‘He said you’d be reading a book. I said you’d be watching telly. He always wins.’

My sandwich stilled at my lips. 'Always? You've been betting on how boring my life is?'

'That's not a word we would use,' Will said. The faintly guilty look in his eyes told me otherwise.

I sat up straight. 'Let me get this straight. You two are betting actual money that on a Friday night I would either be at home reading a book or watching television?'

'No,' said Will. 'I had each way on you seeing Running Man down at the track.'

Nathan released Will's leg. He pulled Will's arm straight and began massaging it from the wrist up.

'What if I said I was actually doing something completely different?'

'But you never do,' Nathan said.

'Actually, I'll have that.' I plucked the tenner from Will's hand. 'Because tonight you're wrong.'

'You said you were going to read your book!' he protested.

'Now I have this,' I said, brandishing the ten-pound note. 'I'll be going to the pictures. So there. Law of unintended consequences, or whatever it is you call it.'

I stood up, pocketed the money, and shoved the remains of my lunch into its brown paper bag. I was smiling as I walked away from them but, weirdly, and for no reason that I could immediately understand, my eyes were prickling with tears.

I had spent an hour working on the calendar before coming to Granta House that morning. Some days I just sat and stared at it from my bed, magic marker in hand, trying to work out what I could take Will to. I wasn't yet convinced that I could get Will to go much further afield, and even with Nathan's help the thought of an overnight visit seemed daunting.

I scanned the local paper, glancing at football matches and village fêtes, but was afraid after the racing debacle that Will's chair might get stuck in the grass. I was concerned that crowds might leave him feeling exposed. I had to rule out all horse-related activities, which in an area like ours meant a surprising amount of outdoor stuff. I knew he wouldn't want to watch Patrick running, and cricket and rugby left him cold. Some days I felt crippled by my own inability to think up new ideas.

Perhaps Will and Nathan were right. Perhaps I was boring. Perhaps I was the least well-equipped person in the world to try to come up with things

that might inflame Will's appetite for life.

A book, or the television.

Put like that, it was hard to believe any differently.

After Nathan left, Will found me in the kitchen. I was sitting at the small table, peeling potatoes for his evening meal, and didn't look up when he positioned his wheelchair in the doorway. He watched me long enough for my ears to turn pink with the scrutiny.

'You know,' I said, finally, 'I could have been horrible to you back there. I could have pointed out that you do nothing either.'

'I'm not sure Nathan would have offered particularly good odds on me going out dancing,' Will said.

'I know it's a joke,' I continued, discarding a long piece of potato peel. 'But you just made me feel really crap. If you were going to bet on my boring life, did you have to make me aware of it? Couldn't you and Nathan just have had it as some kind of private joke?'

He didn't say anything for a bit. When I finally looked up, he was watching me. 'Sorry,' he said.

'You don't look sorry.'

'Well ... okay ... maybe I wanted you to hear it. I wanted you to think about what you're doing.'

'What, how I'm letting my life slip by ... ?'

'Yes, actually.'

'God, Will. I wish you'd stop telling me what to do. What if I like watching television? What if I don't want to do much else other than read a book?' My voice had become shrill. 'What if I'm tired when I get home? What if I don't need to fill my days with frenetic activity?'

'But one day you might wish you had,' he said, quietly. 'Do you know what I would do if I were you?'

I put down my peeler. 'I suspect you're going to tell me.'

'Yes. And I'm completely unembarrassed about telling you. I'd be doing night school. I'd be training as a seamstress or a fashion designer or whatever it is that taps into what you really love.' He gestured at my minidress, a Sixties-inspired Pucci-type dress, made with fabric that had once been a pair of Granddad's curtains.

The first time Dad had seen it he had pointed at me and yelled, 'Hey, Lou, pull yourself together!' It had taken him a full five minutes to stop

laughing.

‘I’d be finding out what I could do that didn’t cost much – keep-fit classes, swimming, volunteering, whatever. I’d be teaching myself music or going for long walks with somebody else’s dog, or –’

‘Okay, okay, I get the message,’ I said, irritably. ‘But I’m not you, Will.’
‘Luckily for you.’

We sat there for a bit. Will wheeled himself in, and raised the height of his chair so that we faced each other over the table.

‘Okay,’ I said. ‘So what did you do after work? That was so valuable?’

‘Well, there wasn’t much time left after work, but I tried to do something every day. I did rock climbing at an indoor centre, and squash, and I went to concerts, and tried new restaurants –’

‘It’s easy to do those things if you have money,’ I protested.

‘And I went running. Yes, really,’ he said, as I raised an eyebrow.

‘And I tried to learn new languages for places I thought I might visit one day. And I saw my friends – or people I thought were my friends ...’ He hesitated for a moment. ‘And I planned trips. I looked for places I’d never been, things that would frighten me or push me to my limit. I swam the Channel once. I went paragliding. I walked up mountains and skied down them again. Yes –’ he said, as I made to interrupt ‘– I know a lot of these need money, but a lot of them don’t. And besides, how do you think I made money?’

‘Ripping people off in the City?’

‘I worked out what would make me happy, and I worked out what I wanted to do, and I trained myself to do the job that would make those two things happen.’

‘You make it sound so simple.’

‘It is simple,’ he said. ‘The thing is, it’s also a lot of hard work. And people don’t want to put in a lot of work.’

I had finished the potatoes. I threw the peel into the bin, and put the pan on to the stove ready for later. I turned and lifted myself on my arms so that I was sitting on the table facing him, my legs dangling.

‘You had a big life, didn’t you?’

‘Yeah, I did.’ He moved a bit closer, and raised his chair so that he was almost at eye level. ‘That’s why you piss me off, Clark. Because I see all this talent, all this ...’ He shrugged. ‘This energy and brightness, and –’

‘Don’t say potential ...’

‘... potential. Yes. Potential. And I cannot for the life of me see how you can be content to live this tiny life. This life that will take place almost entirely within a five-mile radius and contain nobody who will ever surprise you or push you or show you things that will leave your head spinning and unable to sleep at night.’

‘This is your way of telling me I should be doing something far more worthwhile than peeling your potatoes.’

‘I’m telling you there’s a whole world out there. But that I’d be very grateful if you’d do me some potatoes first.’ He smiled at me, and I couldn’t help but smile back.

‘Don’t you think –’ I started, and then broke off.

‘Go on.’

‘Don’t you think it’s actually harder for you ... to adapt, I mean? Because you’ve done all that stuff?’

‘Are you asking me if I wish I’d never done it?’

‘I’m just wondering if it would have been easier for you. If you’d led a smaller life. To live like this, I mean.’

‘I will never, ever regret the things I’ve done. Because most days, if you’re stuck in one of these, all you have are the places in your memory that you can go to.’ He smiled. It was tight, as if it cost him. ‘So if you’re asking me would I rather be reminiscing about the view of the castle from the minimart, or that lovely row of shops down off the roundabout, then, no. My life was just fine, thanks.’

I slid off the table. I wasn’t entirely sure how, but I felt, yet again, like I’d somehow been argued into a corner. I reached for the chopping board on the drainer.

‘And Lou, I’m sorry. About the money thing.’

‘Yeah. Well.’ I turned, and began rinsing the chopping board under the sink. ‘Don’t think that’s going to get you your tenner back.’

Two days later Will ended up in hospital with an infection. A precautionary measure, they called it, although it was obvious to everyone that he was in a lot of pain. Some quadriplegics had no sensation but, while he was impervious to temperature, below his chest Will could feel both pain and touch. I went in to see him twice, bringing him music and nice things to eat, and offering to keep him company, but peculiarly I felt in the way, and

realized quite quickly that Will didn't actually want the extra attention in there. He told me to go home and enjoy some time to myself.

A year previously, I would have wasted those free days; I would have trawled the shops, maybe gone over to meet Patrick for lunch. I would probably have watched some daytime television, and maybe made a vague attempt to sort out my clothes. I might have slept a lot.

Now, however, I felt oddly restless and dislocated. I missed having a reason to get up early, a purpose to my day.

It took me half a morning to work out that this time could be useful. I went to the library and began to research. I looked up every website about quadriplegics that I could find, and worked out things we could do when Will was better. I wrote lists, adding to each entry the equipment or things I might need to consider for each event.

I discovered chat rooms for those with spinal injuries, and found there were thousands of men and women out there just like Will – leading hidden lives in London, Sydney, Vancouver, or just down the road – aided by friends or family, or sometimes, heartbreakingly alone.

I wasn't the only carer interested in these sites. There were girlfriends, asking how they could help their partners gain the confidence to go out again, husbands seeking advice on the latest medical equipment. There were advertisements for wheelchairs that would go on sand or off-road, clever hoists or inflatable bathing aids.

There were codes to their discussions. I worked out that SCI was a spinal cord injury, AB the able-bodied, a UTI an infection. I saw that a C4/5 spinal injury was far more severe than a C11/12, most of whom still seemed to have use of their arms or torso. There were stories of love and loss, of partners struggling to cope with disabled spouses as well as young children. There were wives who felt guilty that they had prayed their husbands would stop beating them – and then found they never would again. There were husbands who wanted to leave disabled wives but were afraid of the reaction of their community. There was exhaustion and despair, and a lot of black humour – jokes about exploding catheter bags, other people's well-meaning idiocy, or drunken misadventures. Falling out of chairs seemed to be a common theme. And there were threads about suicide – those who wanted to, those who encouraged them to give themselves more time, to learn to look at their lives in a different way. I read each thread, and felt like I was getting a secret insight into the workings of Will's brain.

At lunchtime I left the library and went for a brief walk around town to clear my head. I treated myself to a prawn sandwich and sat on the wall watching the swans in the lake below the castle. It was warm enough for me to take off my jacket, and I let my face tilt towards the sun. There was something curiously restful about watching the rest of the world getting on with its business. After spending all morning stuck in the world of the confined, just being able to walk out and eat my lunch in the sun felt like a freedom.

When I had finished, I walked back to the library, reclaimed my computer terminal. And I took a breath and typed a message.

Hi – I am the friend/carer of a 35 yo C5/6 quadriplegic. He was very successful and dynamic in his former life and is having trouble adjusting to his new one. In fact, I know that he does not want to live, and I am trying to think of ways of changing his mind. Please could anyone tell me how I could do this? Any ideas for things he might enjoy, or ways I could get him to think differently? All advice gratefully received.

I called myself Busy Bee. Then I sat back in my chair, chewed at my thumbnail for a bit, and finally pressed ‘Send’.

When I sat down at the terminal the next morning, I had fourteen answers. I logged into the chat room, and blinked as I saw the list of names, the responses which had come from people worldwide, throughout the day and night. The first one said:

Dear Busy Bee,

Welcome to our board. I’m sure your friend will gain a lot of comfort from having someone looking out for him.

I’m not so sure about that, I thought.

Most of us on here have hit a definite hump at some point in our lives. It may be that your friend has hit his. Don’t let him push you away. Stay positive. And remind him that it is not his place to decide both when we enter and depart this world, but that of the Lord. He decided to change your friend’s life, in His own wisdom and there may be a lesson in it that He –

I scanned down to the next one.

Dear Bee,

There is no way around it, being a quad can suck. If your guy was a bit of a player too, then he is going to find it extra hard. These are the things that helped me. A lot of company, even when I didn’t feel like it. Good food. Good docs. Good meds, depression meds when necessary. You didn’t say where you were based, but if you can get him talking to others in the SCI community it may help. I was pretty reluctant at first (I think

some part of me didn't want to admit I was actually a quad) but it does help to know you're not alone out there.

Oh, and DON'T let him watch any films like *The Diving Bell and the Butterfly*. Major downer!

Let us know how you get on.

All best,

Ritchie

I looked up *The Diving Bell and the Butterfly*. 'The story of a man who suffers a paralysing stroke, and his attempts to communicate with the outside world,' it said. I wrote the title down on my pad, uncertain whether I was doing so to make sure Will avoided it, or so I remembered to watch it.

The next two answers were from a Seventh-day Adventist, and a man whose suggested ways in which I could cheer Will up were certainly not covered by my working contract. I flushed and hurriedly scrolled down, afraid that someone might glance at the screen from behind me. And then I hesitated on the next reply.

Hi Busy Bee,

Why do you think your friend/charge/whatever needs his mind changing? If I could work out a way of dying with dignity, and if I didn't know it would devastate my family, I would take it. I have been stuck in this chair eight years now, and my life is a constant round of humiliations and frustrations. Can you really put yourself in his shoes? Do you know how it feels to not even be able to empty your bowels without help? To know that forever after you are going to be stuck in your bed/unable to eat, dress, communicate with the outside world without someone to help you? To never have sex again? To face the prospect of sores, and ill health and even ventilators? You sound like a nice person, and I'm sure you mean well. But it may not be you looking after him next week. It may be someone who depresses him, or even doesn't like him very much. That, like everything else, is out of his control. We SCIs know that very little is under our control – who feeds us, dresses us, washes us, dictates our medication. Living with that knowledge is very hard.

So I think you are asking the wrong question. Who are the AB to decide what our lives should be? If this is the wrong life for your friend, shouldn't the question be: How do I help him to end it?

Best wishes,

Gforce, Missouri, US

I stared at the message, my fingers briefly stilled on the keyboard. Then I scrolled down. The next few were from other quadriplegics, criticizing Gforce for his bleak words, protesting that they had found a way forward, that theirs was a life worth living. There was a brief argument going on that seemed to have little to do with Will at all.

And then the thread dragged itself back to my request. There were suggestions of antidepressants, massage, miracle recoveries, stories of how members' own lives had been given new value. There were a few practical suggestions: wine tasting, music, art, specially adapted keyboards.

'A partner,' said Grace31 from Birmingham. 'If he has love, he will feel he can go on. Without it, I would have sunk many times over.'

That phrase echoed in my head long after I had left the library.

Will came out of hospital on Thursday. I picked him up in the adapted car, and brought him home. He was pale and exhausted, and stared out of the window listlessly for the whole journey.

'No sleep in these places,' he explained, when I asked him if he was okay. 'There's always someone moaning in the next bed.'

I told him he would have the weekend to recover, but after that I had a series of outings planned. I told him I was taking his advice and trying new things, and he would have to come with me. It was a subtle change in emphasis, but I knew that was the only way I could get him to accompany me.

In fact, I had devised a detailed schedule for the next couple of weeks. Each event was carefully marked on my calendar in black, with red pen outlining the precautions I should take, and green for the accessories I would need. Every time I looked at the back of my door I felt a little glimmer of excitement, both that I had been so organized, but also that one of these events might actually be the thing that changed Will's view of the world.

As my Dad always says, my sister is the brains of our family.

The art gallery trip lasted a shade under twenty minutes. And that included driving round the block three times in search of a suitable parking space. We got there, and almost before I had closed the door behind him he said all the work was terrible. I asked him why and he said if I couldn't see it he couldn't explain it. The cinema had to be abandoned after the staff told us, apologetically, that their lift was out of order. Others, such as the failed attempt to go swimming, required more time and organization – the ringing of the swimming pool beforehand, the booking of Nathan for overtime, and then, when we got there, the flask of hot chocolate drunk in silence in the leisure centre car park when Will resolutely refused to go in.

The following Wednesday evening, we went to hear a singer he had once seen live in New York. That was a good trip. When he listened to music he wore an expression of intense concentration. Most of the time, it was as if Will were not wholly present, as if there were some part of him struggling with pain, or memories, or dark thoughts. But with music it was different.

And then the following day I took him to a wine tasting, part of a promotional event held by a vineyard in a specialist wine shop. I had to promise Nathan I wouldn't get him drunk. I held up each glass for Will to sniff, and he knew what it was even before he'd tasted it. I tried quite hard not to snort when Will spat it into the beaker (it did look really funny), and he looked at me from under his brows and said I was a complete child. The shop owner went from being weirdly disconcerted by having a man in a wheelchair in his shop to quite impressed. As the afternoon went on, he sat down and started opening other bottles, discussing region and grape with Will, while I wandered up and down looking at the labels, becoming, frankly, a little bored.

'Come on, Clark. Get an education,' he said, nodding at me to sit down beside him.

'I can't. My mum told me it was rude to spit.'

The two men looked at each other as if I were the mad one. And yet he didn't spit every time. I watched him. And he was suspiciously talkative for the rest of the afternoon – swift to laugh, and even more combative than usual.

And then, on the way home, we were driving through a town we didn't normally go to and, as we sat, motionless, in traffic, I glanced over and saw the Tattoo and Piercing Parlour.

'I always quite fancied a tattoo,' I said.

I should have known afterwards that you couldn't just say stuff like that in Will's presence. He didn't do small talk, or shooting the breeze. He immediately wanted to know why I hadn't had one.

'Oh ... I don't know. The thought of what everyone would say, I guess.'

'Why? What would they say?'

'My dad hates them.'

'How old are you again?'

'Patrick hates them too.'

'And he *never* does anything that you might not like.'

'I might get claustrophobic. I might change my mind once it was done.'

‘Then you get it removed by laser, surely?’

I looked at him in my rear-view mirror. His eyes were merry.

‘Come on, then,’ he said. ‘What would you have?’

I realized I was smiling. ‘I don’t know. Not a snake. Or anyone’s name.’

‘I wasn’t expecting a heart with a banner saying “mother”.’

‘You promise not to laugh?’

‘You know I can’t do that. Oh God, you’re not going to have some Indian Sanskrit proverb or something, are you? *What doesn’t kill me makes me stronger.*’

‘No. I’d have a bee. A little black and yellow bee. I love them.’

He nodded, as if that were a perfectly reasonable thing to want. ‘And where would you have it? Or daren’t I ask?’

I shrugged. ‘Dunno. My shoulder? Lower hip?’

‘Pull over,’ he said.

‘Why, are you okay?’

‘Just pull over. There’s a space there. Look, on your left.’

I pulled the car into the kerb and glanced back at him. ‘Go on, then,’ he said. ‘We’ve got nothing else on today.’

‘Go on where?’

‘To the tattoo parlour.’

I started to laugh. ‘Yeah. Right.’

‘Why not?’

‘You *have* been swallowing instead of spitting.’

‘You haven’t answered my question.’

I turned in my seat. He was serious.

‘I can’t just go and get a tattoo. Just like that.’

‘Why not?’

‘Because ...’

‘Because your boyfriend says no. Because you still have to be a good girl, even at twenty-seven. Because it’s *too scary*. C’mon, Clark. Live a little. What’s stopping you?’

I stared down the road at the tattoo parlour frontage. The slightly grimy window bore a large neon heart, and some framed photographs of Angelina Jolie and Mickey Rourke.

Will’s voice broke into my calculations. ‘Okay. I will, if you will.’

I turned back to him. ‘You’d get a tattoo?’

‘If it persuaded you, just once, to climb out of your little box.’

I switched off the engine. We sat, listening to it tick its way down, the dull murmur of the cars queuing along the road beside us.

‘It’s quite permanent.’

‘No “quite” about it.’

‘Patrick will hate it.’

‘So you keep saying.’

‘And we’ll probably get hepatitis from dirty needles. And die slow, horrible, painful deaths.’ I turned to Will. ‘They probably wouldn’t be able to do it now. Not actually right now.’

‘Probably not. But shall we just go and check?’

Two hours later we exited the tattoo parlour, me eighty pounds lighter and bearing a surgical patch over my hip where the ink was still drying. Its relatively small size, the tattoo artist said, meant that I could have it lined and coloured in one visit, so there I was. Finished. Tattooed. Or, as Patrick would no doubt say, scarred for life. Under that white dressing sat a fat little bumblebee, culled from the laminated ring binder of images that the tattoo artist had handed us when we walked in. I felt almost hysterical with excitement. I kept reaching around to peek at it until Will told me to stop, or I was going to dislocate something.

Will had been relaxed and happy in there, oddly enough. They had not given him a second look. They had done a few quads, they said, which explained the ease with which they had handled him. They were surprised when Will said he could feel the needle. Six weeks earlier they had finished inking a paraplegic who had had trompe l’oeil bionics inked the whole way down one side of his leg.

The tattooist with the bolt through his ear had taken Will into the next room and, with my tattooist’s help, laid him down on a special table so that all I could see through the open door were his lower legs. I could hear the two men murmuring and laughing over the buzz of the tattooing needle, the smell of antiseptic sharp in my nostrils.

When the needle first bit into my skin, I chewed my lip, determined not to let Will hear me squeal. I kept my mind on what he was doing next door, trying to eavesdrop on his conversation, wondering what it was he was having done. When he finally emerged, after my own had been finished, he refused to let me see. I suspected it might be something to do with Alicia.

‘You’re a bad bloody influence on me, Will Traynor,’ I said, opening the car door and lowering the ramp. I couldn’t stop grinning.

‘Show me.’

I glanced down the street, then turned and peeled a little of the dressing down from my hip.

‘It’s great. I like your little bee. Really.’

‘I’m going to have to wear high-waisted trousers around my parents for the rest of my life.’ I helped him steer his chair on to the ramp and raised it.

‘Mind you, if your mum gets to hear you’ve had one too ... ’

‘I’m going to tell her the girl from the council estate led me astray.’

‘Okay then, Traynor, you show me yours.’

He gazed at me steadily, half smiling. ‘You’ll have to put a new dressing on it when we get home.’

‘Yeah. Like that never happens. Go on. I’m not driving off until you do.’

‘Lift my shirt, then. To the right. Your right.’

I leant through the front seats, and tugged at his shirt, peeling back the piece of gauze beneath. There, dark against his pale skin was a black and white striped ink rectangle, small enough that I had to look twice before I realized what it said.

Best before: 19 March 2007

I stared at it. I half laughed, and then my eyes filled with tears. ‘Is that the —’

‘Date of my accident. Yes.’ He raised his eyes to the heavens. ‘Oh, for Christ’s sake, don’t get maudlin, Clark. It was meant to be funny.’

‘It is funny. In a crappy sort of way.’

‘Nathan will enjoy it. Oh, come on, don’t look like that. It’s not as if I’m ruining my perfect body, is it?’

I pulled Will’s shirt back down and then I turned and fired up the ignition. I didn’t know what to say. I didn’t know what any of this meant. Was this him coming to terms with his state? Or just another way of showing his contempt for his own body?

‘Hey, Clark, do me a favour,’ he said, just as I was about to pull away.

‘Reach into the backpack for me. The zipped pocket.’

I glanced into the rear-view mirror, and put the handbrake on again. I leant through the front seats and put my hand in the bag, rummaging around according to his instructions.

‘You want painkillers?’ I was inches from his face. He had more colour in his skin than at any time since he came back from hospital. ‘I’ve got some in my –’

‘No. Keep looking.’

I pulled out a piece of paper and sat back. It was a folded ten-pound note.

‘There you go. The emergency tenner.’

‘So?’

‘It’s yours.’

‘For what?’

‘That tattoo.’ He grinned at me. ‘Right up until you were in that chair, I didn’t think for a minute you were going to actually do it.’



16

There was no way around it. The sleeping arrangements just weren't working. Every weekend that Treena came home, the Clark family began a lengthy, nocturnal game of musical beds. After supper on Friday night Mum and Dad would offer up their bedroom, and Treena would accept it, after they had reassured her that no, they were not in the least bit put out, and how much better Thomas was at sleeping in a room he knew. It would mean, they said, that everyone got a good night's sleep.

But Mum sleeping downstairs also involved her and Dad needing their own quilt, their own pillows and even under-sheet, as Mum couldn't sleep properly unless her bed was just as she liked it. So after supper she and Treena would strip Mum and Dad's bed and put on a new set of sheets, together with a mattress protector, just in case Thomas had an accident. Mum and Dad's bedding, meanwhile, would be folded and placed in the corner of the living room, where Thomas would dive into it and on to it and string the sheet across the dining chairs to turn it into a tent.

Granddad offered his room, but nobody took it. It smelt of yellowing copies of the *Racing Post* and Old Holborn, and it would have taken all weekend to clear out. I would alternately feel guilty – all this was my fault, after all – while knowing I would not offer to return to the box room. It had become a kind of spectre for me, that airless little room with no windows. The thought of sleeping in there again made my chest feel tight. I was twenty-seven years old. I was the main earner of the family. I could not sleep in what was essentially a cupboard.

One weekend I offered to sleep at Patrick's, and everyone looked secretly relieved. But then, while I was away, Thomas put sticky fingers all over my new blinds and drew on my new duvet cover in permanent pen, at which point Mum and Dad decided it would be best if *they* slept in my room, while Treena and Thomas went into theirs, where the odd bit of felt tip apparently didn't matter.

Once you had accounted for all the extra bed stripping and laundry, me spending Friday and Saturday nights at Pat's, Mum admitted, wasn't actually much help at all.

And then there was Patrick. Patrick was now a man obsessed. He ate, drank, lived and breathed the Xtreme Viking. His flat, normally sparsely furnished and immaculate, was strung with training schedules and dietary sheets. He had a new lightweight bike which lived in the hallway and which I wasn't allowed to touch, in case I interfered with its finely balanced lightweight racing capabilities.

And he was rarely home, even on a Friday or Saturday night. What with his training and my work hours we seemed to have become used to spending less time together. I could follow him down to the track and watch him push himself round and round in circles until he had completed the requisite number of miles, or I could stay home and watch television by myself, curled up in a corner of his vast leather settee. There was no food in the fridge, apart from strips of turkey breast and vile energy drinks the consistency of frogspawn. Treena and I had tried one once and spat it out, gagging theatrically, like children.

The truth of it was I didn't like Patrick's flat. He had bought it a year ago, when he finally felt his mother would be okay by herself. His business had done well, and he had told me it was important that one of us get on to the property ladder. I suppose that would have been the cue for us to have a conversation about whether we were going to live together, but somehow it didn't happen, and neither of us is the type to bring up subjects that make us feel a bit uncomfortable. As a result, there was nothing of me in that flat, despite our years together. I had never quite been able to tell him, but I would rather live in my house, with all its noise and clutter, than in that soulless, featureless bachelor pad, with its allocated parking spaces and executive view of the castle.

And besides, it was a bit lonely.

‘Got to stick to the schedule, babe,’ he would say, if I told him. ‘If I do any fewer than twenty-three miles at this stage of the game, I’ll never make it back on schedule.’ Then he would give me the latest update on his shin splints or ask me to pass him the heat spray.

When he wasn’t training, he was at endless meetings with other members of his team, comparing kit and finalizing travel arrangements. Sitting amongst them was like being with a bunch of Korean speakers. I had no idea what any of it meant, and no great desire to immerse myself.

And I was supposed to be going with them to Norway in seven weeks’ time. I hadn’t yet worked out how to tell Patrick that I hadn’t asked the Traynors for the time off. How could I? By the time the Xtreme Viking took place, there would be less than one week of my contract left to run. I suppose I was childishly refusing to deal with it all, but truthfully, all I could see was Will and a ticking clock. Not a lot else seemed to register.

The great irony of all this was that I didn’t even sleep well at Patrick’s flat. I don’t know what it was, but I came to work from there feeling like I was speaking through a glass jar, and looking like I had been punched in both eyes. I began painting concealer on my dark shadows with the same slapdash abandon as if I were decorating.

‘What’s going on, Clark?’ Will said.

I opened my eyes. He was right beside me, his head cocked to one side, watching me. I got the feeling he might have been there for some time. My hand went automatically for my mouth in case I had been dribbling.

The film I was supposed to have been watching was now a series of slow-moving credits.

‘Nothing. Sorry. It’s just warm in here.’ I pushed myself upright.

‘It’s the second time you’ve fallen asleep in three days.’ He studied my face. ‘And you look bloody awful.’

So I told him. I told him about my sister, and our sleeping arrangements, and how I didn’t want to make a fuss because every time I looked at Dad’s face I saw his barely concealed despair that he could not even provide his family with a house we could all sleep in.

‘He’s still not found anything?’

‘No. I think it’s his age. But we don’t talk about it. It’s ... ’ I shrugged. ‘It’s too uncomfortable for everyone.’

We waited for the movie to finish, and then I walked over to the player, ejected the DVD and put it back in its case. It felt somehow wrong, telling Will my problems. They seemed embarrassingly trivial next to his.

‘I’ll get used to it,’ I said. ‘It’ll be fine. Really.’

Will seemed preoccupied for the rest of the afternoon. I washed up, then came through and set up his computer for him. When I brought him a drink, he swivelled his chair towards me.

‘It’s quite simple,’ he said, as if we had been in conversation. ‘You can sleep here at weekends. There’s a room going spare – it might as well get some use.’

I stopped, the beaker in my hand. ‘I can’t do that.’

‘Why not? I’m not going to pay you for the extra hours you’re here.’

I placed the beaker in his holder. ‘But what would your mum think?’

‘I have no idea.’

I must have looked troubled, because he added, ‘It’s okay. I’m safe in taxis.’

‘What?’

‘If you’re worried I have some devious secret plan to seduce you, you can just pull my plug out.’

‘Funny.’

‘Seriously. Think about it. You could have it as your backup option. Things might change faster than you think. Your sister might decide she doesn’t want to spend every weekend at home after all. Or she might meet someone. A million things might change.’

And you might not be here in two months, I told him silently, and immediately hated myself for thinking it.

‘Tell me something,’ he said, as he went to leave the room. ‘Why isn’t Running Man offering you his place?’

‘Oh, he has,’ I said.

He looked at me, as if he were about to pursue the conversation.

And then he seemed to change his mind. ‘Like I said.’ He shrugged. ‘The offer’s there.’

These are the things that Will liked.

1. Watching films, especially foreign ones with subtitles. He could occasionally be persuaded into an action thriller, even an epic

romance, but drew the line at romantic comedies. If I dared to rent one, he would spend the entire 120 minutes letting out little *pffts* of derision, or pointing out the great clichés in the plot, until it was no fun for me at all.

2. Listening to classical music. He knew an awful lot about it. He also liked some modern stuff, but said jazz was mostly pretentious guff. When he saw the contents of my MP3 player one afternoon, he laughed so hard he nearly dislodged one of his tubes.
3. Sitting in the garden, now that it was warm. Sometimes I stood in the window and watched him, his head tilted back, just enjoying the sun on his face. When I remarked on his ability to be still and just enjoy the moment – something I had never mastered – he pointed out that if you can't move your arms and legs, you haven't actually got a lot of choice.
4. Making me read books or magazines, and then talk about them. *Knowledge is power, Clark*, he would say. I hated this at first; it felt like I was at school, being quizzed on my powers of memory. But after a while I realized that, in Will's eyes, there were no wrong answers. He actually liked me to argue with him. He asked me what I thought of things in the newspapers, disagreed with me about characters in books. He seemed to hold opinions on almost everything – what the government was doing, whether one business should buy another, whether someone should have been sent to jail. If he thought I was being lazy, or parroting my parents' or Patrick's ideas, he would just say a flat, 'No. Not good enough.' He would look so disappointed if I said I knew nothing about it; I had begun to anticipate him and now read a newspaper on the bus on the way in, just so I felt prepared. 'Good point, Clark,' he would say, and I would find myself beaming. And then give myself a kick for allowing Will to patronize me again.
5. Getting a shave. Every two days now, I lathered up his jaw and made him presentable. If he wasn't having a bad day, he would

lean back in his chair, close his eyes, and the closest thing I saw to physical pleasure would spread across his face. Perhaps I've invented that. Perhaps I saw what I wanted to see. But he would be completely silent as I gently ran the blade across his chin, smoothing and scraping, and when he did open his eyes his expression had softened, like someone coming out of a particularly satisfactory sleep. His face now held some colour from our time spent outside; his was the kind of skin that tanned easily. I kept the razors high up in the bathroom cabinet, tucked behind a large bottle of conditioner.

6. Being a bloke. Especially with Nathan. Occasionally, before the evening routine, they would go and sit at the end of the garden and Nathan would crack open a couple of beers. Sometimes I heard them discussing rugby, or joking about some woman they had seen on the television, and it wouldn't sound like Will at all. But I understood he needed this; he needed someone with whom he could just be a bloke, doing blokey things. It was a small bit of 'normal' in his strange, separate life.
7. Commenting on my wardrobe. Actually, that should be raising an eyebrow at my wardrobe. Except for the black and yellow tights. On the two occasions I had worn those he hadn't said anything, but simply nodded, as if something were right with the world.

'You saw my dad in town the other day.'

'Oh. Yes.' I was hanging washing out on a line. The line itself was hidden in what Mrs Traynor called the Kitchen Garden. I think she didn't want anything as mundane as laundry polluting the view of her herbaceous borders. My own mother pegged her whites out almost as a badge of pride. It was like a challenge to her neighbours: *Beat this, ladies!* It was all Dad could do to stop her putting a second revolving clothes dryer out the front.

'He asked me if you'd said anything about it.'

'Oh.' I kept my face a studied blank. And then, because he seemed to be waiting, 'Evidently not.'

'Was he with someone?'

I put the last peg back in the peg bag. I rolled it up, and placed it in the empty laundry basket. I turned to him.

‘Yes.’

‘A woman.’

‘Yes.’

‘Red-haired?’

‘Yes.’

Will thought about this for a minute.

‘I’m sorry if you think I should have told you,’ I said. ‘But it ... it didn’t seem like my business.’

‘And it’s never an easy conversation to have.’

‘No.’

‘If it’s any consolation, Clark, it’s not the first time,’ he said, and headed back into the house.

Deirdre Bellows said my name twice before I looked up. I was scribbling in my notepad, place names and question marks, pros and cons, and I had pretty much forgotten I was even on a bus. I was trying to work out a way of getting Will to the theatre. There was only one within two hours’ drive, and it was showing *Oklahoma!* It was hard to imagine Will nodding along to ‘Oh What A Beautiful Morning’, but all the serious theatre was in London. And London still seemed like an impossibility.

Basically, I could now get Will out of the house, but we had pretty much reached the end of what was available within an hour’s radius, and I had no idea how to get him to go further.

‘In your own little world, eh, Louisa?’

‘Oh. Hi, Deirdre.’ I scooped over on the seat to make room for her.

Deirdre had been friends with Mum since they were girls. She owned a soft-furnishings shop and had been divorced three times. She possessed hair thick enough to be a wig, and a fleshy, sad face that looked like she was still dreaming wistfully of the white knight who would come and sweep her away.

‘I don’t normally get the bus but my car’s in for a service. How are you? Your mum told me all about your job. Sounds *very* interesting.’

This is the thing about growing up in a small town. Every part of your life is up for grabs. Nothing is secret – not the time I was caught smoking at the out-of-town supermarket car park when I was fourteen, nor the fact that

my father had re-tiled the downstairs loo. The minutiae of everyday lives were currency for women like Deirdre.

‘It’s good, yes.’

‘And well paid.’

‘Yes.’

‘I was so relieved for you after the whole Buttered Bun thing. Such a shame they shut the cafe. We’re losing all the useful shops in this town. I remember when we had a grocer, a baker and a butcher on the high street. All we needed was a candlestick maker!’

‘Mmm.’ I saw her glance at my list and closed my notepad. ‘Still. At least we do have somewhere to buy curtains. How’s the shop?’

‘Oh, fine ... yes ... What’s that, then? Something to do with work?’

‘I’m just working on things that Will might like to do.’

‘Is that your disabled man?’

‘Yes. My boss.’

‘Your boss. That’s a nice way of putting it.’ She nudged me. ‘And how’s your clever old sister getting on at university?’

‘She’s good. And Thomas.’

‘She’ll end up running the country, that one. I have to say, though, Louisa, I was always surprised you didn’t leave before her. We always thought you were such a bright little thing. Not that we still don’t, of course.’

I raised a polite smile. I wasn’t sure what else I could do.

‘But still. Someone’s got to do it, eh? And it’s nice for your mum that one of you is happy to stay so close to home.’

I wanted to contradict her, and then I realized that nothing I had done in the last seven years suggested I had either any ambition or any desire to move further than the end of my street. I sat there, as the bus’s tired old engine snarled and juddered beneath us, and had a sudden sense of time racing, of losing whole chunks of it in my small journeys backwards and forwards along the same stretch. Round and round the castle. Watching Patrick go round and round the track. The same petty concerns. The same routines.

‘Oh, well. Here’s my stop.’ Deirdre rose heavily beside me, hoisting her patent handbag over her shoulder. ‘Give your mum my love. Tell her I’ll be round tomorrow.’

I looked up, blinking. ‘I got a tattoo,’ I said suddenly. ‘Of a bee.’

She hesitated, holding on to the side of the seat.

‘It’s on my hip. An actual tattoo. It’s permanent,’ I added.

Deirdre glanced towards the door of the bus. She looked a bit puzzled, and then gave me what I think she thought was a reassuring smile.

‘Well, that’s very nice, Louisa. As I said, tell your mum I’ll be round tomorrow.’

Every day, while he was watching television, or otherwise engaged, I sat in front of Will’s computer and worked on coming up with the magic event that might Make Will Happy. But as time went on, I found that my list of things we couldn’t do, places we couldn’t go to, had begun to exceed my ideas for those we could by a significant factor. When the one figure first exceeded the other, I went back on to the chatroom sites, and asked their advice.

Ha! said Ritchie. *Welcome to our world, Bee.*

From the ensuing conversations I learnt that getting drunk in a wheelchair came with its own hazards, including catheter disasters, falling down kerbs, and being steered to the wrong home by other drunks. I learnt that there was no single place where non-quads were more or less helpful than anywhere else, but that Paris was singled out as the least wheelchair-friendly place on earth. This was disappointing, as some small, optimistic part of me had still hoped we might make it there.

I began to compile a new list – things you cannot do with a quadriplegic.

1. Go on a tube train (most underground stations don’t have lifts), which pretty much ruled out activities in half of London unless we wanted to pay for taxis.
2. Go swimming, without help, and unless the temperature was warm enough to stop involuntary shivering within minutes. Even disabled changing rooms are not much use without a pool hoist. Not that Will would have allowed himself into a pool hoist.
3. Go to the cinema, unless guaranteed a seat at the front, or unless Will’s spasms were low-grade that day. I had spent at least twenty minutes of *Rear Window* on my hands and knees picking up the popcorn that Will’s unexpected knee jerk had sent flying into the air.

4. Go on a beach, unless your chair had been adapted with ‘fat wheels’. Will’s hadn’t.
5. Fly on aircraft where the disabled ‘quota’ had already been used up.
6. Go shopping, unless all the shops had got their statutory ramps in place. Many around the castle used their listed building status to say they couldn’t fit them. Some were even telling the truth.
7. Go anywhere too hot, or too cold (temperature issues).
8. Go anywhere spontaneously (bags needed to be packed, routes to be double-checked for accessibility).
9. Go out to eat, if feeling self-conscious about being fed, or – depending on the catheter situation – if the restaurant’s bathroom was down a flight of stairs.
10. Go on long train journeys (exhausting, and too difficult to get heavy motorized chair on to train without help).
11. Get a haircut if it had been raining (all the hair stuck to Will’s wheels. Weirdly, this made both of us nauseous).
12. Go to friend’s houses, unless they had wheelchair ramps. Most houses have stairs. Most people do not have ramps. Our house was a rare exception. Will said there was nobody he wanted to see anyway.
13. Go down the hill from the castle in heavy rain (the brakes were not always safe, and that chair was too heavy for me to hold).
14. Go anywhere where there were likely to be drunks. Will was a magnet for drunks. They would crouch down, breathe fumes all over him, and make big, sympathetic eyes. Sometimes they would, indeed, try to wheel him off.
15. Go anywhere where there might be crowds. This meant that, as summer approached, outings around the castle were getting harder, and half the places I thought we might be able to go – fairs, outdoor theatre, concerts – were ruled out.

When, struggling for ideas, I asked the online quads what was the thing they would like to do most in all the world, the answer nearly always came back as, 'Have sex.' I got quite a lot of unsolicited detail on that one.

But essentially it was not a huge help. There were eight weeks to go, and I had run out of ideas.

A couple of days after our discussion under the washing line, I returned home to find Dad standing in the hallway. This would have been unusual in itself (the last few weeks he seemed to have retreated to the sofa in the daytime, supposedly to keep Granddad company), but he was wearing an ironed shirt, had shaved, and the hallway was filled with the scent of Old Spice. I am pretty sure he'd had that bottle of aftershave since 1974.

'There you are.'

I closed the door behind me. 'Here I am.'

I was feeling tired and anxious. I had spent the whole bus journey home talking on my mobile phone to a travel agent about places to take Will, but we were both stumped. I needed to get him further away from home. But there didn't seem to be a single place outside a five-mile radius of the castle that he actually wanted to visit.

'Are you okay getting your own tea tonight?'

'Sure. I can join Patrick at the pub later. Why?' I hung up my coat on a free peg.

The rack was so much emptier with all Treena's and Thomas's coats gone.

'I am taking your mother out for dinner.'

I did a quick mental calculation. 'Did I miss her birthday?'

'Nope. We're celebrating.' He lowered his voice, as if it were some kind of secret. 'I got a job.'

'You didn't!' And now I could see it; his whole body had lightened. He was standing straighter again, his face wreathed in smiles. He looked years younger.

'Dad, that's fantastic.'

'I know. Your mother's over the moon. And, you know, she's had a tough few months what with Treena going and Granddad and all. So I want to take her out tonight, treat her a bit.'

'So what's the job?'

'I'm going to be head of maintenance. Up at the castle.'

I blinked. 'But that's –'

'Mr Traynor. That's right. He rang me and said he was looking for someone, and your man, Will there, had told him that I was available. I went this afternoon and showed him what I could do, and I'm on a month's trial. Beginning Saturday.'

'You're going to work for Will's dad?'

'Well, he said they have to do a month's trial, to go through the proper procedures and all, but he said he couldn't think of any reason why I shouldn't get it.'

'That – that's great,' I said. I felt weirdly unbalanced by the news. 'I didn't even know there was a job going.'

'Nor me. It's great, though. He's a man who understands quality, Lou. I talked to him about green oak, and he showed me some of the work done by the previous man. You wouldn't believe it. Shocking. He said he was very impressed by my work.'

He was animated, more so than I had seen him for months.

Mum had appeared beside him. She was wearing lipstick, and her good pair of heels. 'There's a van. He gets his own van. And the pay is good, Lou. It's even a bit more than your dad was getting at the furniture factory.'

She was looking up at him like he was some kind of all-conquering hero. Her face, when she turned to me, told me I should do the same. It could contain a million messages, my mother's face, and this one told me Dad should be allowed his moment.

'That's great, Dad. Really.' I stepped forward and gave him a hug.

'Well, it's really Will you should thank. What a smashing bloke. I'm just bloody grateful that he thought of me.'

I listened to them leave the house, the sound of Mum fussing in the hall mirror, Dad's repeated reassurances that she looked lovely, that she was just fine as she was. I heard him patting his pockets for keys, wallet, loose change, followed by a brief burst of laughter. And then the door slammed, I heard the hum of the car pulling away and then there was just the distant sound of the television in Granddad's room. I sat on the stairs. And then I pulled out my phone and rang Will's number.

It took him a while to answer. I pictured him heading to the hands-free device, depressing the button with his thumb.

'Hello?'

‘Is this your doing?’

There was a brief pause. ‘Is that you, Clark?’

‘Did you get my dad a job?’

He sounded a little breathless. I wondered, absently, whether he was sitting up okay.

‘I thought you’d be pleased.’

‘I am pleased. It’s just ... I don’t know. I feel weird.’

‘You shouldn’t do. Your dad needed a job. Mine needed a skilled maintenance man.’

‘Really?’ I couldn’t keep the scepticism from my voice.

‘What?’

‘This has nothing to do with what you asked me the other day? About him and the other woman?’

There was a long pause. I could see him there, in his living room, looking out through the French windows.

His voice, when it came, was careful. ‘You think I’d blackmail my father into giving yours a job?’

Put like that it did sound far-fetched.

I sat down again. ‘Sorry. I don’t know. It’s just weird. The timing. It’s all a bit convenient.’

‘Then be pleased, Clark. It’s good news. Your dad will be great. And it means ... ’ He hesitated.

‘It means what?’

‘... that one day you can go off and spread your wings without worrying about how your parents are going to be able to support themselves.’

It was as if he had punched me. I felt the air disappear from my lungs.

‘Lou?’

‘Yes?’

‘You’re awfully quiet.’

‘I’m ... ’ I swallowed. ‘Sorry. Distracted by something. Granddad’s calling me. But yes. Thanks for – for putting a word in for him.’ I had to get off the phone. Because out of nowhere a huge lump had lodged itself somewhere in my throat and I wasn’t sure I could say anything else.

I walked to the pub. The air was thick with the smell of blossom, and people smiled as they passed me on the street. I couldn’t raise a single greeting in return. I just knew I couldn’t stay in that house, alone with my

thoughts. I found the Triathlon Terrors all in the beer garden, their two tables pushed together in a dappled corner, arms and legs spilling off the ends in sinewy pink angles. I got a few polite nods (none from the women) and Patrick stood, creating a small space for me beside him. I realized I really wished Treena was around.

The pub garden was full, with that peculiarly English mix of braying students and post-work salesmen in their shirtsleeves. This pub was a favourite with tourists, and among the English voices were a variety of other accents – Italian, French, American. From the west wall they could see the castle, and – just as they did every summer – the tourists were lining up for photographs with it behind them in the distance.

‘I wasn’t expecting you. Do you want a drink?’

‘In a minute.’ I just wanted to sit there, to let my head rest against Patrick. I wanted to feel like I used to feel – normal, untroubled. I wanted not to think about death.

‘I broke my best time today. Fifteen miles in just 79.2 minutes.’

‘Great.’

‘Cooking with gas now, eh, Pat?’ someone said.

Patrick bunched both his fists and made a revving noise with his mouth.

‘That’s great. Really.’ I tried to look pleased for him.

I had a drink, and then another. I listened to their talk of mileage, of the skinned knees and hypothermic swimming bouts. I tuned out, and watched the other people in the pub, wondering about their lives. Each of them would have huge events in their own families – babies loved and lost, dark secrets, great joys and tragedies. If they could put it into perspective, if they could just enjoy a sunny evening in a pub garden, then surely I should too.

And then I told Patrick about Dad’s job. His face looked a little like I imagine mine had. I had to repeat it, just so he could be sure he had heard me right.

‘That’s ... very cosy. You both working for him.’

I wanted to tell him then, I really did. I wanted to explain that so much of everything was tied up in my battle to keep Will alive. I wanted to tell him how afraid I was that Will seemed to be trying to buy me my freedom. But I knew I could say nothing. I might as well get the rest of it over while I could.

‘Um ... that’s not the only thing. He says I can stay there when I want, in the spare room. To get past the whole bed problem at home.’

Patrick looked at me. 'You're going to live at his house?'

'I might. It's a nice offer, Pat. You know what it's been like at home. And you're never here. I like coming to your house, but ... well, if I'm honest, it doesn't feel like home.'

He was still staring at me. 'Then make it home.'

'What?'

'Move in. Make it home. Put your stuff up. Bring your clothes. It's about time we moved in together.'

It was only afterwards, when I thought about it, that I realized he had actually looked really unhappy as he said this. Not like a man who had finally worked out he could not live without his girlfriend close by him, and wanted to make a joyous union of our two lives. He looked like someone who felt outmanoeuvred.

'You really want me to move in?'

'Yes. Sure.' He rubbed at his ear. 'I mean, I'm not saying let's get married or anything. But it does make sense, right?'

'You old romantic.'

'I mean it, Lou. It's time. It's probably been time for ages, but I guess I've just been wrapped up in one thing and another. Move in. It'll be good.' He hugged me. 'It will be really good.'

Around us the Triathlon Terrors had diplomatically resumed their chatter. A small cheer went up as a group of Japanese tourists got the photograph they had wanted. Birds sang, the sun dipped, the world turned. I wanted to be part of it, not stuck in a silent room, worrying about a man in a wheelchair.

'Yes,' I said. 'It will be good.'



The worst thing about working as a carer is not what you might think. It's not the lifting and cleaning, the medicines and wipes and the distant but somehow always perceptible smell of disinfectant. It's not even the fact that most people assume you're only doing it because you really aren't smart enough to do anything else. It's the fact that when you spend all day in really close proximity to someone, there is no escape from their moods. Or your own.

Will had been distant with me all morning, since I had first told him my plans. It was nothing an outsider could have put their finger on, but there were fewer jokes, perhaps less casual conversation. He asked me nothing about the contents of the day's newspapers.

'That's ... what you want to do?' His eyes had flickered, but his face betrayed nothing.

I shrugged. Then I nodded more emphatically. I felt there was something childishly non-committal about my response. 'It's about time, really,' I said. 'I mean, I *am* twenty-seven.'

He studied my face. Something tightened in his jaw.

I felt suddenly, unbearably tired. I felt this peculiar urge to say sorry, and I wasn't sure what for.

He gave a little nod, raised a smile. 'Glad you've got it all sorted out,' he said, and wheeled himself into the kitchen.

I was starting to feel really cross with him. I had never felt judged by anyone as I felt judged by Will now. It was as if me deciding to settle down

with my boyfriend had made me less interesting to him. Like I could no longer be his pet project. I couldn't say any of this to him, of course, but I was just as cool with him as he was with me.

It was, frankly, exhausting.

In the afternoon, there was a knock at the back door. I hurried down the corridor, my hands still wet from washing up, and opened it to find a man standing there in a dark suit, a briefcase in hand.

'Oh no. We're Buddhist,' I said firmly, closing the door as the man began to protest.

Two weeks previously a pair of Jehovah's Witnesses had kept Will captive at the back door for almost fifteen minutes, while he struggled to reverse his chair back over the dislodged doormat. When I finally shut the door they had opened the letter box to call that 'he more than anyone' should understand what it was to look forward to the afterlife.

'Um ... I'm here to see Mr Traynor?' the man said, and I opened the door cautiously. In all my time at Granta House nobody had ever come to see Will via the back door.

'Let him in,' Will said, appearing behind me. 'I asked him to come.' When I still stood there, he added, 'It's okay, Clark ... he's a friend.'

The man stepped over the threshold, held out his hand and shook mine. 'Michael Lawler,' he said.

He was about to say something else, but Will moved his chair between us, effectively cutting off any further conversation.

'We'll be in the living room. Could you make some coffee, then leave us for a while?'

'Um ... okay.'

Mr Lawler smiled at me, a little awkwardly, and followed Will into the living room. When I walked in with a tray of coffee some minutes later they were discussing cricket. The conversation about legs and runs continued until I had no further reason to lurk.

Brushing invisible dust from my skirt, I straightened up and said, 'Well. I'll leave you to it.'

'Thanks, Louisa.'

'You sure you don't want anything else? Biscuits?'

'Thank you, Louisa.'

Will never called me Louisa. And he had never banished me from anything before.

Mr Lawler stayed almost an hour. I did my chores, then hung around in the kitchen, wondering if I was brave enough to eavesdrop. I wasn't. I sat, ate two Bourbon creams, chewed my nails, listened to the low hum of their voices, and wondered for the fifteenth time why Will had asked this man not to use the front entrance.

He didn't look like a doctor, or consultant. He could have been a financial adviser, but he somehow didn't have the right air about him. He certainly didn't look like a physiotherapist, occupational therapist or dietician – or one of the legions of other people employed by the local authority to pop by and assess Will's ever-changing needs. You could spot those a mile off. They always looked exhausted, but were briskly, determinedly cheerful. They wore woollens in muted colours, with sensible shoes, and drove dusty estate cars full of folders and boxes of equipment. Mr Lawler had a navy-blue BMW. His gleaming 5-series was not a local authority sort of a car.

Finally, Mr Lawler emerged. He closed his briefcase, and his jacket hung over his arm. He no longer looked awkward.

I was in the hallway within seconds.

'Ah. Would you mind pointing me towards the bathroom?'

I did so, mutely, and stood there, fidgeting, until he emerged.

'Right. So that's all for now.'

'Thank you, Michael.' Will didn't look at me. 'I'll wait to hear from you.'

'I should be in touch later this week,' Mr Lawler said.

'Email would be preferable to letter – at least, for now.'

'Yes. Of course.'

I opened the back door to see him out. Then, as Will disappeared back into the living room, I followed him into the courtyard and said lightly, 'So – do you have far to go?'

His clothes were beautifully cut; they carried the sharp edge of the city in their tailoring, serious money in their thread count.

'London, unfortunately. Still, hope the traffic won't be too bad at this time of the afternoon.'

I stepped out after him. The sun was high in the sky and I had to squint to see him. 'So ... um ... where in London are you based?'

'Regent Street.'

'*The* Regent Street? Nice.'

‘Yes. Not a bad place to be. Right. Thank you for the coffee, Miss ... ’

‘Clark. Louisa Clark.’

He stopped then and looked at me for a moment, and I wondered whether he had sussed my inadequate attempts to work out who he might be.

‘Ah. Miss Clark,’ he said, his professional smile swiftly reinstated.

‘Thank you, anyway.’

He put his briefcase carefully on the back seat, climbed into his car and was gone.

That night, I stopped off at the library on my way home to Patrick’s. I could have used his computer, but I still felt like I should ask, and this just seemed easier. I sat down at the terminal, and typed ‘Michael Lawler’ and ‘Regent Street, London’ into the search engine. *Knowledge is power, Will*, I told him, silently.

There were 3,290 results, the first three of which revealed a ‘Michael Lawler, practitioner at law, specialist in wills, probate and power of attorney’ based in that same street. I stared at the screen for a few minutes, then I typed in his name again, this time against the search engine of images, and there he was, at some Round Table function, in a dark suit – Michael Lawler, specialist in wills and probate, the same man who had spent an hour with Will.

I moved into Patrick’s that night, in the hour and a half between me finishing work and him heading off to the track. I took everything except my bed and the new blinds. He arrived with his car, and we loaded my belongings into bin bags. Within two trips we had it all – bar my school books in the loft – at his.

Mum cried; she thought she was forcing me out.

‘For goodness’ sake, love. It’s time she moved on. She’s twenty-seven years old,’ my father told her.

‘She’s still my baby,’ she said, pressing two tins of fruit cake and a carrier bag of cleaning products into my arms.

I didn’t know what to say to her. I don’t even like fruit cake.

It was surprisingly easy, fitting my belongings into Patrick’s flat. He had next to nothing, anyway, and I had almost nothing from years spent in the box room. The only thing we fell out over was my CD collection, which apparently could only be combined with his once I had stickered the backs of mine and sorted them into alphabetical order.

‘Make yourself at home,’ he kept saying, as if I were some kind of guest. We were nervous, strangely awkward with each other, like two people on a first date. While I was unpacking, he brought me tea and said, ‘I thought this could be your mug.’ He showed me where everything lived in the kitchen, then said, several times, ‘Of course, put stuff where you want. I don’t mind.’

He had cleared two drawers and the wardrobe in the spare room. The other two drawers were filled with his fitness clothes. I didn’t know there were so many permutations of Lycra and fleece. My wildly colourful clothes left several feet of space still empty, the wire hangers jangling mournfully in the closet space.

‘I’ll have to buy more stuff just to fill it up,’ I said, looking at it.

He laughed nervously. ‘What’s that?’

He looked at my calendar, tacked up on the spare-room wall, with its ideas in green and its actual planned events in black. When something had worked (music, wine tasting), I put a smiley face next to it. When it hadn’t (horse racing, art galleries), it stayed blank. There was little marked in for the next two weeks – Will had become bored of the places nearby, and as yet I could not persuade him to venture further afield. I glanced over at Patrick. I could see him eyeing the 12 August date, which was now underlined with exclamation marks in black.

‘Um ... it’s just reminding me about my job.’

‘You don’t think they’re going to renew your contract?’

‘I don’t know, Patrick.’

Patrick took the pen from its clip, looked at the next month, and scribbled under week 28: ‘Time to start job hunting.’

‘That way you’re covered for whatever happens,’ he said. He kissed me and left me to it.

I laid my creams out carefully in the bathroom, tucked my razors, moisturizer and tampons neatly into his mirrored cabinet. I put some books in a neat row along the spare-room floor under the window, including the new titles that Will had ordered from Amazon for me. Patrick promised to put up some shelves when he had a spare moment.

And then, as he left to go running, I sat and looked out over the industrial estate towards the castle, and practised saying the word *home*, silently under my breath.

I am pretty hopeless at keeping secrets. Treena says I touch my nose as soon as I even think of lying. It's a pretty straightforward giveaway. My parents still joke about the time I wrote absence notes for myself after bunking off school. 'Dear Miss Trowbridge,' they read. 'Please excuse Louisa Clark from today's lessons as I am very poorly with women's problems.' Dad had struggled to keep a straight face even while he was supposed to be tearing a strip off me.

Keeping Will's plan from my family had been one thing – I was good at keeping secrets from my parents (it's one of the things we learn while growing up, after all) – but coping with the anxiety by myself was something else entirely.

I spent the next couple of nights trying to work out what Will was up to, and what I could do to stop him, my thoughts racing even as Patrick and I chatted, cooking together in the little galley kitchen. (I was already discovering new things about him – like, he really *did* know a hundred different things to do with turkey breast.) At night we made love – it seemed almost obligatory at the moment, as if we should take full advantage of our freedom. It was as if Patrick somehow felt I owed him something, given my constant physical proximity to Will. But as soon as he dropped off to sleep, I was lost in my thoughts again.

There were just over seven weeks left.

And Will was making plans, even if I wasn't.

The following week, if Will noticed that I was preoccupied, he didn't say anything. We went through the motions of our daily routine – I took him for short drives into the country, cooked his meals, saw to him when we were in his house. He didn't make jokes about Running Man any more.

I talked to him about the latest books he had recommended: we had done *The English Patient* (I loved this), and a Swedish thriller (which I hadn't). We were solicitous with each other, almost excessively polite. I missed his insults, his crabbiness – their absence just added to the looming sense of threat that hung over me.

Nathan watched us both, as if he were observing some kind of new species.

'You two had a row?' he asked me one day in the kitchen, as I unpacked the groceries.

'You'd better ask him,' I said.

'That's exactly what he said.'

He looked at me sideways, and disappeared into the bathroom to unlock Will's medical cabinet.

Meanwhile, I'd lasted three days after Michael Lawler's visit before I rang Mrs Traynor. I asked if we could meet somewhere other than her house, and we agreed on a little cafe that had opened in the grounds of the castle. The same cafe, ironically, that had cost me my job.

It was a much smarter affair than The Buttered Bun – all limed oak and bleached wood tables and chairs. It sold home-made soup full of actual vegetables, and fancy cakes. And you couldn't buy a normal coffee, only lattes, cappuccinos and macchiatos. There were no builders, or girls from the hairdresser's. I sat nursing my tea, and wondered about the Dandelion Lady and whether she would feel comfortable enough to sit in here and read a newspaper all morning.

'Louisa, I'm sorry I'm late.' Camilla Traynor entered briskly, her handbag tucked under her arm, dressed in a grey silk shirt and navy trousers.

I fought the urge to stand up. There was never a time when I spoke to her that I didn't still feel like I was engaged in some kind of interview.

'I was held up in court.'

'Sorry. To get you out of work, I mean. I just ... well, I wasn't sure it could wait.'

She held up a hand, and mouthed something at the waitress, who within seconds had brought her a cappuccino. Then she sat across from me. I felt her gaze like I was transparent.

'Will had a lawyer come to the house,' I said. 'I found out he is a specialist in wills and probate.' I couldn't think of any gentler way to open the conversation.

She looked like I'd just smacked her in the face. I realized, too late, that she might actually have thought I'd have something good to tell her.

'A lawyer? Are you sure?'

'I looked him up on the internet. He's based in Regent Street. In London,' I added unnecessarily. 'His name is Michael Lawler.'

She blinked hard, as if trying to take this in. 'Did Will tell you this?'

'No. I don't think he wanted me to know. I ... I got his name and looked him up.'

Her coffee arrived. The waitress put it on the table in front of her, but Mrs Traynor didn't seem to notice.

‘Did you want anything else?’ the girl said.

‘No, thank you.’

‘We have carrot cake on special today. We make it here ourselves. It’s got a lovely buttercream fill–’

‘No.’ Mrs Traynor’s voice was sharp. ‘Thank you.’

The girl stood there just long enough to let us know she was offended and then stalked off, her notepad swinging conspicuously from one hand.

‘I’m sorry,’ I said. ‘You told me before that I should let you know anything important. I stayed awake half the night trying to work out whether to say anything.’

Her face looked almost leached of colour.

I knew how she felt.

‘How is he in himself? Have you ... have you come up with any other ideas? Outings?’

‘He’s not keen.’ I told her about Paris, and my list of things I had compiled.

All the while I spoke, I could see her mind working ahead of me, calculating, assessing.

‘Anywhere,’ she said, finally. ‘I’ll finance it. Any trip you want. I’ll pay for you. For Nathan. Just – just see if you can get him to agree to it.’

I nodded.

‘If there’s anything else you can think of ... just to buy us some time. I’ll pay your wages beyond the six months, obviously.’

‘That’s ... that’s really not an issue.’

We finished our drinks in silence, both lost in our thoughts. As I watched her, surreptitiously, I noticed that her immaculate hairstyle was now flecked with grey, her eyes as shadowed as my own. I realized I didn’t feel any better for having told her, to have passed my own heightened anxiety on to her – but what choice did I have? The stakes were getting higher with every day that passed. The sound of the clock striking two seemed to spur her out of her stasis.

‘I suppose I should get back to work. Please let me know anything that you ... you can come up with, Louisa. It might be better if we have these conversations away from the annexe.’

I stood up. ‘Oh,’ I said, ‘you’ll need my new number. I just moved.’ As she reached into her handbag for a pen, I added, ‘I moved in with Patrick ... my boyfriend.’

I don't know why this news surprised her so much. She looked startled, and then she handed me her pen.

'I didn't know you had a boyfriend.'

'I didn't know I needed to tell you.'

She stood, one hand resting on the table. 'Will mentioned the other day that you ... he thought you might be moving into the annexe. At weekends.'

I scribbled Patrick's home number.

'Well, I thought it might be more straightforward for everyone if I moved in with Patrick.' I handed her the slip of paper. 'But I'm not far away. Just by the industrial estate. It won't affect my hours. Or my punctuality.'

We stood there. Mrs Traynor seemed agitated, her hand running through her hair, reaching down for the chain around her neck. Finally – as if she could not help herself – she blurted out, 'Would it really have hurt you to have waited? Just a few weeks?'

'I'm sorry?'

'Will ... I think Will is very fond of you.' She bit her lip. 'I can't see ... I can't see how this really helps.'

'Hold on. Are you telling me I shouldn't have moved in with my boyfriend?'

'I'm just saying that the timing is not ideal. Will is in a very vulnerable state. We're all doing our best to keep him optimistic ... and you –'

'I what?' I could see the waitress watching us, her notepad stilled in her hand. 'I what? Dared to have a life away from work?'

She lowered her voice. 'I am doing everything I can, Louisa, to stop this ... thing. You know the task we're facing. And I'm just saying that I wish – given the fact he is very fond of you – that you had waited a while longer before rubbing your ... your happiness in his face.'

I could hardly believe what I was hearing. I felt the colour rise to my face, and took a deep breath before I spoke again.

'How dare you suggest I would do anything to hurt Will's feelings. I have done everything,' I hissed. 'I have done everything I can think of. I've come up with ideas, got him out, talked to him, read to him, looked after him.' My last words exploded out of my chest. 'I've cleaned up after him. I've changed his bloody catheter. I've made him laugh. I've done more than your bloody family have done.'

Mrs Traynor stood very still. She drew herself up to her full height, tucked her handbag under her arm. 'I think this conversation has probably

ended, Miss Clark.'

'Yes. Yes, Mrs Traynor. I think it probably has.'

She turned, and walked swiftly out of the cafe.

When the door slammed shut, I realized I too was shaking.

That conversation with Mrs Traynor kept me jangling for the next couple of days. I kept hearing her words, the idea that I was *rubbing my happiness in his face*. I didn't think Will could be affected by anything that I did. When he had seemed disapproving about my decision to move in with Patrick, I had thought it was about him not liking Patrick rather than any feelings he had for me. More importantly, I didn't think I had looked particularly happy.

At home, I couldn't shake this feeling of anxiety. It was like a low-level current running through me, and it fed into everything I did. I asked Patrick, 'Would we have done this if my sister hadn't needed my room at home?'

He had looked at me as if I were daft. He leant over and pulled me to him, kissing the top of my head. Then he glanced down. 'Do you have to wear these pyjamas? I hate you in pyjamas.'

'They're comfortable.'

'They look like something my mum would wear.'

'I'm not going to wear a basque and suspenders every night just to keep you happy. And you're not answering my question.'

'I don't know. Probably. Yes.'

'But we weren't talking about it, were we?'

'Lou, most people move in with each other because it's sensible. You can love someone and still see the financial and practical advantages.'

'I just ... don't want you to think I made this happen. I don't want to feel like I made this happen.'

He sighed, and rolled on to his back. 'Why do women always have to go over and over a situation until it becomes a problem? I love you, you love me, we've been together nearly seven years and there was no room at your parents' house any more. It's actually pretty simple.'

But it didn't feel simple.

It felt like I was living a life I hadn't had a chance to anticipate.

That Friday it rained all day – warm, heavy sheets of it, like we were in the tropics, making the guttering gurgle and bowing the stems of the flowering shrubs as if in supplication. Will stared out of the windows like a

dog denied a walk. Nathan came and went, a plastic bag lifted above his head. Will watched a documentary about penguins, and afterwards, while he logged on to his computer, I busied myself, so that we didn't have to talk to each other. I felt our discomfort with each other keenly, and being in the same room as him all the time made it that much worse.

I had finally begun to understand the consolations of cleaning. I mopped, cleaned windows and changed duvets. I was a constant whirl of activity. No dust mote escaped my eye, no tea ring my forensic attentions. I was dislodging the limescale on the bathroom taps using kitchen roll soaked in vinegar (my mother's tip) when I heard Will's chair behind me.

'What are you doing?'

I was bent low over the bath. I didn't turn round. 'I'm descaling your taps.'

I could feel him watching me.

'Say that again,' he said, after a beat.

'What?'

'Say that again.'

I straightened up. 'Why, are you having problems with your hearing? I'm descaling your taps.'

'No, I just want you to listen to what you're saying. There is no reason to descale my taps, Clark. My mother won't notice it, I won't care, and it's making the bathroom stink like a fish and chip shop. Besides, I'd like to go out.'

I wiped a lock of hair from my face. It was true. There was a definite waft of large haddock in the atmosphere.

'Come on. It's finally stopped raining. I just spoke to my dad. He said he'll give us the keys to the castle after five o'clock, once all the tourists are out.'

I didn't feel great about the idea of us having to make polite conversation during a walk around the grounds. But the thought of being out of the annexe was appealing.

'Okay. Give me five minutes. I need to try and get the smell of vinegar off my hands.'

The difference between growing up like me and growing up like Will was that he wore his sense of entitlement lightly. I think if you grow up as he had done, with wealthy parents, in a nice house, if you go to good schools

and nice restaurants as a matter of course, you probably just have this sense that good things will fall into place, that your position in the world is naturally an elevated one.

Will had escaped into the empty grounds of the castle his whole childhood, he said. His dad let him roam the place, trusting him not to touch anything. After 5.30pm, when the last of the tourists had gone, as the gardeners began to trim and tidy, as the cleaners emptied the bins and swept up the empty cartons of drink and commemorative toffee fudge, it had become his private playground. As he told me this, I mused that if Treena and I had been given the freedom of the castle, all to ourselves, we would have been air punching with disbelief and getting giddy all over the place.

‘First girl I ever kissed was in front of the drawbridge,’ he said, slowing to look towards it as we walked along the gravel path.

‘Did you tell her it was your place?’

‘No. Perhaps I should have done. She dumped me a week later for the boy who worked in the minimart.’

I turned and stared at him in shock. ‘Not Terry Rowlands? Dark slicked-back hair, tattoos up to his elbows?’

He raised an eyebrow. ‘That’s him.’

‘He still works there, you know. In the minimart. If that makes you feel any better.’

‘I’m not sure he’d feel entirely envious of where I ended up,’ Will said, and I stopped talking again.

It was strange seeing the castle like this, in silence, the two of us the only people there apart from the odd gardener in the distance. Instead of gazing at the tourists, being distracted by their accents and their alien lives, I found myself looking at the castle for perhaps the first time, beginning to absorb some of its history. Its flinted walls had stood there for more than 800 years. People had been born and died there, hearts filled and broken. Now, in the silence, you could almost hear their voices, their own footsteps on the path.

‘Okay, confession time,’ I said. ‘Did you ever walk around here and pretend secretly that you were some kind of warrior prince?’

Will looked sideways at me. ‘Honestly?’

‘Of course.’

‘Yes. I even borrowed one of the swords off the walls of the Great Hall once. It weighed a ton. I remember being petrified that I wouldn’t be able to lift it back on to its stand.’

We had reached the swell of the hill, and from here, at the front of the moat, we could look down the long sweep of grass to the ruined wall that had marked the boundary. Beyond it lay the town, the neon signs and queues of traffic, the bustle that marked the small town's rush hour. Up here it was silent apart from the birds and the soft hum of Will's chair.

He stopped the chair briefly and swivelled it so that we looked down at the grounds. 'I'm surprised we never met each other,' he said. 'When I was growing up, I mean. Our paths must have crossed.'

'Why would they? We didn't exactly move in the same circles. And I would just have been the baby you passed in the pram, while swinging your sword.'

'Ah. I forgot – I am positively ancient compared to you.'

'Eight years would definitely have qualified you as an "older man",' I said. 'Even when I was a teenager my dad would never have let me go out with an older man.'

'Not even if he had his own castle?'

'Well, that would change things, obviously.'

The sweet smell of the grass rose up around us as we walked, Will's wheels hissing through the clear puddles on the path. I felt relieved. Our conversation wasn't quite as it had been, but perhaps that was only to be expected. Mrs Traynor had been right – it would always be hard for Will to watch other people moving on with their lives. I made a mental note to think more carefully about how my actions might make an impact on his life. I didn't want to be angry any more.

'Let's do the maze. I haven't done it for ages.'

I was pulled back from my thoughts. 'Oh. No, thanks.' I glanced over, noticing suddenly where we were.

'Why, are you afraid of getting lost? C'mon, Clark. It'll be a challenge for you. See if you can memorize the route you take in, then take the reverse one out. I'll time you. I used to do it all the time.'

I glanced back towards the house. 'I'd really rather not.' Even the thought of it had brought a knot to my stomach.

'Ah. Playing safe again.'

'That's not it.'

'No problem. We'll just take our boring little walk and go back to the boring little annexe.'

I know he was joking. But something in his tone really got to me. I thought of Deirdre on the bus, her comments about how good it was that one of us girls had stayed behind. Mine was to be the small life, my ambitions the petty ones.

I glanced over at the maze, at its dark, dense box hedging. I was being ridiculous. Perhaps I had been behaving ridiculously for years. It was all over, after all. And I was moving on.

‘Just remember which turn you take, then reverse it to come out. It’s not as hard as it looks. Really.’

I left him on the path before I could think about it. I took a breath, and walked in past the sign that warned ‘No Unaccompanied Children’, striding briskly between the dark, damp hedging which still glistened with raindrops.

It’s not so bad, it’s not so bad, I found myself murmuring under my breath. *It’s just a load of old hedges*. I took a right turn, then a left through a break in the hedge. I took another right, a left, and as I went I rehearsed in my head the reverse of where I had been. *Right. Left. Break. Right. Left.*

My heart rate began to rise a little, so that I could hear the blood pumping in my ears. I forced myself to think about Will on the other side of the hedge, glancing down at his watch. It was just a silly test. I was no longer that naive young woman. I was twenty-seven. I lived with my boyfriend. I had a responsible job. I was a different person.

I turned, went straight on, and turned again.

And then, almost from nowhere, the panic rose within me like bile. I thought I saw a man darting at the end of the hedge. Even though I told myself it was just my imagination, the act of reassuring myself made me forget my reversed instructions. *Right. Left. Break. Right. Right?* Had I got that the wrong way around? My breath caught in my throat. I forced myself onwards, only to realize that I had completely lost my bearings. I stopped and glanced around me at the direction of the shadows, trying to work out which direction was west.

And as I stood there, it dawned on me that I couldn’t do it. I couldn’t stay in there. I whipped round, and began to walk in what I thought was a southerly direction. I would get out. I was twenty-seven years old. It was fine. But then I heard their voices, the catcalling, the mocking laughter. I saw them, darting in and out of the gaps in the hedge, felt my own feet

sway drunkenly under my high heels, the unforgiving prickle of the hedge as I fell against it, trying to steady myself.

‘I want to get out now,’ I had told them, my voice slurring and unsteady. ‘I’ve had enough, guys.’

And they had all vanished. The maze was silent, just the distant whispers that might have been them on the other side of the hedge – or might have been the wind dislodging the leaves.

‘I want to go out now,’ I had said, my voice sounding uncertain even to me. I had gazed up at the sky, briefly unbalanced by the vast, studded black of the space above me. And then I jumped as someone caught me around my waist – the dark-haired one. The one who had been to Africa.

‘You can’t go yet,’ he said. ‘You’ll spoil the game.’

I had known then, just from the feel of his hands on my waist. I had realized that some balance had shifted, that some restraint on behaviour had begun to evaporate. And I had laughed, pushed at his hands as if they were a joke, unwilling to let him know that I knew. I heard him shout for his friends. And I broke away from him, running suddenly, trying to fight my way to the exit, my feet sinking into the damp grass. I heard them all around me, their raised voices, their bodies unseen, and felt my throat constrict in panic. I was too disorientated to work out where I was. The tall hedges kept swaying, pitching towards me. I kept going, pushing my way around corners, stumbling, ducking into openings, trying to get away from their voices. But the exit never came. Everywhere I turned there was just another expanse of hedge, another mocking voice.

I stumbled into an opening, briefly exultant that I was near freedom. But then I saw I was back at the centre again, back where I had started. I reeled as I saw them all standing there, as if they had simply been waiting for me.

‘There you go,’ one of them said, as his hand grabbed my arm. ‘I told you she was up for it. Come on, Lou-lou, give me a kiss and I’ll show you the way out.’ His voice was soft and drawling.

‘Give us all a kiss and we’ll all show you the way out.’

Their faces were a blur.

‘I just ... I just want you to –’

‘Come on, Lou. You like me, don’t you? You’ve been sitting on my lap all evening. One kiss. How hard is that?’

I heard a snigger.

‘And you’ll show me how to get out?’ My voice sounded pathetic, even to me.

‘Just one.’ He moved closer.

I felt his mouth on mine, a hand squeezing my thigh.

He broke away, and I heard the tenor of his breathing change. ‘And now Jake’s turn.’

I don’t know what I said then. Someone had my arm. I heard the laughter, felt a hand in my hair, another mouth on mine, insistent, invasive, and then

—

‘Will ...’

I was sobbing now, crouched over myself. ‘Will,’ I was saying his name, over and over again, my voice ragged, emerging somewhere from my chest. I heard him somewhere far off, beyond the hedge.

‘Louisa? Louisa, where are you? What’s the matter?’

I was in the corner, as far under the hedge as I could get. Tears blurred my eyes, my arms wrapped tightly around me. I couldn’t get out. I would be stuck here forever. Nobody would find me.

‘Will ...’

‘Where are —?’

And there he was, in front of me.

‘I’m sorry,’ I said, looking up, my face contorted. ‘I’m sorry. I can’t ... do it.’

He lifted his arm a couple of inches — the maximum he could manage. ‘Oh Jesus, what the —? Come here, Clark. He moved forward, then glanced down at his arm in frustration. ‘Bloody useless thing ... It’s okay. Just breathe. Come here. Just breathe. Slowly.’

I wiped my eyes. At the sight of him, the panic had begun to subside. I stood up, unsteadily, and tried to straighten my face. ‘I’m sorry. I ... don’t know what happened.’

‘Are you claustrophobic?’ His face, inches from mine, was etched with worry. ‘I could see you didn’t want to go in. I just ... I just thought you were being —’

I shut my eyes. ‘I just want to go now.’

‘Hold on to my hand. We’ll go out.’

He had me out of there within minutes. He knew the maze backwards, he told me as we walked, his voice calm, reassuring. It had been a challenge for him as a boy to learn his way through. I entwined my fingers with his

and felt the warmth of his hand as something comforting. I felt foolish when I realized how close to the entrance I had been all along.

We stopped at a bench just outside, and I rummaged in the back of his chair for a tissue. We sat there in silence, me on the end of the bench beside him, both of us waiting for my hiccupping to subside.

He sat, sneaking sideways glances at me.

‘So ... ?’ he said, finally, when I must have looked as if I could speak without falling apart again. ‘You want to tell me what’s going on?’

I twisted the tissue in my hands. ‘I can’t.’

He closed his mouth.

I swallowed. ‘It’s not you,’ I said, hurriedly. ‘I haven’t talked to anyone about ... It’s ... it’s stupid. And a long time ago. I didn’t think ... I would ...’

I felt his eyes on me, and wished he wouldn’t look. My hands wouldn’t stop trembling, and my stomach felt as if it were made of a million knots.

I shook my head, trying to tell him that there were things I couldn’t say. I wanted to reach for his hand again, but I didn’t feel I could. I was conscious of his gaze, could almost hear his unspoken questions.

Below us, two cars had pulled up near the gates. Two figures got out – from here it was impossible to see who – and embraced. They stood there for a few minutes, perhaps talking, and then got back into their cars and drove off in the opposite direction. I watched them but I couldn’t think. My mind felt frozen. I didn’t know what to say about anything any more.

‘Okay. Here’s a thing,’ he said, finally. I turned around, but he wasn’t looking at me. ‘I’ll tell you something that I never tell anyone. All right?’

‘All right.’ I screwed the tissue into a ball in my hands, waiting.

He took a deep breath.

‘I get really, really scared of how this is going to go.’ He let that settle in the air between us, and then, in a low, calm voice, he carried on. ‘I know most people think living like me is about the worst thing that could happen. But it could get worse. I could end up not being able to breathe by myself, not being able to talk. I could get circulatory problems that mean my limbs have to be amputated. I could be hospitalized indefinitely. This isn’t much of a life, Clark. But when I think about how much worse it could get – some nights I lie in my bed and I can’t actually breathe.’

He swallowed. ‘And you know what? Nobody wants to hear that stuff. Nobody wants you to talk about being afraid, or in pain, or being scared of

dying through some stupid, random infection. Nobody wants to know how it feels to know you will never have sex again, never eat food you've made with your own hands again, never hold your own child. Nobody wants to know that sometimes I feel so claustrophobic, being in this chair, I just want to scream like a madman at the thought of spending another day in it. My mother is hanging on by a thread and can't forgive me for still loving my father. My sister resents me for the fact that yet again I have overshadowed her – and because my injuries mean she can't properly hate me, like she has since we were children. My father just wants it all to go away. Ultimately, they want to look on the bright side. They need me to look on the bright side.'

He paused. 'They need to believe there *is* a bright side.'

I blinked into the darkness. 'Do I do that?' I said, quietly.

'You, Clark,' he looked down at his hands, 'are the only person I have felt able to talk to since I ended up in this bloody thing.'

And so I told him.

I reached for his hand, the same one that had led me out of the maze, and I looked straight down at my feet and I took a breath and I told him about the whole night, and how they had laughed at me and made fun of how drunk and stoned I was, and how I had passed out and later my sister had said it might actually be a good thing, the not remembering all of what they had done, but how that half-hour of not knowing had haunted me ever since. I filled it, you see. I filled it with their laughter, their bodies and their words. I filled it with my own humiliation. I told him how I saw their faces every time I went anywhere beyond the town, and how Patrick and Mum and Dad and my small life had been just fine for me, with all their problems and limitations. They had let me feel safe.

By the time we finished talking the sky had grown dark, and there were fourteen messages on my mobile phone wondering where we were.

'You don't need me to tell you it wasn't your fault,' he said, quietly.

Above us the sky had become endless and infinite.

I twisted the handkerchief in my hand. 'Yes. Well. I still feel ... responsible. I drank too much to show off. I was a terrible flirt. I was –'

'No. They were responsible.'

Nobody had ever said those words aloud to me. Even Treena's look of sympathy had held some mute accusation. *Well, if you will get drunk and*

silly with men you don't know ...

His fingers squeezed mine. A faint movement, but there it was.

'Louisa. It wasn't your fault.'

I cried then. Not sobbing, this time. The tears left me silently, and told me something else was leaving me. Guilt. Fear. A few other things I hadn't yet found words for. I leant my head gently on his shoulder and he tilted his head until it rested against mine.

'Right. Are you listening to me?'

I murmured a yes.

'Then I'll tell you something good,' he said, and then he waited, as if he wanted to be sure he had my attention. 'Some mistakes ... just have greater consequences than others. But you don't have to let that night be the thing that defines you.'

I felt his head tilt against mine.

'You, Clark, have the choice not to let that happen.'

The sigh that left me then was long, and shuddering. We sat there in silence, letting his words sink in. I could have stayed there all night, above the rest of the world, the warmth of Will's hand in mine, feeling the worst of myself slowly begin to ebb away.

'We'd better get back,' he said, eventually. 'Before they call out a search party.'

I released his hand and stood, a little reluctantly, feeling the cool breezes on my skin. And then, almost luxuriously, I stretched my arms high above my head. I let my fingers straighten in the evening air, the tension of weeks, months, perhaps years, easing a little, and let out a deep breath.

Below me the lights of the town winked, a circle of light amid the black countryside below us. I turned back towards him. 'Will?'

'Yes?'

I could barely see him in the dim light, but I knew he was watching me. 'Thank you. Thank you for coming to get me.'

He shook his head, and turned his chair back towards the path.



18

‘Disneyland is good.’

‘I told you, no theme parks.’

‘I know you said that, but it’s not just roller coasters and whirling teacups. At Florida you’ve got the film studios and the science centre. It’s actually quite educational.’

‘I don’t think a 35-year-old former company head needs educating.’

‘There are disabled loos on every corner. And the members of staff are incredibly caring. Nothing is too much trouble.’

‘You’re going to say there are rides specially for handicapped people next, aren’t you?’

‘They accommodate everyone. Why don’t you try Florida, Miss Clark? If you don’t like it you could go on to SeaWorld. And the weather is lovely.’

‘In Will versus killer whale I think I know who would come off worst.’

He didn’t seem to hear me. ‘And they are one of the top-rated companies for dealing with disability. You know they do a lot of Make-A-Wish Foundation stuff for people who are dying?’

‘He is *not* dying.’ I put the phone down on the travel agent just as Will came in. I fumbled with the receiver, trying to set it back in its cradle, and snapped my notepad shut.

‘Everything all right, Clark?’

‘Fine.’ I smiled brightly.

‘Good. Got a nice frock?’

‘What?’

‘What are you doing on Saturday?’

He was waiting expectantly. My brain was still stalled on killer whale versus travel agent.

‘Um ... nothing. Patrick’s away all day training. Why?’

He waited just a few seconds before he said it, as if it actually gave him some pleasure to surprise me.

‘We’re going to a wedding.’

Afterwards, I was never entirely sure why Will changed his mind about Alicia and Rupert’s nuptials. I suspected there was probably a large dose of natural contrariness in his decision – nobody expected him to go, probably least of all Alicia and Rupert themselves. Perhaps it was about finally getting closure. But I think in the last couple of months she had lost the power to wound him.

We decided we could manage without Nathan’s help. I called up to make sure the marquee was suitable for Will’s wheelchair, and Alicia sounded so flustered when she realized we weren’t actually declining the invitation that it dawned on me her embossed correspondence really had been for appearance’s sake.

‘Um ... well ... there is a very small step up into the marquee, but I suppose the people who are putting it up did say they could provide a ramp ...’ She tailed off.

‘That will be lovely, then. Thank you,’ I said. ‘We’ll see you on the day.’

We went online and picked out a wedding present. Will spent £120 on a silver picture frame, and a vase that he said was ‘absolutely vile’ for another £60. I was shocked that he would spend that much money on someone he didn’t even really like, but I had worked out within weeks of being employed by the Traynors that they had different ideas about money. They wrote four-figure cheques without giving it a thought. I had seen Will’s bank statement once, when it had been left on the kitchen table for him to look at. It contained enough money to buy our house twice over – and that was only his current account.

I decided to wear my red dress – partly because I knew Will liked it (and I figured today he was going to need all the minor boosts he could get) – but also because I didn’t actually have any other dresses which I felt brave enough to wear at such a gathering. Will had no idea of the fear I felt at the thought of going to a society wedding, let alone as ‘the help’. Every time I

thought of the braying voices, the assessing glances in our direction, I wanted to spend the day watching Patrick run in circles instead. Perhaps it was shallow of me to even care, but I couldn't help it. The thought of those guests looking down on both of us was already tying my stomach in knots.

I didn't say anything to Will, but I was afraid for him. Going to the wedding of an ex seemed a masochistic act at the best of times, but to go to a public gathering, one that would be full of his old friends and work colleagues, to watch her marry his former friend, seemed to me a sure-fire route to depression. I tried to suggest as much the day before we left, but he brushed it off.

'If I'm not worried about it, Clark, I don't think you should be,' he said.

I rang Treena and told her.

'Check his wheelchair for anthrax and ammunition,' was all she said.

'It's the first time I've got him a proper distance from home and it's going to be a bloody disaster.'

'Maybe he just wants to remind himself that there are worse things than dying?'

'Funny.'

Her mind was only half on our phone call. She was preparing for a week's residential course for 'potential future business leaders', and needed Mum and me to look after Thomas. It was going to be fantastic, she said. Some of the top names in industry would be there. Her tutor had put her forward and she was the only person on the whole course who didn't have to pay her own fees. I could tell that, as she spoke to me, she was also doing something on a computer. I could hear her fingers on the keyboard.

'Nice for you,' I said.

'It's in some college at Oxford. Not even the ex-poly. The actual "dreaming spires" Oxford.'

'Great.'

She paused for a moment. 'He's not suicidal, is he?'

'Will? No more than usual.'

'Well, that's something.' I heard the ping of an email.

'I'd better go, Treen.'

'Okay. Have fun. Oh, and don't wear that red dress. It shows way too much cleavage.'

The morning of the wedding dawned bright and balmy, as I had secretly known it would. Girls like Alicia always got their own way. Someone had probably put in a good word with the weather gods.

‘That’s remarkably bitter of you, Clark,’ Will said, when I told him.

‘Yes, well, I’ve learnt from the best.’

Nathan had come early to get Will ready so that we could leave the house by nine. It was a two-hour drive, and I had built in rest stops, planning our route carefully to ensure we had the best facilities available. I got ready in the bathroom, pulling stockings over my newly shaved legs, painting on make-up and then rubbing it off again in case the posh guests thought I looked like a call girl. I dared not put a scarf around my neck, but I had brought a wrap, which I could use as a shawl if I felt overexposed.

‘Not bad, eh?’ Nathan stepped back, and there was Will, in a dark suit and a cornflower-blue shirt with a tie. He was clean-shaven, and carried a faint tan on his face. The shirt made his eyes look peculiarly vivid. They seemed, suddenly, to carry a glint of the sun.

‘Not bad,’ I said – because, weirdly, I didn’t want to say how handsome he actually looked. ‘She’ll certainly be sorry she’s marrying that braying bucket of lard, anyway.’

Will raised his eyes heavenwards. ‘Nathan, do we have everything in the bag?’

‘Yup. All set and ready to go.’ He turned to Will. ‘No snogging the bridesmaids, now.’

‘As if he’d want to,’ I said. ‘They’ll all be wearing pie-crust collars and smell of horse.’

Will’s parents came out to see him off. I suspected they had just had an argument, as Mrs Traynor could not have stood further away from her husband unless they had actually been in separate counties. She kept her arms folded firmly, even as I reversed the car for Will to get in. She didn’t once look at me.

‘Don’t get him too drunk, Louisa,’ she said, brushing imaginary lint from Will’s shoulder.

‘Why?’ Will said. ‘I’m not driving.’

‘You’re quite right, Will,’ his father said. ‘I always needed a good stiff drink or two to get through a wedding.’

‘Even your own,’ Mrs Traynor murmured, adding more audibly, ‘You look very smart, darling.’ She knelt down, adjusting the hem of Will’s

trousers. 'Really, very smart.'

'So do you.' Mr Traynor eyed me approvingly as I stepped out of the driver's seat. 'Very eye-catching. Give us a twirl, then, Louisa.'

Will turned his chair away. 'She doesn't have time, Dad. Let's get on the road, Clark. I'm guessing it's bad form to wheel yourself in behind the bride.'

I climbed back into the car with relief. With Will's chair secured in the back, and his smart jacket hung neatly over the passenger's seat so that it wouldn't crease, we set off.

I could have told you what Alicia's parents' house would be like even before I got there. In fact, my imagination got it so nearly spot on that Will asked me why I was laughing as I slowed the car. A large, Georgian rectory, its tall windows partly obscured by showers of pale wisteria, its drive a caramel pea shingle, it was the perfect house for a colonel. I could already picture her growing up within it, her hair in two neat blonde plaits as she sat astride her first fat pony on the lawn.

Two men in reflective tabards were directing traffic into a field between the house and the church beside it. I wound down the window. 'Is there a car park beside the church?'

'Guests are this way, Madam.'

'Well, we have a wheelchair, and it will sink into the grass here,' I said. 'We need to be right beside the church. Look, I'll go just there.'

They looked at each other, and murmured something between themselves. Before they could say anything else, I drove up and parked in the secluded spot beside the church. *And here it starts*, I told myself, catching Will's eye in the mirror as I turned off the ignition.

'Chill out, Clark. It's all going to be fine,' he said.

'I'm perfectly relaxed. Why would you think I wasn't?'

'You're ridiculously transparent. Plus you've chewed off four of your fingernails while you've been driving.'

I parked, climbed out, adjusted my wrap around myself, and clicked the controls that would lower the ramp. 'Okay,' I said, as Will's wheels met the ground. Across the road from us in the field, people were climbing out of huge, Germanic cars, women in fuchsia dresses muttering to their husbands as their heels sank into the grass. They were all leggy and streamlined in pale muted colours. I fiddled with my hair, wondering if I had put on too

much lipstick. I suspected I looked like one of those plastic tomatoes you squeeze ketchup out of.

‘So ... how are we playing today?’

Will followed my line of vision. ‘Honestly?’

‘Yup. I need to know. And please don’t say Shock and Awe. Are you planning something terrible?’

Will’s eyes met mine. Blue, unfathomable. A small cloud of butterflies landed in my stomach.

‘We’re going to be incredibly well behaved, Clark.’

The butterflies’ wings began to beat wildly, as if trapped against my ribcage. I began to speak, but he interrupted me.

‘Look, we’ll just do whatever it takes to make it fun,’ he said.

Fun. Like going to an ex’s wedding could ever be less painful than root canal surgery. But it was Will’s choice. Will’s day. I took a breath, trying to pull myself together.

‘One exception,’ I said, adjusting the wrap around my shoulders for the fourteenth time.

‘What?’

‘You’re not to do the Christy Brown. If you do the Christy Brown I will drive home and leave you stuck here with the pointy-heads.’

As Will turned and began making his way towards the church, I thought I heard him murmur, ‘Spoilsport.’

We sat through the ceremony without incident. Alicia looked as ridiculously beautiful as I had known she would, her skin polished a pale caramel, the bias-cut off-white silk skimming her slim figure as if it wouldn’t dare rest there without permission. I stared at her as she floated down the aisle, wondering how it would feel to be tall and long-legged and look like something most of us only saw in airbrushed posters. I wondered if a team of professionals had done her hair and make-up. I wondered if she was wearing control pants. Of course not. She would be wearing pale wisps of something lacy – underwear for women who didn’t need anything actually supported, and which cost more than my weekly salary.

While the vicar droned on, and the little ballet-shod bridesmaids shuffled in their pews, I gazed around me at the other guests. There was barely a woman there who didn’t look like she might appear in the pages of a glossy magazine. Their shoes, which matched their outfits to the exact hue, looked as if they had never been worn before. The younger women stood elegantly

in four- or five-inch heels, with perfectly manicured toenails. The older women, in kitten heels, wore structured suits, boxed shoulders with silk linings in contrasting colours, and hats that looked as if they defied gravity.

The men were less interesting to look at, but nearly all had that air about them that I could sometimes detect in Will – of wealth and entitlement, a sense that life would settle itself agreeably around you. I wondered about the companies they ran, the worlds they inhabited. I wondered if they noticed people like me, who nannied their children, or served them in restaurants. *Or pole danced for their business colleagues*, I thought, remembering my interviews at the Job Centre.

The weddings I went to usually had to separate the bride and groom's families for fear of someone breaching the terms of their parole.

Will and I had positioned ourselves at the rear of the church, Will's chair just to the right of my end of the pew. He looked up briefly as Alicia walked down the aisle, but apart from that he faced straight ahead, his expression unreadable. Forty-eight choristers (I counted) sang something in Latin. Rupert sweated into his penguin suit and raised an eyebrow as if he felt pleased and a bit daft at the same time. Nobody clapped or cheered as they were pronounced man and wife. Rupert looked a bit awkward, dived in towards his bride like somebody apple bobbing and slightly missed her mouth. I wondered if the upper classes felt it was a bit 'off' to really get stuck in at the altar.

And then it was over. Will was already making his way out towards the exit of the church. I watched the back of his head, upright and curiously dignified, and wanted to ask him if it had been a mistake to come. I wanted to ask him if he still had feelings for her. I wanted to tell him that he was too good for that silly caramel woman, no matter what appearances might suggest, and that ... I didn't know what else I wanted to say.

I just wanted to make it better.

'You okay?' I said, as I caught up.

The bottom line was, it should have been him.

He blinked a couple of times. 'Fine,' he said. He let out a little breath, as if he had been holding it. Then he looked up at me. 'Come on, let's go and get a drink.'

The marquee was situated in a walled garden, the wrought-iron gateway into it intertwined with garlands of pale-pink flowers. The bar, positioned at the far end, was already crowded, so I suggested that Will waited outside

while I went and got him a drink. I weaved my way through tables clad in white linen cloths and laden with more cutlery and glassware than I had ever seen. The chairs had gilt backs, like the ones you see at fashion shows, and white lanterns hung above each centrepiece of freesias and lilies. The air was thick with the scent of flowers, to the point where I found it almost stifling.

‘Pimm’s?’ the barman said, when I got to the front. ‘Um ...’ I looked around, seeing that this was actually the only drink on offer. ‘Oh. Okay. Two, please.’

He smiled at me. ‘The other drinks come out later, apparently. But Miss Dewar wanted everyone to start with Pimm’s.’ The look he gave me was slightly conspiratorial. It told me with the faintest lift of an eyebrow what he thought of that.

I stared at the pink lemonade drink. My dad said it was always the richest people who were the tightest, but I was amazed that they wouldn’t even start the wedding with alcohol. ‘I guess that’ll have to do, then,’ I said, and took the glasses from him.

When I found Will, there was a man talking to him. Young, bespectacled, he was half crouching, one arm resting on the arm of Will’s chair. The sun was now high in the sky, and I had to squint to see them properly. I could suddenly see the point of all those wide-brimmed hats.

‘So bloody good to see you out again, Will,’ he was saying. ‘The office isn’t the same without you. I shouldn’t say as much ... but it’s not the same. It just isn’t.’

He looked like a young accountant – the kind of man who is only really comfortable in a suit.

‘It’s nice of you to say so.’

‘It was just so odd. Like you fell off a cliff. One day you were there, directing everything, the next we were just supposed to ...’

He glanced up as he noticed me standing there. ‘Oh,’ he said, and I felt his eyes settle on my chest. ‘Hello.’

‘Louisa Clark, meet Freddie Derwent.’

I put Will’s glass in his holder and shook the younger man’s hand.

He adjusted his sightline. ‘Oh,’ he said again. ‘And –’

‘I’m a friend of Will’s,’ I said, and then, not entirely sure why, let my hand rest lightly on Will’s shoulder.

‘Life not all bad, then,’ Freddie Derwent said, with a laugh that was a bit like a cough. He flushed a little as he spoke. ‘Anyway ... must mingle. You know these things – apparently, we’re meant to see them as a networking opportunity. But good to see you, Will. Really. And ... and you, Miss Clark.’

‘He seemed nice,’ I said, as we moved away. I lifted my hand from Will’s shoulder and took a long sip of my Pimm’s. It was actually tastier than it looked. I had been slightly alarmed by the presence of cucumber.

‘Yes. Yes, he’s a nice kid.’

‘Not too awkward, then.’

‘No.’ Will’s eyes flickered up to meet mine. ‘No, Clark, not too awkward at all.’

As if freed by the sight of Freddie Derwent doing so, over the next hour several more people approached Will to say hello. Some stood a little way back from him, as if this absolved them of the handshake dilemma, while others hoisted the knees of their trousers and crouched down almost at his feet. I stood by Will and said little. I watched him stiffen slightly at the approach of two of them.

One – a big, bluff man with a cigar – seemed not to know what to say when he was actually there in front of Will, and settled for, ‘Bloody nice wedding, wasn’t it? Thought the bride looked splendid.’ I guessed he hadn’t known Alicia’s romantic history.

Another, who seemed to be some business rival of Will’s, hit a more diplomatic note, but there was something in his very direct gaze, his straightforward questions about Will’s condition, that I could see made Will tense. They were like two dogs circling each other, deciding whether to bare their teeth.

‘New CEO of my old company,’ Will said, as the man finally departed with a wave. ‘I think he was just making sure that I wouldn’t be trying to stage a takeover.’

The sun grew fierce, the garden became a fragrant pit, people sheltered under dappled trees. I took Will into the doorway of the marquee, worried about his temperature. Inside the marquee huge fans had been kicked into life, whirring lazily over our heads. In the distance, under the shelter of a summer house, a string quartet played music. It was like a scene from a film.

Alicia, floating around the garden – an ethereal vision, air-kissing and exclaiming – didn't approach us.

I watched Will drain two glasses of Pimm's and was secretly glad.

Lunch was served at 4pm. I thought that was a pretty odd time to serve lunch but, as Will pointed out, it was a wedding. Time seemed to have stretched and become meaningless, anyway, its passage blurred by endless drinks and meandering conversations. I don't know if it was the heat, or the atmosphere, but by the time we arrived at our table I felt almost drunk. When I found myself babbling incoherently to the elderly man on my left, I realized it was actually a possibility.

'Is there any alcohol in that Pimm's stuff?' I said to Will, after I had managed to tip the contents of the salt cellar into my lap.

'About the same as a glass of wine. In each one.'

I stared at him in horror. Both of him. 'You're kidding. It had fruit in it! I thought that meant it was alcohol free. How am I going to drive you home?'

'Some carer you are,' he said. He raised an eyebrow. 'What's it worth for me not to tell my mother?'

I was stunned by Will's reaction to the whole day. I had thought I was going to get Taciturn Will, Sarcastic Will. At the very least, Silent Will. But he had been charming to everybody. Even the arrival of soup at lunch didn't faze him. He just asked politely whether anybody would like to swap his soup for their bread, and the two girls on the far side of the table – who professed themselves 'wheat intolerant' – nearly threw their rolls at him.

The more anxious I grew about how I was going to sober up, the more upbeat and carefree Will became. The elderly woman on his right turned out to be a former MP who had campaigned on the rights of the disabled, and she was one of the few people I had seen talk to Will without the slightest discomfort. At one point I watched her feed him a slice of roulade. When she briefly got up to leave the table, he muttered that she had once climbed Kilimanjaro. 'I love old birds like that,' he said. 'I could just picture her with a mule and a pack of sandwiches. Tough as old boots.'

I was less fortunate with the man on my left. He took about four minutes – the briefest of quizzes about who I was, where I lived, who I knew there – to work out that there was nothing I had to say that might be of interest to him. He turned back to the woman on his left, leaving me to plough silently through what remained of my lunch. At one point, when I started to feel

properly awkward, I felt Will's arm slide off the chair beside me, and his hand landed on my arm. I glanced up and he winked at me. I took his hand and squeezed it, grateful that he could see it. And then he moved his chair back six inches, and brought me into the conversation with Mary Rawlinson.

'So Will tells me you're in charge of him,' she said. She had piercing blue eyes, and wrinkles that told of a life impervious to skincare routines.

'I try,' I said, glancing at him.

'And have you always worked in this field?'

'No. I used to ... work in a cafe.' I'm not sure I would have told anybody else at this wedding that fact, but Mary Rawlinson nodded approvingly.

'I always thought that might be rather an interesting job. If you like people, and are rather nosy, which I am.' She beamed.

Will moved his arm back on to his chair. 'I'm trying to encourage Louisa to do something else, to widen her horizons a bit.'

'What did you have in mind?' she asked me.

'She doesn't know,' Will said. 'Louisa is one of the smartest people I know, but I can't make her see her own possibilities.'

Mary Rawlinson gave him a sharp look. 'Don't patronize her, dear. She's quite capable of answering for herself.'

I blinked.

'I rather think that you of all people should know that,' she added.

Will looked as if he were about to say something, and then closed his mouth. He stared at the table and shook his head a little, but he was smiling.

'Well, Louisa, I imagine your job at the moment takes up an awful lot of mental energy. And I don't suppose this young man is the easiest of clients.'

'You can say that again.'

'But Will is quite right about seeing possibilities. Here's my card. I'm on the board of a charitable organization that encourages retraining. Perhaps you would like to consider something different in the future?'

'I'm very happy working with Will, thank you.'

I took the card that she proffered regardless, a little stunned that this woman would have the slightest interest in what I did with my life. But even as I took it, I felt like an imposter. There was no way I would be able to give up work, even if I knew what I wanted to learn. I wasn't convinced I was the kind of person who would suit retraining. And besides, keeping

Will alive was my priority. I was so lost in my thoughts that I briefly stopped listening to the two of them beside me.

‘... it’s very good that you’ve got over the hump, so to speak. I know it can be crushing to have to readjust your life so dramatically around new expectations.’

I stared at the remains of my poached salmon. I had never heard anyone speak to Will like that.

He frowned at the table, and then turned back to her. ‘I’m not sure I am over the hump,’ he said, quietly.

She eyed him for a moment, and glanced over at me.

I wondered if my face betrayed me.

‘Everything takes time, Will,’ she said, placing her hand briefly on his arm. ‘And that’s something that your generation find it a lot harder to adjust to. You have all grown up expecting things to go your way almost instantaneously. You all expect to live the lives you chose. Especially a successful young man like yourself. But it takes time.’

‘Mrs Rawlinson – Mary – I’m not expecting to recover,’ he said.

‘I’m not talking about physically,’ she said. ‘I’m talking about learning to embrace a new life.’

And then, just as I waited to hear what Will was going to say next, there was a loud tapping of a spoon on a glass, and the room hushed for the speeches.

I barely heard what they said. It seemed to me to be one puffed-up penguin-suited man after another, referring to people and places I didn’t know, provoking polite laughter. I sat and chewed my way through the dark-chocolate truffles that had arrived in silver baskets on the table, and drank three cups of coffee in quick succession so that as well as feeling drunk I felt jittery and wired. Will, on the other hand, was a picture of stillness. He sat and watched the guests applaud his ex-girlfriend, and listened to Rupert drone on about what a perfectly wonderful woman she was. Nobody acknowledged him. I don’t know if that was because they wanted to spare his feelings, or because his presence there was actually a bit of an embarrassment. Occasionally Mary Rawlinson leant in and muttered something into his ear and he nodded slightly, as if in agreement.

When the speeches finally ended, an army of staff appeared and began clearing the centre of the room for dancing. Will leant in to me. ‘Mary

reminded me there is a very good hotel up the road. Ring them and see if we can stay there.'

'What?'

Mary handed me a name and a telephone number scribbled on a napkin.

'It's okay, Clark,' he said, quietly, so that she couldn't hear. 'I'll pay. Go on, and then you can stop worrying about how much you've drunk. Grab my credit card from my bag. They'll probably want to take the number.'

I took it, reached for my mobile phone and walked off into the further reaches of the garden. They had two rooms available, they said – a single, and a double on the ground floor. Yes, it was suitable for disabled access. 'Perfect,' I said, and then had to swallow a small yelp when they told me the price. I gave them Will's credit card number, feeling slightly sick as I read the numbers.

'So?' he said, when I reappeared.

'I've done it, but ...' I told him how much the two rooms had come to.

'That's fine,' he said. 'Now ring that bloke of yours to tell him you're staying out all night, then have another drink. In fact, have six. It would please me no end to see you get hammered on Alicia's father's bill.'

And so I did.

Something happened that evening. The lights dropped, so that our little table was less conspicuous, the overpowering fragrance of the flowers was tempered by the evening breezes, and the music and the wine and the dancing meant that in the most unlikely of places, we all began to actually enjoy ourselves. Will was the most relaxed I had seen him. Sandwiched between me and Mary, he talked and smiled at her, and there was something about the sight of him being briefly happy that repelled those people who might otherwise have looked at him askance, or offered pitying glances. He made me lose my wrap and sit up straight. I took off his jacket and loosened his tie, and we both tried not to giggle at the sight of the dancing. I cannot tell you how much better I felt once I saw the way posh people danced. The men looked as if they had been electrocuted, the women did little pointy fingers at the stars and looked horribly self-conscious even as they twirled.

Mary Rawlinson muttered, 'Dear God,' several times. She glanced over at me. Her language had got fruitier with every drink. 'You don't want to go and strut your stuff, Louisa?'

'God, no.'

‘Jolly sensible of you. I’ve seen better dancing at a bloody Young Farmers Club disco.’

At nine, I got a text from Nathan.

All okay?

Yes. Lovely, believe it or not. Will having great time.

And he was. I watched him laughing hard at something Mary had said, and something in me grew strange and tight. This had shown me it could work. He could be happy, if surrounded by the right people, if allowed to be Will, instead of The Man in the Wheelchair, the list of symptoms, the object of pity.

And then, at 10pm, the slow dances began. We watched Rupert wheel Alicia around the dance floor, applauded politely by onlookers. Her hair had begun to droop, and she wrapped her arms around his neck as if she needed the support. Rupert’s arms linked around her, resting on the small of her back. Beautiful and wealthy as she was, I felt a little sorry for her. I thought she probably wouldn’t realize what she had lost until it was much too late.

Halfway through the song, other couples joined them so that they were partially obscured from view, and I got distracted by Mary talking about carers’ allowances, until suddenly I looked up and there she was, standing right in front of us, the supermodel in her white silk dress. My heart lodged in my throat.

Alicia nodded a greeting to Mary, and dipped a little from her waist so that Will could hear her over the music. Her face was a little tense, as if she had had to prime herself to come over.

‘Thank you for coming, Will. Really.’ She glanced sideways at me but said nothing.

‘Pleasure,’ Will said, smoothly. ‘You look lovely, Alicia. It was a great day.’

A flicker of surprise passed across her face. And then a faint wistfulness. ‘Really? You really think so? I do think ... I mean, there’s so much I want to say –’

‘Really,’ Will said. ‘There’s no need. You remember Louisa?’

‘I do.’

There was a brief silence.

I could see Rupert hovering in the background, eyeing us all warily. She glanced back at him, and then held out a hand in a half-wave. ‘Well, thank

you anyway, Will. You are a superstar for coming. And thank you for the ... '

'Mirror.'

'Of course. I absolutely loved the mirror.' She stood up and walked back to her husband, who turned away, already clasping her arm.

We watched them cross the dance floor.

'You didn't buy her a mirror.'

'I know.'

They were still talking, Rupert's gaze flickering back to us. It was as if he couldn't believe Will had simply been nice. Mind you, neither could I.

'Does it ... did it bother you?' I said to him.

He looked away from them. 'No,' he said, and he smiled at me. His smile had gone a bit lopsided with drink and his eyes were sad and contemplative at the same time.

And then, as the dance floor briefly emptied for the next dance, I found myself saying, 'What do you say, Will? Going to give me a whirl?'

'What?'

'Come on. Let's give these fuckers something to talk about.'

'Oh good,' Mary said, raising a glass. 'Fucking marvellous.'

'Come on. While the music is slow. Because I don't think you can pogo in that thing.'

I didn't give him any choice. I sat down carefully on Will's lap, draped my arms around his neck to hold myself in place. He looked into my eyes for a minute, as if working out whether he could refuse me. Then, astonishingly, Will wheeled us out on to the dance floor, and began moving in small circles under the sparkling lights of the mirrorballs.

I felt simultaneously acutely self-conscious and mildly hysterical. I was sitting at an angle that meant my dress had risen halfway up my thighs.

'Leave it,' Will murmured into my ear.

'This is ... '

'Come on, Clark. Don't let me down now.'

I closed my eyes and wrapped my arms around his neck, letting my cheek rest against his, breathing in the citrus smell of his aftershave. I could feel him humming along with the music.

'Are they all appalled yet?' he said. I opened one eye, and glanced out into the dim light.

A couple of people were smiling encouragingly, but most seemed not to know what to make of it. Mary saluted me with her drink. And then I saw Alicia staring at us, her face briefly falling. When she saw me looking, she turned away and muttered something to Rupert. He shook his head, as if we were doing something disgraceful.

I felt a mischievous smile creeping across my face. 'Oh yes,' I said.

'Hah. Move in closer. You smell fantastic.'

'So do you. Although, if you keep turning in left-hand circles I may throw up.'

Will changed direction. My arms looped around his neck, I pulled back a little to look at him, no longer self-conscious. He glanced down at my chest. To be fair, with me positioned where I was, there wasn't anywhere else he could really look. He lifted his gaze from my cleavage and raised an eyebrow. 'You know, you would never have let those breasts so close to me if I weren't in a wheelchair,' he murmured.

I looked back at him steadily. 'You would never have looked at my breasts if you hadn't been in a wheelchair.'

'What? Of course I would.'

'Nope. You would have been far too busy looking at the tall blonde girls with the endless legs and the big hair, the ones who can smell an expense account at forty paces. And anyway, I wouldn't have been here. I would have been serving the drinks over there. One of the invisibles.'

He blinked.

'Well? I'm right, aren't I?'

Will glanced over at the bar, then back at me. 'Yes. But in my defence, Clark, I was an arse.'

I burst out laughing so hard that even more people looked over in our direction.

I tried to straighten my face. 'Sorry,' I mumbled. 'I think I'm getting hysterical.'

'Do you know something?'

I could have looked at his face all night. The way his eyes wrinkled at the corners. That place where his neck met his shoulder. 'What?'

'Sometimes, Clark, you are pretty much the only thing that makes me want to get up in the morning.'

'Then let's go somewhere.' The words were out almost before I knew what I wanted to say.

‘What?’

‘Let’s go somewhere. Let’s have a week where we just have fun. You and me. None of these ... ’

He waited. ‘Arses?’

‘... arses. Say yes, Will. Go on.’

His eyes didn’t leave mine.

I don’t know what I was telling him. I don’t know where it all came from. I just knew if I didn’t get him to say yes tonight, with the stars and the freesias and the laughter and Mary, then I had no chance at all.

‘Please.’

The seconds before he answered me seemed to take forever.

‘Okay,’ he said.



19

Nathan

They thought we couldn't tell. They finally got back from the wedding around lunchtime the following day and Mrs Traynor was so mad she could barely even speak.

'You could have rung,' she said.

She had stayed in just to make sure they arrived back okay. I had listened to her pacing up and down the tiled corridor next door since I got there at 8am.

'I must have called or texted you both eighteen times. It was only when I managed to call the Dewars' house and somebody told me "the man in the wheelchair" had gone to a hotel that I could be sure you hadn't both had some terrible accident on the motorway.'

"The man in the wheelchair". Nice,' Will observed.

But you could see he wasn't bothered. He was all loose and relaxed, carried his hangover with humour, even though I had the feeling he was in some pain. It was only when his mum started to have a go at Louisa that he stopped smiling. He jumped in and just said that if she had anything to say she should say it to him, as it had been his decision to stay overnight, and Louisa had simply gone along with it.

'And as far as I can see, Mother, as a 35-year-old man I'm not strictly answerable to anybody when it comes to choosing to spend a night at a hotel. Even to my parents.'

She had stared at them both, muttered something about ‘common courtesy’ and then left the room.

Louisa looked a bit shaken but he had gone over and murmured something to her, and that was the point at which I saw it. She went kind of pink and laughed, the kind of laugh you do when you know you shouldn’t be laughing. The kind of laugh that spoke of a conspiracy. And then Will turned to her and told her to take it easy for the rest of the day. Go home, get changed, maybe catch forty winks.

‘I can’t be walking around the castle with someone who has so clearly just done the walk of shame,’ he said.

‘Walk of shame?’ I couldn’t keep the surprise from my voice.

‘Not *that* walk of shame,’ Louisa said, flicking me with her scarf, and grabbed her coat to leave.

‘Take the car,’ he called out. ‘It’ll be easier for you to get back.’

I watched Will’s eyes follow her all the way to the back door.

I would have offered you seven to four just on the basis of that look alone.

He deflated a little after she left. It was as if he had been holding on until both his mum and Louisa had left the annexe. I had been watching him carefully now, and once his smile left his face I realized I didn’t like the look of him. His skin held a faint blotchiness, he had winced twice when he thought no one was looking, and I could see even from here that he had goosebumps. A little alarm bell had started to sound, distant but shrill, inside my head.

‘You feeling okay, Will?’

‘I’m fine. Don’t fuss.’

‘You want to tell me where it hurts?’

He looked a bit resigned then, as if he knew I saw straight through him. We had worked together a long time.

‘Okay. Bit of a headache. And ... um ... I need my tubes changed. Probably quite sharpish.’

I had transferred him from his chair on to his bed and now I began getting the equipment together. ‘What time did Lou do them this morning?’

‘She didn’t.’ He winced. And he looked a little guilty. ‘Or last night.’

‘What?’

I took his pulse, and grabbed the blood pressure equipment. Sure enough, it was sky high. When I put my hand on his forehead it came away with a

faint sheen of sweat. I went for the medicine cabinet, and crushed some vasodilator drugs. I gave them to him in water, making sure he drank every last bit. Then I propped him up, placing his legs over the side of the bed, and I changed his tubes swiftly, watching him all the while.

‘AD?’

‘Yeah. Not your most sensible move, Will.’

Autonomic dysreflexia was pretty much our worst nightmare. It was Will’s body’s massive overreaction against pain, discomfort – or, say, an un-emptied catheter – his damaged nervous system’s vain and misguided attempt to stay in control. It could come out of nowhere and send his body into meltdown. He looked pale, his breathing laboured.

‘How’s your skin?’

‘Bit prickly.’

‘Sight?’

‘Fine.’

‘Aw, man. You think we need help?’

‘Give me ten minutes, Nathan. I’m sure you’ve done everything we need. Give me ten minutes.’

He closed his eyes. I checked his blood pressure again, wondering how long I should leave it before calling an ambulance. AD scared the hell out of me because you never knew which way it was going to go. He had had it once before, when I had first started working with him, and he had ended up in hospital for two days.

‘Really, Nathan. I’ll tell you if I think we’re in trouble.’

He sighed, and I helped him backwards so that he was leaning against his bedhead.

He told me Louisa had been so drunk he hadn’t wanted to risk letting her loose on his equipment. ‘God knows where she might have stuck the ruddy tubes.’ He half laughed as he said it. It had taken Louisa almost half an hour just to get him out of his chair and into bed, he said. They had both ended up on the floor twice. ‘Luckily we were both so drunk by then I don’t think either of us felt a thing.’ She had had the presence of mind to call down to reception, and they had asked a porter to help lift him. ‘Nice chap. I have a vague memory of insisting Louisa give him a fifty-pound tip. I knew she was properly drunk because she agreed to it.’

Will had been afraid when she finally left his room that she wouldn’t actually make it to hers. He’d had visions of her curled up in a little red ball

on the stairs.

My own view of Louisa Clark was a little less generous just at that moment. ‘Will, mate, I think maybe next time you should worry a little more about yourself, yeah?’

‘I’m all right, Nathan. I’m fine. Feeling better already.’

I felt his eyes on me as I checked his pulse.

‘Really. It wasn’t her fault.’

His blood pressure was down. His colour was returning to normal in front of me. I let out a breath I hadn’t realized I had been holding.

We chatted a bit, passing the time while everything settled down, discussing the previous day’s events. He didn’t seem a bit bothered about his ex. He didn’t say much, but for all he was obviously exhausted, he looked okay.

I let go of his wrist. ‘Nice tattoo, by the way.’

He gave me a wry look.

‘Make sure you don’t graduate to an “End by”, yeah?’

Despite the sweats and the pain and the infection, he looked for once like there was something else on his mind other than the thing that consumed him. I couldn’t help thinking that if Mrs Traynor had known this, she might not have kicked off as hard as she did.

We didn’t tell her anything of the lunchtime events – Will made me promise not to – but when Lou came back later that afternoon she was pretty quiet. She looked pale, with her hair washed and pulled back like she was trying to look sensible. I kind of guessed how she felt; sometimes when you get hammered till the small hours you feel pretty good in the morning, but really it’s just because you’re still a bit drunk. That old hangover is just toying with you, working out when to bite. I figured it must have bitten her around lunchtime.

But it became clear after a while that it wasn’t just the hangover troubling her.

Will kept on and on at her about why she was being so quiet, and then she said, ‘Yes, well, I’ve discovered it’s not the most sensible thing to stay out all night when you’ve just moved in with your boyfriend.’

She was smiling as she said it, but it was a forced smile, and Will and I both knew that there must have been some serious words.

I couldn't really blame the guy. I wouldn't have wanted my missus staying out all night with some bloke, even if he was a quad. And he hadn't seen the way Will looked at her.

We didn't do much that afternoon. Louisa emptied Will's backpack, revealing every free hotel shampoo, conditioner, miniature sewing kit and shower cap she could lay her hands on. ('Don't laugh,' she said. 'At those prices, Will paid for a bloody shampoo factory.') We watched some Japanese animated film which Will said was perfect hangover viewing, and I stuck around – partly because I wanted to keep an eye on his blood pressure and partly, to be honest, because I was being a bit mischievous. I wanted to see his reaction when I announced I was going to keep them both company.

'Really?' he said. 'You like Miyazaki?'

He caught himself immediately, saying that of course I would love it ... it was a great film ... blah, blah, blah. But there it was. I was glad for him, on one level. He had thought about one thing for too long, that man.

So we watched the film. Pulled down the blinds, took the phone off the hook, and watched this weird cartoon about a girl who ends up in a parallel universe, with all these weird creatures, half of whom you couldn't tell if they were good or bad. Lou sat right up close to Will, handing him his drink or, at one point, wiping his eye when he got something in it. It was quite sweet, really, although a little bit of me wondered what on earth this was going to lead to.

And then, as Louisa pulled up the blinds and made us all some tea, they looked at each other like two people wondering whether to let you in on a secret, and they told me about going away. Ten days. Not sure where yet, but it would probably be long haul and it would be good. Would I come and help?

Does a bear shit in the woods?

I had to take my hat off to the girl. If you had told me four months ago that we'd get Will off on a long-haul holiday – hell, that we would get him out of this house – I would have told you that you were a few sandwiches short of a picnic. Mind you, I'd have a quiet word with her about Will's medical care before we went. We couldn't afford a near miss like that again if we were stuck in the middle of nowhere.

They even told Mrs T as she popped by, just as Louisa was leaving. Will said it, like it was no more remarkable than him going for a walk around the

castle.

I have to tell you, I was really pleased. That ruddy online poker site had eaten all my money, and I wasn't even planning on a holiday this year. I even forgave Louisa for being stupid enough to listen to Will when he said he hadn't wanted her to do his tubes. And believe me, I had been pretty pissed about that. So it was all looking great, and I was whistling when I shouldered my way into my coat, already looking forward to white sands and blue seas. I was even trying to work out if I could tie in a short visit home to Auckland.

And then I saw them – Mrs Traynor standing outside the back door, as Lou waited to set off down the road. I don't know what sort of a chat they'd had already, but they both looked grim.

I only caught the last line but, to be honest, that was enough for me.

'I hope you know what you're doing, Louisa.'



20

‘You what?’

We were on the hills just outside town when I told him. Patrick was halfway through a sixteen-mile run and wanted me to time him while following behind on the bicycle. As I was marginally less proficient on a bicycle than I was at particle physics, this involved a lot of swearing and swerving on my part, and a lot of exasperated shouting on his. He had actually wanted to do twenty-four miles, but I had told him I didn’t think my seat could take it, and besides, one of us needed to do the weekly shop after we got home. We were out of toothpaste and instant coffee. Mind you, it was only me who wanted the coffee. Patrick was on herbal tea.

As we reached the top of Sheepcote Hill, me puffing, my legs like lead, I decided to just throw it out there. I figured we still had ten miles home for him to recover his good mood.

‘I’m not coming to the Xtreme Viking.’

He didn’t stop, but he came close. He turned to face me, his legs still moving under him, and he looked so shocked that I nearly swerved into a tree.

‘What? Why?’

‘I’m ... working.’

He turned back to the road and picked up speed. We had reached the brow of the hill, and I had to close my fingers around the brakes a little to stop myself overtaking him.

‘So when did you work this out?’ Fine beads of sweat had broken out on his forehead, and tendons stood out on his calves. I couldn’t look at them too long or I started wobbling.

‘At the weekend. I just wanted to be sure.’

‘But we’ve booked your flights and everything.’

‘It’s only easyJet. I’ll reimburse you the £39 if you’re that bothered.’

‘It’s not the cost. I thought you were going to support me. You said you were coming to support me.’

He could look quite sulky, Patrick. When we were first together, I used to tease him about it. I called him Mr Grumpy Trousers. It made me laugh, and him so cross that he usually stopped sulking just to shut me up.

‘Oh, come on. I’m hardly not supporting you now, am I? I hate cycling, Patrick. You know I do. But I’m supporting you.’

We went on another mile before he spoke again. It might have been me, but the pounding of Patrick’s feet on the road seemed to have taken on a grim, resolute tone. We were high above the little town now, me puffing on the uphill stretches, trying and failing to stop my heart racing every time a car came past. I was on Mum’s old bike (Patrick wouldn’t let me anywhere near his racing demon) and it had no gears so I was frequently left tailing him.

He glanced behind, and slowed his pace a fraction so that I could draw level. ‘So why can’t they get an agency person in?’ he said.

‘An agency person?’

‘To come to the Traynors’ house. I mean, if you’re there for six months you must be entitled to a holiday.’

‘It’s not that simple.’

‘I don’t see why not. You started work there knowing nothing, after all.’

I held my breath. This was quite hard given that I was completely breathless from cycling. ‘Because he needs to go on a trip.’

‘What?’

‘He needs to go on a trip. So they need me and Nathan there to help him.’

‘Nathan? Who’s Nathan?’

‘His medical carer. The guy you met when Will came to Mum’s.’

I could see Patrick thinking about this. He wiped sweat from his eyes.

‘And before you ask,’ I added, ‘no, I am not having an affair with Nathan.’

He slowed, and glanced down at the tarmac, until he was practically jogging on the spot. 'What is this, Lou? Because ... because it seems to me that there is a line being blurred here between what is work and what is ...' he shrugged, '... normal.'

'It's not a normal job. You know that.'

'But Will Traynor seems to take priority over everything these days.'

'Oh, and this doesn't?' I took my hand off the handlebars, and gestured towards his shifting feet.

'That's different. He calls, you come running.'

'And you go running, I come running.' I tried to smile.

'Very funny.' He turned away.

'It's six months, Pat. Six months. You were the one who thought I should take this job, after all. You can't have a go at me for taking it seriously.'

'I don't think ... I don't think it's about the job ... I just ... I think there's something you're not telling me.'

I hesitated, just a moment too long. 'That's not true.'

'But you won't come to the Viking.'

'I've told you, I –'

He shook his head slightly, as if he couldn't hear me properly. Then he began to run down the road, away from me. I could see from the set of his back how angry he was.

'Oh, come on, Patrick. Can't we just stop for a minute and discuss this?'

His tone was mulish. 'No. It will throw out my time.'

'Then let's stop the clock. Just for five minutes.'

'No. I have to do it in real conditions.'

He began to run faster, as if he had gained a new momentum.

'Patrick?' I said, struggling suddenly to keep up with him. My feet slipped on the pedals, and I cursed, kicking a pedal back to try and set off again. 'Patrick? Patrick!'

I stared at the back of his head and the words were out of my mouth almost before I knew what I was saying. 'Okay. Will wants to die. He wants to commit suicide. And this trip is my last attempt to change his mind.'

Patrick's stride shortened and then slowed. He stopped on the road ahead, his back straight, still facing away from me. He turned slowly. He had finally stopped jogging.

'Say that again.'

‘He wants to go to Dignitas. In August. I’m trying to change his mind. This is the last chance I have.’

He was staring at me like he didn’t know quite whether to believe me.

‘I know it sounds mad. But I have to change his mind. So ... so I can’t come to the Viking.’

‘Why didn’t you tell me this before?’

‘I had to promise his family I wouldn’t tell anyone. It would be awful for them if it got out. Awful. Look, even he doesn’t know I know. It’s all been ... tricky. I’m sorry.’ I reached out a hand to him. ‘I would have told you if I could.’

He didn’t answer. He looked crushed, as if I had done something terrible. There was a faint frown on his face, and he swallowed twice, hard.

‘Pat –’

‘No. Just ... I just need to run now, Lou. By myself.’ He ran a hand across his hair. ‘Okay?’

I swallowed. ‘Okay.’

He looked for a moment as if he had forgotten why we were even out there. Then he struck off again, and I watched him disappear on the road ahead of me, his head facing resolutely ahead, his legs eating up the road beneath him.

I had put the request out on the day after we returned from the wedding.

Can anyone tell me a good place to go where quadriplegics can have adventures? I am looking for things that an able-bodied person might be able to do, things that might make my depressed friend forget for a while that his life is a bit limited. I don’t really know what I’m hoping for, but all suggestions gratefully received. This is quite urgent. Busy Bee.

As I logged on I found myself staring at the screen in disbelief. There were eighty-nine responses. I scrolled up and down the screen, unsure at first whether they could all possibly be in response to my request. Then I glanced around me at the other computer users in the library, desperate for one of them to look at me so that I could tell them. Eighty-nine responses! To a single question!

There were tales of bungee jumping for quadriplegics, of swimming, canoeing, even horse riding, with the aid of a special frame. (When I watched the online video this linked to, I was a little disappointed that Will had said he really couldn’t stand horses. It looked ace.)

There was swimming with dolphins, and scuba diving with supporters. There were floating chairs that would enable him to go fishing, and adapted quad bikes that would allow him to off-road. Some of them had posted photographs or videos of themselves taking part in these activities. A few of them, including Ritchie, had remembered my previous posts, and wanted to know how he was doing.

This all sounds like good news. Is he feeling better?

I typed a quick response:

Maybe. But I'm hoping this trip will really make a difference.

Ritchie responded:

Attagirl! If you've got the funds to sort it all out, the sky's the limit!

Scootagirl wrote:

Make sure you post up some pics of him in the bungee harness. Love the look on guys' faces when they're upside down!

I loved them – these quads and their carers – for their courage and their generosity and their imaginations. I spent two hours that evening writing down their suggestions, following their links to related websites they had tried and tested, even talking to a few in the chat rooms. By the time I left I had a destination; we would head to California, to The Four Winds Ranch, a specialist centre which offered experienced help 'in a way that will make you forget you ever needed help', according to its website. The ranch itself, a low-slung timber building set into a forest clearing near Yosemite, had been set up by a former stuntman who refused to let his spinal injury limit the things he could do, and the online visitors book was full of happy and grateful holidaymakers who swore that he had changed the way they felt about their disability – and themselves. At least six of the chat-room users had been there, and all said it had turned their lives around.

It was wheelchair friendly, but with all the facilities you would expect from a luxury hotel. There were outside sunken baths with discreet hoists, and specialist masseurs. There was trained medical help on site, and a cinema with spaces for wheelchairs beside the normal seats. There was an accessible outdoor hot tub where you could sit and stare up at the stars. We would spend a week there, and then a few days on the coast at a hotel complex where Will could swim, and get a good look at the rugged coastline. Best of all, I had found a climax to the holiday that Will would

never forget – a skydive, with the help of parachute instructors who were trained in helping quads jump. They had special equipment that would strap Will to them (apparently, the most important thing was securing their legs so that their knees didn't fly up and bash them in the face).

I would show him the hotel brochure, but I wasn't going to tell him about this. I was just going to turn up there with him and then watch him do it. For those few, precious minutes Will would be weightless, and free. He would escape the dreaded chair. He would escape gravity.

I printed out all the information and kept that one sheet at the top. Whenever I looked at it I felt a germ of excitement building – both at the thought of my first ever long-haul trip, but also at the thought that this might just be it.

This might be the thing that would change Will's mind.

I showed Nathan the next morning, the two of us stooping furtively over our coffees in the kitchen as if we were doing something properly clandestine. He flicked through the papers that I had printed off.

'I have spoken to other quads about the skydiving thing. There's no medical reason he can't do it. And the bungee jumping. They have special harnesses to relieve any potential pressure points on his spine.'

I studied his face anxiously. I knew Nathan didn't rate my capabilities when it came to Will's medical well-being. It was important to me that he was happy with what I'd planned.

'The place here has everything we might need. They say if we call ahead and bring a doctor's prescription, they can even get any generic drugs that we might need, so that there is no chance of us running out.'

He frowned. 'Looks good,' he said, finally. 'You did a great job.'

'You think he'll like it?'

He shrugged. 'I haven't got a clue. But –' he handed me the papers '– you've surprised us so far, Lou.' His smile was a sly thing, breaking in from the side of his face. 'No reason you couldn't do it again.'

I showed Mrs Traynor before I left for the evening.

She had just pulled into the drive in her car and I hesitated, out of sight of Will's window, before I approached her. 'I know this is expensive,' I said. 'But ... I think it looks amazing. I really think Will could have the time of his life. If ... if you know what I mean.'

She glanced through it all in silence, and then studied the figures that I had compiled.

‘I’ll pay for myself, if you like. For my board and lodging. I don’t want anyone thinking –’

‘It’s fine,’ she said, cutting me off. ‘Do what you have to do. If you think you can get him to go then just book it.’

I understood what she was saying. There was no time for anything else.

‘Do you think you can persuade him?’ she said.

‘Well ... if I ... if I make out that it’s ...’ I swallowed, ‘... partly for my benefit. He thinks I’ve never done enough with my life. He keeps telling me I should travel. That I should ... do things.’

She looked at me very carefully. She nodded. ‘Yes. That sounds like Will.’ She handed back the paperwork.

‘I am ...’ I took a breath, and then, to my surprise, I found that I couldn’t speak. I swallowed hard, twice. ‘What you said before. I –’

She didn’t seem to want to wait for me to speak. She ducked her head, her slim fingers reaching for the chain around her neck. ‘Yes. Well, I’d better go in. I’ll see you tomorrow. Let me know what he says.’

I didn’t go back to Patrick’s that evening. I had meant to, but something led me away from the industrial park and, instead, I crossed the road and boarded the bus that led towards home. I walked the 180 steps to our house, and let myself in. It was a warm evening, and all the windows were open in an attempt to catch the breeze. Mum was cooking, singing away in the kitchen. Dad was on the sofa with a mug of tea, Granddad napping in his chair, his head lolling to one side. Thomas was carefully drawing in black felt tip on his shoes. I said hello and walked past them, wondering how it could feel so swiftly as if I didn’t quite belong here any more.

Treena was working in my room. I knocked on the door, and walked in to find her at the desk, hunched over a pile of textbooks, glasses that I didn’t recognize perched on her nose. It was strange to see her surrounded by the things I had chosen for myself, with Thomas’s pictures already obscuring the walls I had painted so carefully, his pen drawing still scrawled over the corner of my blind. I had to gather my thoughts so that I didn’t feel instinctively resentful.

She glanced over her shoulder at me. ‘Does Mum want me?’ she said. She glanced up at the clock. ‘I thought she was going to do Thomas’s tea.’

‘She is. He’s having fish fingers.’

She looked at me, then removed the glasses. ‘You okay? You look like shit.’

‘So do you.’

‘I know. I went on this stupid detox diet. It’s given me hives.’ She reached a hand up to her chin.

‘You don’t need to diet.’

‘Yeah. Well ... there’s this bloke I like in Accountancy 2. I thought I might start making the effort. Huge hives all over your face is always a good look, right?’

I sat down on the bed. It was my duvet cover. I had known Patrick would hate it, with its crazy geometric pattern. I was surprised Katrina didn’t.

She closed her book, and leant back in her chair. ‘So what’s going on?’

I bit my lip, until she asked me again.

‘Treen, do you think I could retrain?’

‘Retrain? As what?’

‘I don’t know. Something to do with fashion. Design. Or maybe just tailoring.’

‘Well ... there are definitely courses. I’m pretty sure my uni has one. I could look it up, if you want.’

‘But would they take people like me? People who don’t have qualifications?’

She threw her pen up in the air and caught it. ‘Oh, they love mature students. Especially mature students with a proven work ethic. You might have to do a conversion course, but I don’t see why not. Why? What’s going on?’

‘I don’t know. It’s just something Will said a while back. About ... about what I should do with my life.’

‘And?’

‘And I keep thinking ... maybe it’s time I did what you’re doing. Now that Dad can support himself again, maybe you’re not the only one capable of making something of herself?’

‘You’d have to pay.’

‘I know. I’ve been saving.’

‘I think it’s probably a bit more than you’ve managed to save.’

‘I could apply for a grant. Or maybe a loan. And I’ve got enough to see me through for a bit. I met this MP woman who said she has links to some

agency that could help me. She gave me her card.'

'Hang on,' Katrina said, swivelling on her chair, 'I don't really get this. I thought you wanted to stay with Will. I thought the whole point of this was that you wanted to keep him alive and keep working with him.'

'I do, but ... ' I stared up at the ceiling.

'But what?'

'It's complicated.'

'So's quantitative easing. But I still get that it means printing money.'

She rose from her chair and walked over to shut the bedroom door. She lowered her voice so that nobody outside could possibly hear.

'You think you're going to lose? You think he's going to ... ?'

'No,' I said hurriedly. 'Well, I hope not. I've got plans. Big plans. I'll show you in a bit.'

'But ... '

I stretched my arms above me, twisting my fingers together. 'But, I like Will. A lot.'

She studied me. She was wearing her thinking face. There is nothing more terrifying than my sister's thinking face when it is trained directly on you.

'Oh, shit.'

'Don't ... '

'So *this* is interesting,' she said.

'I know.' I dropped my arms.

'You want a job. So that ... '

'It's what the other quads tell me. The ones who I talk to on the message boards. You can't be both. You can't be carer and ... ' I lifted my hands to cover my face.

I could feel her eyes on me.

'Does he know?'

'No. I'm not sure *I* know. I just ... ' I threw myself down on her bed, face first. It smelt of Thomas. Underlaid with a faint hint of Marmite. 'I don't know what I think. All I know is that most of the time I would rather be with him than anyone else I know.'

'Including Patrick.'

And there it was, out there. The truth that I could barely admit to myself.

I felt my cheeks flood with colour. 'Yes,' I said into the duvet.

'Sometimes, yes.'

‘Fuck,’ she said, after a minute. ‘And I thought *I* liked to make my life complicated.’

She lay down beside me on the bed, and we stared up at the ceiling. Downstairs we could hear Granddad whistling tunelessly, accompanied by the whine and clunk of Thomas driving some remote-control vehicle backwards and forwards into a piece of skirting. For some unexplained reason my eyes filled with tears. After a minute, I felt my sister’s arm snake around me.

‘You fucking madwoman,’ she said, and we both began to laugh.

‘Don’t worry,’ I said, wiping at my face. ‘I’m not going to do anything stupid.’

‘Good. Because the more I think about this, the more I think it’s about the intensity of the situation. It’s not real, it’s about the drama.’

‘What?’

‘Well, this is actual life or death, after all, and you’re locked into this man’s life every day, locked into his weird secret. That’s got to create a kind of false intimacy. Either that or you’re getting some weird Florence Nightingale complex.’

‘Believe me, that is definitely not it.’

We lay there, staring at the ceiling.

‘But it is a bit mad, thinking about loving someone who can’t ... you know, love you back. Maybe this is just a panic reaction to the fact that you and Patrick have finally moved in together.’

‘I know. You’re right.’

‘And you two have been together a long time. You’re bound to get crushes on other people.’

‘Especially while Patrick is obsessed with being Marathon Man.’

‘And you might go off Will again. I mean, I remember when you thought he was an arse.’

‘I still do sometimes.’

My sister reached for a tissue and dabbed at my eyes. Then she thumbed at something on my cheek.

‘All that said, the college idea is good. Because – let’s be blunt – whether it all goes tits up with Will, or whether it doesn’t, you’re still going to need a proper job. You’re not going to want to be a carer forever.’

‘It’s not going to go “tits up”, as you call it, with Will. He’s ... he’s going to be okay.’

‘Sure he is.’

Mum was calling Thomas. We could hear her, singing it beneath us in the kitchen. ‘*Thomas. Tomtomtomtom Thomas ...*’

Treena sighed and rubbed at her eyes. ‘You going back to Patrick’s tonight?’

‘Yes.’

‘You want to grab a quick drink at the Spotted Dog and show me these plans, then? I’ll see if Mum will put Thomas to bed for me. Come on, you can treat me, seeing as you’re now loaded enough to go to college.’

It was a quarter to ten by the time I got back to Patrick’s.

My holiday plans, astonishingly, had met with Katrina’s complete approval. She hadn’t even done her usual thing of adding, ‘Yes, but it would be even better if you ...’ There had been a point where I wondered if she was doing it just to be nice, because I was obviously going a bit nuts. But she kept saying things like, ‘Wow, I can’t believe you found this! You’ve got to take lots of pictures of him bungee jumping.’ And, ‘Imagine his face when you tell him about the skydiving! It’s going to be brilliant.’

Anyone watching us at the pub might have thought that we were two friends who actually really quite liked each other.

Still mulling this over, I let myself in quietly. The flat was dark from outside and I wondered if Patrick was having an early night as part of his intensive training. I dropped my bag on the floor in the hall and pushed at the living-room door, thinking as I did so that it was nice of him to have left a light on for me.

And then I saw him. He was sitting at a table laid with two places, a candle flickering between them. As I closed the door behind me, he stood up. The candle was burnt halfway down to the base.

‘I’m sorry,’ he said.

I stared at him.

‘I was an idiot. You’re right. This job of yours is only for six months, and I have been behaving like a child. I should be proud that you’re doing something so worthwhile, and taking it all so seriously. I was just a bit ... thrown. So I’m sorry. Really.’

He held out a hand. I took it.

‘It’s good that you’re trying to help him. It’s admirable.’

‘Thank you.’ I squeezed his hand.

When he spoke again, it was after a short breath, as if he had successfully managed some pre-rehearsed speech. 'I've made supper. I'm afraid it's salad again.' He reached past me into the fridge, and pulled out two plates. 'I promise we'll go somewhere for a blowout meal once the Viking is over. Or maybe once I'm on to carb loading. I just ... ' He blew out his cheeks. 'I guess I haven't been able to think about much else lately. I guess that's been part of the problem. And you're right. There's no reason you should follow me about. It's my thing. You have every right to work instead.'

'Patrick ... ' I said.

'I don't want to argue with you, Lou. Forgive me?'

His eyes were anxious and he smelt of cologne. Those two facts descended upon me slowly like a weight.

'Sit down, anyway,' he said. 'Let's eat, and then ... I don't know. Enjoy ourselves. Talk about something else. Not running.' He forced a laugh.

I sat down and looked at the table.

Then I smiled. 'This is really nice,' I said.

Patrick really could do 101 things with turkey breast.

We ate the green salad, the pasta salad and seafood salad and an exotic fruit salad that he had prepared for pudding, and I drank wine while he stuck to mineral water. It took us a while, but we did begin to relax. There, in front of me, was a Patrick I hadn't seen for some time. He was funny, attentive. He policed himself rigidly so that he didn't say anything about running or marathons, and laughed whenever he caught the conversation veering in that direction. I felt his feet meet mine under the table and our legs entwine, and slowly I felt something that had felt tight and uncomfortable begin to ease in my chest.

My sister was right. My life had become strange and disconnected from everyone I knew – Will's plight and his secrets had swamped me. I had to make sure that I didn't lose sight of the rest of me.

I began to feel guilty about the conversation I had had earlier with my sister. Patrick wouldn't let me get up, not even to help him clear the dishes. At a quarter past eleven he rose and moved the plates and bowls to the kitchenette and began to load the dishwasher. I sat, listening to him as he talked to me through the little doorway. I was rubbing at the point where my neck met my shoulder, trying to release some of the knots that seemed to be firmly embedded there. I closed my eyes, trying to relax into it, so that it was a few minutes before I realized the conversation had stopped.

I opened my eyes. Patrick was standing in the doorway, holding my holiday folder. He held up several pieces of paper. 'What's all this?'

'It's ... the trip. The one I told you about.'

I watched him flick through the paperwork I had shown my sister, taking in the itinerary, the pictures, the Californian beach.

'I thought ... ' His voice, when it emerged, sounded strangely strangled. 'I thought you were talking about Lourdes.'

'What?'

'Or ... I don't know ... Stoke Mandeville ... or somewhere. I thought, when you said you couldn't come because you had to help him, it was actual work. Physio, or faith healing, or something. This looks like ... ' He shook his head disbelievingly. 'This looks like the holiday of a lifetime.'

'Well ... it kind of is. But not for me. For him.'

Patrick grimaced. 'No ... ' he said, shaking his head. 'You wouldn't enjoy this *at all*. Hot tubs under the stars, swimming with dolphins ... Oh, look, "five-star luxury" and "twenty-four-hour room service".' He looked up at me. 'This isn't a work trip. This is a bloody honeymoon.'

'That's not fair!'

'But this is? You ... you really expect me to just sit here while you swan off with another man on a holiday like *this*?'

'His carer is coming too.'

'Oh. Oh yes, *Nathan*. That makes it all right, then.'

'Patrick, come on – it's complicated.'

'So explain it to me.' He thrust the papers towards me. 'Explain this to me, Lou. Explain it in a way that I can possibly understand.'

'It matters to me that Will wants to live, that he sees good things in his future.'

'And those good things would include you?'

'That's not fair. Look, have I ever asked you to stop doing the job you love?'

'My job doesn't involve hot tubs with strange men.'

'Well, I don't mind if it does. You can have hot tubs with strange men! As often as you like! There!' I tried to smile, hoping he would too.

But he wasn't having any of it. 'How would you feel, Lou? How would you feel if I said I was going on some keep-fit convention with – I don't know – Leanne from the Terrors because she needed cheering up?'

‘Cheering up?’ I thought of Leanne, with her flicky blonde hair and her perfect legs, and I wondered absently why he had thought of her name first.

‘And then how would you feel if I said she and I were going to eat out together all the time, and maybe sit in a hot tub or go on days out together. In some destination six thousand miles away, just because she had been a bit down. That really wouldn’t bother you?’

‘He’s not “a bit down”, Pat. He wants to kill himself. He wants to take himself off to Dignitas, and end his own bloody life.’ I could hear my blood thumping in my ears. ‘And you can’t turn it around like this. You were the one who called Will a cripple. You were the one who made out he couldn’t possibly be a threat to you. “The perfect boss,” you said. Someone not even worth worrying about.’

He put the folder back down on the worktop.

‘Well, Lou ... I’m worrying now.’

I sank my face into my hands and let it rest there for a minute. Out in the corridor I heard a fire door swing, and the voices of people swallowed up as a door was unlocked and closed behind them.

Patrick slid his hand slowly backwards and forwards along the edge of the kitchen cabinets. A little muscle worked in his jaw. ‘You know how this feels, Lou? It feels like I might be running, but I feel like I’m permanently just a little bit behind the rest of the field. I feel like ... ’ He took a deep breath, as if he were trying to compose himself. ‘I feel like there’s something bad on the bend around the corner, and everyone else seems to know what it is except me.’

He lifted his eyes to mine. ‘I don’t think I’m being unreasonable. But I don’t want you to go. I don’t care if you don’t want to do the Viking, but I don’t want you to go on this ... this holiday. With him.’

‘But I –’

‘Nearly seven years, we’ve been together. And you’ve known this man, had this job, for five months. Five months. If you go with him now, you’re telling me something about our relationship. About how you feel about us.’

‘That’s not fair. It doesn’t have to say anything about us,’ I protested.

‘It does if I can say all this and you’re still going to go.’

The little flat seemed so still around us. He was looking at me with an expression I had never seen before.

When my voice emerged, it did so as a whisper. ‘But he needs me.’

I realized almost as soon as I said it, heard the words and how they twisted and regrouped in the air, knew already how I would have felt if he had said the same to me.

He swallowed, shook his head a little as if he were having trouble taking in what I said. His hand came to rest on the side of the worktop, and then he looked up at me.

‘Whatever I say isn’t going to make a difference, is it?’

That was the thing about Patrick. He always was smarter than I gave him credit for.

‘Patrick, I –’

He closed his eyes, just for a moment, and then he turned and walked out of the living room, leaving the last of the empty dishes on the sideboard.



21

Steven

The girl moved in at the weekend. Will didn't say anything to Camilla or me, but I walked into the annexe on Saturday morning still in my pyjamas to see if Will needed any help, as Nathan was delayed, and there she was, walking up the hallway with a bowlful of cereal in one hand and the newspaper in the other. She blushed when she saw me. I don't know why – I was wearing my dressing gown, all perfectly decent. I remember thinking afterwards that there had been a time when it had been perfectly normal to find pretty young things creeping out of Will's bedroom in the morning.

'Just bringing Will his post,' I said, waving it.

'He's not up yet. Do you want me to give him a shout?' Her hand went to her chest, shielding herself with the newspaper. She was wearing a Minnie Mouse T-shirt and the kind of embroidered trousers you used to see Chinese women wearing in Hong Kong.

'No, no. Not if he's sleeping. Let him rest.'

When I told Camilla, I thought she'd be pleased. She had been so wretchedly cross about the girl moving in with her boyfriend, after all. But she just looked a bit surprised, and then adopted that tense expression which meant she was already imagining all sorts of possible and undesirable consequences. She didn't say as much, but I was pretty sure she was not keen on Louisa Clark. That said, I didn't know who it was Camilla

approved of these days. Her default setting seemed to be stuck on Disapprove.

We never got to the bottom of what had prompted Louisa to stay – Will just said ‘family issues’ – but she was a busy little thing. When she wasn’t looking after Will, she was dashing around, cleaning and washing, whizzing backwards and forwards to the travel agent’s and to the library. I would have known her anywhere in town because she was so conspicuous. She wore the brightest-coloured clothing of anyone I’d seen outside the tropics – little jewel-hued dresses and strange-looking shoes.

I would have said to Camilla that she brightened the place up. But I couldn’t make that sort of remark to Camilla any more.

Will had apparently told her that she could use his computer, but she refused, in favour of using those at the library. I don’t know if she was afraid of being seen to be taking advantage, or if it was because she didn’t want him to see whatever it was that she was doing.

Whichever it was, Will seemed a little happier when she was around. A couple of times I heard their conversations filtering through my open window, and I’m sure I heard Will laugh. I spoke to Bernard Clark, just to make sure he was quite happy with the arrangement, and he said it was a bit tricky as she had split up with her long-term boyfriend, and all sorts of things seemed to be up in the air at their home. He also mentioned that she had applied for some conversion course to continue her education. I decided not to tell Camilla about that one. I didn’t want her to think what that might mean. Will said she was into fashion and that sort of thing. She was certainly easy on the eye, and had a lovely figure – but, honestly, I wasn’t sure who on earth would buy the kinds of things she wore.

On Monday evening, she asked if Camilla and I would come with Nathan into the annexe. She had laid out the table with brochures, printed timetables, insurance documents and other things that she’d printed off the internet. There were copies for each of us, in clear plastic folders. It was all terribly organized.

She wanted, she said, to present us with her plans for a holiday. (She had warned Camilla that she would make it sound like she was the one gleaning all the benefit, but I could still see Camilla’s eyes grow a little steely as she detailed all the things she had booked for them.)

It was an extraordinary trip that seemed to involve all sorts of unusual activities, things I couldn’t imagine Will doing even before his accident.

But every time she mentioned something – white-water rafting, or bungee jumping or what have you – she would hold up a document in front of Will, showing other injured young men taking part, and say, ‘If I’m going to try all these things you keep saying I should, then you have to do them with me.’

I have to admit, I was secretly rather impressed by her. She was a resourceful little thing.

Will listened to her, and I could see him reading the documents she laid out in front of him.

‘Where did you find all this information?’ he said, finally.

She raised her eyebrows at him. ‘Knowledge is power, Will,’ she said.

And my son smiled, as if she had said something particularly clever.

‘So ...’ Louisa said, when all the questions had been asked. ‘We will be leaving in eight days’ time. Are you happy, Mrs Traynor?’ There was a faint air of defiance in the way she said it, as if she were daring Camilla to say no.

‘If that’s what you all want to do, then it’s quite all right by me,’ Camilla said.

‘Nathan? Are you still up for it?’

‘You bet.’

‘And ... Will?’

We all looked at him. There was a time, not that long ago, when any one of these activities would have been unthinkable. There was a time when Will would have taken pleasure in saying no just to upset his mother. He had always been like that, our son – quite capable of doing the opposite of what was right, simply because he didn’t want to be seen to be complying, in some way. I don’t know where it came from, this urge to subvert. Perhaps it was what made him such a brilliant negotiator.

He looked up at me, his eyes unreadable, and I felt my jaw tense. And then he looked at the girl, and smiled.

‘Why not?’ he said. ‘I’m quite looking forward to seeing Clark throw herself into some rapids.’

The girl seemed to physically deflate a little – with relief – as if she had half expected him to say no.

It’s funny – I admit, when she first wound her way into our lives I was a little suspicious of her. Will, despite all his bluster, had been vulnerable. I was a little afraid that he could be manipulated. He’s a wealthy young man,

despite it all, and that wretched Alicia running off with his friend had made him feel about as worthless as anyone in his position could feel.

But I saw the way Louisa looked at him then, a strange mixture of pride and gratitude on her face, and I was suddenly immensely glad that she was there. My son, although we never said as much, was in the most untenable of situations. Whatever it was she was doing, it seemed to be giving him just a small respite from that.

There was, for a few days, a faint but definitely celebratory air in the house. Camilla wore an air of quiet hopefulness, although she refused to admit to me that that was what it was. I knew her subtext: what did we really have to celebrate, when all was said and done? I heard her on the telephone to Georgina late at night, justifying what she had agreed to. Her mother's daughter, Georgina, she was already looking for any way in which Louisa might have used Will's situation to advantage herself.

'She offered to pay for herself, Georgina,' Camilla said. And, 'No, darling. I don't really think we have a choice. We have very little time and Will has agreed to it, so I'm just going to hope for the best. I think you really have to do the same now.'

I knew what it cost her to defend Louisa, to even be nice to her. But she tolerated that girl because she knew, as I did, that Louisa was our only chance of keeping our son even halfway happy.

Louisa Clark had become, although neither of us said it, our only chance of keeping him alive.

I went for a drink with Della last night. Camilla was visiting her sister, so we went for a walk down by the river on the way back.

'Will's going to take a holiday,' I said.

'How wonderful,' she replied.

Poor Della. I could see her fighting her instinctive urge to ask me about our future – to consider how this unexpected development might affect it – but I didn't suppose she ever would. Not until this was all resolved.

We walked, watching the swans, smiling at the tourists splashing around in their boats in the early evening sun, and she chatted away about how this might all be actually rather wonderful for Will, and probably showed that he was really learning to adapt to his situation. It was a sweet thing for her to say as I knew that, in some respects, she might legitimately have hoped for an end to it all. It was Will's accident that had so curtailed our plans for a

life together, after all. She must have secretly hoped that my responsibilities towards Will would one day end so that I could be free.

And I walked along beside her, feeling her hand resting in the crook of my arm, listening to her sing-song voice. I couldn't tell her the truth – the truth that just a handful of us knew. That if the girl failed with her ranches and her bungee jumping and hot tubs and what have you, she would paradoxically be setting me free. Because the only way I would ever be able to leave my family was if Will decided, after all, that he was still determined to go to this infernal place in Switzerland.

I knew it, and Camilla knew it. Even if neither of us would admit it to ourselves. Only on my son's death would I be free to live the life of my choosing.

'Don't,' she said, catching my expression.

Dear Della. She could tell what I was thinking, even when I didn't know myself.

'It's good news, Steven. Really. You never know, this might be the start of a whole new independent life for Will.'

I placed my hand over hers. A braver man might have told her what I really thought. A braver man would have let her go long ago – her, and maybe even my wife too.

'You're right,' I said, forcing a smile. 'Let's hope he comes back full of tales of bungee ropes or whatever horror it is the young people like to inflict upon each other.'

She nudged me. 'He might make you put one up in the castle.'

'White-water rafting in the moat?' I said. 'I shall file it away as a possible attraction for next summer's season.'

Sustained by this unlikely picture, we walked, occasionally chuckling, all the way down to the boathouse.

And then Will got pneumonia.



22

I ran into Accident and Emergency. The sprawling layout of the hospital and my natural lack of any kind of internal compass meant that the critical-care ward took me forever to find. I had to ask three times before someone pointed me in the right direction. I finally swung open the doors to Ward C12, breathless and gasping, and there, in the corridor, was Nathan, sitting reading a newspaper. He looked up as I approached him.

‘How is he?’

‘On oxygen. Stable.’

‘I don’t understand. He was fine on Friday night. He had a bit of a cough Saturday morning, but ... but this? What happened?’

My heart was racing. I sat down for a moment, trying to catch my breath. I had been running pretty much since I received Nathan’s text message an hour previously. He sat up, and folded his newspaper.

‘It’s not the first time, Lou. He gets a bit of bacteria in his lungs, his cough mechanism doesn’t work like it should, he goes down pretty fast. I tried to do some clearing techniques on him Saturday afternoon but he was in too much pain. He got a fever out of nowhere, then he got a stabbing pain in his chest. We had to call an ambulance Saturday night.’

‘Shit,’ I said, bending over. ‘Shit, shit, shit. Can I go in?’

‘He’s pretty groggy. Not sure you’ll get much out of him. And Mrs T is with him.’

I left my bag with Nathan, cleaned my hands with antibacterial lotion, then pushed at the door and entered.

Will was in the middle of the hospital bed, his body covered with a blue blanket, wired up to a drip and surrounded by various intermittently beeping machines. His face was partially obscured by an oxygen mask and his eyes were closed. His skin looked grey, tinged with a blue-whiteness which made something in me constrict. Mrs Traynor sat next to him, one hand resting on his covered arm. She was staring, unseeing, at the wall opposite.

‘Mrs Traynor,’ I said.

She glanced up with a start. ‘Oh. Louisa.’

‘How ... how is he doing?’ I wanted to go and take Will’s other hand, but I didn’t feel like I could sit down. I hovered there by the door. There was an expression of such dejection on her face that even to be in the room felt like intruding.

‘A bit better. They have him on some very strong antibiotics.’

‘Is there ... anything I can do?’

‘I don’t think so, no. We ... we just have to wait. The consultant will be making his rounds in an hour or so. He’ll be able to give us more information, hopefully.’

The world seemed to have stopped. I stood there a little longer, letting the steady beep of the machines burn a rhythm into my consciousness.

‘Would you like me to take over for a while? So you can have a break?’

‘No. I think I’ll stay, actually.’

A bit of me was hoping that Will would hear my voice. A bit of me was hoping his eyes would open above that clear plastic mask, and he would mutter, ‘Clark. Come and sit down for God’s sake. You’re making the place look untidy.’

But he just lay there.

I wiped at my face with a hand. ‘Would ... would you like me to get you a drink?’

Mrs Traynor looked up. ‘What time is it?’

‘A quarter to ten.’

‘Is it really?’ She shook her head, as if she found that hard to believe.

‘Thank you, Louisa. That would be ... that would be very kind. I seem to have been here rather a long time.’

I had been off on Friday – in part because the Traynors insisted I was owed a day off, but mostly because there was no way I could get a passport other than heading to London on the train and queuing up at Petty France. I

had popped by their house on Friday night, on my return, to show Will my spoils and to make sure his own passport was still valid. I thought he had been a little quiet, but there had been nothing particularly unusual in that. Some days he was in more discomfort than others. I had assumed it was one of those days. If I'm honest, my mind was so full of our travel plans that I didn't have a lot of room to think about anything else.

I spent Saturday morning picking up my belongings from Patrick's house with Dad, and then I went shopping in the high street with Mum in the afternoon to pick up a swimsuit and some holiday necessities, and I stayed over at my parents' house Saturday and Sunday nights. It was a tight squeeze, with Treena and Thomas there as well. On Monday morning I got up at 7, ready to be at the Traynors' by 8am. I arrived there to find the whole place closed up, the front and back doors locked. There was no note. I stood under the front porch and rang Nathan's phone three times without an answer. Mrs Traynor's phone was set to voicemail. Finally, as I sat on the steps for forty-five minutes, Nathan's text arrived.

We are at county hospital. Will has pneumonia. Ward C12.

Nathan left, and I sat outside Will's room for a further hour. I flicked through the magazines that somebody had apparently left on the table in 1982, and then pulled a paperback from my bag and tried to read that, but it was impossible to concentrate.

The consultant came round, but I didn't feel that I could follow him in while Will's mother was in there. When he emerged, fifteen minutes later, Mrs Traynor came out behind him. I'm not sure if she told me simply because she had to talk to somebody, and I was the only person available, but she said in a voice thick with relief that the consultant was fairly confident that they had got the infection under control. It had been a particularly virulent bacterial strain. It was lucky that Will had gone to hospital when he had. Her 'or ...' hung in the silence between us.

'So what do we do now?' I said.

She shrugged. 'We wait.'

'Would you like me to get you some lunch? Or perhaps I could sit with Will while you go and get some?'

Just occasionally, something like understanding passed between me and Mrs Traynor. Her face softened briefly and – without that customary, rigid

expression – I could see suddenly how desperately tired she looked. I think she had aged ten years in the time that I had been with them.

‘Thank you, Louisa,’ she said. ‘I would very much like to nip home and change my clothes, if you wouldn’t mind staying with him. I don’t really want Will to be left alone right now.’

After she’d gone I went in, closing the door behind me, and sat down beside him. He seemed curiously absent, as if the Will I knew had gone on a brief trip somewhere else and left only a shell. I wondered, briefly, if that was how it was when people died. Then I told myself to stop thinking about death.

I sat and watched the clock tick and heard the occasional murmuring voices outside and the soft squeak of shoes on the linoleum. Twice a nurse came in and checked various levels, pressed a couple of buttons, took his temperature, but still Will didn’t stir.

‘He is ... okay, isn’t he?’ I asked her.

‘He’s asleep,’ she said, reassuringly. ‘It’s probably the best thing for him right now. Try not to worry.’

It’s an easy thing to say. But I had a lot of time to think, in that hospital room. I thought about Will and the frightening speed with which he had become dangerously ill. I thought about Patrick, and the fact that even as I had collected my things from his flat, unpeeled and rolled up my wall calendar, folded and packed the clothes I had laid so carefully in his chest of drawers, my sadness was never the crippling thing I should have expected. I didn’t feel desolate, or overwhelmed, or any of the things you should feel when you split apart a love of several years. I felt quite calm, and a bit sad and perhaps a little guilty – both at my part in the split, and the fact that I didn’t feel the things I probably should. I had sent him two text messages, to say I was really, really sorry, and that I hoped he would do really well in the Xtreme Viking. But he hadn’t replied.

After an hour, I leant over, lifted the blanket from Will’s arm, and there, pale brown against the white sheet, lay his hand. A cannula was taped to the back of it with surgical tape. When I turned it over, the scars were still livid on his wrists. I wondered, briefly, if they would ever fade, or if he would be permanently reminded of what he had tried to do.

I took his fingers gently in mine and closed my own around them. They were warm, the fingers of someone very much living. I was so oddly reassured by how they felt in my own that I kept them there, gazing at them,

at the calluses that told of a life not entirely lived behind a desk, at the pink seashell nails that would always have to be trimmed by somebody else.

Will's were good man's hands – attractive and even, with squared-off fingers. It was hard to look at them and believe that they held no strength, that they would never again pick something up from a table, stroke an arm or make a fist.

I traced his knuckles with my finger. Some small part of me wondered whether I should be embarrassed if Will opened his eyes at this point, but I couldn't feel it. I felt with some certainty that it was good for him to have his hand in mine. Hoping that in some way, through the barrier of his drugged sleep, he knew this too, I closed my eyes and waited.

Will finally woke up shortly after four. I was outside in the corridor, lying across the chairs, reading a discarded newspaper, and I jumped when Mrs Traynor came out to tell me. She looked a little lighter when she mentioned he was talking, and that he wanted to see me. She said she was going to go downstairs and ring Mr Traynor.

And then, as if she couldn't quite help herself, she added, 'Please don't tire him.'

'Of course not,' I said.

My smile was charming.

'Hey,' I said, peeping my head round the door.

He turned his face slowly towards me. 'Hey, yourself.'

His voice was hoarse, as if he had spent the past thirty-six hours not sleeping but shouting. I sat down and looked at him. His eyes flickered downwards.

'You want me to lift the mask for a minute?'

He nodded. I took it and carefully slid it up over his head. There was a fine film of moisture where it had met his skin, and I took a tissue and wiped gently around his face.

'So how are you feeling?'

'Been better.'

A great lump had risen, unbidden, to my throat, and I tried to swallow it. 'I don't know. You'll do anything for attention, Will Traynor. I bet this was all just a –'

He closed his eyes, cutting me off in mid-sentence. When he opened them again, they held a hint of an apology. 'Sorry, Clark. I don't think I can

do witty today.'

We sat. And I talked, letting my voice rattle away in the little pale-green room, telling him about getting my things back from Patrick's – how much easier it had been getting my CDs out of his collection, given his insistence on a proper cataloguing system.

'You okay?' he said, when I had finished. His eyes were sympathetic, like he expected it to hurt more than it actually did.

'Yeah. Sure.' I shrugged. 'It's really not so bad. I've got other things to think about anyway.'

Will was silent. 'The thing is,' he said, eventually, 'I'm not sure I'm going to be bungee jumping any time soon.'

I knew it. I had half expected this ever since I had first received Nathan's text. But hearing the words fall from his mouth felt like a blow.

'Don't worry,' I said, trying to keep my voice even. 'It's fine. We'll go some other time.'

'I'm sorry. I know you were really looking forward to it.'

I placed a hand on his forehead, and smoothed his hair back. 'Shh. Really. It's not important. Just get well.'

He closed his eyes with a faint wince. I knew what they said – those lines around his eyes, that resigned expression. They said there wasn't necessarily going to be another time. They said he thought he would never be well again.

I stopped off at Granta House on the way back from the hospital. Will's father let me in, looking almost as tired as Mrs Traynor. He was carrying a battered wax jacket, as if he were just on his way out. I told him Mrs Traynor was with Will again, and that the antibiotics were considered to be working well, but that she had asked me to let him know that she would be spending the night at the hospital again. Why she couldn't tell him herself, I don't know. Perhaps she just had too much to think about.

'How does he look?'

'Bit better than this morning,' I said. 'He had a drink while I was there. Oh, and he said something rude about one of the nurses.'

'Still his impossible self.'

'Yeah, still his impossible self.'

Just for a moment I saw Mr Traynor's mouth compress and his eyes glisten. He looked away at the window and then back at me. I didn't know

whether he would have preferred it if I'd looked away.

'Third bout. In two years.'

It took me a minute to catch up. 'Of pneumonia?'

He nodded. 'Wretched thing. He's pretty brave, you know. Under all that bluster.' He swallowed and nodded, as if to himself. 'It's good you can see it, Louisa.'

I didn't know what to do. I reached out a hand and touched his arm. 'I do see it.'

He gave me a faint nod, then took his panama hat from the coat hooks in the hall. Muttering something that might have been a thank you or a goodbye, Mr Traynor moved past me and out of the front door.

The annexe felt oddly silent without Will in it. I realized how much I had become used to the distant sound of his motorized chair moving backwards and forwards, his murmured conversations with Nathan in the next room, the low hum of the radio. Now the annexe was still, the air like a vacuum around me.

I packed an overnight bag of all the things he might want the next day, including clean clothes, his toothbrush, hairbrush and medication, plus earphones in case he was well enough to listen to music. As I did so I had to fight a peculiar and rising feeling of panic. A subversive little voice kept rising up inside me, saying, *This is how it would feel if he were dead*. To drown it out, I turned on the radio, trying to bring the annexe back to life. I did some cleaning, made Will's bed with fresh sheets and picked some flowers from the garden, which I put in the living room. And then, when I had got everything ready, I glanced over and saw the holiday folder on the table.

I would spend the following day going through all the paperwork and cancelling every trip, every excursion I had booked. There was no saying when Will would be well enough to do any of them. The consultant had stressed that he had to rest, to complete his course of antibiotics, to stay warm and dry. White-water rafting and scuba diving were not part of his plan for convalescence.

I stared at my folders, at all the effort and work and imagination that had gone into compiling them. I stared at the passport that I had queued to collect, remembering my mounting sense of excitement even as I sat on the train heading into the city, and for the first time since I had embarked upon my plan, I felt properly despondent. There were just over three weeks to go,

and I had failed. My contract was due to end, and I had done nothing to noticeably change Will's mind. I was afraid to even ask Mrs Traynor where on earth we went from here. I felt suddenly overwhelmed. I dropped my head into my hands and, in the silent little house, I left it there.

'Evening.'

My head shot up. Nathan was standing there, filling the little kitchen with his bulk. He had his backpack over his shoulder.

'I just came to drop off some prescription meds for when he gets back. You ... okay?'

I wiped briskly at my eyes. 'Sure. Sorry. Just ... just a little daunted about cancelling this lot.'

Nathan swung his backpack off his shoulder and sat down opposite me. 'It's a pisser, that's for sure.' He picked up the folder, and began flicking through. 'You want a hand tomorrow? They don't want me at the hospital, so I could stop by for an hour in the morning. Help you put in the calls.'

'That's kind of you. But no. I'll be fine. Probably simpler if I do it all.'

Nathan made tea, and we sat opposite each other and drank it. I think it was the first time Nathan and I had really talked to each other – at least, without Will between us. He told me about a previous client of his, C3/4 quadriplegic with a ventilator, who had been ill at least once a month for the whole time he worked there. He told me about Will's previous bouts of pneumonia, the first of which had nearly killed him, and from which it had taken him weeks to recover.

'He gets this look in his eye ... ' he said. 'When he's really sick. It's pretty scary. Like he just ... retreats. Like he's almost not even there.'

'I know. I hate that look.'

'He's a –' he began. And then, abruptly, his eyes slid away from me and he closed his mouth.

We sat holding our mugs. From the corner of my eye I studied Nathan, looking at his friendly open face that seemed briefly to have closed off. And I realized I was about to ask a question to which I already knew the answer.

'You know, don't you?'

'Know what?'

'About ... what he wants to do.'

The silence in the room was sudden and intense.

Nathan looked at me carefully, as if weighing up how to reply.

‘I know,’ I said. ‘I’m not meant to, but I do. That’s what ... that’s what the holiday was meant to be about. That’s what the outings were all about. Me trying to change his mind.’

Nathan put his mug on the table. ‘I did wonder,’ he said. ‘You seemed ... to be on a mission.’

‘I was. Am.’

He shook his head, whether to say I shouldn’t give up, or to tell me that nothing could be done, I wasn’t sure.

‘What are we going to do, Nathan?’

It took him a moment or two before he spoke again. ‘You know what, Lou? I really like Will. I don’t mind telling you, I love the guy. I’ve been with him two years now. I’ve seen him at his worst, and I’ve seen him on his good days, and all I can say to you is I wouldn’t be in his shoes for all the money in the world.’

He took a swig of his tea. ‘There have been times when I’ve stayed over and he’s woken up screaming because in his dreams he’s still walking and skiing and doing stuff and just for those few minutes, when his defences are right down and it’s all a bit raw, he literally can’t bear the thought of never doing it again. He can’t bear it. I’ve sat there with him and there is nothing I can say to the guy, nothing that is going to make it any better. He’s been dealt the shittiest hand of cards you can imagine. And you know what? I looked at him last night and I thought about his life and what it’s likely to become ... and although there is nothing I’d like more in the world than for the big guy to be happy, I ... I can’t judge him for what he wants to do. It’s his choice. It should be his choice.’

My breath had started to catch in my throat. ‘But ... that was before. You’ve all admitted that it was before I came. He’s different now. He’s different with me, right?’

‘Sure, but –’

‘But if we don’t have faith that he can feel better, even get better, then how is he supposed to keep the faith that good things might happen?’

Nathan put his mug on the table. He looked straight into my eyes.

‘Lou. He’s not going to get better.’

‘You don’t know that.’

‘I do. Unless there is some massive breakthrough in stem cell research, Will is looking at another decade in that chair. Minimum. He knows it, even if his folks don’t want to admit it. And this is half the trouble. She wants to

keep him alive at any cost. Mr T thinks there is a point where we have to let him decide.'

'Of course he gets to decide, Nathan. But he has to see what his actual choices are.'

'He's a bright guy. He knows exactly what his choices are.'

My voice lifted in the little room. 'No. You're wrong. You tell me he was in the same place before I came. You tell me he hasn't changed his outlook even a little bit just through me being here.'

'I can't see inside his head, Lou.'

'You know I've changed the way he thinks.'

'No, I know that he will do pretty much anything to make you happy.'

I stared at him. 'You think he's going through the motions just to keep me happy?' I felt furious with Nathan, furious with them all. 'So if you don't believe any of this can do any good, why were you going to come at all? Why did you even want to come on this trip? Just a nice holiday, was it?'

'No. I want him to live.'

'But –'

'But I want him to live if *he* wants to live. If he doesn't, then by forcing him to carry on, you, me – no matter how much we love him – we become just another shitty bunch of people taking away his choices.'

Nathan's words reverberated into the silence. I wiped a solitary tear from my cheek and tried to make my heart rate return to normal. Nathan, apparently embarrassed by my tears, scratched absently at his neck, and then, after a minute, silently handed me a piece of kitchen roll.

'I can't just let it happen, Nathan.'

He said nothing.

'I can't.'

I stared at my passport, sitting on the kitchen table. It was a terrible picture. It looked like someone else entirely. Someone whose life, whose way of being, might actually be nothing like my own. I stared at it, thinking.

'Nathan?'

'What?'

'If I could fix some other kind of trip, something the doctors would agree to, would you still come? Would you still help me?'

'Course I would.' He stood, rinsed his mug and hauled his backpack over his shoulder. He turned to face me before he left the kitchen. 'But I've got

to be honest, Lou. I'm not sure even you are going to be able to pull this one off.'



23

Exactly ten days later, Will's father disgorged us from the car at Gatwick Airport, Nathan wrestling our luggage on to a trolley, and me checking and checking again that Will was comfortable – until even he became irritated.

'Take care of yourselves. And have a good trip,' Mr Traynor said, placing a hand on Will's shoulder. 'Don't get up to too much mischief.' He actually winked at me when he said this.

Mrs Traynor hadn't been able to leave work to come too. I suspected that actually meant she hadn't wanted to spend two hours in a car with her husband.

Will nodded but said nothing. He had been disarmingly quiet in the car, gazing out of the window with his impenetrable stare, ignoring Nathan and me as we chatted about traffic and what we already knew we had forgotten.

Even as we walked across the concourse I wasn't sure we were doing the right thing. Mrs Traynor had not wanted him to go at all. But from the day he agreed to my revised plan, I knew she had been afraid to tell him he shouldn't. She seemed to be afraid of talking to us at all that last week. She sat with Will in silence, talking only to the medical professionals. Or busied herself in her garden, cutting things down with frightening efficiency.

'The airline is meant to meet us. They're meant to come and meet us,' I said, as we made our way to the check-in desk, flicking through my paperwork.

'Chill out. They're hardly going to post someone at the doors,' Nathan said.

‘But the chair has to travel as a “fragile medical device”. I checked with the woman on the phone three times. And we need to make sure they’re not going to get funny about Will’s on-board medical equipment.’

The online quad community had given me reams of information, warnings, legal rights and checklists. I had subsequently triple-checked with the airline that we would be given bulkhead seats, and that Will would be boarded first, and not moved from his power chair until we were actually at the gates. Nathan would remain on the ground, remove the joystick and turn it to manual, and then carefully tie and bolster the chair, securing the pedals. He would personally oversee its loading to protect against damage. It would be pink-tagged to warn luggage handlers of its extreme delicacy. We had been allocated three seats in a row so that Nathan could complete any medical assistance that Will needed without prying eyes. The airline had assured me that the armrests lifted so that we wouldn’t bruise Will’s hips while transferring him from the wheelchair to his aircraft seat. We would keep him between us at all times. And we would be the first allowed off the aircraft.

All this was on my ‘airport’ checklist. That was the sheet in front of my ‘hotel’ checklist but behind my ‘day before we leave’ checklist and the itinerary. Even with all these safeguards in place, I felt sick.

Every time I looked at Will I wondered if I had done the right thing. Will had only been cleared by his GP for travel the night before. He ate little and spent much of every day asleep. He seemed not just weary from his illness, but exhausted with life, tired of our interference, our upbeat attempts at conversation, our relentless determination to try to make things better for him. He tolerated me, but I got the feeling that he often wanted to be left alone. He didn’t know that this was the one thing I could not do.

‘There’s the airline woman,’ I said, as a uniformed girl with a bright smile and a clipboard walked briskly towards us.

‘Well, she’s going to be a lot of use on transfer,’ Nathan muttered. ‘She doesn’t look like she could lift a frozen prawn.’

‘We’ll manage,’ I said. ‘Between us, we will manage.’

It had become my catchphrase, ever since I had worked out what I wanted to do. Since my conversation with Nathan in the annexe, I had been filled with a renewed zeal to prove them all wrong. Just because we couldn’t do the holiday I’d planned did not mean that Will could not do anything at all.

I hit the message boards, firing out questions. Where might be a good place for a far weaker Will to convalesce? Did anyone else know where we could go? Temperature was my main consideration – the English climate was too changeable (there was nothing more depressing than an English seaside resort in the rain). Much of Europe was too hot in late July, ruling out Italy, Greece, the South of France and other coastal areas. I had a vision, you see. I saw Will, relaxing by the sea. The problem was, with only a few days to plan it and go, there was a diminishing chance of making it a reality.

There were commiserations from the others, and many, many stories about pneumonia. It seemed to be the spectre that haunted them all. There were a few suggestions as to places we could go, but none that inspired me. Or, more importantly, none that I felt Will would be inspired by. I did not want spas, or places where he might see other people in the same position as he was. I didn't really know what I wanted, but I scrolled backwards through the list of their suggestions and knew that nothing was right.

It was Ritchie, that chat-room stalwart, who had come to my aid in the end. The afternoon that Will was released from hospital, he typed:

Give me your email address. Cousin is travel agent. I have got him on the case.

I had rung the number he gave me and spoken to a middle-aged man with a broad Yorkshire accent. When he told me what he had in mind, a little bell of recognition rang somewhere deep in my memory. And within two hours, we had it sorted. I was so grateful to him that I could have cried.

'Think nothing of it, pet,' he said. 'You just make sure that bloke of yours has a good time.'

That said, by the time we left I was almost as exhausted as Will. I had spent days wrangling with the finer requirements of quadriplegic travel, and right up until the morning we left I had not been convinced that Will would be well enough to come. Now, seated with the bags, I gazed at him, withdrawn and pale in the bustling airport, and wondered again if I had been wrong. I had a sudden moment of panic. What if he got ill again? What if he hated every minute, as he had with the horse racing? What if I had misread this whole situation, and what Will needed was not an epic journey, but ten days at home in his own bed?

But we didn't have ten days to spare. This was it. This was my only chance.

‘They’re calling our flight,’ Nathan said, as he strolled back from the duty free. He looked at me, raised an eyebrow, and I took a breath.

‘Okay,’ I replied. ‘Let’s go.’

The flight itself, despite twelve long hours in the air, was not the ordeal I had feared. Nathan proved himself dextrous at doing Will’s routine changes under cover of a blanket. The airline staff were solicitous and discreet, and careful with the chair. Will was, as promised, loaded first, achieved transfer to his seat with no bruising, and then settled in between us.

Within an hour of being in the air I realized that, oddly enough, above the clouds, provided his seat was tilted and he was wedged in enough to be stable, Will was pretty much equal to anyone in the cabin. Stuck in front of a screen, with nowhere to move and nothing to do, there was very little, 30,000 feet up, that separated him from any of the other passengers. He ate and watched a film, and mostly he slept.

Nathan and I smiled cautiously at each other and tried to behave as if this were fine, all good. I gazed out of the window, my thoughts as jumbled as the clouds beneath us, unable yet to think about the fact that this was not just a logistical challenge but an adventure for me – that I, Lou Clark, was actually headed to the other side of the world. I couldn’t see it. I couldn’t see anything beyond Will by then. I felt like my sister, when she had first given birth to Thomas. ‘It’s like I’m looking through a funnel,’ she had said, gazing at his newborn form. ‘The world has just shrunk to me and him.’

She had texted me when I was in the airport.

You can do this. Am bloody proud of you xxx

I called it up now, just to look at it, feeling suddenly emotional, perhaps because of her choice of words. Or perhaps because I was tired and afraid and still finding it hard to believe that I had even got us this far. Finally, to block my thoughts, I turned on my little television screen, gazing unseeing at some American comedy series until the skies around us grew dark.

And then I woke to find that the air stewardess was standing over us with breakfast, that Will was talking to Nathan about a film they had just watched together, and that – astonishingly, and against all the odds – the three of us were less than an hour away from landing in Mauritius.

I don’t think I believed that any of this could actually happen until we touched down at Sir Seewoosagar Ramgoolam International Airport. We

emerged groggily through Arrivals, still stiff from our time in the air, and I could have wept with relief at the sight of the operator's specially adapted taxi. That first morning, as the driver sped us towards the resort, I registered little of the island. True, the colours seemed brighter than England, the sky more vivid, an azure blue that just disappeared and grew deeper and deeper to infinity. I saw that the island was lush and green, fringed with acres of sugar cane crops, the sea visible like a strip of mercury through the volcanic hills. The air was tinged with something smoky and gingery, the sun so high in the sky that I had to squint into the white light. In my exhausted state it was as if someone had woken me up in the pages of a glossy magazine.

But even as my senses wrestled with the unfamiliar, my gaze returned repeatedly to Will, to his pale, weary face, to the way his head seemed oddly slumped on his shoulders. And then we pulled into a palm-tree-lined driveway, stopped outside a low framed building and the driver was already out and unloading our bags.

We declined the offer of iced tea, of a tour around the hotel. We found Will's room, dumped his bags, settled him into his bed and almost before we had drawn the curtains, he was asleep again. And then there we were. I had done it. I stood outside his room, finally letting out a deep breath, while Nathan gazed out of the window at the white surf on the coral reef beyond. I don't know if it was the journey, or because this was the most beautiful place I had ever been in my life, but I felt suddenly tearful.

'It's okay,' Nathan said, catching sight of my expression. And then, totally unexpectedly, he walked up to me and enveloped me in a huge bear hug. 'Relax, Lou. It's going to be okay. Really. You did good.'

It was almost three days before I started to believe him. Will slept for most of the first forty-eight hours – and then, astonishingly, he began to look better. His skin regained its colour and he lost the blue shadows around his eyes. His spasms lessened and he began to eat again, wheeling his way slowly along the endless, extravagant buffet and telling me what he wanted on his plate. I knew he was feeling more like himself when he bullied me into trying things I would never have eaten – spicy creole curries and seafood whose name I did not recognize. He swiftly seemed more at home in this place than I did. And no wonder. I had to remind myself that, for most of his life, this had been Will's domain – this globe, these wide shores – not the little annexe in the shadow of the castle.

The hotel had, as promised, come up with the special wheelchair with wide wheels, and most mornings Nathan transferred Will into it and we all three walked down to the beach, me carrying a parasol so that I could protect him if the sun grew too fierce. But it never did; that southern part of the island was renowned for sea breezes and, out of season, the resort temperatures rarely rose past the early twenties. We would stop at a small beach near a rocky outcrop, just out of view of the main hotel. I would unfold my chair, place myself next to Will under a palm tree, and we would watch Nathan attempt to windsurf, or waterski – occasionally shouting encouragement, plus the odd word of abuse – from our spot on the sand.

At first the hotel staff wanted to do almost too much for Will, offering to push his chair, constantly pressing cool drinks upon him. We explained what we didn't need from them, and they cheerfully backed off. It was good, though, during the moments when I wasn't with him, to see porters or reception staff stopping by to chat with him, or sharing with him some place that they thought we should go. There was one gangly young man, Nadil, who seemed to take it upon himself to act as Will's unofficial carer when Nathan was not around. One day I came out to find him and a friend gently lowering Will out of his chair on to a cushioned sunbed he had positioned by 'our' tree.

'This better,' he said, giving me the thumbs up as I walked across the sand. 'You just call me when Mr Will want to go back in his chair.'

I was about to protest, and tell them they should not have moved him. But Will had closed his eyes and lay there with a look of such unexpected contentment that I just closed my mouth and nodded.

As for me, as my anxiety about Will's health began to ebb, I slowly began to suspect that I was actually in paradise. I had never, in my life, imagined I would spend time somewhere like this. Every morning I woke to the sound of the sea breaking gently on the shore, unfamiliar birds calling to each other from the trees. I gazed up at my ceiling, watching the sunlight playing through the leaves, and from next door heard the murmured conversation that told me Will and Nathan had already been up long before me. I dressed in sarongs and swimsuits, enjoying the feeling of the warm sun on my shoulders and back. My skin grew freckled, my nails bleached, and I began to feel a rare happiness at the simple pleasures of existing here – of walking on a beach, eating unfamiliar foods, swimming in warm, clear water where black fish gazed shyly from under volcanic rocks, or watching

the sun sink fiery red into the horizon. Slowly the past few months began to slip away. To my shame, I hardly thought of Patrick at all.

Our days fell into a pattern. We ate breakfast together, all three of us, at the gently shaded tables around the pool. Will usually had fruit salad, which I fed to him by hand, and sometimes followed up with a banana pancake as his appetite grew. We then went down to the beach, where we stayed – me reading, Will listening to music – while Nathan practised his watersport skills. Will kept telling me to try something too, but at first I said no. I just wanted to stay next to him. When Will insisted, I spent one morning windsurfing and kayaking, but I was happiest just hanging around next to him.

Occasionally if Nadil was around, and the resort was quiet, he and Nathan would ease Will into the warm water of the smaller pool, Nathan holding him under his head so that he could float. He didn't say much when they did this, but he looked quietly contented, as if his body were remembering long-forgotten sensations. His torso, long pale, grew golden. His scars silvered and began to fade. He grew comfortable without a shirt.

At lunchtime we would wheel our way over to one of the resort's three restaurants. The surface of the whole complex was tiled, with only a few small steps and slopes, which meant that Will could move in his chair with complete autonomy. It was a small thing, but him being able to get himself a drink without one of us accompanying him meant not so much a rest for me and Nathan as the brief removal of one of Will's daily frustrations – being entirely dependent on other people. Not that any of us had to move much anywhere. It seemed wherever you were, beach or poolside, or even the spa, one of the smiling staff would pop up with some drink they thought you might like, usually decorated with a fragrant pink flower. Even as you lay on the beach, a small buggy would pass, and a smiling waiter would offer you water, fruit juice, or something stronger.

In the afternoons, when the temperatures were at their highest, Will would return to his room and sleep for a couple of hours. I would swim in the pool, or read my book, and then in the evening we would all meet again to eat supper at the beachside restaurant. I swiftly developed a taste for cocktails. Nadil had worked out that if he gave Will the correct size straw and placed a tall glass in his holder, Nathan and I need not be involved at all. As dusk fell, the three of us talked of our childhoods and our first

boyfriends and girlfriends and our first jobs and our families and other holidays we had had, and slowly I saw Will re-emerge.

Except this Will was different. This place seemed to have granted him a peace that had been missing the whole time I had known him.

‘He’s doing good, huh?’ said Nathan, as he met me by the buffet.

‘Yes, I think he is.’

‘You know –’ Nathan leant towards me, reluctant for Will to see we were talking about him ‘– I think the ranch thing and all the adventures would have been great. But looking at him now, I can’t help thinking this place has worked out better.’

I didn’t tell him what I had decided on the first day, when we checked in, my stomach knotted with anxiety, already calculating how many days I had until the return home. I had to try for each of those ten days to forget why we were actually there – the six-month contract, my carefully plotted calendar, everything that had come before. I had to just live in the moment and try to encourage Will to do the same. I had to be happy, in the hope that Will would be too.

I helped myself to another slice of melon, and smiled. ‘So what’s on later? Are we doing the karaoke? Or have your ears not yet recovered from last night?’

On the fourth night, Nathan announced with only faint embarrassment that he had a date. Karen was a fellow Kiwi staying in the next hotel, and he had agreed to go down to the town with her.

‘Just to make sure she’s all right. You know ... I’m not sure if it’s a good place for her to go alone.’

‘No,’ Will said, nodding his head sagely. ‘Very chivalrous of you, Nate.’

‘I think that is a very responsible thing to do. Very civic minded,’ I agreed.

‘I have always admired Nathan for his selflessness. Especially when it comes to the fairer sex.’

‘Piss off, you two,’ Nathan grinned, and disappeared.

Karen swiftly became a fixture. Nathan disappeared with her most evenings and, although he returned for late duties, we tacitly gave him as much time as possible to enjoy himself.

Besides, I was secretly glad. I liked Nathan, and I was grateful that he had come, but I preferred it when it was just Will and I. I liked the

shorthand we seemed to fall into when nobody else was around, the easy intimacy that had sprung up between us. I liked the way he turned his face and looked at me with amusement, like I had somehow turned out to be so much more than he had expected.

On the penultimate night, I told Nathan that I didn't mind if he wanted to bring Karen back to the complex. He had been spending nights in her hotel, and I knew it made it difficult for him, walking the twenty minutes each way in order to sort Will out last thing at night.

'I don't mind. If it will ... you know ... give you a bit of privacy.'

He was cheerful, already lost in the prospect of the night ahead, and didn't give me another thought beyond an enthusiastic, 'Thanks, mate.'

'Nice of you,' said Will, when I told him.

'Nice of you, you mean,' I said. 'It's your room I've donated to the cause.'

That night we got him into mine, and Nathan helped Will into bed and gave him his medication while Karen waited in the bar. In the bathroom I changed into my T-shirt and knickers and then opened the bathroom door and potted over to the sofa with my pillow under my arm. I felt Will's eyes on me, and felt oddly self-conscious for someone who had spent most of the previous week walking around in front of him in a bikini. I plumped my pillow down on the sofa arm.

'Clark?'

'What?'

'You really don't have to sleep over there. This bed is large enough for an entire football team as it is.'

The thing is, I didn't really even think about it. That was how it was, by then. Perhaps the days spent near-naked on the beach had loosened us all up a little. Perhaps it was the thought of Nathan and Karen on the other side of the wall, wrapped up in each other, a cocoon of exclusion. Perhaps I did just want to be near him. I began to walk towards the bed, then flinched at a sudden crash of thunder. The lights stuttered, someone shouted outside. From next door we heard Nathan and Karen burst out laughing.

I walked to the window and pulled back the curtain, feeling the sudden breeze, the abrupt drop in temperature. Out at sea a storm had exploded into life. Dramatic flashes of forked lightning briefly illuminated the sky, and then, as if in afterthought, the heavy drumbeat roll of a deluge hit the roof of our little bungalow, so fierce that at first it drowned out sound.

‘I’d better close the shutters,’ I said.

‘No, don’t.’

I turned.

‘Throw the doors open.’ Will nodded towards the outside. ‘I want to see it.’

I hesitated, then slowly opened the glass doors out on to the terrace. The rain hammered down on to the hotel complex, dripping from our roof, sending rivers running away from our terrace and out towards the sea. I felt the moisture on my face, the electricity in the air. The hairs on my arms stood bolt upright.

‘Can you feel it?’ he said, from behind me.

‘It’s like the end of the world.’

I stood there, letting the charge flow through me, the white flashes imprinting themselves on my eyelids. It caused my breath to catch in my throat.

I turned back, and walked over to the bed, seating myself on its edge. As he watched, I leant forwards and gently pulled his sun-browned neck towards me. I knew just how to move him now, how I could make his weight, his solidity, work with me. Holding him close to me, I leant across and placed a fat white pillow behind his shoulders before releasing him back into its soft embrace. He smelt of the sun, as if it had seeped deep into his skin, and I found myself inhaling silently, as if he were something delicious.

Then, still a little damp, I climbed in beside him, so close that my legs touched his, and together we gazed out at the blue-white scorch as the lightning hit the waves, at the silvered stair rods of rain, the gently shifting mass of turquoise that lay only a hundred feet away.

The world around us shrank, until it was just the sound of the storm, the mauve blue-black sea, and the gently billowing gauze curtains. I smelt the lotus flowers on the night breeze, heard the distant sounds of clinking glasses and hastily drawn-back chairs, of music from some far-off celebration, felt the charge of nature unleashed. I reached across for Will’s hand, and took it in my own. I thought, briefly, that I would never feel as intensely connected to the world, to another human being, as I did at that moment.

‘Not bad, eh, Clark?’ Will said into the silence. In the face of the storm, his face was still and calm. He turned briefly and smiled at me, and there

was something in his eyes then, something triumphant.

‘No,’ I said. ‘Not bad at all.’

I lay still, listening to his breathing slow and deepen, the sound of the rain below it, felt his warm fingers entwined with mine. I did not want to go home. I thought I might never go home. Here Will and I were safe, locked in our little paradise. Every time I thought about heading back to England, a great claw of fear gripped my stomach and began to tighten its hold.

It’s going to be okay. I tried to repeat Nathan’s words to myself. *It’s going to be okay.*

Finally, I turned on to my side, away from the sea, and gazed at Will. He turned his head to look back at me in the dim light, and I felt he was telling me the same thing. *It’s going to be okay.* For the first time in my life I tried not to think about the future. I tried to just be, to simply let the evening’s sensations travel through me. I can’t say how long we stayed like that, just gazing at each other, but gradually Will’s eyelids grew heavier, until he murmured apologetically that he thought he might ... His breathing deepened, he tipped over that small crevasse into sleep, and then it was just me watching his face, looking at the way his eyelashes separated into little points near the corner of his eyes, at the new freckles on his nose.

I told myself I had to be right. I had to be right.

The storm finally blew itself out sometime after 1am, disappearing somewhere out at sea, its flashes of anger growing fainter and then finally disappearing altogether, off to bring meteorological tyranny to some other unseen place. The air slowly grew still around us, the curtains settling, the last of the water draining away with a gurgle. Sometime in the early hours I got up, gently releasing my hand from Will’s, and closed the French windows, muffling the room in silence. Will slept – a sound, peaceful sleep that he rarely slept at home.

I didn’t. I lay there and watched him and I tried to make myself think nothing at all.

Two things happened on the last day. One was that, under pressure from Will, I agreed to try scuba diving. He had been on at me for days, stating that I couldn’t possibly come all this way and not go under the water. I had been hopeless at windsurfing, barely able to lift my sail from the waves, and had spent most of my attempts at water-skiing faceplanting my way along the bay. But he was insistent and, the day before, he arrived back at lunch

announcing that he had booked me in for a half-day beginners' diving course.

It didn't get off to a good start. Will and Nathan sat on the side of the pool as my instructor tried to get me to believe I would continue to breathe underwater, but the knowledge that they were watching me made me hopeless. I'm not stupid – I understood that the oxygen tanks on my back would keep my lungs working, that I was not about to drown – but every time my head went under, I panicked and burst through the surface. It was as if my body refused to believe that it could still breathe underneath several thousand gallons of Mauritius's finest chlorinated.

'I don't think I can do this,' I said, as I emerged for the seventh time, spluttering.

James, my diving instructor, glanced behind me at Will and Nathan.

'I can't,' I said, crossly. 'It's just not me.'

James turned his back on the two men, tapped me on the shoulder and gestured towards the open water. 'Some people actually find it easier out there,' he said quietly.

'In the sea?'

'Some people are better thrown in at the deep end. Come on. Let's go out on the boat.'

Three-quarters of an hour later, I was gazing underwater at the brightly coloured landscape that had been hidden from view, forgetting to be afraid that my oxygen might fail, that against all evidence I would sink to the bottom and die a watery death, even that I was afraid at all. I was distracted by the secrets of a new world. In the silence, broken only by the exaggerated *oosh shoo* of my own breath, I watched shoals of tiny iridescent fish, and larger black and white fish that stared at me with blank, inquisitive faces, with gently swaying anemones filtering the gentle currents of their tiny, unseen haul. I saw distant landscapes, twice as brightly coloured and varied as they were above land. I saw caves and hollows where unknown creatures lurked, distant shapes that shimmered in the rays of the sun. I didn't want to come up. I could have stayed there forever, in that silent world. It was only when James started gesticulating towards the dial of his oxygen tank that I realized I didn't have a choice.

I could barely speak when I finally walked up the beach towards Will and Nathan, beaming. My mind was still humming with the images I had seen, my limbs somehow still propelling me under the water.

‘Good, eh?’ said Nathan.

‘Why didn’t you tell me?’ I exclaimed to Will, throwing my flippers down on the sand in front of him. ‘Why didn’t you make me do that earlier? All that! It was all there, all the time! Just right under my nose!’

Will gazed at me steadily. He said nothing, but his smile was slow and wide. ‘I don’t know, Clark. Some people just won’t be told.’

I let myself get drunk that last night. It wasn’t just that we were leaving the next day. It was the first time I had felt truly that Will was well and that I could let go. I wore a white cotton dress (my skin had coloured now, so that wearing white didn’t automatically make me resemble a corpse wearing a shroud) and a pair of silvery strappy sandals, and when Nadil gave me a scarlet flower and instructed me to put it in my hair I didn’t scoff at him as I might have done a week earlier.

‘Well, hello, Carmen Miranda,’ Will said, when I met them at the bar. ‘Don’t you look glamorous.’

I was about to make some sarcastic reply, and then I realized he was looking at me with genuine pleasure.

‘Thank you,’ I said. ‘You’re not looking too shabby yourself.’

There was a disco at the main hotel complex, so shortly before 10pm – when Nathan left to be with Karen – we headed down to the beach with the music in our ears and the pleasant buzz of three cocktails sweetening my movements.

Oh, but it was so beautiful down there. The night was warm, carrying on its breezes the scents of distant barbecues, of warm oils on skin, of the faint salt tang of the sea. Will and I stopped near our favourite tree. Someone had built a fire on the beach, perhaps for cooking, and all that was left was a pile of glowing embers.

‘I don’t want to go home,’ I said, into the darkness.

‘It’s a hard place to leave.’

‘I didn’t think places like this existed outside films,’ I said, turning so that I faced him. ‘It has actually made me wonder if you might have been telling the truth about all the other stuff.’

He was smiling. His whole face seemed relaxed and happy, his eyes crinkling as he looked at me. I looked at him, and for the first time it wasn’t with a faint fear gnawing away at my insides.

‘You’re glad you came, right?’ I said, tentatively.

He nodded. 'Oh yes.'

'Hah!' I punched the air.

And then, as someone turned the music up by the bar, I kicked off my shoes and I began to dance. It sounds stupid – the kind of behaviour that on another day you might be embarrassed by. But there, in the inky dark, half drunk from lack of sleep, with the fire and the endless sea and infinite sky, with the sounds of the music in our ears and Will smiling and my heart bursting with something I couldn't quite identify, I just needed to dance. I danced, laughing, not self-conscious, not worrying about whether anybody could see us. I felt Will's eyes on me and I knew he knew – that this was the only possible response to the last ten days. Hell, to the last six months.

The song ended, and I flopped, breathless, at his feet.

'You ... ' he said.

'What?' My smile was mischievous. I felt fluid, electrified. I barely felt responsible for myself.

He shook his head.

I rose, slowly, on to my bare feet, walked right up to his chair and then slid on to his lap so that my face was inches from his. After the previous evening, it somehow didn't seem like such a leap to make.

'You' His blue eyes, glinting with the light of the fire, locked on to mine. He smelt of the sun, and the bonfire, and something sharp and citrusy.

I felt something give, deep inside me.

'You ... are something else, Clark.'

I did the only thing I could think of. I leant forward, and I placed my lips on his. He hesitated, just for a moment, and then he kissed me. And just for a moment I forgot everything – the million and one reasons I shouldn't, my fears, the reason we were here. I kissed him, breathing in the scent of his skin, feeling his soft hair under my fingertips, and when he kissed me back all of this vanished and it was just Will and me, on an island in the middle of nowhere, under a thousand twinkling stars.

And then he pulled back. 'I ... I'm sorry. No –'

My eyes opened. I lifted a hand to his face and let it trace his beautiful bones. I felt the faint grit of salt under my fingertips. 'Will ... ' I began.

'You can. You –'

'No.' It held a hint of metal, that word. 'I can't.'

'I don't understand.'

‘I don’t want to go into it.’

‘Um ... I think you have to go into it.’

‘I can’t do this because I can’t ... ’ he swallowed. ‘I can’t be the man I want to be with you. And that means that this –’ he looked up into my face ‘– this just becomes ... another reminder of what I am not.’

I didn’t let go of his face. I tipped my forehead forward so that it touched his, so that our breath mingled, and I said, quietly, so that only he could have heard me, ‘I don’t care what you ... what you think you can and can’t do. It’s not black and white. Honestly ... I’ve talked to other people in the same situation and ... and there are things that are possible. Ways that we can both be happy ... ’ I had begun to stammer a little. I felt weird even having this conversation. I looked up and into his eyes. ‘Will Traynor,’ I said, softly. ‘Here’s the thing. I think we can do –’

‘No, Clark –’ he began.

‘I think we can do all sorts of things. I know this isn’t a conventional love story. I know there are all sorts of reasons I shouldn’t even be saying what I am. But I love you. I do. I knew it when I left Patrick. And I think you might even love me a little bit.’

He didn’t speak. His eyes searched my own, and there was this huge weight of sadness within them. I stroked the hair away from his temples, as if I could somehow lift his sorrow, and he tilted his head to meet the palm of my hand, so that it rested there.

He swallowed. ‘I have to tell you something.’

‘I know,’ I whispered. ‘I know everything.’

Will’s mouth closed on his words. The air seemed to still around us.

‘I know about Switzerland. I know ... why I was employed on a six-month contract.’

He lifted his head away from my hand. He looked at me, then gazed upwards at the skies. His shoulders sagged.

‘I know it all, Will. I’ve known for months. And, Will, please listen to me ...’ I took his right hand in mine, and I brought it up close to my chest. ‘I know we can do this. I know it’s not how you would have chosen it, but I know I can make you happy. And all I can say is that you make me ... you make me into someone I couldn’t even imagine. You make me happy, even when you’re awful. I would rather be with you – even the you that you seem to think is diminished – than with anyone else in the world.’

I felt his fingers tighten a fraction around mine, and it gave me courage.

‘If you think it’s too weird with me being employed by you, then I’ll leave and I’ll work somewhere else. I wanted to tell you – I’ve applied for a college course. I’ve done loads of research on the internet, talking to other quads and carers of quads, and I have learnt so much, so much about how to make this work. So I can do that, and just be with you. You see? I’ve thought of everything, researched everything. This is how I am now. This is your fault. You changed me.’ I was half laughing. ‘You’ve turned me into my sister. But with better dress sense.’

He had closed his eyes. I placed both my hands around his, lifted his knuckles to my mouth, and I kissed them. I felt his skin against mine, and knew as I had never known anything that I could not let him go.

‘What do you say?’ I whispered.

I could have looked into his eyes forever.

He said it so quietly, that for a minute I could not be sure I had heard him correctly.

‘What?’

‘No, Clark.’

‘No?’

‘I’m sorry. It’s not enough.’

I lowered his hand. ‘I don’t understand.’

He waited before he spoke, as if he were struggling, for once, to find the right words. ‘It’s not enough for me. This – my world – even with you in it. And believe me, Clark, my whole life has changed for the better since you came. But it’s not enough for me. It’s not the life I want.’

Now it was my turn to pull away.

‘The thing is, I get that this could be a good life. I get that with you around, perhaps it could even be a very good life. But it’s not *my* life. I am not the same as these people you speak to. It’s nothing like the life I want. Not even close.’ His voice was halting, broken. His expression frightened me.

I swallowed, shaking my head. ‘You ... you once told me that the night in the maze didn’t have to be the thing that defined me. You said I could choose what it was that defined me. Well, you don’t have to let that ... that chair define you.’

‘But it does define me, Clark. You don’t know me, not really. You never saw me before this thing. I loved my life, Clark. Really loved it. I loved my job, my travels, the things I was. I loved being a physical person. I liked

riding my motorbike, hurling myself off buildings. I liked crushing people in business deals. I liked having sex. Lots of sex. I led a *big life*.' His voice had lifted now. 'I am not designed to exist in this thing – and yet for all intents and purposes it is now the thing that defines me. It is the only thing that defines me.'

'But you're not even giving it a chance,' I whispered. My voice didn't seem to want to emerge from my chest. 'You're not giving *me* a chance.'

'It's not a matter of giving you a chance. I've watched you these six months becoming a whole different person, someone who is only just beginning to see her possibilities. You have no idea how happy that has made me. I don't want you to be tied to me, to my hospital appointments, to the restrictions on my life. I don't want you to miss out on all the things someone else could give you. And, selfishly, I don't want you to look at me one day and feel even the tiniest bit of regret or pity that –'

'I would *never* think that!'

'You don't know that, Clark. You have no idea how this would play out. You have no idea how you're going to feel even six months from now. And I don't want to look at you every day, to see you naked, to watch you wandering around the annexe in your crazy dresses and not ... not be able to do what I want with you. Oh, Clark, if you had any idea what I want to do to you right now. And I ... I can't live with that knowledge. I can't. It's not who I am. I can't be the kind of man who just ... *accepts*.'

He glanced down at his chair, his voice breaking. 'I will never accept this.'

I had begun to cry. 'Please, Will. Please don't say this. Just give me a chance. Give us a chance.'

'Sshhh. Just listen. You, of all people. Listen to what I'm saying. This ... tonight ... is the most wonderful thing you could have done for me. What you have told me, what you have done in bringing me here ... knowing that, somehow, from that complete arse I was at the start of this, you managed to salvage something to love is astonishing to me. But –' I felt his fingers close on mine '– I need it to end here. No more chair. No more pneumonia. No more burning limbs. No more pain and tiredness and waking up every morning already wishing it was over. When we get back, I am still going to go to Switzerland. And if you do love me, Clark, as you say you do, the thing that would make me happier than anything is if you would come with me.'

My head whipped back.

‘What?’

‘It’s not going to get any better than this. The odds are I’m only going to get increasingly unwell and my life, reduced as it is, is going to get smaller. The doctors have said as much. There are a host of conditions encroaching on me. I can feel it. I don’t want to be in pain any more, or trapped in this thing, or dependent on everyone, or afraid. So I’m asking you – if you feel the things you say you feel – then do it. Be with me. Give me the end I’m hoping for.’

I looked at him in horror, my blood thumping in my ears. I could barely take it in.

‘How can you ask me that?’

‘I know, it’s –’

‘I tell you I love you and I want to build a future with you, and you ask me to come and watch you kill yourself?’

‘I’m sorry. I don’t mean it to sound blunt. But I haven’t got the luxury of time.’

‘Wha– what? Why, are you actually booked in? Is there some appointment you’re afraid of missing?’

I could see people at the hotel stopping, perhaps hearing our raised voices, but I didn’t care.

‘Yes,’ Will said, after a pause. ‘Yes, there is. I’ve had the consultations. The clinic agreed that I am a suitable case for them. And my parents agreed to the thirteenth of August. We’re due to fly out the day before.’

My head had begun to spin. It was less than a week away.

‘I don’t believe this.’

‘Louisa –’

‘I thought ... I thought I was changing your mind.’

He tilted his head sideways and gazed at me. His voice was soft, his eyes gentle. ‘Louisa, nothing was ever going to change my mind. I promised my parents six months, and that’s what I’ve given them. You have made that time more precious than you can imagine. You stopped it being an endurance test –’

‘Don’t!’

‘What?’

‘Don’t say another word.’ I was choking. ‘You are so selfish, Will. So stupid. Even if there was the remotest possibility of me coming with you to

Switzerland ... even if you thought I might, after all I've done for you, be someone who could do that, is that all you can say to me? I tore my heart out in front of you. And all you can say is, "No, you're not enough for me. And now I want you to come watch the worst thing you can possibly imagine." The thing I have dreaded ever since I first found out about it. Do you have any idea what you are asking of me?'

I was raging now. Standing in front of him, shouting like a madwoman. 'Fuck you, Will Traynor. Fuck you. I wish I'd never taken this stupid job. I wish I'd never met you.' I burst into tears, ran up the beach and back to my hotel room, away from him.

His voice, calling my name, rang in my ears long after I had closed the door.



24

There is nothing more disconcerting to passers-by than to see a man in a wheelchair pleading with a woman who is meant to be looking after him. It's apparently not really the done thing to be angry with your disabled charge.

Especially when he is plainly unable to move, and is saying, gently, 'Clark. Please. Just come over here. *Please.*'

But I couldn't. I couldn't look at him. Nathan had packed up Will's stuff, and I had met them both in the lobby the following morning – Nathan still groggy from his hangover – and from the moment we had to be in each other's company again, I refused to have anything to do with him. I was furious and miserable. There was an insistent, raging voice inside my head, which demanded to be as far as possible from Will. To go home. To never see him again.

'You okay?' Nathan said, appearing at my shoulder.

As soon as we arrived at the airport, I had marched away from them to the check-in desk.

'No,' I said. 'And I don't want to talk about it.'

'Hangover?'

'No.'

There was a short silence.

'This mean what I think it does?' He was suddenly sombre.

I couldn't speak. I nodded, and I watched Nathan's jaw stiffen briefly. He was stronger than I was, though. He was, after all, a professional. Within

minutes he was back with Will, showing him something he had seen in a magazine, wondering aloud about the prospects for some football team they both knew of. Watching them, you would know nothing of the momentousness of the news I had just imparted.

I managed to make myself busy for the entire wait at the airport. I found a thousand small tasks to do – busying myself with luggage labels, buying coffee, perusing newspapers, going to the loo – all of which meant that I didn't have to look at him. I didn't have to talk to him. But every now and then Nathan would disappear and we were left alone, sitting beside each other, the short distance between us jangling with unspoken recriminations.

'Clark –' he would begin.

'Don't,' I would cut him off. 'I don't want to talk to you.'

I surprised myself with how cold I could be. I certainly surprised the air stewardesses. I saw them on the flight, muttering between themselves at the way I turned rigidly away from Will, plugging my earphones in or resolutely staring out of the window.

For once, he didn't get angry. That was almost the worst of it. He didn't get angry, and he didn't get sarcastic, and he simply grew quieter until he barely spoke. It was left to poor Nathan to bounce the conversation along, to ask questions about tea or coffee or spare packets of dry-roasted peanuts or whether anyone minded if he climbed past us to go to the loo.

It probably sounds childish now, but it was not just a matter of pride. I couldn't bear it. I couldn't bear the thought that I would lose him, that he was so stubborn, and determined not to see what was good, what could be good, that he would not change his mind. I couldn't believe that he would stick to that one date, as if it were cast in stone. A million silent arguments rattled around my head. *Why is this not enough for you? Why am I not enough for you? Why could you not have confided in me? If we'd had more time, would this have been different?* Every now and then I would catch myself staring down at his tanned hands, those squared-off fingers, just inches from my own, and I would remember how our fingers felt entwined – the warmth of him, the illusion, even in stillness, of a kind of strength – and a lump would rise in my throat until I thought I could barely breathe and I had to retreat to the WC where I would lean over the sink and sob silently under the strip lighting. There were a few occasions, when I thought about what Will still intended to do, where I actually had to fight the urge to scream; I felt overcome by a kind of madness and thought I might just sit

down in the aisle and howl and howl until someone else stepped in. Until someone else made sure he couldn't do it.

So although I looked childish – although I seemed to the cabin staff (as I declined to talk to Will, to look at him, to feed him) as if I were the most heartless of women – I knew that pretending he was not there was about the only way I could cope with these hours of enforced proximity. If I had believed Nathan capable of coping alone I would honestly have changed my flight, perhaps even disappeared until I could make sure that there was between us a whole continent, not just a few impossible inches.

The two men slept, and it came as something of a relief – a brief respite from the tension. I stared at the television screen and, with every mile that we headed towards home, I felt my heart grow heavier, my anxiety greater. It began to occur to me then that my failure was not just my own; Will's parents were going to be devastated. They would probably blame me. Will's sister would probably sue me. And it was my failure for Will too. I had failed to persuade him. I had offered him everything I could, including myself, and nothing I had shown him had convinced him of a reason to keep living.

Perhaps, I found myself thinking, he had deserved someone better than me. Someone cleverer. Someone like Treena might have thought of better things to do. They might have found some rare piece of medical research or something that could have helped him. They might have changed his mind. The fact that I was going to have to live with this knowledge for the rest of my life made me feel almost dizzy.

'Want a drink, Clark?' Will's voice would break into my thoughts.

'No. Thank you.'

'Is my elbow too far over your armrest?'

'No. It's fine.'

It was only in those last few hours, in the dark, that I allowed myself to look at him. My gaze slid slowly sideways from my glowing television screen until I gazed at him surreptitiously in the dim light of the little cabin. And as I took in his face, so tanned and handsome, so peaceful in sleep, a solitary tear rolled down my cheek. Perhaps in some way conscious of my scrutiny Will stirred, but didn't wake. And unseen by the cabin staff, by Nathan, I pulled his blanket slowly up around his neck, tucking it in carefully, to make sure, in the chill of the cabin air conditioning, that Will would not feel the cold.

They were waiting at the Arrivals Gate. I had somehow known they would be. I had felt the faintly sick sensation expanding inside me even as we wheeled Will through passport control, fast-tracked by some well-meaning official even as I prayed that we would be forced to wait, stuck in a queue that lasted hours, preferably days. But no, we crossed the vast expanse of linoleum, me pushing the baggage trolley, Nathan pushing Will, and as the glass doors opened, there they were, standing at the barrier, side by side in some rare semblance of unity. I saw Mrs Traynor's face briefly light up as she saw Will and I thought, absently, *Of course – he looks so well*. And, to my shame, I put on my sunglasses – not to hide my exhaustion, but so that she wouldn't immediately see from my naked expression what it was I was going to have to tell her.

'Look at you!' she was exclaiming. 'Will, you look wonderful. Really wonderful.'

Will's father had stooped, was patting his son's hair, his knee, his face wreathed in smiles. 'We couldn't believe it when Nathan told us you were down on the beach every day. And swimming! What was the water like, then – lovely and warm? It's been raining cats and dogs here. Typical August!'

Of course. Nathan would have been texting them or calling them. As if they would have let us go all that time without some kind of contact.

'It ... it was a pretty amazing place,' said Nathan. He had grown quiet too, but now tried to smile, to seem his normal self.

I felt frozen, my hand clutching my passport like I was about to go somewhere else. I had to remind myself to breathe.

'Well, we thought you might like a special dinner,' Will's father said. 'There's a jolly nice restaurant at the Intercontinental. Champagne on us. What do you think? Your mother and I thought it might be a nice treat.'

'Sure,' said Will. He was smiling at his mother and she was looking back at him as if she wanted to bottle it. *How can you?* I wanted to yell at him. *How can you look at her like that when you already know what you are going to do to her?*

'Come on, then. I've got the car in disabled parking. It's only a short ride from here. I was pretty sure you'd all be a bit jet-lagged. Nathan, do you want me to take any of those bags?'

My voice broke into the conversation. 'Actually,' I said – I was already pulling my luggage from the trolley – 'I think I'm going to head off. Thank

you, anyway.'

I was focused on my bag, deliberately not looking at them, but even above the hubbub of the airport I could detect the brief silence my words provoked.

Mr Traynor's voice was the first to break it. 'Come on, Louisa. Let's have a little celebration. We want to hear all about your adventures. I want to know all about the island. And I promise you don't have to tell us *everything*.' He almost chuckled.

'Yes.' Mrs Traynor's voice had a faint edge to it. 'Do come, Louisa.'

'No.' I swallowed, tried to raise a bland smile. My sunglasses were a shield. 'Thank you. I'd really rather get back.'

'To where?' said Will.

I realized what he was saying. I didn't really have anywhere to go.

'I'll go to my parents' house. It will be fine.'

'Come with us,' he said. His voice was gentle. 'Don't go, Clark. Please.'

I wanted to cry then. But I knew with utter certainty that I couldn't be anywhere near him. 'No. Thank you. I hope you have a lovely meal.' I hoisted my bag over my shoulder and, before anyone could say anything else, I was walking away from them, swallowed up by the crowds in the terminal.

I was almost at the bus stop when I heard her. Camilla Traynor, her heels clipping on the pavement, half walked, half ran towards me.

'Stop. Louisa. Please stop.'

I turned, and she was forcing her way through a coach party, casting the backpacking teenagers aside like Moses parting the waves. The airport lights were bright on her hair, turning it a kind of copper colour. She was wearing a fine grey pashmina, which draped artistically over one shoulder. I remember thinking absently how beautiful she must have been, only a few years earlier.

'Please. Please stop.'

I stopped, glancing behind me at the road, wishing that the bus would appear now, that it would scoop me up and take me away. That anything would happen. A small earthquake, maybe.

'Louisa?'

'He had a good time.' My voice sounded clipped. Oddly like her own, I found myself thinking.

‘He does look well. Very well.’ She stared at me, standing there on the pavement. She was suddenly acutely still, despite the sea of people moving around her.

We didn’t speak.

And then I said, ‘Mrs Traynor, I’d like to hand in my notice. I can’t ... I can’t do these last few days. I’ll forfeit any money owed to me. In fact, I don’t want this month’s money. I don’t want anything. I just –’

She went pale then. I saw the colour drain from her face, the way she swayed a little in the morning sunshine. I saw Mr Traynor coming up behind her, his stride brisk, one hand holding his panama hat firmly on his head. He was muttering his apologies as he pushed through the crowds, his eyes fixed on me and his wife as we stood rigidly a few feet apart.

‘You ... you said you thought he was happy. You said you thought this might change his mind.’ She sounded desperate, as if she were pleading with me to say something else, to give her some different result.

I couldn’t speak. I stared at her, and the most I could manage was a small shake of my head.

‘I’m sorry,’ I whispered, so quietly that she could not have heard me.

He was almost there as she fell. It was as if her legs just gave way under her, and Mr Traynor’s left arm shot out and caught her as she went down, her mouth a great O, her body slumped against his.

His hat fell to the pavement. He glanced up at me, his face confused, not yet registering what had just taken place.

And I couldn’t look. I turned, numb, and I began to walk, one foot in front of the other, my legs moving almost before I knew what they were doing, away from the airport, not yet even knowing where it was I was going to go.



25

Katrina

Louisa didn't come out of her room for a whole thirty-six hours after she got back from her holiday. She arrived back from the airport late evening on the Sunday, pale as a ghost under her suntan – and we couldn't work that out for a start, as she had definitely said she'd see us first thing Monday morning. *I just need to sleep*, she had said, then shut herself in her room and gone straight to bed. We had thought it a little odd, but what did we know? Lou has been peculiar since birth, after all.

Mum had taken up a mug of tea in the morning, and Lou had not stirred. By supper, Mum had become worried and shaken her, checking she was alive. (She can be a bit melodramatic, Mum – although, to be fair, she had made fish pie and she probably just wanted to make sure Lou wasn't going to miss it.) But Lou wouldn't eat, and she wouldn't talk and she wouldn't come downstairs. *I just want to stay here for a bit, Mum*, she said, into her pillow. Finally, Mum left her alone.

'She's not herself,' said Mum. 'Do you think it's some kind of delayed reaction to the thing with Patrick?'

'She couldn't give a stuff about Patrick,' Dad said. 'I told her he rang to tell us he came 157th in the Viking thing, and she couldn't have looked less interested.' He sipped his tea. 'Mind you, to be fair on her, even I found it pretty hard to get excited about 157th.'

‘Do you think she’s ill? She’s awful pale under that tan. And all that sleeping. It’s just not like her. She might have some terrible tropical disease.’

‘She’s just jet-lagged,’ I said. I said it with some authority, knowing that Mum and Dad tended to treat me as an expert on all sorts of matters that none of us really knew anything about.

‘Jet lag! Well, if that’s what long-haul travel does to you, I think I’ll stick with Tenby. What do you think, Josie, love?’

‘I don’t know ... who would have thought a holiday could make you look so ill?’ Mum shook her head.

I went upstairs after supper. I didn’t knock. (It was still, strictly speaking, my room, after all.) The air was thick and stale, and I pulled the blind up and opened a window, so that Lou turned groggily from under the duvet, shielding her eyes from the light, dust motes swirling around her.

‘You going to tell me what happened?’ I put a mug of tea on the bedside table.

She blinked at me.

‘Mum thinks you’ve got Ebola virus. She’s busy warning all the neighbours who have booked on to the Bingo Club trip to PortAventura.’

She didn’t say anything.

‘Lou?’

‘I quit,’ she said, quietly.

‘Why?’

‘Why do you think?’ She pushed herself upright, and reached clumsily for the mug, taking a long sip of tea.

For someone who had just spent almost two weeks in Mauritius, she looked bloody awful. Her eyes were tiny and red-rimmed, and her skin, without the tan, would have been even blotchier. Her hair stuck up on one side. She looked like she’d been awake for several years. But most of all she looked sad. I had never seen my sister look so sad.

‘You think he’s really going to go through with it?’

She nodded. Then she swallowed, hard.

‘Shit. Oh, Lou. I’m really sorry.’

I motioned to her to shove over, and I climbed into bed beside her. She took another sip of her tea, and then leant her head on my shoulder. She was wearing my T-shirt. I didn’t say anything about it. That was how bad I felt for her.

‘What do I do, Treen?’

Her voice was small, like Thomas’s, when he hurts himself and is trying to be really brave. Outside we could hear next door’s dog running up and down alongside the garden fence, chasing the neighbourhood cats. Every now and then we could hear a burst of manic barking; its head would be popping up over the top right now, its eyes bulging with frustration.

‘I’m not sure there’s anything you can do. God. All that stuff you fixed up for him. All that effort ...’

‘I told him I loved him,’ she said, her voice dropping to a whisper. ‘And he just said it wasn’t enough.’ Her eyes were wide and bleak. ‘How am I supposed to live with that?’

I am the one in the family who knows everything. I read more than anyone else. I go to university. I am the one who is supposed to have all the answers.

But I looked at my big sister, and I shook my head. ‘I haven’t got a clue,’ I said.

She finally emerged the following day, showered and wearing clean clothes, and I told Mum and Dad not to say a word. I implied it was boyfriend trouble, and Dad raised his eyebrows and made a face as if that explained everything and God only knew what we had been working ourselves into such a fuss over. Mum ran off to ring the Bingo Club and tell them she’d had second thoughts about the risks of air travel.

Lou ate a piece of toast (she didn’t want lunch) and she put on a big floppy sunhat and we walked up to the castle with Thomas to feed the ducks. I don’t think she really wanted to go out, but Mum insisted that we all needed some fresh air. This, in my mother’s vocabulary, meant she was itching to get into the bedroom and air it and change the bedding. Thomas skipped and hopped ahead of us, clutching a plastic bag full of crusts, and we negotiated the meandering tourists with an ease born of years of practice, ducking out of the way of swinging backpacks, separating around posing couples and rejoining on the other side. The castle baked in the high heat of summer, the ground cracked and the grass wispy, like the last hairs on the head of a balding man. The flowers in the tubs looked defeated, as if they were already half preparing for autumn.

Lou and I didn’t say much. What was there to say?

As we walked past the tourist car park I saw her glance under her brim at the Traynors' house. It stood, elegant and red-brick, its tall blank windows disguising whatever life-changing drama was being played out in there, perhaps even at this moment.

'You could go and talk to him, you know,' I said. 'I'll wait here for you.'

She looked at the ground, folded her arms across her chest, and we kept walking. 'There's no point,' she said. I knew the other bit, the bit she didn't say aloud. *He's probably not even there.*

We did a slow circuit of the castle, watching Thomas roll down the steep parts of the hill, feeding the ducks that by this stage in the season were so well stuffed they could barely be bothered to come over for mere bread. I watched my sister as we walked, seeing her brown back exposed by her halter-neck top, her stooped shoulders, and I realized that even if she didn't know it yet, everything had changed for her. She wouldn't stay here now, no matter what happened with Will Traynor. She had an air about her, a new air of knowledge, of things seen, places she had been. My sister finally had new horizons.

'Oh,' I said, as we headed back towards the gates, 'you got a letter. From the college, while you were away. Sorry – I opened it. I thought it must be for me.'

'You opened it?'

I had been hoping it was extra grant money.

'You got an interview.'

She blinked, as if receiving news from some long-distant past.

'Yeah. And the big news is, it's tomorrow,' I said. 'So I thought maybe we should go over some possible questions tonight.'

She shook her head. 'I can't go to an interview tomorrow.'

'What else are you going to do?'

'I can't, Treen,' she said, sorrowfully. 'How am I supposed to think about anything at a time like this?'

'Listen, Lou. They don't give interviews out like bread for ducks, you eejit. This is a big deal. They know you're a mature student, you're applying at the wrong time of year, and they're still going to see you. You can't muck them around.'

'I don't care. I can't think about it.'

'But you –'

'Just leave me alone, Treen. Okay? *I can't do it.*'

‘Hey,’ I said. I stepped in front of her so that she couldn’t keep walking. Thomas was talking to a pigeon, a few paces up ahead. ‘This is exactly the time you have to think about it. This is the time when, like it or not, you finally have to work out what you are going to do with the rest of your life.’

We were blocking the path. Now the tourists had to separate to walk around us – they did so, heads down or eyeing with mild curiosity the arguing sisters.

‘I can’t.’

‘Well, tough. Because, in case you forgot, you have no job any more. No Patrick to pick up the pieces. And if you miss this interview, then in two days’ time you are headed back down the Job Centre to decide whether you want to be a chicken processor or a lap dancer or wipe some other person’s bum for a living. And believe it or not, because you are now headed for thirty, that’s your life pretty well mapped out. And all of this – everything you’ve learnt over the past six months – will have been a waste of time. All of it.’

She stared at me, wearing that look of mute fury she wears when she knows I am right and she can’t say anything back. Thomas appeared beside us now and pulled at my hand.

‘Mum ... you said *bum*.’

My sister was still glaring at me. But I could see her thinking.

I turned to my son. ‘No, sweetheart, I said *bun*. We’re going to go home for tea now – aren’t we, Lou? – and see if we can have some *buns*. And then, while Granny gives you a bath, I’m going to help Auntie Lou do her homework.’

I went to the library the next day, and Mum looked after Thomas, so I saw Lou off on the bus and knew I wouldn’t see her again till teatime. I didn’t hold out a lot of hope for the interview, but from the moment I left her I didn’t actually give her another thought.

It might sound a bit selfish, but I don’t like getting behind with my coursework, and it was a bit of a relief to have a break from Lou’s misery. Being around someone that depressed is a bit of a drain. You might feel sorry for them, but you can’t help wanting to tell them to pull themselves together too. I shoved my family, my sister, the epic mess she had got herself into, into a mental file, shut the drawer, and focused my attention on VAT exemptions. I got the second-highest marks in my year for

Accountancy 1 and there was no way on earth I was dropping back just because of the vagaries of HMRC's flat rate system.

I got home around a quarter to six, put my files on the hall chair, and they were all lurking around the kitchen table already, while Mum began to serve up. Thomas jumped on me, winding his legs around my waist, and I kissed him, breathing in his lovely yeasty little-boy smell.

'Sit down, sit down,' Mum said. 'Dad's only just in.'

'How'd you get on with your books?' Dad said, hanging his jacket on the back of the chair. He always referred to them as 'my books'. Like they had a life of their own and had to be wrangled into order.

'Good, thanks. I'm three-quarters of the way through my Accountancy 2 module. And then tomorrow I'm on corporate law.' I peeled Thomas from me and put him down on the chair next to me, one hand resting in his soft hair.

'Hear that, Josie? Corporate law.' Dad stole a potato from the dish and stuffed it into his mouth before Mum could see. He said it like he relished the sound of it. I suppose he probably did. We chatted for a bit about the kinds of things my module involved. Then we talked about Dad's job – mostly about how the tourists broke everything. You wouldn't believe the maintenance, apparently. Even the wooden posts at the car park gateway needed replacing every few weeks because the eejits couldn't drive a car through a twelve-foot gap. Personally, I would have put a surcharge on the ticket price to cover it – but that's just me.

Mum finished serving up, and finally sat down. Thomas ate with his fingers while he thought nobody noticed and said *bum* under his breath with a secret smile, and Granddad ate with his gaze tilted upwards, as if he were actually thinking about something else entirely. I glanced over at Lou. She was gazing at her plate, pushing the roast chicken around as if trying to disguise it. *Uh-oh*, I thought.

'You not hungry, love?' said Mum, following the line of my gaze.

'Not very,' she said.

'It is very warm for chicken,' Mum conceded. 'I just thought you needed perking up a bit.'

'So ... you going to tell us how you got on at this interview?' Dad's fork stopped halfway to his mouth.

'Oh, that.' She looked distracted, as if he had just dredged up something she did five years ago.

‘Yes, that.’

She speared a tiny piece of chicken. ‘It was okay.’

Dad glanced at me.

I gave a tiny shrug. ‘Just okay? They must have given you some idea how you did.’

‘I got it.’

‘What?’

She was still looking down at her plate. I stopped chewing.

‘They said I was exactly the kind of applicant they were looking for. I’ve got to do some kind of foundation course, which takes a year, and then I can convert it.’

Dad sat back in his chair. ‘That’s fantastic news.’

Mum reached over and patted her shoulder. ‘Oh, well done, love. That’s brilliant.’

‘Not really. I don’t think I can afford four years of study.’

‘Don’t you worry about that just now. Really. Look how well Treena’s managing. Hey –’ he nudged her ‘– we’ll find a way. We always find a way, don’t we?’ Dad beamed at us both. ‘I think everything’s turning around for us, now, girls. I think this is going to be a good time for this family.’

And then, out of nowhere, she burst into tears. Real tears. She cried like Thomas cries, wailing, all snot and tears and not caring who hears, her sobs breaking through the silence of the little room like a knife.

Thomas stared at her, open-mouthed, so that I had to haul him on to my lap and distract him so that he didn’t get upset too. And while I fiddled with bits of potato and talking peas and made silly voices, she told them.

She told them everything – about Will and the six-month contract and what had happened when they went to Mauritius. As she spoke, Mum’s hands went to her mouth. Granddad looked solemn. The chicken grew cold, the gravy congealing in its boat.

Dad shook his head in disbelief. And then, as my sister detailed her flight home from the Indian Ocean, her voice dropping to a whisper as she spoke of her last words to Mrs Traynor, he pushed his chair back and stood up. He walked slowly around the table and he took her in his arms, like he had when we were little. He stood there and held her really, really tightly to him.

‘Oh Jesus Christ, the poor fella. And poor you. Oh Jesus.’

I’m not sure I ever saw Dad look so shocked.

‘What a bloody mess.’

‘You went through all this? Without saying anything? And all we got was a postcard about scuba diving?’ My mother was incredulous. ‘We thought you were having the holiday of a lifetime.’

‘I wasn’t alone. Treena knew,’ she said, looking at me. ‘Treena was great.’

‘I didn’t do anything,’ I said, hugging Thomas. He had lost interest in the conversation now that Mum had put an open tin of Celebrations in front of him. ‘I was just an ear. You did the lot. You came up with all the ideas.’

‘And some ideas they turned out to be.’ She leant against Dad, sounding bereft.

Dad tilted her chin so that she had to look at him. ‘But you did everything you could.’

‘And I failed.’

‘Who says you failed?’ Dad stroked her hair back from her face. His expression was tender. ‘I’m just thinking of what I know about Will Traynor, what I know about men like him. And I’ll say one thing to you. I’m not sure anyone in the world was ever going to persuade that man once he’d set his mind to something. He’s who he is. You can’t make people change who they are.’

‘But his parents! They can’t let him kill himself,’ said Mum. ‘What kind of people are they?’

‘They’re normal people, Mum. Mrs Traynor just doesn’t know what else she can do.’

‘Well, not bloody taking him to this clinic would be a start.’ Mum was angry. Two points of colour had risen to her cheekbones. ‘I would fight for you two, for Thomas, until my dying breath.’

‘Even if he’d already tried to kill himself?’ I said. ‘In really grim ways?’

‘He’s ill, Katrina. He’s depressed. People who are vulnerable should not be given the chance to do something that they’ll ...’ She tailed off in mute fury and dabbed at her eyes with a napkin. ‘That woman must be heartless. *Heartless*. And to think they got Louisa involved in all this. She’s a magistrate, for goodness’ sake. You’d think a magistrate would know what was right or wrong. Of all people. I’ve a good mind to head down there now and bring him back here.’

‘It’s complicated, Mum.’

‘No. It’s not. He’s vulnerable and there is no way on earth she should entertain the thought of it. I’m shocked. That poor man. That *poor* man.’ She got up from the table, taking the remains of the chicken with her, and stalked out to the kitchen.

Louisa watched her go, her expression a little stunned. Mum was never angry. I think the last time we heard her raise her voice was 1993.

Dad shook his head, his mind apparently elsewhere. ‘I’ve just thought – no wonder I haven’t seen Mr Traynor. I wondered where he was. I assumed they were all off on some family holiday.’

‘They’ve ... they’ve gone?’

‘He’s not been in these last two days.’

Lou sat back down and slumped in her chair.

‘Oh shit,’ I said, and then clamped my hands around Thomas’s ears.

‘It’s tomorrow.’

Lou looked at me, and I glanced up at the calendar on the wall.

‘The thirteenth of August. It’s tomorrow.’

Lou did nothing that last day. She was up before me, staring out of the kitchen window. It rained, and then it cleared, and then it rained again. She lay on the sofa with Granddad, and she drank the tea that Mum made her, and every half an hour or so I watched her gaze slide silently towards the mantelpiece and check the clock. It was awful to watch. I took Thomas swimming and I tried to make her come with us. I said Mum would mind him if she wanted to go to the shops with me later. I said I’d take her to the pub, just the two of us, but she refused every offer.

‘What if I made a mistake, Treen?’ she said, so quietly that only I could hear it.

I glanced up at Granddad, but he had eyes only for the racing. I think Dad was still putting on a sneaky bet each way for him, even though he denied it to Mum.

‘What do you mean?’

‘What if I should have gone with him?’

‘But ... you said you couldn’t.’

Outside, the skies were grey. She stared through our immaculate windows at the miserable day beyond.

‘I know what I said. But I just can’t bear not knowing what’s happening.’ Her face crumpled a little. ‘I can’t bear not knowing how he’s feeling. I

can't bear the fact that I never even got to say goodbye.'

'Couldn't you go now? Maybe try and get a flight?'

'It's too late,' she said. And then she closed her eyes. 'I'd never get there in time. There's only two hours left until ... until it stops for the day. I looked it up. On the internet.'

I waited.

'They don't ... do ... it ... after five thirty.' She shook her head in bemusement. 'Something to do with the Swiss officials who have to be there. They don't like ... certifying ... things outside office hours.'

I almost laughed. But I didn't know what to say to her. I couldn't imagine having to wait, as she was waiting, knowing what might be happening in some far-off place. I had never loved a man like she seemed to love Will. I had liked men, sure, and wanted to sleep with them, but sometimes I wondered if I was missing some sensitivity chip. I couldn't imagine crying over anyone I'd been with. The only equivalent was if I thought about Thomas, waiting to die in some strange country, and as soon as that thought came to mind it made something inside me actually flip over, it was so hideous. So I stuck that in the back of my mental filing cabinet too, under the drawer labelled: *Unthinkable*.

I sat down beside my sister on the sofa and we stared in silence at the three thirty Maiden Stakes, then the four o'clock handicap stakes, and the four races that followed it, with the fixed intensity of people who might actually have all the money in the world on the winner.

And then the doorbell rang.

Louisa was off the sofa and in the hallway in seconds. She opened the door and the way she wrenched it open made even my heart stop.

But it wasn't Will there on the doorstep. It was a young woman, her make-up thick and perfectly applied, her hair cut in a neat bob around her chin. She folded her umbrella and smiled, reaching round towards the large bag she had over her shoulder. I wondered briefly if this was Will Traynor's sister.

'Louisa Clark?'

'Yes?'

'I'm from *The Globe*. I wondered if I could have a quick word?'

'*The Globe*?'

I could hear the confusion in Lou's voice.

‘The newspaper?’ I stepped behind my sister. I saw then the notepad in the woman’s hand.

‘Can I come in? I’d just like to have a little chat with you about William Traynor. You do work for William Traynor, don’t you?’

‘No comment,’ I said. And before the woman had a chance to say anything else, I slammed the door in her face.

My sister stood stunned in the hallway. She flinched as the doorbell rang again.

‘Don’t answer it,’ I hissed.

‘But how –?’

I began to push her up the stairs. God, she was impossibly slow. It was like she was half asleep. ‘Granddad, don’t answer the door!’ I yelled. ‘Who have you told?’ I said, when we reached the landing. ‘Someone must have told them. Who knows?’

‘Miss Clark,’ the woman’s voice came through the letter box. ‘If you just give me ten minutes ... we do understand this is a very sensitive issue. We’d like you to put your side of the story ... ’

‘Does this mean he’s dead?’ Her eyes had filled with tears.

‘No, it just means some arse is trying to cash in.’ I thought for a minute.

‘Who was that, girls?’ Mum’s voice came up the stairwell.

‘No one, Mum. Just don’t answer the door.’

I peered over the banister. Mum was holding a tea towel in her hands and gazing at the shadowy figure visible through the glass panels of the front door.

‘Don’t answer the door?’

I took my sister’s elbow. ‘Lou ... you didn’t say anything to Patrick, did you?’

She didn’t need to say anything. Her stricken face said it all.

‘Okay. Don’t have a baby. Just don’t go near the door. Don’t answer the phone. Don’t say a word to them, okay?’

Mum was not amused. She was even less amused after the phone started ringing. After the fifth call we put all calls through to the answerphone, but we still had to listen to them, their voices invading our little hallway. There were four or five of them, all the same. All offering Lou the chance to put her side of ‘the story’, as they called it. Like Will Traynor was now some commodity that they were all scrabbling over. The telephone rang and the

doorbell rang. We sat with the curtains closed, listening to the reporters on the pavement just outside our gate, chatting to each other and speaking on their mobile phones.

It was like being under siege. Mum wrung her hands and shouted through the letter box for them to get the hell out of our front garden, whenever one of them ventured past the gate. Thomas gazed out of the upstairs bathroom window and wanted to know why there were people in our garden. Four of our neighbours rang, wanting to know what was going on. Dad parked in Ivy Street and came home via the back garden, and we had a fairly serious talk about castles and boiling oil.

Then, after I'd thought a bit longer, I rang Patrick and asked him how much he had got for his sordid little tip. The slight delay before he denied everything told me all I needed to know.

'You shitbag,' I yelled. 'I'm going to kick your stupid marathon-running shins so hard you're going to think 157th was actually a good result.'

Lou just sat in the kitchen and cried. Not proper sobbing, just silent tears that ran down her face and which she wiped away with the palm of her hand. I couldn't think what to say to her.

Which was fine. I had plenty to say to everyone else.

All but one of the reporters cleared off by half past seven. I didn't know if they had given up, or if Thomas's habit of posting bits of Lego out of the letter box every time they passed another note through had become boring. I told Louisa to bath Thomas for me, mainly because I wanted her to get out of the kitchen, but also because that way I could go through all the messages on our answerphone and delete the newspaper ones while she couldn't hear me. Twenty-six. Twenty-six of the buggers. And all sounding so nice, so understanding. Some of them even offered her money.

I pressed delete on every one. Even those offering money, although I admit I was a teeny bit tempted to see how much they were offering. All the while, I heard Lou talking to Thomas in the bathroom, the whine and splash of him dive-bombing his six inches of soapsuds with the Batmobile. That's the thing you don't know about children unless you have them – bath time, Lego and fish fingers don't allow you to dwell on tragedy for too long. And then I hit the last message.

'Louisa? It's Camilla Traynor. Will you call me? As soon as possible?'

I stared at the answerphone. I rewound and replayed it. Then I ran upstairs and whipped Thomas out of the bath so fast my boy didn't even

know what hit him. He was standing there, the towel wrapped tightly around him like a compression bandage, and Lou, stumbling and confused, was already halfway down the stairs, me pushing her by the shoulder.

‘What if she hates me?’

‘She didn’t sound like she hated you.’

‘But what if the press are surrounding them there? What if they think it’s all my fault?’ Her eyes were wide and terrified. ‘What if she’s ringing to tell me he’s done it?’

‘Oh, for Christ’s sake, Lou. For once in your life, just get a grip. You won’t know anything unless you call. Call her. Just call. You don’t have a bloody choice.’

I ran back into the bathroom, to set Thomas free. I shoved him into his pyjamas, told him that Granny had a biscuit for him if he ran to the kitchen super fast. And then I peered out of the bathroom door, to peek at my sister on the phone down in the hallway.

She was turned away from me, one hand smoothing the hair at the back of her head. She reached out a hand to steady herself.

‘Yes,’ she was saying. ‘I see.’ And then, ‘Okay.’

And after a pause, ‘Yes.’

She looked down at her feet for a good minute after she’d put the phone down.

‘Well?’ I said.

She looked up as if she’d only just seen me there, and shook her head.

‘It was nothing about the newspapers,’ she said, her voice still numb with shock. ‘She asked me – begged me – to come to Switzerland. And she’s booked me on to the last flight out this evening.’



26

In other circumstances I suppose it might have seemed strange that I, Lou Clark, a girl who had rarely been more than a bus ride from her home town in twenty years, was now flying to her third country in less than a week. But I packed an overnight case with the swift efficiency of an air stewardess, rejecting all but the barest necessities. Treena ran around silently fetching any other things she thought I might need, and then we headed downstairs. We stopped halfway down. Mum and Dad were already in the hall, standing side by side in the ominous way they used to do when we sneaked back late from a night out.

‘What’s going on?’ Mum was staring at my case.

Treena had stopped in front of me.

‘Lou’s going to Switzerland,’ she said. ‘And she needs to leave now. There’s only one flight left today.’

We were about to move when Mum stepped forward.

‘No.’ Her mouth was set into an unfamiliar line, her arms folded awkwardly in front of her. ‘Really. I don’t want you involved. If this is what I think it is, then no.’

‘But –’ Treena began, glancing behind at me.

‘No,’ said Mum, and her voice held an unusually steely quality. ‘No buts. I’ve been thinking about this, about everything you told us. It’s wrong. Morally wrong. And if you get embroiled in it and you’re seen to be helping a man kill himself, then you could end up in all sorts of trouble.’

‘Your mum’s right,’ Dad said.

‘We’ve seen it in the news. This could affect your whole life, Lou. This college interview, everything. If you get a criminal record, you will never get a college degree or a good job or anything –’

‘He’s asked for her to come. She can’t just ignore him,’ Treena interrupted.

‘Yes. Yes, she can. She’s given six months of her life to this family. And a fat lot of good it’s brought her, judging by the state of things. A fat lot of good it’s brought this family, with people banging on the door and all the neighbours thinking we’ve been done for benefit fraud or some such. No, she’s finally got the chance to make something of herself, and now they want her to go to that dreadful place in Switzerland and get involved in God knows what. Well, I say no. No, Louisa.’

‘But she has to go,’ Treena said.

‘No, she doesn’t. She’s done enough. She said herself last night, she’s done everything she could.’ Mum shook her head. ‘Whatever mess the Traynors are going to make of their lives going to this ... this ... whatever they’re going to do to their own son, I don’t want Louisa involved. I don’t want her ruining her whole life.’

‘I think I can make my own mind up,’ I said.

‘I’m not sure you can. This is your friend, Louisa. This is a young man with his whole life ahead of him. You cannot be part of this. I’m ... I’m shocked that you could even consider it.’ Mum’s voice had a new, hard edge. ‘I didn’t bring you up to help someone end his life! Would you end Granddad’s life? Do you think we should shove him off to Dignitas too?’

‘Granddad is different.’

‘No, he isn’t. He can’t do what he used to. But his life is precious. Just as Will’s is precious.’

‘It’s not my decision, Mum. It’s Will’s. The whole point of this is to support Will.’

‘Support Will? I’ve never heard such rubbish. You are a child, Louisa. You’ve seen nothing, done nothing. And you have no idea what this is going to do to you. How in God’s name will you ever be able to sleep at night if you help him to go through with it? You’d be helping a man to *die*. Do you really understand that? You’d be helping Will, that lovely, clever young man, to *die*.’

‘I’d sleep at night because I trust Will to know what is right for him, and because what has been the worst thing for him has been losing the ability to

make a single decision, to do a single thing for himself ... ' I looked at my parents, trying to make them understand. 'I'm not a child. I love him. I love him, and I shouldn't have left him alone, and I can't bear not being there and not knowing what ... what he's ... ' I swallowed. 'So yes. I'm going. I don't need you to look out for me or understand. I'll deal with it. But I'm going to Switzerland – whatever either of you says.'

The little hallway grew silent. Mum stared at me like she had no idea who I was. I took a step closer to her, trying to make her understand. But as I did, she took a step back.

'Mum? I owe Will. I owe it to him to go. Who do you think got me to apply to college? Who do you think encouraged me to make something of myself, to travel places, to have ambitions? Who changed the way I think about everything? About myself even? Will did. I've done more, lived more, in the last six months than in the last twenty-seven years of my life. So if he wants me to go to Switzerland, then yes, I'm going to go. Whatever the outcome.'

There was a brief silence.

'She's like Aunt Lily,' Dad said, quietly.

We all stood, staring at each other. Dad and Treena were shooting glances at each other, as if each of them were waiting for the other to say something.

But Mum broke the silence. 'If you go, Louisa, you needn't come back.'

The words fell out of her mouth like pebbles. I looked at my mother in shock. Her gaze was unyielding. It tensed as she watched for my reaction. It was as if a wall I had never known was there had sprung up between us.

'Mum?'

'I mean it. This is no better than murder.'

'Josie ... '

'That's the truth, Bernard. I can't be part of this.'

I remember thinking, as if at a distance, that I had never seen Katrina look so uncertain as she did now. I saw Dad's hand reach out to Mum's arm, whether in reproach or comfort I couldn't tell. My mind went briefly blank. Then almost without knowing what I was doing, I walked slowly down the stairs and past my parents to the front door. And after a second, my sister followed me.

The corners of Dad's mouth turned down, as if he were struggling to contain all sorts of things. Then he turned to Mum, and placed one hand on

her shoulder. Her eyes searched his face and it was as if she already knew what he was going to say.

And then he threw Treena his keys. She caught them one-handed.

‘Here,’ he said. ‘Go out the back door, through Mrs Doherty’s garden, and take the van. They won’t see you in the van. If you go now and the traffic’s not too bad you might just make it.’

‘You have any idea where this is all headed?’ Katrina said.

She glanced sideways at me as we sped down the motorway.

‘Nope.’

I couldn’t look at her for long – I was rifling through my handbag, trying to work out what I had forgotten. I kept hearing the sound of Mrs Traynor’s voice down the line. *Louisa? Please will you come? I know we’ve had our differences, but please ... It’s vital that you come now.*

‘Shit. I’ve never seen Mum like that,’ Treena continued.

Passport, wallet, door keys. Door keys? For what? I no longer had a home.

Katrina glanced sideways at me. ‘I mean, she’s mad now, but she’s in shock. You know she’ll be all right in the end, right? I mean, when I came home and told her I was up the duff I thought she was never going to speak to me again. But it only took her – what? – two days, to come round.’

I could hear her babbling away beside me, but I wasn’t really paying attention. I could barely focus on anything. My nerve endings seemed to have come alive; they almost jangled with anticipation. I was going to see Will. Whatever else, I had that. I could almost feel the miles between us shrinking, as if we were at two ends of some invisible elastic thread.

‘Treen?’

‘Yes?’

I swallowed. ‘Don’t let me miss this flight.’

My sister is nothing if not determined. We queue-jumped, sped up the inside lane, broke the speed limit and scanned the radio for the traffic reports, and finally the airport came into view. She screeched to a halt and I was halfway out of the car before I heard her.

‘Hey! Lou!’

‘Sorry.’ I turned back and ran the few steps to her.

She hugged me, really tightly. ‘You’re doing the right thing,’ she said. She looked almost close to tears. ‘Now fuck off. If you miss the bloody

plane on top of me getting six points on my licence, I'm never talking to you again.'

I didn't look back. I ran all the way to the Swiss Air desk and it took me three goes to say my name clearly enough to request my tickets.

I arrived in Zurich shortly before midnight. Given the late hour, Mrs Traynor had, as promised, booked me into a hotel at the airport and said she would send a car for me at nine the following morning. I had thought I wouldn't sleep, but I did – an odd, heavy and disjointed trawl through the hours – waking up at seven the next morning with no idea where I was.

I stared groggily around the unfamiliar room, at the heavy burgundy drapes, designed to block out light, at the large flat-screen television, at my overnight bag, which I hadn't even bothered to unpack. I checked the clock, which said it was shortly after seven Swiss time. And as I realized where I was, I suddenly felt my stomach clench with fear.

I scrambled out of bed just in time to be sick in the little bathroom. I sank down on the tiled floor, my hair sticking to my forehead, my cheek pressed against the cold porcelain. I heard my mother's voice, her protests, and I felt a dark fear creeping over me. I wasn't up to this. I didn't want to fail again. I didn't want to have to watch Will die. With an audible groan, I scrambled up to be sick again.

I couldn't eat. I managed to swallow down a cup of black coffee and showered and dressed, and that took me to 8am. I stared at the pale-green dress I had thrown in last night and wondered if it was appropriate for where I was going. Would everyone wear black? Should I have worn something more vibrant and alive, like the red dress I knew Will liked? Why had Mrs Traynor called me here? I checked my mobile phone, wondering whether I could call Katrina. It would be seven in the morning there now. But she would probably be dressing Thomas, and the thought of talking to Mum was too much. I put on some make-up and then sat down by the window, and the minutes ticked slowly past.

I don't think I had ever felt lonelier in my life.

When I couldn't bear being in the little room any longer, I threw the last of my things into my bag and left. I would buy a newspaper, and wait in the lobby. It couldn't be worse than sitting in my room with the silence or the satellite news channel and the suffocating darkness of the curtains. It was as

I was passing reception that I saw the computer terminal, discreetly placed in a corner. It was marked: *For Use Of Guests. Please Ask At Reception.*

‘Can I use this?’ I said to the receptionist.

She nodded, and I bought an hour’s token. I knew suddenly very clearly who I wanted to speak to. I knew in my gut that he was one of the few people I could rely on to be online at this time. I logged on to the chat room and typed on the message board:

Ritchie. Are you there?

Morning, Bee. You’re early today?

I hesitated for just a moment before typing:

I am about to begin the strangest day of my life. I am in Switzerland.

He knew what it meant. They all knew what it meant. The clinic had been the subject of many heated debates. I typed:

I’m frightened.

Then why are you there?

Because I can’t not be here. He asked me. Am in hotel waiting to go see him.

I hesitated, then typed:

I have no idea how this day is going to end.

Oh, Bee.

What do I say to him? How do I change his mind?

There was a delay before he typed again. His words appeared on the screen more slowly than usual, as if he were taking great care.

If he’s in Switzerland, Bee, I’m not sure he’s going to change his mind.

I felt a huge lump in my throat, and swallowed it. Ritchie was still typing.

It’s not my choice. It’s not the choice of most of us on this board. I love my life, even if I wish it was different. But I understand why your friend might well have had enough. It’s tiring, leading this life, tiring in a way the AB can never truly understand. If he is determined, if he really can’t see a way of things being better for him, then I guess the best thing you can do is just be there. You don’t have to think he’s right. But you do have to be there.

I realized I was holding my breath.

Good luck, Bee. And come see me after. Things may get a little bumpy for you afterwards. Either way, I could do with a friend like you.

My fingers stilled on the keyboard. I typed:

I will.

And then the receptionist told me that my car had arrived outside.

I don't know what I expected – maybe some white building next to a lake, or snow-capped mountains. Perhaps some medical-looking marble frontage with a gold-plated plaque on the wall. What I didn't expect was to be driven through an industrial estate until I arrived at what looked remarkably like an ordinary house, surrounded by factories and, weirdly, a football pitch. I walked across decking, past a goldfish pond, and then I was in.

The woman who opened the door knew immediately who I was looking for. 'He is here. Would you like me to show you?'

I stalled then. I stared at the closed door, oddly similar to the one I had stood outside in Will's annexe all those months ago, and I took a breath. And nodded.

I saw the bed before I saw him; it dominated the room with its mahogany wood, its quaintly flowered quilt and pillows weirdly out of place in that setting. Mr Traynor sat on one side of it, Mrs Traynor on the other.

She looked ghostly pale, and stood up when she saw me. 'Louisa.'

Georgina was seated on a wooden chair in the corner, bent over her knees, her hands pressed together as if in prayer. She lifted her gaze as I walked in, revealing shadowed eyes, reddened with grief, and I felt a brief spasm of sympathy for her.

What would I have done if Katrina had insisted on her right to do the same?

The room itself was light and airy, like an upmarket holiday home. There was a tiled floor and expensive rugs, and a sofa at the end that looked out on to a little garden. I didn't know what to say. It was such a ridiculous, mundane sight, the three of them sitting there, as if they were a family trying to work out where to go sightseeing that day.

I turned towards the bed. 'So,' I said, my bag over my shoulder, 'I'm guessing the room service isn't up to much?'

Will's eyes locked on to mine and despite everything, despite all my fears, the fact that I had thrown up twice, that I felt like I hadn't slept for a

year, I was suddenly glad I had come. Not glad, relieved. Like I had excised some painful, nagging part of myself, and given it over.

And then he smiled. It was lovely, his smile – a slow thing, full of recognition.

Weirdly, I found myself smiling back. ‘Nice room,’ I said, and immediately realized the idiocy of the remark. I saw Georgina Traynor close her eyes, and I blushed.

Will turned towards his mother. ‘I want to talk to Lou. Is that okay?’

She tried to smile. I saw a million things in the way she looked at me then – relief, gratitude, a faint resentment at being shut out of these few minutes, perhaps even a distant hope that my appearance meant something, that this fate might yet be twisted from its tracks.

‘Of course.’

She moved past me into the corridor, and as I stood back from the doorway to let her pass, she reached out a hand and touched my upper arm, just lightly. Our eyes met, and hers softened, so that briefly she looked like someone else entirely, and then she turned away from me.

‘Come, Georgina,’ she said, when her daughter made no attempt to move.

Georgina stood slowly and walked out silently, her very back broadcasting her reluctance.

And then it was just us.

Will was half propped up in the bed, able to see out of the window to his left, where the water feature in the little garden merrily trickled a thin stream of clear water below the decking. On the wall was a badly framed print picture of dahlias. I remember thinking that was a really crummy print to have to look at in your last hours.

‘So ...’

‘You’re not going to –’

‘I’m not going to try and change your mind.’

‘If you’re here, you accept it’s my choice. This is the first thing I’ve been in control of since the accident.’

‘I know.’

And there it was. He knew it, and I knew it. There was nothing left for me to do.

Do you know how hard it is to say nothing? When every atom of you strains to do the opposite? I had practised not saying anything the whole

way from the airport, and it was still nearly killing me. I nodded. When I finally spoke, my voice was a small, broken thing. What emerged was the only thing I could safely say.

‘I missed you.’

He seemed to relax then. ‘Come over here.’ And then, when I hesitated. ‘Please. Come on. Right here, on the bed. Right next to me.’

I realized then that there was actual relief in his expression. That he was pleased to see me in a way he wasn’t actually going to be able to say. And I told myself that it was going to have to be enough. I would do the thing he had asked for. That would have to be enough.

I lay down on the bed beside him and I placed my arm across him. I rested my head on his chest, letting my body absorb the gentle rise and fall of it. I could feel the faint pressure of Will’s fingertips on my back, his warm breath in my hair. I closed my eyes, breathing in the scent of him, still the same expensive cedar-wood smell, despite the bland freshness of the room, the slightly disturbing scent of disinfectant underneath. I tried not to think of anything at all. I just tried to be, tried to absorb the man I loved through osmosis, tried to imprint what I had left of him on myself. I did not speak. And then I heard his voice. I was so close to him that when he spoke it seemed to vibrate gently through me.

‘Hey, Clark,’ he said. ‘Tell me something good.’

I stared out of the window at the bright-blue Swiss sky and I told him a story of two people. Two people who shouldn’t have met, and who didn’t like each other much when they did, but who found they were the only two people in the world who could possibly have understood each other. And I told him of the adventures they had, the places they had gone, and the things I had seen that I had never expected to. I conjured for him electric skies and iridescent seas and evenings full of laughter and silly jokes. I drew a world for him, a world far from a Swiss industrial estate, a world in which he was still somehow the person he had wanted to be. I drew the world he had created for me, full of wonder and possibility. I let him know a hurt had been mended in a way that he couldn’t have known, and for that alone there would always be a piece of me indebted to him. And as I spoke I knew these would be the most important words I would ever say and that it was important that they were the right words, that they were not propaganda, an attempt to change his mind, but respectful of what Will had said.

I told him something good.

Time slowed, and stilled. It was just the two of us, me murmuring in the empty, sunlit room. Will didn't say much. He didn't answer back, or add a dry comment, or scoff. He nodded occasionally, his head pressed against mine, and murmured, or let out a small sound that could have been satisfaction at another good memory.

'It has been,' I told him, 'the best six months of my entire life.'

There was a long silence.

'Funnily enough, Clark, mine too.'

And then, just like that, my heart broke. My face crumpled, my composure went and I held him tightly and I stopped caring that he could feel the shudder of my sobbing body because grief swamped me. It overwhelmed me and tore at my heart and my stomach and my head and it pulled me under, and I couldn't bear it. I honestly thought I couldn't bear it.

'Don't, Clark,' he murmured. I felt his lips on my hair. 'Oh, please. Don't. Look at me.'

I screwed my eyes shut and shook my head.

'Look at me. Please.'

I couldn't.

'You're angry. Please. I don't want to hurt you or make you –'

'No ...' I shook my head again. 'It's not that. I don't want ...' My cheek was pressed to his chest. 'I don't want the last thing you see to be my miserable, blotchy face.'

'You still don't get it, Clark, do you?' I could hear the smile in his voice. 'It's not your choice.'

It took some time to regain my composure. I blew my nose, took a long deep breath. Finally, I raised myself on my elbow, and I looked back at him. His eyes, so long strained and unhappy, looked oddly clear and relaxed.

'You look absolutely beautiful.'

'Funny.'

'Come here,' he said. 'Right up close to me.'

I lay down again, facing him. I saw the clock above the door and had a sudden sense of time running out. I took his arm and wrapped it tightly around me, threading my own arms and legs around him so that we were tightly entwined. I took his hand – the good one – and wrapped my fingers in his, kissing the knuckles as I felt him squeeze mine. His body was so familiar to me now. I knew it in a way I had never known Patrick's – its

strengths and vulnerabilities, its scars and scents. I placed my face so close to his that his features became indistinct, and I began to lose myself in them. I stroked his hair, his skin, his brow, with my fingertips, tears sliding unchecked down my cheeks, my nose against his, and all the time he watched me silently, studying me intently as if he were storing each molecule of me away. He was already retreating, withdrawing to somewhere I couldn't reach him.

I kissed him, trying to bring him back. I kissed him and let my lips rest against his so that our breath mingled and the tears from my eyes became salt on his skin, and I told myself that, somewhere, tiny particles of him would become tiny particles of me, ingested, swallowed, alive, perpetual. I wanted to press every bit of me against him. I wanted to will something into him. I wanted to give him every bit of life I felt and force him to live.

I realized I was afraid of living without him. *How is it you have the right to destroy my life, I wanted to demand of him, but I'm not allowed a say in yours?*

But I had promised.

So I held him, Will Traynor, ex-City whiz kid, ex-stunt diver, sportsman, traveller, lover. I held him close and said nothing, all the while telling him silently that he was loved. Oh, but he was loved.

I couldn't say how long we stayed like that. I was dimly aware of soft conversation outside, of the shuffle of shoes, a distant church bell ringing in some far-off place. Finally, I felt him loosen a great breath, almost a shudder, and he drew his head back just an inch so that we could see each other clearly.

I blinked at him.

He gave me a small smile, almost an apology.

'Clark,' he said, quietly. 'Can you call my parents in?'



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CROWN PROSECUTION SERVICE
FAO: Director of Public Prosecutions
Confidential Advisory
Re: William John Traynor
4.9.2009

Detectives have now interviewed everyone involved in the above case, and I attach files containing all related documents accordingly.

The subject at the centre of the investigation is Mr William Traynor, a 35-year-old former partner in the firm Madingley Lewins, based in the City of London. Mr Traynor suffered a spinal injury in a road accident in 2007 and had been diagnosed C5/6 quadriplegic with very limited movement in one arm only, requiring 24-hour care. His medical history is attached.

The papers show that Mr Traynor had been at pains to regularize his legal affairs sometime before his trip to Switzerland. We have been forwarded a signed and witnessed statement of intent by his lawyer, Mr Michael Lawler, as well as copies of all relevant documentation relating to his consultations with the clinic beforehand.

Mr Traynor's family and friends had all expressed their opposition to his stated desire to end his life prematurely but given his medical history and previous attempts on his own life (detailed in his attached hospital records), his intellect and strength of character, they were apparently unable to

dissuade him, even during an extended six-month period which was negotiated with him specifically for this purpose.

It will be noted that one of the beneficiaries of Mr Traynor's will is his paid female carer, Miss Louisa Clark. Given the limited length of her association with Mr Traynor some questions may be asked about the extent of his generosity towards her, but all parties say they do not wish to contest Mr Traynor's stated wishes, which are legally documented. She has been interviewed at length several times and police are satisfied that she made every effort to deter Mr Traynor from his intention (please see her 'calendar of adventures' included in the evidence).

It should also be noted that Mrs Camilla Traynor, his mother, who has been a respected JP for many years, has tendered her resignation in light of the publicity surrounding the case. It is understood that she and Mr Traynor separated soon after their son's death.

While the use of assisted suicide at foreign clinics is not something the CPS can be seen to encourage, judging by the evidence gathered, it is evident that the actions of Mr Traynor's family and carers fall well within current guidelines as laid out relating to assisted suicide and the possible prosecution of those close to the deceased.

1. Mr Traynor was deemed competent and had a 'voluntary, clear, settled and informed' wish to make such a decision.
2. There is no evidence of mental illness, or of coercion on any part.
3. Mr Traynor had indicated unequivocally that he wished to commit suicide.
4. Mr Traynor's disability was severe and incurable.
5. The actions of those accompanying Mr Traynor were of only minor assistance or influence.
6. The actions of those accompanying Mr Traynor may be characterized as reluctant assistance in the face of a determined wish on the part of the victim.
7. All parties involved have offered every assistance to the police investigating this case.

Given these facts as outlined, the previous good character of all parties, and the evidence enclosed, I would advise that it does not serve the public

interest to pursue a prosecution in this case.

I suggest that if and when any public statement is made to this effect, the Director of Public Prosecutions makes it clear that the Traynor case sets no kind of precedent, and that the CPS will continue to judge each case on its individual merits and circumstances.

With best wishes

Sheilagh Mackinnon
Crown Prosecution Service

Epilogue

I was just following instructions.

I sat in the shadow of the dark-green cafe awning, staring down the length of the Rue des Francs Bourgeois, the tepid sun of a Parisian autumn warming the side of my face. In front of me the waiter had, with Gallic efficiency, deposited a plate of croissants and a large cup of filter coffee. A hundred yards down the street two cyclists stopped near the traffic lights and struck up a conversation. One wore a blue backpack from which two large baguettes poked at odd angles. The air, still and muggy, held the scents of coffee and patisserie and the acrid tang of someone's cigarettes.

I finished Treena's letter (she would have called, she said, but she couldn't afford the overseas charges). She had come top of her year in Accountancy 2 and had a new boyfriend, Sundeep, who was trying to work out whether to work for his dad's import-export business outside Heathrow and had even worse taste in music than she did. Thomas was dead excited about moving up a class at school. Dad was still going great guns at his job, and sent his love. She was pretty confident that Mum would forgive me soon. *She definitely got your letter*, she said. *I know she read it. Give her time.*

I took a sip of my coffee, briefly transported to Renfrew Road, and a home that seemed a million miles away. I sat and squinted a little against the low sun, watching a woman in sunglasses adjust her hair in the mirror of a shop window. She pursed her lips at her reflection, straightened up a little, and then continued her path down the road.

I put down the cup, took a deep breath, and then picked up the other letter, the letter that I had carried around with me for almost six weeks now.

On the front of the envelope, in typed capitals, it said, under my name:

ONLY TO BE READ IN THE CAFE MARQUIS, RUE DES FRANCS BOURGEOIS,
ACCOMPANIED BY CROISSANTS AND A LARGE CAFÉ CRÈME.

I had laughed, even as I wept, on first reading the envelope – typical Will, bossy to the last.

The waiter – a tall, brisk man with a dozen bits of paper sticking out of the top of his apron – turned back and caught my eye. *All okay?* his raised eyebrows said.

‘Yes,’ I said. And then, a little self-consciously, ‘*Oui.*’

The letter was typewritten. I recognized the font from a card he had sent me long ago. I settled back in my chair, and I began to read.

Clark,

A few weeks will have passed by the time you read this (even given your newfound organizational skills, I doubt you will have made it to Paris before early September). I hope the coffee is good and strong and the croissants fresh and that the weather is still sunny enough to sit outside on one of those metallic chairs that never sit quite level on the pavement. It’s not bad, the Marquis. The steak is also good, if you fancy coming back for lunch. And if you look down the road to your left you will hopefully see L’Artisan Parfumeur where, after you read this, you should go and try the scent called something like Papillons Extrême (can’t quite remember). I always did think it would smell great on you.

Okay, instructions over. There are a few things I wanted to say and would have told you in person, but a) you would have got all emotional and b) you wouldn’t have let me say all this out loud. You always did talk too much.

So here it is: the cheque you got in the initial envelope from Michael Lawler was not the full amount, but just a small gift, to help you through your first weeks of unemployment, and to get you to Paris.

When you get back to England, take this letter to Michael in his London office and he will give you the relevant documents so you can access an account he has set up for me in your name. This account contains enough for you to buy somewhere nice to live and to pay for your degree course and your living expenses while you are in full-time education.

My parents will have been told all about it. I hope that this, and Michael Lawler’s legal work, will ensure there is as little fuss as possible.

Clark, I can practically hear you starting to hyperventilate from here. Don’t start panicking, or trying to give it away – it’s not enough for you to sit on your arse for the rest of your life. But it should buy you your freedom, both from that claustrophobic little town we both call home, and from the kind of choices you have so far felt you had to make.

I’m not giving the money to you because I want you to feel wistful, or indebted to me, or to feel that it’s some kind of bloody memorial.

I’m giving you this because there is not much that makes me happy any more, but you do.

I am conscious that knowing me has caused you pain, and grief, and I hope that one day when you are less angry with me and less upset you will see not just that I could only have done the thing that I did, but also that this will help you live a really good life, a better life, than if you hadn’t met me.

You're going to feel uncomfortable in your new world for a bit. It always does feel strange to be knocked out of your comfort zone. But I hope you feel a bit exhilarated too. Your face when you came back from diving that time told me everything; there is a hunger in you, Clark. A fearlessness. You just buried it, like most people do.

I'm not really telling you to jump off tall buildings, or swim with whales or anything (although I would secretly love to think you were), but to live boldly. Push yourself. Don't settle. Wear those stripy legs with pride. And if you insist on settling down with some ridiculous bloke, make sure some of this is squirrelled away somewhere. Knowing you still have possibilities is a luxury. Knowing I might have given them to you has alleviated something for me.

So this is it. You are scored on my heart, Clark. You were from the first day you walked in, with your ridiculous clothes and your bad jokes and your complete inability to ever hide a single thing you felt. You changed my life so much more than this money will ever change yours.

Don't think of me too often. I don't want to think of you getting all maudlin. Just live well.

Just *live*.

Love,

Will

A tear had plopped on to the rickety table in front of me. I wiped at my cheek with my palm, and put the letter down on the table. It took me some minutes to see clearly again.

'Another coffee?' said the waiter, who had reappeared in front of me.

I blinked at him. He was younger than I had thought, and had dropped his faint air of haughtiness. Perhaps Parisian waiters were trained to be kind to weeping women in their cafes.

'Maybe ... a cognac?' He glanced at the letter and smiled, with something resembling understanding.

'No,' I said, smiling back. 'Thank you. I've ... I've got things to do.'

I paid the bill, and tucked the letter carefully into my pocket.

And stepping out from behind the table, I straightened my bag on my shoulder and set off down the street towards the parfumerie and the whole of Paris beyond.

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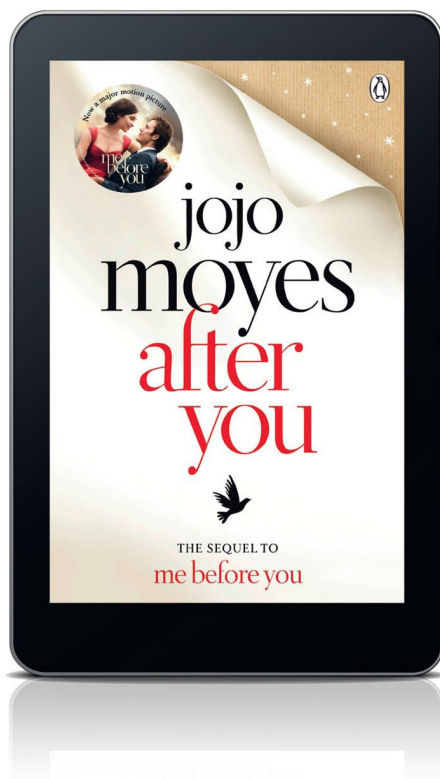
Thanks to Lizzie and Brian Sanders, and to Jim, Bea and Clemmie Moyes. But most of all, as ever, to Charles, Saskia, Harry and Lockie.

Reading Group Questions

1. When Lou meets Will for the first time he is less than welcoming to her, even playing a mean trick on her to put her on edge. What were your first impressions of both Will and Lou? Did your view of them change over the course of the book and to what extent?
2. Will and Lou have a profound effect on each other's lives. How do their lives change after they meet compared with how they were before? In what ways do they change each other?
3. When Lou first learns of Will's intentions to go to Dignitas to end his life, she is shocked that his mother Camilla could be prepared to play such a role in her son's death and thinks of her as heartless: a view shared by other characters, such as Georgina and Lou's mother. How do you feel about Camilla as a character? Do you think this view of her is justified?
4. Both Will and Lou have experienced a terrible life altering moment – Will's accident and Lou's assault in the castle maze. How do their reactions to each of their experiences compare? In what ways are their reactions similar/different?
5. As his nurse and friend, Nathan is also a big part of Will's life. How important is his role in the novel? How does he affect the dynamic between Will, Lou and Will's parents?

6. Lou is very close to her family, despite her frequent squabbles with her sister Treena. How important are they in the decisions she makes, such as her decision to take the job with the Traynors and keep it – even when she discovers why she is only contracted for six months – and her decision to go to Switzerland to be with Will at the end?
7. Will and Lou come from very different worlds. Will's was one of success, ambition and privilege before his accident, while Lou inhabits a modest, simple and unadventurous world, restricted to the boundaries of the small town she's lived in all of her life. Do you think they would have fallen for each other if they had met under different circumstances?
8. Will's right to die, and Lou's determination to change his mind about exercising that right, is a theme that runs throughout the novel. How did you feel about Will's decision at the end? Was it what you expected? Do you think the novel should have ended differently?

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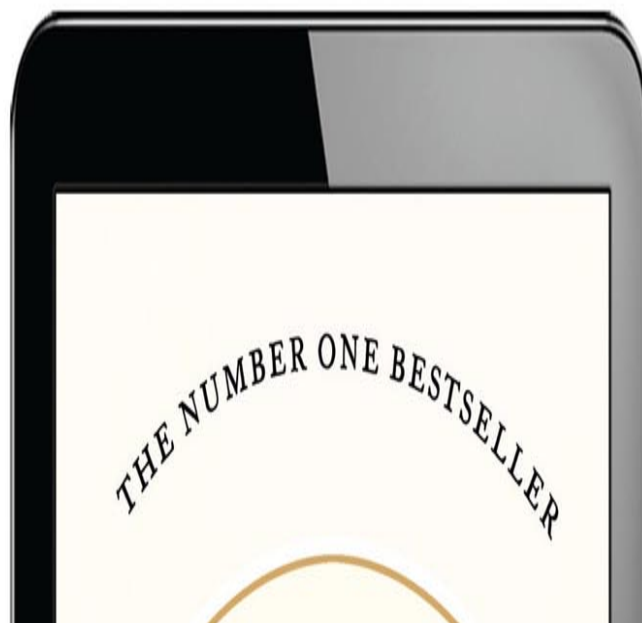
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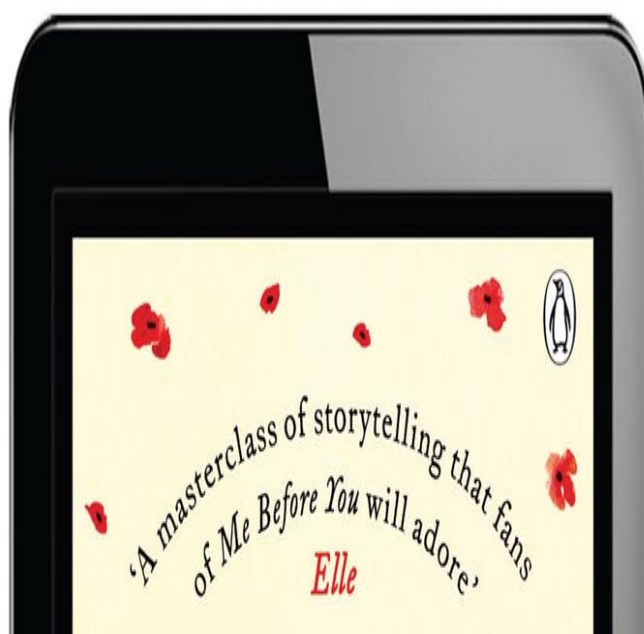
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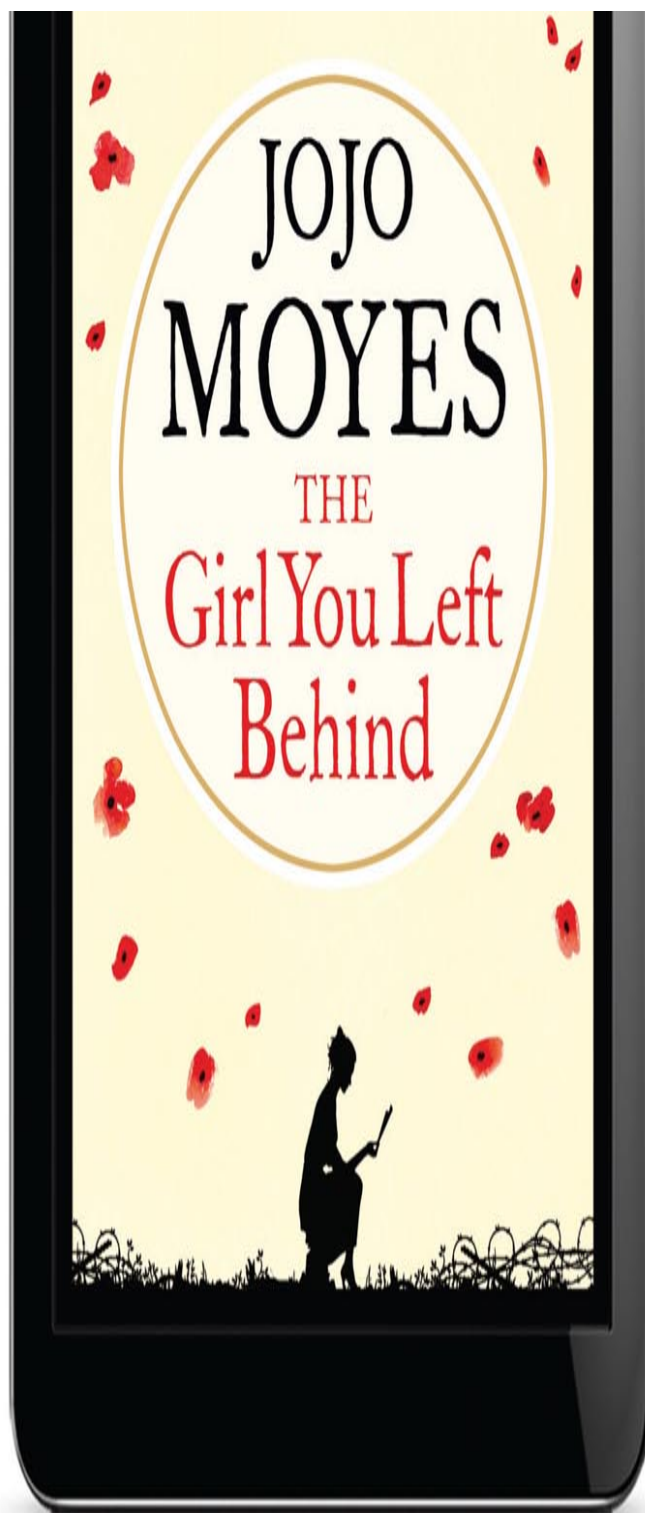
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THE SEQUEL TO
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Acknowledgements

For my grandmother, Betty McKee



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And then all is black.



CHAPTER TWO

‘What’s your name, sweetheart?’

A brace around my neck.

A hand feeling around my head, gently, swiftly.

I am alive. This is actually quite surprising.

‘That’s it. Open your eyes. Look at me, now. Look at me. Can you tell me your name?’

I want to speak, to open my mouth, but my voice emerges muffled and nonsensical. I think I have bitten my tongue. There is blood in my mouth, warm and tasting of iron. I cannot move.

‘We’re going to put you onto a spinal board, okay? You may be a bit uncomfortable for a minute, but I’m going to give you some morphine to make the pain a bit easier.’ The man’s voice is calm, level, as if it is the most normal thing in the world to be lying broken on concrete, staring up at the dark sky. I want to laugh. I want to tell him how ridiculous it is that I am here. But nothing seems to work as it should.

The man’s face disappears from view. A woman in a neon jacket, her dark curly hair tied back in a ponytail, looms over me and shines a thin torch abruptly in my eyes, gazing at me with the same detached interest as if I was a specimen, not a person.

‘Do we need to bag her?’

I want to speak but I’m distracted by the pain in my legs. *Jesus*, I say, but I’m not sure if I say it aloud.

‘Multiple fractures. Pupils normal and reactive. BP ninety over sixty. She’s lucky she hit that awning. What are the odds of landing on a daybed, eh? ... I don’t like that bruising, though.’ Cold air on my midriff, the light touch of warm fingers. ‘Internal bleeding?’

‘Do we need a second team?’

‘Can you step back, please, sir? Right back?’

Another man’s voice: ‘I came outside for a smoke, and she dropped on to my bloody balcony. She nearly bloody landed on me.’

‘Well, there you go – it’s your lucky day. She didn’t.’

‘I got the shock of my life. You don’t expect people to just drop out of the bloody sky. Look at my chair. That was eight hundred pounds from the Conran Shop ... Do you think I can claim for it?’

A brief silence.

‘You can do what you want, sir. Tell you what, you could charge her for cleaning the blood off your balcony while you’re at it. How about that?’

The first man’s eyes slide towards his colleague. Time slips, I tilt with it. I’ve fallen off a roof? My face is cold and I realize distantly that I’m starting to shake.

‘She’s going into shock, Sam.’

A van door slides open somewhere below. And then the board beneath me moves and briefly *the pain the pain the pain* – Everything turns black.

A siren and a swirl of blue. Always a siren in London. We are moving. Neon slides across the interior of the ambulance, hiccups and repeats, illuminating the unexpectedly packed interior, the man in the green uniform, who is tapping something into his phone, before turning to adjust the drip above my head. The pain has lessened – morphine? – but with consciousness comes growing terror. A giant airbag is inflating slowly inside me, steadily blocking out everything else. *Oh, no. Oh, no.*

‘Egcuse nge?’

It takes two goes for the man, his arm braced against the back of the cab, to hear me. He turns and stoops towards my face. He smells of lemons and he has missed a bit when shaving. ‘You okay there?’

‘Ang I –’

The man leans down. ‘Sorry. Hard to hear over the siren. We’ll be at the hospital soon.’ He places a hand on mine. It is dry and warm and reassuring. I’m suddenly panicked in case he decides to let go. ‘Just hang on in there. What’s our ETA, Donna?’

I can’t say the words. My tongue fills my mouth. My thoughts are muddled, overlapping. Did I move my arms when they picked me up? I lifted my right hand, didn’t I?

‘Ang I garalysed?’ It emerges as a whisper.

‘What?’ He drops his ear to somewhere near my mouth.

‘Garalysed? Ang I garalysed?’

‘Paralysed?’ The man hesitates, his eyes on mine, then turns and looks down at my legs. ‘Can you wiggle your toes?’

I try to remember how to move my feet. It seems to require several more leaps of concentration than it used to. The man reaches down and lightly touches my toe, as if to remind me where they are. 'Try again. There you go.'

Pain shoots up both my legs. A gasp, possibly a sob. Mine.

'You're all right. Pain is good. I can't say for sure, but I don't think there's any spinal injury. You've done your hip, and a few other bits besides.'

His eyes are on mine. Kind eyes. He seems to understand how much I need convincing. I feel his hand close on mine. I have never needed a human touch more.

'Really. I'm pretty sure you're not paralysed.'

'Oh, thang Gog.' I hear my voice, as if from afar. My eyes brim with tears. 'Please don' leggo ogme,' I whisper.

He moves his face closer. 'I am not letting go of you.'

I want to speak, but his face blurs, and I am gone again.

Afterwards they tell me I fell two floors of the five, busting through an awning, breaking my fall on a top-of-the-range outsized canvas and wicker-effect waterproof-cushioned sun-lounger on the balcony of Mr Antony Gardiner, a copyright lawyer, and neighbour I have never met. My hip smashed into two pieces and two of my ribs and my collarbone snapped straight through. I broke two fingers on my left hand, and a metatarsal, which poked through the skin of my foot and caused one of the medical students to faint. My X-rays are a source of some fascination.

I keep hearing the voice of the paramedic who treated me: *You never know what will happen when you fall from a great height.* I am apparently very lucky. They tell me this and wait, smiling, as if I should respond with a huge grin, or perhaps a little tap dance. I don't feel lucky. I don't feel anything. I doze and wake, and sometimes the view above me is the bright lights of an operating theatre, and then it is a quiet, still room. A nurse's face. Snatches of conversation.

Did you see the mess the old woman on D4 made? That's some end of a shift, eh?

You work up at the Princess Elizabeth, right? You can tell them we know how to run an ER. Ha-ha-ha-ha-ha.

You just rest now, Louisa. We're taking care of everything. Just rest now.

The morphine makes me sleepy. They up my dose and it's a welcome cold trickle of oblivion.

I open my eyes to find my mother at the end of my bed.

'She's awake. Bernard, she's awake. Do we need to get the nurse?'

She's changed the colour of her hair, I think distantly. And then: Oh. It's my mother. My mother doesn't talk to me any more.

'Oh, thank God. Thank God.' My mother reaches up and touches the crucifix around her neck. It reminds me of someone but I cannot think who. She leans forward and lightly strokes my cheek. For some reason this makes my eyes fill immediately with tears. 'Oh, my little girl.' She is leaning over me, as if to shelter me from further damage. I smell her perfume, as familiar as my own. 'Oh, Lou.' She mops my tears with a tissue. 'I got the fright of my life when they called. Are you in pain? Do you need anything? Are you comfortable? What can I get you?'

She talks so fast that I cannot answer.

'We came as soon as they said. Treena's looking after Granddad. He sends his love. Well, he sort of made that noise, you know, but we all know what he means. Oh, love, how on earth did you get yourself into this mess? What on earth were you *thinking*?'

She doesn't seem to require an answer. All I have to do is lie here.

My mother dabs at her eyes, and again at mine. 'You're still my daughter. And ... and I couldn't bear it if something happened to you and we weren't ... you know.'

'Ngung -' I swallow the words. My tongue feels ridiculous. I sound drunk. 'I ngever wanged -'

'I know. But you made it so hard for me, Lou. I couldn't -'

'Not now, love, eh?' Dad touches her shoulder.

She looks away into the middle distance, and takes my hand. 'When we got the call. Oh. I thought - I didn't know -' She is sniffing again, her handkerchief pressed to her lips. 'Thank God she's okay, Bernard.'

'Of course she is. Made of rubber, this one, eh?'

Dad looms over me. We had last spoken on the telephone two months previously, but I haven't seen him in person for the eighteen months since I left my home town. He looks enormous and familiar, and desperately, desperately tired.

'Shorry,' I whisper. I can't think what else to say.

‘Don’t be daft. We’re just glad you’re okay. Even if you do look like you’ve done six rounds with Mike Tyson. Have you seen yourself in a mirror since you got here?’

I shake my head.

‘Maybe ... I might just hold off a bit longer. You know Terry Nicholls, that time he went right over his handlebars by the mini-mart? Well, take off the moustache, and that’s pretty much what you look like. Actually,’ he peers closer at my face, ‘now you mention it ...’

‘Bernard.’

‘We’ll bring you some tweezers tomorrow. Anyway, the next time you decide you want flying lessons, let’s head down the ole airstrip, yes? Jumping and flapping your arms is plainly not working for you.’

I try to smile.

They both bend over me. Their faces are strained, anxious. My parents.

‘She’s got thin, Bernard. Don’t you think she’s got thin?’

Dad leans closer, and then I see his eyes are a little watery, his smile a bit wobblier than usual. ‘Ah ... she looks beautiful, love. Believe me. You look bloody beautiful.’ He squeezes my hand, then lifts it to his mouth and kisses it. My dad has never done anything like that to me in my whole life.

It is then that I realize they thought I was going to die and a sob bursts unannounced from my chest. I shut my eyes against the hot tears and feel his large, wood-roughened palm around mine.

‘We’re here, sweetheart. It’s all right now. It’s all going to be okay.’

They make the fifty-mile journey every day for two weeks, catching the early train down, and then after that, every few days. Dad gets special dispensation from work, because Mum won’t travel by herself. There are, after all, all sorts in London. This is said more than once and always accompanied by a furtive glance behind her, as if a knife-wielding hood is even now sneaking into the ward. Treena is staying over to keep an eye on Granddad. There is an edge to the way Mum says it that makes me think this might not be my sister’s first choice of arrangements.

Mum brings homemade food, and has done so since the day we all stared at my lunch and, despite five minutes of intense speculation, couldn’t work out what it was. ‘And in plastic trays, Bernard. Like a prison.’ She prodded it sadly with a fork, then sniffed it. Since then she has arrived with enormous sandwiches, thick slices of ham or cheese in white bloomer

bread, homemade soups in flasks. ‘Food you can recognize,’ and feeds me like a baby. My tongue slowly returns to its normal size. Apparently I’d almost bitten through it when I landed. It’s not unusual, they tell me.

I have two operations to pin my hip, and my left foot and left arm are in plaster up to the joints. Keith, one of the porters, asks if he can sign my casts – apparently it’s bad luck to have them virgin white – and promptly writes a comment so filthy that Eveline, the Filipina nurse, has to put a plaster on it before the consultant comes around. When he pushes me to X-ray, or to the pharmacy, he tells me the gossip from around the hospital. I could do without hearing about the patients who die slowly and horribly, of which there seem to be an endless number, but it keeps him happy. I sometimes wonder what he tells people about me. I am the girl who fell off a five-storey building and lived. In hospital status, this apparently puts me some way above the compacted bowel in C ward, or That Daft Bint Who Accidentally Took Her Thumb Off with Pruning Shears.

It’s amazing how quickly you become institutionalized. I wake, accept the ministrations of a handful of people I now recognize, try to say the right thing to the consultants, and wait for my parents to arrive. My parents keep busy with small tasks in my room, and become uncharacteristically deferential in the face of the doctors. Dad apologizes repeatedly for my inability to bounce, until Mum kicks him, quite hard, in the ankle.

After the rounds are finished, Mum usually has a walk around the concourse shops downstairs and returns exclaiming in hushed tones at the number of fast-food outlets. ‘That one-legged man from the cardio ward, Bernard. Sitting down there stuffing his face with cheeseburger and chips, like you wouldn’t believe.’

Dad sits and reads the local paper in the chair at the end of my bed. The first week he keeps checking it for reports of my accident. I try to tell him that in this part of the city even double murders barely merit a News In Brief, but in Stortfold the previous week the local paper’s front page ran with ‘Supermarket Trolleys Left in Wrong Area of Car Park’. The week before that it was ‘Schoolboys Sad at State of Duck Pond’ so he has yet to be convinced.

On the Friday after the final operation on my hip, my mother brings a dressing-gown that is one size too big for me, and a large brown-paper bag of egg sandwiches. I don’t have to ask what they are: the sulphurous smell

floods the room as soon as she opens her bag. My father wafts his hand in front of his nose. 'The nurses'll be blaming me, Josie,' he says, opening and closing my door.

'Eggs will build her up. She's too thin. And, besides, you can't talk. You were blaming the dog for your awful smells two years after he'd actually died.'

'Just keeping the romance alive, love.'

Mum lowers her voice: 'Treena says her last fellow put the blankets over her head when he broke wind. Can you imagine!'

Dad turns to me. 'When I do it, your mother won't even stay in the same postcode.'

There is tension in the air, even as they laugh. I can feel it. When your whole world shrinks to four walls, you become acutely attuned to slight variations in atmosphere. It's in the way consultants turn away slightly when they're examining X-rays or the nurses cover their mouths when they're talking about someone nearby who has just died.

'What?' I say. 'What is it?'

They look awkwardly at each other.

'So ...' Mum sits on the end of my bed. 'The doctor said ... the consultant said ... it's not clear how you fell.'

I bite into an egg sandwich. I can pick things up with my left hand now. 'Oh, that. I got distracted.'

'While walking around a roof.'

I chew for a minute.

'Is there any chance you were sleepwalking, sweetheart?'

'Dad – I've never sleepwalked in my life.'

'Yes, you have. There was that time when you were thirteen and you sleepwalked downstairs and ate half of Treena's birthday cake.'

'Um. I may not have actually been asleep.'

'And there's your blood-alcohol level. They said ... you had drunk ... an awful lot.'

'I'd had a tough night at work. I had a drink or two and I just went up on the roof to get some air. And then I got distracted by a voice.'

'You heard a *voice*.'

'I was standing on the top – looking out. I do it sometimes. And there was this girl's voice behind me and it gave me a shock and I lost my footing.'

‘A girl?’

‘I only really heard her voice.’

Dad leans forward. ‘You’re sure it was an actual girl? Not an imaginary —’

‘It’s my hip that’s mashed up, Dad, not my brain.’

‘They did say it was a girl who called the ambulance.’ Mum touches Dad’s arm.

‘So you’re saying it really *was* an accident,’ he says.

I stop eating. They look away from each other guiltily.

‘What? You ... you think I jumped off?’

‘We’re not saying anything.’ Dad scratches his head. ‘It’s just – well – things had all gone so wrong since ... and we hadn’t seen you for so long ... and we were a bit surprised that you’d be up walking on the roof of a building in the wee small hours. You used to be afraid of heights.’

‘I used to be engaged to a man who thought it was normal to calculate how many calories he’d burned while he slept. Jesus. This is why you’ve been so nice to me? You think I tried to kill myself?’

‘It’s just he was asking us all sorts ...’

‘Who was asking what?’

‘The psychiatrist bloke. They just want to make sure you’re okay, love. We know things have been all – well, you know – since –’

‘Psychiatrist?’

‘They’re putting you on the waiting list to see someone. To talk, you know. And we’ve had a long chat with the doctors and you’re coming home with us. Just while you recover. You can’t stay by yourself in that flat of yours. It’s –’

‘You’ve been in my flat?’

‘Well, we had to fetch your things.’

There is a long silence. I think of them standing in my doorway, my mother’s hands tight on her bag as she surveyed the unwashed bed-linen, the empty wine bottles lined up in a row on the mantelpiece, the solitary half-bar of Fruit and Nut in the fridge. I picture them shaking their heads, looking at each other. *Are you sure we’ve got the right place, Bernard?*

‘Right now you need to be with your family. Just till you’re back on your feet.’

I want to say I’ll be fine in my flat, no matter what they think of it. I want to do my job and come home and not think until my next shift. I want to say

I can't come back to Stortfold and be *that girl* again, *the one who*. I don't want to have to feel the weight of my mother's carefully disguised disapproval, of my father's cheerful determination that *it's all okay, everything is just fine*, as if saying it enough times will actually make it okay. I don't want to pass Will's house every day, to think about what I was part of, the thing that will always be there.

But I don't say any of it. Because suddenly I'm tired and everything hurts and I just can't fight any more.

Dad brings me home two weeks later in his work van. There is only room for two in the front, so Mum has stayed behind to prepare the house, and as the motorway speeds beneath us, I find my stomach tightening nervously.

The cheerful streets of my hometown feel foreign to me now. I look at them with a distant, analytical eye, noting how small everything looks, how tired, how *twee*. I realize this is how Will must have seen it when he first came home after his accident, and push the thought away. As we drive down our street, I find myself sinking slightly in my seat. I don't want to make polite conversation with neighbours, to explain myself. I don't want to be judged for what I did.

'You okay?' Dad turns, as if he guesses something of what's going through my head.

'Fine.'

'Good girl.' He puts a hand briefly on my shoulder.

Mum is already at the door as we pull up. I suspect she has been standing by the window for the past half-hour. Dad puts one of my bags on the step, then comes back to help me out, hoisting the other over his shoulder.

I place my cane carefully on the paving stones, and feel the twitching of curtains behind me as I make my way slowly up the path. *Look who it is*, I can hear them whispering. *What do you think she's done now?*

Dad steers me forward, watching my feet carefully, as if they might suddenly shoot out and go somewhere they shouldn't. 'Okay there?' he keeps saying. 'Not too fast now.'

I can see Granddad hovering behind Mum in the hall, wearing his checked shirt and his good blue jumper. Nothing has changed. The wallpaper is the same. The hall carpet is the same, the lines in the worn pile visible from where Mum must have vacuumed that morning. I can see my

old blue anorak hanging on the hook. Eighteen months. I feel as if I have been away for a decade.

‘Don’t rush her,’ Mum says, her hands pressed together. ‘You’re going too fast, Bernard.’

‘She’s hardly flipping Mo Farah. If she goes any slower we’ll be moonwalking.’

‘Watch those steps. Should you stand behind her, Bernard, coming up the steps? You know, in case she falls backwards?’

‘I know where the steps are,’ I say, through gritted teeth. ‘I only lived here for twenty-six years.’

‘Watch she doesn’t catch herself on that lip there, Bernard. You don’t want her to smash the other hip.’

Oh, God, I think. Is this what it was like for you, Will? Every single day?

And then my sister is in the doorway, pushing past Mum. ‘Oh, for God’s sake, Mum. Come on, Hopalong. You’re turning us into a freaking sideshow.’

Treena wedges her shoulder under my armpit and turns briefly to glare out at the neighbours, her eyebrows raised as if to say, *Really?* I can almost hear the swishing of curtains as they close.

‘Bunch of bloody rubberneckers. Anyway, hurry up. I promised Thomas he could see your scars before I take him to youth club. God, how much weight have you lost? Your boobs must look like two tangerines in a pair of socks.’

It’s hard to laugh and walk at the same time. Thomas runs to hug me so that I have to stop and put a hand against the wall to keep my balance as we collide. ‘Did they really cut you open and put you back together?’ he says. His head comes up to my chest. He’s missing four front teeth. ‘Grandpa says they probably put you back together all the wrong way. And God only knows how we’ll tell the difference.’

‘Bernard!’

‘I was *joking*.’

‘Louisa.’ Granddad’s voice is thick and hesitant. He reaches forward unsteadily and hugs me and I hug him back. He pulls away, his old hands gripping my arms surprisingly tightly, and frowns at me, a mock anger.

‘I know, Daddy. I know. But she’s home now,’ says Mum.

‘You’re back in your old room,’ says Dad. ‘I’m afraid we redecorated with Transformers wallpaper for Thom. You don’t mind the odd Autobot

and Predacon, right?’

‘I had worms in my bottom,’ says Thomas. ‘Mum says I’m not to talk about it outside the house. Or put my fingers up my –’

‘Oh, good Lord,’ says Mum.

‘Welcome home, Lou,’ says Dad, and promptly drops my bag on my foot.



CHAPTER THREE

Looking back, for the first nine months after Will's death I was in a kind of daze. I went straight to Paris and simply didn't go home, giddy with freedom, with the appetites that Will had stirred in me. I got a job at a bar favoured by expats where they didn't mind my terrible French, and I grew better at it. I rented a tiny attic room in the 16th, above a Middle Eastern restaurant, and I would lie awake, listening to the sound of the late drinkers and the early-morning deliveries, and every day I felt like I was living someone else's life.

Those early months, it was as if I had lost a layer of skin – I felt everything more intensely. I woke up laughing, or crying, saw everything as if a filter had been removed. I ate new foods, walked strange streets, spoke to people in a language that wasn't mine. Sometimes I felt haunted by him, as if I was seeing it all through his eyes, heard his voice in my ear.

What do you think of that, then, Clark?

I told you you'd love this.

Eat it! Try it! Go on!

I felt lost without our daily routines. It took weeks for my hands not to feel useless without daily contact with his body: the soft shirt I would button, the warm, motionless hands I would wash gently, the silky hair I could still feel between my fingers. I missed his voice, his abrupt, hard-earned laugh, the feel of his lips against my fingers, the way his eyelids would lower when he was about to drop off to sleep. My mother, still aghast at what I had been part of, had told me that while she loved me, she could not reconcile this Louisa with the daughter she had raised, so with the loss of my family, as well as the man I had loved, every thread that had linked me to who I was had been cut. I felt as if I had simply floated off, untethered, to some unknown universe.

So I acted out a new life. I made casual, arm's-length friendships with other travellers: young English students on gap years, Americans retracing the steps of literary heroes, certain that they would never return to the Midwest, wealthy young bankers, day-trippers, a constantly changing cast that drifted in and through and past; escapees from other lives. I smiled and

I chatted and I worked, and I told myself I was doing what he wanted. That there had to be comfort, at least, in that.

Winter loosened its grip and the spring was beautiful. Then almost overnight I woke up one morning and realized I had fallen out of love with the city. Or, at least, I didn't feel Parisian enough to stay. The stories of the expats began to sound wearily similar, the Parisians to seem unfriendly – or, at least, I noticed, several times a day, the myriad ways in which I would never quite fit in. The city, compelling as it was, felt like a glamorous couture dress that I had bought in haste but didn't quite fit me after all. I handed in my notice and went travelling around Europe.

No two months had ever left me feeling more inadequate. I was lonely almost all the time. I hated not knowing where I was going to sleep each night, was permanently anxious about train timetables and currency, found it difficult to make friends when I didn't trust anyone I met. And what could I say about myself, anyway? When people asked me, I could give them only the most cursory details. All the stuff that was important or interesting about me was what I couldn't share. Without someone to talk to, every sight I saw – whether it was the Trevi Fountain or a canal in Amsterdam – felt simply like a box I'd needed to tick on a list. I spent the last week on a beach in Greece that reminded me too much of a beach I had been on with Will not too long before, and finally, after a week of sitting on the sand fending off bronzed men, who all seemed to be called Dmitri, and trying to tell myself I was actually having a good time, I gave up and returned to Paris. Mostly because that was the first time it had occurred to me that I had nowhere else to go.

For two weeks I slept on the sofa of a girl I'd worked with at the bar, while I tried to decide what to do next. Recalling a conversation I'd had with Will about careers, I wrote to several colleges about fashion courses, but I had no history of work to show them and they rebuffed me politely. The place on the course I had originally won after Will died had been awarded to someone else because I had failed to defer. I could apply again next year, the administrator said, in the tones of someone who knew I wouldn't.

I looked online at jobs websites and saw that, despite everything I had been through, I was still unqualified for the kind of jobs I might be interested in doing. And then by chance, just as I was wondering what to do next, Michael Lawler, Will's lawyer, rang me and suggested it was time to

do something with the money Will had left. It was the excuse to move that I needed. He helped me negotiate a price on a scarily expensive two-bedroomed flat on the edge of the Square Mile, which I bought largely because I remembered Will once talking about the wine bar on the corner, which made me feel a bit closer to him; there was a little left over with which to furnish it. Six weeks later I came back to England, got a job at the Shamrock and Clover, slept with a man called Phil I would never see again, and waited to feel as if I had really started living.

Nine months on I was still waiting.

I didn't go out much that first week home. I was sore, and grew tired quickly, so it was easy to lie in bed and doze, wiped out by extra-strength painkillers, and tell myself that letting my body recover was all that mattered. In a weird way, being back in our little family house suited me: it was the first place I had managed to sleep more than four hours at a stretch since I had left; it was small enough that I could always reach out for a wall to support myself. Mum fed me, Granddad kept me company (Treena had gone back to college, taking Thom with her), and I watched a lot of daytime television, marvelling at its never-ending advertisements for loan companies and stair lifts, and its preoccupations with minor celebrities that the best part of a year abroad had left me unable to recognize. It was like being in a little cocoon, one that, admittedly, had a whacking great elephant squatting in its corner.

We didn't talk about anything that might upset this delicate equilibrium. I would watch whatever celebrity news daytime television threw up and then say, at supper, 'Well, what about that Shayna West, then, eh?' And Mum and Dad would leap on the topic gratefully, remarking that she was a trollop or had nice hair or that she was no better than she should be. We covered *Bargains In Your Attic* ('I always wonder what that Victorian planter of your mother's would have been worth ... ugly old thing.') and *Ideal Homes in the Country* ('I wouldn't wash a dog in that bathroom'). I didn't think beyond each mealtime, beyond the basic challenges of getting dressed, brushing my teeth and completing whatever tiny tasks my mother set me ('You know, love, when I'm out, if you could sort your washing, I'll do it with my coloureds').

But, like a creeping tide, the outside world insisted steadily on intruding. I heard the neighbours asking questions of my mother as she hung out the

washing. *Your Lou home, then, is she?* And Mum's uncharacteristically curt response: *She is.* I found myself avoiding the rooms in the house from which I could see the castle. But I knew it was there, the people in it living, breathing links to Will. Sometimes I wondered what had happened to them; while in Paris I had been forwarded a letter from Mrs Traynor, thanking me formally for everything I had done for her son. 'I am conscious that you did everything you could.' But that was it. That family had gone from being my whole life to a ghostly remnant of a time I wouldn't allow myself to remember. Now, as our street sat moored in the shadow of the castle for several hours every evening, I felt the Traynors' presence like a rebuke.

I'd been there two weeks before I realized that Mum and Dad no longer went to their social club. 'Isn't it Tuesday?' I said, on the third week, as we sat around the dinner table. 'Shouldn't you be gone by now?'

They glanced at each other. 'Ah, no. We're fine here,' Dad said, chewing a piece of his pork chop.

'I'm fine by myself, honestly,' I told them. 'I'm much better now. And I'm quite happy watching television.' I secretly longed to sit, unobserved, with nobody else in the room. I had barely been left alone for more than half an hour at a time since I'd come home. 'Really. Go out and enjoy yourselves. Don't mind me.'

'We ... we don't really go to the club any more,' said Mum, as she sliced through a potato.

'People ... they had a lot to say. About what went on.' Dad shrugged. 'In the end it was easier just to stay out of it.' The silence that followed this lasted a full six minutes.

And there were other, more concrete, reminders of the life I had left behind. Ones that wore skin-tight running pants with special wicking properties.

It was on the fourth morning Patrick jogged past our house that I thought it might be more than coincidence. I had heard his voice the first day and limped blearily to the window, peering through the blind. And there he was below me, stretching out his hamstrings while talking to a blonde girl with a ponytail; she was clad in matching blue Lycra so tight I could pretty much work out what she'd had for breakfast. They looked like two Olympians missing a bobsleigh.

I stood back from the window in case he looked up and saw me, and within a minute, they were gone again, jogging down the road, backs erect,

legs pumping, like a pair of glossy turquoise carriage ponies.

Two days later I was getting dressed when I heard them. Patrick was saying something loudly about carb-loading, and this time the girl flicked a suspicious glance towards my house, as if she were wondering why they had stopped in exactly the same place twice.

On the third day I was in the front room with Granddad when they arrived. 'We should practise sprints,' Patrick was saying loudly. 'Tell you what, you go to the third lamppost and back and I'll time you. Two-minute intervals. Go!'

Granddad rolled his eyes meaningfully.

'Has he been doing this the whole time I've been back?'

Granddad's eyes rolled pretty much into the back of his head.

I watched through the net curtains as Patrick stood, eyes fixed on his stopwatch, his best side presented to my window. He was wearing a black fleece zip-up top and matching Lycra shorts, and as he stood, a few feet the other side of the curtain, I was able to gaze at him, quietly amazed that this was someone I had been sure, for so long, I loved.

'Keep going!' he yelled, looking up from the stopwatch. And, like an obedient gun dog, the girl touched the lamppost beside him and bolted away again. 'Forty-two point three eight seconds,' he said approvingly, when she returned, panting. 'I reckon you could shave another point five of a second off that.'

'That's for your benefit,' said my mother, who had walked in bearing two mugs.

'I did wonder.'

'His mother asked me in the supermarket were you back and I said you were. Don't look at me like that – I could hardly lie to the woman.' She nodded towards the window. 'That one's had her boobs done. They're the talk of Stortfold. Apparently you could rest two cups of tea on them.' She stood beside me for a moment. 'You know they're engaged?'

I waited for the pang, but it was so mild it could have been wind. 'They look ... well suited.'

My mother stood there for a moment, watching him. 'He's not a bad sort, Lou. You just ... changed.' She handed me a mug and turned away.

Finally, on the morning he stopped to do press-ups on the pavement outside the house, I opened the front door and stepped out. I leaned against the

porch, my arms folded across my chest, watching until he looked up. 'I wouldn't stop there for too long. Next door's dog is a bit partial to that bit of pavement.'

'Lou!' he exclaimed, as if I was the very last person he expected to see standing outside my own house, which he had visited several times a week for the seven years we had been together. 'Well ... I'm surprised to see you back. I thought you were off to conquer the big wide world!'

His fiancée, who was doing press-ups beside him, looked up, then back down at the pavement. It might have been my imagination, but her buttocks might have clenched even more tightly. Up, down, she bobbed furiously. Up and down. I found myself worrying slightly for the welfare of her new bosom.

He bounced to his feet. 'This is Caroline, my fiancée.' He kept his eyes on me, perhaps waiting for some kind of reaction. 'We're training for the next Ironman. We've done two together already.'

'How ... romantic,' I said.

'Well, Caroline and I feel it's good to do things together,' he said.

'So I see,' I replied. 'And his and hers turquoise Lycra!'

'Oh. Yeah. Team colour.'

There was a short silence.

I gave a little air punch. 'Go, team!'

Caroline sprang to her feet and began to stretch out her thigh muscles, folding her leg behind her like a stork. She nodded towards me, the least civility she could reasonably get away with.

'You've lost weight,' he said.

'Yeah, well. A saline-drip diet will do that to you.'

'I heard you had an ... accident.' He cocked his head sideways, sympathetically.

'News travels fast.'

'Still. I'm glad you're okay.' He sniffed, looked down the road. 'It must have been hard for you this past year. You know. Doing what you did and all.'

And there it was. I tried to keep control of my breathing. Caroline resolutely refused to look at me, extending her leg in a hamstring stretch. Then, 'Anyway ... congratulations on the marriage.'

He surveyed his future wife proudly, lost in admiration of her sinewy leg. 'Well, it's like they say – you just know when you know.' He gave me a

faux-apologetic smile. And that was what finished me off.

‘I’m sure you did. And I guess you’ve got plenty put aside to pay for the wedding – they’re not cheap, are they?’

They both looked at me.

‘What with selling my story to the newspapers. What did they pay you, Pat? A couple of thousand? Treena never could find out the exact figure. Still, Will’s death should be good for a few matching Lycra onesies, right?’

The way Caroline’s face shot towards his told me this was one particular part of Patrick’s history that he had not yet got round to sharing.

He stared at me, two pinpricks of colour bleeding onto his face. ‘That was nothing to do with me.’

‘Of course not. Nice to see you, anyway, Pat. Good luck with the wedding, Caroline! I’m sure you’ll be the ... firmest bride around.’ I turned and walked slowly back inside. I closed the door, resting against it, heart thumping, until I could be sure that they had finally jogged on.

‘Arse,’ said Granddad, as I limped back into the living room. And again, glancing dismissively at the window: ‘Arse.’ Then he chuckled.

I stared at him. And, completely unexpectedly, I found I had started to laugh, for the first time in as long as I could remember.

‘So did you decide what you’re going to do? When you’re better?’

I was lying on my bed. Treena was calling from college, while she waited for Thomas to come out of his football club. I stared up at the ceiling, on which Thomas had stuck a whole galaxy of Day-glo stickers, which, apparently, nobody could remove without bringing half the ceiling with them. ‘Not really.’

‘You’ve got to do something. You can’t sit around here on your backside for all eternity.’

‘I won’t sit on my backside. Besides, my hip still hurts. The physio said I’m better off lying down.’

‘Mum and Dad are wondering what you’re going to do. There are no jobs in Stortfold.’

‘I do know that.’

‘But you’re drifting. You don’t seem to be interested in anything.’

‘Treen, I just fell off a building. I’m recuperating.’

‘And before that you were wafting around travelling. And then you were working in a bar until you knew what you wanted to do. You’ll have to sort

your head out at some point. If you're not going back to school, you have to figure out what it is you're actually going to do with your life.

'I'm just saying. Anyway, if you're going to stay in Stortfold, you need to rent out that flat. Mum and Dad can't support you for ever.'

'This from the woman who has been supported by the Bank of Mum and Dad for the past eight years.'

'I'm in full-time education. That's different. So, anyway, I went through your bank statements while you were in hospital, and after I'd paid all your bills, I worked out you've got about fifteen hundred pounds left over, including statutory sick pay. By the way, what the hell were all those transatlantic phone calls? They cost you a fortune.'

'None of your business.'

'So, I made you a list of estate agents in the area who do rentals. And then I thought maybe we could take another look at college applications. Someone might have dropped out of that course you wanted.'

'Treen. You're making me tired.'

'No point hanging around. You'll feel better once you've got some focus.'

For all it was annoying, there was something reassuring about my sister nagging at me. Nobody else dared to. It was as if my parents still believed there was something very wrong at the heart of me, and that I must be treated with kid gloves. Mum laid my washing, neatly folded, on the end of my bed and cooked me three meals a day, and when I caught her watching me she would smile, an awkward half-smile, which covered everything we didn't want to say to each other. Dad took me to my physio appointments, sat beside me on the sofa to watch television and didn't even take the mickey out of me. Treena was the only one who treated me like she always had.

'You know what I'm going to say, don't you?'

I turned onto my side, wincing.

'I do. And don't.'

'Well, you know what Will would have said. You had a deal. You can't back out of it.'

'Okay. That's it, Treen. We're done with this conversation.'

'Fine. Thom's just coming out of the changing rooms. See you Friday!' she said, as if we had just been talking about music, or where she was going on holiday, or soap.

And I was left staring at the ceiling.
You had a deal.
Yeah. And look how that turned out.

For all Treena moaned at me, in the weeks that had passed since I'd come home I had made some progress. I'd stopped using the cane, which had made me feel around eighty-nine years old, and which I had managed to leave behind in almost every place I'd visited since coming home. Most mornings I took Granddad for a walk around the park, at Mum's request. The doctor had instructed him to take daily exercise but when she had followed him one day she had found he was simply walking to the corner shop to buy a bumper pack of pork scratchings and eating them on a slow walk home.

We walked slowly, both of us with a limp and neither of us with any real place to be.

Mum kept suggesting we do the grounds of the castle 'for a change of scene', but I ignored her, and as the gate shut behind us each morning Granddad nodded firmly in the direction of the park. It wasn't just because this way was shorter, or closer to the betting shop. I think he knew I didn't want to go back there. I wasn't ready. I wasn't sure I would ever be ready.

We did two slow circuits of the duck pond, and sat on a bench in the watery spring sunshine to watch the toddlers and their parents feeding the fat ducks, and the teenagers smoking, yelling and whacking each other; the helpless combat of early courtship. We took a stroll over to the bookie's so Granddad could lose three pounds on an each-way bet on a horse called Wag The Dog. Then, as he crumpled up his betting slip and threw it into the bin, I said I'd buy him a jam doughnut from the supermarket.

'Oh fat,' he said, as we stood in the bakery section.

I frowned at him.

'Oh fat,' he said, pointing at our doughnuts, and laughed.

'Oh. Yup. That's what we'll tell Mum. Low-fat doughnuts.'

Mum said his new medication made him giggly. I had decided there were worse things that could happen to you.

Granddad was still giggling at his own joke as we queued at the checkout. I kept my head down, digging in my pockets for change. I was thinking about whether I would help Dad with the garden that weekend. So it took me a minute to grasp what was being said in whispers behind me.

‘It’s the guilt. They say she tried to jump off a block of flats.’

‘Well, you would, wouldn’t you? I know I couldn’t live with myself.’

‘I’m surprised she can show her face around here.’

I stood very still.

‘You know, poor Josie Clark is still mortified. She goes to confession every single week, and you know that woman is as blameless as a line of clean laundry.’

Granddad was pointing at the doughnuts and mouthing at the checkout girl: ‘Oh fat.’

She smiled politely. ‘Eighty-six pence, please.’

‘The Traynors have never been the same.’

‘Well, it destroyed them, didn’t it?’

‘Eighty-six pence, please.’

It took me several seconds to register that the checkout girl was looking at me, waiting. I pulled a handful of coins from my pocket. My fingers fumbled as I tried to sort through them.

‘You’d think Josie wouldn’t dare leave her in sole charge of her granddaddy, wouldn’t you?’

‘You don’t think she’d ...’

‘Well, you don’t know. She’s done it the once, after all ...’

My cheeks were flaming. My money clattered onto the counter. Granddad was still repeating, ‘OH FAT. OH FAT,’ at the bemused checkout girl, waiting for her to get the joke. I pulled at his sleeve. ‘Come on, Granddad, we have to go.’

‘Oh fat,’ he insisted, again.

‘Right,’ she said, and smiled kindly.

‘*Please, Granddad.*’ I felt hot and dizzy, as if I might faint. They might still have been talking but my ears were ringing so loudly I couldn’t tell.

‘Bye-bye,’ he said.

‘Bye then,’ said the girl.

‘Nice,’ said Granddad, as we emerged into the sunlight. Then, looking at me: ‘Why you crying?’

So here is the thing about being involved in a catastrophic, life-changing event. You think it’s just the catastrophic life-changing event that you’re going to have to deal with: the flashbacks, the sleepless nights, the endless running over events in your head, asking yourself if you had done the right

thing, said the things you should have said, whether you could have changed things, had you done it even a degree differently.

My mother had told me that being with Will at the end would affect the rest of my life, and I had thought she meant me, psychologically. I'd thought she meant the guilt I would have to learn to get over, the grief, the insomnia, the weird, inappropriate bursts of anger, the endless internal dialogue with someone who wasn't even there. But now I saw it wasn't just me: in a digital age, I would be that person for ever. Even if I managed to wipe the whole thing from my memory, I would never be allowed to disassociate myself from Will's death. My name would be tied to his for as long as there were pixels and a screen. People would form judgements about me, based on the most cursory knowledge – or sometimes no knowledge at all – and there was nothing I could do about it.

I cut my hair into a bob. I changed the way I dressed, bagging up everything that had ever made me distinctive and stuffing it into the back of my wardrobe. I adopted Treena's uniform of jeans and a generic T-shirt. Now, when I read newspaper stories about the bank teller who had stolen a fortune, the woman who had killed her child, the sibling who had disappeared, I found myself not shuddering in horror, as I once might have, but wondering instead at the story that hadn't made it into black and white.

What I felt with them was a weird kinship. I was tainted. The world around me knew it. Worse, I had started to know it too.

I tucked what remained of my dark hair into a beanie, put my sunglasses on, and walked to the library, doing everything I could not to let my limp show, even though it made my jaw ache with concentration.

I made my way past the singing-toddler group in the children's corner, and the silent genealogy enthusiasts trying to confirm that, yes, they were distantly connected to King Richard III, and sat down in the corner with the files of local papers. It wasn't hard to locate August 2009. I took a breath, then opened them halfway and flicked through the headlines.

Local Man Ends His Life at Swiss Clinic

Traynor Family Ask for Privacy at 'Difficult Time'

The 35-year-old son of Steven Traynor, custodian of Stortfold Castle, has ended his life at Dignitas, the controversial centre for assisted suicide. Mr Traynor was left quadriplegic after a traffic accident in 2007. He apparently travelled to the clinic with his family and his carer, Louisa Clark, 27, also from Stortfold.

Police are investigating the circumstances surrounding the death. Sources say they have not ruled out the possibility that a prosecution may arise.

Louisa Clark's parents, Bernard and Josephine Clark, of Renfrew Road, refused to comment.

Camilla Traynor, a Justice of the Peace, is understood to have stood down from the bench following her son's suicide. A local source said her position, given the actions of the family, had become 'untenable'.

And then there it was, Will's face, looking out from the grainy newspaper photograph. That slightly sardonic smile, the direct gaze. I felt, briefly, winded.

Mr Traynor's death ends a successful career in the City, where he was known as a ruthless asset stripper, but also as someone with a sure eye for a corporate bargain. His colleagues yesterday lined up to pay tribute to a man they described as

I closed the newspaper. When I could be sure that I had got my face under control, I looked up. Around me the library hummed with quiet industry. The toddlers kept singing, their reedy voices chaotic and meandering, their mothers clapping fondly around them. The librarian behind me was discussing *sotto voce*, with a colleague, the best way to make Thai curry. The man beside me ran his finger down an ancient electoral roll, murmuring, 'Fisher, Fitzgibbon, Fitzwilliam ...'

I had done nothing. It was more than eighteen months and I had done nothing, bar sell drinks in two different countries and feel sorry for myself. And now, after four weeks back in the house I'd grown up in, I could feel Stortfold reaching out to suck me in, to reassure me that I could be fine here. It would be all right. There might be no great adventures, sure, and a bit of discomfort as people adjusted to my presence again, but there were worse things, right, than to be with your family, loved and secure? Safe?

I looked down at the pile of newspapers in front of me. The most recent front-page headline read:

ROW OVER DISABLED PARKING SPACE IN FRONT OF POST OFFICE

I thought back to Dad, sitting on my hospital bed, looking in vain for a report of an extraordinary accident.

I failed you, Will. I failed you in every way possible.

You could hear the shouting all the way up the street when I finally arrived home. As I opened the door my ears were filled with the sound of Thomas wailing. My sister was scolding him, her finger wagging, in the corner of

the living room. Mum was leaning over Granddad with a washing-up bowl of water and a scouring pad, while Granddad politely batted her away.

‘What’s going on?’

Mum moved to the side and I saw Granddad’s face clearly for the first time. He was sporting a new set of jet black eyebrows and a thick black slightly uneven moustache.

‘Permanent pen,’ said Mum. ‘From now on nobody is to leave Granddad napping in the same room as Thomas.’

‘You have to stop drawing on things,’ Treena was yelling. ‘Paper only, okay? Not walls. Not faces. Not Mrs Reynolds’s dog. Not my pants.’

‘I was doing you days of the week!’

‘I don’t need days-of-the-week pants!’ she shouted. ‘And if I did I would spell Wednesday correctly!’

‘Don’t scold him, Treen,’ said Mum, leaning back to see if she’d had any effect. ‘It could be a lot worse.’

In our little house, Dad’s footsteps coming down the stairs sounded like a particularly emphatic roll of thunder. He barrelled into the front room, his shoulders hunched in frustration, his hair standing up on one side. ‘Can’t a man get a nap in his own house on his day off? This place is like a ruddy madhouse.’

We all stopped and stared at him.

‘What? What did I say?’

‘Bernard –’

‘Ah, come on. Our Lou doesn’t think I mean *her* –’

‘Oh, my sweet Lord.’ Mum’s hand flew to her face.

My sister had started to push Thomas out of the room. ‘Oh, boy,’ she hissed. ‘Thomas, you’d better get out of here right now. Because I swear when your grandpa gets hold of you –’

‘What?’ Dad frowned. ‘What’s the matter?’

Granddad barked a laugh. He held up a shaking finger.

It was almost magnificent. Thomas had coloured in the whole of Dad’s face with blue marker pen. His eyes emerged like two gooseberries from a sea of cobalt blue. ‘What?’

Thomas’s voice, as he disappeared down the corridor, was a wail of protest. ‘We were watching *Avatar*! He said he wouldn’t mind being an avatar!’

Dad’s eyes widened. He strode to the mirror over the mantelpiece.

There was a brief silence. ‘Oh, my God.’

‘Bernard, don’t take the Lord’s name in vain.’

‘He’s turned me bloody blue, Josie. I think I’m entitled to take the Lord’s name to Butlins in a flipping wheelbarrow. Is this permanent pen? THOMMO? IS THIS PERMANENT PEN?’

‘We’ll get it off, Dad.’ My sister closed the door to the garden behind her. Beyond it you could just make out Thomas’s wailing.

‘I’m meant to be overseeing the new fencing at the castle tomorrow. I have contractors coming. How the hell am I meant to deal with contractors if I’m *blue*?’ Dad spat on his hand and started to rub at his face. The faintest smudging appeared, but mostly seemed to spread onto his palm. ‘It’s not coming off. Josie, *it’s not coming off!*’

Mum shifted her attention from Granddad and set about Dad with the scouring pad. ‘Just stay still, Bernard. I’m doing what I can.’

Treena went for her laptop bag. ‘I’ll go on the internet. I’m sure there’s something. Toothpaste or nail-polish remover or bleach or –’

‘You are not putting bleach on my ruddy face!’ Dad roared. Granddad, with his new pirate moustache, sat giggling in the corner of the room.

I began to edge past them.

Mum was holding Dad’s face with her left hand as she scrubbed. She turned, as if she’d only just seen me. ‘Lou! I didn’t ask – are you okay, love? Did you have a nice walk?’ Everyone stopped abruptly to smile at me; a smile that said, *Everything’s okay here, Lou. You don’t have to worry.* I hated that smile.

‘Fine.’

It was the answer they all wanted. Mum turned to Dad. ‘That’s grand. Isn’t it grand, Bernard?’

‘It is. Great news.’

‘If you sort out your whites, love, I’ll pop them in the wash with Daddy’s later.’

‘Actually,’ I said, ‘don’t bother. I’ve been thinking. It’s time for me to go home.’

Nobody spoke. Mum glanced at Dad. Granddad let out another little giggle and clamped his hand over his mouth.

‘Fair enough,’ said Dad, with as much dignity as a middle-aged, blueberry-coloured man could muster. ‘But if you go back to that flat, Louisa, you go on one condition ...’



CHAPTER FOUR

‘My name is Natasha and I lost my husband to cancer three years ago.’

On a humid Monday night, the members of the Moving On Circle sat in a ring of orange office chairs in the Pentecostal Church Hall, alongside Marc, the leader, a tall, moustachioed man, whose whole being exuded a kind of exhausted melancholy, and one empty chair.

‘I’m Fred. My wife, Jilly, died in September. She was seventy-four.’

‘Sunil. My twin brother died of leukaemia two years ago.’

‘William. Dead father, six months ago. All a bit ridiculous, frankly, as we never really got on when he was alive. I keep asking myself why I’m here.’

There was a peculiar scent to grief. It smelt of damp, imperfectly ventilated church halls and poor-quality teabags. It smelt of meals for one and stale cigarettes, smoked hunched against the cold. It smelt of spritzed hair and armpits, little practical victories against a morass of despair. That smell alone told me I did not belong there, whatever I had promised Dad.

I felt like a fraud. Plus they all looked so ... *sad*.

I shifted uneasily in my seat, and Marc caught me. He gave me a reassuring smile. *We know*, it said. *We’ve been here before*.

I bet you haven’t, I responded silently.

‘Sorry. Sorry I’m late.’ The door opened, letting in a blast of warm air, and the empty chair was taken by a mop-headed teenager, who folded his limbs into place as if they were always somehow too long for the space they were in.

‘Jake. You missed last week. Everything okay?’

‘Sorry. Dad messed up at work and he couldn’t get me here.’

‘Don’t worry. It’s good you made it. You know where the drinks are.’

The boy glanced around the room from under his long fringe, hesitating slightly when his gaze landed on my glittery green skirt. I pulled my bag onto my lap in an attempt to hide it and he looked away.

‘Hello, dear. I’m Daphne. My husband took his own life. I don’t think it was the nagging!’ The woman’s half-laugh seemed to leak pain. She patted her carefully set hair and peered down awkwardly at her knees. ‘We were happy. We were.’

The boy's hands were tucked under his thighs. 'Jake. Mum. Two years ago. I've been coming here for the past year because my dad can't deal with it, and I needed someone to talk to.'

'How is your dad this week, Jake?' said Marc.

'Not bad. I mean, he brought a woman home last Friday night but, like, he didn't sit on the sofa and cry afterwards. So that's something.'

'Jake's father is handling his own grief in his own way,' Marc said in my direction.

'Shagging,' said Jake. 'Mostly shagging.'

'I wish I was younger,' said Fred, wistfully. He was wearing a collar and tie, the kind of man who considers himself undressed without one. 'I think that would have been a marvellous way to handle Jilly dying.'

'My cousin picked up a man at my aunt's funeral,' said a woman in the corner who might have been called Leanne; I couldn't remember. She was small and round and had a thick fringe of chocolate-coloured hair.

'Actually during the funeral?'

'She said they went to a Travelodge after the sandwiches.' She shrugged. 'It's the heightened emotions, apparently.'

I was in the wrong place. I could see that now. Surreptitiously, I gathered my belongings, wondering whether I should announce my leaving or whether it would be simpler just to run.

Then Marc turned to me expectantly.

I stared blankly at him.

He raised his eyebrows.

'Oh. Me? Actually, I was just leaving. I think I've ... I mean, I don't think I'm -'

'Oh, everyone wants to leave on their first day, dear.'

'I wanted to leave on my second and third too.'

'That's the biscuits. I keep telling Marc we should have better ones.'

'Just tell us the bare bones of it, if you like. Don't worry. You're among friends.'

They were all waiting. I couldn't run. I hunched back into my seat. 'Um. Okay. Well, my name's Louisa and the man I ... I loved ... died at thirty-five.'

There were a few nods of sympathy.

'Too young. When did this happen, Louisa?'

'Twenty months ago. And a week. And two days.'

‘Three years, two weeks and two days.’ Natasha smiled at me from across the room.

There was a low murmur of commiseration. Daphne, beside me, reached out a plump, beringed hand and patted my leg.

‘We’ve had many discussions in this room about the particular difficulties when someone dies young,’ said Marc. ‘How long were you together?’

‘Uh. We ... well ... a little less than six months.’

A few barely hidden looks of surprise.

‘That’s – quite brief,’ a voice said.

‘I’m sure Louisa’s pain is just as valid,’ said Marc, smoothly. ‘And how did he pass, Louisa?’

‘Pass what?’

‘Die,’ said Fred, helpfully.

‘Oh. He – uh – he took his own life.’

‘That must have been a great shock.’

‘Not really. I knew he was planning it.’

There is a peculiar sort of silence, it turns out, when you tell a room full of people who think they know everything there is to know about the death of a loved one that they don’t.

I took a breath. ‘He knew he wanted to do it before I met him. I tried to change his mind and I couldn’t. So I went along with it, because I loved him, and it seemed to make sense at the time. And now it makes a lot less sense. Which is why I’m here.’

‘Death never makes sense,’ said Daphne.

‘Unless you’re Buddhist,’ said Natasha. ‘I keep trying to think Buddhist thoughts but I’m worried that Olaf is going to come back as a mouse or something and I’m going to poison him.’ She sighed. ‘I have to put poison down. We have a terrible mouse problem in our block.’

‘You’ll never get rid of them. They’re like fleas,’ said Sunil. ‘For every one you see, there are hundreds of them behind the scenes.’

‘You might want to think about what you’re doing, Natasha, love,’ said Daphne. ‘There could be hundreds of little Olafs running around. My Alan could be one of them. You could actually be poisoning the both of them.’

‘Well,’ said Fred, ‘if it’s Buddhist, he’d just come back as something else, wouldn’t he?’

‘But what if it’s a fly or something and Natasha kills that too?’

‘I’d hate to come back as a fly,’ said William. ‘Horrible black hairy things.’ He shuddered.

‘I’m not, like, some mass murderer,’ said Natasha. ‘You’re making it sound like I’m out there slaughtering everyone’s reincarnated husbands.’

‘Well, that mouse might be someone’s husband. Even if it isn’t Olaf.’

‘I think we should try to steer this session back on track,’ said Marc, rubbing his temple. ‘Louisa, it’s brave of you to come and tell your story. Why don’t you tell us a bit more about how you and – what was his name? – how you met. You’re in a circle of trust. We’ve all pledged that our stories go no further than these walls.’

It was at this point that I happened to catch Jake’s eye. He glanced at Daphne, then at me, and shook his head subtly.

‘I met him at work,’ I said. ‘And his name was ... Bill.’

Despite what I had promised Dad, I wasn’t planning to attend the Moving On Circle. But my return to work had been so awful that by the time the day ended I hadn’t been able to face going home to an empty flat.

‘You’re back!’ Carly had placed the cup of coffee on the bar, taken the businessman’s change, and hugged me, all while dropping the coins into the correct sections of the till drawer, in one fluid motion. ‘What the hell happened? Tim just told us you had an accident. And then he left so I wasn’t even sure you were coming back.’

‘Long story.’ I stared at her. ‘Uh ... what are you wearing?’

Nine o’clock on Monday morning and the airport had been a blue-grey blur of men charging laptops, staring into iPhones, reading the City pages or talking discreetly into handsets about market share. Carly caught the eye of someone on the other side of the till. ‘Yeah. Well, things have changed since you’ve been gone.’

I turned to see a businessman standing on the wrong side of the bar. I blinked at him and put my bag down. ‘Um – if you’d like to wait there, I’ll serve you –’

‘You must be Louise.’ His handshake was emphatic and without warmth. ‘I’m the new bar manager. Richard Percival.’ I took in his slick hair, his suit, his pale blue shirt, and wondered what kind of bars he had actually managed.

‘Nice to meet you.’

‘You’re the one who’s been off for two months.’

‘Well. Yes. I –’

He walked along the optics, scanning each bottle. ‘I just want you to know that I’m not a fan of people taking endless sick leave.’

My neck shifted a few centimetres back in my collar.

‘I’m just laying down a marker, Louise. I’m not one of those managers who turn a blind eye. I know that in many companies time off is pretty much considered a staff perk. But not in companies where I work.’

‘Believe me, I’ve not thought of the last nine weeks as a perk.’

He examined the underside of a tap, and rubbed at it meditatively with his thumb.

I took a breath before I spoke. ‘I fell off a building. Perhaps I could show you my surgery scars. So, you know, you can be reassured that I’m unlikely to want to do it again.’

He stared at me. ‘There’s no need to be sarcastic. I’m not saying you’re about to have other accidents, but your sick leave is, *pro rata*, at an unusually high level for someone who has worked for this company a relatively short time. That’s all I wanted to point out. That it has been noted.’

He wore cufflinks with racing cars on them.

‘Message received, Mr Percival.’ I said. ‘I’ll do my best to avoid further near-fatal accidents.’

‘You’ll need a uniform. If you give me five minutes I’ll get one out of the stockroom. What size are you? Twelve? Fourteen?’

I stared at him. ‘Ten.’

He raised an eyebrow. I raised one back. As he walked to his office, Carly leaned over from the coffee machine and smiled sweetly in his direction. ‘Utter, utter bellend,’ she said, from the side of her mouth.

She wasn’t wrong. From the moment I returned, Richard Percival was, in the words of my father, all over me like a bad suit. He measured my measures, checked every corner of the bar for molecular peanut crumbs, was in and out of the loos checking on hygiene and wouldn’t let us leave until he had stood over us cashing up and ensuring each till roll matched takings to the last penny.

I no longer had time to chat to the customers, to look up departure times, hand over lost passports, contemplate the planes we could see taking off through the great glass window. I didn’t even have time to be irritated by

Celtic Pan Pipes, Vol. III. If a customer was left waiting to be served for more than ten seconds Richard would magically appear from his office, sighing ostentatiously, then apologize loudly and repeatedly because they had been kept waiting *so long*. Carly and I, usually busy with other customers, would exchange secret glances of resignation and contempt.

He spent half the day meeting reps, the rest on the phone to Head Office, bleating about Footfall and Spend Per Head. We were encouraged to upsell with every transaction, and taken to one side for a talking-to if we forgot. All that was bad enough.

But then there was the uniform.

Carly came into the Ladies as I was finishing getting changed and stood beside me in front of the mirror. 'We look like a pair of eejits,' she said.

Not content with dark skirts and white shirts, some marketing genius high up the corporate ladder had decided that the atmosphere of the Shamrock and Clover chain would benefit from genuine Irish clothing. This genuine Irish clothing had evidently been thought up by someone who believed that across Dublin, right this minute, businesswomen and checkout girls were pirouetting across their workplaces dressed in embroidered tabards, knee-high socks and laced-up dancing shoes, all in glittering emerald green. With accompanying ringlet wigs.

'Jesus. If my boyfriend saw me dressed like this he'd dump me.' Carly lit a cigarette, and climbed up on the sink to disable the smoke alarm on the ceiling. 'Mind you, he'd probably want to do me first. The perv.'

'What do the men have to wear?' I pulled my short skirt out at the sides and eyed Carly's lighter nervously, wondering how flammable I was.

'Look outside. There's only Richard. And he has to wear that shirt with a green logo. The poor thing.'

'That's it? No pixie shoes? Or little leprechaun hat?'

'Surprise, surprise. It's only us girls who have to work looking like porno Munchkins.'

'I look like Dolly Parton: The Early Years in this wig.'

'Grab a red one. Lucky us, we have a choice of three colours.'

From somewhere outside we could hear Richard calling. My stomach had begun to clench reflexively when I heard his voice.

'Anyway, I'm not staying. I'm going to *Riverdance* my way out of this place and into another job,' Carly said. 'He can stick his bloody shamrocks up his tight little corporate arse.' She had given what I could only describe

as a sarcastic skip, and left the Ladies. I spent the rest of the day getting little electric shocks from the static.

The Moving On Circle ended at half past nine. I walked out into the humid summer evening, exhausted by the twin trials of work and the evening's events. I took off my jacket, too hot, feeling suddenly that, having laid myself bare in front of a room full of strangers, being seen in a *faux*-Irish dancer uniform, which was, in truth, ever so slightly too small, didn't really make much difference.

I hadn't been able to talk about Will – not the way they talked, as if their loved ones were still part of their lives, perhaps in the next room.

– *Oh yes, my Jilly used to do that all the time.*

– *I can't delete my brother's voicemail message. I have a little listen to his voice when I feel like I'm going to forget what he sounded like.*

– *Sometimes I can hear him in the next room.*

I could barely even say Will's name. And listening to their tales of family relationships, of thirty-year marriages, shared houses, lives, children, I felt like a fraud. I had been a carer for someone for six months. I'd loved him, and watched him end his life. How could these strangers possibly understand what Will and I had been to each other during that time? How could I explain the way we had so swiftly understood each other, the shorthand jokes, the blunt truths and raw secrets? How could I convey the way those short months had changed the way I felt about everything? The way he had skewed my world so totally that it made no sense without him in it?

And when it came down to it, what was the point in re-examining your sadness all the time anyway? It was like picking at a wound and refusing to let it heal. I knew what I had been part of. I knew what my role was. What was the point in going over and over it?

I wouldn't come next week, I knew now. I would find an excuse for Dad.

I walked slowly across the car park, rummaging in my bag for my keys, telling myself it had at least meant that I hadn't had to spend another evening alone in front of my television, dreading the passing of the twelve hours until I had to return to work.

'His name wasn't really Bill, right?'

Jake fell into step alongside me.

'Nope.'

‘Daphne’s like a one-woman broadcasting corporation. She means well, but your personal story will be all over her social club before you can say Rodent Reincarnation.’

‘Thanks for that.’

He grinned at me, and nodded towards my Lurex skirt. ‘Nice threads, by the way. It’s a good look for a grief-counselling session.’ He stopped briefly to retie a shoelace.

I stopped with him. I hesitated, then said: ‘I’m sorry about your mum.’

His face was sombre. ‘You can’t say that. It’s like prison – you can’t ask someone what they’re in for.’

‘Really? Oh, I’m sorry. I didn’t –’

‘I’m joking. See you next week.’

A man leaning against a motorbike lifted a hand in greeting. He stepped forward as Jake crossed the car park and enveloped him in a bear hug, kissing his cheek. I stopped to watch, mostly because it was rare to see a man hug his son like that in public, once they were over satchel-carrying age.

‘How was it?’

‘Okay. The usual.’ Jake gestured to me. ‘Oh, this is ... Louisa. She’s new.’

The man squinted at me. He was tall and broad-shouldered. A nose that might once have been broken gave him the faintly bruising appearance of a former boxer.

I nodded a polite greeting. ‘It was nice to meet you, Jake. Bye then.’ I lifted a hand, and began to make my way to my car. But as I passed the man he kept staring at me, and I felt myself colour under the intensity of his gaze. ‘You’re that girl,’ he said.

Oh, no, I thought, slowing suddenly. Not here too.

I stared at the ground for a moment and took a breath. Then I turned back to face them both. ‘Okay. As I’ve just made clear in the group, my friend made his own decisions. All I ever did was support them. Not that, if I’m honest, I really want to get into this right here and with a complete stranger.’

Jake’s father continued to squint at me. He lifted his hand to his head.

‘I understand that not everybody will get it. But that’s the way it was. I don’t feel I have to debate my choices. And I’m really tired and it’s been a bit of a day, and I think I’m going to go home now.’

He cocked his head to one side. And then he said, 'I have no idea what you're talking about.'

I frowned.

'The limp. I noticed you have a limp. You live near that massive new development, right? You're the girl who fell off the roof. March. April.'

And suddenly I recognized him. 'Oh – you were –'

'The paramedic. We were the team who picked you up. I'd been wondering what happened to you.'

I almost buckled with relief. I let my gaze run over his face, his hair, his arms, suddenly recalling with Pavlovian accuracy his reassuring manner, the sound of the siren, the faint scent of lemons. And I let out a breath. 'I'm good. Well. Not good exactly. I have a shot hip and a new boss who's an utter arse and – you know – I'm at a grief-counselling club in a damp church hall with people who are just really, really ...'

'Sad,' said Jake, helpfully.

'The hip will get better. It's plainly not hindering your dance career.'

My laugh emerged as a honk.

'Oh. No. This is ... The outfit is related to the boss who is an arse. Not my normal mode of dress. Anyway. Thank you. Wow ...' I put my hand to my head. 'This is weird. You saved me.'

'It's good to see you. We don't often get to see what happens afterwards.'

'You did a great job. It was ... Well, you were really kind. I remember that much.'

'*De nada.*'

I stared at him.

'*De nada.* Spanish. "It was nothing." '

'Oh, okay, then. I take it all back. Thanks for nothing.'

He smiled and raised a paddle-sized hand.

Afterwards, I didn't know what made me do it. 'Hey.'

He looked back towards me. 'It's Sam, actually.'

'Sam. I didn't jump.'

'Okay.'

'No. Really. I mean, I know you've just seen me coming out of a grief-counselling group and everything but it's – well, I just – I wouldn't jump.'

He gave me a look that seemed to suggest he had seen and heard everything.

'Good to know.'

We gazed at each other for a minute. Then he lifted his hand again. ‘Nice to see you, Louisa.’

He pulled on a helmet and Jake slid onto the bike behind him. I found myself watching as they pulled out of the car park. And because I was still watching I caught Jake’s exaggerated eye roll as he pulled on his own helmet. And then I remembered what he had said in the session.

The compulsive shagger.

‘Idiot,’ I told myself, and limped across the rest of the tarmac to where my car was boiling gently in the evening heat.



CHAPTER FIVE

I lived on the edge of the City. In case I was in any doubt, across the road stood a huge office-block-sized crater, surrounded by a developer's hoarding, upon which was written: FARTHINGATE – WHERE THE CITY BEGINS. We existed at the exact point where the glossy glass temples to finance butted up against the grubby old brick and sash-windows of curry shops and twenty-four-hour grocers, of stripper pubs and minicab offices that resolutely refused to die. My block sat among those architectural refuseniks, a lead-stained, warehouse-style building staring at the steady onslaught of glass and steel and wondering how long it could survive, perhaps rescued by a hipster juice bar or pop-up retail experience. I knew nobody except Samir who ran the convenience store and the woman in the bagel bakery, who smiled at me in greeting but didn't seem to speak any English.

Mostly this anonymity suited me. I had come here, after all, to escape my history, from feeling as if everyone knew every thing there was to know about me. And the City had begun to alter me. I had come to know my little corner of it, its rhythms and its danger points. I learned that if you gave money to the drunk at the bus station he would come and sit outside your flat for the next eight weeks; that if I had to walk through the estate at night it was wise to do it with my keys lodged between my fingers; that if I was walking out to get a late-night bottle of wine it was probably better not to glance at the group of young men huddled outside Kebab Korner. I was no longer disturbed by the persistent *whump whump whump* of the police helicopter overhead.

I could survive. Besides, I knew, more than anyone, that worse things could happen.

'Hey.'

'Hey, Lou. Can't sleep again?'

'It's just gone ten o'clock here.'

'So, what's up?'

Nathan, Will's former physio, had spent the last nine months working in New York for a middle-aged CEO with a Wall Street reputation, a four-storey townhouse and a muscular condition. Calling him in my sleepless small hours had become something of a habit. It was good to know there was someone who understood, out there in the dark, even if sometimes his news felt tinged with a series of small blows – *everyone else has moved on. Everyone else has achieved something.*

'So how's the Big Apple?'

'Not bad?' His Antipodean drawl made every answer a question.

I lay down on the sofa, pushing my feet up on the armrest. 'Yeah. That doesn't tell me a whole lot.'

'Okay. Well, got a pay rise, so that was cool. Booked myself a flight home in a couple of weeks to see the olds. So that'll be good. They're over the moon because my sister's having a baby. Oh, and I met a really fit bird in a bar down on Sixth Avenue and we were getting on real well so I asked her out, and when I told her what I did, she said sorry but she only went out with guys who wore suits to work.' He laughed.

I found I was smiling. 'So scrubs don't count?'

'Apparently not. Though she did say she might have changed her mind if I was an actual doctor.' He laughed again. Nathan was made of equanimity. 'It's cool. Girls like that get all picky if you don't take them to the right restaurants and stuff. Better to know sooner, right? How about you?'

I shrugged. 'Getting there. Sort of.'

'You still sleeping in his T-shirt?'

'No. It stopped smelling of him. And it had started to get a bit unsavoury, if I'm honest. I washed it and I've packed it in tissue. But I've got his jumper for bad days.'

'Good to have back-up.'

'Oh, and I went to the grief-counselling group.'

'How was it?'

'Crap. I felt like a fraud.'

Nathan waited.

I shifted the pillow under my head. 'Did I imagine it all, Nathan? Sometimes I think I've made what happened between Will and me so much bigger in my head. Like how can I have loved someone that much in such a short time? And all these things I think about the two of us – did we

actually feel what I remember? The further we get from it, the more those six months just seems like this weird ... dream.'

There was a tiny pause before Nathan responded. 'You didn't imagine it, mate.'

I rubbed my eyes. 'Am I the only one? Still missing him?'

Another short silence.

'Nah. He was a good bloke. The best.'

That was one of the things I liked about Nathan. He didn't mind a lengthy phone silence. I finally sat up and blew my nose. 'Anyway. I don't think I'll go back. I'm not sure it's my thing.'

'Give it a go, Lou. You can't judge anything from one session.'

'You sound like my dad.'

'Well, he always was a sensible fella.'

I started at the sound of the doorbell. Nobody ever rang my doorbell, aside from Mrs Nellis in flat twelve, when the postman had accidentally swapped our mail. I doubted she was up at this hour. And I certainly was not in receipt of her *Elizabethan Doll* partwork magazine.

It rang again. A third time, shrill and insistent.

'I've got to go. Someone's at the door.'

'Keep your pecker up, mate. You'll be okay.'

I put the phone down and stood up warily. I had no friends nearby. I hadn't worked out how you actually made them when you moved to a new area and spent most of your upright hours working. And if my parents had decided to stage an intervention and bring me back to Stortford, they would have organized it between rush-hours as neither of them liked driving in the dark.

I waited, wondering if whoever it was would simply realize their mistake and go away. But it rang again, jarring and endless, as if they were now leaning against the bell.

I got up and walked to the door. 'Who is it?'

'I need to talk to you.'

A girl's voice. I peered through the spy-hole. She was looking down at her feet, so I could only make out long chestnut hair, an oversized bomber jacket. She swayed slightly, rubbed at her nose. Drunk?

'I think you have the wrong flat.'

'Are you Louisa Clark?'

I paused. 'How do you know my name?'

‘I need to talk to you. Can you just open the door?’

‘It’s almost half past ten at night.’

‘Yeah. That’s why I’d rather not be standing here in your corridor.’

I had lived there long enough to know not to open my door to strangers. In that area of town it was not unusual to get the odd junkie ringing bells speculatively in the hope of cash. But this was a well-spoken girl. And young. Too young to be one of the journalists who had briefly fixated on the story of the handsome former whizz-kid who had decided to end his life. Too young to be out this late? I angled my head, trying to see if there was anyone else in the corridor. It appeared to be empty. ‘Can you tell me what it’s about?’

‘Not out here, no.’

I opened the door to the length of the safety chain, so that we were eye to eye. ‘You’re going to have to give me more than that.’

She couldn’t have been more than sixteen, the dewy plumpness of youth still visible in her cheeks. Her hair long and lustrous. Long skinny legs in tight black jeans. Flicky eyeliner, in a pretty face. ‘So ... who did you say you were?’ I asked.

‘Lily. Lily Houghton-Miller. Look,’ she said, and lifted her chin an inch, ‘I need to talk to you about my father.’

‘I think you have the wrong person. I don’t know anyone called Houghton-Miller. There must be another Louisa Clark you’ve confused me with.’

I made to shut the door, but she had wedged the toe of her shoe in it. I looked down at it, and slowly back up at her.

‘Not *his* name,’ she said, as though I was stupid. And when she spoke, her eyes were both fierce and searching. ‘His name is Will Traynor.’

Lily Houghton-Miller stood in the middle of my living room and surveyed me with the detached interest of a scientist gazing at a new variety of manure-based invertebrate. ‘Wow. What are you wearing?’

‘I – I work in an Irish pub.’

‘Pole dancing?’ Having apparently lost interest in me, she pivoted slowly, gazing at the room. ‘This is where you actually live? Where’s your furniture?’

‘I just moved in.’

‘One sofa, one television, two boxes of books?’ She nodded towards the chair on which I sat, my breathing still unbalanced, trying to make any kind of sense out of what she had just told me.

I stood up. ‘I’m going to get a drink. Would you like something?’

‘I’ll have a Coke. Unless you’ve got wine.’

‘How old are you?’

‘Why do you want to know?’

‘I don’t understand ...’ I went behind the kitchen counter. ‘Will didn’t have children. I would have known.’ I frowned at her, suddenly suspicious. ‘Is this some kind of joke?’

‘A joke?’

‘Will and I talked ... a lot. He would have told me.’

‘Yeah. Well, turns out he didn’t. And I need to talk about him to someone who is not going to totally freak out every time I even mention his name, like the rest of my family.’

She picked up the card from my mother and put it down again. ‘I’m hardly going to say it as a *joke*. I mean, yeah. My real dad, some sad bloke in a wheelchair. Like *that’s* funny.’

I handed her a glass of water. ‘But who ... who is your family? I mean, who is your mother?’

‘Have you got any cigarettes?’ She had started pacing around the room, touching things, picking up the few belongings I had and putting them down. When I shook my head, she said, ‘My mother is called Tanya. Tanya Miller. She’s married to my stepdad, who is called Francis Stupid Fuckface Houghton.’

‘Nice name.’

She put down the water and pulled a packet of cigarettes from her bomber jacket and lit one. I was going to say she couldn’t smoke in my home, but I was too taken aback, so I simply walked over to the window and opened it.

I couldn’t take my eyes off her. I could maybe see little hints of Will. It was in her blue eyes, that vaguely caramel colouring. It was in the way she tilted her chin slightly before she spoke, her unblinking stare. Or was I seeing what I wanted to see? She gazed out of the window at the street below.

‘Lily, before we go on there’s something I need to –’

‘I know he’s dead,’ she said. She inhaled sharply and blew the smoke into the centre of the room. ‘I mean, that was how I found out. There was some documentary on television about assisted suicide and they mentioned his name and Mum totally freaked out for no reason and ran to the bathroom and Fuckface went after her so obviously I listened outside. And she was in total shock because she hadn’t even known that he’d ended up in a wheelchair. I heard the whole thing. I mean, it’s not like I didn’t know Fuckface wasn’t my real dad. It’s just that my mum only ever said my real dad was an asshole who didn’t want to know me.’

‘Will wasn’t an asshole.’

She shrugged. ‘He sounded like one. But, anyway, when I tried to ask her questions she just started totally flipping out and said that I knew everything about him that I needed to know and Fuckface Francis had been a better dad to me than Will Traynor ever would have been and I really should leave it alone.’

I sipped my water. I had never wanted a glass of wine more. ‘So what did you do?’

She took another drag of her cigarette. ‘I Googled him, of course. And I found you.’

I needed to be alone to digest what she had told me. It was too overwhelming. I didn’t know what to make of the spiky girl, who walked around my living room, making the air around her crackle.

‘So did he not say anything about me *at all*?’

I was staring at her shoes: ballerina pumps, heavily scuffed as if they had spent too much time shuffling around London streets. I felt as if I was being reeled in. ‘How old are you, Lily?’

‘Sixteen. Do I at least look like him? I saw a picture on Google images, but I was thinking maybe you had a photograph.’ She gazed around the living room. ‘Are all your photographs in boxes?’

She eyed the cardboard crates in the corner, and I wondered whether she would actually open them and start going through them. I was pretty sure the one she was about to go into contained Will’s jumper. And I felt a sudden panic. ‘Um. Lily. This is all ... quite a lot to take in. And if you are who you say you are, then we – we do have a lot to discuss. But it’s nearly eleven o’clock, and I’m not sure this is the time to start. Where do you live?’

‘St John’s Wood.’

‘Well. Uh. Your parents are going to be wondering where you are. Why don’t I give you my number and we –’

‘I can’t go *home*.’ She faced the window, flicked the ash out with a practised finger. ‘Strictly speaking, I’m not even meant to be here. I’m meant to be at school. Weekly boarding. They’ll all be freaking out now because I’m not there.’ She pulled out her phone, as an afterthought, and grimaced at whatever she saw on its screen, then shoved it back in her pocket.

‘Well, I’m ... not sure what I can do other than –’

‘I thought maybe I could stay here? Just tonight? And then you could tell me some more stuff about him?’

‘Stay *here*? No. No. I’m sorry, you can’t. I don’t know you.’

‘But you did know my dad. Did you say you think he didn’t actually know about me?’

‘You need to go home. Look, let’s call your parents. They can come and collect you. Let’s do that and I –’

She stared at me. ‘I thought you’d help me.’

‘I will help you, Lily. But this isn’t the way to –’

‘You don’t believe me, do you?’

‘I – I have no idea what to –’

‘You don’t want to help. You don’t want to do anything. What have you actually told me about my dad? Nothing. How have you actually helped? You haven’t. Thanks.’

‘Hold on! That’s not fair – we’ve only just –’

But the girl flicked her cigarette butt out of the window and turned to walk past me out of the room.

‘What? Where are you going?’

‘Oh, what do *you* care?’ she said, and before I could say anything more, the front door had slammed and she was gone.

I sat very still on my sofa, trying to digest what had just happened for the best part of an hour, Lily’s voice ringing in my ears. Had I heard her correctly? I went over and over what she had told me, trying to recall it through the buzz in my ears.

My father was Will Traynor.

Lily's mother had apparently told her Will had not wanted anything to do with her. But surely he would have mentioned something to me. We had no secrets from each other. Weren't we the two people who had managed to talk about everything? For a moment I wobbled: had Will not been as honest with me as I'd believed? Had he actually possessed the ability simply to airbrush an entire daughter out of his conscience?

My thoughts were chasing each other in circles. I grabbed my laptop, sat cross-legged on the sofa and typed 'Lily Hawton Miller' into a search engine, and when that came up with no results, I tried again with various spellings, settling on 'Lily Houghton-Miller', which brought up a number of hockey-fixture results posted by a school called Upton Tilton in Shropshire. I called up some of the images, and as I zoomed in, there she was, an unsmiling girl in a row of smiling hockey players. *Lily Houghton-Miller played a brave, if unsuccessful defence.* It was dated two years ago. Boarding-school. She'd said she was meant to be at boarding-school. But it still didn't mean she was any relation of Will or, indeed, that her mother had been telling the truth about her parentage.

I altered the search to just the words 'Houghton-Miller', which brought up a short diary item about Francis and Tanya Houghton-Miller attending a banking dinner at the Savoy, and a planning application from the previous year for a wine cellar under a house in St John's Wood.

I sat back, thinking, then did a search on 'Tanya Miller' and 'William Traynor'. It turned up nothing. I tried again, using 'Will Traynor', and suddenly I was on a Facebook thread for alumni of Durham University, on which several women, all of whose names seemed to end in '-ella' – Estella, Fenella, Arabella – were discussing Will's death.

I couldn't believe it when I heard it on the news. Him of all people! RIP Will.

Nobody gets through life unscathed. You know Rory Appleton died in the Turks and Caicos, in a speed-boating accident?

Didn't he do geography? Red hair?

No, PPE.

I'm sure I snogged Rory at the Freshers' Ball. Enormous tongue.

I'm not being funny, Fenella, but that's rather bad taste. The poor man is dead.

Wasn't Will Traynor the one who went out with Tanya Miller for the whole of the third year?

I don't see how it's in poor taste to mention that I may have kissed someone just because they then went on to pass away.

I'm not saying you have to rewrite history. It's just his wife might be reading this and she might not want to know that her beloved stuck his tongue in the face of some girl on Facebook.

I'm sure she knows his tongue was enormous. I mean, she married him.

Rory Appleton got married?

Tanya married some banker. Here's a link. I always thought she and Will would get married when we were at uni. They were so gorgeous.

I clicked on the link, which showed a picture of a reed-thin blonde woman with an artfully tousled chignon smiling as she stood on the steps of a register office with an older, dark-haired man. A short distance away, at the edge of the picture, a young girl in a white tulle dress was scowling. She bore a definite resemblance to the Lily Houghton-Miller I had met. But the image was seven years old, and in truth it could have portrayed any grumpy young bridesmaid with long mid-brown hair.

I reread the thread, and closed my laptop. What should I do? If she really was Will's daughter, should I call the school? I was pretty sure there were rules about strangers who tried to contact teenage girls.

And what if this really was some elaborate scam? Will had died a wealthy man. It wasn't beyond the realm of possibility that somebody could think up an intricate scheme by which to leach money from his family. When Dad's mate Chalky died of a heart attack, seventeen people had turned up at the wake telling his wife he owed them betting money.

I would steer clear, I decided. There was too much potential for pain and disruption if I got this wrong.

But when I went to bed it was Lily's voice I heard, echoing into the silent flat.

Will Traynor was my father.



CHAPTER SIX

‘Sorry. My alarm didn’t go off.’ I rushed past Richard and hung my coat on the peg, pulling my synthetic skirt down over my thighs.

‘Three-quarters of an hour late. This is not acceptable.’

It was eight thirty a.m. We were, I noted, the only two people in the bar.

Carly had left: she hadn’t even bothered telling Richard to his face. She simply sent a text message telling him she would drop the sodding uniform in at the end of the week, and that as she was owed two weeks’ sodding holiday pay she was taking her sodding notice in lieu. *If she had bothered to read the employment handbook, he had fumed, she would have known that taking notice in lieu of holiday was completely unacceptable. It was there in Section Three, as clear as day, if she had cared to look. And the sodding language was simply unnecessary.*

He was now going through the due processes to find a replacement. Which meant that until due processes were completed it was just me. And Richard.

‘I’m sorry. Something ... came up at home.’

I had woken with a start at seven thirty, unable for several minutes to recall what country I was in or what my name was, and had lain on my bed, unable to move, while I mulled over the previous evening’s events.

‘A good worker doesn’t bring their home life to the workplace with them,’ Richard intoned, as he pushed past me with his clipboard. I watched him go, wondering if he even had a home life. He never seemed to spend any time there.

‘Yeah. Well. A good employer doesn’t make his employee wear a uniform Stringfellow’s would have rejected as tacky,’ I muttered, as I tapped my code into the till, pulling the hem of my Lurex skirt down with my free hand.

He turned swiftly, and walked back across the bar. ‘What did you say?’

‘Nothing.’

‘Yes, you did.’

‘I said I’ll remember that for next time. Thank you very much for reminding me.’

I smiled sweetly at him.

He looked at me for several seconds longer than was comfortable for either of us. And then he said, 'The cleaner is off sick again. You'll need to do the Gents before you start on the bar.'

His gaze was steady, daring me to say something. I reminded myself that I could not afford to lose this job. I swallowed. 'Right.'

'Oh, and cubicle three's a bit of a mess.'

'Jolly good,' I said.

He turned on his highly polished heel and walked back into the office. I sent mental voodoo arrows into the back of his head the whole way.

'This week's Moving On Circle is about guilt, survivor's guilt, guilt that we didn't do enough ... It's often this that keeps us from moving forward.'

Marc waited as we handed around the biscuit tin, then leaned forward on his plastic chair, his hands clasped in front of him. He ignored the low rumbling of discontent that there were no bourbon creams.

'I used to get ever so impatient with Jilly,' Fred said, into the silence. 'When she had the dementia, I mean. She would put dirty plates back in the kitchen cupboards and I would find them days later and ... I'm ashamed to say, I did shout at her a couple of times.' He wiped at an eye. 'She was such a houseproud woman, before. That was the worst thing.'

'You lived with Jilly's dementia for a long time, Fred. You'd have to have been superhuman not to find it a strain.'

'Dirty plates would drive me mad,' said Daphne. 'I think I would have shouted something terrible.'

'But it wasn't her fault, was it?' Fred straightened on his chair. 'I think about those plates a lot. I wish I could go back. I'd wash them up without saying a word. Just give her a nice cuddle instead.'

'I find myself fantasizing about men on the tube,' said Natasha. 'Sometimes when I'm riding up an escalator, I exchange a look with some random man going down. And before I've even got to the platform I'm building a whole relationship with him in my head. You know, where he runs back down the escalator because he just knows there's something magical between us, and we stand there, gazing at each other, amid the crowds of commuters on the Piccadilly Line, and then we go for a drink, and before you know it, we're -'

'Sounds like a Richard Curtis movie,' said William.

‘I like Richard Curtis movies,’ said Sunil. ‘Especially that one about the actress and the man in his pants.’

‘Shepherd’s Bush,’ said Daphne.

There was a short pause. ‘I think it’s *Notting Hill*, Daphne,’ Marc said.

‘I preferred Daphne’s version. What?’ said William, snorting. ‘We’re not allowed to laugh now?’

‘So in my head we’re getting married,’ said Natasha. ‘And then when we’re standing at the altar, I think, What am I doing? Olaf only died three years ago and I’m fantasizing about other men.’

Marc leaned back in his chair. ‘You don’t think that’s natural, after three years by yourself? To fantasize about other relationships?’

‘But if I had really loved Olaf, surely I wouldn’t think about anyone else.’

‘It’s not the Victorian age,’ said William. ‘You don’t have to wear widow’s weeds till you’re elderly.’

‘If it was me that died, I’d hate the thought of Olaf falling in love with someone else.’

‘You wouldn’t know,’ said William. ‘You’d be dead.’

‘What about you, Louisa?’ Marc had noticed my silence. ‘Do you suffer feelings of guilt?’

‘Can we – can we do someone else?’

‘I’m Catholic,’ said Daphne. ‘I feel guilty about everything. It’s the nuns, you know.’

‘What do you find difficult about this subject, Louisa?’

I took a swig of coffee. I felt everyone’s eyes on me. *Come on*, I told myself. I swallowed. ‘That I couldn’t stop him,’ I said. ‘Sometimes I think if I had been smarter, or ... handled things differently ... or just been more – I don’t know. More anything.’

‘You feel guilty about Bill’s death because you feel you could have stopped him?’

I pulled at a thread. When it came away in my hand it seemed to loosen something in my brain. ‘Also that I’m living a life that is so much less than the one I promised him I’d live. And guilt over the fact that he basically paid for my flat when my sister will probably never be able to afford one of her own. And guilt that I don’t even really like living in it, because it doesn’t feel like mine, and it feels wrong to make it nice because all I

associate it with is the fact that W— Bill is dead and somehow I benefited from that.'

There was a short silence.

'You shouldn't feel guilty about property,' said Daphne.

'I wish someone would leave me a flat,' said Sunil.

'But that's just a fairy tale ending, isn't it? Man dies, everyone learns something, moves on, creates something wonderful out of his death.' I was speaking without thinking now. 'I've done none of those things. I've basically just failed at all of it.'

'My dad cries nearly every time he shags someone who isn't my mum,' Jake blurted, twisting his hands together. He stared out from under his fringe. 'He charms women into sleeping with him and then he gets off on being sad about it. It's like as long as he feels guilty about it afterwards it's okay.'

'You think he uses his guilt as a crutch.'

'I just think either you have sex and feel glad that you're having all the sex —'

'I wouldn't feel guilty about having all the sex,' said Fred.

'Or you treat women like human beings and make sure you don't have anything to feel guilty about. Or don't even sleep with anyone, and treasure Mum's memory until you're actually ready to move on.'

His voice broke on *treasure* and his jaw tautened. We were used, by then, to the sudden stiffening of expressions, and an unspoken group courtesy meant that we each looked away until any potential tears subsided.

Marc's voice was gentle. 'Have you told your father how you feel, Jake?'

'We don't talk about Mum. He's fine as long as, you know, we don't actually mention her.'

'That's quite a burden for you to carry alone.'

'Yeah. Well ... That's why I'm here, isn't it?'

There was a short silence.

'Have a biscuit, Jake darling,' said Daphne, and we passed the tin back around the circle, vaguely reassured, in some way nobody could quite define, when Jake finally took one.

I kept thinking about Lily. I barely registered Sunil's tale of weeping in the baked-goods section of the supermarket, and just about raised a sympathetic expression for Fred's solitary marking of Jilly's birthday with a

bunch of foil balloons. For days now the whole episode with Lily had taken on the tenor of a dream, vivid and surreal.

How could Will have had a daughter?

‘You look happy.’

Jake’s father was leaning against his motorbike as I walked across the church hall’s car park.

I stopped in front of him. ‘It’s a grief-counselling session. I’m hardly going to come out tap-dancing.’

‘Fair point.’

‘It’s not what you think. I mean, it’s not me,’ I said. ‘It’s ... to do with a teenager.’

He tipped his head backwards, spying Jake behind me. ‘Oh. Right. Well, you have my sympathies there. You look young to have a teenager, if you don’t mind me saying.’

‘Oh. No. Not mine! It’s ... complicated.’

‘I’d love to give you advice. But I don’t have a clue.’ He stepped forward and enveloped Jake in a hug, which the boy tolerated glumly. ‘You all right, young man?’

‘Fine.’

‘Fine,’ Sam said, glancing sideways at me. ‘There you go. Universal response of all teenagers to everything. War, famine, lottery wins, global fame. It’s all *fine*.’

‘You didn’t need to pick me up. I’m going to Jools’s.’

‘You want a lift?’

‘She lives, like, there. In that block.’ Jake pointed. ‘I think I can manage that by myself.’

Sam’s expression remained even. ‘So, maybe text me next time? Save me coming here and waiting?’

Jake shrugged, and walked off, his rucksack slung over his shoulder. We watched him go in silence.

‘I’ll see you later, yes, Jake?’

Jake lifted a hand without looking back.

‘Okay,’ I said. ‘So now I feel a tiny bit better.’

Sam gave the slightest shake of his head. He watched his son go, as if, even now, he couldn’t bear to just leave him. ‘Some days he feels it harder than others.’ And then he turned to me. ‘You want to grab a coffee or

something, Louisa? Just so I don't have to feel like the world's biggest loser? It is Louisa, right?'

I thought of what Jake had said in that evening's session. *On Friday Dad brought home this psycho blonde called Mags who is obsessed with him. When he was in the shower she kept asking me if he talked about her when she wasn't there.*

The compulsive shagger. But he was nice enough, and he had helped put me back together in the ambulance, and the alternative was another night at home wondering what had been going on in Lily Houghton-Miller's head. 'If we can talk about anything but teenagers.'

'Can we talk about your outfit?'

I looked down at my green Lurex skirt and my Irish dancing shoes. 'Absolutely not.'

'It was worth a try,' he said, and climbed onto his motorbike.

We sat outside a near-empty bar a short distance from my flat. He drank black coffee, and I had fruit juice.

I had time to study him surreptitiously now that I wasn't dodging cars in a car park or lying strapped to a hospital gurney. His nose held a tell-tale ridge, and his eyes crinkled in a way that suggested there was almost no human behaviour he hadn't seen and, perhaps, been slightly amused by. He was tall and broad, his features coarser than Will's somehow, yet he moved with a kind of gentle economy, as if he had absorbed the effort of not damaging things just from his size. He was evidently more comfortable with listening than talking, or perhaps it was just that it was unsettling to be on my own with a man after so much time because I found I was gabbling. I talked about my job at the bar, making him laugh about Richard Percival and the horrors of my outfit, and how strange it had been to live briefly at home again, and my father's bad jokes, and Granddad and his doughnuts, and my nephew's unorthodox use of a blue marker pen. But I was conscious as I spoke, as so often these days, of how much I didn't say: about Will, about the surreal thing that had happened to me the previous evening, about me. With Will I had never had to consider what I said: talking to him was as effortless as breathing. Now I was good at not really saying anything about myself at all.

He just sat, and nodded, watched the traffic go by and sipped his coffee, as if it were perfectly normal for him to be passing the time with a

feverishly chatting stranger in a green Lurex mini-skirt.

‘So, how’s the hip?’ he asked, when finally I ground to a halt.

‘Not bad. I’d quite like to stop limping, though.’

‘You’ll get there, if you keep up the physio.’ For a moment, I could hear that voice from the back of the ambulance. Calm, unfazed, reassuring. ‘The other injuries?’

I peered down at myself, as if I could see through what I was wearing. ‘Well, other than the fact that I look like someone’s drawn all over bits of me with a particularly vivid red pen, not bad.’

Sam nodded. ‘You were lucky. That was quite a fall.’

And there it was again. The sick lurch in my stomach. The air beneath my feet. *You never know what will happen when you fall from a great height.* ‘I wasn’t trying to –’

‘You said.’

‘But I’m not sure anyone believes me.’

We exchanged an awkward smile and for a minute I wondered if he didn’t either.

‘So ... do you pick up many people who fall off the tops of buildings?’

He shook his head, gazed out across the road. ‘I just pick up the pieces. I’m glad that, in your case, the pieces fitted back together.’

We sat in silence for a while longer. I kept thinking about things I should say, but I was so out of practice at being alone with a man – while sober at least – that I kept losing my nerve, my mouth opening and closing like that of a goldfish.

‘So you want to tell me about the teenager?’ Sam said.

It was a relief to explain it to someone. I told him about the late-night knock at the door, and our bizarre meeting and what I had found on Facebook, and the way she had run away before I’d had a chance to work out what on earth to do.

‘Whoa,’ he said when I’d finished. ‘That’s ...’ He gave a little shake of his head. ‘You think she is who she says she is?’

‘She does look a bit like him. But I don’t honestly know. Am I looking for signs? Am I seeing what I want to see? It’s possible. I spend half my time thinking how amazing that there’s something of him left behind, and the other half wondering if I’m being a complete sucker. And then there’s this whole extra layer of stuff in the middle – like if this is his daughter then how is it fair that he never even got to meet her? And how are his parents

supposed to cope with it? And what if meeting her would actually have changed his mind? What if that would have been the thing that convinced him ...' My voice tailed away.

Sam leaned back in his chair, his brow furrowed. 'And this man would be the reason you're attending the group.'

'Yes.'

I could feel him studying me, perhaps reassessing what Will had meant to me.

'I don't know what to do,' I said. 'I don't know whether to seek her out, or whether I should just leave well enough alone.'

He looked out at the city street, thinking. And then he said: 'Well, what would he have done?'

And just like that, I faltered. I gazed up at that big man with his direct gaze, his two-day stubble, and his kind, capable hands. And all my thoughts evaporated.

'You okay?'

I took a deep gulp of my drink, trying to hide what I felt was written clearly on my face. Suddenly, for no reason I could work out, I wanted to cry. It was too much. That odd, unbalancing night. The fact that Will had loomed up again, ever-present in every conversation. I could see his face suddenly, that sardonic eyebrow raised, as if to say, *What on earth are you up to now, Clark?*

'Just ... a long day. Actually, would you mind if I –'

Sam pushed his chair back, stood up. 'No. No, you go. Sorry. I didn't think –'

'This has been really nice. It's just –'

'No problem. A long day. And the whole grief thing. I get it. No, no – don't worry,' he said, as I reached for my purse. 'Really. I can stand you an orange juice.'

I think I might have run to my car, in spite of my limp. I felt his eyes on me the whole way.

I pulled up in the car park, and let out a breath I felt as if I'd been holding all the way from the bar. I glanced over at the corner shop, then back at my flat, and decided I didn't want to be sensible. I wanted wine, several large glasses of it, until I could persuade myself to stop looking backwards. Or maybe not look at anything at all.

My hip ached as I climbed out of the car. Since Richard had arrived, it hurt constantly; the physio at the hospital had told me not to spend too much time on my feet. But the thought of saying as much to Richard filled me with dread.

I see. So you work in a bar but you want to be allowed to sit down all day, is that it?

That milk-fed, preparing-for-middle-management face; that carefully nondescript haircut. That air of weary superiority, even though he was barely two years older than me. I closed my eyes, and tried to make the knot of anxiety in my stomach disappear.

‘Just this, please,’ I said, placing a bottle of cold Sauvignon Blanc on the counter.

‘Party, is it?’

‘What?’

‘Fancy dress. You going as – Don’t tell me.’ Samir stroked his chin.

‘Snow White?’

‘Sure,’ I said.

‘You want to be careful with that. Empty calories, innit? You want to drink vodka. That’s a clean drink. Maybe a bit of lemon. That’s what I tell Ginny, across the road. You know she’s a lap-dancer, right? They got to watch their figures.’

‘Dietary advice. Nice.’

‘It’s like all this stuff about sugar. You got to watch the sugar. No point buying the low-fat stuff if it’s full of sugar, right? There’s your empty calories. Right there. And them chemical sugars are the worst. They stick to your gut.’

He rang up the wine, handed me my change.

‘What’s that you’re eating, Samir?’

‘Smoky Bacon Pot Noodle. It’s good, man.’

I was lost in thought – somewhere in the dark crevasse between my sore pelvis, existential job-related despair, and a weird craving for a Smoky Bacon Pot Noodle – when I saw her. She was in the doorway of my block, sitting on the ground, her arms wrapped around her knees. I took my change from Samir, and half walked, half ran across the road. ‘Lily?’

She looked up slowly.

Her voice was slurred, her eyes bloodshot, as if she had been crying.

‘Nobody would let me in. I rang all the bells but nobody would let me in.’

I wrestled the key into the door and propped it with my bag, crouching down beside her. 'What happened?'

'I just want to go to sleep,' she said, rubbing her eyes. 'I'm so, so tired. I wanted to get a taxi home but I hadn't got any money.'

I caught the sour whiff of alcohol. 'Are you drunk?'

'I don't know.' She blinked at me, tilting her head. I wondered then if it was just alcohol. 'If I'm not, you've totally turned into a leprechaun.' She patted her pockets. 'Oh, look – look what I've got!' She held up a half-smoked roll-up that even I could smell was not just tobacco. 'Let's have a smoke, Lily,' she said. 'Oh, no. You're Louisa. I'm Lily.' She giggled and, pulling a lighter clumsily from her pocket, promptly tried to light the wrong end.

'Okay, you. Time to go home.' I took it from her hand, and, ignoring her vague protests, squashed it firmly under my foot. 'I'll call you a taxi.'

'But I don't –'

'Lily!'

I glanced up. A young man stood across the street, his hands in his jeans pockets, watching us steadily. Lily looked up at him and then away.

'Who is that?' I said.

She stared at her feet.

'Lily. Come here.' His voice held the surety of possession. He stood, legs slightly apart, as if even at that distance he expected her to obey him. Something made me instantly uneasy.

Nobody moved.

'Is he your boyfriend? Do you want to talk to him?' I said quietly.

The first time she spoke I couldn't make out what she said. I had to lean closer and ask her to repeat herself.

'Make him go away.' She closed her eyes, and turned her face towards the door. 'Please.'

He began to walk across the street towards us. I stood, and tried to make my voice sound as authoritative as possible. 'You can go now, thanks. Lily's coming inside with me.'

He stopped halfway across the road.

I held his gaze. 'You can speak to her some other time. Okay?'

I had my hand on the buzzer, and now muttered at some imaginary, muscular, short-tempered boyfriend. 'Yeah. Do you want to come down and give me a hand, Dave? Thanks.'

The young man's expression suggested this was not the last of it. Then he turned, pulled his phone from his pocket and began a low, urgent conversation with someone as he walked away, ignoring the beeping taxi that had to swerve around him, and casting us only the briefest of backwards looks.

I sighed, a little more shakily than I'd expected, put my hands under her armpits and, with not very much elegance and a fair amount of muffled swearing, managed to haul Lily Houghton-Miller into the lobby.

That night she slept at my flat. I couldn't think what else to do with her. She was sick twice in the bathroom, batting me away when I tried to hold her hair up for her. She refused to give me a home phone number, or maybe couldn't remember it, and her mobile phone was pin-locked.

I cleaned her up, helped her into a pair of my jogging bottoms and a T-shirt, and led her into the living room. 'You tidied up!' she said, with a little exclamation, as if I had done it just for her. I made her drink a glass of water and put her on the sofa in the recovery position, even though I was pretty sure by then that there was nothing left inside her to come out.

As I lifted her head and placed it on the pillow, she opened her eyes, as if recognizing me properly for the first time. 'Sorry.' She spoke so quietly that, for a moment, I couldn't be entirely sure that that was what she had said, and her eyes brimmed briefly with tears.

I covered her with a blanket and watched her as she fell asleep – her pale face, the blue shadows under her eyes, the eyebrows that followed the same curve that Will's had, the same faint sprinkling of freckles.

Almost as an afterthought I locked the flat door and brought the keys into my bedroom with me, tucking them under my pillow to stop her stealing anything, or simply to stop her leaving, I wasn't sure. I lay awake, my mind still busy with the sound of the sirens and the airport and the faces of the grieving in the church hall and the hard, knowing stare of the young man across the road, and the knowledge that I had someone who was essentially a stranger sleeping under my roof. And all the while a voice kept saying: *What on earth are you doing?*

But what else could I have done? Finally, some time after the birds started singing, and the bakery van unloaded its morning delivery downstairs, my thoughts slowed, and stilled, and I fell asleep.



CHAPTER SEVEN

I could smell coffee. It took me several seconds to consider why the smell of coffee might be filtering through my flat, and when the answer registered I sat bolt upright and leaped out of bed, hauling my hoodie over my head.

She was cross-legged on the sofa, smoking, using my one good mug as an ashtray. The television was on – some manic children’s confection of brightly clad, gurning presenters – and two Styrofoam cups sat on the mantelpiece.

‘Oh, hi. That one on the right’s yours,’ she said, turning briefly towards me. ‘I didn’t know what you liked so I got you an Americano.’

I blinked, wrinkling my nose against the cigarette smoke. I crossed the room and opened a window. I looked at the clock. ‘Is that the time?’

‘Yeah. The coffee might be a bit cold. Didn’t know whether to wake you.’

‘It’s my day off,’ I said, reaching for the coffee. It was warm enough. I took a slug gratefully. Then I stared at the cup. ‘Hang on. How did you get these? I locked the front door.’

‘I went down the fire escape,’ she said. ‘I didn’t have any money so I told the guy at the bakery whose flat it was and he said you could bring it in later. Oh, and you also owe him for two bagels with smoked salmon and cream cheese.’

‘I do?’ I wanted to be cross, but I was suddenly really hungry.

She followed my gaze. ‘Oh. I ate those.’ She blew a smoke ring into the centre of the room. ‘You didn’t have anything much in your fridge. You really do need to sort this place out.’

The Lily of this morning was such a different character from the girl I had picked off the street last night that it was hard to believe they were the same person. I walked back into the bedroom to get dressed, listening to her watching television, padding into the kitchen to fetch herself a drink.

‘Hey, thingy ... Louise. Could you lend me some money?’ she called out.

‘If it’s to get off your face again, no.’

She walked into my bedroom without knocking. I pulled my sweatshirt up to my chest. ‘And can I stay tonight?’

‘I need to talk to your mum, Lily.’

‘What for?’

‘I need to know a little bit more about what’s actually going on here.’

She stood in the doorway. ‘So you don’t believe me.’

I gestured to her to turn around, so I could finish putting my bra on. ‘I do believe you. But that’s the deal. You want something from me, I need to know a bit more about you first.’

Just as I pulled my T-shirt over my head, she turned back again. ‘Suit yourself. I need to pick up some more clothes anyway.’

‘Why? Where have you been staying?’

She walked away from me, as if she hadn’t heard, sniffing her armpit.

‘Can I use your shower? I absolutely reek.’

An hour later, we drove to St John’s Wood. I was exhausted, both by the night’s events and the strange energy Lily gave off beside me. She fidgeted constantly, smoked endless cigarettes, then sat in a silence so loaded I could almost feel the weight of her thoughts.

‘So who was he? That guy last night?’ I kept my face to the front, my voice neutral.

‘Just someone.’

‘You told me he was your boyfriend.’

‘Then that’s who he was.’ Her voice had hardened, her face closed. As we drew nearer to her parents’ house, she crossed her arms in front of her, bringing her knees up to her chin, her gaze set and defiant, as if already in silent battle. I had wondered if she had been telling me the truth about St John’s Wood, but she gestured to a wide, tree-lined street, and told me to take the third left, and we were in the kind of road where diplomats or expat American bankers live, the kind of road that nobody ever seems to go in or come out of. I pulled the car up, gazing out of the window at the tall white stucco buildings, the carefully trimmed yew hedging, and immaculate window boxes.

‘You live *here*?’

She slammed the passenger door behind her so hard that my little car rattled. ‘I don’t live here. *They* live here.’

She let herself in and I followed awkwardly, feeling like an intruder. We were in a spacious, high-ceilinged hallway, with parquet flooring and a

huge gilt mirror on the wall, a slew of white-card invitations jostling for space in its frame. A vase of beautifully arranged flowers sat on a small antique table. The air was scented with their perfume.

From upstairs came the sound of commotion, possibly children's voices – it was hard to tell.

'My half-brothers,' Lily said dismissively, and walked through to the kitchen, apparently expecting me to follow. It was enormous, in modernist grey, with an endless mushroom-coloured polished-concrete worktop. Everything in it screamed money, from the Dualit toaster to the coffee-maker, which was large and complicated enough not to be out of place in a Milanese café. Lily opened the fridge and scanned it, finally pulling out a box of fresh pineapple pieces that she started to eat with her fingers.

'Lily?'

A voice from upstairs, urgent, female.

'Lily, is that you?' The sound of footsteps racing down.

Lily rolled her eyes.

A blonde woman appeared in the doorway. She stared at me, then at Lily, who was dropping a piece of pineapple languidly into her mouth. She walked over and snatched the container from her hands. 'Where the *hell* have you been? The school is beside themselves. Daddy was out driving round the neighbourhood. We thought you'd been murdered! Where *were* you?'

'He's not my dad.'

'Don't get smart with me, young lady. You can't just walk back in here like nothing's happened! Do you have any idea of the trouble you've caused? I was up with your brother half the night, and then I couldn't sleep for worrying about what had happened to you. I've had to cancel our trip to Granny Houghton's because we didn't know where you were.'

Lily stared at her coolly. 'I don't know why you bothered. You don't usually care where I am.'

The woman stiffened with rage. She was thin, the kind of thin that comes with faddy diets or compulsive exercise; her hair was expensively cut and coloured so that it looked neither, and she was wearing what I assumed were designer jeans. But her face, tanned as it was, betrayed her: she looked exhausted.

She spun round to me. 'Is it you she's been staying with?'

'Well, yes, but –'

She looked me up and down, and apparently decided she was not enamoured of what she saw. 'Do you know the trouble you're causing? Do you have any idea how old she is? What the hell do you want with a girl that young anyway? You must be, what, thirty?'

'Actually, I –'

'Is this what it's about?' she asked her daughter. 'Are you having a relationship with this woman?'

'Oh, Mum, shut *up*.' Lily had picked up the pineapple again, and was fishing around in it with her forefinger. 'It's not what you think. She hasn't caused any of it.' She lowered the last piece of pineapple into her mouth, pausing to chew, perhaps for dramatic effect, before she spoke again. 'She's the woman who used to look after my dad. My real dad.'

Tanya Houghton-Miller sat back in the endless cushions of her cream sofa and stirred her coffee. I perched on the edge of the sofa opposite, gazing at the oversized Diptyque candles and the artfully placed *Interiors* magazines. I was slightly afraid that if I sat back as she had, my coffee would tip into my lap.

'How did you meet my daughter?' she said wearily. Her wedding finger sported two of the biggest diamonds I'd ever seen.

'I didn't, really. She turned up at my flat. I had no idea who she was.'

She digested that for a minute. 'And you used to look after Will Traynor.'

'Yes. Until he died.'

There was a brief pause as we both studied the ceiling – something had just crashed above our heads. 'My sons.' She sighed. 'They have some behavioural issues.'

'Are they from your ... ?'

'They're not Will's, if that's what you're asking.'

We sat there in silence. Or as near to silence as it could get when you could hear furious screaming upstairs. There was another thud, followed by an ominous silence.

'Mrs Houghton-Miller,' I said. 'Is it true? Is Lily Will's daughter?'

She raised her chin slightly. 'Yes.'

I felt suddenly shaky, and put my coffee cup on the table. 'I don't understand. I don't understand how –'

'It's quite simple. Will and I were together during the last year of uni. I was totally in love with him, of course. Everyone was. Although I should

say it wasn't all one-way traffic – you know?' She raised a small smile and waited, as if expecting me to say something.

I couldn't. How could Will not have told me he had a daughter? After everything we had been through?

Tanya drawled on: 'Anyway. We were the golden couple of our group. Balls, punting, weekends away, you know the drill. Will and I – well, we were everywhere.' She told the story as if it were still fresh to her, as if it were something she had gone over and over in her head. 'And then at our Founders' Ball, I had to leave to help my friend Liza, who had got herself into a bit of a mess, and when I came back, Will was gone. No idea where he was. So I waited there for ages, and all the cars came and took everyone home, and finally a girl I didn't even know very well came up to me and told me that Will had gone off with a girl called Stephanie Loudon. You won't know her but she'd had her eye on him for ever. At first I didn't believe it, but I drove to her house anyway, and sat outside, and sure enough, at five a.m. he came out and they stood there kissing on the doorstep, like they couldn't care who saw. And when I got out of the car and confronted him, he didn't even have the grace to be ashamed. He just said there was no point in us getting emotional as we were never going to last beyond college anyway.

'And then, of course, college finished, which was something of a relief, to be honest, because who wants to be the girl Will Traynor dumped? But it was so hard to get over, because it had ended so abruptly. After we left and he started work in the City I wrote to him asking if we could at least meet for a drink so I could work out what on earth had gone wrong. Because, as far as I was concerned, we had been really happy, you know? And he just got his secretary to send this – this *card*, saying she was very sorry but Will's diary was absolutely full and he didn't have time right now but he wished me all the best. "All the best".' She grimaced.

I winced internally. Much as I wanted to discount her story, this version of Will held a horrible ring of truth. Will himself had looked back at his earlier life with utter clarity, had confessed how badly he had treated women when he was younger. (His exact words were: 'I was a complete arse.')

Tanya was still talking. 'And then, about two months later, I discovered I was pregnant. And it was already awfully late because my periods had always been erratic and I hadn't realized I'd already missed two. So I

decided to go ahead and have Lily. But –' here she lifted her chin again, as if braced to defend herself – 'there was no point in telling him. Not after everything he'd said and done.'

My coffee had gone cold. 'No point in telling him?'

'He'd as good as said he didn't want anything to do with me. He would have acted as if I'd done it deliberately, to trap him or something.'

My mouth was hanging open. I closed it. 'But you – you don't think he had the right to know, Mrs Houghton-Miller? You don't think he might have wanted to meet his child? Regardless of what had happened between the two of you?'

She put down her cup.

'She's *sixteen*,' I said. 'She would have been fourteen, fifteen when he died. That's an awful long –'

'And by that time she had Francis. He was her father. And he has been very good to her. We were a family. Are a family.'

'I don't understand –'

'Will didn't *deserve* to know her.'

The words settled in the air between us.

'He was an arsehole. Okay? Will Traynor was a selfish arsehole.' She pushed a strand of hair back from her face. 'Obviously I didn't know what had happened to him. That came as a complete shock. But I can't honestly say it would have made a difference.'

It took me a moment to find my voice. 'It would have made every difference. To him.'

She looked at me sharply.

'Will killed himself,' I said, and my voice cracked a little. 'Will ended his life because he couldn't see any reason to go on. If he'd known he had a daughter –'

She stood up. 'Oh, no. You don't pin that on me, Miss Whoever-you-are. I am not going to be made to feel responsible for that man's suicide. You think my life isn't complicated enough? Don't you dare come here judging me. If you'd had to cope with half of what I cope with ... No. Will Traynor was a horrible man.'

'Will Traynor was the finest man I ever knew.'

She let her gaze run up and down me. 'Yes. Well, I can imagine that's probably true.'

I thought I had never been filled with such an instant dislike for someone.

I had stood to leave when a voice broke into the silence. ‘So my dad really didn’t know about me.’

Lily was standing very still in the doorway. Tanya Houghton-Miller blanched. Then she recovered herself. ‘I was saving you from hurt, Lily. I knew Will very well, and I was not prepared to put either of us through the humiliation of trying to persuade him to be part of a relationship he wouldn’t have wanted.’ She smoothed her hair. ‘And you really must stop this awful eavesdropping habit. You’re likely to get quite the wrong end of the stick.’

I couldn’t listen to any more. I walked to the door as a boy began shouting upstairs. A plastic truck flew down the stairs and crashed into pieces somewhere below. An anxious face – Filipina? – gazed at me over the banister. I began to walk down the stairs.

‘Where are you going?’

‘I’m sorry, Lily. We’ll – perhaps we’ll talk some other time.’

‘But you’ve hardly told me anything about my dad.’

‘He wasn’t your father,’ Tanya Houghton-Miller said. ‘Francis has done more for you since you were little than Will ever would have done.’

‘Francis is not my *dad*,’ Lily roared.

Another crash from upstairs, and a woman’s voice, shouting in a language I didn’t understand. A toy machine-gun sent tinny blasts into the air. Tanya put her hands to her head. ‘I can’t cope with this. I simply can’t cope.’

Lily caught up with me at the door. ‘Can I stay with you?’

‘What?’

‘At your flat? I can’t stay here.’

‘Lily, I don’t think –’

‘Just for tonight. Please.’

‘Oh, be my guest. Have her stay with you for a day or two. She’s just delightful company.’ Tanya waved a hand. ‘Polite, helpful, loving. A dream to have around!’ Her face hardened. ‘Let’s see how that works out. You know she drinks? And smokes in the house? And that she was suspended from school? She’s told you all this, has she?’

Lily seemed almost bored, as if she had heard this a million times before.

‘She didn’t even bother turning up for her exams. We’ve done everything possible for her. Counsellors, the best schools, private tutors. Francis has treated her as if she were his own. And she just throws it all back in our

faces. My husband is having a very difficult time at the bank right now, and the boys have their issues, and she doesn't give us an inch. She never has.'

'How would you even *know*? I've been with nannies half my life. When the boys were born, you sent me to boarding-school.'

'I couldn't cope with all of you! I did what I could!'

'You did what you *wanted*, which was to start your perfect family all over again, without me.' Lily turned back to me. 'Please? Just for a bit? I promise I won't get under your feet at all. I'll be really helpful.'

I should have said no. I knew I should. But I was so angry with that woman. And just for a moment I felt as if I had to stand in for Will, to do the thing he couldn't do. 'Fine,' I said, as a large Lego creation whistled past my ear and smashed into tiny coloured pieces by my feet. 'Grab your things. I'll be waiting outside.'

The rest of the day was a blur. We moved my boxes out of the spare room, stacking them in my bedroom, and made the room hers, or at least less of a storage area, putting up the blind I had never quite got round to fixing, and moving in a lamp and my spare bedside table. I bought a camp bed, and we carried it up the stairs together, with a hanging rail for her few things, a new duvet cover and pillow cases. She seemed to like having a purpose, and was completely unfazed at the idea of moving in with somebody she hardly knew. I watched her arranging her few belongings in the spare room that evening and felt oddly sad. How unhappy did a girl have to be to want to leave all that luxury for a box room with a camp bed and a wobbly clothes rail?

I cooked pasta, conscious of the strangeness of having someone to cook for, and we watched television together. At half past eight her phone went off and she asked for a piece of paper and a pen. 'Here,' she said, scribbling on it. 'This is my mum's mobile number. She wants your phone number and address. In case of emergencies.'

I wondered fleetingly how often she thought Lily was going to stay.

At ten, exhausted, I told her I was turning in. She was still watching television, sitting cross-legged on the sofa, and messaging someone on her little laptop. 'Don't stay up too late, okay?' It sounded fake on my lips, like someone pretending to be an adult.

Her eyes were still glued to the television.

‘Lily?’

She looked up, as if she’d only just noticed I was in the room. ‘Oh, yeah, I meant to tell you. I was there.’

‘Where?’

‘On the roof. When you fell. It was me who called the ambulance.’

I saw her face suddenly, those big eyes, that skin, pale in the darkness.

‘But what were you doing up there?’

‘I found your address. After everyone at home had gone nutso, I just wanted to work out who you were before I tried to talk to you. I saw I could get up there by the fire escape and your light was on. I was just waiting, really. But when you came up and started messing about on the edge I suddenly thought if I said anything I’d freak you out.’

‘Which you did.’

‘Yeah. I didn’t mean to do that. I actually thought I’d killed you.’ She laughed, nervously.

We sat there for a minute.

‘Everyone thinks I tried to jump.’

Her face swivelled towards me. ‘Really?’

‘Yeah.’

She thought about this. ‘Because of what happened to my dad?’

‘Yes.’

‘Do you miss him?’

‘Every single day.’

She was silent. Eventually she said, ‘So when is your next day off?’

‘Sunday. Why?’ I said, dragging my thoughts back.

‘Can we go to your home town?’

‘You want to go to Stortfold?’

‘I want to see where he lived.’



CHAPTER EIGHT

I didn't tell Dad we were coming. I wasn't entirely sure how to have that conversation. We pulled up outside our house and I sat for a minute, conscious, as she peered out of the window, of the small, rather weary appearance of my parents' house in comparison with her own. She had suggested we bring flowers when I told her my mother would insist we stay for lunch, and got cross when I suggested petrol-station carnations, even though they were for someone she'd never met.

I had driven to the supermarket on the other side of Stortfold, where she had chosen a huge hand-tied bouquet of freesias, peonies and ranunculus. Which I had paid for.

'Stay here a minute,' I said, as she started to climb out. 'I'm going to explain before you come in.'

'But –'

'Trust me,' I said. 'They're going to need a minute.'

I walked up the little garden path and knocked on the door. I could hear the television in the living room, and pictured Granddad there, watching the racing, his mouth working silently along with the horses' legs. The sights and sounds of home. I thought of the months I had kept away, no longer sure I was even welcome, of how I had refused to allow myself to think of how it felt to walk up this path, the fabric-conditioned scent of my mother's embrace, my father's distant bellow of laughter.

Dad opened the door, and his eyebrows shot up. 'Lou! We weren't expecting you! ... Were we expecting you?' He stepped forward and enveloped me in a hug.

I realized I liked having my family back. 'Hi, Dad.'

He waited on the step, arm outstretched. The smell of roast chicken wafted down the corridor. 'You coming in, then, or are we going to have a picnic out on the front step?'

'I need to tell you something first.'

'You lost your job.'

'No, I did not lose my –'

'You got another tattoo.'

‘You knew about the tattoo?’

‘I’m your father. I’ve known about every bloody thing you and your sister have done since you were three years old.’ He leaned forward. ‘Your mother would never let me have one.’

‘No, Dad, I don’t have another tattoo.’ I took a breath. ‘I ... I have Will’s daughter.’

Dad stood very still. Mum appeared behind him, with her apron on. ‘Lou!’ She caught the look on Dad’s face. ‘What? What’s wrong?’

‘She says she has Will’s daughter.’

‘She has Will’s *what?*’ Mum squawked.

Dad had gone quite white. He reached behind him for the radiator and clutched it.

‘What?’ I said, anxious. ‘What’s the matter?’

‘You – you’re not telling me you harvested his ... you know ... his little fellas?’

I pulled a face. ‘She’s in the *car*. She’s sixteen years old.’

‘Oh, thank God. Oh, Josie, thank God. These days, you’re so ... I never know what –’ He composed himself. ‘Will’s *daughter*, you say? You never said he –’

‘I didn’t know. Nobody knew.’

Mum peered around him to my car, where Lily was trying to act as if she didn’t know she was being talked about.

‘Well, you’d better bring her in,’ said Mum, her hand to her neck. ‘It’s a decent-sized chicken. It will do all of us if I add a few more potatoes.’ She shook her head in amazement. ‘Will’s *daughter*. Well, goodness, Lou. You’re certainly full of surprises.’ She waved at Lily, who waved back tentatively. ‘Come on in, love!’

Dad lifted a hand in greeting, then murmured quietly, ‘Does Mr Traynor know?’

‘Not yet.’

Dad rubbed his chest. ‘Is there anything else?’

‘Like what?’

‘Anything else you need to tell me. You know, apart from jumping off buildings and bringing home long-lost children. You’re not joining the circus, or adopting a kid from Kazakhstan or something?’

‘I promise I am doing none of the above. Yet.’

‘Well, thank the Lord for that. What’s the time? I think I’m ready for a drink.’

‘So where’d you go to school, Lily?’

‘It’s a small boarding-school in Shropshire. No one’s ever heard of it. It’s mostly posh retards and distant members of the Moldavian royal family.’

We had crammed ourselves around the dining-table in the front room, the seven of us knee to knee, and six of us praying that nobody needed the loo, which would necessitate everyone getting up and moving the table six inches towards the sofa.

‘Boarding-school, eh? Tuck shops and midnight feasts and all that? I bet that’s a gas.’

‘Not really. They shut the tuck shop last year because half the girls had eating disorders and were making themselves sick on Snickers bars.’

‘Lily’s mother lives in St John’s Wood,’ I said. ‘She’s staying with me for a couple of days while she ... while she gets to know a bit about the other side of her family.’

Mum said, ‘The Traynors have lived here for generations.’

‘Really? Do you know them?’

Mum froze. ‘Well, not as such ...’

‘What’s their house like?’

Mum’s face closed. ‘You’d be better asking Lou about that sort of thing. She’s the one who spent ... all the time there.’

Lily waited.

Dad said, ‘I work with Mr Traynor, who is responsible for the running of the estate.’

‘Granddad!’ exclaimed Granddad, and laughed. Lily glanced at him, then back at me. I smiled, although even the mention of Mr Traynor’s name made me feel oddly unbalanced.

‘That’s right, Daddy,’ said Mum. ‘He’d be Lily’s granddad. Just like you. Now who wants some more potatoes?’

‘Granddad,’ Lily repeated quietly, clearly pleased.

‘We’ll ring them and ... tell them,’ I said. ‘And if you like we can drive past their house when we leave. Just so you can see a bit of it.’

My sister sat silently throughout this exchange. Lily had been placed next to Thom, possibly in an attempt to get him to behave better, although the risk of him starting a conversation related to intestinal parasites was still

quite high. Treena watched Lily. She was more suspicious than my parents, who had just accepted everything I'd told them. She had hauled me upstairs while Dad was showing Lily the garden, and asked all the questions that had flown wildly around my head, like a trapped pigeon in a closed room. *How did I know she was who she said? What did she want? And then, finally, Why on earth would her own mother want her to come and live with you?*

'So how long is she staying?' she said, at the table, while Dad was telling Lily about working with green oak.

'We haven't really discussed it.'

She pulled the kind of face at me that told me simultaneously that I was an eejit, and also that this was no surprise to her whatsoever.

'She's been with me for two nights, Treen. And she's only young.'

'My point exactly. What do you know about looking after children?'

'She's hardly a child.'

'She's worse than a child. Teenagers are basically toddlers with hormones – old enough to want to do stuff without having any of the common sense. She could get into all sorts of trouble. I can't believe you're actually doing this.'

I handed her the gravy boat. "Hello, Lou. Well done on keeping your job in a tough market. Congratulations on getting over your terrible accident. It's really lovely to see you." '

She passed me the salt, and muttered, under her breath, 'You know, you won't be able to cope with this, as well as ...'

'As well as what?'

'Your depression.'

'I don't *have* depression,' I hissed. 'I'm not depressed, Treena. For crying out loud, I did not throw myself off a building.'

'You haven't been yourself for ages. Not since the whole Will thing.'

'What do I have to do to convince you? I'm holding down a job. I'm doing my physio to get my hip straight and going to a flipping grief-counselling group to get my mind straight. I think I'm doing pretty well, okay?' The whole table was now listening to me. 'In fact – here's the thing. Oh, yes. Lily was there. She saw me fall. It turns out she was the one who called the ambulance.'

Every member of my family looked at me. 'You see, it's true. She saw me fall. I didn't jump. Lily, I was just telling my sister. You were there

when I fell, weren't you? See? I told you all I heard a girl's voice. I wasn't going mad. She actually saw the whole thing. I slipped, right?'

Lily looked up from her plate, still chewing. She had barely stopped eating since we sat down. 'Yup. She totally wasn't trying to kill herself.'

Mum and Dad exchanged a glance. My mother sighed, crossed herself discreetly and smiled. My sister lifted her eyebrows, the closest I was going to get to an apology. I felt, briefly, elated.

'Yeah. She was just shouting at the sky.' Lily lifted her fork. 'And really, really pissed.'

There was a brief silence.

'Oh,' said Dad. 'Well, that's –'

'That's ... good,' said Mum.

'This chicken's great,' said Lily. 'Can I have some more?'

We stayed until late afternoon, partly because every time I got up to leave, Mum kept pressing more food on us, and partly because having other people to chat to Lily made the situation seem a little less weird and intense. Dad and I moved out to the back garden and the two deckchairs that had somehow failed to rot during another winter (although it was wisest to stay almost completely still once you were in them, just in case).

'You know your sister has been reading *The Female Eunuch*? And some old shite called *The Women's Bedroom* or something. She says your mother is a classic example of oppressed womanhood, and that the fact your mother disagrees shows how oppressed she is. She's trying to tell her I should be doing the cooking and cleaning and making out I'm some fecking caveman. But if I dare to say anything back she keeps telling me to "check my privilege". Check my privilege! I told her I'd be happy to check it if I knew where the hell your mother had put it.'

'Mum seems fine to me,' I said. I took a swig of my tea, feeling a faintly guilty pang that the sounds I could hear were Mum washing up.

He looked sideways at me. 'She hasn't shaved her legs in three weeks. Three weeks, Lou! If I'm really honest it gives me the heebie-jeebies when they touch me. I've been on the sofa for the last two nights. I don't know, Lou. Why are people never happy just to let things *be* any more? Your mum was happy, I'm happy. We know what our roles are. I'm the one with hairy legs. She's the one who fits the rubber gloves. Simple.'

Down the garden, Lily was teaching Thom to make birdcalls using a thick blade of grass. He held it up between his thumbs, but it's possible that his four missing teeth hampered any sound production, as all that emerged was a raspberry and a light shower of saliva.

We sat in companionable silence for a while, listening to the squawks of the birdcalls, Granddad whistling, and next door's dog yelping to be let in. I felt happy to be home.

'So how is Mr Traynor?' I asked.

'Ah, he's grand. You know he's going to be a daddy again?'

I turned, carefully, in my chair. 'Really?'

'Not with Mrs Traynor. She moved out straight after ... you know. This is with the red-headed girl, I forget her name.'

'Della,' I said, remembering suddenly.

'That's the one. They seem to have known each other quite a while, but I think the whole, you know, having-a-baby thing was a bit of a surprise to the both of them.' Dad cracked open another beer. 'He's cheerful enough. I suppose it's nice for him to have a new son or daughter on the way. Something to focus on.'

Some part of me wanted to judge him. But I could too easily imagine the need to create something good out of what had happened, the desire to climb back out, by whatever means.

They're only still together because of me, Will had told me, more than once.

'What do you think he'll make of Lily?' I asked.

'I have no idea, love.' Dad thought for a bit. 'I think he'll be happy. It's like he's getting a bit of his son back, isn't it?'

'What do you think Mrs Traynor will think?'

'I don't know, love. I have no idea where she even lives these days.'

'Lily's ... quite a handful.'

Dad burst out laughing. 'You don't say! You and Treena drove your mother and me half demented for years with your late nights and your boyfriends and your heartbreaks. It's about time you had some of it coming back your way.' He took a swig of his beer and chuckled again. 'It's good news, love. I'm glad you won't be on your own in that empty old flat of yours.'

Thom's grass let out a squawk. His face lit up, and he thrust his blade skyward. We raised our thumbs in salute.

‘Dad.’

He turned to me.

‘You know I’m fine, right?’

‘Yes, love.’ He gave me a gentle shoulder bump. ‘But it’s my job to worry. I’ll be worrying till I’m too old to get out of my chair.’ He looked down at it. ‘Mind you, that might be sooner than I’d like.’

We left shortly before five. In the rear-view mirror Treena was the only one of the family not waving. She stood there, her arms crossed over her chest, her head moving slowly from side to side as she watched us go.

When we got home, Lily disappeared onto the roof. I hadn’t been up there since the accident. I’d told myself the spring weather had made it pointless to try, that the fire escape would be slippery because of the rain, that the sight of all those pots of dead plants would make me feel guilty, but, really, I was afraid. Even thinking about heading up there again made my heart thump harder; it took nothing for me to recall that sense of the world disappearing from beneath me, like a rug pulled from under my feet.

I watched her climb out of the landing window and shouted up that she should come down in twenty minutes. When twenty-five had gone by, I began to get anxious. I called out of the window but only the sound of the traffic came back to me. At thirty-five minutes I found myself, swearing under my breath, climbing out of the hall window onto the fire escape.

It was a warm summer evening and the rooftop asphalt radiated heat. Below us the sounds of the city spelled a lazy Sunday in slow-moving traffic, windows down, music blaring, youths hanging out on street corners, and the distant chargrilled smells of barbecues on other rooftops.

Lily sat on an upturned plant pot, looking out over the City. I stood with my back to the water tank, trying not to feel a reflexive panic whenever she leaned towards the edge.

It had been a mistake to go up there. I felt the asphalt listing gently underneath my feet, like the deck of a ship. I made my way unsteadily to the rusting iron seat, lowering myself into it. My body knew exactly how it felt to stand on that ledge; how the infinitesimal difference between the solid business of living, and the lurch that would end everything could be measured in the smallest of units, in grams, in millimetres, in degrees, and that knowledge made the hairs on my arms prickle and a fine sweat seep through the skin on the back of my neck.

‘Can you come down, Lily?’

‘All your plants have died.’ She was picking at the dead leaves of a desiccated shrub.

‘Yes. Well, I haven’t been up here for months.’

‘You shouldn’t let plants die. It’s cruel.’

I looked at her sharply, to see if she was joking, but she didn’t seem to be. She stooped, breaking off a twig and examining the dried-up centre.

‘How did you meet my dad?’

I reached for the corner of the water tank, trying to stop my legs shaking. ‘I just applied for a job to look after him. And I got it.’

‘Even though you weren’t medically trained.’

‘Yes.’

She considered this, flicked the dead stem away into the air, then got up, walked to the far end of the terrace, and stood, her hands on her hips, legs braced, a skinny Amazon warrior. ‘He was handsome, wasn’t he?’

The roof was swaying under me. I needed to go downstairs. ‘I can’t do this up here, Lily.’

‘Are you really frightened?’

‘I’d just really rather we went down. Please.’

She tilted her head and watched me, as if trying to work out whether to do as I asked. She took a step towards the wall, and put her foot up speculatively, as if to jump onto the edge, just long enough to make me break out into a spontaneous sweat. Then she turned to me, grinned, put her cigarette between her teeth and walked back across the roof towards the fire escape. ‘You won’t fall off again, silly. Nobody’s that unlucky.’

‘Yeah. Well, right now, I don’t really want to test the odds.’

Some minutes later, when I could make my legs obey my brain, we went down the two flights of iron steps. We stopped outside my window when I realized I was shaking too much to climb through and I sat down on the step.

Lily rolled her eyes, waiting. Then, when she grasped I couldn’t move, she sat down on the steps beside me. We were only, perhaps, ten feet lower than we had been, but with my hallway visible through the window, and a rail on each side, I began to breathe normally again.

‘You know what you need,’ she said, and held up her roll-up.

‘Are you seriously telling me to get stoned? Four floors up? You know I just fell off a roof?’

‘It’ll help you relax.’

And then, when I didn’t take it, ‘Oh, come *on*. What – are you seriously the straightest person in the whole of London?’

‘I’m not from London.’

Afterwards, I couldn’t believe I had been manipulated by a sixteen-year-old. But Lily was like the cool girl in class, the one you found yourself trying to impress. Before she could say anything else, I took it from her and had a tentative drag, trying not to cough when it hit the back of my throat. ‘Anyway, you’re sixteen,’ I muttered. ‘You shouldn’t be doing this. And where is someone like you getting this stuff?’

Lily peered over the railing. ‘Did you fancy him?’

‘Fancy who? Your dad? Not at first.’

‘Because he was in a wheelchair.’

Because he was doing an impression of Daniel Day-Lewis in My Left Foot and it scared the bejaysus out of me, I wanted to say, but it would have taken too much explaining. ‘No. The wheelchair was the least important thing about him. I didn’t fancy him because ... he was very angry. And a bit intimidating. And those two things made him quite hard to fancy.’

‘Do I look like him? I Googled him but I can’t tell.’

‘A bit. Your colouring is the same. Maybe your eyes.’

‘My mum said he was really handsome and that was what made him such an arsehole. One of the things. Whenever I’m getting on her nerves now she tells me I’m just like him. *Oh, God, you’re just like Will Traynor*.’ She always calls him Will Traynor, though. Not “your father”. She’s determined to make out like Fuckface is my dad, even though he is patently not. It’s like she thinks she can just make a family by insisting that we are one.’

I took another drag. I could feel myself getting woozy. Apart from one night at a house party in Paris, it had been years since I’d had a joint. ‘You know, I think I’d enjoy this more if there wasn’t a small possibility of me falling off this fire escape.’

She took it from me. ‘Jeez, Louise. You need to have some fun.’ She inhaled deeply, and leaned her head back. ‘Did he tell you about how he was feeling? Like the real stuff?’ She inhaled again and handed it back to me. She seemed totally unaffected.

‘Yes.’

‘Did you argue?’

‘Quite a lot. But we laughed a lot, too.’

‘Did he fancy you?’

‘Fancy me? ... I don’t know if “fancy” is the right word.’

My mouth worked silently around words I couldn’t find. How could I explain to this girl what Will and I had been to each other, the way I felt that no person in the world had ever understood me like he did or ever would again? How could she understand that losing him was like having a hole shot straight through me, a painful, constant reminder, an absence I could never fill?

She stared at me. ‘He did! My dad fancied you!’ She started to giggle. And it was such a ridiculous thing to say, such a useless word, faced with what Will and I had been to each other, that, despite myself, I giggled too.

‘My dad had the hots for you. How mad is that?’ She gasped. ‘Oh, my God! In a different universe, you could have been MY STEPMUM.’

We gazed at each other in mock-horror and somehow this fact swelled between us until a bubble of merriment lodged in my chest. I began to laugh, the kind of laugh that verges on hysteria, that makes your stomach hurt, where the mere act of looking at someone sets you off again.

‘Did you have sex?’

And that killed it.

‘Okay. This conversation has now got weird.’

Lily pulled a face. ‘Your whole relationship sounds weird.’

‘It wasn’t at all. It ... it ...’

It was suddenly too much: the rooftop, the questions, the joint, the memories of Will. We seemed to be conjuring him out of the air between us: his smile, his skin, the feel of his face against mine, and I wasn’t sure I wanted to do it. I let my head fall slightly between my knees. *Breathe*, I told myself.

‘Louisa?’

‘What?’

‘Did he always plan to go to that place? Dignitas?’

I nodded. I repeated the word to myself, trying to quell my rising sense of panic. In. Out. *Just breathe*.

‘Did you try to change his mind?’

‘Will was ... stubborn.’

‘Did you argue about it?’

I swallowed. ‘Right up until the last day.’

The last day. Why had I said that? I closed my eyes.

When I finally opened them again, she was watching me.

‘Were you with him when he died?’

Our eyes locked. The young are terrifying, I thought. They are without boundaries. They fear nothing. I could see the next question forming on her lips, the faint searching in her gaze. But perhaps she was not as brave as I’d thought.

Finally she dropped her gaze. ‘So when are you going to tell his parents about me?’

My heart lurched. ‘This week. I’ll call this week.’

She nodded, turned her face away so that I couldn’t see her expression. I watched as she inhaled again. And then, abruptly, she dropped the joint through the bars of the fire-escape steps, stood up and climbed inside without a backward look. I waited until my legs felt as if they could support me again, then followed her through the window.



CHAPTER NINE

I called on Tuesday lunchtime, when a joint one-day strike by French and German air-traffic control had left the bar almost empty. I waited until Richard had disappeared to the wholesaler's, then stood out on the concourse, outside the last Ladies before security, and searched my phone for the number I had never been able to delete.

The phone rang three, four times, and just for a moment I was filled with the overwhelming urge to press END CALL. But then a man's voice answered, his vowels clipped, familiar. 'Hello?'

'Mr Traynor? It – it's Lou.'

'Lou?'

'Louisa Clark.'

A short silence. I could hear his memories thudding down on him along with the simple fact of my name and felt oddly guilty. The last time I had seen him had been at Will's graveside, a prematurely aged man, repeatedly straightening his shoulders as he struggled under the weight of his grief.

'Louisa. Well ... Goodness. This is – How are you?'

I shifted to allow Violet to sway past with her trolley. She gave me a knowing smile, adjusting her purple turban with her free hand. I noticed she had little Union Jacks painted on her fingernails.

'I'm very well, thank you. And how are you?'

'Oh – you know. Actually, I'm very well, too. Circumstances have changed a little since we last saw each other, but it's all ... you know ...'

That temporary and uncharacteristic loss of bonhomie almost caused me to falter. I took a deep breath. 'Mr Traynor, I'm ringing because I really need to talk to you about something.'

'I thought Michael Lawler had sorted out all the financial matters.' His tone altered just slightly.

'It's not to do with money.' I closed my eyes. 'Mr Traynor, I had a visitor a short time ago and it's someone I think you need to meet.'

A woman bumped into my legs with her wheeled case, and mouthed an apology.

‘Okay. There’s no simple way of doing this, so I’m just going to say it. Will had a daughter and she turned up on my doorstep. She’s desperate to meet you.’

A long silence this time.

‘Mr Traynor?’

‘I’m sorry. Can you repeat what you just said?’

‘Will had a daughter. He didn’t know about her. The mother is an old girlfriend of his, from university, who took it upon herself not to tell him. He had a daughter and she tracked me down and she really wants to meet you. She’s sixteen. Her name is Lily.’

‘Lily?’

‘Yes. I’ve spoken to her mother and she seems genuine. A woman called Miller. Tanya Miller.’

‘I – I don’t remember her. But Will did have an awful lot of girlfriends.’

Another long silence. When he spoke again his voice cracked. ‘Will had ... a daughter?’

‘Yes. Your granddaughter.’

‘You – you really think she is his daughter?’

‘I’ve met her mother, and heard what she had to say and, yes, I really think she is.’

‘Oh. Oh, my.’

I could hear a voice in the background: ‘Steven? *Steven? Are you all right?*’

Another silence.

‘Mr Traynor?’

‘I’m so sorry. It’s just – I’m a little ...’

I put my hand to my head. ‘It’s a huge shock. I know. I’m sorry. I couldn’t think of the best way to tell you. I didn’t want to just turn up at your house in case ...’

‘No. No, don’t be sorry. It’s good news. Extraordinary news. A *granddaughter.*’

‘What’s going on? Why are you sitting down like that?’ The voice in the background sounded concerned.

I heard a hand go over the receiver, then: ‘I’m fine, darling. Really. I – I’ll explain everything in a minute.’

More muffled conversation. And then back to me, his voice suddenly uncertain: ‘Louisa?’

‘Yes?’

‘You’re absolutely sure? I mean, this is just so –’

‘As sure as I can be, Mr Traynor. I’m happy to explain more to you, but she’s sixteen and she’s full of life and she’s ... well, she’s just very keen to find out about the family she never knew she had.’

‘Oh, my goodness. Oh, my ... Louisa?’

‘I’m still here.’

When he spoke again I found my eyes had filled unexpectedly with tears.

‘How do I meet her? How do we go about meeting ... Lily?’

We drove up the following Saturday. Lily was afraid to go alone, but wouldn’t say as much. She just told me it was better if I explained everything to Mr Traynor because ‘Old people are better at talking to each other.’

We drove in silence. I felt almost sick with nerves at having to enter the Traynor house again, not that I could explain it to the passenger beside me. Lily said nothing.

Did he believe you?

Yes, I told her. I think he did. Although she might be wise to have a blood test, just to reassure everyone.

Did he actually ask to meet me, or did you suggest it?

I couldn’t remember. My brain had set up a kind of static buzz just speaking to him again.

What if I’m not what he’s expecting?

I wasn’t sure he was expecting anything. He’d only just discovered he had a grandchild.’

Lily had turned up on Friday night, even though I hadn’t expected her until Saturday morning, saying that she’d had a massive row with her mother and that Fuckface Francis had told her she had some growing up to do. She sniffed. ‘This from a man who thinks it’s normal to have a whole room devoted to a *train set*.’

I had told her she was welcome to stay as long as (a) I could get confirmation from her mother that she always knew where she was, (b) she didn’t drink and (c) she didn’t smoke in my flat. Which meant that while I was in the bath she walked across the road to Samir’s shop and chatted to him for the length of time it took to smoke two cigarettes, but it seemed churlish to argue. Tanya Houghton-Miller wailed on for almost twenty

minutes about the impossibility of everything, told me four times I would end up sending Lily home within forty-eight hours and only got off the phone when a child started screaming in the background. I listened to Lily clattering around in my little kitchen, and music I didn't understand vibrating the few bits of furniture in my living room.

Okay, Will, I told him silently. If this was your idea of pushing me into a whole new life you certainly pulled a blinder.

The next morning I walked into the spare room to wake Lily and found her already awake, her arms curled round her legs, smoking by my open window. An array of clothes was tossed around on the bed, as if she had tried on a dozen outfits and found them all wanting.

She glared at me, as if daring me to say anything. I had a sudden image of Will, turning from the window in his wheelchair, his gaze furious and pained, and just for a moment it took my breath away.

'We leave in half an hour,' I said.

We reached the outskirts of town shortly before eleven. Summer had brought the tourists flocking back to the narrow streets of Stortfold, like clumps of earthbound, gaudily coloured swallows, clutching guidebooks and ice creams, weaving their way aimlessly past the cafés and seasonal shops full of castle-imprinted coasters and calendars that would be swiftly placed in drawers at home and rarely looked at again. I drove slowly past the castle in the long queue of National Trust traffic, wondering at the Pac-a-macs, the anoraks and sunhats that seemed to stay the same every year. This year was the five-hundredth anniversary of the castle, and everywhere we looked there were posters advertising events linked to it: morris dancers, hog roasts, fêtes ...

I drove up to the front of the house, grateful that we weren't facing the annex where I had spent so much time with Will. We sat in the car and listened to the engine ticking down. Lily, I noticed, had bitten away nearly all of her nails. 'You okay?'

She shrugged.

'Shall we go in, then?'

She stared at her feet. 'What if he doesn't like me?'

'Why wouldn't he?'

'Nobody else does.'

‘I’m sure that’s not true.’

‘Nobody at school likes me. My parents can’t wait to get rid of me.’ She bit savagely at the corner of a remaining thumbnail. ‘What kind of mother lets her daughter go and live at the mouldy old flat of someone they don’t even know?’

I took a deep breath. ‘Mr Traynor’s a nice man. And I wouldn’t have brought you here if I thought it wouldn’t go well.’

‘If he doesn’t like me, can we just leave? Like, really quickly?’

‘Of course.’

‘I’ll know. Just from how he looks at me.’

‘We’ll skid out on two wheels if necessary.’

She smiled reluctantly.

‘Okay,’ I said, trying not to show her that I was almost as nervous as she was. ‘Let’s go.’

I stood on the step, watching Lily so that I wouldn’t think too hard about where I was. The door opened slowly, and there he stood, still in the same cornflower blue shirt I remembered from two summers previously, but a newer, shorter haircut, perhaps a vain attempt to combat the ageing effects of extreme grief. He opened his mouth as if he wanted to say something to me but had forgotten what it was, and then he looked at Lily and his eyes widened just a little. ‘Lily?’

She nodded.

He gazed at her intently. Nobody moved. And then his mouth compressed, and tears filled his eyes, and he stepped forward and swept her into his arms. ‘Oh, my dear. Oh, my goodness. Oh, it’s so very good to meet you. Oh, my goodness.’

His grey head came down to rest against hers. I wondered, briefly, if she would pull back: Lily was not someone who encouraged physical contact. But as I watched, her hands crept out and she reached around his waist and clutched his shirt, her knuckles whitening and her eyes closing as she let herself be held by him. They stood like that for what seemed an eternity, the old man and his granddaughter, not moving from the front step.

He leaned back, and there were tears running down his face. ‘Let me look at you. Let me look.’

She glanced at me, embarrassed and pleased at the same time.

‘Yes. Yes, I can see it. Look at you! Look at you!’ His face swung towards mine. ‘She looks like him, doesn’t she?’

I nodded.

She was staring at him, too, searching, perhaps, for traces of her father. When she looked down, they were still holding each other’s hands.

Until that moment, I hadn’t realized I was crying. It was the naked relief on Mr Traynor’s battered old face, the joy of something he had thought lost and partially recaptured, the sheer unexpected happiness of both of them in finding each other. And as she smiled back at him – a slow, sweet smile of recognition – my nervousness, and any doubts I’d had about Lily Houghton-Miller, were banished.

It had been less than two years, but Granta House had changed significantly since I had last been there. Gone were the enormous antique cabinets, the trinket boxes on highly polished mahogany tables, the heavy drapes. It took the waddling figure of Della Layton to indicate why that might be. There were still a few glowing pieces of antique furniture, yes, but everything else was white or brightly coloured – new sunshine yellow Sanderson curtains and pale rugs on the old wood floors, modern prints in un moulded frames. She moved towards us slowly and her smile was faintly guarded, like something she had forced herself to wear. I found myself moving back involuntarily as she approached: there was something oddly shocking about such a very pregnant woman – the sheer bulk of her, the almost obscene curve of her stomach.

‘Hello, you must be Louisa. How lovely to meet you.’

Her lustrous red hair was pinned up in a clip, a pale blue linen shirt rolled up around slightly swollen wrists. I couldn’t help noticing the enormous diamond ring cutting into her wedding finger, and wondered with a vague pang what the last months had been like for Mrs Traynor.

‘Congratulations,’ I said, indicating her belly. I wanted to say something else, but I could never work out whether it was appropriate to say a heavily pregnant woman was ‘large’, ‘not large’, ‘neat’, ‘blooming’, or any of the other euphemisms people seemed to use to disguise what they wanted to say, which was essentially along the lines of *Bloody hell*.

‘Thank you. It was a bit of a surprise, but a very welcome one.’ Her gaze slid away from me. She was watching Mr Traynor and Lily. He still had one of her hands encased in his, patting it for emphasis, and was telling her

about the house, how it had been passed through the family for so many generations. 'Would everyone like tea?' she asked. And then, again, 'Steven? Tea?'

'Lovely, darling. Thank you. Lily, do you drink tea?'

'Could I have juice, please? Or some water?' Lily smiled.

'I'll help you,' I said to Della. Mr Traynor had begun to point out ancestors in the portraits on the wall, his hand at Lily's elbow, remarking on the similarity of her nose to this one, or the colour of her hair to that one over there.

Della watched them for a moment, and I thought I noticed something close to dismay flicker across her features. She caught me looking, and smiled briskly, as if embarrassed to have her feelings so nakedly on display. 'That would be lovely. Thank you.'

We moved around each other in the kitchen, fetching milk, sugar, a teapot, exchanging polite queries about biscuits. I stooped to get the cups out of the cupboard when Della couldn't comfortably reach that low, and placed them on the kitchen worktop. New cups, I noticed. A modern, geometrical design, instead of the worn flowery porcelain her predecessor had favoured, all delicately painted wild herbs and flowers with Latin names. All traces of Mrs Traynor's thirty-eight-year tenure here seemed to have been swiftly and ruthlessly erased.

'The house looks ... nice. Different,' I said.

'Yes. Well, Steven lost a lot of his furniture in the divorce. So we had to change the look a bit.' She reached for the tea caddy. 'He lost things that had been in his family for generations. Of course, she took everything she could.'

She flashed me a look, as if assessing whether I could be considered an ally.

'I haven't spoken to Mrs ... Camilla since Will ...' I said, feeling oddly disloyal.

'So. Steven said this girl just turned up on your doorstep.' Her smile was small and fixed.

'Yes. It was a surprise. But I've met Lily's mother, and she ... well, she was obviously close to Will for some time.'

Della put her hand to the small of her back, then turned back to the kettle. Mum had said she headed a small solicitors' practice in the next town. *You've got to wonder about a woman who hasn't been married by thirty, she*

had said sniffily, and then, after a quick look in my direction, *Forty. I meant forty.*

‘What do you think she wants?’

‘I’m sorry?’

‘What do you think she wants? The girl?’

I could hear Lily in the hall, asking questions, childish and interested, and felt oddly protective. ‘I don’t think she *wants* anything. She just discovered she had a father she hadn’t known about and wants to get to know his family. *Her* family.’

Della warmed and emptied the teapot, measured out the tea-leaves (loose, I noted, just as Mrs Traynor would have had). She poured the boiling water slowly, careful not to splash herself. ‘I have loved Steven for a very long time. He – he – has had a very hard time this last year or so. It would be ...’ she didn’t look at me as she spoke ‘... very difficult for him if Lily were to complicate his life at this point.’

‘I don’t think Lily wants to complicate either of your lives,’ I said carefully. ‘But I do think she has a right to know her own grandfather.’

‘Of course,’ she said smoothly, that automatic smile in place. I realized, in that instant, that I had failed some internal test, and also that I didn’t care. And then, with a final murmured check of the tray, Della picked it up and, accepting my offer to bring the cake and the teapot, carried it through to the drawing room.

‘And how are you, Louisa?’

Mr Traynor leaned back in his easy chair, a broad smile breaking his saggy features. He had talked to Lily almost constantly throughout tea, asking questions about her mother, where she lived, what she was studying (she didn’t tell him about the problems at school), whether she preferred fruit cake or chocolate (‘Chocolate? Me too!’) or ginger (no), and cricket (not really – ‘Well, we’ll have to do something about that!’). He seemed reassured by her, by her likeness to his son. At that point, he probably wouldn’t have cared if she had announced that her mother was a Brazilian lap-dancer.

I watched him sneaking looks at Lily, when she was talking, studying her in profile, as if perhaps he could see Will there too. Other times I caught a flicker of melancholy in his expression. I suspected that he was thinking what I had thought: this new grief that his son would never know her. Then

he would almost visibly pull himself together, forcing himself a little more upright, a ready smile back upon his face.

He had walked her around the grounds for half an hour, exclaiming when they returned that Lily had found her way out of the maze 'on your first go! It must be a genetic thing.' Lily had smiled as broadly if she had won a prize.

'And, Louisa? What is happening in your life?'

'I'm fine, thank you.'

'Are you still working as a ... carer?'

'No. I – I went travelling for a bit, and now I'm working at an airport.'

'Oh! Good! British Airways, I hope?'

I felt my cheeks colour.

'Management, is it?'

'I work in a bar. At the airport.'

He hesitated, just a fraction of a second, and nodded firmly. 'People always need bars. Especially at airports. I always have a double whisky before I get on a plane, don't I, darling?'

'Yes, you do,' replied Della.

'And I suppose it must be rather interesting watching everyone fly off every day. Exciting.'

'I have other things in the pipeline.'

'Of course you do. Good. Good ...'

There was a short silence.

'When is the baby due?' I said, to shift everybody's attention away from me.

'Next month,' said Della, her hands resting on the swell of her belly. 'It's a girl.'

'How lovely. What are you going to call her?'

They exchanged the glances that parents-to-be do when they have chosen a name but don't want to tell anyone.

'Oh ... we don't know.'

'Feels most odd. To be a father again, at my age. Can't quite imagine it. You know, changing nappies, that sort of thing.' He glanced at Della, then added reassuringly, 'It's marvellous, though. I'm a very lucky man. We're both very lucky, aren't we, Della?'

She smiled at him.

'I'm sure,' I said. 'How's Georgina?'

Perhaps only I would have noticed how Mr Traynor's expression changed, just a degree. 'Oh, she's fine. Still in Australia, you know.'

'Right.'

'She did come over a few months ago ... but she spent most of her time with her mother. She was very busy.'

'Of course.'

'I think she's got a boyfriend. I'm sure someone told me she had a boyfriend. So that's ... that's nice.'

Della's hand reached across and touched his.

'Who's Georgina?' Lily was eating a biscuit.

'Will's younger sister,' said Mr Traynor, turning to her. 'Your aunt! Yes! In fact, she looked a little like you when she was your age.'

'Can I see a picture?'

'I'll find you one.' Mr Traynor rubbed the side of his face. 'I'm trying to remember where we put that graduation photo.'

'Your study,' said Della. 'Stay there, darling. I'll get it. Good for me to keep moving.' She levered herself out of the sofa and walked heavily out of the room. Lily insisted on going with her. 'I want to see the rest of the photographs. I want to see who I look like.'

Mr Traynor watched them go, still smiling. We sat and sipped our tea in silence. He turned to me. 'Have you spoken to her yet? ... Camilla?'

'I don't know where she lives. I was going to ask you for her details. I know Lily wants to meet her, too.'

'She's had a difficult time of it. George says so, anyway. We haven't really spoken. It's all a bit complicated because of ...' He nodded towards the door and let out an almost imperceptible sigh.

'Would you like to tell her? About Lily?'

'Oh, no. Oh ... No. I – I'm not sure she'd really want ...' He ran a hand over his brow. 'Probably better if you do it.'

He copied out the address and phone number on a piece of paper and handed it to me. 'It's some distance away,' he noted, and smiled apologetically. 'Think she wanted a fresh start. Give her my best, won't you? It's odd ... to finally have a grandchild, in these circumstances.' He lowered his voice. 'Funnily enough, Camilla is the only person who could really understand how I'm feeling right now.'

If he had been anybody else I might have hugged him just then, but we were English and he had once been my boss of sorts, so we simply smiled

awkwardly at each other. And possibly wished we were somewhere else.

Mr Traynor straightened in his chair. 'Still. I'm a lucky man. A new start, at my age. Not sure I really deserve it.'

'I'm not sure happiness is a matter of what you deserve.'

'And you? I know you were very fond of Will ...'

'He's a hard act to follow.' I was conscious of a lump in my throat. When it cleared, Mr Traynor was still looking at me.

'My son was all about living, Louisa. I don't need to tell you that.'

'That's the thing, though, isn't it?'

He waited.

'He was just better at it than the rest of us.'

'You'll get there, Louisa. We all get there. In our ways.' He touched my elbow, his expression soft.

Della, arriving back in the room, began to load the tray, stacking the cups so ostentatiously that it could only have been a signal.

'We'd better get going,' I said to Lily, standing as she came in, holding out the framed photograph.

'She does look like me, doesn't she? Do you think our eyes are a bit the same? Do you think she'd want to speak to me? Is she on email?'

'I'm sure she will,' said Mr Traynor. 'But if you don't mind, Lily, I'll speak to her myself first. It's quite big news for us all to digest. Best give her a few days to get used to it.'

'Okay. So when can I come and stay?'

To my right, I heard the clatter of Della almost dropping a cup. She stooped slightly, righting it on the tray.

'Stay?' Mr Traynor bent forward, as if he weren't sure he'd heard her correctly.

'Well. You're my grandfather. I thought maybe I could come and stay for the rest of the summer? Get to know you. We've got so much to catch up on, haven't we?' Her face was alight with anticipation.

Mr Traynor looked towards Della, whose expression halted whatever he might have been about to say.

'It would be lovely to have you at some point,' Della said, holding the tray in front of her, 'but we have other things going on just now.'

'It's Della's first child, you see. I think she'd like –'

'I just need a little time by myself with Steven. And the baby.'

‘I could help. I’m really good with babies,’ Lily said. ‘I used to look after my brothers all the time when they were babies. And they were awful. Really horrible babies. They screamed, like, all the time.’

Mr Traynor looked at Della. ‘I’m sure you’ll be simply brilliant, Lily darling,’ he said. ‘It’s just that right now is not a very good time.’

‘But you’ve got loads of room. I can just stay in one of the guest rooms. You won’t even know I’m here. I’ll be really helpful with nappies and stuff and I could babysit so you could still go out. I could just ...’ Lily trailed off. She glanced from one to the other, waiting.

‘Lily ...’ I said, hovering uncomfortably near the door.

‘You don’t want me here.’

Mr Traynor stepped forward, made as if to put a hand on her shoulder. ‘Lily darling. That’s not –’

She ducked away. ‘You like the idea of having a granddaughter, but you don’t actually want me in your life. You just – you just want a *visitor*.’

‘It’s the timing, Lily,’ said Della, calmly. ‘It’s just – well, I waited a long time for Steven – your grandfather – and this time with our baby is very precious to us.’

‘And I’m not.’

‘That’s not it at all.’ Mr Traynor moved towards her again.

She batted him off. ‘Oh, God, you’re all the same. You and your perfect little families, all closed off. Nobody has any room for me.’

‘Oh, come on. Let’s not be dramatic about –’ Della began.

‘*Get lost*,’ Lily spat. And as Della shrank back, and Mr Traynor’s eyes widened in shock, she ran, and I left them in the silent drawing room to race after her.



CHAPTER TEN

I emailed Nathan. The answer came back:

Lou, have you started on strong meds? WTAF?

I sent him a second email, filling in a little more detail, and his normal equanimity seemed to return.

Well, the old dog. Still had some surprises for us, eh?

I didn't hear from Lily for two days. Half of me was concerned, the other a tiny bit relieved just to have a brief interlude of calm. I wondered if, once she was free of any fairytale ideas about Will's family, she might be more inclined to build bridges with her own. Then I wondered whether Mr Traynor would call her directly to smooth things over. And I wondered where Lily was, and whether her absence involved the young man who had stood and watched her in my doorway. There had been something about him – about Lily's evasiveness when I asked about him – that had stayed with me.

I had thought a lot about Sam, regretting my rapid exit. With hindsight, it had all seemed a bit overemotional and weird, running away from him like that. I must have seemed the exact person I kept protesting I wasn't. I resolved that the next time I saw him outside the Moving On Circle I would react very calmly, perhaps say hello with an enigmatic, non-depressed-person smile.

Work sagged and dragged. A new girl had started: Vera, a stern Lithuanian, who completed all the bar's tasks wearing the kind of peculiar half-smile of someone contemplating the fact that they had planted a dirty bomb nearby. She called all men 'filthy, filthy beasts' when out of earshot of Richard.

He had begun giving morning 'motivational' chats, after which we all had to pump the air and jump and shout, 'YEAH!' which always dislodged my curly wig, at which he would frown, as if it was somehow a failure indicative of my personality, not an inbuilt hazard of wearing a nylon

hairpiece that didn't actually stick to my head. Vera's wig stayed immobile on hers. Perhaps it was too afraid to fall off.

One night when I got home I did an internet search on teenagers' problems, trying to work out whether I could help to repair the damage of the weekend. But it had quite a lot on hormonal breakouts and nothing on what to do when you had introduced a sixteen-year-old you had just met to her dead quadriplegic father's surviving family. At half past ten I gave up, gazed around at the bedroom in which half my clothes were still stored in boxes, promised myself that this would be the week I did something about it, and then, having reassured myself that I totally would, fell asleep.

I was woken at half past two in the morning by the sound of someone trying to force my front door. I stumbled out of bed, grabbed a mop, then put my eye to the spy-hole, my heart thumping. 'I'm calling the police!' I yelled. 'What do you want?'

'It's Lily. *Duh.*' She fell through the door as I opened it, half laughing, reeking of cigarettes, her mascara smeared around her eyes.

I wrapped my dressing-gown around myself, and locked the door behind her. 'Jesus, Lily. It's the middle of the night.'

'Do you want to go dancing? I thought we could go dancing. I love dancing. Actually, that's not entirely true. I do like dancing but that's not why I'm here. Mum wouldn't let me in. They've changed the locks. Can you believe it?'

I was tempted to answer that, with my alarm clock set for six a.m., funnily enough, I could.

Lily bumped heavily against the wall. 'She wouldn't even open the stupid door. Just shouted through the letterbox at me. Like I was some kind of ... vagrant. So ... I thought I'd stay here. Or we could go dancing ...' She swayed past me and headed for the music system, where she turned up the sound to a deafening level. I raced towards it to turn it down, but she grabbed my hand. 'Let's dance, Louisa! You need to bust some moves! You're so sad all the time! Cut loose! C'mon!'

I wrenched my hand away, and rushed to the volume button, just in time for the first thumps of outrage to land from downstairs. When I turned, Lily had disappeared into the spare room, where she teetered and finally collapsed, face down, on the camp bed.

'Oh. My. God. This bed is soooooo rubbish.'

‘Lily? You can’t just come in here and – Oh, for God’s sake.’

‘Just for a minute,’ came the muffled answer. ‘Literally a stopover. And then I’m going dancing. We’re going dancing.’

‘Lily. I have work tomorrow morning.’

‘I love you, Louisa. Did I tell you that? I really do love you. You’re the only one who ...’

‘You can’t just collapse here like –’

‘Mmph ... disco nap ...’

She didn’t move.

I touched her shoulder. ‘Lily ... Lily?’

She let out a small snore.

I sighed, waited a few minutes, then carefully removed her tatty pumps, and the contents of her pocket (cigarettes, mobile phone, a crumpled fiver), which I took into my room. I propped her on her side in the recovery position, and finally, wide awake at three a.m., knowing I would probably not sleep for fear she would choke, sat on the chair, to watch her.

Lily’s face was peaceful. The wary scowl and the manic, overeager smile had stilled into something unearthly and beautiful, her hair fanned around her shoulders. Maddening as her behaviour was, I couldn’t be angry. I kept recalling the hurt on her face that Sunday. Lily was my polar opposite. She didn’t nurse a hurt, or contain it. She lashed out, got drunk, did God-knew-what to try to forget. She was more like her father than I’d thought.

What would you have made of this, Will? I asked him silently.

But, just as I had struggled to help him, I didn’t know what to do for her. I didn’t know how to make it better.

I thought of my sister’s words: *You won’t be able to cope, you know.* And just for a few still, pre-dawn moments, I hated her for being right.

We developed a routine of sorts, in which Lily would turn up to see me every few days. I was never certain which Lily I would find at my door: manically cheerful Lily, demanding that we go out and eat at this restaurant or look at the totally gorgeous cat outside on the wall downstairs, or dance in the living room to some band she’d just discovered; or subdued, wary Lily, who would nod a silent greeting on her way in, then lie on my sofa and watch television. Sometimes she would ask random questions about Will – what programmes did he like? (He barely watched television; he preferred films.) Did he have a favourite fruit? (Seedless grapes. Red ones.)

When was the last time I'd seen him laugh? (He didn't laugh much. But his smile ... I could picture it now, a rare flash of even white teeth, his eyes crinkling.) I was never sure whether she found my answers satisfactory.

And then, every ten days or so, there was drunk Lily, or worse (I was never sure), who would hammer on my door in the small hours, ignoring my protests about time and lost sleep, stumble past me with mascara-smudged cheeks and missing shoes and pass out on the little camp bed, refusing to wake when I left in the morning.

She seemed to have no hobbies, and few friends. She would talk to anyone in the street, asking favours with the unembarrassed insouciance of a feral kid. But she wouldn't answer the phone at home and seemed to expect everyone she met to dislike her.

Given that most private schools had finished for the summer, I asked her where she was when she wasn't at my flat or visiting her mother, and after a brief pause, she said, 'Martin's.' When I asked if he was her boyfriend, she pulled the universal teenage face in response to an adult who had said something not just spectacularly stupid but revolting, too.

Sometimes she would be angry, at others rude. But I could never refuse her. Chaotic as her behaviour was, I got the feeling my flat was a safe haven. I found myself searching for clues: examining her phone for messages (pin-locked), her pockets for drugs (none, apart from that one joint) and once, ten minutes after she had come in, tear-stained and drunk, staring down at the car outside my block, its horn blaring intermittently for the best part of three-quarters of an hour. Eventually one of my neighbours went downstairs and thumped on the window so hard that the occupant had driven off.

'You know, I'm not judging, but it's not a good idea to get so drunk that you don't know what you're doing, Lily,' I said one morning, as I made us both coffee. Lily spent so much time with me now that I'd had to adjust the way I lived: shopping for two, picking up mess that wasn't my own, making twice the hot drinks, remembering to lock the bathroom door to avoid shrieks of *Oh, my God. Gross!*

'You are totally judging. That's exactly what "it's not a good idea" means.'

'I'm serious.'

'Do I tell you how to live your life? Do I tell you that this flat is depressing, and you dress like someone who has lost the will to live, apart

from when you're being a gammy-legged porno pixie? Do I? Do I? No. I don't say anything, so just leave me alone.'

I wanted to tell her then. I wanted to tell her what had happened to me nine years previously, on a night when I had drunk too much, and how my sister had led me home, shoeless and crying silently, in the early hours. But she would no doubt greet it with the same childish scorn with which she greeted most of my revelations, and it was a conversation I had only ever managed to have with one person. And he wasn't here any more. 'It's also not fair to wake me up in the middle of the night. I have to get up early for work.'

'So give me a key. Then I won't wake you up, will I?'

She blasted me with that winning smile. It was rare and dazzling, and enough like Will's that I found myself giving the key to her. Even as I handed it over, I knew what my sister would say.

I spoke to Mr Traynor twice during that time. He was anxious to know Lily was well, had started to worry about what she was going to do with her life. 'I mean, she's plainly a bright girl. It's not a good idea for her to drop out of school at sixteen. Do her parents not have anything to say about it?'

'They don't seem to speak very much.'

'Should I have a word with them? Do you think she needs a university fund? I have to say, things are a tad tighter than they were since the divorce, but Will left a fair bit. So I thought that might be ... an appropriate use for it.' He lowered his voice. 'It might be wise, though, for us not to mention anything to Della just now. I don't want her getting the wrong idea.'

I resisted the urge to ask what the right idea might be.

'Louisa, do you think you could persuade Lily to come back? I keep thinking about her. I'd like us to all try again. I know Della would love to get to know her better too.'

I remembered Della's expression as we had tiptoed around each other in the kitchen, and wondered whether Mr Traynor was wilfully blind or just an eternal optimist.

'I'll try,' I promised.

There is a peculiar sort of silence in a flat when you are on your own in a city on a hot summer weekend. I was on earlies, finished my shift at four, arrived home by five, exhausted, and was secretly grateful that, for a few

brief hours, I had my home to myself. I showered, ate some toast, took a look online to see if there were any jobs that either paid more than the minimum wage or were not zero-hours contracts, then sat in the living room with all the windows open to encourage a breeze, listening to the sounds of the city filtering in on the warm air.

Most of the time, I was reasonably content with my life. I had been to enough group sessions now to know that it was important to be grateful for simple pleasures. I was healthy. I had my family again. I was working. If I hadn't made peace with Will's death, I did at least feel like I might be crawling out from under its shadow.

And yet.

On evenings like this, when the streets below were filled with couples strolling, and laughing people spilled out of pubs, already planning meals, nights out, trips to clubs, something ached inside me; something primal telling me that I was in the wrong place, that I was missing something.

These were the moments when I felt most left behind.

I tidied up a little, washed my uniform, and then, just as I was sinking into a kind of quiet melancholy, my buzzer went. I stood and picked up the entry-phone wearily, expecting a request for directions from a UPS driver, or some misdirected Hawaiian pizza, but instead I heard a man's voice.

'Louisa?'

'Who is this?' I said, though I knew immediately who it was.

'Sam. Ambulance Sam. I was just passing on the way home from work, and I just ... Well, you left in such a hurry the other night, I thought I'd make sure you were okay.'

'A fortnight later? I could have been eaten by cats by now.'

'I'm guessing you weren't.'

'I don't have a cat.' A short silence. 'But I'm fine, Ambulance Sam. Thanks.'

'Great ... That's good to hear.'

I shifted, so I could see him through the grainy black and white of the little entry video screen. He was wearing a biker jacket instead of his paramedic uniform, and had one hand resting against the wall, which he now removed, and turned to face the road. I saw him let out a breath, and that small motion prompted me to speak. 'So ... what are you up to?'

'Not much. Trying and failing to chat someone up through an entry-phone, mostly.'

My laugh was too quick. Too loud. 'I gave up on that ages ago,' I said. 'It makes buying them a drink really, really hard.'

I saw him laugh. I looked around at my silent flat. And I spoke before I could think: 'Stay there. I'll come down.'

I was going to bring my car, but when he held out a spare motorbike helmet, it seemed prissy to insist on my own transport. I stuffed my keys into my pocket and stood waiting for him to motion me aboard.

'You're a paramedic. And you ride a motorbike.'

'I know. But, as vices go, she's pretty much the only one I have left.' He grinned wolfishly. Something inside me lurched unexpectedly. 'You don't feel safe with me?'

There was no appropriate answer to that question. I held his gaze and climbed onto the back. If he did anything dangerous he had the skills to patch me up again afterwards.

'So what do I do?' I said, as I pulled the helmet over my head. 'I've never been on one of these before.'

'Hold on to those handlebars on the seat, and just move with the bike. Don't brace against me. If you're not happy, tap me on the shoulder and I'll stop.'

'Where are we going?'

'You any good at interior decorating?'

'Hopeless. Why?'

He fired up the ignition. 'I thought I'd show you my new house.'

And then we were in the traffic, weaving in and out of the cars and lorries, following signs to the motorway. I had to shut my eyes, press myself against his back and hope that he couldn't hear me squeal.

We went out to the very edge of the city, a place where the gardens grew larger, then morphed into fields, and houses had names instead of numbers. We came through a village that wasn't quite separate from the one before it, and Sam slowed the bike at a field gate and finally cut the engine, motioning for me to climb off. I removed the helmet, my heart still thumping in my ears, and tried to lift my sweaty hair from my head with fingers that were still stiff from gripping the pillion handlebars.

Sam opened the gate, and ushered me through. Half the field was grassland, the other an irregular mess of concrete and breeze blocks. In the

corner beyond the building work, sheltered by a high hedge, stood a railway carriage and, beside it, a chicken run in which several birds stopped to look expectantly towards us.

‘My house.’

‘Nice!’ I glanced around. ‘Um ... where is it?’

Sam began to walk down the field. ‘There. That’s the foundations. Took me the best part of three months to get those down.’

‘You live here?’

‘Yup.’

I stared at the concrete slabs. When I looked at him, something in his expression made me bite back what I was going to say. I rubbed at my head. ‘So... are you going to stand there all evening? Or are you going to give me a guided tour?’

Bathed in the evening sun, and surrounded by the scents of grass and lavender, and the lazy hum of the bees, we walked slowly from one slab to another, Sam pointing to where the windows and doors would be. ‘This is the bathroom.’

‘Bit draughty.’

‘Yeah. I need to do something about that. Watch out. That’s not actually a doorway. You just walked into the shower.’

He stepped over a pile of breeze blocks onto another large grey slab, holding out his hand so that I could step safely over them too. ‘And here’s the living room. So if you look through that window there,’ he held his fingers in a square, ‘you get the views of the open countryside.’

I looked out at the shimmering landscape below. I felt as if we were a million miles out of the city, not ten. I took a deep breath, enjoying the unexpectedness of it all. ‘It’s nice, but I think your sofa’s in the wrong place,’ I said. ‘You need two. One here, and maybe one there. And I’m guessing you have a window here?’

‘Oh, yes. Got to be dual aspect.’

‘Hmm. Plus you totally need to rethink your storage.’

The crazy thing was, within a few minutes of our walking and talking, I could actually see the house. I followed the line of Sam’s hands, as he gestured towards invisible fireplaces, summoned staircases out of his imagination, drew lines across invisible ceilings. I could see its over-height windows, the banisters that a friend of his would carve from aged oak.

‘It’s going to be lovely,’ I said, when we had conjured the last en-suite.

‘In about ten years. But, yup, I hope so.’

I gazed around the field, taking in the vegetable patch, the chicken run, the birdsong. ‘I have to tell you, this is not what I expected. You aren’t tempted to, you know, get builders in?’

‘I probably will eventually. But I like doing it. It’s good for the soul, building a house.’ He shrugged. ‘When you spend all day patching up stab wounds and over-confident cyclists and the wives whose husbands have used them as a punch-bag and the kids with chronic asthma from the damp ...’

‘... and the daft women who fall off rooftops.’

‘Those too.’ He gestured towards the concrete mixer, the piles of bricks. ‘I do this so I can live with that. Beer?’ He climbed into the railway carriage, motioning for me to join him.

It was no longer a carriage inside. It had a small, immaculately laid-out kitchen area, and an L-shaped upholstered seat at the end, though it still carried the faint smell of beeswax and tweedy passengers. ‘I don’t like mobile homes,’ he said, as if in explanation. He waved to the seat, ‘Sit,’ then pulled a cold beer from the fridge, cracking it open and handing me the bottle. He set a kettle on the stove for himself.

‘You’re not drinking?’

He shook his head. ‘I found after a couple of years on the job that I’d come home and have a drink to relax. And then it was two. And then I found I couldn’t relax until I’d had those two, or maybe three.’ He opened a caddy, dropped a teabag into a mug. ‘And then I ... lost someone close to me, and I decided that either I stopped or I would never stop drinking again.’ He didn’t look at me while he said this, just moved around the railway carriage, a bulky, yet oddly graceful presence within its narrow walls. ‘I do have the odd beer, but not tonight. I’m driving you home later.’

Comments like that took the weirdness out of sitting in a railway carriage with a man I didn’t really know. How could you maintain a reserve with someone who had tended your broken, partially unclothed body? How could you feel anxious around a man who had already told you of his plan to take you home again? It was as if the manner of our first meeting had removed the normal, awkward obstacles to getting to know someone. He had seen me in my underwear. Hell, he had seen under my actual skin. It meant I felt at ease around Sam in a way I didn’t with anyone else.

The carriage reminded me of the gypsy caravans I had read about in childhood, where everything had a place, and there was order in a confined space. It was homey, but austere, and unmistakably male. It smelt agreeably of sun-warmed wood, soap and bacon. A fresh start, I guessed. I wondered what had happened to his and Jake's old home. 'So ... um ... what does Jake think of it?'

He sat down at the other end of the bench with his tea. 'He thought I was mad at first. Now he quite likes it. He does the animals when I'm on shift. In return I've promised to teach him to drive around the field once he turns seventeen.' He lifted a mug. 'God help me.'

I raised my beer in return.

Perhaps it was the unexpected pleasure of being out on a warm Friday evening with a man who held your eye as he spoke and had the kind of hair you slightly wanted to ruffle with your fingers, or maybe it was just the second beer, but I finally started to enjoy myself. It got stuffy in the carriage, so we moved outside onto two fold-up chairs, and I watched the chickens peck around in the grass, which was oddly restful, and listened to Sam's tales of obese patients, who required four teams to lift them out of their homes, and young gang members, who tried to attack each other even as they were being stitched up in the back of his rig. As we talked I found myself sneaking surreptitious glances at him, at the way his hands held his mug, at his unexpected smiles, which caused three perfect lines to span out from the corner of each eye as if they had been drawn with fine-point precision.

He told me about his parents: his father a retired fireman, his mother a nightclub singer, who had given up her career for her children. ('I think it's why your outfit spoke to me. I'm comfortable with glitter.') He didn't mention his late wife by name, but observed that his mother worried about the ongoing lack of a feminine influence in Jake's life. 'She comes and scoops him up once a month and takes him back to Cardiff so she and her sisters can coo over him and feed him up and make sure he has enough socks.' He rested his elbows on his knees. 'He moans about going, but he secretly loves it.'

I told him about Lily's return, and he winced at my tale of her meeting with the Traynors. I told him about her perplexing moods, and her erratic behaviour, and he nodded, as if this were all to be expected. When I told him about Lily's mother he shook his head. 'Just because they're wealthy

doesn't make them better parents,' he said. 'If she was on benefits, that mother would probably get a little visit from Social Services.' He lifted a mug to me. 'It's a nice thing you're doing, Louisa Clark.'

'I'm not sure I'm doing it very well.'

'Nobody ever feels they're doing well with teenagers,' he said. 'I think that's kind of the point of them.'

It was hard to reconcile this Sam, at ease in his home, caring for his chickens, with the sobbing, skirt-chasing version we heard about in the Moving On Circle. But I knew very well how the persona you chose to present to the world could be very different from what was inside. I knew how grief could make you behave in ways you couldn't even begin to understand. 'I love your railway carriage,' I said. 'And your invisible house.'

'Then I hope you'll come again,' he said.

The compulsive shagger. If this was how he picked up women, I thought a little wistfully, then, boy, he was good. It was a potent mix: the gentlemanly grieving father, the rare smiles, the way he could scoop up a hen one-handed and the hen actually looked happy about it. I would not allow myself to become one of the psycho-girlfriends, I told myself repeatedly. But there was a sneaking pleasure to be had in just flirting gently with a handsome man. It was nice to feel something other than anxiety, or mute fury, the twin emotions that seemed to make up so much of my daily life. The only other encounters I'd had with the opposite sex over the last several months had been fuelled by alcohol and ended with a taxi and tears of self-loathing in the shower.

What do you think, Will? Is this okay?

It had grown darker, and we watched as the chickens clucked their way indignantly into their coop.

Sam watched them. He leant back in his chair. 'I get the feeling, Louisa Clark, that when you're talking to me there's a whole other conversation going on somewhere else.'

I wanted to come back with a smart answer. But he was right, and there was nothing I could say.

'You and I. We're both skirting around something.'

'You're very direct.'

'And now I've made you uncomfortable.'

'No.' I glanced at him. 'Well, maybe, a little.'

Behind us, a crow lifted noisily into the sky, its flapping wings sending vibrations through the still air. I fought the urge to smooth my hair and instead took a last swig of my beer. 'Okay. Well. Here's a real question. How long do you think it takes to get over someone dying? Someone you really loved, I mean.'

I'm not sure why I asked him. It was almost cruelly blunt, given his circumstances. Perhaps I was afraid that the compulsive shagger was about to come out to play.

Sam's eyes widened a little. 'Woah. Well ...' he peered down at his mug, and then out at the shadowy fields '... I'm not sure you ever do.'

'That's cheery.'

'No. Really. I've thought about it a lot. You learn to live with it, with them. Because they do stay with you, even if they're not living, breathing people any more. It's not the same crushing grief you felt at first, the kind that swamps you, and makes you want to cry in the wrong places, and get irrationally angry with all the idiots who are still alive when the person you love is dead. It's just something you learn to accommodate. Like adapting around a hole. I don't know. It's like you become ... a doughnut instead of a bun.'

There was such sadness in his face that I felt suddenly guilty. 'A doughnut.'

'Stupid analogy,' he said, with a half-smile.

'I didn't mean to -'

He shook his head. He looked at the grass between his feet, then sideways at me. 'C'mon. Let's get you home.'

We walked across the field to his bike. The air had cooled, and I crossed my arms over my chest. He saw, and handed me his jacket, insisting when I said I was okay. It was pleasingly heavy, and potently male. I tried not to inhale.

'Do you pick up all your patients like this?'

'Only the live ones.'

I laughed. It came out of me unexpectedly, louder than I had intended.

'We're not really meant to ask patients out on dates.' He held out the spare helmet. 'But I figure you're not my patient any more.'

I took it. 'And this isn't really a date.'

'It isn't?' He gave a small, philosophical nod as I climbed aboard. 'Okay.'



CHAPTER ELEVEN

That week, when I arrived at the Moving On Circle Jake wasn't there. As Daphne discussed her inability to open jars without a man in her kitchen, and Sunil talked of the problems of dividing up his brother's few belongings among his remaining siblings, I found myself waiting for the heavy red doors to open at the end of the church hall. I told myself it was his welfare I was concerned about, that he needed to be able to express his discomfort at his father's behaviour in a safe place. I told myself firmly that it was not Sam I was hoping to see, leaning against his bike.

'What are the small things that trip you up, Louisa?'

Perhaps Jake had finished with the group, I thought. Perhaps he had decided he didn't need it any more. People did drop out, everyone said. And that would be it. I would never see either of them again.

'Louisa? The daily things? There must be something.'

I kept thinking about that field, the neat confines of the railway carriage, the way Sam had strolled down the field with a hen under one arm, as if he was carrying a precious parcel. The feathers on her chest had been as soft as a whisper.

Daphne nudged me.

'We were discussing the small things in day-to-day life that force you to contemplate loss,' said Marc.

'I miss sex,' said Natasha.

'That's not a small thing,' replied William.

'You didn't know my husband,' said Natasha, and snorted a laugh. 'Not really. That's a terrible joke to make. I'm sorry. I don't know what came over me.'

'It's good to joke,' said Marc, encouragingly.

'Olaf was perfectly well endowed. Very well endowed, in fact.' Natasha's eyes flickered around us. When nobody spoke she held up her hands, a foot apart, and nodded emphatically. 'We were very happy.'

There was a short silence.

'Good,' said Marc. 'That's nice to hear.'

‘I don’t want anyone thinking ... I mean, that’s not what I want people thinking when they think of my husband. That he had a tiny –’

‘I’m sure nobody thinks that about your husband.’

‘I will, if you keep going on about it,’ said William.

‘I don’t want you thinking about my husband’s penis,’ said Natasha. ‘In fact, I forbid you to think about my husband’s penis.’

‘Stop going on about it then!’ said William.

‘Can we not talk about penises?’ said Daphne. ‘It makes me go a bit peculiar. The nuns used to smack us with rulers if we even used the word “undercarriage”.’

Marc’s voice was now tinged with desperation. ‘Can we steer the conversation away from – back to symbols of loss. Louisa, you were about to tell us which small things brought your loss home to you.’

I sat there, trying to ignore Natasha holding up her hands again, silently measuring some unlikely invisible length.

‘I think I miss having someone to discuss things with,’ I said carefully.

There was a murmur of agreement.

‘I mean, I’m not one of those people who has a massive circle of friends. I was with my last boyfriend for ages and we ... we didn’t really go out much. And then there was ... Bill. We just used to talk all the time. About music, and people, and things we’d done and wanted to do, and I never worried about whether I was going to say the wrong thing or offend someone because he just “got” me, you know? And now I’ve moved to London and I’m sort of on my own, apart from my family, and talking to them is always ... tricky.’

‘Word,’ said Sunil.

‘And now there’s something going on that I’d really like to chat to him about. I talk to him in my head, but it isn’t the same. I miss having that ... ability to just go, “Hey, what do you think of this?” And knowing that whatever he said was probably going to be the right thing.’

The group was silent for a minute.

‘You can talk to us, Louisa,’ said Marc.

‘It’s ... complicated.’

‘It’s always complicated,’ said Leanne.

I looked at their faces, kind and expectant, and completely unlikely to understand anything I told them. Not *really* understand it.

Daphne adjusted her silk scarf. 'What Louisa needs is another young man to talk to. Of course she does. You're young and pretty. You'll find someone else,' she said. 'And you, Natasha. Get back out there. It's too late for me, but you two shouldn't be sitting in this dingy old hall – Sorry, Marc, but they shouldn't. You should be out dancing, having a laugh.'

Natasha and I exchanged a look. Clearly, she wanted to go out dancing about as much as I did.

I had a sudden memory of Ambulance Sam and pushed the thought away.

'And if you ever do want another penis,' William said, 'I'm sure I could pencil in a –'

'Okay, everyone. Let's move on to wills,' said Marc. 'Anyone surprised by what turned up?'

I got home, exhausted, at a quarter past nine, to find Lily lying on the sofa in front of the television in her pyjamas. I dropped my bag. 'How long have you been here?'

'Since breakfast.'

'Are you okay?'

'Mm.'

Her face held a pallor that spoke of either illness or exhaustion.

'Not feeling well?'

She was eating popcorn out of a bowl and lazily scooped her fingers around the bottom of the bowl for crumbs. 'I just didn't feel like doing anything today.'

Lily's phone beeped. She stared listlessly at the message that came through, then pushed it away from her under a sofa cushion.

'Everything really okay?' I asked, after a minute.

'Fine.'

She didn't look fine.

'Anything I can help with?'

'I said I was fine.'

She didn't look at me as she spoke.

Lily spent that night at the flat. The following day, as I was leaving for work, Mr Traynor rang and asked to speak to her. She was stretched across the sofa and looked blankly up at me when I told her who was on the phone, then finally, reluctantly, held out a hand for the receiver. I stood there as she

listened to him. I couldn't hear his words, but I could hear his tone: kind, reassuring, emollient. When he finished, she left a short pause, then said, 'Okay. Fine.'

'Are you going to see him again?' I said, as she handed back the phone.

'He wants to come to London to see me.'

'Well, that's nice.'

'But he can't be too far away from *her* just now in case she goes into labour.'

'Do you want me to take you back there to see him?'

'No.'

She tucked her knees underneath her chin, reached out the remote control and flicked through the channels.

'Do you want to talk about it?' I said, after a minute.

She didn't respond, and after a minute or two, I realized the conversation was over.

On Thursday, I went into my bedroom, closed the door and called my sister. We were speaking several times a week. It was easier now that my estrangement from our parents no longer hung between us, like a conversational minefield.

'Do you think it's normal?'

'Dad told me I once didn't speak to him for two whole weeks when I was sixteen. Only grunts. And I was actually quite happy.'

'She's not even grunting. She just looks miserable.'

'All teenagers do. It's their default setting. It's the cheerful ones you want to worry about – they're probably hiding some massive eating disorder or stealing lipsticks from Boots.'

'She's spent the last three days just lying on the sofa.'

'And your point is?'

'I think something's wrong.'

'She's sixteen years old. Her dad never knew she existed, and popped his clogs before she could meet him. Her mother married someone she calls Fuckface, she has two little brothers who sound like trainee Reggie and Ronnie Kray, and they changed the locks to the family home. I would probably lie on a sofa for a year if I was her.' Treena took a noisy slurp of her tea. 'Plus she's living with someone who wears glittery green Spandex to a bar job and calls it a career.'

‘Lurex. It’s Lurex.’

‘Whatever. So when are you going to find yourself a decent job?’

‘Soon. I just need to get this situation sorted first.’

‘This situation.’

‘She’s really down. I feel bad for her.’

‘You know what makes me feel down? The way you keep promising to live some kind of a life, then sacrifice yourself to every waif and stray who comes across your path.’

‘Will was not a waif and stray.’

‘But Lily is. You don’t even *know* this girl, Lou. You should be focusing on moving forward. You should be sending off your CV, talking to contacts, working out where your strengths are, not finding yet another excuse to put your own life on hold.’

I stared outside at the city sky. In the next room, I could hear the television burbling away, then Lily getting up, walking to the fridge and flopping down again. I lowered my voice: ‘So what would you do, Treen? The child of the man you loved turns up on your doorstep, and everyone else seems to have pretty much handed over responsibility for her. You’d walk away too, would you?’

My sister fell briefly silent. This was a rare enough occurrence that I felt obliged to keep talking. ‘So if Thom, in eight years’ time, had fallen out with you, for whatever reason – say he was pretty much on his own, and was going off the rails – you’d think it was great if the one person he asked for help decided it was altogether too much of a pain in the arse, would you? That they should just bugger off and suit themselves?’ I rested my head against the wall. ‘I’m trying to do the right thing here, Treen. Just cut me a break, okay?’

Nothing.

‘It makes me feel better. Okay? It makes me feel better knowing I’m helping.’

My sister was silent for so long I wondered whether she had hung up. ‘Treen?’

‘Okay. Well, I do remember reading a thing in social psychology about how teenagers find too much face-to-face contact exhausting.’

‘You want me to talk to her through a door?’ One day I would have a telephone conversation with my sister that didn’t involve the weary sigh of someone explaining something to a halfwit.

‘No, doofus. What it means is that if you’re going to get her to talk you need to be doing something together, side by side.’

On my way home on Friday evening I stopped off at the DIY superstore. Back at my block, I lugged the bags up the four flights of stairs, and let myself in. Lily was exactly where I was expecting to find her: stretched out in front of the television. ‘What’s that?’ she asked.

‘Paint. This flat’s a bit tired. You keep telling me I need to brighten it up. I thought we could get rid of this boring old magnolia.’

She couldn’t help herself. I pretended to be busy making myself a drink, watching out of the corner of my eye as she stretched, then walked over and examined the paint cans. ‘That’s hardly any less boring. It’s basically pale grey.’

‘I was told grey was the in thing. I’ll take it back if you think it won’t work.’

She peered at it. ‘No. It’s okay.’

‘I thought the spare room could have cream on two, then one grey wall. Do you think they go?’ I busied myself with unwrapping the paintbrushes and rollers as I spoke. I changed into an old shirt and some shorts and asked if she could put on some music.

‘What sort?’

‘You choose.’ I hauled a chair off to one side and laid some dust sheets along the wall. ‘Your dad said I was a musical Philistine.’

She didn’t say anything, but I had her attention. I cracked open a paint tin and began to mix it. ‘He made me go to my first ever concert. Classical, not pop. I only agreed because it meant he would leave the house. He didn’t like going out much in the early days. He put on a shirt and a good jacket and it was the first time I had seen him look like ...’ I remembered the jolt as I had seen, emerging from the stiff blue collar, the man he had been before his accident. I swallowed. ‘Anyway. I went preparing to be bored, and cried my way through the second half like a complete loon. It was the most amazing thing I’d ever heard in my life.’

A short silence.

‘What was it? What did you listen to?’

‘I can’t remember. Sibelius? Does that sound right?’

She shrugged. I started painting, as she came up beside me. She picked up a brush. She said nothing at first, but she seemed to lose herself in the

repetitive nature of the task. She was careful, too, adjusting the sheet so that she didn't spill paint on the floor, wiping her brush on the edge of the pot. We didn't speak, except for muttered requests: *Can you pass me the smaller brush? Do you think that will still show through on the second coat?* It took us just half an hour to do the first wall between us.

'So what do you think?' I said, admiring it. 'Think we can do another?'

She moved a dust sheet and started on the next wall. She had put on some indie band I had never heard of, light-hearted and agreeable. I started to paint again, ignoring the ache in my shoulder, the urge to yawn.

'You should get some pictures.'

'You're right.'

'I've got this big print at home of a Kandinsky. It doesn't really go in my room. You could have it if you want it.'

'That would be great.'

She was working faster now, speeding across the wall, carefully cutting in around the large window.

'So I was thinking,' I said, 'we should speak to Will's mum. Your grandmother. Are you okay if I write to her?'

She said nothing. She crouched down, apparently absorbed in carefully coating the wall to the skirting-board. Finally, she stood up. 'Is she like him?'

'Like who?'

'Mrs Traynor? Is she like Mr Traynor?'

I stepped down from the box I was using to stand on, and wiped my brush on the edge of the tin. 'She's ... different.'

'That's your way of saying she's a cow.'

'She's not a cow. She's just – It takes longer to get to know her is all.'

'That's your way of telling me she's a cow and she's not going to like me.'

'I'm not saying that at all, Lily. But she is someone who doesn't show her emotions easily.'

Lily sighed and put down her paintbrush. 'I'm basically the only person in the world who could discover two grandparents I didn't know I had, then find out that neither of them even likes me.'

We stared at each other. And suddenly, unexpectedly, we started to laugh.

I put the lid on the paint. 'Come on,' I said. 'Let's go out.'

'Where?'

‘You’re the one who says I need to have some fun. You tell me.’

I pulled out a series of tops from one of my storage boxes until Lily finally determined which one was acceptable, and I let her take me to a tiny cavernous club in a back-street near the West End where the bouncers knew her by name and nobody seemed to consider for a minute that she might be under eighteen. ‘It’s nineties music. Olden-days stuff!’ she said cheerfully, and I tried not to think too hard about the fact that I was, in her eyes, basically geriatric.

We danced until I stopped feeling self-conscious, sweat came through our clothes, our hair stuck out in fronds and my hip hurt so much that I wondered whether I would be able to stand up behind the bar the following week. We danced as if we had nothing to do but dance. Lord, it felt good. I had forgotten the joy of just existing; of losing yourself in music, in a crowd of people, the sensations that came with becoming one communal, organic mass, alive only to a pulsing beat. For a few dark, thumping hours, I let go of everything, my problems floating away like helium balloons: my awful job, my picky boss, my failure to move on. I became a thing, alive, joyful. I looked over the crowd at Lily, her eyes closed as her hair flew about her face, that peculiar mixture of concentration and freedom in her features that comes when someone loses themselves in rhythm. Then she opened her eyes and I wanted to be angry that her raised arm held a bottle that clearly wasn’t cola, but I found myself smiling back at her – a broad, euphoric grin – and thinking how strange it was that a messed-up child who barely knew herself had so much to teach me about the business of living.

Around us London was shrill and heaving, even though it was two a.m. We paused for Lily to take joint selfies of us in front of a theatre, a Chinese sign and a man dressed as a large bear (apparently every event had to be marked by photographic evidence), then wove our way through crowded streets in search of a night bus, past the late-night kebab shops and the bellowing drunks, the pimps and the gaggles of screeching girls. My hip was throbbing badly, and sweat was cooling unpleasantly under my damp clothes, but I still felt energized, as if I had been snapped back on.

‘God knows how we’re going to get home,’ Lily said cheerfully.

And then I heard the shout.

‘Lou!’ There was Sam, leaning out of the driver’s window of an ambulance. As I lifted my hand in response, he pulled the truck across the road in a giant U-turn. ‘Where you headed?’

‘Home. If we can ever find a bus.’

‘Hop in. Go on. I won’t tell if you won’t. We’re just finishing our shift.’ He looked at the woman beside him. ‘Ah come on, Don. She’s a patient. Broken hip. Can’t leave her to walk home.’

Lily was delighted by this unexpected turn of events. And then the rear door opened and the woman, in a paramedic uniform, eyes rolling, was shepherding us in. ‘You’re going to get us sacked, Sam,’ she said, and motioned for us to sit down on the gurney. ‘Hiya. I’m Donna. Oh, no – I do remember you. The one who ...’

‘... fell off a building. Yup.’

Lily pulled me to her for an ‘ambulance selfie’ and I tried not to look as Donna rolled her eyes again.

‘So where have you been?’ Sam called through to the rear.

‘Dancing,’ said Lily. ‘I’ve been trying to persuade Louisa to be less of a boring old fart. Can we put the siren on?’

‘Nope. Where’d you go? That’s from another boring old fart, by the way. I won’t have a clue whatever you say.’

‘The Twenty-two,’ said Lily. ‘Down the back of Tottenham Court Road?’

‘That’s where we had the emergency tracheotomy, Sam.’

‘I remember. You look like you’ve had a good night.’ He met my eye in the mirror and I coloured a little. I was suddenly glad to have been out dancing. It made me seem like I might be someone else altogether. Not just a tragic airport barmaid whose idea of a night out was falling off a roof.

‘It was great,’ I said, beaming.

Then he looked down at the computer screen on the dashboard. ‘Oh, great. Got a Green One over at Spencer’s.’

‘But we’re headed back in,’ said Donna. ‘Why does Lennie always do this to us? That man’s a sadist.’

‘No one else available.’

‘What’s going on?’

‘A job’s come up. I might have to drop you. It’s not far from yours, though. Okay?’

‘Spencer’s,’ said Donna, and let out a deep sigh. ‘Oh, marvellous. Hold on tight, girls.’

The siren went on. And we were off, lurching through the London traffic with the blue light screaming above our head, Lily squealing with delight.

On any given week-night, Donna told us, as we clutched the handrails, the station would get calls from Spencer's, summoned to fix those who hadn't made it upright to closing time, or to stitch up the faces of young men for whom six pints in an evening left them combative and without any accompanying sense. 'These youngsters should be feeling great about life, but instead they're just knocking themselves out with every spare pound they earn. Every bloody week.'

We were there in minutes, the ambulance slowing outside to avoid the drunks spilling out onto the pavement. The signs in Spencer's nightclub's smoked windows advertised 'Free drinks for girls before 10 p.m.' Despite the stag and hen nights, the catcalling and gaudy clothes, the packed streets of the drinking zone had less of a carnival atmosphere than something tense and explosive. I found myself gazing out of the window warily.

Sam opened the rear doors and picked up his bag. 'Stay in the rig,' he said, and climbed out.

A police officer headed over to him, muttered something, and we watched as they walked over to a young man who was sitting in the gutter, blood streaming from a wound to his temple. Sam squatted beside him, while the officer attempted to keep back the drunken gawkers, the 'helpful' friends, the wailing girlfriends. He seemed to be surrounded by a bunch of well-dressed extras from *The Walking Dead*, swaying mindlessly and grunting, occasionally bloodied and toppling.

'I hate these jobs,' said Donna, checking briskly through her pack of plastic-wrapped medical supplies as we watched. 'Give me a woman in labour or a nice old granny with cardiomyopathy any day. Oh, flipping heck, he's off.'

Sam was tilting the young lad's face to examine it when another boy, his hair thick with gel and the collar of his shirt soaked in blood, grabbed at his shoulder. 'Oi! I need to go in the ambulance!'

Sam turned slowly towards the young drunk, who was spraying blood and saliva as he spoke. 'Back away now, mate. All right? Let me do my job.'

Drink had made the boy stupid. He glanced at his mates, and then he was in Sam's face, snarling, 'Don't you tell me to back away.'

Sam ignored him, and continued attending to the other boy's face.

‘Hey! Hey you! I need to get to the hospital.’ He pushed Sam’s shoulder. ‘Hey!’

Sam stayed crouched for a moment, very still. Then he straightened slowly, and turned, so that he was nose to nose with the drunk. ‘I’ll explain something in terms you might be able to understand, son. You’re not getting in the truck, okay? That’s it. So save your energy, go finish your night with your mates, put a bit of ice on it, and see your GP in the morning.’

‘You don’t get to tell me *nothing*. I pay your wages. My *effing nose is broke*.’

As Sam gazed steadily back at him, the boy swung out a hand and pushed at Sam’s chest. Sam looked down at it.

‘Uh-oh,’ said Donna, beside me.

Sam’s voice, when it emerged, was a growl: ‘Okay. I’m warning you now —’

‘You don’t warn me!’ The boy’s face was scornful. ‘You don’t warn me! Who do you think you are?’

Donna was out of the truck and jogging towards a cop. She murmured something in his ear and I saw them both look over. Donna’s face was pleading. The boy was still yelling and swearing, now pushing at Sam’s chest. ‘So you sort *me* out before you deal with that *wanker*.’

Sam adjusted his collar. His face had become dangerously still.

And just as I realized I was holding my breath, the policeman was there, between them. Donna’s hand was on Sam’s sleeve and she was steering him back to the young lad on the kerb. The policeman muttered something into his radio, his hand on the drunk’s shoulder. The boy swung round and spat on Sam’s jacket. ‘*Fuck you*.’

There was a brief, shocked silence. Sam stiffened.

‘Sam! Come on, give me a hand, yes? I need you.’ Donna propelled him forwards. When I caught sight of Sam’s face, his eyes glittered as cold and hard as diamonds.

‘Come on,’ said Donna, as they loaded the semi-comatose lad into the back of the truck. ‘Let’s get out of here.’

He drove silently, Lily and I wedged into the front seat beside him. Donna cleaned the back of his jacket as he stared ahead, stubbly jaw jutting.

‘Could be worse,’ Donna said cheerfully. ‘I had one throw up in my hair last month. And the little monster did it on purpose. Shoved his fingers

down the back of his throat and ran up behind me, just because I wouldn't take him home, like I was some kind of bloody minicab.'

She stood up and motioned for the energy drink she kept in the front. 'It's a waste of resources. When you think what we could be doing, instead of scooping up a load of little ...' She took a swig, then looked down at the barely conscious young boy. 'I don't know. You have to wonder what goes on in their heads.'

'Not much,' said Sam.

'Yeah. Well, we have to keep this one on a tight leash.' Donna patted Sam's shoulder. 'He got a caution last year.'

Sam glanced sideways at me, suddenly sheepish. 'We went to pick up a girl from the top of Commercial Street. Face smashed to a pulp. Domestic. As I went to lift her onto the gurney, her boyfriend came flying out of the pub and went for her again. Couldn't help myself.'

'You took a swing at him?'

'More than one,' Donna scoffed.

'Yeah. Well. It wasn't a good time.'

Donna shifted to grimace at me. 'Well, this one can't afford to get in trouble again. Or he's out of the service.'

'Thanks,' I said, as he let us out. 'For the lift, I mean.'

'Couldn't leave you in that open-air asylum,' he said.

His eyes briefly met mine. Then Donna shut the door and they were gone, heading for the hospital with their battered human cargo.

'You totally fancy him,' said Lily, as we watched the ambulance disappear.

I had forgotten she was even there. I sighed as I reached into my pockets for the keys. 'He's a shagger.'

'So? I would totally shag that,' Lily said, as I opened the door to let her in. 'I mean, if I was old. And a bit desperate. Like you.'

'I don't think I'm ready for a relationship, Lily.'

She was walking behind me, so there was no way I could actually prove it, but I swear I could feel her pulling faces at me the whole way up the stairs.



CHAPTER TWELVE

I wrote to Mrs Traynor. I didn't tell her about Lily, just that I hoped she was well, that I was back from my travels and would be in her area in a few weeks with a friend, and would like to say hello if possible. I sent it first class, and felt oddly excited as it plopped into the post-box.

Dad had told me over the phone that she had left Granta House within weeks of Will's death. He said the estate workers had been shocked, but I thought back to the time I had spotted Mr Traynor out with Della, the woman he was now about to have a baby with, and I wondered how many genuinely had been. There were few secrets in a small town.

'She took it all terrible hard,' Dad said. 'And once she was gone your redheaded woman there was in like Flynn. She saw her chance, all right. Nice auld fella, own hair, big house, he's not going to be single for long, eh? Speaking of which, Lou. You – you wouldn't have a word with your mother about her armpits, would you? She's going to be after plaiting it if she lets it all grow any longer.'

I kept thinking about Mrs Traynor, trying to imagine how she would react to the news about Lily. I remembered the joy and disbelief on Mr Traynor's face at their first meeting. Would Lily help to heal her pain a little? Sometimes I watched Lily laughing at something on television, or simply gazing steadily out of the window lost in thought, and I saw Will so clearly in her features – the precise angles of her nose, those almost Slavic cheekbones – that I forgot to breathe. (At this point she would usually grumble, 'Stop staring at me like a weirdo, Clark. You're freaking me out.')

Lily had come to stay for two weeks. Tanya Houghton-Miller had called to say they were off on a family holiday to Tuscany and Lily didn't want to go with them. 'Frankly, the way she's behaving right now, as far as I'm concerned, that's fine. She's exhausting me.'

I pointed out that, given Lily was barely at home, and Tanya had changed the locks to her front door, it would be pretty hard for Lily to exhaust anyone unless she was tapping at their window and singing a lament. There was a short silence.

‘When you have your own children, Louisa, you might eventually have some idea what I’m talking about.’ Oh, the trump card of all parents. *How could I possibly understand?*

She offered me money to cover Lily’s board and lodging while they were away. I took some pleasure in telling her I wouldn’t dream of taking it, even though, frankly, it was costing me more than I had anticipated to have her there. Lily, it turned out, wasn’t satisfied with my beans-on-toast or cheese-sandwich suppers. She would ask for cash, then return with artisan bread, exotic fruit, Greek yoghurt, organic chicken – the staples of a wealthy middle-class kitchen. I remembered Tanya’s house, the way Lily had stood by the oversized fridge and thoughtlessly dropped chunks of fresh pineapple into her mouth.

‘By the way,’ I said, ‘who is Martin?’

There was a short pause. ‘Martin is my former partner. Lily apparently insists on seeing him, even though she knows I don’t like it.’

‘Could I have his number? I’d just like to make sure I know where she is. You know, while you’re gone.’

‘Martin’s number? Why would I have Martin’s number?’ she squawked, and the phone went dead.

Something had changed since I’d met Lily. It wasn’t just that I’d learned to accommodate the explosion of teenage-related mess in my near-empty flat, I had actually started to quite enjoy having Lily in my life, having someone to eat with, sit side by side with on the sofa, commenting on whatever we happened to be watching on the television, or keeping a poker face when she offered me some concoction she’d made. *Well, how should I know you have to cook the potatoes in a potato salad? It’s a salad, for God’s sake.*

At work I now listened to the fathers at the bar wishing their children goodnight as they flew off on business trips – *You be good for Mummy now, Luke ... Did you? ... You did? Aren’t you a clever boy!* – and the custody arguments conducted in hissed telephone conversations: *No, I did not say I could pick him up from school that day. I was always due in Barcelona ... Yes, I was ... No, no, you just don’t listen.*

I couldn’t believe that you could give birth to someone, love them, nurture them, and by their sixteenth year claim that you were so exasperated that you’d change the locks of your house against them. Sixteen was still a child, surely. For all her posturing, I could see the child in Lily. It was there

in the excitements and sudden enthusiasms. It was there in the sulks, the trying on of different looks in front of my bathroom mirror and the abrupt, innocent sleep.

I thought of my sister and her uncomplicated love for Thom. I thought of my parents, encouraging, worrying about and supporting Treena and me, even though we were both well into adulthood. And in those moments I felt Will's absence in Lily's life like I felt it in my own. *You should have been here, Will*, I told him silently. *It was you she really needed.*

I booked a day's holiday – an outrage, according to Richard. ('You've only been back five weeks. I really don't see why you need to disappear again.') I smiled, bobbed a curtsy in a grateful Irish-dancing-girl manner, and drove home later to find Lily painting one of the spare-room walls a particularly vivid shade of jade green. 'You said you wanted it brightening up,' she said, as I stood with my mouth open. 'Don't worry. I paid for the paint myself.'

'Well,' I pulled off my wig, and unlaced my shoes, 'just make sure you've finished by this evening because I've got the day off tomorrow,' I said, when I had changed into my jeans, 'and I'm going to show you some of the things your dad liked.'

She stopped, dripping jade paint onto the carpet. 'What things?'

'You'll see.'

We spent the day driving, our soundtrack a playlist on Lily's iPod that provided one minute a heart-breaking dirge of love and loss, the next an ear-perforating raging anthem of hatred against all mankind. I mastered the art, while on the motorway, of mentally rising above the noise and focusing on the road, while Lily sat beside me, nodding in time to the beat and occasionally performing an impromptu drum roll on the dashboard. It was good, I thought, that she was enjoying herself. And who needed both working eardrums anyway?

We started off in Stortfold, and took in the places Will and I used to sit and eat, the picnic spots in the fields above the town, his favourite benches around the grounds of the castle, and Lily had the grace to try not to look bored. To be fair, it was quite hard to work up enthusiasm about a series of fields. So I sat down and told her how, when I had first met him, Will had barely left the house, and how, through a mixture of subterfuge and bloody-mindedness, I had set about getting him out again. 'You have to

understand,' I said, 'that your father hated to be dependent on anyone. And us going out didn't just mean that he had to rely on someone else but he had to be seen to be relying on someone else.'

'Even if it was you.'

'Even if it was me.'

She was thoughtful for a moment. 'I'd hate people seeing me like that. I don't even like people seeing me with wet hair.'

We visited the gallery where he had tried to explain to me the difference between 'good' and 'bad' modern art (I still couldn't tell), and she pulled a face at almost everything on its walls. We poked our heads into the wine merchant's where he had made me taste different sorts of wine ('No, Lily, we are *not* doing a wine-tasting today'), then walked to the tattoo shop where he had persuaded me to get my tattoo. She asked if I could lend her the money for one (I nearly wept with relief when the man told her no under-eighteens), then asked to see my little bumble bee. That was one of the few occasions when I felt I'd actually impressed her. She laughed out loud when I told her what he had chosen for himself: a Best Before date stencilled on his chest.

'You have the same awful sense of humour,' I said, and she tried not to look pleased.

It was then that the owner, overhearing our conversation, mentioned that he had a photograph. 'I keep pictures of all of my tattoos,' he said, from under a heavily waxed handlebar moustache. 'I like to have a record. Just remind me of the date?'

We stood there silently as he flicked through his laminated binder. And there it was, from almost two years previously, a close-up of that black and white design, neatly inked onto Will's caramel skin. I stood and stared at the photograph, its familiarity taking my breath away. The little black and white patterned block, the one I had washed with a soft cloth, which I had dried, rubbed sun cream into, rested my face against. I would have reached out to touch it, but Lily got there first, her fingers with their bitten nails tracing gently over the image of her father's skin. 'I think I'll get one,' she said. 'Like his, I mean. When I'm old enough.'

'So how is he?'

Lily and I turned. The tattooist was sitting on his chair, rubbing at a heavily coloured forearm. 'I remember him. We don't get many quadriplegics in here.' He grinned. 'He's a bit of a character, isn't he?'

A lump rose suddenly to my throat.

‘He’s dead,’ said Lily, baldly. ‘My dad. He’s dead.’

The tattooist winced. ‘Sorry, sweetheart. I had no idea.’

‘Can I keep this?’ Lily had started to work the photograph of Will’s tattoo out of its plastic binder.

‘Sure,’ he said hurriedly. ‘If you want it, take it. Here, have the plastic cover as well. Case it rains.’

‘Thank you,’ she said, tucking it neatly under her arm, and as the man stuttered another apology, we walked out of the shop.

We had lunch – an all-day breakfast – silently in a café. Feeling the day’s mood leach away from us, I began to talk. I told Lily what I knew of Will’s romantic history, about his career, that he was the kind of man who made you long for his approval, whether just by doing something that impressed him or making him laugh with some stupid joke. I told her how he was when I met him, and how he had changed, softened, starting to find joy in small things, even if many of those small things seemed to involve making fun of me. ‘Like I wasn’t very adventurous when it came to food. My mum basically has ten set meals which she’s rotated for the past twenty-five years. And none of them involves quinoa. Or lemongrass. Or guacamole. Your dad would eat anything.’

‘And now you do too?’

‘Actually, I still try guacamole every couple of months or so. For him, really.’

‘You don’t like it?’

‘It tastes okay, I suppose. I just can’t get past the fact that it looks like something you blow out of your nose.’

I told her about his previous girlfriend, and how we had gatecrashed her wedding dance, me sitting on Will’s lap as we turned his motorized wheelchair in circles on the dance floor, and she had snorted her drink through her nose. ‘Seriously? Her wedding?’ In the overheated confines of the little café, I conjured her father for her as best I could, and perhaps it was because we were away from all the complications of home, or because her parents were in a different country, or because, just for once, someone was telling her stories about him that were uncomplicated and funny, she laughed, and asked questions, nodding often as if my answers had

confirmed something she already believed. *Yes, yes, he was like this. Yes, maybe I'm like that too.*

And as we talked well into the afternoon, letting our cups of tea cool in front of us, and the weary waitress offered yet again to remove the last of the toast we had taken two hours to eat, I grasped something else: for the first time, I was recalling Will without sadness.

‘What about you?’

‘What about me?’ I put the last crust into my mouth, eyeing the waitress, who looked as if this was her trigger to come back again.

‘What happened to you after Dad died? I mean, you seem to have done a lot more stuff when you were with him – even with him being stuck in a wheelchair – than you do now.’

The bread had turned claggy in my mouth. I struggled to swallow. Eventually, when the mouthful had gone down, I said, ‘I do things. I’ve just been busy. Working. I mean, when you’re on shifts, it’s hard to make plans.’

She raised her eyebrows a fraction, but she didn’t say anything.

‘And my hip is still quite painful. I’m not really up to mountain-climbing yet.’

Lily stirred her tea idly.

‘My life is eventful. I mean, falling off a roof isn’t exactly humdrum. That’s quite a lot of excitement for one year!’

‘But it’s hardly *doing* something, is it?’

We were silent for a moment. I took a breath, trying to quell the sudden buzzing in my ears. The waitress, arriving between us, swept up our empty plates, with a faint air of triumph, and took them to the kitchen.

‘Hey,’ I said. ‘Did I tell you about the time I took your dad to the races?’

With immaculate timing, my car overheated on the motorway, forty miles from London. Lily was surprisingly sanguine about it. In fact, she was curious. ‘I’ve never been in a car that broke down. I didn’t know they even did that any more.’

At this statement my jaw dropped (my dad would regularly pray loudly to his old van, promising premium petrol, regular tyre-pressure checks, endless love, if she would make it back home again). Then she told me her parents traded up their Mercedes every year. Mostly, she added, because of the level of damage done to the leather interior by her half-brothers.

We sat by the side of the motorway, waiting for the breakdown truck to arrive, and feeling the little car judder sporadically as the lorries rumbled past. Eventually, deciding it would be safer for us to be out of the car, we scrambled up the embankment at the side of the motorway and sat on the grass, watching as the afternoon sun lost its heat and slid down the other side of the motorway bridge.

‘So who is Martin?’ I said, when we had exhausted all breakdown-related conversation.

Lily plucked at the grass beside her. ‘Martin Steele? He’s the man I grew up with.’

‘I thought that was Francis.’

‘No. Fuckface only came into the picture when I was seven.’

‘You know, Lily, you might want to stop calling him that.’

She gave me a sideways look. ‘Okay. You’re probably right.’ She lay back on the grass, and smiled sweetly. ‘I’ll call him Penisfeatures instead.’

‘Let’s stick with Fuckface then. So how come you still visit him?’

‘Martin? He’s the only dad I really remember. Mum got together with him while I was small. He’s a musician. Very creative. He used to read stories and stuff and make up songs about me, that kind of thing. I just ...’ She trailed off.

‘What happened? Between him and your mum?’

Lily reached into her bag, pulled out a packet of cigarettes and lit one. She inhaled and let out a long flute of smoke, almost dislocating her jawbone in the process. ‘I came home from school one day with the au pair and Mum just announced that he’d gone. She said they’d agreed he had to go because they weren’t getting on any more.’ She inhaled again.

‘Apparently he wasn’t interested in her personal growth or he didn’t share her vision of the future. Some bullshit. I think she just met Francis and knew Martin was never going to give her what she wanted.’

‘Which was?’

‘Money. And a big house. And the chance to spend her day shopping and bitching to her friends and aligning her *chakras* or whatever. Francis earns a fortune doing private bank things in his private bank with all the other private bankers.’ She turned to me. ‘So, basically, one day Martin was my dad – I mean, I called him Daddy right up until the day he left – and the next he wasn’t. He used to take me to nursery and primary school and everything – and then she decides she’s had enough of him, and I get home

and he's just ... gone. It's her house, so he's gone. Just like that. And I'm not allowed to see him and I'm not even allowed to talk about him because I'm just *dredging things up* and *being difficult*. And obviously she is in *so much pain and emotional distress*.' Here Lily did a scarily good impression of Tanya's voice. 'And when I really did get mad at her, she told me there was no point in getting so upset because he wasn't even my real dad. So *that* was a nice way to find out.'

I stared at her.

'And the next thing, there's Francis turning up at our door, all over-the-top bunches of flowers and so-called family days out, where I'm basically playing gooseberry and sent off with the nannies while they're all over each other at some child-friendly luxury hotel. And then six months later she takes me to Pizza Express. I think it's some treat for me and that maybe Martin is coming back, but she says she and Francis are getting married and it's wonderful and he's going to be the most wonderful daddy to me and I "must love him very much".'

Lily blew a smoke ring up into the sky, watching as it swelled, wavered and evaporated.

'And you didn't.'

'I hated him.' She looked sideways at me. 'You can tell, you know, when someone's just putting up with you. Even if you're little. He never wanted me, only my mother. I can sort of understand it – who wants another man's kid hanging around? So when she had the twins they sent me away to boarding-school. Bang. Job done.'

Her eyes had filled with tears and I wanted to reach out to her, but she had wrapped her arms around her knees and stared straight ahead. We sat there in silence for a few minutes, watching the traffic start to build below us as the sun slid further down the sky.

'I found him, you know.'

I faced her.

'Martin. When I was eleven. I heard my nanny telling another one that she wasn't allowed to tell me he had called round. So I told her she had to tell me where he lived or I'd tell my mum she was stealing. I looked up the address and he lived about fifteen minutes' walk from where we were. Pyecroft Road – do you know it?'

I shook my head. 'Was he pleased to see you?'

She hesitated. ‘So happy. He nearly cried, actually. He said he’d missed me so much, and that it was awful being away from me and that I could come around whenever I wanted. But he had hooked up with someone else and they had a baby. And when you turn up at someone’s house and they have a baby and, like, a proper family of their own, you realize you’re not part of his family any more. You’re a leftover.’

‘I’m sure nobody thought –’

‘Yes, well. Anyway, he’s really lovely and all, but I’ve told him I can’t really see him. It’s too weird. And, you know, like I said to him, *I’m not your real daughter*. He still calls me all the time, though. Stupid, really.’ Lily shook her head furiously. We sat there for a while and then she looked up at the sky. ‘You know the thing that really bugs me?’

I waited.

‘She changed my name when she got married. My own name, and nobody ever even bothered to ask me.’ Her voice cracked a little. ‘I didn’t even want to be a Houghton-Miller.’

‘Oh, Lily.’

She wiped briskly at her face with the palm of her hand, as if embarrassed to be seen crying. She inhaled her cigarette, then ground it out on the grass and sniffed noisily. ‘Mind you, these days Penisfeatures and Mum argue *all* the time. I wouldn’t be surprised if they split up too. If that happens, no doubt we’ll all have to move house again and change names and nobody will be able to say anything because of *her pain* and her need to *move forward emotionally* or whatever. And in two years’ time there will be some other Fuckface and my brothers will be Houghton-Miller-Branson or Ozymandias or Toodlepip or whatever.’ She half laughed. ‘Luckily I’ll be long gone by then. Not that she’ll even notice.’

‘You really believe she thinks that little of you?’

Lily’s head swivelled round, and the look she gave me was both far too wise for her age and utterly heartbreaking. ‘I think she loves me. But she loves herself more. Or how could she do what she does?’



CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Mr Traynor's baby was born the following day. My phone rang at six thirty in the morning and, for a brief, awful moment, I thought something terrible had happened. But it was Mr Traynor, breathless and tearful, announcing, in slightly disbelieving, exclamatory tones, 'It's a girl! Eight pounds one ounce! And she's absolutely perfect!' He told me how beautiful she was, how like Will when he had been a baby, how I simply must come and see her, and then asked me to wake Lily, which I did, and watched her, sleepy and silent as he gave her the news that she had a ... a ... (they took a minute to work it out) an aunt!

'Okay,' she said finally. And then, having listened for a while: 'Yeah ... sure.'

She ended the call and handed the phone back to me. Her eyes met mine, then she turned in her crumpled T-shirt and went back to bed, closing the door firmly behind her.

The well-lubricated health-plan salesmen were, I estimated at ten forty-five, one round off being barred from their flight, and I was wondering whether to point this out when a familiar reflective jacket appeared at the bar.

'No one in need of medical assistance here.' I walked over to him slowly. 'Yet, anyway.'

'I never get tired of that outfit. I have no idea why.'

Sam climbed up on a stool and rested his elbows on the counter. 'The wig is ... interesting.'

I tugged at my Lurex skirt. 'The creation of static electricity is my superpower. Would you like a coffee?'

'Thanks. I can't hang around, though.' He checked his radio and put it back in his jacket pocket.

I made him an Americano, trying not to look as pleased as I felt to see him. 'How did you know where I worked?'

'We had a call-out at gate fourteen. Suspected heart attack. Jake reminded me you worked at the airport and, you know, you weren't exactly hard to track down ...'

The businessmen were briefly muted. Sam was the kind of man, I had noticed, who made other men go a bit quiet. 'Donna's sneaking a look in Duty Free. Handbags.'

'I'm guessing you've seen your patient?'

He grinned. 'No. I was going to ask for directions to gate fourteen after I'd sat down with a coffee.'

'Funny. So did you save his life?'

'I gave her some aspirin, and advised her that drinking four double espressos before ten a.m. was not the best idea. I'm flattered that you have such an exciting view of my working day.'

I couldn't help but laugh. I handed him his coffee. He took a grateful swig. 'So. I was wondering ... You up for another non-date some time soon?'

'With or without an ambulance?'

'Definitely without.'

'Can we discuss problem teenagers?' I found I was twirling a curly lock of nylon-fibre hair with my fingers. For crying out loud. I was playing with my hair and it wasn't even my actual hair. I dropped it.

'We can discuss whatever you like.'

'What did you have in mind?'

His pause was long enough to make me blush. 'Dinner? At mine? Tonight? I promise if it rains I won't make you sit in the dining room.'

'You're on.'

'I'll pick you up at seven thirty.'

He was just gulping down the last of his coffee when Richard appeared. He looked at Sam, then at me. I was still leaning against the bar, a few inches from him. 'Is there a problem?' he said.

'No problem whatsoever,' said Sam. When he stood up, he was a whole head taller than Richard.

A few fleeting thoughts flickered across Richard's face, so transparent that I could see the progression of each one. *Why is this paramedic here? Why is Louisa not doing something? I would like to tell Louisa off for not being obviously busy but this man is too big and there is a dynamic I do not entirely understand and I am a little bit wary of him.* It almost made me laugh out loud.

'So. Tonight.' Sam nodded at me. 'Keep the wig on, yes? I like you flammable.'

One of the businessmen, florid and pleased with himself, leaned back in his chair so that his stomach strained the seams of his shirt. 'Are you going to give us the lecture about alcohol limits now?'

The others laughed.

'No, you go ahead, gentlemen,' Sam said, saluting them. 'I'll just see you in a year or two.'

I watched him head off to Departures, joined by Donna outside the newsagent. When I turned back to the bar Richard was watching me. 'I have to say, Louisa, I don't approve of your conducting your social life in a work setting,' he said.

'Fine. Next time I'll tell him to ignore the heart attack at gate fourteen.'

Richard's jaw tightened. 'And what he said just then. About your wearing your wig later on. That wig is the property of Shamrock and Clover Irish Themed Bars Inc. You are not allowed to wear it in your own time.'

This time I couldn't help it. I started to laugh. 'Really?'

Even he had the grace to flush a little. 'It's company policy. It's classified as uniform.'

'Damn,' I said. 'I guess I'll just have to buy my own Irish-dancing-girl wigs in future. Hey, Richard!' I called, as he walked back into the office, bristling. 'For fairness, does that mean you can't get jiggy with Mrs Percival while wearing your polo-shirt?'

I arrived home to find no sign of Lily, other than a cereal packet on the kitchen counter and, inexplicably, a pile of dirt on the floor in the hallway. I tried her phone, got no response, and wondered how you were ever meant to find a balance between Over-anxious Parent, Normally Concerned Parent, and Tanya Houghton-Miller. And then I jumped into the shower and got ready for my date that absolutely, definitely, wasn't a date.

It rained, the heavens opening shortly after we arrived at Sam's field, and we were both soaked even running the short distance from his bike to the railway carriage. I stood dripping as he closed the door behind me, remembering how unpleasant the sensation of wet socks was.

'Stay there,' he said, brushing the drops from his head with a hand. 'You can't sit around in those wet clothes.'

'This is like the opening to a really bad porn movie,' I said. He stood very still and I realized I had actually said the words out loud. I gave him a

smile that went a bit wonky.

‘Okay,’ he said, raising his eyebrows.

He disappeared into the back of the carriage and emerged a minute later with a jumper and what looked like some jogging bottoms.

‘Jake’s joggers. Freshly washed. Possibly not very porn star, though.’ He handed them to me. ‘My room’s back there if you want to get changed, or the bathroom’s through that door, if you’d prefer.’

I walked into his bedroom and closed the door behind me. Above my head the rain beat noisily on the carriage roof, obscuring the windows with a never-ending stream of water. I wondered about drawing the curtains, then remembered there was nobody to see me, other than the hens, which were huddling out of the wet, grumpily shaking drops from their feathers. I pulled off my soaked top and jeans and dried myself with the towel he’d placed with the clothes. For fun, I flashed the hens through the window, something, I observed afterwards, Lily might do. They didn’t look impressed. I held the towel to my face and sniffed it guiltily, like someone inhaling a forbidden drug. It was freshly laundered but somehow still managed to smell irrevocably male. I hadn’t breathed in a scent like it since Will. It made me feel briefly unbalanced and I put it down.

The double bed filled most of the floor space. A narrow cupboard opposite acted as a wardrobe, and two pairs of work boots were neatly stacked in the corner. There was a book on the nightstand and beside it a photograph of Sam with a smiling woman, whose blonde hair was tied up in a messy knot. She had her arm around his shoulders and was grinning at the camera. She was not supermodel beautiful, but there was something compelling about her smile. She looked like the kind of woman who would have laughed a lot. She looked like a feminine version of Jake. I felt suddenly crushingly sad for him, and had to look away before I made myself sad, too. Sometimes I felt as if we were all wading around in grief, reluctant to admit to others how far we were waving or drowning. I wondered fleetingly whether Sam’s reluctance to talk about his wife mirrored my own, the knowledge that the moment you opened the box, let out even a whisper of your sadness, it would mushroom into a cloud that overwhelmed all other conversation.

I checked myself, took a breath. ‘Just have a nice evening,’ I murmured, recalling the words of the Moving On Circle. *Allow yourself moments of happiness.*

I wiped the mascara smudges from under my eyes, observing in the small mirror that little could be done for my hair. Then I pulled Sam's oversized sweater over my head, trying to ignore the weird intimacy that came from wearing a man's clothes, pulled on Jake's joggers and gazed at my reflection.

What do you think, Will? Just a nice evening. It doesn't have to mean anything, right?

Sam grinned as I emerged, rolling up the sleeves of his jumper. 'You look about twelve.'

I went into the bathroom, wrung out my jeans, shirt and socks in the sink, then hung them over the shower curtain.

'What's cooking?'

'Well, I was going to do a salad, but it's not really salad weather any more. So I'm improvising.'

He had set a pot of water boiling on the stove, where it had fogged the windows. 'You eat pasta, right?'

'I eat anything.'

'Excellent.'

He opened a bottle of wine and poured me a glass, motioning me to the bench seat. In front of me the little table had been laid for two, and I felt a faint frisson at the sight. It was okay just to enjoy a moment, a small pleasure. I had been out dancing. I had flashed some hens. And now I was going to enjoy spending an evening with a man who wanted to cook me dinner. It was all progress, of sorts.

Perhaps Sam detected something of this internal struggle because he waited until I took my first sip, then said, while stirring something on the hob, 'Was that the boss you were talking about? That man today?'

The wine was delicious. I took another sip. I hadn't dared drink while Lily had been with me: I might have let my guard down. 'Yup.'

'I know the type. If it's any consolation, within five years he'll either have a stomach ulcer or enough hypertension to cause erectile dysfunction.'

I laughed. 'Both those thoughts are oddly comforting.'

Finally he sat down, presenting me with a steaming bowl of pasta. 'Cheers,' he said, raising a glass of water. 'And now tell me what's going on with this long-lost girl of yours.'

Oh, but it was such a relief to have someone to talk to. I was so unused to people who actually listened – as opposed to those, at the bar, who only wanted to hear the sound of their own voices – that talking to Sam was a revelation. He didn't interrupt, or tell me what he thought, or what I should do. He listened, and nodded, and topped up my wine and said, finally, when it was long dark outside, 'It's quite a responsibility you've taken on.'

I leaned back on the bench and put my feet up. 'I don't feel like I have a choice. I keep asking myself what you said: what would Will want me to do?' I took another sip. 'It's harder than I'd imagined, though. I thought I'd just drop her in to meet her grandmother and grandfather and everyone would be delighted and it would be a happy ending, like those reunion programmes on television.'

He studied his hands. I studied him.

'You think I'm mad getting involved.'

'No. Too many people follow their own happiness without a thought for the damage they leave in their wake. You wouldn't believe the kids I pick up at the weekends, drunk, drugged, off their heads, whatever. The parents are wrapped up in their own stuff, or have disappeared completely, so they exist in a vacuum, and they make bad choices.'

'Is it worse than it used to be?'

'Who knows? I only know I see all these messed up kids. And that the hospital's young persons' psych has a waiting list as long as your arm.' He smiled wryly. 'Hold that soapbox. I need to shut the birds up for the night.'

I wanted to ask him then how someone so apparently wise could be so careless of his own son's feelings. I wanted to ask if he knew how unhappy Jake was. But it seemed a bit too confrontational, given the way he was talking, and the fact that he had just cooked me a very nice supper ... I was distracted by the sight of the hens popping one at a time into their coop, and then he came back, bringing with him the faint scents of outside, and the cooler air, and the moment passed.

He poured more wine, and I drank it. I let myself take pleasure in the snugness of the little railway carriage, and the sensation of a properly full belly, and I listened to Sam talk. He told of nights holding the hands of elderly people who didn't want to make a fuss, and of management targets that left them all demoralized, feeling they weren't doing the job they'd been trained for. I listened, losing myself in a world far from my own,

watching his hands draw animated circles in the air, his rueful smile when he felt he was taking himself too seriously. I watched his hands.

I coloured slightly as I realized where my thoughts were headed, and took another swig of my wine to hide it. 'Where's Jake tonight?'

'Barely seen him. At his girlfriend's, I think.' He looked rueful. 'She has this *Waltons*-style family, about a billion brothers and sisters and a mum who's home all day. He likes hanging out there.' He took another sip of his water. 'So where's Lily?'

'Don't know. I texted her twice but she hasn't bothered to reply.'

The sheer presence of him. It was like he was twice as large and twice as vivid as other men. My thoughts kept drifting, pulled on tides towards his eyes, which narrowed slightly as he listened, as if he were trying to ensure he had understood me perfectly ... The faint hint of stubble on his jaw, the shape of his shoulder under the soft wool of his jumper. My gaze kept sliding downwards to his hands, resting on the table, fingers absently tapping on the surface. Such capable hands. I remembered the tenderness with which he had cradled my head, the way I had held on to him in the ambulance as if he were the only thing anchoring me. He looked at me and smiled, a gentle enquiry in it, and something in me turned molten. Would it be so bad, as long as my eyes were open?

'You want a coffee, Louisa?'

He had this way of looking at me. I shook my head.

'Do you want –'

Before I could think about it, I leaned across the little table, reached for the back of his head and kissed him. He hesitated for just a moment then shifted forward, and kissed me back. At some point I think someone knocked over a wineglass but I couldn't stop. I wanted to kiss him for ever. I blocked out all thoughts about what this was, what it might mean, what further mess I might create for myself. *C'mon, live*, I told myself. And I kissed him until reason seeped out through my pores and I became a living pulse, alive only to what I wanted to do to him.

He pulled back first, slightly dazed. 'Louisa –'

A piece of cutlery clattered to the floor. I stood and he stood, and pulled me to him. And suddenly we were crashing around the little railway carriage, all hands and lips and, oh God, the scent and taste and feel of him. It was like tiny fireworks going off all over me, bits of me I'd thought dead reigniting into life. He picked me up and I wrapped myself around him, all

bulk and strength and muscle. I kissed his face, his ear, my fingers in his soft dark hair. And then he stood me back down and we were inches apart, his eyes on me, his expression a silent question.

I was breathing hard. 'I haven't taken my clothes off in front of anyone since ... the accident,' I said.

'It's okay. I'm medically trained.'

'I'm serious. I'm a bit of a mess.' I felt suddenly, oddly tearful.

'You want me to make you feel better?'

'That's the cheesiest line I've –'

He lifted his shirt, revealing a two-inch purple scar across his stomach. 'There. Stabbed by an Australian with mental-health issues four years ago. Here.' He turned to reveal a huge green and yellow bruise across his lower back. 'Got a kicking from a drunk last Saturday. Woman.' He held out his hand. 'Broken finger. Caught in a gurney while lifting an overweight patient. And, oh, yes – here.' He showed me his hip, along which ran a short, silvery, jagged line with the stitch marks just about visible. 'Puncture wound, unknown provenance, nightclub fight in Hackney Road last year. The cops never worked out who did it.'

I looked at the solidity of him, at the smattering of scars. 'What's that one?' I said, gently touching a smaller scar on the side of his stomach. His skin was hot under his shirt.

'That? Oh. Appendix. I was nine.'

I gazed at his torso, then his face. Then holding his gaze, I lifted the jumper slowly over my head. I shivered involuntarily, whether from the cooler air or nerves I couldn't tell. He moved closer, so close that he was inches from me, and ran his finger gently along the line of my hip. 'I remember this. I remember I could feel the break here.' He ran it gently across my bare stomach, so that my muscles contracted. 'And there. You had this bloom of purple on your skin. I was afraid it was organ damage.' He placed his palm against it. It was warm, and my breath caught.

'I never thought the words "organ damage" could sound sexy before.'

'Oh, I haven't started yet.'

He walked me slowly backwards towards his bed. I sat down, my eyes on his, and he knelt, running his hands down my legs. 'And then there was that.' He picked up my right foot, with the vivid red scar across the top. He traced the line of it tenderly with his thumb. 'There. Broken. Soft tissue damage. That one would have hurt.'

‘You remember a lot.’

‘Most people I couldn’t recognize in the street a day later. But you, Louisa, well, you kind of stuck.’ He dipped his head and kissed the top of my foot, then slowly ran his hands up my leg and placed them either side of me, so that he was above me, supporting his own weight. ‘Nothing hurts now, right?’

I shook my head, mute. I didn’t care any more. I didn’t care if he was a compulsive shagger or playing games. I was so overwhelmed with wanting him I didn’t actually care if he broke my other hip.

He moved across me, inch by inch, like a tide, and I lay back so that I was flat on the bed. With each movement my breath became shallower until it was all I could hear in the silence. He gazed down at me, then closed his eyes and kissed me, slowly and tenderly. He kissed me and let his weight fall onto me just far enough that I felt the delicious powerlessness of lust, the hardness of a body against mine. We kissed, his lips on my neck, his skin against my skin, until I was giddy with it, until I was arching involuntarily against him, my legs wrapped around him.

‘Oh, God,’ I said, breathlessly, when we came up for air. ‘I wish you weren’t so totally wrong for me.’

His eyebrows shot up. ‘That’s – uh – seductive.’

‘You’re not going to cry afterwards, are you?’

He blinked. ‘Er ... no.’

‘And just so you know, I’m not some weird obsessive. I’m not going to follow you around afterwards. Or ask Jake to tell me things about you while you’re in the shower.’

‘That’s ... that’s good to know.’

And once we had established the ground rules, I flipped over so that I was on top of him and kissed him until I had forgotten everything we had just talked about.

An hour and a half later I was lying on my back and gazing dazedly up at the low ceiling. My skin buzzed, my bones hummed, I ached in places I hadn’t known could ache, yet I was possessed with an extraordinary sense of peace, as if the core of me had simply melted and settled into a new shape. I wasn’t sure I would ever get up again.

You never know what will happen when you fall from a great height.

That surely wasn't me. I coloured as I thought back to even twenty minutes previously. Did I really – and did I ... Memories chased themselves in hot circles. I had never had sex like that. Not in seven years with Patrick. It was like comparing a cheese sandwich with ... what? The most incredible *haute cuisine*? An enormous steak? I giggled involuntarily and clamped a hand over my mouth. I felt utterly unlike myself.

Sam had dozed off beside me and I turned my head to look at him. *Oh, my God*, I thought, marvelling at the planes of his face, his lips – it was impossible to look at him and not want to touch him. I wondered whether I should move my face a little bit closer and my hand so that I could –

‘Hey,’ he said softly, his eyes slanted with sleep.

... and then it hit me.

Oh, God. I've become one of them.

We dressed in near silence. Sam offered to make me tea, but I said I should probably get back as I needed to check whether Lily was home. ‘Her family being on holiday and all.’ I tugged my fingers through my now-matted hair.

‘Sure. Oh. You want to go *now*?’

‘Yes ... please.’

I fetched my clothes from the bathroom, feeling self-conscious and suddenly sober. I couldn't let him see how unbalanced I was. Every bit of me was focused on trying to re-distance myself and it made me awkward. When I came out he was dressed and tidying up the last of the supper things. I tried not to look at him. It was easier that way.

‘Could I borrow these clothes to go home? Mine are still damp.’

‘Sure. Just ... whatever.’ He rifled in a drawer and held out a plastic bag.

I took it and we stood there in the dark space. ‘It was a ... nice evening.’

“Nice”. He looked at me as if he were trying to work something out.

‘Okay.’

As we rode through the damp night, I tried not to rest my cheek against his back. He insisted on lending me a leather jacket, although I had insisted I'd be fine. A few miles in, the air was cold and I was glad of it. We made it back to my flat by a quarter past eleven, although I had to check when I saw the clock. I felt like I'd lived several lifetimes since he'd picked me up.

I dismounted from the bike and started to take off his jacket. But he pushed down his kickstand with his heel. ‘It's late. Let me at least see you

upstairs.'

I hesitated. 'Okay. If you wait I can give you back your clothes.'

I tried to sound insouciant. He gave a shrug and followed me to the door.

We emerged from the stairwell to the sound of music thumping down the hallway. I knew immediately where it was coming from. I limped briskly down the corridor, paused outside the flat and opened the door slowly. Lily stood in the middle of the hall, cigarette in one hand, a glass of wine in the other. She was wearing a yellow flowered dress I had bought from a vintage boutique, back in the days when I cared about what I wore. I stared – and it's possible that when I registered what else she was wearing I stumbled: I felt Sam reach for my arm.

'Nice leathers, Louisa!'

Lily pointed her toe. She was wearing my green glittery shoes. 'Why don't you wear these? You have all these crazy outfits yet you just wear, like, jeans and T-shirts and stuff every day. Sooo boring!'

She walked back into my room and emerged a minute later, holding up a gold seventies lamé jumpsuit I used to pair with brown boots. 'I mean, look at this! I have total and utter jumpsuit envy right now.'

'Get them off,' I said, when I could speak.

'What?'

'Those tights. Get them off.' My voice emerged strangled and unrecognizable.

Lily looked down at the black and yellow tights. 'No, seriously though, you have some proper vintage gear in there. Biba, DVF. That purple Chanel type thing. Do you know what this stuff is worth?'

'Get them *off*.'

Perhaps registering my sudden rigidity, Sam began to propel me forwards. 'Look, why don't we go through to the living room and –'

'I'm not moving until she takes those tights off.'

Lily pulled a face.

'Jesus. No need to have a baby about it.'

I watched, vibrating with anger, as Lily began to peel down my bumble-bee tights, kicking at them when they wouldn't slide off her feet.

'Don't rip them!'

'It's just a pair of tights.'

'They are *not* just a pair of tights. They were ... a gift.'

‘Still a pair of tights,’ she muttered.

She finally got them off, leaving them in a black and yellow heap on the floor. In the other room I could hear the clatter of hangers as the rest of my clothes were presumably being hastily replaced.

A moment later, Lily appeared in the living room. In her bra and knickers. She waited until she could be sure she had our attention, then pulled a short dress slowly and ostentatiously over her head, wiggling as it went over her slim, pale hips. Then she smiled at me sweetly. ‘I’m going clubbing. Don’t wait up. Nice to see you again, Mr –’

‘Fielding,’ said Sam.

‘Mr Fielding.’ She smiled at me. A smile that wasn’t a smile at all. And with a slam of the door, she was gone.

I let out a shaky breath, then walked over and retrieved the tights. I sat down on the sofa and straightened them out, smoothing them until I could be sure there were no snags or cigarette burns.

Sam sat down beside me. ‘You okay?’ he said.

‘I’m know you must think I’m crazy,’ I said eventually, ‘but they were a –’

‘You don’t have to explain.’

‘I was a different person. They meant that – I was – he gave ...’ My voice was choked.

We sat there in the silent flat. I knew I should say something but I was lost for words, and there was an enormous lump in my throat.

I took Sam’s jacket off, and held it out to him. ‘It’s fine,’ I said. ‘You don’t have to stay.’

I felt his eyes on me but didn’t raise mine from the floor.

‘I’ll leave you to it then.’

And then, before I could say anything else, he was gone.



CHAPTER FOURTEEN

I was late to the Moving On Circle that week. Having left me a coffee, perhaps in lieu of an apology, Lily had subsequently spilt green paint on the hall floor, left a tub of ice cream to melt on the side in the kitchen, taken my door keys, with my car key attached, because she couldn't find her own, and borrowed my wig for a night out without asking. I had recovered it from the floor of her bedroom. When I put it on, I looked as if an Old English Sheepdog were doing something unmentionable to my head.

By the time I reached the church hall, everyone else was sitting down. Natasha moved obligingly so that I could take the plastic chair beside her.

'Tonight we're talking about signs that we might be moving on,' said Marc, who was holding a mug of tea. 'These don't have to be huge things – new relationships, or throwing out clothes or whatever. Just small things that make us see there may be a way through grief. It's surprising how many of these signs go unnoticed, or we refuse to acknowledge them because we feel guilty for moving forward.'

'I joined a dating website,' said Fred. 'It's called May to December.'

There was a low hum of surprise and approval.

'That's very encouraging, Fred.' Marc sipped his tea. 'What are you hoping to get from it? Some company? I remember you said you particularly missed having someone to go for a walk with on Sunday afternoons. Down by the duck pond, wasn't it, where you and your wife used to go?'

'Oh, no. It's for internet sex.'

Marc spluttered. There was a brief pause while someone handed him a tissue to mop the tea off his trousers.

'Internet sex. That's what they're all doing, isn't it? I've joined three sites.' Fred held up his hand, counting them off on his fingers. 'May to December, that's for young women who like older men, Sugar-Papas, for young women who like older men with money, and ... um ... Hot Studs.' He paused. 'They weren't specific.'

There was a short silence.

'It's nice to be optimistic, Fred,' said Natasha.

‘How about you, Louisa?’

‘Um ...’ I hesitated, given Jake was in front of me, and then thought, *What the hell?* ‘I actually went on a date this weekend.’

There was a low *woo-hoo!* from other members of the group. I looked down a little sheepishly. I couldn’t even think about that night without colour seeping into my face.

‘And how did it go?’

‘It was ... surprising.’

‘She shagged someone. She totally shagged someone,’ said Natasha.

‘She’s got that glow,’ said William.

‘Did he have moves?’ said Fred. ‘Got any tips?’

‘And you managed to not think about Bill too much?’

‘Not enough to stop me ... I just felt I wanted to do something that ...’ I shrugged ‘... I just wanted to feel alive.’

There was a murmur of agreement at that word. It was what we all wanted, ultimately, to be freed from our grief. To be released from this underworld of the dead, half our hearts lost underground, or trapped in little porcelain urns. It felt good to have something positive to say for once.

Marc nodded encouragingly. ‘I think it sounds very healthy.’

I listened to Sunil say that he had started to listen to music again, and Natasha talk about how she had moved some of the pictures of her husband from the living room to her bedroom ‘so that I don’t end up talking about him every single time somebody comes round’. Daphne had stopped sniffing her husband’s shirts, furtively, in his wardrobe. ‘If I’m honest, they didn’t really smell of him any more anyway. I think it was just a habit I’d got into.’

‘And you, Jake?’

He still looked miserable. ‘I go out more, I s’pose.’

‘Have you talked to your father about your feelings?’

‘No.’

I tried not to look at him as he spoke. I felt oddly raw, not knowing what he knew.

‘I think he likes someone, though.’

‘More shagging?’ said Fred.

‘No, I mean as in properly likes someone.’

I could feel myself blushing. I tried rubbing at an invisible mark on my shoe in an attempt to hide my face.

‘What makes you think that, Jake?’

‘He started talking about her over breakfast the other day. He was saying that he thought he was going to stop the whole picking-up-random-women thing. That he had met someone and he might want to make a go of it with her.’

I was glowing like a beacon. I couldn’t believe that nobody else in the room was able to see it.

‘So do you think he’s finally worked out that rebound relationships are not the way forward? Perhaps he just needed a few partners before he fell in love with someone again.’

‘He’s done a lot of rebounding,’ said William. ‘Actual Space Hopper levels of rebounding.’

‘Jake? How does that make you feel?’ said Marc.

‘A bit weird. I mean, I miss my mum, but I do think it’s probably good that he’s moving on.’

I tried to imagine what Sam had said. Had he mentioned me by name? I could picture the two of them in the kitchen of the little railway carriage, having this earnest discussion over tea and toast. My cheeks were aflame. I wasn’t sure I wanted Sam to make assumptions about us so early on. I should have been clearer that it hadn’t meant we were in a relationship. It was too soon. And too soon to have Jake discussing us in public.

‘And have you met the woman?’ said Natasha. ‘Do you like her?’

Jake ducked his head. ‘Yeah. That was the really crap bit.’

I glanced up.

‘He asked her round for brunch on Sunday, and she was a total nightmare. She wore this super-tight top and she kept putting her arm around me like she knew me, and laughing too loudly, and then when my dad was in the garden she would look at me with these big round eyes and go, “And how *are* you?” with this really annoying head tilt.’

‘Oh, the *head tilt*,’ said William, and there was a low murmur of agreement. Everyone knew the head tilt.

‘And when Dad was there she just giggled and flicked her hair all the time, like she was trying to be a teenager even though she was plainly at *least* thirty.’ He wrinkled his nose in disgust.

‘Thirty!’ said Daphne, her gaze sliding sideways. ‘Imagine!’

‘I actually preferred the one who used to quiz me about what he was up to. At least she didn’t pretend to be my best friend.’

I could barely hear the rest of what he said. A distant ringing had begun in my ears, drowning out all sound. How could I have been so stupid? I suddenly recalled Jake's eye roll the first time he had watched Sam chatting me up. There was my warning, right there, and I had been stupid enough to ignore it.

I felt hot and shaky. I couldn't stay there. I couldn't listen to any more. 'Um ... I just remembered. I have an appointment,' I mumbled, gathering up my bag and bolting from my seat. 'Sorry.'

'Everything all right, Louisa?' said Marc.

'Totally fine. Got to dash.' I ran for the door, my fake smile plastered on my face so tightly that it was painful.

He was there. Of course he was. He had just pulled up on the bike in the car park and was removing his helmet. I emerged from the church hall and stopped at the top of the steps, wondering if there was any way I could get to my car without passing him, but it was hopeless. The physical part of my brain registered the shape of him before the remaining synapses caught up: a flush of pleasure, the flash of memory of how his hands had felt on me. And then that blazing anger, the blood pulse of humiliation.

'Hey,' he said, as he caught sight of me, his smile easy, his eyes crinkling with pleasure. The fucking charmer.

I slowed my step just long enough for him to register the hurt on my face. I didn't care. I felt like Lily suddenly. I was not going to internalize this. This had not been *me* climbing out of one person's bed and straight into another.

'Nice job, you utter, utter wanker,' I spat, then ran past him to my car before the choke in my voice could turn into an actual sob.

The week, as if in response to some unheard malign dog whistle, actually managed to go downhill from there. Richard grew ever pickier, complained that we didn't smile enough and that our lack of 'cheery bantz' with the customers was sending travellers along the way to the Wings in the Air Bar and Grill. The weather turned, sending the skies a gunmetal grey and delaying flights with tropical rainstorms, so the airport was filled with bad-tempered passengers, and then, with immaculate timing, the baggage handlers went on strike. 'What can you expect? Mercury is in retrograde,'

said Vera, savagely, and growled at a customer who asked for less froth on his cappuccino.

At home, Lily arrived under her own dark cloud. She sat in my living room, glued to her mobile phone, but whatever was on it seemed to give her no pleasure. She would stare out of the window, stony-faced, as her father had, as if she were just as trapped as he had been. I had tried to explain that Will had given me the yellow and black tights, that their significance was not in the colour or the quality, but that they –

‘Yeah, yeah, tights. Whatever,’ she said.

For three nights I barely slept. I stared at my ceiling, fired by a stone-cold fury that lodged in my chest and refused to go away. I was so angry with Sam. But I was angrier with myself. He texted twice, a maddeningly *faux*-innocent ‘??’, to which I didn’t trust myself to respond. I had done the classic thing women do of ignoring everything a man says or does, preferring to listen to their own insistent drumbeat: *It will be different with me*. I had kissed him. I had made the whole thing happen. So I had only myself to blame.

I tried to tell myself I’d probably had a lucky escape. I told myself, with little internal exclamation marks, that it was better to find out now, rather than in six months’ time! I tried to view it through Marc’s eyes: it was good to have moved on! I could chalk this one up to experience! At least the sex was good! And then the stupid hot tears would leak out of my stupid eyes and I would screw them up and tell myself that this was what you got for letting anyone close.

Depression, we had learned in the group, loves a vacuum. Far better to be doing, or at least planning. Sometimes the illusion of happiness could inadvertently create it. Sick of coming home to find Lily prostrate on my sofa every evening, and just as sick of trying not to look irritated by it, on Friday night I told her that we would go to see Mrs Traynor the following day.

‘But you said she didn’t reply to your letter.’

‘Maybe she didn’t get it. Whatever. At some point Mr Traynor is going to tell his family about you, so we might as well go and see her before that happens.’

She didn’t say anything. I took that as a tacit sign of agreement, and left her to it.

That night I found myself going through the clothes that Lily had pulled out of the packing case, the clothes I had ignored since leaving England for Paris two years previously. There had been no point in wearing them. I hadn't felt like that person since Will died.

Now, though, it felt important to put something on that was neither jeans nor a green Irish-dancing-girl outfit. I found a navy mini-dress I had once loved that seemed sober enough for a slightly formal visit, ironed it and put it to one side. I told Lily we would be leaving at nine the following morning and went to bed, wondering at how exhausting it was to live in a home with someone who believed that any speech more than a grunt was simply a superhuman step too far.

Ten minutes after I had closed my door, a handwritten note was pushed under it.

Dear Louisa

I'm sorry I borrowed your clothes. And thanks for everything. I know I'm a pain sometimes.

Sorry.

Lily xxx

PS You should totally wear those clothes though. They are WAY better than that stuff you wear.

I opened the door, and Lily was standing there, unsmiling. She stepped forwards and gave me a brief, emphatic hug, so tight that my ribs hurt. Then she turned and, without a word, disappeared back into the living room.

The day dawned brighter, and our mood lifted a little with it. We drove several hours to a tiny village in Oxfordshire, a place of walled gardens and mustard-tinted, sun-baked stone walls. I prattled on during the journey, mostly to hide my nerves about seeing Mrs Traynor again. The hardest thing about talking to teenagers, I had discovered, was that whatever you said inevitably came across like someone's elderly aunt at a wedding.

'So what things do you like doing? When you're not at school?'

She shrugged.

'What do you think you might want to do after you leave?'

She gave me the look.

'You must have had hobbies growing up?'

She reeled off a dizzying list: show-jumping, lacrosse, hockey, piano (grade five), cross-country running, county-level tennis.

'All that? And you didn't want to keep any of it up?'

She sniffed and shrugged simultaneously, then put her feet up on the dashboard, as if the conversation were closed.

‘Your father loved to travel,’ I remarked, a few miles on.

‘You said.’

‘He once told me he’d been everywhere except North Korea. And Disneyland. He could tell stories about places I’d never even heard of.’

‘People my age don’t go on adventures. There’s nowhere left to discover. And people who backpack in their gap year are unbelievably tedious. Always yakking on about some bar they discovered on Ko Phang Yan, or how they scored amazing drugs in the Burmese rainforest.’

‘You don’t have to backpack.’

‘Yeah, but once you’ve seen the inside of one Mandarin Oriental you’ve seen them all.’ She yawned. ‘I went to school near here once,’ she observed later, peering out of the window. ‘It was the only school I actually liked.’ She paused. ‘I had a friend called Holly.’

‘What happened?’

‘Mum got obsessed with the idea that it wasn’t the *right sort of school*. She said they weren’t far enough up the league tables or something. It was just some little boarding-school. Not academic. So they moved me. After that I couldn’t be arsed making friends. What’s the point if they’re just going to move you on again?’

‘Did you keep in touch with Holly?’

‘Not really. There’s no point when you can’t actually see each other.’

I had a vague memory of the intensity of teenage female relationships, more of a passion than a normal friendship. ‘What do you think you’ll do? I mean if you really aren’t going to go back to school.’

‘I don’t like thinking ahead.’

‘But you’re going to have to think about something, Lily.’

She closed her eyes for a minute, then put her feet down and peeled some purple varnish off her thumbnail. ‘I don’t know, Louisa. Perhaps I’ll just follow your amazing example and do all the exciting things that you do.’

I took three deep breaths, just to prevent myself stopping the car on the motorway. Nerves, I told myself. It was just her nerves. And then, to annoy her, I turned on Radio 2 really loudly and kept it there the rest of the way.

We found Four Acres Lane with help from a local dog-walker, and pulled up outside Fox’s Cottage, a modest white-rendered building with a thatched

roof. Outside, scarlet roses tumbled around an iron arch at the start of the garden path, and delicately coloured blooms fought for space in neatly tended beds. A small hatchback sat in the drive.

‘She’s gone down in the world,’ said Lily, peering out.

‘It’s pretty.’

‘It’s a shoebox.’

I sat, listening to the engine tick down. ‘Listen, Lily. Before we go in. Just don’t expect too much,’ I said. ‘Mrs Traynor’s sort of formal. She takes refuge in manners. She’ll probably speak to you like she’s a teacher. I mean, I don’t think she’ll hug you, like Mr Traynor did.’

‘My grandfather is a hypocrite.’ Lily sniffed. ‘He makes out like you’re the greatest thing ever, but really he’s just pussy-whipped.’

‘And please don’t use the term “pussy-whipped”.’

‘There’s no point pretending to be someone I’m not,’ Lily said sulkily.

We sat there for a while. I realized that neither of us wanted to be the one to walk up to the door. ‘Shall I try to call her one more time?’ I said, holding up my phone. I’d tried twice that morning but it had gone straight to voicemail.

‘Don’t tell her straight away,’ she said suddenly. ‘Who I am, I mean. I just ... I just want to see who she is. Before we tell her.’

‘Sure,’ I said, softening. And before I could say anything else, Lily was out of the car and striding up towards the front gate, her hands bunched into fists, like a boxer about to enter a ring.

Mrs Traynor had gone grey. Her hair, which had been tinted dark brown, was now white and short, making her look much older than she actually was, or like someone recently recovered from a serious illness. She was probably a stone lighter than when I had last seen her, and there were liver-coloured hollows under her eyes. She looked at Lily with a confusion that told me she didn’t expect any visitors, at any time. And then she saw me, and her eyes widened. ‘Louisa?’

‘Hello, Mrs Traynor.’ I stepped forward and held out a hand. ‘We were in the area. I don’t know if you got my letter. I just thought I’d stop by and say hello ...’

My voice – false and unnaturally cheery – tailed away. The last time she had seen me was when I helped clear her dead son’s room; the time before

that at his last breath. I watched her relive both those facts now. 'We were just admiring your garden.'

'David Austin roses,' said Lily.

Mrs Traynor looked at her as if noticing her for the first time. Her smile was slight and wavering. 'Yes. Yes, they are. How clever of you. It's – I'm very sorry. I don't have many visitors. What did you say your name was?'

'This is Lily,' I said, and watched as Lily took Mrs Traynor's hand and shook it, studying her intently as she did so.

We stood there on her front step for a moment, and finally, as if she thought she had no alternative, Mrs Traynor turned and pushed the door open. 'I suppose you'd better come in.'

The cottage was tiny, its ceilings so low that even I had to duck when moving from the hall to the kitchen. I waited as Mrs Traynor made tea, watching Lily walk restlessly around the tiny living room, navigating her way among the few bits of highly polished antique furniture that I remembered from my days in Granta House, picking things up and putting them down again.

'And ... how have you been?'

Mrs Traynor's voice was flat, as if it were not a question she was really seeking an answer to.

'Oh, quite well, thank you.'

Long silence.

'It's a lovely village.'

'Yes. Well. I couldn't really stay in Stortfold ...' She poured boiling water into the teapot and I couldn't help but be reminded of Della, moving heavily around Mrs Traynor's old kitchen.

'Do you know many people in the area?'

'No.' She said it as if that might have been the sole reason for her moving there. 'Would you mind taking the milk jug? I can't fit everything on this tray.'

There followed a painfully laboured half-hour of conversation. Mrs Traynor, a woman infused with the instinctive upper-middle-class skill of being all over any social situation, had apparently lost the ability to communicate. She seemed only half with us when I spoke. She asked a question, then asked it again ten minutes later, as if she had failed to register the answer. I wondered about the use of anti-depressants. Lily watched her

surreptitiously, her thoughts ticking across her face, and I sat between them, my stomach in an increasingly tight knot, waiting for something to happen.

I chattered on into the silence, talking of my awful job, things I'd done in France, the fact that my parents were well, thank you – anything to end the awful, oppressive stillness that crept across the little room whenever I stopped. But Mrs Traynor's grief hung over the little house, like a fog. If Mr Traynor had seemed exhausted by sadness, Mrs Traynor appeared to be swallowed by it. There was almost nothing left of the brisk, proud woman I had known.

'What brings you to this area?' she said, finally.

'Um ... just visiting friends,' I said.

'How do you two know each other?'

'I ... knew Lily's father.'

'How nice,' said Mrs Traynor, and we smiled awkwardly. I watched Lily, waiting for her to say something, but she had frozen, as if she, too, were overwhelmed, faced with the reality of this woman's pain.

We drank a second cup of tea, and remarked upon her beautiful garden for the third, possibly fourth time, and I fought the sensation that our enduring presence was requiring a sort of superhuman effort on her behalf. She didn't want us there. She was far too polite to say so, but it was obvious that she really just wanted to be on her own. It was in every gesture – every forced smile, every attempt to stay on top of the conversation. I suspected that the moment we were gone she would simply retreat into a chair and stay there, or shuffle upstairs and curl up in her bed.

And then I noticed it: the complete absence of photographs. Where Granta House had been filled with silver-framed pictures of her children, of their family, ponies, skiing holidays, distant grandparents, this cottage was bare. A small bronze of a horse, a watercolour of some hyacinths, but no people. I found myself shifting in my seat, wondering if I had simply missed them, gathered on some occasional table or windowsill. But no: the cottage was brutally impersonal. I thought of my own flat, my utter failure to personalize it or allow myself to turn it into any kind of a home. And I felt suddenly leaden, and desperately sad.

What have you done to us all, Will?

'It's probably time to go, Louisa,' said Lily, looking pointedly at the clock. 'You did say we wouldn't want to hit traffic.'

I gazed at her. 'But –'

‘You said we shouldn’t stay too long.’ Her voice was high and clear.

‘Oh. Yes. Traffic can be very tedious.’ Mrs Traynor began to rise from her chair.

I was glaring at Lily, about to protest again, when the phone rang. Mrs Traynor flinched, as if the sound were now unfamiliar. She looked at each of us, as if wondering whether to answer it, and then, perhaps realizing she couldn’t ignore it while we were there, she excused herself and walked through to the other room, where we heard her answer.

‘What are you doing?’ I said.

‘It just feels all wrong,’ said Lily, miserably.

‘But we can’t go without telling her.’

‘I just can’t do this today. It’s all ...’

‘I know it’s scary. But look at her, Lily. I really think it might help her if you told her. Don’t you?’

Lily’s eyes widened.

‘Tell me what?’

My head swivelled. Mrs Traynor was standing motionless by the door to the little hallway. ‘What is it you need to tell me?’

Lily looked at me, then back towards Mrs Traynor. I felt time slow around us. She swallowed, then lifted her chin a little. ‘That I’m your granddaughter.’

A brief silence.

‘My ... what?’

‘I’m Will Traynor’s daughter.’

Her words echoed into the little room. Mrs Traynor’s gaze slid towards mine, as if to check that this was in fact some insane joke.

‘But ... you can’t be.’

Lily recoiled.

‘Mrs Traynor, I know this must have come as something of a shock –’ I began.

She didn’t hear me. She was staring fiercely at Lily. ‘How could my son have had a daughter I didn’t know about?’

‘Because my mum didn’t tell anyone.’ Lily’s voice emerged as a whisper.

‘All this time? How can you have been a secret for all this time?’ Mrs Traynor turned towards me. ‘You knew about this?’

I swallowed. ‘It was why I wrote to you. Lily came to find me. She wanted to know about her family. Mrs Traynor, we didn’t want to cause you

any more pain. It's just that Lily wanted to know her grandparents and it didn't go particularly well with Mr Traynor and ...'

'But Will would have said something.' She shook her head. 'I know he would. He was *my son*.'

'I'll take a blood test if you really don't believe me,' said Lily, her arms folding across her chest. 'But I'm not after anything of yours. I don't need to come and stay with you or anything. I have my own *money*, if that's what you think.'

'I'm not sure what I –' Mrs Traynor began.

'You don't have to look horrified. I'm not, like, some contagious disease you've just inherited. Just, you know, a *granddaughter*. Jesus.'

Mrs Traynor sank slowly into a chair. After a moment, a trembling hand went to her head.

'Are you all right, Mrs Traynor?'

'I don't think I ...' Mrs Traynor closed her eyes. She seemed to have retreated somewhere far inside herself.

'Lily, I think we should go. Mrs Traynor, I'm going to write down my number. We'll come back when this news has had a chance to sink in.'

'Says who? I'm not coming back here. She thinks I'm a liar. Jesus. This *family*.'

Lily stared at us both in disbelief, then pushed her way out of the little room, knocking over a small walnut occasional table as she went. I stooped, picking it up, and carefully replaced the little silver boxes that had been laid out neatly on its surface.

Mrs Traynor was gaunt with shock.

'I'm sorry, Mrs Traynor,' I said. 'I really did try to speak to you before we came.'

I heard the car door slam.

Mrs Traynor took a breath. 'I don't read things if I don't know where they've come from. I had letters. Vile letters. Telling me that I ... I don't answer anything much now ... It's never anything I want to hear.' She looked bewildered and old and fragile.

'I'm sorry. I'm really sorry.' I picked up my bag and fled.

'Don't say anything,' said Lily, as I got into the car. 'Just don't. Okay?'

'Why did you do that?' I sat in the driver's seat, keys in my hand. 'Why would you sabotage it all?'

‘I could see how she felt about me from the moment she looked at me.’

‘She’s a mother, plainly still grieving her son. We had just given her an enormous shock. And you went off at her like a rocket. Could you not have been quiet and let her digest it all? Why do you have to push everyone away?’

‘Oh, what the hell would you know about me?’

‘You seem determined to wreck your relationship with every person who might get close to you.’

‘Oh, *God*, is this about the stupid tights again? What do you know about anything? You spend your whole life alone in a crappy flat where nobody visits. Your parents plainly think you’re a loser. You don’t have the guts to walk out of even the world’s most pathetic job.’

‘You have no idea how hard it is to get any job, these days, so don’t you tell me –’

‘You’re a *loser*. Worse than that you’re a loser who thinks you can tell other people what to do. And who gives you the right? You sat there at my dad’s bedside and you watched him die and you did nothing about it. Nothing! So I hardly think you’re any great judge of how to behave.’

The silence in the car was as hard and brittle as glass. I stared at the wheel. I waited until I was sure I could breathe normally.

Then I started the car and we drove the 120 miles home in silence.



CHAPTER FIFTEEN

I barely saw Lily for the next few days, and that suited me fine. When I came home from work a trail of crumbs or empty mugs confirmed that she had been there. A couple of times I walked in and the air felt oddly disturbed, as if something had taken place I couldn't quite identify. But nothing was missing and nothing obviously altered, and I put it down to the weirdness of sharing a flat with someone you weren't getting on with. For the first time I allowed myself to admit that I missed being on my own.

I called my sister, and she had the good grace not to say, 'I told you so.' Well, maybe just once.

'That is the worst thing about being a parent,' she said, as if I were one too. 'You're meant to be this serene, all-knowing, gracious person who can handle every situation. And sometimes when Thom is rude, or I'm tired, I just want to slam the door at him or stick my tongue out and tell him he's an arse.'

Which was pretty much how I felt.

Work had reached a misery point where I had to make myself sing show tunes in my car even to make myself drive to the airport.

And then there was Sam.

Who I didn't think about.

I didn't think about him in the morning, when I caught sight of my naked body in the bathroom mirror. I didn't remember the way his fingers had traced my skin and made my vivid red scars not so much invisible as part of a shared history – or how, for one brief evening, I had felt reckless and alive again. I didn't think about him when I watched the couples, heads bowed together as they examined their boarding passes, off to share romantic adventures – or just hot monkey sex – in destinations far from there. I didn't think about him on the way to and from work, whenever an ambulance went screaming past. Which seemed to happen an inordinate number of times. And I definitely didn't think about him in the evening when I sat home alone on my sofa, gazing at a television show whose plot I couldn't have told you, and looking, I suspected, like the loneliest flammable porno pixie on the planet.

Nathan rang and left a message, asking me to call. I wasn't sure I could bear to hear the latest episode of his exciting new life in New York, and put it on my mental to-do list of things that would never actually get done. Tanya texted me to say the Houghton-Millers had come home three days early, something to do with Francis's work. Richard rang, telling me I was on the late shift from Monday to Friday. *And please don't be late, Louisa. I'd like to remind you again that you are on your final warning.*

I did the only thing I could think of: I went home, driving to Stortfold with the music turned up loud so that I didn't have to be alone with my thoughts. I felt grateful for my parents. I felt an almost umbilical pull towards home, the comfort offered by a traditional family and Sunday lunch on the table.

'Lunch?' said Dad, his arms crossed across his stomach, his jaw set in indignation. 'Oh, no. We don't do Sunday lunch any more. Lunch is a sign of patriarchal oppression.'

Granddad nodded mournfully from the corner.

'No, no, we can't have lunch. We do sandwiches on a Sunday now. Or soup. Soup is apparently agreeable to feminism.'

Treena, studying at the dining-table, rolled her eyes. 'Mum is doing a women's poetry class on Sunday mornings at the adult education centre. She's hardly turned into Andrea Dworkin.'

'See, Lou? Now I'm expected to know all about feminism and this Andrew Dorkin fella has stolen my bloody Sunday lunch.'

'You're being dramatic, Dad.'

'How is this dramatic? Sundays is *family* time. We should have family Sunday lunch.'

'Mum's entire life has been family time. Why can't you just let her have some time to herself?'

Dad pointed his folded-up newspaper at Treena. 'You did this. Your mammy and I were perfectly happy before you started telling her she wasn't.'

Granddad nodded in agreement.

'It's all gone pear-shaped around here. I can't watch the television without her muttering, "Sexist," at the yoghurt ads. This is sexist. That's sexist. When I brought home Ade Palmer's copy of the *Sun* just for a bit of

a read of the sports pages she chucked it in the fire because of Page Three. I never know where she is from one day to the next.'

'One two-hour class,' said Treena, mildly, not looking up from her books. 'On a Sunday.'

'I'm not being funny, Dad,' I said, 'but those things on the end of your arms?'

'What?' Dad looked down. 'What?'

'Your hands,' I said. 'They're not painted on.'

He frowned at me.

'So I'm guessing you could make the lunch. Give Mum a surprise when she gets back from her poetry class?'

Dad's eyes widened. 'Me make the Sunday lunch? Me? We've been married nearly thirty years, Louisa. I don't do the bloody lunch. I do the earning, and your mother does the lunch. That's the deal! That's what I signed up for! What's the world coming to if I'm there with a pinny on, peeling spuds, on a Sunday? How is that fair?'

'It's called modern life, Dad.'

'Modern life. You're no help,' Dad said, and harrumphed. 'I'll bet you Mr bloody Traynor gets his Sunday lunch. That girl of his wouldn't be a feminist.'

'Ah. Then you need a castle, Dad. Castles trump feminism every time.'

Treena and I started to laugh.

'You know what? There's a reason why the two of you haven't got boyfriends.'

'Ooh. Red card!' We both held up our right hands. He shoved his paper up in the air and stomped off to the garden.

Treena grinned at me. 'I was going to suggest we cook lunch but ... now?'

'I don't know. I wouldn't want to perpetuate patriarchal oppression. Pub?'

'Excellent. I'll text Mum.'

My mother, it emerged, had, at the age of fifty-six, begun to come out of her shell, first as tentatively as a hermit crab but now, apparently, with increasing enthusiasm. For years she hadn't left the house unaccompanied, had been satisfied with the little domain that was our three-and-a-half-bedroomed house. But spending weeks in London after I'd had my accident had forced her out of her normal routine and sparked some long-dormant

curiosity about life beyond Stortfold. She had started flicking through some of the feminist texts Treena had been given at the GenderQuake awareness group at college, and these two alchemic happenings had caused my mother to undergo something of an awakening. She had ripped her way through *The Second Sex* and *Fear of Flying*, followed up with *The Female Eunuch*, and after reading *The Women's Room* had been so shocked at what she saw as the parallels to her own life that she had refused to cook for three days, until she had discovered Granddad was hoarding four-packs of stale doughnuts.

'I keep thinking about what your man Will said,' she remarked, as we sat around the table in the pub garden, watching Thom periodically butt heads with the other children on the sagging bouncy castle. 'You only get the one life – isn't that what he told you?' She was wearing her usual blue short-sleeved shirt, but she had tied her hair back in a way I hadn't seen before and looked oddly youthful. 'So I just want to make the most of things. Learn a little. Take the rubber gloves off once in a while.'

'Dad's quite pissed off,' I said.

'Language.'

'It's a sandwich,' said my sister. 'He's not trekking forty days through the Gobi desert for food.'

'And it's a ten-week course. He'll live,' said my mother, firmly, then sat back and surveyed the two of us. 'Well, now, isn't this nice? I'm not sure the three of us have been out together since ... well, since you were teenagers and we would go shopping in town on a Saturday.'

'And Treena would complain that all the shops were boring.'

'Yeah, but that's because Lou liked charity shops that smelt of people's armpits.'

'It's nice to see you in some of your favourite things again.' Mum nodded at me admiringly. I had put on a bright yellow T-shirt in the hope that it would make me look happier than I felt.

They asked about Lily, and I said she was back with her mother, and had been a bit of a handful, and they exchanged looks, like that was pretty much what they had expected me to say. I didn't tell them about Mrs Traynor.

'That whole Lily thing was a very odd situation. I can't think much of that mother just handing her daughter over to you.'

'Mum means that nicely, by the way,' said Treena.

‘But that job of yours, Lou, love. I don’t like the thought of you prancing around behind a bar in your next-to-nothings. It sounds like that place ... What is it?’

‘Hooters,’ said Treena.

‘It’s not like Hooters. It’s an airport. My hooters are fully suited and hooted.’

‘Nobody toots those hooters,’ said Treena.

‘But you’re wearing a sexist costume to serve drinks. If that’s what you want to do, you could do that at ... I don’t know, Disneyland Paris. If you were Minnie, or Winnie the Pooh, you wouldn’t even have to show your legs.’

‘You’ll be thirty soon,’ said my sister. ‘Minnie, Winnie or Nell Gwynnie. The choice is yours.’

‘Well,’ I said, as the waitress brought our chicken and chips, ‘I’ve been thinking, and, yes, you’re right. From now on I’m going to move on. Focus on my career.’

‘Can you say that again?’ My sister moved some of the chips from her plate on to Thom’s. The pub garden had become noisier.

‘Focus on my career,’ I said, louder.

‘No. That bit where you said I was right. I’m not sure you’ve said that since 1997. Thom, don’t go back on the bouncy castle yet, sweetheart. You’ll be sick.’

We sat there for a good part of the afternoon, avoiding Dad’s increasingly cross texts demanding to know what we were doing. I had never sat with my mother and sister, like normal people, grown-ups, having conversations that didn’t involve putting anything away or somebody being *so annoying*. We found ourselves surprisingly interested in each other’s lives and opinions, as if we had suddenly realized each of us might have roles beyond *the brainy one*, *the chaotic one*, and *the one who does all the housework*.

It was an odd sensation, having to view my family as human beings.

‘Mum,’ I said, shortly after Thom had finished his chicken and run off to play, and about five minutes before he would lose his lunch on the bouncy castle and put it out of action for the rest of the afternoon, ‘do you ever mind not having had a career?’

‘No. I loved being a mum. I really did. But it’s odd ... Everything that’s happened over the past two years, it does make you think.’

I waited.

‘I’ve been reading about all these women – these brave souls who made such a difference in the world to the way people think and do things. And I look at what I’ve done and wonder whether, well, whether anyone would notice a jot if I wasn’t here.’

She said this quite evenly so I couldn’t tell if she was actually much more upset about it than she was prepared to let on. ‘We’d notice more than a jot, Mum,’ I said.

‘But it’s not like I’ve made an impact on much, is it? I don’t know. I’ve always been content. But it’s like I’ve spent thirty years doing one thing and now everything I read, the television, the papers, it’s like everyone’s telling me it was worth nothing.’

My sister and I stared at each other.

‘It wasn’t nothing to us, Mum.’

‘You’re sweet girls.’

‘I mean it. You ...’ I thought suddenly of Tanya Houghton-Miller ‘... you made us feel safe. And loved. I liked you being there every day when we came home.’

Mum put her hand on mine. ‘I’m fine. I’m so proud of the pair of you, making your own way in the world. Really. But I just need to work out some things for myself. And it’s an interesting journey, really it is. I’m loving the reading. Mrs Deans at the library is calling in all sorts of things she thinks I might be interested in. I’m going to move on to the American New Wave feminists next. Very interesting, all their theories.’ She folded her paper napkin neatly. ‘I do wish they’d all stop arguing with each other, though. I slightly want to smack their heads together.’

‘And ... are you really still not shaving your legs?’

I had gone too far. My mother’s face closed off, and she gave me the fishy eye. ‘Sometimes, it takes you a while to wake up to a true sign of oppression. I have told your father, and I’ll tell you girls, the day he goes to the salon to have his legs covered with hot wax, then have it ripped off by a ruddy twenty-one-year-old is the day I’ll start doing mine again.’

The sun eased down over Stortfold, like melting butter. I stayed much later into the evening than I had intended, said goodbye to my family, climbed into my car and drove home. I felt grounded, tethered. After the emotional turbulence of the past week, it was good to be surrounded by a bit of normality. And my sister, who never showed signs of weakness, had

confessed that she thought she would remain single for ever, brushing away Mum's insistence that she was 'a gorgeous-looking girl'.

'But I'm a single mother,' she'd said. 'And, worse, I don't do flirting. I wouldn't know how to flirt with someone if Louisa stood behind them holding up placards. And the only men I've met in two years have either been frightened off by Thom or after one thing.'

'Oh, not –' my mother began.

'Free accounting advice.'

Suddenly, looking at her from the outside, I'd felt a sudden sympathy. She was right: I had been handed, against the odds, all the advantages – a home of my own, a future free of any responsibilities – and the only thing stopping me embracing them was myself. The fact that she wasn't eaten up with bitterness over our respective lots was pretty impressive. I hugged her before I left. She was a little shocked, then momentarily suspicious, patted her upper back to check for KICK ME signs, then finally hugged me back.

'Come and stay,' I said. 'Really. Come and stay. I'll take you dancing at this club I know. Mum can mind Thom.'

My sister laughed, and closed the door of the car as I started it. 'Yeah. You dancing? Like *that's* going to happen.' She was still laughing as I drove away.

Six days later I returned home after a late shift to a nightclub of my own. As I came up the stairs of my block, instead of the usual silence, I could hear the distant sound of laughter, the irregular thump of music. I hesitated for a moment outside my front door, thinking that in my exhausted state I must be mistaken, then unlocked it.

The smell of weed hit me first, so strong I almost reflexively held my breath rather than inhale. I walked slowly to the living room, opened the door and stood there, not quite able to believe at first the scene that confronted me. In the dimly lit room, Lily was lying along my sofa, her short skirt rucked up somewhere just below her bottom, a badly rolled joint midway to her mouth. Two young men were sprawled against the sofa, islands amid a sea of alcoholic detritus, empty crisps packets and polystyrene takeaway cartons. Also seated on the floor were two girls of Lily's age; one, her hair pulled back tightly into a ponytail, looked at me with her eyebrows raised, as if to question what I was doing there. Music

thumped from the sound system. The number of beer cans and overflowing ashtrays told of a long night.

‘Oh,’ Lily said, exaggeratedly. ‘Hi-i-i.’

‘What are you doing?’

‘Yeah. We were out, and we sort of missed the late bus, so I thought it would be okay if we crashed here. You don’t mind, do you?’

I was so stunned I could barely speak. ‘Yes,’ I said tightly. ‘Actually, I do mind.’

‘Uh-oh.’ She began to cackle.

I dropped my bag with a thump at my feet. I gazed around me at the municipal rubbish dump that had once passed as my living room. ‘Party’s over. I’ll give you five minutes to clear up your mess, and go.’

‘Oh, God. I knew it. You’re going to be boring about it, aren’t you? Ugh. I *knew* it.’ She threw herself back on the sofa melodramatically. Her voice was slurred, her actions thickened with – what? Drugs? I waited. For one brief, tense moment, the two men looked steadily at me and I could see they were assessing whether to get up or simply to sit there.

One of the girls sucked her teeth audibly.

‘Four minutes,’ I said slowly. ‘I’m counting.’

Perhaps my righteous anger gave me some authority. Perhaps they were actually less brave than they appeared. One by one they clambered to their feet and sloped past me to the open front door. As the last of the boys left, he ostentatiously lifted his hand and dropped a can on the hall floor so that beer sprayed up the wall and over the carpet. I kicked the door shut behind them and picked it up. By the time I got to Lily, I was shaking with anger. ‘What the *hell* do you think you’re playing at?’

‘Jesus. It was just a few friends, okay?’

‘This is not your flat, Lily. It is not your place to bring people back as you see fit ...’ A sudden flashback: that strange sense of dislocation when I had returned home a week ago. ‘Oh, my God. You’ve done this before, haven’t you? Last week. You had people home and then left before I got back.’

Lily climbed unsteadily to her feet. She pulled down her skirt and ran her hand through her hair, tugging at the tangles. Her eyeliner was smudged, and she had what could have been a bruise, or perhaps a hickey, on her neck. ‘God. Why do you have to make such a big *deal* out of everything? They were just people, okay?’

‘In my *home*.’

‘Well, it’s hardly a home, is it? It’s got no furniture, and nothing personal. You haven’t even got pictures on your walls. It’s like ... a garage. A garage without a car. I’ve actually seen homelier petrol stations.’

‘What I do with my home is none of your business.’

She let out a small belch and fanned the air in front of her mouth. ‘Ugh. Kebab breath.’ She padded to the kitchen where she opened three cupboards until she found a glass. She filled it and gulped down the water. ‘And you haven’t even got a proper television. I didn’t know people still had eighteen-inch televisions.’

I began to pick up the cans, shoving them into a plastic bag. ‘So who were they?’

‘I don’t know. Just some people.’

‘You don’t *know*?’

‘Friends.’ She sounded irritated. ‘People I know from clubbing.’

‘You met them in a club?’

‘Yes. Clubbing. Blah blah blah. It’s like you’re being deliberately thick. Yes. Just some friends I met in a club. It’s what normal people do, you know? Have friends they go out with.’

She threw the glass into the washing-up bowl – I heard it crack – and stalked resentfully out of the kitchen.

I stared at her, my heart suddenly sinking. I ran next door to my room, and opened my top drawer. I riffled through my socks, looking for the little jewellery box that contained my grandmother’s chain and wedding ring. I stopped and took a deep breath, telling myself I couldn’t see them because I was panicking. It would be there. Of course it would. I began picking up the contents of the drawer, carefully checking through them and throwing them onto the bed.

‘Did they come in here?’ I shouted.

Lily appeared in the doorway. ‘Did what?’

‘Your friends. Did they come in my bedroom? Where’s my jewellery?’

Lily seemed to wake up a little. ‘Jewellery?’

‘Oh, no. Oh, no.’ I opened all my drawers, began dumping the contents on the floor. ‘Where is it? And where’s my emergency cash?’ I turned to her. ‘Who were they? What were their names?’

Lily had gone quiet.

‘Lily!’

‘I – I don’t know.’

‘What do you mean you don’t know? You said they were your friends.’

‘Just ... clubbing friends. Mitch. And ... Lise and – I can’t remember.’

I ran for the door, belted along the corridor and hurled myself down the four flights of stairs. But by the time I reached the front door the corridor and the street beyond were empty, but for the late bus to Waterloo sailing gently, illuminated, down the middle of the dark road.

I stood in the doorway, panting. Then I closed my eyes, fighting back tears, dropping my hands to my knees as I realized what I had lost: my grandmother’s ring, the fine gold chain, with the little pendant she had worn from when I was a child. I knew already I would never see it again. There were so few things to pass down in my family, and now even that was gone.

I walked slowly back up the stairs.

Lily was standing in the hallway when I opened the front door. ‘I’m really sorry,’ she said quietly. ‘I didn’t know they would steal your stuff.’

‘Go away, Lily,’ I said.

‘They seemed really nice. I – I should have thought –’

‘I’ve been at work for thirteen hours. I need to find out what I’ve lost and then I want to go to sleep. Your mother is back from her holiday. Please just go home.’

‘But I –’

‘No. No more.’ I straightened up slowly, taking a moment to catch my breath. ‘You know the real difference between you and your dad? Even when he was at his unhappiest he wouldn’t have treated anyone like this.’

She looked as if I’d slapped her. I didn’t care.

‘I can’t do this any more, Lily.’ I pulled a twenty-pound note from my purse and handed it to her. ‘There. For your taxi.’

She looked at it, then at me, and swallowed. She ran a hand through her hair and walked slowly back into the living room.

I took off my jacket, and stood staring at my reflection in the little mirror above my chest of drawers. I looked pale, exhausted, defeated. ‘And leave your keys,’ I said.

There was a short silence. I heard the clatter as they were dropped on the kitchen counter, and then, with a click, the front door closed and she was gone.



CHAPTER SIXTEEN

I messed it all up, Will.

I hauled my knees up to my chest. I tried to imagine what he would have said if he could see me then, but I could no longer hear his voice in my head and that small fact made me even sadder.

What do I do now?

I understood I could not stay in the flat that Will's legacy had bought me. It felt as if it were steeped in my failures, a bonus prize I had failed to earn. How could you make a home in a place that had come to you for all the wrong reasons? I would sell it and invest the money somewhere. But where would I go instead?

I thought of my job, the reflexive way my stomach now clenched when I heard Celtic pan pipes, even on television; the way Richard made me feel useless, worthless.

I thought of Lily, noting the peculiar weight of the silence that resulted when you knew without doubt that nobody but you would be in your home. I wondered where she was, and pushed the thought away.

The rain eased off, slowing and ceasing almost apologetically, as if the weather were admitting it hadn't really known what had got into it. I pulled on some clothes, vacuumed the flat, and put out the bin-bags of party-related rubbish. I walked to the flower market, mostly to give myself something to do. *Always better to get out and about*, Marc said. I might feel better for being in the thick of Columbia Road, with its gaudy displays of blooms and its slow-moving crowds of shoppers. I fixed my face into a smile, frightened Samir when I bought myself an apple ('Are you on drugs, man?') and headed off into a sea of flowers.

I bought myself a coffee at a little coffee shop and watched the market through its steamed window, ignoring the fact that I was the only person in there on my own. I walked the length of the sodden market, breathed in the damp and heady scents of the lilies, admired the folded secrets of the peonies and roses, glass beads of rain still dotting their surfaces, and bought

myself a bunch of dahlias and the whole time I felt as if I were acting, a figure in an advert: *Single city girl living the London dream*.

I walked home, cradling my dahlias in one arm, doing my best not to limp, all the while trying to stop the words *Oh, who do you think you're kidding?* popping repeatedly into my head.

The evening stretched and sagged, as lonely evenings do. I finished cleaning the flat, having fished cigarette butts out of the toilet, watched some television, washed my uniform. I ran a bath full of bubbles and climbed out of it after five minutes, afraid to be alone with my thoughts. I couldn't call my mother or my sister: I knew I wouldn't be able to keep up the pretence of happiness in front of them.

Finally, I reached into my bedside table, and pulled out the letter, the one Will had arranged for me to receive in Paris, back when I was still full of hope. I unfolded its well-worn creases gently. There were times, that first year, when I would read it nightly, trying to bring him to life beside me. These days I rationed myself: I told myself I didn't need to see it – I was afraid it would lose its talismanic power, the words become meaningless. Well, I needed them now.

The computer text, as dear to me as if he had been able to handwrite it; some residual trace of his energy still in those laser-printed words.

You're going to feel uncomfortable in your new world for a bit. It always does feel strange to be knocked out of your comfort zone ... There is a hunger in you, Clark. A fearlessness. You just buried it, like most people do.

Just live well. Just live.

I read the words of a man who had once believed in me, put my head on my knees and, finally, sobbed.

The phone rang, too loud, too close to my head, sending me lurching upright. I scrabbled for it, noting the time. Two a.m. The familiar reflexive fear. 'Lily?'

'What? Lou?'

Nathan's deep drawl rolled across the phone line.

'It's two a.m., Nathan.'

'Aw, man. I always mess up the time difference. Sorry. Want me to hang up?'

I pushed myself upright, rubbing at my face. 'No. No ... It's good to hear from you.' I flicked on the bedside light. 'How are you?'

'Good! I'm back in New York.'

'Great.'

'Yeah. It was great to see the olds and all, but after a couple of weeks I was itching to get back here. This city is epic.'

I forced a smile, in case he could hear it. 'That's great, Nathan. I'm glad for you.'

'You still happy at that pub of yours?'

'It's fine.'

'You don't ... want to do something else?'

'Well, you know when things are bad, and you tell yourself stuff like, "Oh, it could be worse. I could be the person who cleans the poop out of the dog-poop bins"? Well, right now I'd rather be the person who picks up the poop out of the dog-poop bins.'

'Then I've got a proposition for you.'

'I get that a lot from customers, Nathan. And the answer is always no.'

'Ha. Well. There's a job opening out here, working for this family I live with. And you were the first person I thought of.'

Mr Gopnik's wife, he explained, was not a Wall Street Wife. She didn't do the whole 'shopping and lunches' thing; she was a Polish émigrée, prone to mild depression. She was lonely, and the help – a Guatemalan woman – wouldn't say two words to her.

What Mr Gopnik wanted was someone he could trust to keep his wife company and help with the children, to be an extra pair of hands when they travelled. 'He wants a sort of Girl Friday to the family. Someone cheerful and trustworthy. And someone who is not going to go blabbing about their private life.'

'Does he know –'

'I told him about Will at our first meeting, but he'd already done background. He wasn't put off. Far from it. He said he was impressed that we'd followed Will's wishes and never sold our stories.' Nathan paused. 'I've worked it out. At this level, Lou, people value trust and discretion over anything else. I mean, obviously you can't be an idiot, and have to do your job well, but, yeah, that's basically what matters.'

My mind was whirling, an out-of-control waltzer at a fairground. I held the phone in front of me and put it back to my ear. 'Is this ... Am I actually

still asleep?’

‘It’s not an easy ride. It’s long hours and a lot of work. But I’ll tell you, mate, I’m having the best time.’

I pushed my hand through my hair. I thought about the bar, with its huffing businessmen and Richard’s gimlet stare. I thought about the flat, its walls closing in on me every evening. ‘I don’t know. This is ... I mean it all seems –’

‘It’s a green card, Lou.’ Nathan’s voice dropped. ‘It’s your board and lodging. It’s *New York*. Listen. This is a man who gets stuff done. Work hard, and he’ll look after you. He’s smart, and he’s fair. Get out here, show him what you’re worth, and you could end up with opportunities you wouldn’t believe. Seriously. Don’t think of this as a nanny job. Think of it as a *gateway*.’

‘I don’t know ...’

‘Some fella you don’t want to leave?’

I hesitated. ‘No. But so much has gone on ... I’ve not been ...’ It seemed an awful lot to explain at two o’clock in the morning.

‘I know you were knocked by what happened. We all were. But you’ve got to move on.’

‘Don’t say it’s what he would have wanted.’

‘Okay,’ he said. We both listened, as he said it silently.

I tried to gather my thoughts. ‘Would I have to go to New York for an interview?’

‘They’re in the Hamptons for the summer, so he’s looking for someone to start in September. Basically, in six weeks. If you say you’re interested, he’ll interview you on Skype, sort out the paperwork to get you over, and then we go from there. There will be other candidates. It’s too good a position. But Mr G trusts me, Lou. If I say someone’s a good bet, they’re in with a chance. So shall I throw your hat in the ring? Yes? It is a yes, right?’

I spoke almost before I could think. ‘Uh ... yes. Yes.’

‘Great! Email me if you’ve got questions. I’ll send you some pics.’

‘Nathan?’

‘Gotta go, Lou. The old man has just buzzed me.’

‘Thank you. Thanks for thinking of me.’

There was a slight pause before he responded. ‘No one I’d rather work with, mate.’

I couldn't sleep after he rang off, wondering whether I had imagined the whole conversation, my mind humming with the enormity of what might lie in front of me if I hadn't. At four, I sat up and emailed Nathan a handful of questions, and the answers came straight back.

The family is okay. The rich are never normal (!) but these are good people. Minimal drama.

You'd have your own room and bathroom. We'd share a kitchen with the housekeeper. She's all right. Bit older. Keeps herself to herself.

Hours regular. Eight – at worst ten – a day. You get time off in lieu. You might want to learn a bit of Polish!

I finally fell asleep as it grew light, my mind full of Manhattan duplexes and bustling streets. And when I woke up, an email was waiting for me.

Dear Ms Clark,

Nathan tells me you might be interested in coming to work in our household. Would you be available for a Skype interview on Tuesday evening at 5 p.m. GMT (midday EST)?

Yours sincerely,

Leonard M. Gopnik

I stared at it for a full twenty minutes, proof that I hadn't dreamed the whole thing. And then I got up and showered, made myself a strong mug of coffee and typed my reply. It wouldn't hurt to have the interview, I told myself. I wouldn't get the job, if there were lots of highly professional New York candidates. But it was good practice, if nothing else. And it would make me feel as if I were finally doing something, moving forward.

Before I left for work, I took Will's letter carefully from the bedside table. I pressed my lips to it, then folded it carefully and put it back in the drawer.

Thank you, I told him silently.

It was a slightly thinned-out version of the Moving On Circle that week. Natasha was on holiday, as was Jake, for which I was mostly relieved and a tiny bit put out in a way I couldn't reconcile. The evening's topic was 'If I could turn back time', which meant that William and Sunil hummed or whistled the Cher song unconsciously at intervals for the entire hour and a half.

I listened to Fred wishing he had spent less time at work, then Sunil wishing he'd got to know his brother better ('You just think they're always

going to be there, you know? And then one day they're not'), and wondered if it really had been worth coming.

There had been a couple of times when I'd thought the group might actually be helping. But for an awful lot of the time I was sitting among people I felt I had nothing in common with, droning on for the few hours they had company. I felt grumpy and tired, my hip ached on the hard plastic chair, and I thought I might have got just as much enlightenment about my mental state if I had been watching *EastEnders*. Plus the biscuits were rubbish.

Leanne, a single mother, was talking about how she and her older sister had argued about a pair of tracksuit bottoms two days before her sister had died. 'I accused her of taking them, because she was always nicking my stuff. She said she hadn't, but then she always said she hadn't.'

Marc waited. I wondered if I had any painkillers in my handbag.

'And then, you know, she got hit by the bus and the next time I got to see her was at the morgue. And when I was looking for dark clothes to wear to her funeral, you know what was in my wardrobe?'

'The tracksuit bottoms,' said Fred.

'It's difficult when things are unresolved,' said Marc. 'Sometimes for our own sanity we just have to look at the bigger picture.'

'You can love someone and also call them a prat for nicking your tracksuit bottoms,' said William.

That day I didn't want to speak. I was only there because I couldn't face the silence of my little flat. I had a sudden sneaking suspicion I could easily become one of those people who so crave human contact that they talk inappropriately to other passengers on trains or spend ten minutes picking things in a shop so they can chat to the assistant. I was so busy wondering whether it was symptomatic that I had just discussed my new physio support bandage with Samir at the mini-mart that I tuned out Daphne wishing she'd come back from work an hour earlier that particular day, then found she had dissolved, quietly, into tears.

'Daphne?'

'I'm sorry, everyone. But I've spent so long thinking in "if onlys". If only I hadn't stopped off for a chat with the lady at the flower stall. If only I'd left that stupid bought ledger and come home from work earlier. If only I'd just got back in time ... maybe I could have persuaded him not to do what

he did. Maybe I could have done one thing that persuaded him life was worth living.'

Marc leaned forward with the box of tissues and I placed it gently on Daphne's lap. 'Had Alan tried to end his life before, Daphne?'

She nodded and blew her nose. 'Oh, yes. Several times. He used to get what we called "the blues" from quite a young age. And I didn't like to leave him when they came because it was like ... it was like he couldn't hear you. Didn't matter what you said. So quite often I would call in sick just to stay with him and jolly him along, you know? Make his favourite sandwiches. Sit with him on the sofa. Anything, really, just to let him know I was there. I always think that's why I never got a promotion at work when all the other girls did. I had to keep taking time off, you see.'

'Depression can be very hard. And not just on the sufferer.'

'Was he on medication?'

'Oh, no. But, then, it wasn't ... you know ... chemical.'

'Are you sure? I mean depression was under-diagnosed back in –'

Daphne lifted her head. 'He was a homosexual.' She said the word with its five full, clearly defined syllables, and looked directly at us, a little flushed, as if daring us to say anything in return. 'I've never told anyone that. But he was a homosexual, and I think he was sad because he was a homosexual. And he was ever such a good man and he wouldn't have wanted to hurt me, so he wouldn't have ... you know ... gone off and done things. He would have felt I'd be shamed.'

'What makes you think he was gay, Daphne?'

'I found things when I was looking for one of his ties. Those magazines. Men doing things to other men. In his drawer. I don't suppose you would have those magazines if you weren't.'

Fred stiffened slightly. 'Certainly not,' he said.

'I never mentioned them,' said Daphne. 'I just tucked them back where I found them. But it all started to click into place. He was never very keen on that side of things. But I thought I was lucky, you see, because I wasn't either. It's the nuns. They made you feel dirty for just about everything. So when I married a nice man who wasn't jumping on top of me every five minutes, I thought I was the luckiest woman on earth. I mean, I would have liked children. That would have been nice. But ...' she sighed '... we never really talked about such things. You didn't in those days. Now I wish we had. Looking back, I keep thinking, What a waste.'

‘You think if you’d talked honestly, it might have made a difference?’

‘Well, times are different now, aren’t they? It’s fine to be homosexual. My dry cleaner is and he talks about his boyfriend to every Tom, Dick and Harry that walks in. I would have been sad to lose my husband, but if he was unhappy because of being trapped, then I would have let him go. I would have done. I never wanted to trap anyone. I only wanted him to be a bit happier.’

Her face crumpled, and I put my arm around her. Her hair smelt of lacquer and lamb stew.

‘There, there, old girl,’ said Fred, and stood up to pat her on the shoulder a little awkwardly. ‘I’m sure he knew you only ever wanted the best for him.’

‘Do you think so, Fred?’ Her voice was tremulous.

Fred nodded firmly. ‘Oh, yes. And you’re quite right. Things were different back then. You’re not to blame.’

‘You’ve been very brave sharing that story, Daphne. Thank you.’ Marc smiled sympathetically. ‘And I have huge admiration for you picking yourself up and moving on. Sometimes just getting through each day requires almost superhuman strength.’

When I looked down, Daphne was holding my hand. I felt her plump fingers intertwine with mine. I squeezed hers back. And before I could think I began to talk. ‘I’ve done something I wish I could change.’

Half a dozen faces turned to me. ‘I met Will’s daughter. She sort of landed in my life out of the blue and I thought that was going to be my way of feeling better about his death but instead I just feel like –’

They were staring. Fred was pulling a face.

‘What?’

‘Who’s Will?’ said Fred.

‘You said his name was Bill.’

I slumped a little in my chair. ‘Will is Bill. I felt weird about using his real name before.’ There was a general release of breath around the room.

Daphne patted my hand. ‘Don’t worry, dear. It’s just a name. Our last group we had a woman who invented the whole thing. Said she had a child died from leukaemia. Turned out she didn’t even have a goldfish.’

‘It’s okay, Louisa. You can talk to us.’ Marc gave me his Special Empathetic Gaze. I gave him a small smile back, just to show him I had

received and understood. And that Will was not a goldfish. *What the hell?* I thought. My life is no more mixed up than any of theirs.

So I told them about Lily turning up and how I had thought I could fix her and bring about a reunion that would make everyone happy, and how I now felt stupid for my naivety. 'I feel like I've let Will – everyone – down again,' I said. 'And now she's gone and I keep asking myself what I could have done differently, but the real truth is I couldn't cope. I wasn't strong enough to take charge of it all and make it better.'

'But your things! Your precious things got stolen!' Daphne's other plump, damp hand clamped onto mine. 'You had every right to be angry!'

'Just because she doesn't have a father doesn't give her the excuse to behave like a brat,' said Sunil.

'I think you were very nice to let her stay in the first place. I'm not sure I would,' said Daphne.

'What do you think her father might have done differently, Louisa?' Marc poured himself another cup of coffee.

I wished, suddenly, that we had something stronger. 'I don't know,' I said. 'But he had this way of taking charge. Even when he couldn't move his arms and legs you got the feeling he was capable. He would have stopped her doing stupid stuff. He would have got her straightened out somehow.'

'Are you sure you're not idealizing him? We do idealization in week eight,' said Fred. 'I keep turning Jilly into a saint, don't I, Marc? I forget that she used to leave her hold-ups hanging over the shower rail and it drove me absolutely potty.'

'Her father might not have been able to do anything to help her at all. You have no idea. They might have loathed each other.'

'She sounds like a complicated young woman,' said Marc. 'And it's possible that you gave her as many chances as you could. But ... sometimes, Louisa, moving on means we do have to protect ourselves. And perhaps you understood that, deep down. If Lily simply brought chaos and negativity into your life, then for now, it's possible you did the only thing you could.'

'Oh, yes.' There were nods around the circle. 'Be kind to yourself. You're only human.' They were so sweet, smiling at me reassuringly, wanting me to feel better.

I almost believed them.

On Tuesday I asked Vera if she could give me ten minutes (I muttered vague things about Women's Troubles and she nodded, as if to say Women's Lives Were Nothing but Trouble, and murmured that she would tell me later about her fibroids). I ran to the quietest Ladies loo – the only place I could be sure Richard wouldn't see me – with my laptop in my bag. I threw a shirt over the top of my uniform, balanced the laptop near the basins and hooked into the thirty minutes' free airport Wi-Fi, positioning myself carefully in front of the screen. Mr Gopnik's Skype call came in dead on five o'clock, just as I whipped off my ringlets Irish-dancing-girl wig.

Even if I had seen nothing else of Leonard Gopnik than his pixellated face, I could have told you he was rich. He had beautifully cut salt-and-pepper hair, and gazed out of the small screen with natural authority, and spoke without wasting a word. Well, there was that and the gilt-framed old master on the wall behind him.

He asked nothing about my school record, my qualifications, my CV or why I was conducting an interview beside a hand-dryer. He looked down at some papers, then asked about my relationship with the Traynors.

'Good! I mean, I'm sure they would provide a reference. I've seen both of them recently, for one reason or another. We get on well, despite the – the circumstances of ...'

'The circumstances of the end of your employment.' His voice was low, decisive. 'Yes, Nathan has explained a lot about that situation. Quite a thing to be involved in.'

'Yes. It was,' I said, after a short, awkward silence. 'But I felt privileged. To be part of Will's life.'

He registered this. 'What have you been doing since?'

'Um, well, I travelled a bit, Europe mostly, which was ... interesting. It's good to travel. And get a perspective. Obviously.' I tried to smile. 'And I'm now working at an airport but it's not really –' As I spoke, the door opened behind me and a woman walked in, pulling a wheelie case. I shifted my computer, hoping he couldn't hear the sound of her entering the cubicle. 'It's not really what I want to be doing long term.' *Please don't wee noisily*, I begged her silently.

He asked me a few questions about my current responsibilities, and salary level. I tried to ignore the sound of flushing, and kept my gaze straight ahead, ignoring the woman who emerged.

‘And what do you want –’ As Mr Gopnik began to speak, she reached past me and started up the hand-dryer, which let out a deafening roar beside me. He frowned.

‘Hold on one moment, please, Mr Gopnik.’ I put my thumb over what I hoped was the microphone. ‘I’m sorry,’ I shouted at the woman. ‘You can’t use that. It’s ... broken.’

She turned towards me, rubbing perfectly manicured fingers, then back to the machine. ‘No, it’s not. Where’s the out-of-order sign, then?’

‘Burned off. Suddenly. Awful, dangerous thing.’

She fixed me, then the hand-dryer, with a suspicious look, removed her hands from under it, took her case and walked out. I wedged the chair against the door to stop anyone else coming in, shifting my laptop again so that Mr Gopnik could see me. ‘I’m so sorry. I’m having to do this at work and it’s a little ...’

He was studying his paperwork. ‘Nathan tells me you had an accident recently.’

I swallowed. ‘I did. But I’m much better. I’m completely fine. Well, fine except I walk with a slight limp.’

‘Happens to the best of us,’ he said, with a small smile. I smiled back. Someone tried the door. I moved so that my weight was against it.

‘So what was the hardest part?’ Mr Gopnik said.

‘I’m sorry?’

‘Of working for William Traynor. It sounds like quite a challenge.’

I hesitated. The room was suddenly very quiet. ‘Letting him go.’ I said. And found myself unexpectedly biting back tears.

Leonard Gopnik gazed at me from several thousand miles away. I fought the urge to wipe my eyes. ‘My secretary will be in touch, Miss Clark. Thank you for your time.’ And then, with a nod, his face stilled and the screen went blank and I was left staring at it, contemplating the fact that I had blown it, yet again.

That night, on the way home, I decided not to think about the interview. Instead I repeated Marc’s words in my head, like a mantra. I ran through the things that Lily had done, the uninvited guests, the theft, the drugs, the endless late nights, the borrowing of my things, and ran them through the prism of my group’s counsel. Lily was chaos, disorder, a girl who took and gave nothing in return. She was young, and biologically related to Will, but

that didn't mean I had to assume total responsibility for her or put up with the turmoil she left in her wake.

I felt a little better. I did. I reminded myself of something else Marc had said: that no journey out of grief was straightforward. There would be good days and bad days. Today was just a bad day, a kink in the road, to be traversed and survived.

I let myself into the flat, and dropped my bag, suddenly grateful for the small pleasure of a home that was just as I'd left it. I would allow some time to pass, I told myself, and then I would text her, and I would make sure our future visits were structured. I would focus my energies on getting a new job. I would think about myself for a change. I would let myself heal. I had to stop at that point because I was a little worried that I was starting to sound like Tanya Houghton-Miller.

I glanced at the fire escape. Step one would be getting back up on that stupid roof. I would climb up there by myself without having a panic attack and I would sit there for a full half-hour, breathe the air and stop letting a part of my own home have such a ridiculous hold on my imagination.

I took off my uniform and put on shorts and, just for confidence, Will's lightweight cashmere jumper, the one I had taken from his house after he died, comforted by the soft feel of it against my skin. I walked down the corridor and opened the window wide. It was just two short flights of iron steps. And then I would be up there.

'Nothing will happen,' I said aloud, and took a deep breath. My legs felt curiously hollow as I climbed out onto the fire escape, but I told myself firmly that it was just a feeling, the echo of an old anxiety. I could overcome it, just as I would overcome everything else. I heard Will's voice in my ear.

C'mon, Clark. One step at a time.

I grasped the rails tightly with both hands, and began to make my way up. I didn't look down. I didn't let myself think about what height I was at, or how the faint breeze recalled an earlier time gone wrong, or the recurring pain in my hip that never seemed to go away. I thought about Sam, and the fury that invoked made me push on. I didn't have to be the victim, the person to whom things just *happened*.

I told myself these things and made it up the second flight of steps as my legs began to shake. I climbed inelegantly over the low wall, afraid that they would give way under me, and dropped onto the roof on my hands and

knees. I felt weak and clammy. I stayed on all fours, my eyes shut, while I let myself absorb the fact that I was on the roof. I had made it. I was in control of my destiny. I would stay there for as long as it took to feel normal.

I sat back on my heels, reaching for the solidity of the wall around me, and leaned back, taking a long, deep breath. It felt okay. Nothing was moving. I had done it. And then I opened my eyes and my breath stopped in my chest.

The rooftop was a riot of bloom. The dead pots I had neglected for months were filled with scarlet and purple flowers, spilling over the edges, like little fountains of colour. Two new planters mushroomed with clouds of tiny blue petals, and a Japanese maple sat in an ornamental pot beside one of the benches, its leaves shivering delicately in the breeze.

In the sunny corner by the south wall two grow-bags sat by the water tank, with little red cherry tomatoes dangling from their stalks, and another lay on the asphalt with small frilly green leaves emerging from the centre. I began to walk slowly towards them, breathing in the scent of jasmine, then stopped and sat down, my hand grasping the iron bench. I sank onto a cushion that I recognized from my living room.

I stared in disbelief at the little oasis of calm and beauty that had been created from my barren rooftop. I remembered Lily snapping the dead twig from a pot and informing me in all seriousness that it was a crime to let your plants die, and her casual observation in Mrs Traynor's garden, 'David Austin roses.' And then I remembered little unexplained bits of soil in my hallway.

And I sank my head into my hands.



CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

I texted Lily twice. The first time was to thank her for what she had done to my rooftop. *It's so gorgeous. I wish you had told me.* A day later, I texted to say I was sorry that things had become so tricky between us, and that if she ever wanted to talk more about Will, I would do my best to answer any questions. I added that I hoped she would go and see Mr Traynor and the new baby, as I knew as well as most that it was important to stay in touch with your family.

She didn't reply. I wasn't entirely surprised.

For the next two days I found myself returning to the rooftop, like someone worrying a loose tooth. I watered the plants, feeling a creeping, residual guilt. I walked around the glowing blooms, imagining her stolen hours up there, how she must have carried bags of compost and terracotta pots up the fire escape in the hours I was at work. But every time I thought back to how we had been together, I still went around in circles. What could I have done? I couldn't make the Traynors accept her in the way she needed to be accepted. I couldn't make her happier. And the one person who might have been able to was gone.

There was a motorbike parked outside my block. I locked the car and limped across the road to get a carton of milk after my shift, exhausted. It was spitting, and I put my head down against the rain. When I looked up, I saw a familiar uniform standing in the entrance to my block, and my heart lurched.

I walked back across the road straight past him, fumbling in my bag for my keys. Why did fingers always turn into cocktail sausages at moments of stress?

'Louisa.'

The keys refused to appear. I riffled through my bag a second time, dropping a comb, bits of tissue, loose change, and cursing. I patted my pockets, trying to work out where they might be.

'Louisa.'

Then, with a sickening drop of my stomach, I remembered where they were: in the pocket of the jeans I had changed out of just before leaving for work. Oh, *great*.

‘Really? You’re just going to ignore me? This is how we’re doing this?’

I took a deep breath, and turned to him, straightening my shoulders a little. ‘Sam.’

He looked tired too, his chin greyed with stubble. Probably just off a shift. It was unwise to notice these things. I focused on a point a little left of his shoulder.

‘Can we talk?’

‘I’m not sure there’s any point.’

‘No point?’

‘I got the message, okay? I’m not even sure why you’re here.’

‘I’m here because I’ve just finished a crappy sixteen hour shift and I dropped Donna off up the road and I thought I might as well try to see you and work out what happened with us. Because I sure as hell don’t have a clue.’

‘Really?’

‘Really.’

We glared at each other. Why had I not seen before how abrasive he was? How unpleasant. I couldn’t understand how I had been so blinded by lust for this man when every part of me now wanted to walk away from him. I made one last futile search for my keys and fought the urge to kick the door.

‘So, are you at least going to give me a clue? I’m tired, Louisa, and I don’t like playing games.’

‘*You* don’t like playing games.’ The words emerged in a bitter little laugh.

He took a breath. ‘Okay. One thing. One thing and I’ll go. I just want to know why you won’t return my calls.’

I looked at him in disbelief. ‘Because I’m many things, but I’m not a complete idiot. I mean I must have been – I saw the warning signs, and I ignored them – but, basically, I haven’t returned your calls because you’re an utter, utter knob. Okay?’

I stooped to pick up my things that had fallen on the ground, feeling my whole body heat rapidly, as if my internal thermostat had suddenly gone haywire. ‘Oh, you’re so good, you know? So bloody good. If it weren’t all so sick and pathetic I’d actually be quite impressed by you.’ I straightened

up, zipping my bag. *'Look at Sam, the good father. So caring, so intuitive. And yet what's really going on? You're so busy shagging your way through half of London you don't even notice that your own son is unhappy.'*

'My son.'

'Yes! Because we actually listen to him, you see. I mean, we're not meant to tell outsiders what goes on in the group. And he won't tell you because he's a teenager. But he's miserable, not just for the loss of his mum but because you're busy swallowing your own grief by having an entire army of women traipse in and out of your bed.'

I was shouting now, my words tumbling over each other, my hands waving. I could see Samir and his cousin staring at me through the window of the shop. I didn't care. This might be the last time I ever got to say my piece.

'And, yes, yes, I know, I was stupid enough to be one of those women. So for him, and from me, you're a knob. And that's why I don't want to talk to you right now. Or ever, actually.'

He rubbed at his hair. *'Are we still talking about Jake?'*

'Of course I'm talking about Jake. How many other sons have you got?'

'Jake isn't my son.'

I stared at him.

'Jake is my sister's son. Was,' he corrected himself. 'He's my nephew.'

These words took several seconds to filter into a form I could understand. Sam was gazing at me intently, his brow furrowed as if he, too, were trying to keep up.

'But – but you pick him up. He lives with you.'

'I pick him up on Mondays because his dad works shifts. And he stays with me sometimes, yes. He doesn't live with me.'

'Jake's ... not your son?'

'I don't have any children. That I'm aware of. Though the whole Lily thing does make you wonder.'

I pictured him hugging Jake, mentally rewound half a dozen conversations. *'But I saw him when we first met. And when you and I were talking he rolled his eyes, like ...'*

Sam lowered his head.

'Oh, God,' I said. My hand went to my mouth. 'Those women ...'

'Not mine.'

We stood there in the middle of the street. Samir was now in the doorway, watching. He had been joined by another of his cousins. To our left everyone at the bus stop turned away when they realized we knew they'd been watching us. Sam nodded at the door behind me. 'Do you think we could talk about this inside?'

'Yes. Yes. Oh. No, I can't,' I said. 'I seem to have locked myself out.'

'Spare key?'

'In the flat.'

He ran a hand over his face, then checked his watch. He was clearly drained, weary to the bone. I took a step backwards into the doorway. 'Look – go home and get some rest. We'll talk tomorrow. I'm sorry.'

The rain suddenly grew heavy, a summer dump, creating torrents in gutters and flooding the street. Across the road Samir and his cousins ducked back inside.

Sam sighed. He looked up at the skies and then straight at me. 'Hang on.'

Sam took a large screwdriver he had borrowed from Samir and followed me up the fire escape. Twice I slipped on the wet metal and his hand reached out to steady me. When it did, something hot and unexpected shot through me. When we reached my floor, he pushed the screwdriver deep into the hall window frame and started to lever upwards. It gave gratifyingly swiftly.

'There.' He wrenched it upwards, supporting it with one hand, and turned to me, motioning me through, his expression faintly disapproving. 'That was way too easy for a single girl living in this area.'

'You look nothing like a single girl living in this area.'

'I'm serious.'

'I'm fine, Sam.'

'You don't see what I see. I want you to be safe.'

I tried to smile, but my knees were trembling, my palms slippery on the iron rail. I made to step past him and staggered slightly.

'You okay?'

I nodded. He took my arm and half lifted, half helped me climb clumsily into my flat. I slumped down on the carpet by the window, waiting to feel normal again. I hadn't slept properly for days and felt half dead, as if the fury and adrenalin that had sustained me had all leached away.

Sam climbed in and closed the window behind him, eyeing the broken lock on the top of the sash. The hall was dark, the thrumming of the rain

muffled on the roof. As I watched, he rummaged around in his pocket until, among other detritus, he picked out a small nail. He took the screwdriver and used the handle to knock the nail in at an angle to stop anyone opening it from outside. Then he walked heavily over to where I was sitting, and held out a hand.

‘Benefits of being a part-time housebuilder. There’s always a nail somewhere. ‘C’mon,’ he said. ‘If you sit there you’ll never get up.’

His hair was flattened from the rain, his skin glistening in the hall light, as I let him pull me to my feet. I winced, and he saw.

‘Hip?’

I nodded.

He sighed. ‘I wish you’d talk to me.’ The skin beneath his eyes was mauve with exhaustion. There were two long scratches on the back of his left hand. I wondered what had happened the previous night. He disappeared into the kitchen and I heard running water. When he came back he was holding two pills and a cup. ‘I shouldn’t really be giving you these. But they’ll give you a pain-free night.’

I took them gratefully. He watched me as I swallowed them.

‘Do you ever follow rules?’

‘When I think they’re sensible.’ He took the cup from me. ‘So are we good, Louisa Clark?’

I nodded.

He let out a long breath. ‘I’ll call you tomorrow.’

Afterwards, I wasn’t sure what made me do it. My hand reached out and took his. I felt his fingers close slowly around mine. ‘Don’t go. It’s late. And motorbikes are dangerous.’

I took the screwdriver from his other hand, and let it fall onto the carpet. He looked at me for the longest time, then slid a hand over his face. ‘I don’t think I’m good for much just now.’

‘Then I promise not to use you for sexual gratification.’ I kept my eyes on his. ‘This time.’

His smile was slow to come, but when it did, everything fell away from me, as if I had been carrying a weight I hadn’t known.

You never know what will happen when you fall from a great height.

He stepped over the screwdriver, and I led him silently towards my bedroom.

I lay in the dark in my little flat, my leg slung over the bulk of a sleeping man, his arm pinning me pleasurably beneath it, and gazed at his face.

– *Fatal cardiac arrest, motorbike accident, suicidal teenager and a gang-related stabbing on the Peabody Estate. Some shifts are just a bit ...*

– *Sssh. It's okay. Sleep.*

He had barely managed to get his uniform off. He had stripped to his T-shirt and shorts, kissed me, then closed his eyes and collapsed into a dead slumber. I had wondered whether I should cook him something, or tidy the flat so that when he woke I might look like someone who actually had a handle on life. But instead I undressed to my underwear and slid in next to him. For these few moments I just wanted to be beside him, my bare skin against his T-shirt, my breath mingling with his. I lay listening to his breathing, marvelling at how someone could be so still. I studied the slight bump on the bridge of his nose, the variation in the shade of the bristles that shadowed his chin, the slight curl at the end of his dark, dark eyelashes. I ran through conversations we had had, putting them through a new filter, one that pitched him as a single man, an affectionate uncle, and I wanted to laugh with the idiocy of it all, and cringe at my mistake.

I touched his face twice, lightly, breathing in the scent of his skin, the faint tang of antibacterial soap, the primal sexual hint of male sweat, and the second time I did so I felt his hand tighten reflexively on my waist. I shifted onto my back and gazed out at the streetlights, feeling, for once, that I was not an alien in this city. And finally, I found myself drifting ...

His eyes open on mine. A moment later he realizes where he is.

‘Hey.’

A lurch into waking. The peculiar dreamlike state that suffuses the small hours. *He is in my bed. His leg against mine.* A smile, creeping across my face. ‘Hey yourself.’

‘What time is it?’

I swivel to catch the digital readout of my alarm. ‘A quarter to five.’ Time settles into order, the world, reluctantly, into something that makes sense. Outside, the sodium-lit dark of the street. The minicabs and night buses rumble past. Up here it is just him and me in the night and the warm bed and the sound of his breathing.

‘I can’t even remember getting here.’ He looks off to the side, his face faintly lit by the streetlights, frowning. I watch as memories of the previous

day land softly, a silent, mental *Oh. Right.*

His head turns. His mouth, inches from mine. His breath, warm and sweet. 'I missed you, Louisa Clark.'

I want to tell him then. I want to tell him that I don't know what I feel. I want him but I'm frightened to want him. I don't want my happiness to be entirely dependent on somebody else's, to be a hostage to fortunes I cannot control.

His eyes are on my face, reading me. 'Stop thinking,' he says.

He pulls me to him, and I relax. This man spends each day out here, on the bridge between life and death. He understands. 'You think too much.'

His hand slides down the side of my face. I turn towards him, an involuntary reflex, and put my lips against his palm. 'Just live?' I whisper.

He nods, and then he kisses me, long and slow and sweet, until my body arches and I am just need and want and longing.

His voice is low in my ear. My name, pulling me in. He makes it sound like something precious.

The next three days were a blurred mass of stolen nights and brief meetings. I missed Idealization Week in the Moving On Circle because he turned up at the flat just as I was leaving and we somehow ended up an urgent mess of arms and legs, waiting for my egg-timer to go off so that he could dress and race to pick Jake up on time. Twice he was waiting for me when I returned from my shift, and with his lips on my neck, his big hands on my hips, the indignities of the Shamrock and Clover were, if not forgotten, swept aside along with last night's empties.

I wanted to resist him, but I couldn't. I was giddy, diverted, sleepless. I got cystitis and didn't care. I hummed my way through work, flirted with the businessmen, and smiled cheerfully at Richard's complaints. My happiness offended my manager: I could see it in his chewed cheek, the way he sought ever more feeble misdemeanours for which to tell me off.

I cared about none of it. I sang in the shower, lay awake dreaming. I wore my old dresses, my brightly coloured cardigans and satin pumps, and let myself be enclosed in a bubble of happiness, aware that bubbles only ever existed for so long before they popped anyway.

'I told Jake,' he said. He had half an hour's break, and he and Donna had stopped outside my flat with lunch before I went off for a late shift. I sat beside him in the front seat of the ambulance.

‘You told him what?’ He had made mozzarella, cherry tomato and basil sandwiches. The tomatoes, grown in his garden, burst in little explosions of flavour in my mouth. He was appalled at how I ate when I was alone.

‘That you’d thought I was his dad. He laughed more than I’ve seen him laugh for months.’

‘You didn’t tell him I told you his dad cried after sex, right?’

‘I knew a man who did that once,’ said Donna. ‘But he really sobbed. It got sort of embarrassing. The first time I thought I’d broken his penis.’

I turned to her, open-mouthed.

‘It’s a thing. Really. We’ve had a couple in the rig, haven’t we?’

‘We have. You’d be amazed at the coital injuries we see.’ He nodded at my sandwich, which was still on my lap. ‘I’ll tell you when your mouth’s not full.’

‘Coital injuries. Great. Because there aren’t enough things in life to worry about.’

His gaze slid sideways as he bit into his sandwich, so that I blushed.

‘Trust me. I’d let you know.’

‘Just so we’re straight, my old mucker,’ said Donna, offering up one of her ever-present energy drinks, ‘I am so totally not going to be your first responder for that one.’

I liked being in the cab. Sam and Donna had the no-nonsense wry manner of those who had seen pretty much every human condition, and treated it, too. They were funny and dark, and I felt oddly at home wedged between them, as if my life, with all its strangeness, was actually pretty normal.

These were the things I learned in the space of several snatched lunch hours:

- Almost no men or women over the age of seventy would complain about their pain or their treatment, even if a limb were actually hanging off.
- Those same elderly men or women would almost always apologize for ‘making a fuss’.
- That the term ‘Patient PFO’ was not scientific terminology but ‘Patient Pissed and Fell Over’.

- Pregnant women rarely gave birth in the back of ambulances. (I was quite disappointed by that one.)
- That nobody used the term ‘ambulance driver’ any more. Especially not ambulance drivers.
- There would always be a handful of men who would answer, when asked to describe how much pain they were in out of ten, with ‘eleven’.

But what came through most, when Sam arrived back after a long shift, was the bleakness: solitary pensioners; obese men glued to a television screen, too large even to try to get themselves up and down their own stairs; young mothers who spoke no English, confined to their flats with a million small children, unsure how to call for help when it was needed; and the depressed, the chronically ill, the unloved.

Some days, he said, it felt like a virus: you had to scrub the melancholy from your skin along with the scent of antiseptic. And then there were the suicides, the lives ended under trains or in silent bathrooms, their bodies often unnoticed for weeks or months until somebody remarked on the smell, or wondered why so-and-so’s post was now spilling out of their pigeonhole.

‘Do you ever get frightened?’

He lay, oversized, in my little bath. The water had turned faintly pink with the blood from a patient’s gunshot wound that had leaked all over him. I was a little surprised at how swiftly I had got used to having a naked man in the vicinity. Especially one who could move by himself.

‘You can’t do this job if you’re frightened,’ he said simply.

He had been in the army before he’d joined the paramedics; it was not an unusual career arc. ‘They like us because we don’t scare easy, and we’ve seen it all. Mind you, some of those drunk kids scare me far more than the Taliban ever did.’

I sat on the loo seat beside him and stared at his body in the discoloured water. Even with his size and strength, I shivered.

‘Hey,’ he said, seeing something pass across my face, and reached out a hand to me. ‘It’s fine, really. I have a very good nose for trouble.’ He closed his fingers around mine. ‘It’s not a great job for relationships, though. My last girlfriend couldn’t cope with it. The hours. Nights. The mess.’

‘The pink bathwater.’

‘Yeah. Sorry about that. The showers weren’t working at the station. I should really have gone home first.’ He looked at me in a way that showed me there had been no chance of him going home first. He pulled the plug to let some of the water drain away, then turned on the taps for more.

‘So who was she, your last girlfriend?’ I kept my voice level. I was not going to be one of *those* women, even if he had turned out not to be one of those men.

‘Iona. Travel agent. Sweet girl.’

‘But you weren’t in love with her.’

‘Why do you say that?’

‘Nobody ever says “sweet girl” about someone they were in love with. It’s like the whole “we’ll still be friends” thing. It means you didn’t feel enough.’

He was briefly amused. ‘So what would I have said if I had been in love with her?’

‘You would have looked very serious, and said, “Karen. Complete nightmare,” or shut down and gone all “I don’t want to talk about it.” ’

‘You’re probably right.’ He thought for a bit. ‘If I’m honest I didn’t really want to feel much after my sister died. Being with Ellen for the last few months, helping look after her, kind of knocked me sideways.’ He glanced at me. ‘Cancer can be a pretty brutal way to go. Jake’s dad fell apart. Some people do. So I figured they needed me there. If I’m honest, I probably only held it together myself because we couldn’t all go to pieces.’ We sat in silence for a moment. I couldn’t tell if his eyes had gone a bit red from grief or soap.

‘Anyway. So, yes. Probably not much of a boyfriend back then. So who was yours?’ he said, when he finally turned back to me.

‘Will.’

‘Of course. Nobody since?’

‘Nobody I want to talk about.’ I shuddered.

‘Everyone’s allowed their own way back, Louisa. Don’t beat yourself up about it.’

His skin was hot and wet, making it hard for me to hold on to his fingers. I released them, and he began to wash his hair. I sat and watched him, letting the mood lift, enjoying the bunched muscles in his shoulders, the

gleam of his wet skin. I liked the way he washed his hair: vigorously, with a kind of matter-of-factness, shaking off the excess water like a dog.

‘Oh. I had a job interview,’ I said, when he finished. ‘For a thing in New York.’

‘New York.’ He raised an eyebrow.

‘I won’t get it.’

‘Shame. I’ve always wanted an excuse to go to New York.’ He slid slowly under the water so that only his mouth remained. It broke into a slow smile. ‘But you’d get to keep the pixie outfit, yes?’

I felt the mood shift. And, for no reason at all other than that he didn’t expect it, I climbed fully clothed into the bath and kissed him as he laughed and spluttered, suddenly glad of his solidity in a world where it was so easy to fall.

I finally made an effort to sort out the flat. On my day off I bought an armchair, and a coffee-table, and a small framed print, which I hung near the television, and those things somehow conspired to suggest someone might actually live there. I bought new bedding and two cushions and hung up all my vintage clothes in the wardrobe so that opening it now revealed a riot of pattern and colour, instead of several pairs of cheap jeans and a too-short Lurex dress. I managed to turn my anonymous little flat into something that felt, if not quite like a home, vaguely welcoming.

By some beneficence of the shift-scheduling gods, Sam and I both had a day off. Eighteen uninterrupted hours in which he did not have to listen to a siren, and I did not have to listen to the sound of pan pipes or complaints about dry-roasted peanuts. Time spent with Sam, I noted, seemed to go twice as fast as the hours I spent alone. I had pondered the million things we could do together, then dismissed half of them as too ‘couple-y’. I wondered whether our spending so much time together was wise.

I texted Lily one more time. *Lily, please get in touch. I know you’re mad at me, but just call. Your garden is looking beautiful! I need you to show me how to look after it, and what to do with the tomato plants, which have got really tall (is this right?). Maybe after we could go out dancing? x* I pressed send and stared at the little screen just as the doorbell rang.

‘Hey.’ He filled my doorway, holding a toolbox in one hand and a bag of groceries in the other.

‘Oh, my God,’ I said. ‘You’re like the ultimate female fantasy.’

‘Shelves,’ he said, deadpan. ‘You need shelves.’

‘Oh, baby. Keep talking.’

‘And home-cooked food.’

‘That’s it. I just came.’

He laughed and dropped the tools in the hallway and kissed me, and when we finally untangled ourselves, he walked through to the kitchen. ‘I thought we could go to the pictures. You know one of the greatest benefits to shift-working is empty matinées, right?’

I checked my phone.

‘But nothing with blood in it. I get a bit tired of blood.’

When I looked up he was watching me.

‘What? Don’t fancy it? Or is that going to stamp all over your plans for *Zombie Flesh Eaters Fifteen*? ... What?’

I frowned, and dropped my hand to my side. ‘I can’t get hold of Lily.’

‘I thought you said she’d gone home?’

‘She did. But she won’t take my calls. I think she’s really upset with me.’

‘Her friends stole your stuff. You’re allowed to be the one who’s upset.’

He started to pull things out of the bag, lettuces, tomatoes, avocados, eggs, herbs, stacking them neatly in my near-empty fridge. He looked up at me as I texted her again. ‘Come on. She could have dropped her phone, left it in some club, or run out of credit. You know what teenagers are like. Or she’s just throwing a massive strop. Sometimes you need to let them work it out of their system.’

I took his hand and shut the fridge door. ‘I need to show you something.’ His eyes lit up briefly. ‘Not that, no, you bad man. That will have to wait till later.’

Sam stood on the rooftop and gazed around him at the flowers. ‘And you had no idea?’

‘None at all.’

He sat down heavily on the bench. I sat next to him and we both stared at the little garden.

‘I feel awful,’ I said. ‘I basically accused her of destroying everything she went near. And all the time she was creating this.’

He stooped to feel the leaves on a tomato plant, then straightened, shaking his head. ‘Okay. So we’ll go talk to her.’

‘Really?’

‘Yeah. Lunch first. Then cinema. Then we’ll turn up on her doorstep. That way she won’t be able to avoid you.’ He took my hand and raised it to his lips. ‘Hey. Don’t look so worried. The garden is good news. It shows that her head’s not in a totally bad place.’

He released my hand and I squinted at him. ‘How come you always make everything better?’

‘I just don’t like seeing you sad.’

I couldn’t tell him that I wasn’t sad when I was with him. I couldn’t tell him that he made me so happy I was afraid of it. I thought of how I liked having his food in my fridge, how I glanced at my phone twenty times a day waiting for his messages, how I conjured his naked body in my imagination in the quiet minutes at work and then had to think very hard about floor polish or till receipts just to stop myself glowing.

Slow down, said a warning voice. *Don’t get too close.*

His eyes softened. ‘You have a sweet smile, Louisa Clark. It’s one of the several hundred things I like about you.’

I let myself gaze back at him for a minute. *This man*, I thought. And then I slapped my hands heavily on my knees. ‘C’mon,’ I said briskly. ‘Let’s go watch a movie.’

The cinema was almost empty. We sat side by side at the back in a seat where someone had knocked out the armrest, and Sam fed me popcorn from a cardboard bucket the size of a dustbin, and I tried not to think about the weight of his hand resting on my bare leg, because when I did I frequently lost track of what was happening with the plot.

The film was an American comedy about two mismatched cops who find themselves mistaken for criminals. It wasn’t very funny, but I laughed anyway. Sam’s fingers appeared in front of me, bearing a bulbous knobble of salted popcorn and I took it, and another, then, as an afterthought, kept hold of his fingers between my teeth. He looked at me and shook his head, slowly.

I finished the popcorn and swallowed. ‘Nobody will see,’ I whispered.

He raised an eyebrow. ‘I’m too old for this,’ he murmured. But when I turned his face to mine in the hot, dark air, and started to kiss him, he dropped the popcorn and his hand slid slowly up my back.

And then my phone rang. There was a hiss of disapproval from the two people at the front. ‘Sorry. Sorry, you two!’ (Given there were only four of

us in the cinema.) I scrambled off Sam's lap and answered. A number I didn't recognize.

'Louisa?'

It took me a second to register her voice.

'Just give me a minute.' I pulled a face at Sam, and made my way out.

'Sorry, Mrs Traynor. I just had to – Are you still there? Hello?'

The foyer was empty, the cordoned-off queue areas deserted, the frozen-drinks machine churning its coloured ice listlessly behind the counter.

'Oh, thank goodness. Louisa? I wondered if I could speak to Lily.'

I stood, with the phone pressed to my ear.

'I've been thinking about what happened the other week and I'm so sorry. I must have seemed ...' She hesitated. 'Look, I was wondering if you thought she would agree to see me.'

'Mrs Traynor –'

'I'd like to explain to her. For the last year or so I've ... well, I've not been myself. I've been on these tablets and they make me rather dim-witted. And I was so taken aback to find you on my doorstep, and then I simply couldn't believe what you both were telling me. It all seemed so unlikely. But I ... Well, I've spoken to Steven and he confirmed the whole thing and I've been sitting here for days and digesting it all and I just think ... Will had a *daughter*. *I have a granddaughter*. I keep saying the words. Sometimes I think I dreamed it.'

I listened to the uncharacteristic flurry of her words. 'I know,' I said. 'I felt like that, too.'

'I can't stop thinking about her. I do so want to meet her properly. Do you think she'd agree to see me again?'

'Mrs Traynor, she's not staying with me any more. But yes.' I ran my fingers through my hair. 'Yes, of course I'll ask her.'

I couldn't focus on the rest of the film. In the end, perhaps realizing that I was simply staring at a moving screen, Sam suggested we leave. We stood in the car park by his bike and I told him what she'd said.

'There, see?' he said, as if I had done something to be proud of. 'Let's go.'

He waited on the bike across the road as I knocked on the door. I lifted my chin, determined that this time I would not let Tanya Houghton-Miller

intimidate me. I glanced back, and Sam nodded encouragingly.

The door opened. Tanya was dressed in a chocolate linen dress and Grecian sandals. She looked me up and down as she had when we'd first met, as if my own wardrobe had failed some invisible test. (This was a little annoying as I was wearing my favourite checked cotton pinafore dress.) Her smile stayed on her lips for just a nanosecond, then fell away. 'Louisa.'

'Sorry to turn up unannounced, Mrs Houghton-Miller.'

'Has something happened?'

I blinked. 'Well, yes, actually.' I pushed my hair from the side of my face. 'I've had a call from Mrs Traynor, Will's mother. I'm sorry to bother you with this, but she'd really like to get in contact with Lily, and as she's not picking up her phone, I wondered if you'd mind asking her to call me?'

Tanya gazed at me from under perfectly plucked brows.

I kept my face neutral. 'Or maybe we could have a quick chat with her.'

There was a short silence. 'Why would you think *I* would ask her?'

I took a breath, picking my words carefully. 'I know you have strong feelings about the Traynor family, but I do think it would be in Lily's interests. I don't know if she told you but they had a rather difficult first meeting the other week and Mrs Traynor would really like the chance to start again.'

'She can do what she wants, Louisa. But I don't know why you're expecting me to get involved.'

I tried to keep my voice polite. 'Um ... because you're her mother?'

'Whom she hasn't bothered to contact in more than a week.'

I stood very still. Something cold and hard settled in my stomach. 'What did you just say?'

'Lily. Hasn't bothered to contact me. I thought at least she might come and say hello after we got back from holiday but, no, that's plainly beyond her. Suiting herself, as usual.' She extended a hand to examine her fingernails.

'Mrs Houghton-Miller, she was meant to be with you.'

'What?'

'Lily. Was moving back in with you. When you got home from your holiday. She left my flat ... ten days ago.'



CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

We stood in Tanya Houghton-Miller's immaculate kitchen and I stared at her shiny coffee machine with 108 knobs, which had probably cost more than my car, and ran through the previous week's events for the umpteenth time.

'It was around half twelve. I gave her twenty pounds for a taxi and asked her to leave her key. I just assumed she'd come home.' I felt sick. I walked the length of the breakfast bar and back again, my brain racing. 'I should have checked. But she tended to come and go as she pleased. And we ... well, we'd had a bit of a row.'

Sam stood by the door, rubbing his brow. 'And neither of you has heard anything from her since.'

'I've texted her four or five times,' I said. 'I just assumed she was still angry with me.'

Tanya hadn't offered us coffee. She strolled to the stairwell, peered upstairs, then glanced at her watch, as if she were waiting for us to go. She did not look like a parent who had just discovered her child was missing. Periodically I heard the dull roar of a vacuum-cleaner.

'Mrs Houghton-Miller, has anyone here heard from her at all? Can you tell from your phone whether she's even read her texts?'

'I told you,' she said. Her voice was strangely calm. 'I told you this was what she was like. But you wouldn't listen.'

'I think we –'

She lifted a hand, stopping Sam. 'This is not the first time. Oh, no. She disappeared for days before, when she was meant to be at boarding-school. I blame them, of course. They were meant to know exactly where she was at all times. They only rang us when she'd been gone forty-eight hours and then we had to get the police involved. Apparently one of the girls in her dorm had lied for her. Why they couldn't tell who was and who wasn't there is completely beyond me, especially given the ridiculous fees we pay. Francis was all for suing them. He was called out of his annual board meeting to deal with it. It was a huge embarrassment.'

Upstairs there was a crash and somebody started to cry. Tanya walked to the kitchen door. 'Lena! Take them out to the park, for goodness' sake!' She came back into the kitchen. 'You know she gets drunk. She takes drugs. She stole my Mappin & Webb diamond earrings. She won't admit it, but she did. They were worth thousands. I have no idea what she did with them. She's taken a digital camera, too.'

I thought back to my missing jewellery and something in me tightened uncomfortably.

'So, yes. This is all rather predictable. I did tell you. And now, if you'll excuse me, I really have to go and sort the boys out. They're having a difficult day.'

'But you'll call the police, yes? She's sixteen years old and it's been almost ten days.'

'They won't be interested. Not once they know who it is.' Tanya held up a slender finger. 'Expelled from two schools for truanting. Cautioned for possession of a class-A drug. Drunk and disorderly. Shoplifting. What's the phrase? My daughter has "form". To be perfectly frank, even if the police do find her and bring her back here, she'll simply up and go again when it suits her.'

A wire had tightened across my chest, constricting my breath. Where would she have gone? Was that boy, the one who hung around outside my flat, involved? The nightclubbers who had been with Lily that drunken night? How had I been so distracted?

'Let's call them regardless. She's still very young.'

'No. I do not want the police involved. Francis is having a very tricky time at work right now. He's fighting to retain his place on the board. If they get wind that he's involved in some sort of police business that will be it.'

Sam's jaw tightened. He took a moment before he spoke. 'Mrs Houghton-Miller, your daughter is vulnerable. I really think it's time to get someone else involved.'

'If you call them I'll simply explain to them what I've just told you.'

'Mrs Houghton-Miller –'

'How many times have you met her, Mr Fielding?' She leaned back against the cooker. 'You know her better than I do, do you? You've been kept up nights waiting for her to come home? You've lost sleep? Had to

explain her behaviour to teachers and police officers? Apologize to shop assistants for things she's stolen? Bail out her credit card?'

'Some of the most chaotic kids are those most at risk.'

'My daughter is a talented manipulator. She will be with one of her friends. Just as she has been before. I will guarantee that within the next day or two Lily will turn up here, drunk and screeching in the middle of the night, or knocking at Louisa's door, or begging for money, and you will probably have reason to wish she never had. Someone will let her in and she'll be sorry and contrite and terribly sad, and then a few days later, she'll bring a bunch of friends home or steal something. And the whole sorry cycle will revolve again.'

She pushed her golden hair back from her face. She and Sam stared at each other. 'I've had to undergo counselling to cope with the chaos my daughter has brought into my life, Mr Fielding. It's hard enough coping with her brothers and their ... behavioural difficulties. But one of the things you learn in therapy is that there comes a point when you have to take care of yourself. Lily is old enough to make her own decisions –'

'She's a child,' I said.

'Oh, yes – that's right. A child *you* turned out of your apartment some time after midnight.' Tanya Houghton-Miller held my gaze with the complacency of someone who had just been proven right. 'Not everything is black and white. Much as we would like it to be.'

'You're not even worried, are you?' I said.

She held my gaze. 'No, frankly. I've been here too many times before.' I made to speak again but she was ahead of me. 'Quite the saviour complex, haven't you, Louisa? Well, my daughter doesn't need saving. And if she did, I wouldn't be hugely convinced by your record so far.'

Sam's arm was around me even before I was able to take a breath. My retort formed, toxic, in my mouth, but she had already turned away. 'C'mon,' he said, propelling me out into the hallway. 'Let's go.'

We drove around the West End for several hours, slowing to peer at the groups of catcalling, staggering girls, and, more soberly, at the rough sleepers, then parked up and walked side by side along the dark archways under bridges. We put our heads around the doors of nightclubs, asking if anyone had seen the girl in the photographs on my mobile phone. We went to the club where she had taken me dancing, and to a couple more that Sam

said were notorious haunts for under-age drinkers. We passed bus stops and fast-food joints, and the further we went the more I thought how ridiculous it was to try to find her among the thousands milling around the humming streets of central London. She could have been anywhere. She seemed to be everywhere. I texted her again, twice, to tell her we were urgently looking for her, and when we got back to my flat Sam rang various hospitals just to be sure she hadn't been admitted.

Finally we sat on my little sofa and ate some toast, he made me a cup of tea and we sat in silence for a bit.

'I feel like the worst parent in the world. And I'm not even a parent.'

He leaned forward, his elbows on his knees. 'You can't blame yourself.'

'Yes, I can. What kind of person turfs a sixteen-year-old out of their flat in the small hours without checking where she's actually going?' I closed my eyes. 'I mean, just because she's disappeared before doesn't mean she'll be okay now, does it? She'll be like one of those teenage runaways who disappear and nobody ever hears of them again until some dog out walking digs up their bones in the woods.'

'Louisa.'

'I should have been stronger. I should have understood her better. I should have thought harder about how young she is. Was. Oh, God, if something's happened I'll never forgive myself. And out there right now some innocent dog-walker has no idea that he's about to have his life ruined —'

'Louisa.' Sam put his hand on my leg. 'Stop. You're going round in circles. Irritating as she is, it's entirely possible Tanya Houghton-Miller's right and Lily will coast in or ring your bell in about three hours' time and we'll all feel like fools and forget what's happened until it all starts again.'

'But why won't she answer her phone? She must know I'm worried.'

'Perhaps that's why she's ignoring you.' He gave me a wry look. 'She may be enjoying making you sweat a little. Look, there's not much more we can do tonight. And I've got to go. I have an early shift.' He cleared away the plates and put them in the sink, leaning back against the kitchen cabinets.

'Sorry,' I said. 'Not exactly the most fun start to a relationship.'

He lowered his chin. 'This is a relationship now?'

I felt myself colour. 'Well, I didn't mean —'

‘I’m kidding.’ He reached out a hand and pulled me to him. ‘I quite enjoy your determined attempts to convince me you’re basically just using me for sex.’

He smelt good. Even when he smelt faintly of anaesthetic, he smelt good. He kissed the top of my head. ‘We’ll find her,’ he said, as he left.

After he’d gone, I climbed up onto the roof. I sat in the dark, inhaling the scent of the jasmine she’d trained up the edge of the water tank, and ran my hand softly over the tiny purple heads of the aubretia that tumbled over the terracotta planters. I looked over the parapet, scanned the winking streets of the city and my legs didn’t even tremble. I texted her again, then got ready for bed, feeling the silence of the flat close in around me.

I checked my phone for the millionth time, and then my email, just in case. Nothing. But there was one from Nathan:

Congratulations! Old man Gopnik told me this morning he’s going to offer you the job!
See you in NY, mate!



CHAPTER NINETEEN

Lily

Peter is waiting again. Out of the window, she sees him standing against his car. He spots her, gestures up and mouths, 'You owe me.'

Lily opens the window, glances across the road to where Samir is putting out a fresh box of oranges. 'Leave me alone, Peter.'

'You know what'll happen ...'

'I've given you enough. Just leave me alone, okay?'

'Bad move, Lily.' He raises an eyebrow. He waits just long enough for her to feel uncomfortable. Lou will be home in half an hour. He hangs around so often she's pretty sure he knows this. Eventually he climbs back into his car, and pulls out onto the main road without looking. As he drives off he holds his phone out of the driver's window. A message: *Bad move, Lily.*

Spin the bottle. Such an innocent-sounding game. It had been her and four girls from her school and they had come up to London on an exeat. They had stolen lipsticks from Boots and bought too-short skirts in Top Shop and got into nightclubs for free because they were young and cute and doormen didn't ask too many questions if there were five of you and you were young and cute, and inside, over rum and Cokes, they had met Peter and his friends.

They had ended up in someone's flat in Marylebone at two a.m. She couldn't entirely remember how they had got there. Everyone was sitting in a circle, smoking and drinking. She had said yes to everything that was offered her. Rihanna on the music system. A blue beanbag that smelt of Febreze. Nicole had been ill in the bathroom, the idiot. Time had slipped; two thirty, three seventeen, four ... She lost track. Then someone had suggested Truth or Dare.

The bottle spun, careered into an ashtray, tipping butts and ash onto the carpet. Someone's truth, the girl she didn't know: on holiday the previous year she had engaged in phone sex with her ex-boyfriend while her

grandmother slept in the twin bed beside her. The others reeled in fake horror. Lily had laughed.

‘Niche,’ said someone.

Peter had watched her the whole time. She had been flattered at first: he was the best-looking boy there by miles. A man, even. When he looked at her she refused to drop her eyes. She wasn’t going to be like the other girls.

‘Spin!’

She had shrugged when it pointed to her. ‘Dare,’ she had said. ‘Always dare.’

‘Lily never says no to anything,’ said Jemima. Now she wonders whether there was something in the way she had looked at Peter when she said it.

‘Okay. You know what that means.’

‘Seriously?’

‘You can’t do that!’ Pippa was holding her hands to her face in the way she did when she was being dramatic.

‘Truth, then.’

‘Nah. I hate truth.’ So what? She knew these boys would be chicken. She stood, nonchalantly. ‘Where. Here?’

‘Oh, my God, Lily.’

‘Spin the bottle,’ said one of the boys.

It hadn’t occurred to her to be nervous. She was a bit woozy and, anyway, she quite liked standing there, unbothered, while the other girls clapped and squealed and acted like idiots. They were such fakes. The same girls who would whack anyone on the hockey pitch and talk about politics and what careers in law and marine biology they were aiming for became stupid and giggly and girly in the presence of boys, flicking their hair and doing their lipstick, like they had spontaneously filleted out the interesting parts of themselves.

‘*Peter ...*’

‘Oh, my God. Pete, mate. It’s you.’

The boys, all catcalling and crowing to hide their disappointment, or perhaps relief, that it wasn’t them. Peter, climbing to his feet, his narrow cat’s eyes meeting hers. Different from the others: his accent spoke of somewhere tougher.

‘Here?’

She shrugged. ‘I don’t mind.’

‘Next door.’ He gestured towards the bedroom.

She stepped neatly over the girls' legs as they walked through to the next room. One of the girls grabbed at her ankle, telling her not to, and she shook her off. She walked with a faint swagger, feeling their eyes on her as she left. *Dare. Always dare.*

Peter closed the door behind him and she glanced around her. The bed was rumpled, a horrid patterned duvet that you could tell from five yards hadn't been washed in ages, and left a faint musty trace in the atmosphere. There was a pile of dirty laundry in the corner, a full ashtray by the bed. The room fell silent, the voices outside temporarily stilled.

She lifted her chin. Pushed her hair back from her face. 'You really want to do this?' she said.

He smiled then, a slow, mocking smile. 'I knew you'd back out.'

'Who says I'm backing out?'

But she didn't want to do it. She didn't see his handsome features any more, just the cold glitter in his eyes, the unpleasant twist to his mouth. He put his hands on his zipper.

They stood there for a minute.

'It's fine if you don't want to do it. We'll go outside and say you're chicken.'

'I never said I wouldn't do it.'

'So what *are* you saying?'

She can't think. A low buzzing has started up in the back of her head. She wishes she hadn't come in here.

He stifles a theatrical yawn. 'Getting bored, Lily.'

A frantic knocking on the door. Jemima's voice. 'Lily – you don't have to do it. C'mon. We can go home now.'

'You don't *have* to do it, Lily.' His voice is an imitation, mocking.

A calculation. What's the worst that will happen – two minutes, at worst? Two minutes out of her life. She will not be a chicken. She will show him. She will show them all.

He is holding a bottle of Jack Daniel's loosely in one hand. She takes it from him, opens it and swigs from it twice, her eyes locked on his. Then she hands it back and reaches for his belt.

Pictures or it didn't happen.

She hears the boy's catcalling voice through the thumping in her ears, through the pain in her scalp as he grips her hair too tight. It is too late, by

then. Way too late.

She hears the camera-phone click just as she looks up.

One pair of earrings. Fifty pounds in cash. One hundred. Weeks later and the demands keep coming. He sends her texts: *I wonder what would happen if I put this on Facebook?*

She wants to cry when she sees the picture. He sends it to her again and again: her face, her eyes bloodshot, smudged with mascara. That thing in her mouth. When Louisa comes home she has to stuff the phone under the sofa cushions. It has become radioactive, a toxic thing she has to keep close.

I wonder what your friends would think.

The other girls don't talk to her afterwards. They know what she did because Peter flashed the picture to everyone as soon as they walked back into the party, ostentatiously adjusting his zipper, long after he had to. She had to pretend she didn't care. The girls stared at her and then looked away and she had known as soon as their eyes met hers that their tales of BJ's and sex with unseen boyfriends had been fiction. They were fakes. They had lied about everything.

Nobody thought she was brave. Nobody admired her for not being chicken. She was just Lily, the slag, a girl with a cock in her mouth. It made her stomach go into knots even to think about it. She had swigged more Jack Daniel's and told them all to go to hell.

Meet me at McDonald's Tottenham Court Road.

By then her mother had changed the locks to her house. She couldn't take money from her purse any more. They had blocked her access to her savings account.

I haven't got anything else.

Do you think I'm a mug, Little Rich Girl?

Her mother had never liked the Mappin & Webb earrings. Lily had hoped she wouldn't even notice they were gone. She had made fake cooing faces at Fuckface Francis when he gave them to her, but she had muttered afterwards that she really didn't understand why he'd bought her heart-shaped diamonds when everybody knew they were common, and a pendant shape was far better against her bone structure.

Peter had looked at the glittering earrings as if she had handed him small change, then tucked them into his pocket. He had been eating a Big Mac

and there was mayonnaise in the corner of his mouth. She felt nauseous every time she saw him.

‘Want to come and meet my mates?’

‘No.’

‘Want a drink?’

She shook her head. ‘That’s it. That’s the last thing. Those earrings are worth thousands.’

He had pulled a face. ‘I want cash next time. Proper cash. I know where you live, Lily. I know you got it.’

She felt as if she would never be free of him. He texted her at odd hours, waking her up, keeping her from sleep. That picture, again and again. She saw it in negative, burned onto her retinas. She stopped going to school. She got drunk with strangers, went out clubbing long after she really wanted to. Anything not to be alone with her thoughts and the relentless *ping* of her phone. She had moved to where he couldn’t find her and he had found her, parking his car for hours outside Louisa’s flat, a silent message. She even thought, a few times, about telling Louisa. But what could Louisa do? Half the time she was like a one-woman disaster area herself. So Lily’s mouth would open and nothing would come out, then Louisa would start rattling on about meeting her grandmother or whether she had eaten something and she had realized she was on her own.

Sometimes Lily lay awake and thought about what it would have been like if her dad had been there. She could picture him in her head. He would have walked outside, grabbed Peter by his neck and told him never to come near his little girl again. He would have put his arms around her and told her it was all okay, that she was safe.

Except he wouldn’t. Because he was just an angry quadriplegic who hadn’t even wanted to be alive. And he would have looked at the pictures and been disgusted.

She couldn’t blame him.

The last time, when she’d had nothing to bring him, he had shouted at her on a pavement behind Carnaby Street, calling her *worthless, a whore, a stupid little skank*. He had pulled up in his car and she had drunk two double whiskies because she was afraid to see him. When he’d started shouting at her and saying she was lying, she had started to cry.

‘Louisa’s chucked me out. My mum’s chucked me out. I don’t have anything.’

People hurried past, their eyes averted. Nobody stopped. Nobody said anything, because a man shouting at a drunk girl in Soho on a Friday night was nothing out of the ordinary. Peter swore, and turned on his heel, as if he was leaving, except she knew he wouldn't. And then the big black car had stopped in the middle of the street and reversed, its white lights glowing. The electric window hummed its way down. 'Lily?'

It took her a few seconds to recognize him. Mr Garside from her stepfather's business. His boss? A partner? He looked at her, and then at Peter. 'Are you all right?'

She glanced at Peter, then nodded.

He didn't believe her. She could tell. He had pulled over to the side of the road, in front of Peter's car, and walked across slowly in his dark suit. He had an air of authority, like nothing was going to faze him. She remembered, randomly, her mother talking about him having a helicopter. 'Do you need a ride home, Lily?'

Peter lifted his hand with the phone in it, just an inch. Just so she knew. And she opened her mouth and it came out. 'He has a bad picture of me on his phone and he's threatening to show it to everyone and he wants money and I don't have any left. I've given him what I can and I just don't have anything left. Please help me.'

Peter's eyes widened. He hadn't expected that. But she didn't care what happened. She just felt desperate, and tired, and she didn't want to carry all this by herself any more.

Mr Garside regarded Peter for a moment. Peter stiffened his shoulders and straightened, as if he were considering whether to run for his car.

'Is this true?' Mr Garside said.

'It's not a crime to have pictures of girls on your phone.' Peter smirked, an act of bravado.

'I'm well aware of that. It is, however, a crime to use them to extort money.' Mr Garside's voice was low and calm, as if it were perfectly reasonable to be discussing someone's naked pictures in the middle of the street. He moved his hand to his inside pocket. 'So what will it take to make you go away?'

'What?'

'Your phone. How much do you want for it?'

Lily's breath stopped in her throat. She looked from one man to the other. Peter was staring at him in disbelief.

‘I’m offering you cash for the phone. On the basis that this is the only copy of that photograph.’

‘I’m not selling my phone.’

‘Then I have to advise you, young man, that I’ll be contacting the police and identifying you through your car registration. And I have a lot of friends in the police force. Quite high-up friends.’ He smiled a smile that wasn’t really a smile at all.

Across the road a bunch of people spilled out of a restaurant, laughing. Peter looked at her and back at Mr Garside. He lifted his chin. ‘Five grand.’

Mr Garside reached into his inside pocket. He shook his head. ‘I don’t think so.’ He pulled out his wallet and counted out a bundle of notes. ‘I think this will do. It sounds as though you’ve already been amply rewarded. The phone, please?’

It was as if Peter had been hypnotised. He hesitated for just a moment, then handed Mr Garside his phone. Just like that. Mr Garside checked that the SIM card was in it, tucked it into his inside pocket, and opened the car door for Lily. ‘I think it’s time for you to leave, Lily.’

She climbed in, like an obedient child, hearing the solid *thunk* of the car door as it closed behind her. And then they were off, gliding smoothly down the narrow street, leaving Peter shell-shocked – she could see him in the wing mirror – as if he, too, couldn’t believe what had just happened.

‘Are you all right?’ Mr Garside didn’t look at her as he spoke.

‘Is ... is that it?’

He glanced sideways, then back at the road. ‘I think so, yes.’

She couldn’t believe it. She couldn’t believe the thing that had hung over her for weeks could be fixed just like that. She turned to him, suddenly anxious. ‘Please don’t tell my mum and Francis.’

He frowned slightly. ‘If that’s what you want.’

She let out a long, silent breath. ‘Thank you,’ she said quietly.

He patted her knee. ‘Nasty lad. You need to be careful with your friends, Lily.’ He moved his hand back onto the automatic gearstick before she had even registered its presence.

He hadn’t batted an eyelid when she had told him she had nowhere to stay. He had driven her to a hotel in Bayswater and spoken quietly to the receptionist, who had handed her a room key. She was relieved he hadn’t

suggested taking her to his house: she didn't want to explain herself to anyone else.

'I'll pick you up tomorrow when you're sober,' he said, tucking his wallet into his jacket pocket.

She had walked heavily up to Room 311, lain down on the bed fully clothed and slept for fourteen hours.

He called to say he would meet her for breakfast. She showered, took some clothes out of her rucksack and ran an iron over them in the hope that she looked a little more presentable. She was not good at ironing – Lena had done that sort of thing.

When she came downstairs to the restaurant he was already sitting there, reading a paper, a half-drunk cup of coffee in front of him. He was older than she remembered, his hair thinning on top, a faint crêpiness to the skin of his neck; the last time she had seen him had been at a company event at the races where Francis had drunk too much and her mother had hissed at him furiously whenever nobody else was about, and Mr Garside, catching it, had raised his eyebrows at Lily, as if to say, 'Parents, eh?'

She slid into the chair opposite him and he lowered his newspaper. 'Aha. How are you today?'

She felt embarrassed, as if last night she had been overly histrionic. As if it had all been a fuss over nothing. 'Much better, thank you.'

'Did you sleep well?'

'Very well, thank you.'

He had studied her for a minute over his glasses. 'Very formal.'

She smiled. She didn't know what else to do. It was too weird, being there with her stepdad's work colleague. The waitress offered her coffee and she drank it. She eyed the breakfast buffet, wondering if she was expected to pay. He seemed to sense her discomfort. 'Eat something. Don't worry. It's paid for.' He turned back to his paper.

She wondered whether he would tell her parents. She wondered what he had done with Peter's phone. She hoped he had slowed his big black car on the Thames embankment, lowered his window and hurled it into the swirling currents below. She wanted never to see that picture again. She rose and fetched a croissant with some fruit from the buffet. She was starving.

He sat reading as she ate. She wondered how they looked from outside – like any father and daughter probably. She wondered whether he had children.

‘Don’t you have to be at work?’

He smiled, accepted more coffee from the waitress. ‘I told them I had an important meeting.’ He folded his newspaper neatly and put it down.

She shifted uncomfortably in her seat. ‘I need to get a job.’

‘A job.’ He sat back. ‘Well. What kind of job?’

‘I don’t know. I kind of messed up my exams.’

‘And what do your parents think?’

‘They don’t ... I can’t ... They’re not very happy with me right now. I’ve been staying with friends.’

‘You can’t go back there?’

‘Not right now. My friend isn’t very happy with me either.’

‘Oh, Lily,’ he said, and sighed. He looked out of the window, considering something for a minute, then glanced at his expensive watch. He thought for another moment, then called his office and told someone he was going to be late back from his meeting.

She waited to hear what he had to say next.

‘You finished?’ He put his newspaper into his briefcase, and stood up. ‘Let’s go and make a plan.’

She had not been expecting him to come to the room and was embarrassed by the state of it: the damp towels left on the floor, the television blaring trashy daytime programmes. She dumped the worst of it in the bathroom and shoved what was left of her belongings hastily into her rucksack. He pretended not to notice, just gazed out of the window, then turned back when she sat on the chair, as if he had only just seen the room.

‘It’s not a bad hotel, this,’ he said. ‘I used to stay here when I couldn’t face the drive to Winchester.’

‘Is that where you live?’

‘It’s where my wife lives, yes. My children are long grown-up.’ He put his briefcase on the floor and sat on the edge of the bed. She got up and fetched the complimentary notepad from the bedside table, in case she needed to take notes. Her phone let out a chime and she glanced down. *Lily just call me. Louisa x*

She shoved it into her back pocket and sat down, the notepad on her lap.

‘So what do you think?’

‘That you’re in a tricky position, Lily. You’re a bit young to be getting a job, to be frank. I’m not sure who would hire you.’

‘I’m good at stuff, though. I’m a hard worker. I can garden.’

‘Garden! Well, perhaps you could get work gardening. Whether that’s going to bring in enough for you to support yourself is another matter. Have you got any references? Any holiday jobs?’

‘No. My parents always gave me an allowance.’

‘Mm.’ He tapped his hands on his knees. ‘You’ve had a difficult relationship with your father, haven’t you?’

‘Francis isn’t my real father.’

‘Yes. I’m aware of that. I know you left home some weeks ago. It all seems like a very sad situation. Very sad. You must feel rather isolated.’

She felt the lump swell in her throat and thought for a moment that he was reaching for a handkerchief, but it was then that he reached into his jacket pocket and pulled out a phone. Peter’s phone. He tapped it, once, twice, and she saw a flash of her own image. Her breathing stalled in her chest.

He clicked on it, making it bigger. Her cheeks flooded with colour. He stared at the photograph for what felt like several years. ‘You really have been quite a bad girl, haven’t you?’

Lily’s fingers closed in a fist around the hotel bedspread. She looked up at Mr Garside, her cheeks burning. His eyes didn’t leave the picture.

‘A very bad girl.’ Eventually he looked up at her, his gaze even, his voice soft. ‘I suppose the first thing we need to do is work out how you can repay me for the phone and the hotel room.’

‘But,’ she began, ‘you didn’t say –’

‘Oh, come on, Lily. A live-wire like you? You must know that nothing comes for free.’ He looked down at the image. ‘You must have worked that out a while ago ... You’re obviously good at it.’

Lily’s breakfast rose into her throat.

‘You see, I could be very helpful to you. Give you somewhere to stay until you’re back on your feet, a little leg up the career ladder. You wouldn’t need to do very much in return. *Quid pro quo* – you know that phrase? You did Latin at your school, didn’t you?’

She stood abruptly and reached for her rucksack. His hand shot out and took hold of her arm. With his free hand he tucked the phone slowly back

into his pocket. 'Let's not be hasty about this, Lily. We wouldn't want me to have to show this little picture to your parents, would we? Goodness knows what they would think about what you've been up to.'

Her words stuck in her throat.

He patted the bedspread beside him. 'I would think very carefully about your next move. Now. Why don't we –'

Lily's arm flew back, shaking him off. And then she was wrenching the hotel-room door open and she was gone, feet pumping, racing down the hotel corridor, her bag flying out behind her.

London teemed with life into the small hours. She walked while cars nudged night buses impatiently along main roads, minicabs wove in and out of traffic, men in suits made their way home or sat in glowing office cubicles halfway to the sky, ignoring the cleaners who worked silently around them. She walked with her head low and her rucksack on her shoulder, and when she ate in late-night burger restaurants, she made sure her hood was up and that she had a free newspaper to pretend to read: there was always someone who would sit down at your table and try to get you to talk. *Come on, darling, I'm only being friendly.*

All the while she replayed that morning's events in her head. What had she done? What signal had she sent? Was there something about her that meant everyone assumed she was a whore? The words he had used made her want to cry. She felt herself shrink into her hood, hating him. Hating herself.

She used her student card and rode on underground trains until the atmosphere became drunk and febrile. Then it felt safer to stay above ground. The rest of the time she walked – through the glittering neon lights of Piccadilly, down the lead-dusted length of Marylebone Road, around the pulsing late-night bars of Camden, her stride long, pretending she had somewhere to be, only slowing when her feet began to ache from the unforgiving pavement.

When she got too tired she begged favours. She spent one night at her friend Nina's, but Nina asked too many questions and the sound of her chatting downstairs to her parents while Lily lay, soaking the grime out of her hair in the bath, made her feel like the loneliest person on earth. She left after breakfast, even though Nina's mum said she was welcome to stay another night, gazing at her with concerned maternal eyes. She spent two

nights on the sofa of a girl she had met while clubbing, but there were three men sharing the flat, and she didn't feel relaxed enough to sleep and sat fully clothed, hugging her knees, watching television with the sound turned off until dawn. She spent one night at a Salvation Army hostel, listening to two girls argue in the next-door cubicle, her bag clutched to her chest under the blanket. They said she could have a shower, but she didn't like to leave her bag in the lockers while she got wet. She drank the free soup and left. But mostly she walked, spending the last of her cash on cheap coffee and Egg McMuffins and growing more and more tired and hungry until it was hard to think straight, hard to react quickly when the men in doorways said disgusting things or the staff in the café told her she'd made that one cup of tea last long enough, young lady, and it was time to move on.

And all the while she wondered what her parents were saying at that moment, and what Mr Garside would say about her when he showed them the pictures. She could see her mother's shocked face, Francis's slow shake of the head, as if this new Lily was of no surprise to him whatsoever.

She had been so stupid.

She should have stolen the phone.

She should have stamped on it.

She should have stamped on him.

She shouldn't have gone to that boy's stupid flat and behaved like a stupid idiot and broken her own stupid life, and that was usually the point at which she would start crying again and pull her hood further up around her face and –



CHAPTER TWENTY

‘She’s what?’

In Mrs Traynor’s silence I heard disbelief, and perhaps (maybe I was being oversensitive) a faint echo of the last thing of hers I had failed to keep safe.

‘And you’ve tried to call?’

‘She’s not picking up.’

‘And she hasn’t been in touch with her parents?’

I closed my eyes. I had been dreading this conversation. ‘She’s done this before, apparently. Mrs Houghton-Miller is convinced Lily will turn up any minute.’

Mrs Traynor digested this. ‘But you aren’t.’

‘Something’s not right, Mrs Traynor. I know I’m not a parent, but I just ...’ My words tailed away. ‘Anyway. I’d rather be doing something than nothing, so I’m going to get back out walking the streets to find her. I just wanted you to know the truth about what was going on.’

Mrs Traynor was silent for a moment. And then she said, her voice measured but oddly determined, ‘Louisa, before you go, would you mind giving me Mrs Houghton-Miller’s telephone number?’

I called in sick, noting fleetingly that Richard Percival’s cold ‘I see,’ was actually more ominous than his previous blustering protests. I printed off photographs – one of Lily’s Facebook profile photographs, and one of the selfies she’d taken of the two of us. I spent the morning driving around central London. I parked on kerbs, leaving the hazard lights flashing, as I nipped into pubs, fast-food joints, nightclubs where the cleaners, working in the stale, dim air, peered up at me with suspicious eyes.

– *Have you seen this girl?*

– *Who wants to know?*

– *Have you seen this girl?*

– *Are you police? I don’t want no trouble.*

Some people evidently thought it amusing to string me along for a bit – *Oh, that girl! Brown hair? Yeah, what was her name? ... Nah. Never seen*

her before. Nobody seemed to have seen her. And the further I travelled, the more hopeless it felt. What better place to disappear than London? A teeming metropolis where you could slide into a million doorways, mingle with crowds that never ended. I would gaze up at the tower blocks and wonder whether even now she was lying on someone's sofa in her pyjamas. Lily picked up people with ease, and had no fear of asking for anything – she could be with anyone.

And yet.

I wasn't entirely sure what drove me to keep going. Perhaps it was my cold fury at Tanya Houghton-Miller's semi-detached parenting; perhaps it was my guilt at having failed to do the thing I was criticizing Tanya for not doing. Perhaps it was just that I knew only too well how vulnerable a young girl could be.

Mostly, though, it was Will. I walked and drove and questioned and walked and held endless internal conversations with him as my hip began to ache, and I paused in my car, chewing stale sandwiches and garage chocolate and choking down painkillers to keep me going.

Where would she go, Will?

What would you do?

And – yet again – *I'm sorry. I let you down.*

Any news? I texted Sam. It felt odd speaking to him while having concurrent conversations with Will in my head, a strange infidelity. I just wasn't quite sure who I was being unfaithful to.

Nope. I've called every ER department in London. How about you?

Bit tired.

Hip?

Nothing chewing a few Nurofen won't fix.

Want me to stop by after my shift?

I think I just need to keep looking.

Don't go anywhere I wouldn't go x

Very funny xxx

'Did you try the hospitals?' My sister called from college, in her fifteen-minute break between HMRC: the Changing Face of Revenue Collection, and VAT: A European Perspective.

'Sam says there's nobody with her name has been admitted to any of the teaching hospitals. He's got people everywhere looking out for her.' I

glanced behind me as I spoke, as if even then I half expected to see Lily walking out of the crowds towards me.

‘How long have you been looking?’

‘A few days.’ I didn’t tell her I’d barely slept. ‘I – er – took time off work.’

‘I knew it! I knew she was going to be trouble. Did your boss mind you taking time off? What happened about that other job, by the way? The one in New York? Did you do the interview? Please don’t say you forgot.’

It took me a minute to work out what she was referring to. ‘Oh. That. Yeah – I got it.’

‘You *what*?’

‘Nathan said they’re going to offer it to me.’

Westminster was filling with tourists, lingering at gaudy stalls of Union Jack tat, their mobile phones and expensive cameras held aloft to capture the looming Houses of Parliament. I watched a traffic warden walking towards me and wondered if some anti-terrorism legislation prevented me parking where I’d stopped. I held up a hand, indicating that I was about to leave.

There was a short silence at the other end of the phone.

‘Hang on – you’re not saying you –’

‘I can’t even think about it right now, Treen. Lily’s missing. I need to find her.’

‘Louisa? *You* listen a minute. You have to take this job.’

‘What?’

‘This is the opportunity of a lifetime. If you had the faintest clue what I would give for a chance to move to New York ... with guaranteed employment? A place to live? And you “can’t think about it right now”?’

‘It’s not as simple as that.’

The traffic warden was definitely walking towards me.

‘Oh, my God. This is it. This is the thing I was trying to talk to you about. Every time you get a chance to move forward, you just hijack your own future. It’s like – it’s like you don’t actually want to.’

‘Lily is *missing*, Treen.’

‘A sixteen-year-old girl you barely know, with two parents and at least two grandparents, has buggered off for a few days like she’s done before. Like teenagers sometimes do. And you’re going to use this to throw away

the greatest opportunity you're ever likely to be given? Jeez. You don't even really want to go, do you?'

'What the hell is that supposed to mean?'

'Far easier for you to just stick with that depressing little job and complain about it. Far easier for you to sit tight and not take a risk and make out that everything that happens to you is something you couldn't help.'

'I can't just up and leave while this is going on.'

'You're in charge of your own life, Lou. And yet you act like you're permanently buffeted by events outside your control. What is this – guilt? Is it that you feel you owe Will something? Is it some kind of penance? Giving up your life because you couldn't save his?'

'You don't understand.'

'No. I understand perfectly. I understand you better than you understand yourself. His daughter is *not your responsibility*. Do you hear me? None of this is your responsibility. And if you don't go to New York – an opportunity I can't even talk about because it makes me want to actually kill you – I'll never talk to you again. Ever.'

The traffic warden was at my window. I wound it down, pulling the universal face you make when your sister is going off on one at the other end of your phone and you're really sorry but you can't cut her short. He tapped his watch and I nodded, reassuringly.

'That's it, Lou. Think about it. Lily is not your daughter.'

I was left staring at my phone. I thanked the traffic warden, then wound up my window. And a phrase popped into my head: *I'm not his daughter*.

I drove around the corner, pulled up beside a petrol station and rifled through the battered old A-Z that lived in the footwell of my car, trying to remember the name of the road Lily had mentioned. Pyemore, Pyecrust, *Pyecroft*. I traced the distance to St John's Wood with my finger – would that take fifteen minutes to walk? It had to be the same place.

I used my phone and looked up his surname along with the street name, and there it was. Number fifty-six. My gut tightened with excitement. I started the ignition, wrenched the car into gear and headed out onto the road again.

Although separated by less than a mile, the difference between Lily's mother's house and her former stepfather's could not have been more

pronounced. Where the Houghton-Millers' street was uniformly grand white stucco or red-brick houses, punctuated by yew topiary and large cars that seemingly never got dirty, Martin Steele's road appeared resolutely un-gentrified, a two-storey corner of London where house prices were spiralling but the exteriors resolutely refused to reflect it.

I drove slowly, past cars under canvas and an overturned wheelie-bin, and finally found a parking space near a small Victorian terraced house of the kind that existed in identikit lines all over London. I gazed at it, noting the peeling paintwork on the front door, the child's watering-can on the front step. Please let her be here, I prayed. Safe within those walls.

I climbed out of the car, locked it, and walked up to the front step.

Inside I could hear a piano, a fractured chord being repeated again and again, muffled voices. I hesitated, just a moment, and then I pressed the doorbell, hearing the sudden answering stop to the music.

Footsteps in the corridor, and then the door opened. A forty-something man, lumberjack shirt, jeans and day-old stubble, stood there.

'Yes?'

'I wondered ... is Lily here please?'

'Lily?'

I smiled, held out a hand. 'You are Martin Steele, yes?'

He studied me briefly before he answered. 'I might be. And who are you?'

'I'm a friend of Lily's. I – I've been trying to get in contact with her and I understand that she might be staying here. Or that perhaps you might know where she is.'

He frowned. 'Lily? Lily Miller?'

'Well. Yes.'

He rubbed his hand against his jaw, and glanced behind him towards the hall. 'Could you wait there a moment, please?' He walked back down the corridor, and I heard him issuing instructions to whoever was at the piano. As he came back to me, a scale began playing, hesitantly and then with more emphasis.

Martin Steele half closed the door behind him. He dipped his head for a moment, as if he were trying to make sense of what I had asked him. 'I'm sorry. I'm slightly at a loss here. You're a friend of Lily Miller's? And you've come here why?'

‘Because Lily said she came here to see you. You are – were – her stepfather?’

‘Not technically, but yes. A long time ago.’

‘And you’re a musician? You used to take her to nursery? But you’re still in contact. She told me how close you still were. How much it irritated her mother.’

Martin squinted at me. ‘Miss –’

‘Clark. Louisa Clark.’

‘Miss Clark. Louisa. I haven’t seen Lily Miller since she was five years old. Tanya thought it would be better for all of us when we split up if we broke off all contact.’

I stared at him. ‘So you’re saying she hasn’t been here?’

He thought for a moment. ‘She came once, a few years ago, but it wasn’t great timing. We’d just had a baby and I was trying to teach and, well, to be honest, I couldn’t work out what she really wanted from me.’

‘So you haven’t seen or spoken to her since then?’

‘Apart from that one very brief occasion, no. Is she okay? Is she in some kind of trouble?’

Inside, the piano kept playing – *doh re mi fah soh lah ti doh. Doh ti lah soh fah mi re doh*. Up and down.

I waved a hand, already backing away down the steps. ‘No. It’s fine. My mistake. I’m sorry to have bothered you.’

I spent another evening driving around London, ignoring my sister’s calls and the email from Richard Percival that was marked URGENT and PERSONAL. I drove until my eyes were reddened from the glare of lights and I realized I was now going to places I had already been, and I ran out of cash for petrol.

I drove home just after midnight, promising myself I would pick up my bank card, drink a cup of tea, rest my eyes for half an hour, then hit the road again. I took off my shoes and made some toast that I couldn’t eat. Instead I swallowed another two painkillers and lay back on the sofa, my mind racing. What was I missing? There must be some clue. My brain buzzed with exhaustion, my stomach now permanently knotted with anxiety. What streets had I missed? Was there a chance she had gone somewhere other than London?

There was no choice, I decided. We had to let the police know. It was better to be thought stupid and overly dramatic than to risk something actually happening to her. I lay back and closed my eyes for five minutes.

I was woken three hours later by the phone ringing. I lurched upright, temporarily unsure where I was. Then I stared at the flashing screen beside me, and fumbled it up to my ear. 'Hello?'

'We've got her.'

'What?'

'It's Sam. We've got Lily. Can you come?'

In the evening crush that followed England losing a football match, the ill-temper and associated drink-related injuries, nobody had noticed the slight figure sleeping across two chairs in the corner, her hoodie pulled up high over her face. It was only when the triage nurse had gone person-to-person to ensure they were meeting waiting targets that someone shook the girl awake and she confessed reluctantly that she was just there because it was warm and dry and safe.

The nurse was questioning her when Sam, bringing in an old woman with breathing problems, caught sight of her at the desk. He had quietly instructed the nurses at the desk not to let her leave, and hurried out to call me before she could see him. He told me all this as we rushed into A and E. The waiting area had finally started to thin out, the fever-ridden children safely in cubicles with their parents, the drunks sent home to sleep it off. Only RTAs and stabbing victims, at this time of night.

'They've given her some tea. She looks exhausted. I think she's happy just to sit tight.'

I must have looked anxious at this point because he added, 'It's okay. They won't let her leave.'

I half walked, half ran along the strip-lit corridor, Sam striding beside me. And there she was, looking somehow smaller than she had done, her hair pulled into a messy plait, a plastic cup held between her thin hands. A nurse sat beside her, working through a pile of folders, and when she saw me and registered Sam, she smiled warmly, and stood up to leave. Lily's nails, I noticed, were black with grime.

'Lily?' I said. Her dark, shadowed eyes met mine. 'What – what happened?'

She looked at me, and then at Sam, her eyes huge and a little fearful.

‘We’ve been looking everywhere. We were ... My God, Lily. Where were you?’

‘Sorry,’ she whispered.

I shook my head, trying to tell her that it didn’t matter. That nothing could possibly matter, that the only important thing was that she was safe and she was here.

I held out my arms. She looked into my eyes, took a step forward, and gently came to rest against me. And I closed my arms tight around her, feeling her silent, shaking sobs become my own. All I could do was thank some unknown God and offer up these silent words: *Will. Will – we found her.*



CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

That first night home I put Lily in my bed and she slept for eighteen hours, waking in the evening for some soup and a bath, then crashing out for a further eight. I slept on the sofa, the front door locked, afraid to go out or even to move in case she vanished again. Sam dropped in twice, before and after his shift, to bring milk and to check on how she'd been, and we talked in whispers in the hall, as if we were discussing an invalid.

I rang Tanya Houghton-Miller to tell her that her daughter had turned up safely. 'I told you. You wouldn't listen to me,' she crowed triumphantly, and I put the phone down before she could say anything else. Or I did.

I called Mrs Traynor, who let out a long, shaking sigh of relief and didn't speak for some time. 'Thank you,' she said, finally, and it sounded like it came from somewhere deep in her gut. 'When can I come and see her?'

I finally opened the email from Richard Percival, which informed me that *As you have been given the requisite three warnings, it is considered that, given your poor attendance record and failure to carry out your contractual requirements, your employment at the Shamrock and Clover (Airport) is terminated with immediate effect.* He asked that I return the uniform ('including wig') at my earliest convenience *or you will be charged its full retail value.*

I opened an email from Nathan asking, *Where the hell are you? Have you seen my last email?*

I thought about Mr Gopnik's offer and, with a sigh, closed my computer.

On the third day I woke on the sofa to find Lily missing. My heart lurched reflexively until I saw the open hallway window. I climbed up the fire escape and found her seated on the roof, looking out across the city. She was wearing her pyjama bottoms, which I'd washed, and Will's oversized sweater.

'Hey,' I said, walking across the roof towards her.

'You have food in your fridge,' she observed.

'Ambulance Sam.'

'And you watered everything.'

‘That was mostly him too.’

She nodded, as if that were probably to be expected. I took my place on the bench and we sat in companionable silence for a while, breathing in the scent of the lavender, whose purple heads had burst out of their tight green buds. Everything in the little roof garden had now exploded into gaudy life; the petals and whispering leaves bringing colour and movement and fragrance to the grey expanse of asphalt.

‘Sorry for hogging your bed.’

‘Your need was greater.’

‘You hung up all your clothes.’ She curled her legs neatly under her, tucking her hair behind an ear. She was still pale. ‘The nice ones.’

‘Well, I guess you made me think I shouldn’t hide them in boxes any more.’

She shot me a sideways look and a small, sad smile that somehow made me feel sadder than if she hadn’t smiled at all. The air held the promise of a scorching day, the street sounds muffled as if by the warmth of the sun. You could feel it already seeping through the windows, bleaching the air. Below us a bin lorry clattered and roared its way slowly along the kerbside to a timpanic accompaniment of beeps and men’s voices.

‘Lily,’ I said, quietly, when it had finally receded into the distance, ‘what’s going on?’ I tried not to sound too interrogative. ‘I know I’m not meant to ask you questions and I’m not your actual family or anything, but all I can see is that something’s gone wrong here and I feel ... I feel like I ... well, I feel we’re sort of related and I just want you to trust me. I want you to feel you can talk to me.’

She kept her gaze fixed on her hands.

‘I’m not going to judge you. I’m not going to report anything you say to anyone. I just ... Well, you have to know that if you tell someone the truth, it will help. I promise. It will make things better.’

‘Says who?’

‘Me. There’s nothing you can’t tell me, Lily. Really.’

She glanced at me, then looked away. ‘You won’t understand,’ she said softly.

And then I knew. I knew.

Below us it had become oddly quiet, or perhaps I could no longer hear anything beyond the few inches that separated us. ‘I’m going to tell you a story,’ I said. ‘Only one person in the whole world knows this story because

it was something I didn't feel I could share for years and years. And telling him changed the whole way I felt about it, and how I felt about myself. So here's the thing – you don't have to tell me anything at all, but I'm going to trust you enough to tell you my story anyway, just in case it will help.'

I waited a moment but Lily didn't protest, or roll her eyes, or say it was going to be *boring*. She wrapped her arms around her knees, and she listened. She listened as I told her about the teenage girl who, on a glorious summer evening, had celebrated a little too hard in a place she considered safe, how she had been surrounded by her girlfriends and some nice boys who seemed as if they came from good families and knew the rules, and how much fun it had been, how funny and crazy and wild, until some drinks later she realized nearly all the other girls had drifted away and the laughter had grown hard and the joke, it turned out, had been on her. And I told her, without going into too much detail, how that evening had ended: with a sister silently helping her home, her shoes lost, bruising in secret places and a big black hole where her recall of those hours should have been, and the memories, fleeting and dark, now hanging over her head to remind her every day that she had been stupid, irresponsible and had brought it all on herself. And how, for years, she had let that thought colour what she did, where she went and what she thought she was capable of. And how sometimes it just needed someone to say something as simple as *No. It wasn't your fault. It really wasn't your fault.*

I finished and Lily was still watching me. Her expression gave no clue to her reaction.

'I don't know what was – or is – going on with you, Lily,' I said carefully. 'It might be totally unrelated to what I've just told you. I just want you to know there is nothing so bad that you can't tell me. And there is nothing you could do that would make me close a door on you again.'

Still she didn't speak. I gazed out over the roof terrace, deliberately not looking at her.

'You know, your dad said something to me that I've never forgotten: "You don't have to let that one thing be the thing that defines you." '

'My dad.' She lifted her chin.

I nodded. 'Whatever it is that's happened, even if you don't want to tell me, you need to understand that he was right. These last weeks, months, don't have to be the thing that defines you. Even from the little I know of you, I recognise that you are bright and funny and kind and smart, and that

if you can get yourself past whatever this is, you have an amazing future ahead.'

'How can you possibly know that?'

'Because you're like him. You're even wearing his jumper,' I added softly.

She brought her arm slowly to her face, placing the soft wool against her cheek, thinking.

I sat back on the bench. I wondered if I had pushed it too far, talking about Will.

But then Lily took a breath and, in a quiet, uncharacteristically flat voice, she told me the truth about where she'd been. She told me about the boy, and about the man, and an image on a mobile phone that haunted her, and the days she had spent as a shadow on the city's neon-lit streets. As she spoke she started to cry, shrinking into herself, her face crumpling like that of a five-year-old, so I moved across the seat and brought her in close to me, stroking her hair while she kept talking, her words now jumbled, too fast, too full, broken with sobs and hiccups. By the time she got to the last day, she was huddled into me, swallowed by the jumper, swallowed by her own fear and guilt and sadness.

'I'm sorry,' she sobbed. 'I'm so sorry.'

'You have nothing,' I said fiercely, as I held her, '*nothing* to be sorry for.'

That evening Sam came. He was cheerful, sweet and casual in his dealings with Lily, cooked us pasta with cream, bacon and mushrooms, when she said she didn't want to go out, and we watched a comedy film about a family who got lost in a jungle, a strange facsimile of a family ourselves. I smiled and laughed and made tea, but inside I simmered with anger I didn't dare show.

As soon as Lily went to bed I beckoned Sam onto the fire escape. We climbed up to the roof where I could be sure I wouldn't be heard, and as he sat down on the little wrought-iron bench I told him what she had told me in that spot, just a few hours earlier. 'She thinks it's going to hang over her for ever. He still has the phone, Sam.'

I wasn't sure I had ever been so furious. All evening, as the television burbled in front of me, I had recast the last weeks in a new light: I thought about the times the boy had hung around downstairs, the way Lily had hidden her phone under the sofa cushions when she thought I might see it,

the way she had sometimes flinched when a new message came through. I thought of her stuttering words – of the way she described her relief when she thought she had been rescued – and then the horror of what was to come next. I thought about the arrogance of a man who had seen a young girl in distress and viewed it as an opportunity.

Sam motioned to me to sit down, but I couldn't keep still. I paced backwards and forwards across the roof terrace, my fists tight, my neck rigid. I wanted to throw things over the edge. I wanted to find Mr Garside. He came and stood behind me and rubbed at the knots in my shoulders. I suspected it was his way of making me stand still.

'I actually want to kill him.'

'It can be arranged.'

I looked round at Sam to see if he was joking, and was the tiniest bit disappointed when I saw he was.

It had grown chilly up there in the stiff night breeze and I wished I had brought up a jacket. 'Maybe we should just go to the police. It's blackmail, isn't it?'

'He'll deny it. There are a million places he could hide a phone. And if her mother was telling the truth nobody is going to believe Lily over a so-called pillar of the community. That's how these people get away with it.'

'But how do we get that phone off him? She won't be able to move forward while she knows he's out there, while that image is still out there.' I was shivering. Sam took his jacket off and hung it around my shoulders. It carried the residual warmth of him and I tried not to look as grateful as I felt.

'We can't turn up at his office or her parents will find out. We could email him? Tell him he has to send it back, or else?'

'He's hardly just going to cough it up. He might not even answer an email – that could be used as evidence.'

'Oh, it's hopeless.' I let out a long moan. 'Maybe she's just going to have to learn to live with it. Maybe we can convince her that it's as much in his interests to forget what happened as it is hers. Because it is, right? Maybe he'll just get rid of the phone himself.'

'You think she'll go with that?'

'No.' I rubbed my eyes. 'I can't bear it. I can't bear that he'll get away with it. That creepy, nasty, manipulative, limo-driving scumbag ...' I stood up and gazed out at the city below me, feeling briefly despairing. I could

see the future: Lily, defensive and wild, as she tried to escape the shadow of her past. That phone was the key to her behaviour, to her future.

Think, I told myself. *Think what Will would do*. He would not have let this man win. I had to strategize like he would. I watched the traffic creeping slowly past the front door of my block. I thought of Mr Garside's big black car, cruising the streets of Soho. I thought about a man who moved silently and easily through life, confident that it would always work his way.

'Sam?' I said. 'Is there a drug you could give that could stop someone's heart?'

He let that hang in the air for a moment. 'Please tell me you're kidding.'

'No. Listen. I've got an idea.'

She said nothing at first. 'You'll be safe,' I said. 'And this way nobody has to know a thing.' What moved me most was that she didn't ask me the question I had been asking myself ever since I outlined my plan to Sam.

How do you know this will actually work?

'I've got it all lined up, sweetheart,' Sam said.

'But nobody else knows –'

'Anything. Just that he's hassling you.'

'Won't you get in trouble?'

'Don't worry about me.'

She pulled at her sleeve, then murmured, 'And you won't leave me with him. At all.'

'Not for one minute.'

She chewed her lip. Then she looked at Sam, and over at me. And something seemed to settle inside her. 'Okay. Let's do it.'

I bought a cheap, pay-as-you-go handset, called Lily's stepfather's workplace and got Mr Garside's mobile number from his secretary by pretending we had arranged to meet for a drink. That evening as I waited for Sam to arrive, I sent a text to Garside's number.

Mr Garside. I'm sorry about hitting you. I just freaked. I want to sort it out. L

He left it half an hour before responding, probably to make her sweat.

Why should I talk to you, Lily? You were very rude after all the help I gave you.

‘Prick,’ muttered Sam.

I know. I’m sorry. But I do need your help.

This is not a one-way street, Lily.

I know. You just gave me a shock. I needed time to think. Let’s meet up.

I’ll give you what you want, but you have to give me the phone first.

I don’t think you get to dictate terms, Lily.

Sam looked at me. I looked back at him, then began to type.

Not even ... if I’m a really bad girl?

A pause.

Now you’ve got my interest.

Sam and I exchanged a look. ‘I just did a little sick in my mouth,’ I said.

Tomorrow night then, I typed. I’ll send you the address when I’ve checked my friend will be out.

When we were sure he wouldn’t respond, Sam put the phone into his pocket, where Lily couldn’t see it, and held me for a long time.

I was almost ill with nerves the next day, and Lily was worse. We picked at our breakfast, and I let Lily smoke in the flat, and was almost tempted to ask for a cigarette myself. We watched a film and did some chores badly, and by seven thirty that evening, when Sam arrived, my head was buzzing so much I could barely speak.

‘Did you send the address?’ I asked him.

‘Yup.’

‘Show me.’

The phone message was simply the address of my flat and signed *L*.

He had responded: *I have a meeting in town and I’ll be there shortly after eight.*

‘You okay?’ he said.

My stomach tightened. I felt as if I could hardly breathe. ‘I don’t want to get you into trouble. I mean – what if you get found out? You’ll lose your job.’

Sam shook his head. ‘Won’t happen.’

‘I shouldn’t have pulled you into this mess. You’ve been so brilliant and I feel like I’m repaying you by putting you at risk.’

‘We’ll all be fine. Keep breathing.’ He smiled reassuringly at me, but I thought I could detect a faint strain around his eyes.

He glanced over my shoulder and I turned. Lily was wearing a black T-shirt, denim shorts and black tights, and she had done her make-up so that she looked simultaneously very beautiful and very young. 'You all right, sweetheart?'

She nodded. Her skin, normally the slightly olive colour Will's had been, was unusually pale. Her eyes were huge in her face.

'It's all going to be fine, I'd be surprised if it takes longer than five minutes. Lou's been through it all with you, yes?' Sam's voice was calm, reassuring.

We had rehearsed it a dozen times. I wanted her to reach a point where she wouldn't freeze, where she could repeat her lines without thinking.

'I know what I'm doing.'

'Right,' he said, and clapped his hands together. 'Quarter to eight. Let's get ready.'

He was punctual, I had to give him that. At one minute past eight my buzzer rang. Lily took an audible breath, I squeezed her hand, and then she answered the entry-phone. *Yes. Yes, she's gone. Come up.* It didn't seem to occur to him that she might not be what he thought.

Lily let him in. Only I, watching through the crack in my bedroom door, could see the way her hand trembled as she reached for the lock. Garside ran his hand over his hair, glanced briefly around the hallway. He was wearing a good grey suit, and tucked his car keys into his inside breast pocket. I couldn't stop staring at him, at his expensive shirt, his beady, acquisitive eyes as they scanned the flat. My jaw tightened. What kind of man felt entitled to press himself on a girl forty years younger than he was? To blackmail the child of his own colleague?

He looked uncomfortable, far from relaxed. 'I've parked my car out the back. Will it be safe?'

'I think so.' Lily swallowed.

'You *think* so?' He took a step back towards the door. The kind of man who sees his car as an extension of some minuscule part of himself. 'And what about your friend? Whoever owns this place. They're not coming back?'

I held my breath. Behind me I felt Sam's steadying hand on the small of my back.

‘Oh. No. It will be fine.’ She smiled, suddenly reassuring. ‘She won’t be back for ages. Do come in. Would you like a drink, Mr Garside?’

He looked at her as if he were seeing her for the first time. ‘So formal.’ He took a step forward and finally closed the door behind him. ‘Do you have Scotch?’

‘I’ll check. Come through.’

She began to walk to the kitchen, him following, removing his suit jacket. As they entered the living room, Sam walked past me out of the bedroom, strode across the hallway in his heavy boots and locked the inside door to the flat, placing the keys, jangling, in his pocket.

Garside, startled, turned and saw him, joined now by Donna. They stood there in uniform, against the door. He looked at them, then back at Lily, and faltered, trying to work out what was going on.

‘Hello, Mr Garside,’ I said, stepping out from behind the door. ‘I believe you have something to return to my friend here.’

He actually broke out in a spontaneous sweat. Until then, I hadn’t known it was physically possible. His eyes darted about for Lily, but as I had stepped out into the hall she had moved so that she was half behind me.

Sam stepped forward. Mr Garside’s head reached just above his shoulder. ‘The phone, please.’

‘You can’t threaten me.’

‘We’re not threatening you,’ I said, my heart thumping. ‘We would just like the phone.’

‘You’re threatening me just by blocking my exit.’

‘Oh, no, sir,’ said Sam. ‘Actually *threatening* you would involve mentioning the fact that, if my colleague and I chose, we could pin you down right here and now and inject you with dihypranol, which would slow and ultimately stop your heart. Now *that* would be a threat, especially as nobody would question the word of the paramedic crew who had apparently tried to save you. And as dihypranol is one of the few drugs that leaves no trace in the bloodstream.’

Donna, her arms crossed across her chest, shook her head sadly. ‘It’s a shame, the way these middle-aged businessmen just drop like flies.’

‘All sorts of health issues. They drink too much, eat too well, don’t take enough exercise.’

‘I’m sure this gentleman here isn’t like that.’

‘You’d hope not. But who knows?’

Mr Garside seemed to have shrunk by several inches.

‘And don’t even think of threatening Lily. We know where you live, Mr Garside. All paramedics have that information to hand if and when they need it. It’s amazing what can happen if you piss off a paramedic.’

‘This is outrageous.’ He was blustering now, his face drained of colour.

‘Yup. It really is.’ I held out my hand. ‘The phone, please.’

Garside glanced around him again, then finally reached into his pocket and handed it, to me.

I tossed it to Lily. ‘Check it, Lily.’

I looked away, in deference to her feelings, while she did so. ‘Delete it,’ I said. ‘Just delete it.’ When I looked back, she had the phone, screen blank, in her hand. She gave a faint nod. Sam motioned to her to throw it to him. He dropped it to the floor and stamped down on it with his right foot, so that the plastic splintered. He crushed it with such violence that the floor shook. I found myself flinching, along with Mr Garside, every time Sam’s heavy boot came down.

Finally, Sam stooped and gingerly picked up the tiny SIM card, which had skidded under the radiator. He examined it, and held it up in front of the older man. ‘Was that the only copy?’

Garside nodded. Moisture was darkening his collar.

‘Of course it’s the only copy,’ said Donna. ‘A responsible member of the community wouldn’t want to take the risk of something like that turning up anywhere, would he? Imagine what Mr Garside’s family would say if his nasty little secret got out?’

Garside’s mouth had compressed into a thin line. ‘You’ve got what you wanted. Now let me leave.’

‘No. I would like to say something.’ My voice, I noted distantly, shook slightly with the effort of containing my fury. ‘You are a sleazy, pathetic little man, and if I –’

Mr Garside’s mouth hooked upwards in a sneer. The kind of man who had never once felt threatened by a woman. ‘Oh, do be quiet, you ridiculous little –’

Something hard glittered in Sam’s eyes and he sprang forward. My arm shot out to restrain him. I don’t remember my other fist pulling back. I do remember the pain that shot through my knuckles as it made contact with the side of Garside’s face. He reeled backwards, his upper body hitting the

door, and I stumbled, not expecting the force of the impact. When he righted himself, I was shocked to see blood trickling from his nose.

‘Let me out,’ he hissed, through his fingers. ‘*This minute.*’

Sam blinked at me, then unlocked the door. Donna stepped away, just about allowing him through. She leaned towards him. ‘Are you sure you don’t want a dressing for that before you go?’

Garside kept his pace measured as he left, but as the door clicked shut behind him, we heard the sound of his expensive shoes picking up into a run down the corridor. We stood in silence until we couldn’t hear them any more. And then, the sound of several people exhaling at once.

‘Nice punch, Cassius,’ said Sam, after a minute. ‘Want me to take a look at that hand?’

I couldn’t speak. I was bent double, swearing silently into my chest.

‘Always hurts more than you think it will, doesn’t it?’ said Donna, patting my back. ‘Don’t stress, sweetheart,’ she told Lily. ‘Whatever he said to you, that old man is nothing. Gone.’

‘He won’t be back,’ said Sam.

Donna laughed. ‘He pretty much crapped himself. I think he’ll be running a mile from you from now on. Forget it, darling.’ She hugged Lily briskly, as you might someone who had toppled off a bike, then handed me the pieces of the broken phone to throw away. ‘Right. I promised to pop round my dad’s before our shift. See you later.’ And then, with a wave, she was gone, her boots clumping cheerfully down the corridor.

Sam began to rummage through his medical pack to find a dressing for my hand. Lily and I walked into the living room where she sank down on the sofa. ‘You did brilliantly,’ I told her.

‘You were pretty badass yourself.’

I examined my bloodied knuckles. When I looked up, the smallest grin was playing around her lips. ‘He totally wasn’t expecting that.’

‘Neither was I. I’d never hit anyone before.’ I straightened my face. ‘Not that, you know, you should consider me any kind of moral example.’

‘I’ve never considered you any kind of example, Lou.’ She grinned, almost reluctantly, as Sam came in, bearing some sterile bandage and a pair of scissors.

‘You okay, Lily?’ He raised his eyebrows.

She nodded.

‘Good. Let’s move on to something more interesting. Who fancies spaghetti carbonara?’

When she left the room, he let out a long breath, then stared at the ceiling for a moment, as if composing himself.

‘What?’ I said.

‘Thank God you hit him first. I was afraid I was going to kill him.’

Some time later, after Lily had gone to bed, I joined Sam in the kitchen. For the first time in weeks some sort of peace had descended over my home.

‘She’s happier already. I mean, she bitched about the new toothpaste and left her towels on the floor, but in Lily terms she’s definitely better.’

He nodded at this, and emptied the sink. It felt good having him in my kitchen. I watched him for a minute, wondering how it would feel to walk up and place my arms around his waist. ‘Thank you,’ I said instead. ‘For everything.’

He turned, wiping his hands on the tea towel. ‘You were pretty smart yourself, Punchy.’ He reached out a hand and pulled me to him. We kissed. There was something so delicious about his kisses; the softness of them compared to the brute strength of the rest of him. I lost myself in him for a moment. But –

‘What?’ he said, pulling back. ‘What’s wrong?’

‘You’re going to think it’s weird.’

‘Uh, more weird than this evening?’

‘I keep thinking about that dihypranol stuff. How much would it take to actually kill a person? Is this something you all carry routinely? It just ... sounds ... really dodgy.’

‘You don’t need to worry,’ he said.

‘You say that. But what if someone really hated you? Could they put it in your food? Could terrorists get hold of it? I mean, how much would they actually need?’

‘Lou. There’s no such drug.’

‘What?’

‘I made it up. There’s no such thing as dihypranol. Totally invented.’ He grinned at my shocked face. ‘Funnily enough, I don’t think I’ve ever had a drug that worked better.’



CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

I was the last one to arrive at the Moving On meeting. My car wouldn't start again and I'd had to wait for the bus. When I got there the biscuit tin was just closing, a signal that the real business of the evening was about to begin.

'Today we're going to talk about faith in the future,' Marc said. I muttered my apology and sat down. 'Oh, and we only have an hour today because of an emergency Scouts meeting. Sorry about that, guys.'

Marc fixed each of us with his Special Empathetic Gaze. He was very keen on his Special Empathetic Gaze. Sometimes he would stare at me for so long I wondered if something was poking out of my nostril. He looked down, as if gathering his thoughts – or perhaps he liked to read his opening lines from a pre-prepared script.

'When someone we love is snatched from us, it often feels very hard to make plans. Sometimes people feel like they have lost faith in the future, or they become superstitious.'

'I thought I was going to die,' said Natasha.

'You are,' said William.

'Not helpful, William,' said Marc.

'No – honestly, for the first eighteen months after Olaf died, I thought I had cancer. I think I went to the doctor about a dozen times convinced I was getting cancer. Brain tumours, pancreatic cancer, womb cancer, even little-finger cancer.'

'There's no such thing as little-finger cancer,' said William.

'Oh, how would you know?' snapped Natasha. 'You have a smart answer for everything, William, but sometimes you should just keep your mouth shut, okay? It gets very tedious having you make a snarky comment about everything that someone says in this group. I thought I had little-finger cancer. My GP sent me for tests and it turned out I didn't. It might have been an irrational fear, yes, but you don't have to put down everything I say because, whatever you think, you don't know everything, okay?'

There was a brief silence.

'Actually,' said William, 'I work on an oncology ward.'

‘It still stands,’ she said, after a microsecond. ‘You are insufferable. A deliberate agitator. A pain in the backside.’

‘That’s true,’ said William.

Natasha stared at the floor. Or perhaps we all did. It was hard to tell, given I was studying the floor. She put her face into her hands for a moment, then looked up at him. ‘You’re not really, William. I’m sorry. I think I’m just having one of those days. I didn’t mean to snap at you like that.’

‘Still can’t get little-finger cancer, though,’ said William.

‘So ...’ said Marc, as we tried to ignore Natasha cursing repeatedly under her breath ‘... I’m wondering whether any of you have reached a point where you can consider the prospect of life five years on. Where do you see yourself? What do you see yourself doing? Do you feel okay to imagine the future now?’

‘I’ll be happy if my old ticker’s still ticking,’ said Fred.

‘All that internet sex putting it under strain?’ said Sunil.

‘That!’ Fred exclaimed. ‘That was a total waste of money. The first site, I spent two weeks emailing this woman from Lisbon – total cracker – and when I finally suggested we meet up for a bit of the old how’s-your-father, she tried to sell me a condo in Florida. And then a man called Buffed Adonis private-messaged me to warn me off and tell me she was actually a one-legged Puerto Rican fella called Ramirez.’

‘What about the other sites, Fred?’

‘The only woman who said she’d meet me looked like my great-aunt Elsie, who kept her keys in her knickers. I mean, she was very sweet and all, but the old girl was so ancient I was almost tempted to check.’

‘Don’t give up, Fred,’ said Marc. ‘It might be that you’re looking in the wrong places.’

‘For my keys? Oh, no. I hang those by the door.’

Daphne decided she’d like to retire abroad in the next few years – ‘It’s the cold here. Gets into my joints.’

Leanne said she hoped to finish her philosophy master’s. We gave each other the kind of deliberately blank looks you do when nobody wants to admit they had actually assumed she worked in a supermarket. Or maybe a slaughterhouse. William said, ‘Well, you Kant.’

Nobody laughed, and when he realized nobody was going to, he sat back in his chair, and it might have been only me who heard Natasha muttering,

‘Hah hah,’ like Nelson in *The Simpsons*.

At first, Sunil didn’t want to speak. Then he said he’d thought about it and he’d decided that in five years’ time he’d like to be married. ‘I feel like I’ve turned myself off for the past two years. Like I wouldn’t let anyone get close to me because of what happened. I mean, what’s the point of getting close to someone if you’re only going to lose them? But the other day I started thinking about what I actually want out of life and I realized it was someone to love. Because you got to move on, right? You got to see some kind of future.’

It was the most I had heard Sunil speak in any meeting since I had started coming.

‘That’s very positive, Sunil,’ said Marc. ‘Thank you for sharing.’

I listened to Jake talk about going to college, and how he wanted to train as an animator, and wondered absently where his father would be. Still weeping over his dead wife? Or happily ensconced with some newer version? I suspected the latter. Then I thought about Sam and wondered whether my offhand reference to a relationship had been wise. Then I wondered what we were in if it wasn’t a relationship. Because there were relationships and relationships. And even as I mulled this over I realized that, if he asked, I wasn’t sure which category we even fitted into. I couldn’t help wondering whether the intensity of our search for Lily had acted as a kind of cheap glue, binding us together too quickly. What did we even have in common, other than a fall from a building?

Two days previously I had gone to the Ambulance Station to wait for Sam, and Donna had stood by her car chatting to me for a few minutes while he gathered his belongings. ‘Don’t mess him around.’

I turned, not sure if I had heard her correctly.

She had watched as an ambulance was unloaded by the shutters, and then rubbed her nose. ‘He’s all right. For a great lunk. And he really likes you.’

I hadn’t known what to say.

‘He does. He’s been talking about you. And he doesn’t talk about anyone. Don’t tell him I said anything. I just ... he’s all right. I just want you to know.’ She had raised her eyebrows at me then, and nodded, as if confirming something to herself.

‘I’ve just realized. You’re not in your dancing-girl outfit,’ said Daphne.

There was a murmur of recognition.

‘Did you get promoted?’

I was dragged from my thoughts. 'Oh. No. I got fired.'

'Where are you working now?'

'Nowhere. Yet.'

'But your outfit ...'

I was wearing my little black dress with the white collar. 'Oh. This. It's just a dress.'

'I thought you were working at a themed bar for secretaries. Or maybe French maids.'

'Don't you ever stop, Fred?'

'You don't understand. At my age, the phrase "Use it or lose it" takes on a certain urgency. I might only have twenty or so stiffies left in me.'

'Some of us have never had twenty stiffies in us in the first place.'

We paused to give Fred and Daphne time to stop giggling.

'And your future? It sounds like it's all change for you,' said Marc.

'Well ... I actually got offered another job.'

'You did?' There was a little ripple of applause, which made me blush.

'Oh, I'm not going to take it, but it's fine. I feel I've sort of moved on, just for being offered a job.'

William said: 'So what was the job?'

'Just something in New York.'

They all stared at me.

'You got a job offer in New York?'

'Yes.'

'A paid job?'

'With accommodation,' I said quietly.

'And you wouldn't have to wear that godawful shiny green dress?'

'I hardly think my outfit was a good enough reason to emigrate.' I laughed. Nobody else did. 'Oh, come on,' I said.

They were all still staring at me. Leanne's mouth might actually have been hanging open a little.

'New York New York?'

'You don't know the whole story. I can't go now. I have Lily to sort out.'

'The daughter of your ex-employer.' Jake was frowning at me.

'Well, he was more than my employer. But yes.'

'Does she have no family of her own, Louisa?' Daphne leaned forward.

'It's complicated.'

They all looked at each other.

Marc put his pad on his lap. ‘How much do you feel you’ve really learned from these sessions, Louisa?’

I had received the package from New York: a bundle of documents, with immigration and health-insurance forms, clipped together with a thick piece of cream notepaper on which Mr Leonard M. Gopnik forwarded me a formal offer to work for his family. I had locked myself into the bathroom to read it, then read it a second time, converted the salary to pounds, sighed for a bit, and promised myself I would not Google the address.

After I’d Googled the address I resisted the brief urge to lie on the floor in a foetal position. Then I got a grip, stood up and flushed the loo (in case Lily wondered what I was doing there), washed my hands (out of habit), and took it all into my bedroom where I stuffed it into the drawer under my bed and told myself I would never look at it again.

That night she had knocked on my bedroom door shortly before midnight.

Can I stay here? I don’t really want to go back to my mum’s.

You can stay as long as you want.

She had lain down on the other side of my bed and curled up in a little ball. I watched her sleep, then pulled the duvet over her.

Will’s daughter needed me. It was as simple as that. And, whatever my sister said, I owed him. Here was a way to feel I hadn’t been completely useless. I could still do something for him.

And that envelope proved I was someone who could get a decent job offer. That was progress. I had friends, a sort of boyfriend, even. This, too, was progress.

I ignored Nathan’s missed calls and deleted his voicemail messages. I would explain it all to him in a day or two. It felt, if not like a plan, then as close to one as I was going to get right now.

Sam was due shortly after I got back on Tuesday. He texted at seven to say he was going to be late. He sent another at a quarter past eight, saying he wasn’t sure what time he would make it. I’d felt flat all day, struggling with the stasis that comes from not having a job to go to, worries about how I was going to pay my bills, and being trapped in an apartment with someone else who similarly had nowhere to go and I was unwilling to leave by herself. At half nine the buzzer went. Sam was at the front door, still in

uniform. I let him in and stepped out into the corridor, closing the front door behind me. He emerged from the stairwell and walked towards me, his head down. He was grey with exhaustion and gave off a strange, disturbed energy.

‘I thought you weren’t coming. What happened? Are you okay?’

‘I’m being hauled up in front of Disciplinary.’

‘What?’

‘Another crew saw my rig outside the night we met Garside. They told Control. I couldn’t give them a good answer as to why we were attending something that wasn’t on the system.’

‘So what happened?’

‘I fudged it, said someone had come running out and asked us for help. And that it had turned out to be a prank. Donna backed me up, thank God. But they’re not happy.’

‘It’s not that bad, surely?’

‘And one of the A and E nurses asked Lily how she knew me. And she said I’d given her a lift home from a nightclub.’

My hand went to my mouth. ‘What does that mean?’

‘The union’s arguing my case. But if they find against me I’ll be suspended. Or worse.’ A new, deep furrow had etched its way between his brows.

‘Because of us. Sam, I’m so sorry.’

He shook his head. ‘She wasn’t to know.’

I was going to step forward and hold him then, to put my arms around him, rest my face against his. But something held me back: a sudden, unbidden image of Will, turning his face away from me, unreachable in his unhappiness. I faltered, then a second too late, reached out a hand instead and touched Sam’s arm. He glanced down at it, frowning slightly, and I had the slightly discomfiting sensation that he knew something of what had just passed through my head.

‘You could always give it up and raise your chickens. Build your house.’ I heard my voice, trying too hard. ‘You’ve got options! A man like you. You could do anything!’

He gave a half-smile that didn’t reach his eyes. He kept staring at my hand.

We stood there for an awkward moment. ‘I’d better go. Oh,’ he said, holding out a parcel. ‘Someone left this by the door. Didn’t think it would

last long in your lobby.'

'Come in, please.' I took it from him, feeling I had let him down. 'Let me cook you something badly. Come on.'

'I'd better get home.'

He walked back down the corridor before I could say anything else.

From the window, I watched him leave, walking stiffly back to his motorbike, and I felt a momentary cloud pass over me again. *Don't get too close.* And then I remembered Marc's advice at the end of the last session: *Understand that your grieving, anxious brain is simply responding to cortisol spikes. It is perfectly natural to be fearful of getting close to anyone.* Some days I felt as if I had two cartoon advisers constantly arguing on each side of my head.

In the living room Lily turned away from the television. 'Was that Ambulance Sam?'

'Yup.'

She went back to the television. Then the parcel grabbed her attention. 'What's that?'

'Oh. It was in the lobby. It's addressed to you.'

She stared suspiciously at it, as if she were still too conscious of the possibility of unpleasant surprises. Then she peeled back the layers of wrapping to reveal a leather-bound photograph album, its cover embossed with 'For Lily (Traynor)'.

She opened it slowly, and there, on the first page, covered with tissue, was the black and white photograph of a baby. Underneath it was a handwritten note.

Your father weighed 9lb 2oz. I was absolutely furious with him for being so big, as I'd been told I'd have a nice small one! He was a very cross baby and kept me running ragged for months. But when he smiled ... Oh! Old ladies would cross the road to tickle his cheeks (he hated this, of course).

I sat down beside her. Lily flicked forward two pages and there was Will, in a royal blue prep-school uniform and cap, scowling at the camera. The note underneath read:

Will hated that school cap so much that he hid it in the dog's basket. The second one he 'lost' in a pond. The third time his father threatened to stop his pocket money, but he simply traded football cards until he'd made it back. Even the school couldn't make him wear it – I think he had a weekly detention until he was thirteen.

Lily touched his face. 'I looked like him when I was small.'

‘Well,’ I said, ‘he’s your dad.’

She allowed herself a small smile, then turned to the next page. ‘Look. Look at this one.’

In the next photograph he smiled directly out at the camera – the same skiing-holiday picture that had been in his bedroom when we had first met. I gazed at his beautiful face and the familiar wave of sadness passed over me. And then, unexpectedly, Lily started to laugh. ‘Look! Look at this one!’ Will, his face covered with mud after a rugby game, another where he was dressed as a devil, taking a running jump off a haystack. A page of silliness – Will as prankster, laughing, human. I thought of the typed sheet Marc had given me after I had missed Idealization Week: *It is important not to turn the dead into saints. Nobody can walk in the shadow of a saint.*

I wanted you to see your father before his accident. He was fiercely ambitious and professional, yes, but I also remember times where he slid off his chair laughing, or danced with the dog, or came home covered with bruises because of some ridiculous dare. He once shoved his sister’s face into a bowl of sherry trifle (picture on right) because she had said he wouldn’t, and I wanted to be cross with him as it had taken me simply ages to make, but you really could never be cross with Will for very long.

No, you never could. Lily flicked through the other pictures, all with little notes beside them. This Will, rising from the pages, was not a two-line piece in a newspaper, a careful obituary, a solemn photograph illustrating a sad tale in a long-running legal debate; this was a man – alive, three-dimensional. I gazed at each picture, distantly aware of each lump in my throat as it rose and was overcome.

A card had slid out onto the floor. I picked it up and scanned the two-line message. ‘She wants to come and see you.’

Lily could barely tear her eyes from the album.

‘What do you think, Lily? Are you up for it?’

It took her a moment to hear me. ‘I don’t think so. I mean, it’s nice, but ...’

The mood changed. She closed the leather cover, put it neatly to the side of the sofa and turned back to the television. A few minutes later, without saying a word, she moved up the sofa beside me and let her head fall onto my shoulder.

That night, after Lily had gone to bed, I emailed Nathan.

I’m sorry. I can’t take it. It’s a long story, but I have Will’s daughter living with me and a lot has been going on and I can’t up and leave her. I have to do what’s right. I’ll try to

explain in brief ...

I ended,

Thank you for thinking of me.

I emailed Mr Gopnik, thanking him for his offer and stating that due to a change in circumstances I was very sorry but I wouldn't be able to take the job. I wanted to write more, but the huge knot in my stomach seemed to have drained all the energy from my fingertips.

I waited an hour but neither of them responded. When I walked back into the empty living room to turn off the lights the photograph album was gone.



CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

‘Well, well ... If it isn’t the employee of the year.’

I put the bag containing my uniform and wig down on the counter. The tables of the Shamrock and Clover were already full by breakfast time; a plump forty-something businessman, whose drooping head suggested an early start on the hard stuff, gazed blearily up at me, cradling his glass between fat hands. Vera was at the far end, angrily shifting tables and people’s feet to sweep under them as if she were chasing mice.

I was wearing a man’s style blue shirt – it was easier to feel confident if you were wearing men’s clothes, I had decided – and observed, distantly, that it was almost the same shade as Richard’s. ‘Richard – I wanted to talk to you about what happened last week.’

Around us the airport was half full of bank-holiday passengers; there were fewer suits than usual, and an undertow of small, crying children. Behind the till, a new banner offered the chance to ‘Get Your Trip Off to a Good Start! Coffee, Croissant and a Chaser!’ Richard moved briskly around the bar, placing newly filled cups of coffee and plastic-wrapped cereal bars on a tray, his brow furrowed in concentration. ‘Don’t bother. Is the uniform clean?’

He reached past me for the plastic bag and pulled out my green dress. He scanned it carefully under the strip-lights, his face set in a half-grimace, as if he were primed to spot unsavoury marks. I half expected him to sniff it.

‘Of course it’s clean.’

‘It needs to be in a suitable condition for a new employee to wear.’

‘It was washed yesterday,’ I snapped.

I noticed suddenly that a new version of *Celtic Pan Pipes* was playing. Fewer harp strings. Heavy on the flute.

‘Right. We have some paperwork in the back that you need to sign. I’ll go and get it and you can do that here. And then that’s it.’

‘Maybe we could just do this somewhere a bit more ... private?’

Richard Percival didn’t look at me. ‘Too busy, I’m afraid. I have a hundred things to do and I’m one staff member down today.’ He hustled past me officiously, counting aloud the remaining bags of Scampi Fries

hanging by the optics. 'Six ... seven ... Vera, can you serve that gentleman over there, please?'

'Yes, well, that's what I wanted to talk to you about. I was wondering if there was any way you –'

'Eight ... nine ... The wig.'

'What?'

'Where's the wig?'

'Oh. Here.' I reached into my bag and pulled it out. I had brushed it before putting it in its own bag. It sat, like a piece of blonde roadkill, waiting to make some other person's head itch.

'Did you wash it?'

'Wash the wig?'

'Yes. It's unhygienic for somebody else to put it on without you washing it first.'

'It's made of cheaper synthetic fibres than a cut-price Barbie's. I assumed it would basically melt in a washing-machine.'

'If it's not in suitable condition for a future staff member to wear, I'm going to have to charge you for a replacement.'

I stared at him. 'You're charging me for the wig?'

He held it up, then stuffed it back into the bag. 'Twenty-eight pounds forty. I will, of course, provide you with a receipt.'

'Oh, my God. You really are going to charge me for the wig.'

I laughed. I stood in the middle of the crowded airport, as the planes took off, and I thought about what my life had become working for this man. I pulled my purse from my pocket. 'Fine,' I said. 'Twenty-eight pounds forty, you say? Tell you what, I'll round it up to thirty, you know, to include administrative expenses.'

'You don't need to –'

I counted out the notes, and slammed them onto the bar in front of him. 'You know something, Richard? I like working. If you'd looked beyond your bloody targets for five minutes you would have seen that I was somebody who actually wanted to do well. I worked hard. I wore your horrific uniform, even though it turned my hair static and made small children jig in the street behind me. I did everything you asked, including cleaning men's loos, which I'm pretty sure was not in my contract, and which, in actual employment law, I'm sure should have meant the provision of a Hazchem suit at least. I stood in for extra shifts while you searched for

new bartenders because you've alienated every single member of staff who ever came through this door, and I have upsold your wretched dry-roasted peanuts even though they smell like someone breaking wind.

'But I'm not an automaton. I'm human and I have a life, and just for a short while I had responsibilities that meant I couldn't be the employee you – or I – would have liked. I came here today to ask for my job back – actually, to beg for my job back, as I still have responsibilities and I want a job. I *need* a job. But I just realized I don't want this one. I'd rather work for free than spend another day in this miserable, soul-destroying pan-pipe-chuffing bar. I would rather clean toilets *for free* than work one more day for you.

'So thank you, Richard. You've actually prompted my first positive decision in as long as I can remember.' I rammed my purse into my bag, pushed the wig towards him, and made to leave. 'You can stick your job in the same place you can stick those peanuts.' I turned back. 'Oh, and that thing you do with your hair? All that gel stuff and the perfectly even top thing? Awful. It makes you look like Action Man.'

The businessman sat up on his bar stool and gave a little round of applause. Richard's hand went involuntarily to his head.

I glanced at the businessman, then back at Richard. 'Actually, forget the last bit. That was mean.'

And I left.

I was striding across the concourse, my heart still thumping, when I heard him. '*Louisa! Louisa!*'

Richard was half walking, half running behind me. I considered ignoring him, but finally came to a halt by the perfume concession. 'What?' I said. 'Did I miss a peanut crumb?'

He stopped, puffing slightly. He studied the shop window for a few seconds, as if he was thinking. Then he faced me. 'You're right. Okay? You're right.'

I stared at him.

'The Shamrock and Clover. It's a horrible place. And I know I've not been the greatest to work for. But all I can tell you is that, for every miserable directive I give you, my nuts are being squeezed ten times harder by Head Office. My wife hates me because I'm never home. The suppliers hate me because I have to cut their margins every single week because of pressure from shareholders. My regional manager says I'm

underperforming on units shifted and if I don't pull it out of the bag I'm going to get sent to the North Wales Passenger Ferry branch. At which point my wife will actually leave me. And I won't blame her.

'I hate managing people. I have the social skills of a lamppost, which is why I can't hang on to anyone. Vera only stays because she has the skin of a rhino and I suspect she's secretly after my job. So there – I'm sorry. I'd actually quite like to give you your job back because, whatever I said earlier, you were pretty good. Customers liked you.'

He sighed, and looked out over the milling crowds around us. 'But you know what, Louisa? You should get out while you can. You're pretty, you're smart, hardworking – you could get something way better than this. If I wasn't locked into a mortgage that I can barely afford, a baby on the way and payments to make on a fricking Honda Civic that makes me feel about 120 years old, believe me, I'd be taking off out of here faster than one of those planes.' He held out a hand with a payslip. 'Your holiday pay. Now go. Seriously, Louisa. Get out.'

I looked down at the little brown envelope in my hand. Around us the passengers moved at a crawl, pausing at outlet windows, checking for vanished passports, oblivious to what was going on in their midst. And I knew, with a weary inevitability, what was going to happen.

'Richard? Thanks for that, but ... could I still have the job? Even if it's just for a bit? I do actually really need it.'

Richard looked as if he couldn't believe what I was saying. Then he let out a sigh. 'Actually, if you could do a couple of months it would be a massive relief. I'm right up the proverbial creek here. In fact, if you could start now I could make it over to the wholesalers to pick up the new beer mats.'

We swapped places; a little waltz of mutual disappointment.

'I'll call home,' I said.

'Oh. Here,' he said. We gazed at each other a moment longer, and then he handed me the plastic bag containing my uniform. 'I guess you'll be needing this.'

Richard and I settled into a routine of sorts. He treated me with a little more consideration, only asking me to do the Gents on the days when Noah, the new cleaner, failed to turn up, not commenting if he thought I was spending too long talking to customers (even if he did look a bit pained). In turn I

was cheerful and punctual and careful to upsell when I could. I felt an odd responsibility towards his nuts.

One day he took me to one side and said that, while it was possibly a little premature, Head Office had told him they were looking to elevate one of the permanent staff to an assistant managerial position and if things carried on as they were he felt very much inclined to put my name forward. ('I can't risk promoting Vera. She'd put floor cleaner in my tea to get my job.') I thanked him and tried to look more delighted than I felt.

Lily, meanwhile, asked Samir for a job, and he said he would take her for a half-day's trial if she would do it for free. I handed her a coffee at seven thirty, and made sure she left the flat dressed and ready in time for her eight o'clock start. When I returned home that evening, she had apparently got the job, albeit on £2.73 an hour, which I discovered was the lowest rate he could legally pay her. She had spent most of the day moving crates in the back storeroom and putting prices on tins with an ancient sticker gun, while Samir and his cousin watched football on his iPad. She was filthy and exhausted, but curiously happy. 'If I last a month he says he'll consider putting me on the till.'

I had a shift change, so on Thursday afternoon we drove to Lily's parents' house in St John's Wood, and I waited in the car while Lily went in and collected some more clothes and the Kandinsky print that she had promised would look good in my flat. She emerged twenty minutes later, her face furious and closed. Tanya walked out into the porch, her arms folded, watching silently as Lily opened the boot and threw in an overstuffed holdall and, more carefully, the print. Then she climbed into the front seat and gazed straight ahead at the empty road. As Tanya closed the door behind her, there was a small possibility that she was wiping her eyes.

I put my key into the ignition.

'When I grow up,' Lily said, and perhaps only I could have detected the faint tremor in her voice, 'I am not going to be *anything* like my mother.'

I waited a moment, then started the car and we drove in silence back to my flat.

Fancy the pictures tonight? I could do with some escapism.

I don't think I should leave Lily.

Bring her?

I'd better not. Sorry, Sam x

That evening I found Lily out on the fire escape. She looked up at the sound of the window opening and waved a cigarette. 'Thought it was a bit mean to keep smoking in your flat, given that you don't.'

I wedged the window open, climbed out carefully, and sat down on the iron steps beside her. Below us the car park simmered in the August heat, the scent of hot tarmac rising into the still air. A car with the bonnet up thumped bass from its sound system. The metal of the steps retained the warmth of a month of sunny afternoons and I leaned back, closing my eyes.

'I thought it would all work out,' Lily said.

I opened them.

'I thought if I could just get Peter to go away all my problems would be solved. I thought if I could find my dad I would feel like I belonged somewhere. And now Peter's gone, and Garside's gone, and I know about my dad and I have you. But nothing feels like I expected.'

I was about to tell her not to be silly. I was about to point out that she had come such a long way in a short time, that she had her first job, prospects, a bright future – the standard adult responses. But they sounded trite and patronizing.

At the end of the road a bunch of office workers huddled round a metal table by the pub's rear door. Later tonight it would be packed with hipsters and strays from the City, spilling out with drinks across the pavement, their raucous calls filtering in through my open window. 'I know what you mean,' I said. 'I've been waiting to feel normal again since your dad died. I feel like I'm basically going through the motions. I'm still in a crappy job. I still live in this flat, which I don't think is ever going to feel like home. I had a near-death experience, but I can't say it gave me wisdom or gratitude for life or anything. I go to a grief-counselling group full of people who are as stuck as I am. But I haven't really done anything.'

Lily thought about this. 'You helped me.'

'That's pretty much the one thing I hang onto most days.'

'And you have a boyfriend.'

'He's not my boyfriend.'

'Sure, Louisa.'

We watched the traffic crawl down towards the City. Lily took a final drag of her cigarette, and stubbed it out on the metal step.

'That's my next thing,' I said.

She had the grace to look slightly guilty. 'I know. I will stop. I promise.'

Across the rooftops the sun had started to slide, its orange glow diffused by the lead-grey air of the City evening.

‘You know, Lily, perhaps some things just take longer than others. I think we’ll get there, though.’

She linked her arm through mine and let her head rest on my shoulder. We watched the sun’s gentle fall, and the lengthening shadows creeping towards us, and I thought about the New York skyline and that nobody was truly free. Perhaps all freedom – physical, personal – only came at the cost of somebody or something else.

The sun vanished, and the orange sky began to turn petrol-blue. When we stood up, Lily smoothed her skirt, then gazed at the packet in her hand. She pulled the remaining cigarettes abruptly from the wrapper and snapped them in half, then flung them into the air, a confetti of tobacco and white paper. She looked at me triumphantly and held up her hand. ‘There. I am officially a smoke-free zone.’

‘Just like that.’

‘Why not? You said it might take longer than we thought. Well, that’s my first step. What’s yours?’

‘Oh, God. Maybe I’ll persuade Richard to let me stop wearing that godawful nylon wig.’

‘That would be an excellent first step. It would be nice not to get an electric shock off every door handle in your flat.’

Her smile was infectious. I took the empty cigarette packet from her before she could litter the car park with that too, and stood back so she could climb through the window. She stopped and turned to me, as if she had suddenly thought of something. ‘You know, falling in love with someone else doesn’t mean that you loved my dad any less. You don’t have to be sad just to stay connected to him.’

I stared at her.

‘It’s just a thought.’ She shrugged and climbed back in through the window.

I woke the next day to find that Lily had already gone to work. She’d left a note saying she would bring some bread home at lunchtime as we were a bit short. I had drunk some coffee, had breakfast and put on my trainers to go for a walk (Marc: ‘exercise is as good for your spirit as it is for your body!’) when my mobile rang – a number I didn’t recognize.

‘Hello!’

It took me a minute. ‘Mum?’

‘Look out your window!’

I walked across the living room and gazed out. My mother was on the pavement waving vigorously.

‘What – what are you doing here? Where’s Dad?’

‘He’s at home.’

‘Is Granddad okay?’

‘Granddad’s fine.’

‘But you never come to London by yourself. You don’t even go past the petrol station without Dad in tow.’

‘Well, it was about time I changed, wasn’t it? Shall I come up? I don’t want to use up all the minutes on my new phone.’

I buzzed her in, and went around the living room, clearing the worst of last night’s dishes, and by the time she reached the door I was standing there, arms open, ready to greet her.

She was wearing her good anorak, her handbag slung satchel-style over her shoulder (‘Harder for muggers to snatch it’) and her hair styled into soft waves around her neck. She was beaming, her lips carefully outlined in coral-pink lipstick, and clutching the family A–Z, which dated back to some time around 1983.

‘I can’t believe you came by yourself.’

‘Isn’t it wonderful? I actually feel quite giddy. I told a young man on the tube that it was the first time I’d been on the Underground in thirty years without someone holding my hand, and he moved a full four seats down the carriage. I got quite hysterical with laughter. Will you put the kettle on?’ She sat, pulling off her coat, and gazed at the walls around her. ‘Well now. The green is ... interesting.’

‘Lily’s choice.’ I wondered fleetingly if her arrival was some great joke and Dad was about to barrel in through my front door, laughing at what a great eejit I was, believing Josie would come anywhere by herself. I put a mug in front of her. ‘I don’t understand. Why did you come without Dad?’

She took a sip of the tea. ‘Oh, that’s lovely. You always did make the best cup of tea.’ She put it on the table, carefully sliding a paperback book under it first. ‘Well, I woke up this morning and I thought about all the things I had to do – put a wash on, clean the back windows, change Granddad’s bedding, buy toothpaste – and I just suddenly thought, Nope. I can’t do it.

I'm not going to waste a glorious Saturday doing the same thing I've done for thirty years. I'm going to have an adventure.'

'An adventure.'

'So I thought we could go to a show.'

'A show.'

'Yes – a show. Louisa, have you turned into a parrot? Mrs Cousins from the insurance brokers says there's a stall in Leicester Square where you can buy cheap tickets on the day for shows that aren't full. I was wondering if you'd like to come with me.'

'What about Treena?'

Mum waved a hand. 'Oh, she was busy. So what do you say? Shall we go and see if we can get some tickets?'

'I'll have to tell Lily.'

'Then go and tell her. I'll finish my tea, you can do something with that hair of yours, and we'll head off. I've got a one-day travelcard, you know! I might just hop on and off the Underground all day!'

We got half-price tickets to *Billy Elliot*. It was that or a Russian tragedy, and Mum said she'd been funny about Russians since someone had given her cold beetroot soup and tried to pretend that was how the Russians ate it.

She sat rapt beside me for the entire performance, nudging me and muttering at intervals, 'I remember the actual miners' strike, Louisa. It was very hard on those poor families. Margaret Thatcher! Do you remember her? Oh, she was a terrible woman. Always had a nice handbag, though.' When the young Billy flew into the air, apparently fuelled by his ambitions, she wept quietly beside me, a fresh white handkerchief pressed to her nose.

I watched the boy's dance teacher, Mrs Wilkinson, a woman whose ambitions had never lifted her beyond the confines of the town, and tried not to see anything of my own life. I was a woman with a job and a sort-of-boyfriend, sitting in a West End theatre on a Saturday afternoon. I totted these things up as if they were little victories against some foe I couldn't quite identify.

We emerged into the afternoon light dazed and emotionally spent. 'Right,' said Mum, tucking her handbag firmly under her arm (some habits die hard). 'Tea at a hotel. C'mon. We'll make a day of it.'

We couldn't get into any of the grand ones, but we found a nice hotel near Haymarket with a tea selection that Mum approved of. She asked for a

table in the middle of the room and sat there remarking on every person who walked in, noting their dress, whether they looked like they came from 'abroad', their lack of wisdom in bringing small children, or little dogs that looked like rats.

'Well, look at us!' she would exclaim every now and then, when it grew quiet. 'Isn't this nice?'

We ordered English Breakfast tea (Mum: 'That's just posh for normal tea, yes? None of those weird flavours?') and the 'Afternoon Tea Fancy Plate' and we ate tiny crustless sandwiches, little scones that weren't as good as Mum made and cakes in gold foil. Mum talked for half an hour about *Billy Elliot* and how she thought we should all do this once a month or so and she bet that my father would love it if we could get him down here.

'How is Dad?'

'Oh, he's fine. You know your father.'

I wanted to ask, but was too afraid. When I looked up, she was gazing at me a little beadily. 'And no, Louisa, I am not doing my legs. And, no, he's not happy. But there are more important things in life.'

'What did he say about you coming here today?'

She snorted, and covered it up with a little coughing fit. 'He didn't believe I was going to. I told him about it when I brought him up his tea this morning, and he started to laugh, and if I'm honest with you it annoyed me so much I got dressed and I just went.'

My eyes widened. 'You didn't tell him?'

'I already had told him. He's been leaving messages on this phone thing all day, the eejit.' She peered at the screen, then tucked it neatly back into her pocket.

I sat and watched her fork another little scone delicately onto her plate. She closed her eyes in pleasure as she took a bite. 'This is just marvellous.'

I swallowed. 'Mum, you're not going to get divorced, are you?'

Her eyes shot open. 'Divorced? I'm a good Catholic girl, Louisa. We don't divorce. We just make our men suffer for all eternity!'

I paid the bill, and we disappeared to the Ladies, a cavernous room of walnut-coloured marble and expensive flowers, overseen by a silent attendant who stood by the basins. Mum washed her hands twice, thoroughly, then sniffed the various hand lotions lined up against the sink, pulling faces in the mirror depending on what she liked. 'I shouldn't say so,

given my opposition to the patriarchy and all, but I do wish one of you girls had a nice man.'

'I've met someone,' I said, before I realized I'd said it.

She turned to me, a lotion bottle in her hand. 'You haven't!'

'He's a paramedic.'

'Well, that's smashing. A paramedic! That's almost as useful as a plumber. So when are we going to meet him?'

I faltered. 'Meet him? I'm not sure it's ...'

'It's what?'

'Well. I mean, it's early days. I'm not sure it's that kind of –'

My mother unscrewed the lid of her lipstick and stared into the mirror. 'It's just for sex, is that what you're saying?'

'Mum!' I glanced at the attendant.

'Well, what are you saying?'

'I'm not sure I'm ready for a real relationship just yet.'

'Why? What else have you got going on? Those ovaries won't go in the freezer, you know.'

'So why didn't Treena come?' I said, hurriedly changing the subject.

'She couldn't find a sitter for Thom.'

'You said she was busy.'

Mum's eyes darted across to my reflection. She pressed her lips together and snapped her lipstick back into her handbag. 'She seems to be a little cross with you right now, Louisa.' She activated Maternal X-ray Vision. 'Have you two had a falling out?'

'I don't know why she always has to have opinions about everything I do.' I heard my own voice, the sulky tones of a twelve-year-old.

She fixed me with a look.

So I told her. I sat up on the marble basin, and Mum took the easy chair, and I told her about the job offer and why I couldn't possibly take it, how we had lost Lily and found her again, and how she was finally beginning to come out of the other side. 'I've arranged for her to meet Mrs Traynor again. So we're moving forward. But Treena just won't listen, although if Thom were going through half the same thing she'd be the first person saying I couldn't walk away from him.'

I felt relieved telling my mother. She, of all people, would understand the ties of responsibility. 'So that's why she's not talking to me.'

My mother was staring at me.

‘Jesus, Mary, and Joseph, have you lost your mind?’

‘What?’

‘A job in New York with all the trimmings and you’re sticking around here to work in that godawful place at the airport? Did you hear this?’ She turned to the attendant. ‘I can’t believe she’s my own daughter. Honest to God, I wonder what happened to the brains she was born with.’

The attendant shook her head slowly. ‘No good,’ she said.

‘Mum! I’m doing the right thing!’

‘For whom?’

‘For Lily!’

‘You think nobody other than you could have helped get that girl back on her feet? Well, did you speak to this chap in New York and ask him whether you could defer the job offer a few weeks?’

‘It’s not that kind of a job.’

‘How would you know? You don’t ask, you don’t get. Isn’t that right?’

The attendant nodded slowly.

‘Oh, Jesus. When I think about it ...’

The attendant gave my mother a hand towel and she fanned her neck vigorously with it. ‘Listen to me, Louisa. I’ve got one brilliant daughter stuck at home weighed down with responsibility because she made a bad choice early on – not that I don’t love Thom to bits, but I’ll tell you, I want to cry my heart out when I think of what Treena could have become if she’d just had that boy a bit later. I’m stuck looking after your father and Granddad, and that’s fine. I’m finding my way. But this should not be the most you have to look forward to in your life, you hear me? Not a bunch of half-price tickets and a fancy tea every now and then. You should be out there! You’re the one person in our family with an actual ruddy chance! And to hear you’ve just chucked it away for the sake of some girl you barely even know!’

‘I did the *right thing*, Mum.’

‘Maybe you did. Or maybe it wasn’t actually an either/or situation.’

‘You don’t ask, you don’t get,’ said the attendant.

‘There! This lady knows. You need to get back there and ask this American gentleman is there any way you can come along a bit later ... Don’t you look at me like that, Louisa. I’ve been too soft on you. I haven’t pushed you when I should have done. You need to get yourself out of that dead-end job of yours and start living.’

‘The job is gone, Mum.’

‘Gone my pearly-handled backside it is. Have you actually asked them?’
I shook my head.

Mum huffed and adjusted the scarf around her neck. She pulled two pound coins from her purse and pressed them into the hand of the attendant. ‘Well, I have to say, haven’t you done a grand job! You could eat your supper off this floor. And it all smells simply gorgeous.’

The attendant smiled at her warmly, and then, almost as an afterthought, held up a finger. She peered out of the door, then walked to her cupboard, unlocking it swiftly with a bunch of keys. She emerged and pressed a bar of floral soap into Mum’s hands.

Mum sniffed it and sighed. ‘Well, that is just *heaven*. Just a little piece of heaven.’

‘For you.’

‘For me?’

The woman closed Mum’s hands around it.

‘Well, aren’t you the kindest? May I ask your name?’

‘Maria.’

‘Maria, I’m Josie. I’m going to make sure I come back to London and use your toilet the very next time I’m here. Do you see that, Louisa? Who knows what happens when you break out a little? How’s that for an adventure? And I got the most gorgeous bar of soap from my lovely new friend Maria here!’ They clasped hands with the fervency of old acquaintances about to be parted, and we left the hotel.

I couldn’t tell her. I couldn’t tell her that that job haunted me from the moment I woke until I went to sleep. Whatever I said to anyone else, I knew I would always regret to my bones missing the chance to live and work in New York. That no matter how much I told myself there would be other chances, other places, this would be the lost opportunity I carried, like a cheap handbag I regretted buying, wherever I went.

And sure enough, after I had waved her off on the train to my, no doubt, bemused and blustering father, and long after I had made a salad for Lily from bits that Sam had left in the fridge, when I checked my email that night there was a message from Nathan.

I can’t say I agree, but I do get what you’re doing. I guess Will would have been proud of you. You’re a good person, Clark x



CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

These are the things I learned about being a parent, while not actually being a parent. That whatever you did you would probably be wrong. If you were cruel or dismissive or neglectful, you would leave scars upon your charge. If you were supportive and loving, encouraging and praising them for even their smallest achievements – getting out of bed on time, say, or managing not to smoke for a whole day – it would ruin them in different ways. I learned that if you were a *de facto* parent all these things applied but you had none of the natural authority you might reasonably expect when feeding and looking after another person.

With all this in mind, I loaded Lily into the car on my day off and announced that we were going to lunch. It would probably go horribly wrong, I told myself, but at least there would be two of us there to shoulder it.

Because Lily was so busy staring at her phone, with her earphones plugged in, it was a good forty minutes before she looked out the car window. She frowned as we approached a signpost. ‘This isn’t the way to your mum and dad’s.’

‘I know.’

‘Then where are we going?’

‘I told you. To lunch.’

When she had stared at me long enough to accept that I wasn’t going to elaborate, she squinted out the window for a while. ‘God, you’re annoying sometimes.’

Half an hour later we pulled up at the Crown and Garter, a red-brick hotel set in two acres of parkland, about twenty minutes south of Oxford. Neutral territory, I had decided, was the way forward. Lily climbed out and shut the door emphatically enough to send me the message that this was *actually still quite annoying*.

I ignored her, put on a slick of lipstick and walked into the restaurant, letting Lily follow.

Mrs Traynor was already at a table. When Lily saw her, she let out a little groan.

‘Why are we doing this again?’

‘Because things change,’ I said, and propelled her forwards.

‘Lily.’ Mrs Traynor rose to her feet. She had evidently been to a hairdresser, and her hair was once again beautifully cut and blow-dried. She was wearing a little make-up, too, and those two things conspired to make her look like the Mrs Traynor of old: self-possessed, someone who understood that appearances were, if not everything, at least the foundation of something.

‘Hello, Mrs Traynor.’

‘Hi,’ Lily mumbled. She didn’t reach out a hand, but positioned herself at the seat beside mine.

Mrs Traynor registered this, but gave a brief smile, sat down and summoned the waiter. ‘This restaurant was one of your father’s favourites,’ she said, placing her napkin on her lap. ‘On the rare occasions I could persuade him to leave London, this is where we would meet. It’s rather good food. Michelin-starred.’

I looked at the menu – *turbot quenelles with a frangipane of mussels and langoustine, smoked duck breast with cavalo nero and Israeli couscous* – and hoped very much that as Mrs Traynor had suggested this restaurant she would pay.

‘It looks a bit fussy,’ said Lily, not lifting her head from the menu.

I glanced at Mrs Traynor.

‘That’s exactly what Will said too. But it is very good. I think I’ll have the quail.’

‘I’ll have the sea bass,’ Lily said, and closed the leather-bound menu.

I stared at the list in front of me. There was nothing here I even recognized. What was *rutabaga*? What was *ravioli of bone marrow and samphire*? I wondered if I could ask for a sandwich.

‘Are you ready to order?’ The waiter appeared beside me. I waited as the others reeled off their choices. Then I spotted a word I recognized from my time in Paris. ‘Can I have the *joues de boeuf confites*?’

‘With the potato gnocchi and asparagus? Certainly, Madame.’

Beef, I thought. I can do beef.

We talked of small things while waiting for our starters. I told Mrs Traynor that I was still working at the airport but was being considered for a promotion and tried to make it sound like a positive career choice rather than a cry for help. I told her Lily had found a job, and when she heard what

Lily was doing, Mrs Traynor didn't shudder, as I had secretly been afraid she might, but nodded. 'That sounds eminently sensible. It never hurts to get your hands dirty when you're starting out.'

'It's not got any prospects,' Lily said firmly. 'Unless you count being allowed to move onto the till.'

'Well, neither does having a paper round. But your father did that for two years before he left school. It instils a work ethic.'

'And people always need tins of frankfurters,' I observed.

'Do they really?' said Mrs Traynor, and looked briefly appalled.

We watched as another table was seated beside us, an elderly woman lowered with much fuss and exclamation into a chair by two male relatives.

'We got your photograph album,' I said.

'Oh, you did! I had wondered. Did ... did you like it?'

Lily's eyes flickered towards her. 'It was nice, thank you,' she said.

Mrs Traynor took a sip of her water. 'I wanted to show you another side of Will. I feel sometimes as if his life has been rather taken over by what happened when he died. I just wanted to show that he was more than a wheelchair. More than the manner of his death.'

There was a brief silence.

'It was nice, thank you,' Lily repeated.

Our food arrived, and Lily grew silent again. The waiters hovered officiously, filling water glasses when their levels fell by a centimetre. A breadboard was offered, removed and re-offered five minutes later. The restaurant filled with people like Mrs Traynor: well-dressed, well-spoken, people for whom *turbot quenelles* was a standard lunch and not a conversational minefield. Mrs Traynor asked after my family, and spoke warmly of my father. 'He did such a very good job at the castle.'

'It must be strange, not going back,' I said, then winced internally, wondering if I'd breached some invisible line.

But Mrs Traynor just gazed at the tablecloth in front of her. 'It is,' she agreed, and nodded, her smile a little tighter, then drank some more water.

The conversation carried on like this through our starters (smoked salmon for Lily, salad for Mrs Traynor and me), stalling and moving forward in fits and starts, like someone learning to drive a car. It was with some relief that I saw the waiter approach with our main courses. My smile disappeared as he placed my plate in front of me. It did not look like beef. It looked like soggy brown discs in a thick brown sauce.

‘I’m sorry,’ I said to the waiter. ‘I ordered the beef?’

He let his gaze hang on me for a moment. ‘This is the beef, Madame.’

We both stared at my plate.

‘*Joues de boeuf?*’ he said. ‘Beef cheeks?’

‘Beef *cheeks?*’

We both stared at my plate and my stomach did a little flip.

‘Oh, of course,’ I said. ‘I – yes. Beef cheeks. Thank you.’

Beef cheeks. I was too afraid to ask from which end they came. I wasn’t sure which would be worse. I smiled at Mrs Traynor, and set about nibbling my gnocchi.

We ate in near silence. Mrs Traynor and I were both running out of conversational options. Lily spoke little, and when she did say something it was spiky, as if she were testing her grandmother. She toyed with her food, a reluctant teen dragged along to a too-fancy lunch with the grown-ups. I ate mine in small forkfuls, trying not to listen to the little voice that kept squeaking in my ear: *You’re eating cheeks! Actual cheeks!*

Eventually we ordered coffee. When the waiter had gone, Mrs Traynor removed her napkin and put it on the table. ‘I can’t do this any longer.’

Lily’s head lifted. She looked at me and back at Mrs Traynor.

‘The food is very nice and it’s lovely hearing about your jobs and all, but this really isn’t going to move us forward, is it?’

I wondered if she was going to leave, whether Lily had pushed her too far. I saw the surprise in Lily’s face and realized she was thinking it too. But instead Mrs Traynor pushed away her cup and saucer, and leaned forward over the table. ‘Lily, I didn’t come to impress you with a fancy lunch. I came to say I’m sorry. It’s hard to explain how I was when you turned up that day, but that unfortunate meeting was not your fault, and I want to apologize that your introduction to this side of your family has been so ... inadequate.’

The waiter approached with the coffee, and Mrs Traynor lifted her hand without turning. ‘Can you leave us for two minutes, please?’

He backed away swiftly with his tray. I sat very still. Mrs Traynor, her face taut and her voice urgent, took a breath. ‘Lily, I lost my son – your father – and in truth I probably lost him some time before he died. His death took away everything my life was built on: my role as a mother, my family, my career, even my faith. I have felt, frankly, as if I descended into a dark

hole. But to discover that he had a daughter – that I have a granddaughter – has made me think all might not be lost.’

She swallowed.

‘I’m not going to say that you’ve returned part of him to me, because that wouldn’t be fair on you. You are, as I’ve already grasped, very much your own person. You’ve brought me a whole new person to care about. I hope you’ll give me a second chance, Lily. Because I would very much like – no, *dammit* – I would *love* for us to spend time together. Louisa tells me you’re a strong character. Well, you should know that it runs in your family. So we’ll probably butt heads a few times, just as I did with your father. But essentially, if nothing else comes of today, you must know this.’

She took Lily’s hand and gripped it. ‘I’m so very glad to know you. You’ve changed everything so much simply by existing. My daughter, your aunt Georgina, is flying over next month to meet you, and has already been asking if the two of us might go over to Sydney and stay with her at some point. I have a letter from her for you in my handbag.’

Her voice dropped. ‘I know we can never make up for your father not being here, and I know I’m not – well, I’m still climbing out of things rather – but ... do you think ... perhaps you could find some room for a rather difficult grandmother?’

Lily stared at her.

‘Might you at least ... give it a go?’

Mrs Traynor’s voice cracked slightly on the last sentence. There was a long silence. I could hear the beating of my heart in my ears. Lily looked at me, and after what seemed like an eternity, she looked back at Mrs Traynor. ‘Would you ... would you want me to come and stay with you?’

‘If you wanted to. Yes, I would like that very much.’

‘When?’

‘When can you come?’

I’d never seen Camilla Traynor anything less than composed, but at that moment her face crumpled. Her other hand crept across the table. After a second’s hesitation, Lily took it, and they gripped each other’s fingers tightly across the white linen, like survivors of a shipwreck, while the waiter stood holding his tray, unsure when he could safely move forward again.

‘I’ll bring her back tomorrow afternoon.’

I stood in the car park as Lily hung back by Mrs Traynor's car. She had eaten two puddings – her chocolate molten pot and my own (I had completely lost my appetite by then) and was casually examining the waistband of her jeans. 'You're sure?' I wasn't sure which of them I was directing this to. I was conscious how fragile this new *entente cordiale* was, how easy it would be for it to flare up and go wrong.

'We'll be fine.'

'I don't have work tomorrow, Louisa,' Lily called out. 'Samir's cousin does Sundays.'

It felt odd leaving them there, even if Lily was beaming. I wanted to say 'no smoking', and 'no swearing' and maybe even 'How about we do this some other time?' but Lily waved and climbed into the passenger seat of Mrs Traynor's Golf with barely a backward glance.

It was done. Out of my hands.

Mrs Traynor turned to join her.

'Mrs Traynor? Can I ask you something?'

She stopped. 'Camilla. I think you and I are beyond formalities, don't you?'

'Camilla. Did you ever speak to Lily's mother?'

'Ah. Yes, I did.' She stooped to pick some tiny weed out of a border. 'I told her I was hoping to spend a lot of time with Lily in the future. And that I was quite conscious that in her eyes I was no kind of maternal role model, but that, frankly, none of us appeared to be ideal in that role, and it would behove her to think carefully, for once, about putting her child's happiness before her own.'

My jaw might have dropped a little. "'Behove" is an excellent word,' I said, when I could speak.

'It is rather, isn't it?' She straightened. The faintest hint of mischief glinted in her eyes. 'Yes. Well. The Tanya Houghton-Millers of this world hold no fears for me. I think we'll rub along just fine, Lily and I.'

I made to move back to my car, but this time Mrs Traynor stopped me. 'Thank you, Louisa.'

Her hand lay on my arm. 'I didn't d—

'You did. I'm very much aware that I have an awful lot to thank you for. At some point I hope I can do something for you.'

'Oh, you don't need to. I'm fine.'

Her eyes searched mine, and she gave me a small smile. Her lipstick, I noticed, was perfect. 'Well, I'll ring you tomorrow about dropping Lily home.'

Mrs Traynor tucked her handbag under her arm and walked back to her car, where Lily was waiting.

I watched the Golf disappear, and then I called Sam.

A buzzard wheeled lazily in the azure sky above the field, its enormous wings suspended in the shimmering blue. I had offered to help him finish some bricklaying but we had done one row (I had handed him the bricks). The sultry heat was such that he had suggested we had a cold beer during our break, and somehow after we had lain back in the grass for a while, it had proven impossible to get up again. I had told him the story of the beef cheeks and he had laughed for a full minute, trying to straighten his face when I protested that *If they had only called them something else and I mean, it's like being told you're eating chicken buttock or something*. Now I was stretched out beside him, listening to the birds and the gentle whisper of the grass, watching the peach-coloured sun slide gently towards the horizon, and thought, when I was managing not to worry whether Lily had used the word *pussy-whipped* yet, that life was not all bad.

'Sometimes when it's like this I think I might not bother building the house at all,' said Sam. 'I might just lie in a field till I get old.'

'Good plan.' I was chewing a grass stalk. 'Except the rainwater shower is going to seem a lot less appealing in January.'

I felt his laugh, a low rumble.

I had come straight to him from the restaurant, inexplicably unbalanced by the unexpected absence of Lily. I didn't want to be in the flat alone. When I had pulled up in the gateway of Sam's field, I had sat as my car engine ticked its way to sleep and watched him, content in his own company, scraping mortar onto each brick and pressing it to the next, wiping the sweat from his brow on his faded T-shirt, and I had felt something in me unwind. He had said nothing about the slight awkwardness of our last few conversations and I was grateful.

A solitary cloud drifted across the blue. Sam shifted his leg closer to mine. His feet were twice the size of my own.

'I wonder whether Mrs T has got her photographs out again. You know, for Lily.'

‘Photographs?’

‘Framed pictures. I told you. She didn’t have a single one of Will anywhere that time Lily and I went to her house. I was quite surprised when she sent the album because a little bit of me had wondered if she’d destroyed them all.’

He was silent, thinking.

‘It’s odd. But when I thought about it, I don’t have any pictures of Will on display either. Maybe it just takes a while to ... to be able to have them looking at you again. How long did it take you to have your sister by your bed again?’

‘I never took her down. I like having her there, especially looking like ... like she used to look.’ He lifted his arm above his head. ‘She used to give it to me straight. Typical big sister. When I think I’ve got something wrong, I look at that picture and I hear her voice. *Sam, you great lunk, just get on with it.*’ He turned his face towards me. ‘And, you know, it’s good for Jake to see her around. He needs to feel that it’s okay to talk about her.’

‘Maybe I’ll put one up. It will be nice for Lily to have pictures of her dad in the flat.’

The hens were loose and a few feet away two of them shivered into a patch of dirt, ruffling their feathers and wiggling, sending up little clouds of dust. Poultry, it turned out, had personalities. There was the bossy chestnut, the affectionate one with the piebald comb, the little bantam that had to be plucked out of the tree every evening and put to bed in the coop.

‘Do you think I should text her? To see how it’s going?’

‘Who?’

‘Lily.’

‘Leave them. They’ll be fine.’

‘I know you’re right. It’s weird. I was watching her in that restaurant and she’s so much more like him than I first realized. I think Mrs Traynor – Camilla – could see it, too. She kept blinking at Lily’s mannerisms, like she was suddenly remembering stuff Will did. There was this one time when Lily raised an eyebrow, and neither of us could take our eyes off her. She did it just like he used to.’

‘So what do you want to do tonight?’

‘Oh ... I don’t mind. You choose.’ I stretched out, feeling the grass tickle my neck. ‘I might just lie here. If you happened to fall gently on top of me at some point that would be okay.’

I waited for him to laugh, but he didn't.

'So ... shall we ... talk about us?'

'Us?'

He pulled a blade of grass through his teeth. 'Yup. I just thought ... well, I wondered what you thought was going on here.'

'You make us sound like a maths problem.'

'Just trying to make sure we don't have any more misunderstandings, Lou.'

I watched him discard the grass, and pick a new blade. 'I think we're good,' I said. 'Well, I'm not going to accuse you of having a neglected child this time. Or a trail of imaginary girlfriends.'

'But you're still holding back.'

It was gently said, but it felt like a kick.

I pushed myself up on my elbow, so that I was looking down on him. 'I'm here, aren't I? You're the first person I call at the end of the day. We see each other when we can. I wouldn't call that holding back.'

'Yup. We see each other, we have sex, eat some nice meals.'

'I thought that was basically every man's dream relationship.'

'I'm not every man, Lou.'

We gazed at each other in silence for a minute. I no longer felt relaxed. I felt wrong-footed, defensive.

He sighed. 'Don't look like that. I don't want to get married or anything. I'm just saying ... I've never met any woman who wanted less to talk about what might be going on.' He shaded his eyes with his hand, squinting slightly into the sun. 'It's fine if you don't want this to be a long-term thing. Well, okay, it's not, but I just want an idea of what you're thinking. I guess, since Ellen died, I've realized life is short. I don't want ...'

'You don't want what?'

'To waste time on something that isn't going anywhere.'

'*Waste time?*'

'Bad choice of words. I'm not good at this stuff.' He pushed himself upright.

'Why does it have to *be* anything? We have fun together. Why can't we just let it run and, I don't know, see what happens?'

'Because I'm human. Okay? And it's hard enough to be around someone who is still in love with a ghost, without them also acting like they're just

using you for sex.’ He raised his hand, covering his eyes. ‘Jesus Christ, I can’t believe I just said that out loud.’

My voice, when it emerged, cracked a little. ‘I’m not in love with a ghost.’

This time he didn’t look at me. He pushed himself to a seated position and rubbed at his face. ‘Then let him go, Lou.’

He climbed heavily to his feet and walked off to the railway carriage, leaving me staring behind him.

Lily arrived back the following evening, slightly sunburned. She let herself into the flat and walked past the kitchenette, where I was unloading the washing-machine, wondering for the fifteenth time whether to call Sam, and flopped onto the sofa. As I stood at the counter and watched, she put her feet on the coffee-table, picked up the remote control and flicked on the television.

‘So how was it?’ I said, after a moment had passed.

‘Okay.’

I waited for something more, braced for the remote control to be hurled down, for her to stalk off muttering, *That family is impossible*. But she simply changed channels.

‘What did you do?’

‘Not much. Talked a bit. Actually, we gardened.’ She turned round, resting her chin on her hands on the back of the sofa. ‘Hey, Lou. Have we got any of that cereal with the nuts left? I’m starving.’



CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Are we talking?

Sure. What do you want to say?

Sometimes I look at the lives of the people around me and I wonder if we aren't all destined to leave a trail of damage. It's not just your mum and dad who fuck you up, Mr Larkin. I gazed around me, like someone suddenly handed clear glasses, and saw that pretty much everyone bore the brutal imprint of love, whether lost, whipped away from them or simply vanished into a grave.

Will had done it to all of us, I saw now. He hadn't meant to, but even in simply refusing to live, he had.

I loved a man who had opened up a world to me but hadn't loved me enough to stay in it. And now I was too afraid to love a man who might love me in case ... In case what? I turned it over in my head in the silent hours after Lily had retreated to the glowing digital distractions of her room.

Sam didn't call. I couldn't blame him. What would I have said, anyway? The truth was that I didn't want to talk about what we were because I didn't know.

It wasn't that I didn't love being with him. I suspected I became slightly ridiculous around him – my laugh goofy, my jokes silly and puerile, my passion fierce and surprising even to myself. I felt better when he was there, more the person I wanted to be. More of everything. And yet.

And yet.

To commit to Sam was to commit to the likelihood of more loss. Statistically most relationships ended badly and, given my mental state over the past two years, my chances of beating the odds were pretty low. We could talk around it, we could lose ourselves in brief moments, but love ultimately meant more pain. More damage – to me or, worse, to him.

Who was strong enough for that?

I wasn't sleeping properly again. So I slept through my alarm and, despite tearing my way up the motorway, arrived late for Granddad's birthday. In celebration of his eighty years, Dad had brought out the foldaway gazebo we had used for Thomas's christening, which flapped, mossy and listless, at the end of the garden where, through the open door that led to the back alley, a succession of neighbours popped in and out, bringing cake or good wishes. Granddad sat in the middle of it all on a plastic garden chair, nodding at people he no longer recognized, only occasionally gazing longingly towards his folded copy of the *Racing Post*.

'So this promotion,' Treena was on tea-duty, pouring from an oversized pot and handing out cups, 'what exactly does it mean?'

'Well, I get a title. I balance the till at the end of every shift and I get to hold a set of keys.' *This is a serious responsibility, Louisa*, Richard Percival had said, bestowing them with as much gravitas and pomposity as if he were handing me the Holy Grail. *Use them wisely*. He actually said those words. *Use them wisely*. I wanted to say, What else am I going to do with a set of bar keys? Plough a field?

'Money?' She handed me a cup and I sipped at it.

'A pound an hour extra.'

'Mm.' She was unimpressed.

'And I don't have to wear the uniform any more.'

She scrutinized the *Charlie's Angels* jumpsuit I had put on that morning in honour of the occasion. 'Well, I guess that's something.' She pointed Mrs Laslow towards the sandwiches.

What else could I say? It was a job. Progress of sorts. I didn't tell her about the days when it felt like a peculiar form of torture to work somewhere where I was forced to watch each plane taxi on the runway, gather its energy like a great bird, then launch itself into the sky. I didn't tell her how putting on that green polo shirt each day made me feel somehow as if I had lost something.

'Mum says you've got a boyfriend.'

'He's not really my boyfriend.'

'She said that as well. What is it, then? You just bump uglies once in a while?'

'No. We're good friends –'

'So he's a pig.'

'He's not a pig. He's gorgeous.'

‘But crap in the sack.’

‘He’s wonderful. Not that it’s any of your business. And smart, before you –’

‘Then he’s married.’

‘He is not married. Jesus, Treen. Will you just let me explain? I like him, but I’m not sure I want to get involved just yet.’

‘Because of the long queue of other handsome, employed single sexy men waiting to snap you up?’

I glared at her.

‘I’m just saying. Gift horses and all that.’

‘When do you get your exam results?’

‘Don’t change the subject.’ She sighed and opened a new carton of milk. ‘Couple of weeks.’

‘What’s wrong? You’re going to get top marks. You know you will.’

‘But what’s the difference? I’m stuck.’

I frowned.

‘There are no jobs in Stortfold. But I can’t afford the rent in London, not with childcare for Thom on top. And nobody gets top dollar when they’re first starting out, even with top marks.’

She poured another cup of tea. I wanted to protest, to say it wasn’t so, but I knew only too well how tough the job market was. ‘So what will you do?’

‘Stay here for now, I suppose. Commute, maybe. Hope that Mum’s feminist metamorphosis won’t stop her picking Thom up from school.’ She raised a small smile that wasn’t a smile at all.

I had never seen my sister down. Even if she felt it, she ploughed on, like an automaton, a firm advocate of the ‘short walk and snap out of it’ school of depression. I was trying to work out what to say when there was a sudden commotion on the food table. We looked up to see Mum and Dad facing off over a chocolate cake. They were talking in the lowered, sibilant voices of people who did not want others to know they were arguing, but not enough to stop arguing.

‘Mum? Dad? Everything okay?’ I walked over.

Dad pointed at the table. ‘It’s not a homemade cake.’

‘What?’

‘The cake. It’s not homemade. Look at it.’

I looked at it – a large, lavishly iced chocolate cake, decorated with chocolate buttons between the candles.

Mum shook her head in exasperation. 'I had an essay to write.'

'An essay. You're not at school! You always do a homemade cake for Granddad.'

'It's a nice cake. It's from Waitrose. Daddy doesn't mind that it's not homemade.'

'Yes, he does. He's your father. You do mind, don't you, Granddad?'

Granddad looked from one to the other, and gave a tiny shake of his head. Around us, the conversation stuttered to a halt. Our neighbours eyed each other nervously. Bernard and Josie Clark never argued.

'He's just saying that because he doesn't want to hurt your feelings.' Dad harrumphed.

'If his feelings aren't hurt, Bernard, why on earth should yours be? It's a chocolate cake. It's not like I ignored his whole birthday.'

'I just want you to give priority to your family! Is that too much to ask, Josie? One homemade cake?'

'I'm here! There's a cake, with candles! Here's the ruddy sandwiches! I'm not off sunning myself in the Bahamas!' Mum put her pile of plates heavily on the trestle table and folded her arms.

Dad went to speak again but she shut him up with a raised hand. 'So, Bernard, you devoted family man, you, exactly how much of this little lot did you put together, eh?'

'Uh-oh ...' Treena moved a step closer to me.

'Did you buy Daddy's new pyjamas? Did you? Did you wrap them? No. You wouldn't even know what bloody size he is. You don't even know what bloody size your own pants are because I BUY THEM FOR YOU. Did you get up at seven o'clock this morning to fetch the bread for the sandwiches because some eejit came back from the pub last night and decided he needed to eat two rounds of toast and left the rest of the loaf out to get stale? No. You sat on your arse reading the sports pages. You gripe away at me for weeks on end because I've dared to claim back twenty per cent of my life for myself, to try to work out whether there is anything else I can do before I shuffle off this mortal coil, and while I'm still doing your washing, looking after Granddad and doing the dishes, you're there harping on at me about a shop-bought fecking cake. Well, Bernard, you can take the fecking shop-bought cake that is apparently such a sign of neglect and disrespect and you can shove it up your –' she let out a roar '– up your ... well ...

There's the kitchen, there's my ruddy mixing bowl, you can make one your ruddy self!'

With that, Mum flipped the cake plate upwards, so that it landed nose down in front of Dad, wiped her hands on her apron, and stomped up the garden to the house.

She stopped when she got to the patio, wrenched her apron over her head, and threw it to the ground. 'Oh, yes! Treena? You'd better show your daddy where the recipe books are. He's only lived here twenty-eight years. He can't possibly be expected to know himself.'

After that, Granddad's party didn't last long. The neighbours drifted away, conferring in hushed tones, and thanking us effusively for the *lovely* party, their eyes flickering towards the kitchen. I could see they felt as thrown as I did.

'It's been brewing for weeks,' Treena muttered, as we cleared the table. 'He feels neglected. She can't understand why he won't just let her grow a little.'

I glanced to where Dad was grumpily picking up napkins and empty beer cans from the grass. He looked utterly miserable. I thought of my mother at the London hotel, glowing with new life. 'But they're old! They're meant to have all this relationship stuff sewn up!'

My sister raised her eyebrows.

'You don't think ... ?'

'Of course not,' said Treena. But she didn't sound quite as convinced as she might have done.

I helped Treena tidy the kitchen, and played ten minutes of Super Mario with Thom. Mum stayed in her room, apparently working on her essay, and Granddad retreated with some relief to the more reliable consolations of *Channel 4 Racing*. I wondered if Dad had gone down the pub again, but as I stepped out of the front door to leave, there he was, sitting in the driver's seat of his work van.

I knocked on the window and he jumped. I opened the door and slid in beside him. I'd thought maybe he was listening to sports results but the radio was silent.

He let out a long breath. 'I bet you think I'm an old fool.'

'You're not an old fool, Dad.' I nudged him. 'Well, you're not old.'

We sat in silence, watching the Ellis boys wheel up and down the road on their bikes, wincing in unison when the littler one took a skid too fast and slid halfway across the road.

‘I want things to stay the same. Is that so much to ask?’

‘Nothing stays the same, Dad.’

‘I just ... I just miss my wife.’ He sounded so bleak.

‘You know, you could just enjoy the fact that you’re married to someone who still has a bit of life in her. Mum’s excited. She feels like she’s seeing the world through new eyes. You’ve just got to allow her some room.’

His mouth was set in a grim line.

‘She’s still your wife, Dad. She loves you.’

He finally turned to face me. ‘What if she decides that I’m the one with no life? What if all this new stuff turns her head and ...’ He gulped. ‘What if she leaves me behind?’

I squeezed his hand. Then I thought better and leaned over and gave him a hug. ‘You won’t let that happen.’

The wan smile he gave me stayed with me the whole way home.

Lily came in just as I was leaving for the Moving On Circle. She had been with Camilla again, and arrived home, as she often did now, with black fingernails from gardening. They had created a whole new border for a neighbour, she said cheerfully, and the woman had been so pleased she had given Lily thirty pounds. ‘Actually, she gave us a bottle of wine too but I said Granny should keep that.’ I noted the unselfconscious ‘Granny’.

‘Oh, and I spoke to Georgina on Skype last night. I mean it was morning there, because it’s Australia, but it was really nice. She’s going to email me a whole load of pictures of when she and my dad were little. She said that I really look like him. She’s quite pretty. She has a dog called Jakob and it howls when she plays the piano.’

I put a bowl of salad and some bread and cheese on the table for Lily as she chatted on. I wondered whether to tell her that Steven Traynor had called again, the fourth time in as many weeks, hoping to persuade her to go and see the new baby. ‘We’re all family. And Della is feeling much more *relaxed* about things now that the baby is safely here.’ Maybe that was a conversation for another time. I reached for my keys.

‘Oh,’ she said. ‘Before you go. I’m going back to school.’

‘What?’

‘I’m going back to the school near Granny’s house. Do you remember? The one I told you about? The one I actually liked? Weekly boarding. Just for sixth form. And I’m going to live with Granny at weekends.’

I had missed a leaf with the salad dressing. ‘Oh.’

‘Sorry. I did want to tell you. But it’s all happened really fast. I was talking about it, and just on the off-chance Granny rang up the school and they said I’d be welcome, and you’ll never guess what – my friend Holly’s still there! I spoke to her on Facebook and she said she can’t wait for me to come back. I mean, I didn’t tell her everything that’s happened, and I probably won’t tell her any of it, but it was just really nice. She knew me before it all went wrong. She’s just ... okay, you know?’

I listened to her talking animatedly and fought the sensation that I had been shed, like a skin. ‘When is all this going to happen?’

‘Well, I need to be there for the start of term in September. Granny thought it would probably be best if I moved quite soon. Maybe next week?’

‘Next week?’ I felt winded. ‘What – what does your mum say?’

‘She’s just glad I’m going back to school, especially since Granny’s paying. She had to tell the school a bit about my last school and the fact that I didn’t take my exams, and you can tell she doesn’t like Granny much, but she said it would be fine. “If that’s actually going to make you happy, Lily. And I do hope you’re not going to treat your grandmother the way you’ve treated everyone else.” ’

She cackled at her own impression of Tanya. ‘I caught Granny’s eye when she said that, and Granny’s eyebrow went up the tiniest bit but you could totally see what she thought. Did I tell you she’s dyed her hair? A sort of chestnut brown. She looks quite good now. Less like a cancer patient.’

‘Lily!’

‘It’s all right. She laughed when I told her that.’ She smiled to herself. ‘It was the kind of thing Dad would have said.’

‘Well,’ I muttered, when I’d caught my breath, ‘sounds like you’ve got it all worked out.’

She shot me a look. ‘Don’t say it like that.’

‘Sorry. It’s just ... I’ll miss you.’

She beamed, an abrupt, brilliant smile. ‘You won’t miss me, silly, because I’ll still be back down in the holidays and stuff. I can’t spend all my time in Oxfordshire with old people or I’ll go mad. But it’s good. She just

... she feels like my family. It doesn't feel weird. I thought it would, but it doesn't. Hey, Lou ...' She hugged me, exuberantly. 'You'll still be my friend. You're basically the sister I never had.'

I hugged her back and tried to keep the smile on my face.

'Anyway. You need your privacy.' She disentangled herself and pulled a piece of gum from her mouth, folding it carefully into a torn piece of paper. 'Having to listen to you and Hot Ambulance Man shagging across the corridor was actually pretty gross.'

Lily is going.

Going where?

To live with her grandmother. I feel strange. She's so happy about it. Sorry. I don't mean to talk about Will-related things all the time, but I can't really talk to anyone else.

Lily packed her bag, cheerfully stripping my second bedroom of nearly every sign she had ever been there, apart from the Kandinsky print and the camp bed, a pile of glossy magazines and an empty deodorant canister. I dropped her at the station, listening to her non-stop chatter and trying not to look as unbalanced as I felt. Camilla Traynor would be waiting at the other end.

'You should come up. We've got my room really nice. There's a horse next door that the farmer across the way says I can ride. Oh, and there's quite a nice pub.'

She glanced up at the departures board, and bounced on her toes, suddenly seeing the time. 'Bugger. My train. Right. Where's platform eleven?' She began to run briskly through the crowd, her holdall slung over her shoulder, her legs long in black tights. I stood, frozen, watching her go. Her stride had grown longer.

Suddenly she turned and, spotting me by the entrance, waved, her smile wide, her hair flying up around her face. 'Hey, Lou!' she yelled. 'I meant to say to you. Moving on doesn't mean you loved my dad any less, you know. I'm pretty sure even he would tell you that.'

And then she was gone, swallowed by the crowd.

Her smile was like his.

She was never yours, Lou.

I know. It's I suppose she was the thing I felt was giving me a purpose.

Only one person can give you a purpose.

I let myself absorb these words for a minute.

Can we meet? Please?

I'm on shift tonight.

Come to mine after?

Maybe later in the week. I'll call you.

It was the 'maybe' that did it. There was something final in it, the slow closing of a door. I stared at my phone as the commuters swarmed around me and something in me shifted too. Either I could go home and mourn yet another thing I had lost, or I could embrace an unexpected freedom. It was as if a light had gone on: the only way to avoid being left behind was to start moving.

I went home, made myself a coffee and stared at the green wall. Then I pulled out my laptop.

Dear Mr Gopnik,

My name is Louisa Clark and last month you were kind enough to offer me a job, which I had to turn down. I appreciate that you will have filled your position by now, but if I don't say this I will regret it for ever.

I really wanted your job. If the child of my former employer hadn't turned up in trouble, I would have taken it like a shot. I do not want to blame her for my decision, as it was a privilege to help sort things out for her. But I just wanted to say that if you ever need someone again I really hope you might consider getting in touch.

I know you are a busy man so I won't go on, but I just needed you to know.

With best wishes
Louisa Clark

I wasn't sure what I was doing but at least I was doing something. I pressed send, and with that tiny action, I was suddenly filled with purpose. I raced into the bathroom and ran the shower, stripping off my clothes and tripping on my trouser legs in my hurry to get out of them and under the hot water. I began to lather my hair, already planning ahead. I was going to go to the ambulance station, and I was going to find Sam and I was –

The doorbell rang. I swore and grabbed a towel.

'I've had it,' my mother said.

It took me a moment to register that it was actually her standing there, holding an overnight bag. I pulled my towel around me, my hair dripping onto the carpet. 'Had what?'

She stepped in, closing the front door behind her. 'Your father. Grumbling incessantly at me about everything I do. Acting as if I'm some kind of harlot just for wanting a little time to myself. So I told him I was coming here for a little break.'

'A break?'

‘Louisa, you have no idea. All the mumping and grumping. I can’t stay set in stone, you know? Everyone else gets to change. Why can’t I?’

It was as if I’d come halfway into a conversation that had been going on for an hour. Possibly in a bar. After hours.

‘When I started that feminist consciousness course, I thought a fair bit of it was exaggerated. Man’s patriarchal control of woman? Even the unconscious kind? Well, they only had the half of it. Your father simply can’t see me as a person beyond what I put on the table or put out in bed.’

‘Uh –’

‘Oh. Too much?’

‘Possibly.’

‘Let’s discuss it over some tea.’ My mother walked past me and into the kitchen. ‘Well, this looks a bit better. I’m still not sure about that green, though. It washes you right out. Now, where are your teabags?’

My mother sat on the sofa and, as her tea grew cold, I listened to her litany of frustration and tried not to think about the time. Sam would be arriving for his shift in half an hour. It would take twenty minutes to get over to the ambulance station. And then my mother’s voice would lift and her hands would end up somewhere around her ears and I knew I was going nowhere.

‘Do you know how stifling it is to be told you’re never going to be able to change? For the rest of your life? Because nobody else wants you to? Do you know how awful it is to feel stuck?’

I nodded vigorously. I did. I really did. ‘I’m sure Dad doesn’t mean for you to feel like that – but listen, I –’

‘I even suggested he take a course at the night school. Something he might like – you know, repairing antiques or life drawing or something. I don’t mind him looking at the nudies! I thought we could grow together! That’s the kind of wife I’m trying to be, the kind that doesn’t even mind her husband looking at nudies, if it’s in the name of culture ... But he’s all “What would I want to go down there for?” It’s like he’s got the ruddy menopause. And as for the rabbiting on about me not shaving my legs! Oh, my days. He’s so hypocritical. Do you know how long the hairs in his nostrils are, Louisa?’

‘N-no.’

‘I’ll tell you! He could wipe his plate with them. For the last fifteen years, I’ve been the one telling the barber to give him a trim up there, you

know? Like he's some kind of child. Do I mind? No! Because that's the way he is. He's a human being! Nose hair and all! But if I dare not to be as smooth as a ruddy baby's bottom he acts like I've turned into flipping Chewbacca!

It was ten minutes to six. Sam would be heading out at half past. I sighed, and pulled my towel around me.

'So ... um ... how long do you think you'll be here?'

'Well, now, I don't know.' Mum took a sip of her tea. 'We've got the social services bringing Granddad his lunch now so it's not like I've got to be there all the time. I might just stay for a few days. We had a lovely time last time I was here, didn't we? We could go and see Maria in the toilets tomorrow. Wouldn't that be nice!'

'Lovely.'

'Right. Well, I'll make up the spare bed. Where is the spare bed?'

We had just stood up when the buzzer went again. I opened the door, expecting a random pizza delivery, but there stood Treena and Thom and, behind them, his hands jammed into his trouser pockets like a recalcitrant teenager, my father.

She didn't even look at me. She just walked in past me. 'Mum. This is ridiculous. You can't just run away from Dad. How old are you? Fourteen?'

'I am not running away, Treena. I am giving myself breathing space.'

'Well, we're going to sit here until you two have sorted this ridiculous thing out. You know he's been sleeping in his van, Lou?'

'What? You didn't tell me that.' I turned to Mum.

She lifted her chin. 'You didn't give me a chance, with all your talking.'

Mum and Dad stood there not looking at each other.

'I have nothing to say to your father right now,' Mum said.

'Sit down,' said Treena. 'The both of you.' They shuffled towards the sofa, casting mute glances of resentment at each other. She turned to me.

'Right. Let's make tea. And then we're going to sort this out as a family.'

'Great idea!' I said, sensing my chance. 'There's milk in the fridge. Tea's on the side. Help yourselves. I've got to pop out for half an hour.' And before anyone could stop me I had whipped on a pair of jeans and a top and was running out of the flat with my car keys.

I saw him even as I turned the car into the ambulance-station car park. He was striding towards the ambulance, his pack slung over his shoulder, and

something inside me lurched. I knew the delicious solidity of that body, the soft angles of that face. He turned and his step faltered, as if I had been the last thing he had expected to see. Then he turned back to the ambulance, hauling open the rear doors.

I walked towards him across the tarmac. 'Can we talk?'

He lifted an oxygen tank like it was a tin of hairspray, securing it in its holder. 'Sure. But it'll have to be some other time. I'm on my way out.'

'It won't wait.'

His expression didn't flicker. He stooped to pick up a pack of gauze.

'Look. I just wanted to explain ... what we were talking about. I do like you. I really like you. I just – I'm just scared.'

'We're all scared, Lou.'

'You're not scared of anything.'

'Yeah. I am. Just not stuff you'd notice.'

He stared at his boots. And then he saw Donna running towards him.

'Ah, hell. I've got to go.'

I jumped into the rear of the ambulance. 'I'll come with you. I'll get a taxi home from wherever you're headed.'

'No.'

'Ah, come on. Please.'

'So I can get in even more trouble with Disciplinary?'

'Red Two, reports of a stabbing, young male.' Donna threw her pack into the back of the ambulance.

'We have to go, Louisa.'

I was losing him. I could feel it, in the tone of his voice, the way he wouldn't look at me directly. I climbed out of the back, cursing my lateness. But Donna took me by the elbow and steered me towards the front. 'For God's sake,' she said, as Sam made to protest. 'You've been like a bear with a sore head all week. Just sort this thing out. We'll drop her before we get there.'

Sam walked briskly around to the passenger door and opened it, casting a glance at the controller's office. 'She'd make a great relationship counsellor.' His voice hardened. 'If we were, you know, in a relationship.'

I didn't need telling twice. Sam climbed into the driving seat and looked at me as if he were going to say something, then changed his mind. Donna began sorting out equipment. He started the ignition and put the blue light on.

‘Where are we headed?’

‘*We* are headed to the estate. About seven minutes away with blues and twos. *You* are headed to the high street, two minutes from Kingsbury.’

‘So I’ve got five minutes?’

‘And a long walk back.’

‘Okay,’ I said. And realized, as we sped forward, that I really had no idea what to say next.



CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

‘So, here’s the thing,’ I said. Sam indicated and swung out onto the road. I had to shout as the siren was so loud.

His attention was on the road ahead. He glanced at the computer readout on the dashboard. ‘What have we got, Don?’

‘Possible stabbing. Two reports. Young male collapsed in stairwell.’

‘Is this really a good time to talk?’ I said.

‘Depends what you want to say.’

‘It’s not that I don’t want a relationship,’ I said. ‘I just still feel a bit mixed up.’

‘Everyone’s mixed up,’ said Donna. ‘Every bloke I go out with starts our date with how he’s got trust issues.’ She looked at Sam. ‘Oh. Sorry. Don’t mind me.’

Sam kept his eyes straight ahead. ‘One minute you’re calling me a dick because you’ve decided I’m sleeping with other women. Next you’re keeping me at arm’s length because you’re still attached to someone else. It’s too –’

‘Will is gone. I know that. But I just can’t leap in like you can, Sam. I feel like I’m only just getting back on my feet after a long time of ... I don’t know ... I was a mess.’

‘I know you were a mess. I picked up that mess.’

‘If anything, I like you too much. I like you so much that if it went wrong it would feel like that again. And I’m not sure I’m strong enough.’

‘How is *that* going to happen?’

‘You might go off me. You might change your mind. You’re a good-looking bloke. Some other woman might fall off a building and land on you and you might like it. You could get ill. You could get knocked off that motorbike.’

‘ETA two minutes,’ said Donna, gazing at the satnav. ‘I’m not listening, honest.’

‘You could say that about anyone. So what? So we sit there and do nothing every day in case we have an accident? Is that really how to live?’ He swerved to the left so that I had to hang on to my seat.

‘I’m still a doughnut, okay?’ I said. ‘I want to be a bun. I really do. But I’m still a doughnut.’

‘Jesus, Lou! We’re all doughnuts! You think I didn’t watch my sister being eaten by cancer and know that my heart was going to break, not just for her but for her son, every day of my life? You think I don’t know how that feels? There’s only one response, and I can tell you this because I see it every day. You *live*. And you throw yourself into everything and try not to think about the bruises.’

‘Oh, that’s lovely,’ said Donna, nodding.

‘I’m *trying*, Sam. You have no idea how far I’ve come.’

And then we were there. The sign for Kingsbury estate loomed in front of us. We drove in through a huge archway, past a car park and into a darkened courtyard, where Sam pulled up and swore softly. ‘Dammit. We were meant to drop you off.’

‘I didn’t like to interrupt,’ said Donna.

‘I’ll wait here till you get back.’ I crossed my arms.

‘There’s no point.’ Sam jumped out of the driver’s door and grabbed his pack. ‘I’m not going to jump through hoops to convince you to be with me. Oh, crap. The bloody signs are missing. He could be anywhere.’

I gazed out at the forbidding maroon-brick buildings. There were probably twenty stairwells in those blocks and none you would have wanted to walk around without the company of a large bodyguard.

Donna shrugged her way into her jacket. ‘The last time I came here – heart attack – it took four tries to find the right block, and that gate was locked. We had to find a caretaker to unlock it before we could bring in the mobile unit. By the time I made it to the right flat the patient was dead.’

‘Two gang shootings here last month.’

‘You want me to call in a police escort?’ said Donna.

‘No. No time.’

It was eerily quiet, even though it was barely eight p.m. These were estates in a part of the city where only a few years ago children might have been playing out on bikes, sneaking cigarettes and catcalling long into the evening. Now residents double-locked their doors long before dark, and windows were braced with decorative metal bars. Half the sodium lights had been shot out, and the odd remaining one flickered intermittently, as if uncertain whether it was safe to shine.

Sam and Donna, now outside the cab, were talking, their voices lowered. Donna opened the passenger door, reached in and handed me a high-visibility jacket. 'Right. Put that on and come with us. He doesn't feel safe leaving you here.'

'Why couldn't he –'

'Oh, you two! For God's sake! Look, I'm going to head this way, you follow him that way. Okay?'

I stared at her.

'Sort it out afterwards.' She strode off, her walkie-talkie buzzing in her hand.

I followed close behind Sam as we went along one length of concrete walkway, then another.

'Savernake House,' he muttered. 'How the hell are we supposed to know which one is Savernake?' The radio hissed. 'Control, can we have some guidance? No signs on these buildings, and no idea where this patient is.'

'Sorry,' the voice said apologetically. 'Our map doesn't show individual block names.'

'Want me to head off that way?' I said, pointing in front of us. 'Then we'll have three walkways covered. I've got my phone with me.' We halted in a stairwell that reeked of urine and the stale fat of old takeaway cartons. The walkways sat in shadow, only the occasional muffled burble of a television behind the windows suggesting life deep within each small flat. I had expected a distant commotion, some vibration in the air that would lead us to the injured. But this was eerily still.

'No. Stay close, okay?'

I saw that having me there was making him nervous. I wondered whether I should just leave, but I didn't want to find my way out by myself.

Sam stopped at the end of the walkway. He turned, shaking his head, his mouth compressed. Donna's voice crackled across the radio: 'Nothing this end.' And then we heard a shout.

'There,' I said, following the sound. On the other side of the square, in the half-light, we saw a crouching figure, a body on the ground under the sodium lights.

'Here we go,' said Sam, and we started to run.

Speed was everything in his job, he had once told me. It was one of the first things paramedics were taught – the difference a few seconds could make to someone's chances of survival. If the patient was bleeding out, had

had a stroke or a heart attack, it could be those critical few seconds that kept them alive. We bolted along the concrete walkways, down the reeking, dingy stairs, and then we were across the worn grass towards the prostrate figure.

Donna was already down beside her.

‘A girl.’ Sam dropped his pack. ‘I’m sure they said it was a man.’

As Donna checked her for injuries, he called into Control.

‘Yup. Young male, late teens, Afro-Caribbean appearance,’ the dispatcher responded.

Sam clicked off his radio. ‘They must have misheard. It’s like bloody Chinese whispers some days.’

She was about sixteen, her hair neatly braided, her limbs sprawled as if she had recently fallen. She was strangely peaceful. I wondered, fleetingly, if that was how I had looked when he’d found me.

‘Can you hear me, sweetheart?’

She didn’t move. He checked her pupils, her pulse, her airways. She was breathing, and there was no obvious sign of injury. Yet she seemed completely non-responsive. He checked all around her a second time, staring at his equipment.

‘Is she alive?’

Sam’s eyes met Donna’s. He straightened up and glanced around him, thinking. He gazed up at the windows of the estate. They stared down at us like blank, unfriendly eyes. Then he motioned us over and spoke quietly. ‘Something’s not right. Look, I’m going to do the drop-hand test. And when I do, I want you to head for the rig and start the engine. If it’s what I think it is we need to get out of here.’

‘Drugs ambush?’ muttered Donna, her gaze sliding behind me.

‘Might be. Or turf-related. We should have had a Location Match. I’m sure this is where Andy Gibson had that shooting.’

I tried to keep my voice calm. ‘What’s the drop-hand test?’

‘I’m going to lift her hand and drop it from above her face. If she’s acting, she’ll move her hand rather than hit her own face. They always do. It’s like a reflex. But if there’s someone watching, I don’t want them to get wind that we’ve worked it out. Louisa, you act like you’re going to get some more equipment, okay? I’ll do it once you’ve texted me to say you’re at the rig. If anyone’s near it, don’t go in. Just turn round and come straight

back to me. Donna, get your pack together, and ready. You go after her. If they see two of us leaving together they'll know.'

He handed me the keys. I picked up a bag, as if it were mine, and started to walk briskly towards the ambulance. I was suddenly conscious of unseen people watching from the shadows; my heartbeat was thumping in my ears. I tried to make my face expressionless, my movements purposeful.

The walk along the echoing concourse felt achingly long. When I reached the ambulance, I let out a sigh of relief. I reached for the keys, opened the door, and as I stepped up, a voice called from the shadows, 'Miss.' I glanced behind me. Nothing. 'Miss.'

A young boy appeared from behind a concrete pillar, another behind him, a hoodie pulled forward to obscure his face. I took a step back towards the rig, my heart racing. 'I've got back-up on the way,' I said, trying to keep my voice steady. 'There's no drugs in here. You both need to back off. Okay?'

'Miss. He's by the bins. They don't want you to get to him. He's bleeding real bad, miss. That's why Emeka's cousin is faking it out there. To distract youse. So youse'll go away.'

'What? What do you mean?'

'He's by the bins. You got to help him, miss.'

'What? Where are the bins?'

But the boy glanced warily behind him, and when I turned to ask again, they had disappeared into the shadows.

I glanced around, trying to work out where he meant. And then I spied it, over by the garages – the protruding edge of a bright green plastic rubbish container. I edged along the shadows of the ground-floor walkway, out of view of the main square, until I saw an open doorway out to the refuse area. I ran over, and there, tucked behind the recycling bin, a pair of legs sprawled, tracksuit bottoms soaked with blood. His upper half was slumped under the containers and I crouched down. The boy turned his head and groaned quietly.

'Hello? Can you hear me?'

'They got me.'

Blood seeped stickily from what looked like two wounds to his legs.

'They got me ...'

I grabbed my phone and called Sam, my voice low and urgent. 'I'm over by the bins, to your right. Please. Come quick.'

I could see him, looking around slowly until he spotted me. Two elderly people, Samaritans from a previous age, had appeared beside him. I could see them asking questions about the fallen girl, their faces blanketed with concern. He gently placed a blanket over the faking cousin, asking them to watch over her, then walked briskly towards the rig with his bag, as if to get more equipment. Donna had vanished.

I opened the bag he'd given me, ripping open a pack of gauze and placing it over the boy's leg, but there was so much blood. 'Okay. Someone's coming to help. We'll have you in the ambulance in a moment.' I sounded like someone out of a bad film. I had no idea what else to say. *Come on, Sam.*

'You gotta get me out of here.' The boy groaned. I put my hand on his arm, trying to keep calm. *Come on, Sam. Where the hell are you?* And suddenly I heard the rig's engine starting, and there it was, reversing through the garages towards me at some speed, its engine whining in protest. It bumped to a halt, and Donna jumped out. She ran towards me, threw open the back doors. 'Help me put him in,' she said. 'We're getting out of here.'

There was no time for gurneys. Somewhere above I heard shouting, multiple footsteps. We shouldered the boy towards the ambulance, shoving him into the back. Donna slammed the doors behind him and I ran for the cab, my heart racing, and threw myself in, locking the doors. I could see them now, a gang of men, racing towards us around the upper floor, hands raised with – what? Guns? Knives? I felt something grow liquid inside me. I looked out of the window. Sam was walking along the open space, his face turned to the sky: he had seen them too.

Donna saw before he did: the gun, raised in the man's hand. She swore loudly and slammed the rig into reverse, steering it round the garage, headed straight for the grassed area where Sam was still walking towards us. I could just make him out, the green of his uniform growing larger in the passenger mirror.

'Sam!' I yelled out of my window.

He glanced at me, then up at them. 'Leave the ambulance alone,' he yelled at the men, over the whine of the ambulance's reverse gear. 'Back off, all right? We're just doing our jobs.'

'*Not now, Sam. Not now,*' Donna said, under her breath.

The men kept running, peering over as if calculating the quickest way down, relentless, moving forward like a tide. One vaulted nimbly over a wall, swinging his way easily down a flight of stairs. I wanted to skid out of there so badly I was limp with it.

But Sam was still walking towards them, his hands raised, palms up. 'Leave the ambulance, boys, okay? We're just here to help.' His voice was calm and authoritative, betraying none of the fear that I felt. And then I saw through the back window that the men had slowed. They were walking now, not running. A distant part of me thought, *Oh, thank God*. The boy lay behind us, still moaning.

'That's it,' said Donna, leaning around. 'Come *on*, Sam. In you come. Come on over here now. And we can get the —'

Bang.

The sound cut through the air, amplified in the empty space so that I felt, briefly, as if my whole head had expanded and contracted with the sound. And then, too quickly —

Bang.

I yelped.

'*What the f—*' Donna yelled.

'We need to get out of here, man!' the boy shouted.

I looked back, willing Sam to get in. *Get in now. Please*. But Sam had gone. No, not gone. There was something on the ground: a high-visibility jacket. A yellow stain on the grey concrete.

Everything stopped.

No, I thought. No.

The ambulance screeched to a halt. Then Donna was out, and I was running after her. Sam was motionless and there was blood, so much blood, seeping outwards in a steadily expanding pool around him. In the distance the two old people scrambled stiffly towards the safety of their door, the girl who was supposedly immobile sprinting across the grass at the speed of an athlete. And the men were still coming, running down the upper walkway towards us. I tasted metal in my mouth.

'*Lou! Grab him.*' We hauled Sam towards the back of the rig. He was leaden, as if he were deliberately resisting. I pulled at his collar, his armpits, my breath coming in short bursts. His face was chalk-white, huge black shadows under his half-closed eyes, as if he had not slept for a hundred years. His blood against my skin. Why had I not known how warm blood

is? Donna was already in the rig, hauling at him, and we were pushing, heaving, a sob in my throat as I pulled at his arms, his legs. *'Help me!'* I was shouting, as if there was anyone who could. *'Help me!'*

And then he was in, his leg at the wrong angle, and the doors slammed behind me.

Crack! Something hit the top of the rig. I screamed and ducked. Some part of me thought absently, *Is this it? Is this how I die, in my bad jeans, while a few miles away my parents argue about birthday cakes with my sister?* The boy on the gurney was screaming, his voice shrill with fear. And then the ambulance skidded forwards, steering right as the men approached us from the left. I saw a hand rise, and thought I heard a gunshot. I ducked again instinctively.

'Bloody hell!' Donna swore and swerved again.

I raised my head. I could make out the exit. Donna steered hard left, then right, the ambulance almost on two wheels as she hurled it around the corner. The wing mirror clipped a car. Someone dived towards us but Donna swerved once more and kept going. I heard the *thump* of an angry fist on the side. And then we were out on the road, and the young men were behind us, slowing to a furious, defeated jog as they watched us go.

'Jesus.'

The blue light on, Donna radioing ahead to the hospital, words I couldn't make out through the thumping in my ears. I was cradling Sam's face, grey and covered with a fine sheen, his eyes glassy. He was completely silent.

'What do I do?' I yelled at Donna. *'What do I do?'* She screeched around a roundabout and her head swivelled briefly towards me. *'Find the injury. What can you see?'*

'It's his stomach. There's a hole. Two holes. There is so much blood. Oh, God, there's so much blood.' My hands came away red and glossy. My breath came in short bursts. I felt, briefly, as if I might faint.

'I need you to be calm now, Louisa, okay? Is he breathing? Can you feel a pulse?'

I checked, felt something inside me sag with relief. *'Yes.'*

'I can't stop. We're too close. Elevate his feet, okay? Push up his knees. Keep the blood near his chest. Now make sure his shirt is open. Rip it. Just get to it. Can you describe the wound?'

That stomach, which had lain warm and smooth and solid against mine, now a red, gaping mess. A sob escaped my throat. *'Oh, God ...'*

‘Don’t you panic now, Louisa. You hear me? We’re nearly there. You have to apply pressure. Come on, you can do this. Use the gauze from the pack. The big one. Whatever, just stop him bleeding out. Okay?’

She turned back to the road, sending the ambulance the wrong way up a one-way street. The boy on the gurney swore softly, now lost in his own private world of pain. Ahead, cars swerved obediently out of the way on the sodium-lit road, waves parting on the tarmac. A siren, always a siren. *‘Paramedic down. I repeat paramedic down. Gunshot wound to the abdomen!’* Donna yelled into the radio. *‘ETA three minutes. We’re going to need a crash cart.’*

I unwrapped the bandages, my hands shaking, and ripped open Sam’s shirt, bracing myself as the ambulance tore round corners. How could this be the man who had been arguing with me just fifteen minutes earlier? How could someone so solid just be ebbing away in front of me?

‘Sam? Can you hear me?’ I was crouched over him now on my knees, my jeans darkening red. His eyes closed. When they opened, they seemed to fix on something far away. I put my face down so that I was directly in his field of vision and for a second his eyes locked onto mine and I saw a flicker of something that could have been recognition.

I took hold of his hand, as he had once held mine in another ambulance, a million years ago. ‘You’re going to be okay, you hear me? You’re going to be okay.’

Nothing. He didn’t even seem to register my voice.

‘Sam? Look at me, Sam.’

Nothing.

I was there, back in that Swiss room, Will’s face turning away from mine. Losing him.

‘No. Don’t you dare.’ I placed my face against his, my words falling his ear. ‘Sam. You stay with me, you hear?’ My hand was on the gauze dressing, my body over his, juddering with the rocking of the ambulance. There was the sound of sobbing in my ears and I realized it was my own. I turned his face with my hands, forcing him to look at me. ‘Stay with me! You hear me? Sam? *Sam! Sam!*’ I had never known fear like it. It was in the stilling of his gaze, the wet warmth of his blood, a rising tide.

The closing of a door.

‘*Sam!*’

The ambulance had stopped.

Donna leaped into the back. She ripped open a clear plastic pouch, pulling out drugs, white padding, a syringe, injected something into Sam's arm. With shaking hands she hooked him up to a drip, and placed an oxygen mask over his face. I could hear beeping outside. I was trembling violently. 'Stay there!' she commanded, as I made to scramble out of her way. 'Keep that pressure. That's it – that's good. You're doing great.' Her face lowered to his. 'Come on, mate. Come on, Sam. Nearly there.' I could hear sirens as she worked, still talking, her hands swift and competent on the equipment, always busy, always moving. 'You're going to be fine, my old mucker. Just hang on in there, okay?' The monitor was flickering green and black. The sound of beeping.

Then the doors opened again, flooding the ambulance with swinging neon light, and there were paramedics, green uniforms, white coats, hauling out the boy, still complaining and swearing, then Sam, lifting him gently away from me into the dark night. Blood swilled on the floor of the ambulance and as I made to stand up I slipped and put a hand out to right myself. It came back red.

Their voices receded. I caught a flash of Donna's face, white with anxiety. A barked instruction: '*Straight to theatre.*' I was left standing between the ambulance doors, watching as they ran with him, their boots clumping across the tarmac. The doors of the hospital opened and swallowed him, and as they closed again, I was alone in the silence of the car park.



CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Hours spent on hospital seating have a strange, elastic quality. I had hardly noticed them when I waited for Will during his check-ups; I had read magazines, pecked out messages on my phone, strolled downstairs for too-strong hospital coffee on an overpriced concourse, worried about car-parking charges. Moaned without really meaning it about how long these things always took.

Now I sat on a moulded plastic chair, my mind numb, my gaze fixed on a wall, unable to tell how long I had been there. I couldn't think. I couldn't feel. I just existed: me, the plastic chair, the squeaky linoleum under my bloodied tennis shoes.

The strip-lighting overhead was a harsh constant, illuminating the nurses who walked briskly past, barely giving me a second look. Some time after I had come in, one of them had been kind enough to show me a bathroom so that I could clean my hands, but I could still see Sam's blood in the dips around my nails, rust-coloured cuticles that hinted at a not-so-distant atrocity. Pieces of him in pieces of me. Pieces of him where they shouldn't be.

When I closed my eyes I heard the voices, the sharp *thwack* of the bullet hitting the roof of the ambulance, the echo of the shot, the siren, the siren, the siren. I saw his face, the brief moment when he had looked at me and there had been nothing – no alarm, nothing except perhaps a vague bemusement at finding himself there on the floor, unable to move.

And I kept seeing those wounds, not neat little holes like gunshot injuries in movies, but living, pulsing things, pushing out blood as if they were trying maliciously to rid him of it.

I sat motionless on that plastic chair because I didn't know how to do anything else. Somewhere at the end of that corridor were the operating theatres. He was in there right now. He was alive or he was dead. He was being wheeled to some distant ward, surrounded by relieved, high-fiving colleagues, or someone was pulling that green cloth up over his –

My head sank into my hands and I listened to my breath, in and out. In and out. My body smelt unfamiliar: of blood and antiseptic and something

sour left over from visceral fear. Periodically I would observe distantly that my hands were trembling, but I wasn't sure if it was low blood sugar or exhaustion, and somehow the thought of trying to find food was way beyond me. Movement was beyond me.

My sister had texted me some time ago.

Where are you? We're going for pizza. They are talking, but I need you here as United Nations.

I hadn't answered. I couldn't work out what to say.

He is talking about her hairy legs again. Please come. This could get ugly. She has a fearsome aim with a doughball.

I closed my eyes and I tried to remember what it felt like, a week ago, to lie on the grass beside Sam, the way his stretched-out legs were so much longer than mine, the reassuring scent of his warm shirt, the low rumble of his voice, the sun on my face. His face, turning towards mine to steal kisses, the way he looked secretly pleased after every one. The manner in which he walked, set slightly forward yet his weight so centred, the most solid man I had ever met – as if nothing could knock him down.

I felt the buzz and pulled my phone from my pocket, read my sister's message. *Where are you? Mum getting worried.* I checked the time: 10:48 p.m. I couldn't believe I was the same person who had woken that morning and dropped Lily at the station. I leaned back in the chair, thought for a moment and began to type. *I'm at the City hospital. There's been an accident. I'm fine. I'll be back when I know*

when I know

My finger hovered over the keys. I blinked and, after a moment, pressed send.

And I closed my eyes and prayed.

I came to with a start at the sound of the swing doors. My mother was walking briskly down the corridor, her good coat on, her arms already outstretched.

'What the hell happened?' Treena was close behind, dragging Thom, in his pyjamas with an anorak over the top. 'Mum didn't want to come without Dad and I wasn't going to be left behind.' Thom looked at me sleepily and waved a damp hand.

'We had no clue what had happened to you!' Mum sat down beside me, studying my face. 'Why didn't you say?'

‘What’s going on?’

‘Sam has been shot.’

‘Shot? Your paramedic man?’

‘With a gun?’ said Treena.

It was then that my mother registered my jeans. She gazed at the red stains, disbelieving, and turned mutely to my father.

‘I was with him.’

She pressed her hands to her mouth. ‘Are you okay?’ And then, when she saw the answer was yes, at least physically, ‘Is ... is he okay?’

The four of them stood before me, their faces immobilized by shock and concern. I was suddenly utterly relieved to have them there. ‘I don’t know,’ I said, and as my father stepped forward to take me in his arms, I finally began to cry.

We sat for several years, my family and I, on those plastic chairs. Or something close to that. Thom fell asleep on Treena’s lap, his face pale under the strip-lights, his battered cuddly cat pressed into the silky soft space between his neck and chin. Dad and Mum sat on each side of me and at any time one of them would hold my hand or stroke the side of my face and tell me it was going to be okay. I leaned against Dad and let the tears fall silently, and Mum wiped my face with her ever-present clean handkerchief. Periodically she would head off on a recce trip around the hospital for hot drinks.

‘She’d never have done that by herself a year ago,’ Dad said, the first time she disappeared. I couldn’t tell whether it was said admiringly or with regret.

We spoke little. There was nothing to say. The words repeated in my head like a mantra – *Just let him be okay. Just let him be okay. Just let him be okay.*

This is what catastrophe does: it strips away the fluff and the white noise, the *should I really* and the *but what if*. I wanted Sam. I knew it with a stinging clarity. I wanted to feel his arms around me, hear him talking, and sit in the cab of his ambulance. I wanted him to make me a salad with things he had grown in his garden and I wanted to feel his warm, bare chest rise and fall steadily under my arm while he slept. Why had I not been able to tell him that? Why had I wasted so much time worrying about what was not important?

Then, as Mum came through the doors at the far end, bearing a cardboard holder with four teas in it, the doors to the theatres opened and Donna emerged, her uniform still smeared with blood, trailing her hands through her hair. I stood. She slowed in front of us, her expression grave, her eyes red-rimmed and exhausted. For a moment I thought I might pass out. Her eyes met mine. 'Tough as old boots, that one.'

As I let out an involuntary sob, she touched my arm. 'You did good, Lou,' she said, and let out a long, shaky breath. 'You did good tonight.'

He spent the night in intensive care, and was transferred to a high-dependency unit in the morning. Donna called his parents, and said she would stop by his place after she'd had some sleep to feed his animals. We went in to see him together shortly after midnight, but he was asleep, still ashen, a mask obscuring most of his face. I wanted to move closer to him but I was afraid to touch him, hooked up as he was to all those wires and tubes and monitors.

'He really is going to be okay?'

She nodded. A nurse moved silently around the bed, checking levels, taking his pulse.

'We were lucky it was an older handgun. A lot of kids are getting hold of semi-automatics now. That would have been it.' She rubbed at her eyes. 'It'll probably be on the news, if nothing else happens. Mind you, another crew dealt with the murder of a mother and baby on Athena Road last night, so it's possible it won't be news at all.'

I tore my gaze from him, and turned to her. 'Will you carry on?'

'Carry on?'

'As a paramedic.'

She pulled a face, as if she didn't really understand the question. 'Of course. It's my job.' She patted me on the shoulder and turned towards the door. 'Get some sleep, Lou. He probably won't wake up until tomorrow anyway. He's about eighty-seven per cent fentanyl right now.'

My parents were waiting when I stepped back into the corridor. They didn't say anything. I gave a small nod. Dad took my arm and Mum patted my back. 'Let's get you home, love,' she said. 'And into some clean things.'

It turns out there is a particular tone of voice that emanates from an employer who, several months previously, had to listen to how you couldn't

come to work as you had fallen off the fifth floor of a building, and now would like to swap shifts because a man who may or may not be your boyfriend has been shot twice in the stomach.

‘You – he has – what?’

‘He was shot twice. He’s out of intensive care but I’d like to be there this morning when he comes to. So I was wondering if I could swap shifts with you.’

There was a short silence.

‘Right ... Uh. Okay.’ He hesitated. ‘He was actually shot? With an actual gun?’

‘You can come and inspect the holes, if you like.’ My voice was so calm I almost laughed.

We discussed a couple more logistical details – calls that needed to be made, a visit from Head Office, and before I rang off, Richard grew silent for a moment. Then he said, ‘Louisa, is your life always like this?’

I thought of who I had been just two and a half years ago, my days measured in the short walk between my parents’ house and the café; the Tuesday-night routines of watching Patrick running or supper with my parents. I looked down at the rubbish bag in the corner, which now contained my bloodstained tennis shoes. ‘Possibly. Although I’d like to think it’s just a phase.’

After breakfast, my parents left for home. My mother didn’t want to go, but I assured her that I was fine, and that I didn’t know where I would be for the next few days so there would be little point in her staying. I also reminded her that the last time Granddad was left alone for more than twenty-four hours he had eaten his way through two pots of raspberry jam and a tin of condensed milk in lieu of actual meals.

‘You really are all right, though.’ She held her hand to the side of my face. She said it as though it wasn’t a question, although it clearly was.

‘Mum, I’m fine.’

She shook her head and made to pick up her bag. ‘I don’t know, Louisa. You do pick them.’

She was taken aback when I laughed. It might have been leftover shock. But I like to think it was then that I realized I wasn’t afraid of anything any more.

I showered, trying not to look at the pink water that ran from my legs, and washed my hair, bought the least limp bunch of flowers I could find at Samir's, and headed back to the hospital for ten a.m. Sam's parents had arrived several hours previously, the nurse told me, as she led me to the door. They had headed over to the railway carriage with Jake and Jake's father to fetch Sam's belongings.

'He wasn't very with it when they came but he's making more sense now,' she said. 'It's not unusual when they're recently out of theatre. Some people just bounce back quicker than others.'

I slowed as we reached the door. I could see him now through the glass, his eyes closed, as they had been last night, his hand, strapped up to various monitors, lying motionless alongside his body. There was stubble on his chin and while he was still ghostly pale, he looked a little more like himself.

'You sure I'm okay to go in?'

'You're Louise, right? He's been asking for you.' She smiled and wrinkled her nose. 'Give us a shout if you get tired of that one. He's lovely.'

I pushed the door slowly and his eyes opened, his face turning slightly. He looked at me then, as if he were taking me in, and something inside me weakened with relief.

'Some people will do anything to beat me on the scar front.' I closed the door behind me.

'Yeah. Well.' His voice emerged as a croak. 'I've gone right off that game.' He gave a small, tired smile.

I stood, shifting my weight from one foot to the other. I hated hospitals. I would do almost anything never to enter one again.

'Come here.'

I put the flowers on the table and walked over to him. He moved his arm, motioning for me to sit on the bed beside him. I sat, and then, because it felt wrong to be looking down at him, I lay back, positioning myself carefully, wary of dislodging something, of hurting him. I placed my head on his shoulder and felt the welcome weight of his head come to rest against mine. His lower arm lifted, gently hooking me in. We lay there in silence for a while, listening to the soft-shoe shuffle of the nurses outside, the distant conversation.

'I thought you were dead,' I whispered.

'Apparently some amazing woman who shouldn't have been in the back of the ambulance managed to slow my blood loss.'

‘That’s some woman.’

‘I thought so.’

I closed my eyes, feeling the warmth of his skin against my cheek, the unwelcome scent of chemical disinfectant emanating from his body. I didn’t think about anything. I just let myself exist in the moment, the deep, deep pleasure of being there next to him, of feeling the weight of him beside me, the space he took up in the atmosphere. I shifted my head and kissed the soft skin on the inside of his arm, and felt his fingers trace their way gently through my hair.

‘You scared me, Ambulance Sam.’

There was a long silence. I could hear him thinking the million things he chose not to say.

‘I’m glad you’re here,’ he said eventually.

We lay there for a bit longer, in silence. And when the nurse finally came in and raised an eyebrow at my proximity to various important tubes and wires, I climbed reluctantly off the bed and obeyed her instructions to get some breakfast while she did her medical thing. I kissed him, a little self-consciously, and when I stroked his hair his eyes lifted slightly at the corners and I saw, with gratitude, something of what I was to him. ‘I’ll be back after my shift,’ I said.

‘You might bump into my parents.’ He said it as a warning.

‘That’s fine,’ I said. ‘I’ll make sure I’m not wearing my Fuck Da Police T-shirt.’

He laughed, then grimaced, as if laughing were painful.

I fussed around a little while the nurses were seeing to him, doing the things that people do at patients’ bedsides when they’re simply looking for an excuse to hang around; I put out some fruit, disposed of a tissue, organized some magazines that I knew he wouldn’t read. And then it was time to go. I had made it as far as the door when he spoke. ‘I heard you.’

My hand was outstretched, ready to open it. I turned.

‘Last night. When I was bleeding out. I heard you.’

Our eyes locked. And in that moment everything shifted. I saw what I had really done. I saw that I could be somebody’s centre, their reason for staying. I saw that I could be enough. I walked back, took Sam’s face in my hands and kissed him fiercely, feeling hot tears fall unchecked onto his face, his arm pulling me in tightly as he kissed me back. I pressed my cheek against his, half laughing, half weeping, oblivious to the nurses, to anything

except the man before me. Then, finally, I turned and walked downstairs, wiping my face, laughing at my tears, ignoring the curious faces of the people who passed.

The day was beautiful, even under strip-lights. Outside birds sang, a new morning dawned, people lived and grew and got better and looked forward to getting older. I bought a coffee and ate an over-sweet muffin and they tasted like the most delicious things I had ever had. I sent messages to my parents, to Treena, to Richard, telling him I would be in shortly. I texted Lily: *Thought you might want to know Sam is in hospital. He got shot but he's okay. I know he'd love it if you dropped him a card. Or even just a text if you're busy.*

The answer pinged back within seconds. I smiled. How did girls of that age type so quickly when they did everything else so slowly?

OMG. I just told the other girls and I'm basically now the coolest person they know. Seriously though give him my love. If you text me his details I'll get him a card after school. Oh and I'm sorry for showing off to him in my pants that time. I didn't mean it. Like not in a pervy way. Hope you guys are really happy. Xxx

I didn't wait to respond. I looked at the hospital cafeteria and the shuffling patients and the bright blue day through the skylight and my fingers hit the keys before I knew what I was saying.

I am.



CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Jake was waiting under the porch when I arrived at the Moving On Circle. It was raining heavily, dense clouds the colour of heather abruptly unleashing a thunderstorm that overwhelmed gutters and soaked me in the ten seconds it took to run across the car park.

‘Aren’t you going in? It’s filthy out –’

He stepped forward, and his lanky arms enfolded me in a swift, awkward hug as I reached the door.

‘Oh!’ I lifted my hands, not wanting to drip all over him.

He released me and took a step back. ‘Donna told us what you did. I just – you know – wanted to say thanks.’

His eyes were strained, and shadowed, and I realized what these last days must have been like for him, so close to having lost his mother. ‘He’s tough,’ I said.

‘He’s bloody Teflon,’ he said, and we laughed awkwardly, in the way British people do when they’re experiencing great emotion.

In the meeting, Jake spoke unusually volubly, about the fact that his girlfriend didn’t understand what grief was like for him. ‘She doesn’t get why some mornings I just want to stay in bed with the covers over my head. Or why I get a bit panicky about things happening to people I love. Literally nothing bad has happened to her. Ever. Even her pet rabbit is still alive and it’s, like, nine years old.’

‘I think people get bored of grief,’ said Natasha. ‘It’s like you’re allowed some unspoken allotted time – six months, maybe – and then they get faintly irritated that you’re not “better”. It’s like you’re being self-indulgent hanging on to your unhappiness.’

‘Yes!’ There was a murmur of agreement from around the circle.

‘I sometimes think it would be easier if we still had to wear widows’ weeds,’ said Daphne. ‘Then everyone could know you were still grieving.’

‘Maybe like learner plates, so, you know, you got a different set of colours after a year. Maybe move from black to a deep purple,’ said Leanne.

‘Coming up all the way to yellow when you were really happy again,’ Natasha grinned.

‘Oh, no. Yellow is awful with my complexion.’ Daphne smiled cautiously. ‘I’ll have to stay a bit miserable.’

I listened to their stories in the dank church hall – the tentative steps forward over tiny, emotional obstacles. Fred had joined a bowling league, and was enjoying having another reason to go out on Tuesdays, one that didn’t involve talking about his late wife. Sunil had agreed to let his mother introduce him to a distant cousin from Eltham. ‘I’m not really into the whole arranged-marriage thing but, to be honest, I’m having no luck with other methods. I keep telling myself she’s my mother. She’s hardly going to set me up with someone horrible.’

‘I think it’s a lovely idea,’ said Daphne. ‘My mother would probably have spotted which tree my Alan barked up long before I did. She was ever such a good judge.’

I viewed them as if I were on the outside of something looking in. I laughed at their jokes, winced internally at their tales of inappropriate tears or misjudged comments. But what became clear as I sat on my plastic chair and drank my instant coffee was that I had somehow found myself on the other side. I had crossed a bridge. Their struggle was no longer my struggle. It wasn’t that I would ever stop grieving for Will, or loving him, or missing him, but that my life seemed to have somehow landed back in the present. And it was with a growing satisfaction that I found, even as I sat there with people I now knew and trusted, I wanted to be somewhere else: beside a large man in a hospital bed who I knew, to my utter gratitude, would even now be glancing up at the clock in the corner, wondering how long it was going to take me to get to him.

‘Nothing from you tonight, Louisa?’

Marc was looking at me, one eyebrow raised.

I shook my head. ‘I’m good.’

He smiled, perhaps recognizing something in my tone. ‘Good.’

‘Yes. Actually, I think I don’t need to be here any more. I’m ... okay.’

‘I knew there was something different about you,’ said Natasha, leaning forwards and eyeing me almost suspiciously.

‘It’s the shagging,’ said Fred. ‘I’m sure that’s the cure. I bet I’d have got over Jilly much faster with all the shagging.’

Natasha and William exchanged a strange look.

‘I’d like to come until the end of the term, if it’s okay,’ I said to Marc. ‘It’s just ... I’ve come to think of you all as my friends. I might not need it, but I would still like to come for a bit longer. Just to make sure. And, you know, to see everyone.’

Jake gave a small smile.

‘We should probably go dancing,’ said Natasha.

‘You can come for as long as you want,’ said Marc. ‘That’s what we’re here for.’

My friends. A motley group, but then most friends are.

Orecchiette cooked *al dente*, pine-nuts, basil, home-grown tomatoes, olives, tuna and Parmesan cheese. I had made the pasta salad to the recipe Lily gave me over the phone as she was fed instructions by her grandmother.

‘Good invalid food,’ Camilla shouted, from some distant kitchen. ‘Easy to digest if he’s spending a lot of time lying down.’

‘I’d just buy him a takeaway,’ muttered Lily. ‘Poor man’s suffered enough.’ She cackled quietly. ‘Anyway, I thought you preferred him lying down.’

I walked along the hospital corridor later that evening feeling quietly proud of my little Tupperware box of domesticity. I had made this supper the night before and now carried it in front of me like a badge of honour, half hoping someone would stop me and ask what it was. *Yes, my boyfriend is recuperating. I bring him food every day. Just little things he might fancy. You know I grew these tomatoes myself?*

Sam’s wounds were beginning to heal, the internal damage clearing. He tried to get up too often, and was grumpy about being stuck in bed and worried about his animals, even though Donna, Jake and I had set up a reasonably good animal husbandry schedule.

Two to three weeks, the consultants reckoned. If he did what he was told. Given the extent of his injuries he had been lucky. More than one conversation had taken place in my presence where medical professionals had murmured, ‘A centimetre the other way and ...’ I sang la-la-la-la-la-la in my head during those conversations.

I reached his corridor and buzzed myself in, cleaning my hands with the antibacterial foam, as I pushed at the door with my hip.

‘Evening,’ said the nurse with glasses. ‘You’re late!’

‘Had to go to a meeting.’

‘You just missed his mum. She brought him the most delicious homemade steak and ale pie. You could smell it all the way down the ward. We’re still salivating.’

‘Oh.’ I lowered my box. ‘That’s nice.’

‘Good to see him tuck in. The consultant will be round in about half an hour.’

I was just about to put the Tupperware into my bag when my phone rang. I pressed answer, still wrestling with the zip.

‘Louisa?’

‘Yes?’

‘It’s Leonard Gopnik.’

It took me two seconds to register his name. I made to speak, then stood very still, glancing around me stupidly as if he could be somewhere nearby.

‘Mr Gopnik.’

‘I got your email.’

‘Right.’ I put the food container on the chair.

‘It was an interesting read. I was pretty surprised when you turned down my job offer. As was Nathan. You seemed suited to it.’

‘It’s like I said in my email. I did want it, Mr Gopnik, but I ... well ... things came up.’

‘So is this girl doing okay now?’

‘Lily. Yes. She’s in school. She’s happy. She’s with her family. Her new family. It was just a period of ... adjustment.’

‘You took that very seriously.’

‘I’m not the kind of person who can just leave someone behind.’

There was a long silence. I turned away from Sam’s room and gazed out of the window at the car park, watching as an oversized 4x4 tried and failed to negotiate its way into a too-small parking space. Forwards and backwards. I could see it wasn’t going to fit.

‘So here’s the thing, Louisa. It’s not working out with our new employee. She’s not happy. For whatever reason she and my wife are not really comfortable with each other. By mutual agreement she’s leaving at the end of the month. Which leaves me with a problem.’

I listened.

‘I would like to offer you the job. But I don’t like upheaval, especially when it involves people close to me. So I guess I’m calling because I’m trying to get a clear picture of what it is you actually want.’

‘Oh, I did really want it. But I –’

I felt a hand on my shoulder. I spun around, and there was Sam, leaning against the wall. ‘I – er –’

‘You got another position?’

‘I got a promotion.’

‘Is it a position you want to stay in?’

Sam was watching my face.

‘N-not necessarily. But –’

‘But obviously you have to weigh it all up. Okay. Well, I imagine that I’ve probably caught you by surprise with this call. But on the back of what you wrote me, if you’re genuinely still interested I’d like to offer you the job. Same terms, to start as soon as possible. That’s as long as you’re sure that it’s something you really want. Do you think you can let me know within forty-eight hours?’

‘Yes. Yes, Mr Gopnik. Thank you. Thank you for calling.’

I heard him click off. I looked up at Sam. He was wearing a hospital dressing gown over his too-short hospital nightshirt. Neither of us spoke for a moment.

‘You’re up. You should be in bed.’

‘I saw you through the window.’

‘One ill-timed breeze and those nurses are going to be talking about you till Christmas.’

‘Was that the New York guy?’

I felt, oddly, busted. I put my phone in my pocket and reached for the Tupperware container. ‘The position came up again.’ I watched his gaze slide briefly away from me. ‘But it’s ... I’ve only just got you back. So I’m going to say no. Look, do you think you can manage some pasta after your epic pie? I know you’re probably full, but it’s so rare that I manage to cook something that’s actually edible.’

‘No.’

‘It’s not that bad. You could at least try –’

‘Not the pasta. The job.’

We stared at each other. He ran his hand through his hair, glancing down the corridor. ‘You need to do this, Lou. You know it and I know it. You have to take it.’

‘I tried to leave home before, and I just got even more messed up.’

‘Because it was too soon. You were running away. This is different.’

I gazed up at him. I hated myself for realizing what I wanted to do. And I hated him for knowing it. We stood in the hospital corridor in silence. And then I saw he was rapidly losing colour from his face. 'You need to lie down.'

He didn't fight me. I took his arm and we made our way back to his bed. He winced as he lay back carefully on the pillows. I waited until I saw colour return to his face, then lay down beside him and took his hand.

'I feel like we just sorted it all out. You and me.' I laid my head against his shoulder, feeling my throat constrict.

'We did.'

'I don't want to be with anyone else, Sam.'

'Pfft. Like that was ever in doubt.'

'But long-distance relationships rarely survive.'

'So we are in a relationship?'

I started to protest and he smiled. 'I'm kidding. Some. *Some* don't survive. I'm guessing some do, though. I guess it depends how much both sides want to try.'

His big arm looped around my neck and pulled me to him. I realised I was crying. He wiped at my tears gently with his thumb. 'Lou, I don't know what will happen. Nobody ever does. You can set out one morning and step in front of a motorbike and your whole life can change. You can go to work on a routine job and get shot by a teenager who thinks that's what it takes to be a man.'

'You can fall off a tall building.'

'You can. Or you can go to visit a bloke wearing a nightie in a hospital bed and get the best job offer you can imagine. That's life. We don't know what will happen. Which is why we have to take our chances while we can. And ... I think this might be yours.'

I screwed my eyes shut, not wanting to hear him, not wanting to acknowledge the truth in what he was saying. I wiped at my eyes with the heels of my hands. He handed me a tissue and waited while I wiped the black smears from my face.

'Panda-eyes suit you.'

'I think I might be a bit in love with you.'

'I bet you say that to all the men in intensive care.'

I turned over and kissed him. When I opened my eyes again he was watching me.

‘I’ll give it a go, if you will,’ he said.

It took a moment for the lump in my throat to subside enough for me to be able to speak. ‘I don’t know, Sam.’

‘You don’t know what?’

‘Life is short, right? We both know that. Well, what if you’re my chance? What if you are the thing that’s actually going to make me happiest?’



CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

When people say autumn is their favourite time of year, I think it's days like this that they mean: a dawn mist, burning off to a crisp clear light; piles of leaves blown into corners; the agreeably musty smell of gently mouldering greenery. Some say you don't really notice the seasons in the city, that the endless grey buildings and the microclimate caused by traffic fumes mean there is never a huge difference; there is only inside and out, wet or dry. But on the roof it was clear. It wasn't just in the huge expanse of sky but in Lily's tomato plants, which had pushed out swollen red fruit for weeks, the hanging strawberry pots providing an intermittent array of occasional sweet treats. The flowers budded, bloomed and browned, the fresh green growth of early summer giving way to twiggy stalks and space where foliage had been. Up on the roof you could already detect the faintest hint in the breeze of the oncoming winter. An aeroplane was leaving a vapour trail across the sky and I noted that the streetlights were still on from the night before.

My mother emerged onto the roof in her slacks, gazing around her at the guests, and brushing moisture droplets from the fire escape off her trousers. 'It really is quite something, this space of yours, Louisa. You could fit a hundred people up here.' She was carrying a bag containing several bottles of champagne, and put it down carefully. 'Did I tell you, I think you're very brave getting up the confidence to come up here again?'

'I still can't believe you managed to fall off,' observed my sister, who had been refilling glasses. 'Only you could fall off a space this big.'

'Well, she was drunk as a lord, love, remember?' Mum headed back to the fire escape. 'Where did you get all the champagne from, Louisa? This looks awful grand.'

'My boss gave it to me.'

We had been cashing up a few nights previously, chatting (we chatted quite a lot now, especially since he'd had his baby. I knew more about Mrs Percival's water retention than I think she would have been entirely comfortable with). I had mentioned my plans and Richard had disappeared, as if he hadn't been listening. I had been ready to chalk it up as just another example of how Richard was still basically a bit of a wazzock, but when he

re-emerged from the cellars a few minutes later he was holding a crate containing half a dozen bottles of champagne. 'Here. Sixty per cent off. Last of the order.' He handed me the box and shrugged. 'Actually, sod it. Just take them. Go on. You've earned them.'

I had stuttered my thanks and he had muttered something about them being not a great vintage and the last of the line, but his ears had gone a tell-tale pink.

'You could try to sound a bit pleased that I didn't actually die.' I passed Treena a tray of glasses.

'Oh, I got over my "I wish I was an only child" thing ages ago. Well, maybe two years or so.'

Mum approached with a packet of napkins. She spoke in an exaggerated whisper: 'Now, do you think these will be okay?'

'Why wouldn't they be?'

'It's the Traynors, isn't it? They don't use paper napkins. They'll have linen ones. Probably with a coat of arms embroidered on them or something.'

'Mum, they've travelled to the roof of a former office block in east London. I don't think they're expecting silver service.'

'Oh,' said Treena. 'And I brought Thom's spare duvet and pillow. I thought we might as well start bringing bits and bobs down every time we come. I've got an appointment to look at that after-school club tomorrow.'

'It's wonderful that you've got it all sorted out, girls. Treena, if you like, I'll mind Thom for you. Just let me know.'

We worked around each other, setting out glasses and paper plates, until Mum disappeared to fetch more inadequate napkins. I lowered my voice so that she couldn't hear. 'Treen? Is Dad really not coming?'

My sister grimaced, and I tried not to look as dismayed as I felt.

'Is it really no better?'

'I'm hoping that when I'm gone they'll have to talk to each other. They just skirt around each other and talk to me or Thom most of the time. It's maddening. Mum's pretending she doesn't care that he didn't come down with us, but I know she does.'

'I really thought he'd be here.'

I had seen my mother twice since the shooting. She had signed up for a new course – modern English poetry – at the adult education centre and now grew wistful at symbols everywhere. Every blown leaf was a sign of

impending decrepitude, every airborne bird a sign of hopes and dreams. We had gone once to a live reading of poetry on the South Bank, where she had sat rapt and applauded twice into the silence, and once to the cinema, then on to the loos at the smart hotel, where she had shared sandwiches with Maria in the two easy chairs of the cloakroom. Both times, when we had found ourselves alone, she had been oddly brittle. ‘Well, aren’t we having a lovely time?’ she would say repeatedly, as if challenging me to disagree. And then she would grow quiet or exclaim about the insane price of sandwiches in London.

Treena pulled the bench across, plumping up the cushions she had brought up from downstairs. ‘It’s Granddad I worry about. He doesn’t like all the tension. He changes his socks four times a day and he’s broken two of the buttons on the remote control by over-pressing.’

‘God – there’s a thought. Who would get custody?’

My sister stared at me in horror.

‘Don’t look at me,’ we said in unison.

We were interrupted by the first of the Moving On Circle, Sunil and Leanne, emerging from the cast-iron steps, remarking on the size of the roof terrace, the unexpectedly magnificent view over the east of the City.

Lily arrived at twelve on the dot, throwing her arms around me and letting out a little growl of happiness. ‘I love that dress! You look completely gorgeous.’ She was sun-kissed, her face open and freckled, the tiny hairs on her arms bleached white, clad in a pale blue dress and gladiator sandals. I watched her as she gazed around the roof terrace, clearly delighted to be there again. Camilla, making her way slowly up the fire escape behind her, straightened her jacket and walked over to me, an expression of mild admonishment on her face. ‘You could have waited, Lily.’

‘Why? You’re not some old person.’

Camilla and I exchanged wry glances, and then, almost impulsively, I leaned forward and kissed her cheek. She smelt of expensive department stores and her hair was perfect. ‘It’s lovely that you came.’

‘You’ve even looked after my plants.’ Lily was examining everything. ‘I just assumed you’d kill them all. Oh, and this! I like these. Are they new?’ She pointed to two pots I had bought at the flower market the previous week, to decorate the roof for today. I hadn’t wanted cut flowers, or anything that might die.

‘They’re pelargoniums,’ said Camilla. ‘You won’t want to leave them up here over the winter.’

‘She could put fleece over them. Those terracotta pots are heavy to take down.’

‘They still won’t survive,’ said Camilla. ‘Too exposed.’

‘Actually,’ I said, ‘Thom’s coming to live here and we’re not sure he would be safe on the roof, given what happened to me, so we’re shutting it off. If you’d like to take those with you afterwards ...’

‘No,’ Lily said, after a moment’s thought. ‘Let’s leave it. It will be nice to just think of it like this. As it was.’

She helped me with a trestle table, and talked a little of school – she was happy there but struggling slightly with the work – and of her mother, who was apparently making eyes at a Spanish architect called Felipe, who had bought the house next door in St John’s Wood. ‘I feel almost sorry for Fuckface. He doesn’t know what’s about to hit him.’

‘But you’re okay?’ I said.

‘I’m fine. Life is pretty good.’ She popped a crisp into her mouth. ‘Granny made me go and see the new baby – did I tell you?’

I must have looked startled. ‘I know. But she said someone had to behave like a grown-up. She actually came with me. She was epically cool. I’m not meant to know but she bought a Jaeger jacket specially. I think she needed more confidence than she let on.’ She glanced over at Camilla, who was chatting to Sam over by the food table. ‘Actually, I felt a bit sad for my grandfather. When he thought nobody was looking he kept gazing at her, like he felt a bit sad at how it had all turned out.’

‘And how was it?’

‘It’s a baby. I mean, they all look the same, don’t they? I think they were on their best behaviour, though. It was all a bit “And how is school, Lily? Would you like to fix a date to come and stay? And would you like to hold your aunt?” Like *that* doesn’t sound completely weird.’

‘You’ll go and see them again?’

‘Probably. They’re all right, I suppose.’

I glanced over at Georgina, who was talking politely to her father. He laughed, slightly too loudly. He had barely left her side since she had arrived. ‘He calls me twice a week to chat about stuff, and Della keeps going on about how she wants me and the baby to “build a relationship”,

like a baby can do anything except eat and scream and poo.’ She pulled a face.

I laughed.

‘What?’ she said.

‘Nothing,’ I said. ‘It’s just good to see you.’

‘Oh. And I brought you something.’

I waited as she pulled a little box out of her bag, and handed it to me. ‘I saw it at this totally tedious antiques fair that Granny made me go to and I thought of you.’

I opened the box carefully. Inside, on dark blue velvet, was an art-deco bracelet, its cylindrical beads alternate jet and amber. I picked it up and held it in my palm.

‘It’s a bit out there, right? But it reminded me of –’

‘The tights.’

‘The tights. It’s a thank-you. Just – you know – for everything. You’re about the only person I know who would like it. Or me, for that matter. Back then. Actually, it totally goes with your dress.’

I held out an arm and she put it on my wrist. I rotated it slowly. ‘I love it.’

She kicked at something on the ground, her face briefly serious. ‘Well, I think I kind of owe you some jewellery.’

‘You owe me nothing.’

I looked at Lily, with her new confidence and her father’s eyes, and thought of everything she had given me without even knowing it. And then she punched me quite hard on the arm. ‘Right. Stop being all weird and emotional. Or you’re totally going to ruin my mascara. Let’s go downstairs and fetch the last of the food. Ugh, did you know there’s a Transformers poster gone up in my bedroom? And one of Katy Perry? Who the *hell* have you got as a new flatmate?’

The rest of the Moving On Circle arrived, making their way with varying degrees of trepidation or laughter up the iron steps – Daphne stepping onto the roof with loud exclamations of relief, Fred holding her arm, William vaulting nonchalantly over the last step, Natasha rolling her eyes behind him. Others paused to exclaim at the bundle of white helium balloons, bobbing in the thin light. Marc kissed my hand and told me it was the first time something like this had taken place the whole time he had been

running the group. Natasha and William, I noticed with amusement, spent a lot of time talking alone.

We put the food on the trestle table and Jake was on bar duty, pouring the champagne and looking curiously pleased at the responsibility. He and Lily had skirted around each other at first, pretending the other was invisible, as teenagers do when they're in a small gathering and conscious that everyone will be waiting for them to speak to each other. When she finally made her way over to him she shoved out her hand with exaggerated courtesy and he looked at it for a moment before giving a slow smile.

'Half of me would like them to be friends. The other can think of nothing more terrifying,' Sam murmured into my ear.

I slid my hand into his back pocket. 'She's happy.'

'She's gorgeous. And he's just split up with his girlfriend.'

'What happened to living life to the full, mister?'

He let out a low growl.

'He's safe. She's now tucked away in Oxfordshire for most of the year.'

'Nobody's safe with you two.' He lowered his head and kissed me and I let everything else disappear for a luxurious second or two. 'I like that dress.'

'Not too frivolous?' I held out the pleats of the striped skirt. This part of London was full of vintage-clothes stores. I had spent the previous Saturday lost in rails of ancient silks and feathers.

'I like frivolous. Although I'm a bit sad that you're not wearing your sexy pixie thing.' He stepped back from me as my mother approached, bearing another pack of paper napkins.

'How are you, Sam? Still healing up nicely?' She had visited Sam twice in hospital. She had become deeply concerned at the plight of those left to rely on hospital catering and brought him homemade sausage rolls and egg-mayonnaise sandwiches.

'Getting there, thanks.'

'Don't you do too much today. No carrying. The girls and I can manage just fine.'

'We should probably start,' I said.

Mum glanced again at her watch, then scanned the roof terrace. 'Shall we give it another five minutes? Make sure everyone gets a drink?'

Her smile – fixed and too bright – was heartbreaking. Sam saw it. He stepped forward and took her arm. 'Josie, do you think you could show me

where you've put the salads? I just remembered I didn't bring the dressing from downstairs.'

'Where is she?'

A ripple passed through the small crowd by the table. We turned towards the bellowing voice. 'Jesus Christ, is it really up here, or is Thommo sending me on another wild-goose chase?'

'Bernard!' My mother put down the napkins.

My father's face appeared above the parapet, scanning the rooftop. He climbed the last of the iron steps and blew out his cheeks as he surveyed the view. A light film of sweat shone on his forehead. 'Why you had to do the damn thing all the way up here, Louisa, I have no idea. Jaysus.'

'Bernard!'

'It's not a church, Josie. And I have an important message.'

Mum gazed around her. 'Bernard. Now is not the –'

'And my message is – *these*.'

My father bent over and with exaggerated care pulled up his trouser legs. First the left, and then the right. From my position on the other side of the water tank I could see that his shins were pale and faintly blotchy. The rooftop fell silent. Everyone stared. He extended one leg. 'Smooth as a baby's backside. Go on, Josie, feel them.'

My mother took a nervous step forward and stooped, sliding her fingers up my father's shin. She patted her hand around it.

'You said you'd take me seriously if I had my legs waxed. Well, there you are. I've done it.'

My mother stared at him in disbelief. 'You got your *legs* waxed?'

'I did. And if I'd had any idea you were going through pain like that, love, I would have kept my stupid mouth shut. What fucking torture is that? Who the hell thinks *that* is a good idea?'

'Bernard –'

'I don't care. I've been through hell, Josie. But I'd do it again if it means we can get things back on track. I miss you. *So much*. I don't care if you want to do a hundred college courses – feminist politics, Middle Eastern studies, macramé for dogs, whatever – as long as we're together. And to prove to you exactly how far I'd go for you, I've booked myself in again next week, for a back, sack and – What is it?'

'Crack,' said my sister, unhappily.

'Oh, God.' My mother's hand flew to her neck.

Beside me Sam had started to shake silently. ‘Stop them,’ he murmured. ‘I’m going to bust my stitches.’

‘I’ll do the lot. I’ll go the full-plucked ruddy chicken if it shows you what you mean to me.’

‘Oh, my days, Bernard.’

‘I mean it, Josie. That’s how desperate I am.’

‘And this is why our family doesn’t do romance,’ muttered Treena.

‘What’s a crack, back and wax?’ asked Thomas.

‘Oh, love, I’ve missed the bones of you.’ My mother put her arms around my father’s neck and kissed him. The relief on his face was almost palpable. He buried his head in her shoulder and then he kissed her again, her ear, her hair, holding her hands, like a small boy.

‘Gross,’ said Thomas.

‘So I don’t have to do the –’

My mother stroked my father’s cheek. ‘We’ll cancel your appointment first thing.’

My father visibly relaxed.

‘Well,’ I said, when the commotion had died down, and it was clear from Camilla Traynor’s blanched complexion that Lily had just explained to her exactly what my father had planned to endure in the name of love, ‘I think we should do one last check of everyone’s glasses, and then maybe ... we should start?’

What with the merriment over Dad’s grand gesture, Baby Traynor’s explosive nappy change, and the revelation that Thomas had been dropping egg sandwiches onto Mr Antony Gardiner’s balcony (and his brand-new replacement Conran wicker-effect sun chair) below, it was another twenty minutes before the rooftop grew silent. Amid some surreptitious scanning of notes and clearing of throats, Marc stepped into the middle. He was taller than I’d thought – I had only ever seen him sitting down.

‘Welcome, everyone. First, I’d like to thank Louisa for offering us this lovely space for our end-of-term ceremony. There’s something rather appropriate about being this much closer to the heavens ...’ He paused for laughter. ‘This is an unusual final ceremony for us – for the first time we have some faces here who aren’t part of the group – but I think it’s a rather lovely idea to open up and celebrate among friends. Everyone here knows what it’s like to have loved and lost. So we’re all honorary members of the group today.’

Jake stood beside his father, a freckle-faced, sandy-haired man, who, unfortunately, I couldn't look at without picturing him weeping after coitus. Now he reached out and gently pulled his son to him. Jake caught my eye and rolled his. But he smiled.

'I like to say that although we're called the Moving On Circle, none of us moves on without a backward look. We move on always carrying with us those we have lost. What we aim to do in our little group is ensure that carrying them is not a burden that feels impossible to bear, a weight keeping us stuck in the same place. We want their presence to feel like a gift.

'And what we learn through sharing our memories and our sadnesses and our little victories with each other is that it's okay to feel sad. Or lost. Or angry. It's okay to feel a whole host of things that other people might not understand, and often for a long time. Everyone has his or her own journey. We don't judge.'

'Except the biscuits,' muttered Fred. 'I judge those Rich Teas. They were shocking.'

'And that, impossible as it may feel at first, we will each get to a point where we can rejoice in the fact that every person we have discussed and mourned and grieved over was here, walking among us – and whether they were taken after six months or sixty years, we were lucky to have them.' He nodded. 'We were lucky to have them.'

I looked around the faces I had grown fond of, rapt with attention, and I thought of Will. I closed my eyes and recalled his face, his smile and his laugh, and thought of what loving him had cost me, but mostly of what he had given me.

Marc looked at our little group. Daphne dabbed surreptitiously at the corner of her eye. 'So ... what we usually do now is just say a few words acknowledging where we are. It doesn't have to be much. It's just a closing of a door on this little bit of your journey. And nobody has to do it, but if you do, it can be a nice thing.'

The group exchanged embarrassed smiles and, briefly, it seemed that nobody would say anything at all. Then Fred stepped up. He adjusted his handkerchief in his blazer pocket and straightened a little. 'I'd just like to say thank you, Jilly. You were a smashing wife and I was a lucky man for thirty-eight years. I will miss you every day, sweetheart.'

He stepped back, a little awkwardly, and Daphne mouthed, 'Very nice, Fred,' to him. She adjusted her silk scarf, and then she stepped forwards

too. 'I just wanted to say ... I'm sorry. To Alan. You were such a kind man, and I wish we'd been able to be honest about everything. I wish I'd been able to help you. I wish – well, I hope you're okay, and that – that you've got a nice friend, wherever you are.'

Fred patted Daphne's arm.

Jake rubbed the back of his neck, then stepped forward, blushing, and faced his father. 'We both miss you, Mum. But we're getting there. I don't want you to worry or anything.' When he finished his father hugged him, kissing the top of his head, and blinked hard. He and Sam exchanged small smiles of understanding.

Leanne and Sunil followed, each saying a few words, fixing their eyes on the sky to hide awkward tears or nodding silent encouragement at each other.

William stepped forward and silently placed a white rose at his feet. Unusually short of words, he gazed down at it briefly, his face impassive, then stepped back. Natasha gave him a little hug and he swallowed suddenly, audibly, then folded his arms across his chest.

Marc looked at me, and I felt Sam's hand close around mine. I smiled at him and shook my head. 'Not me. But Lily would like to say a few words, if that's okay.'

Lily was chewing her lip as she stepped into the middle. She glanced down at a bit of paper she had written on, then appeared to change her mind and screwed it into a ball. 'Um, I asked Louisa if I could do this even though, you know, I'm not a member of your group. I didn't know my dad in person and I never got to say goodbye to him at his funeral and I thought it would be nice to say a few words now that I sort of feel I know him a bit better.' She gave a nervous smile, and pushed a strand of hair from her face. 'So. Will ... Dad. When I first found out you were my real father, I'll be honest, I was a bit freaked out. I'd hoped my real dad was going to be this wise, handsome man, who would want to teach me stuff and protect me and take me on trips to show me amazing places that he loved. And what I actually got was an angry man in a wheelchair who just, you know, killed himself. But because of Lou, and your family, over the last few months I've come to understand you a bit better.

'I'll always be sad and maybe even a bit angry that I never got to meet you, but now I want to say thank you too. You gave me a lot, without knowing it. I think I'm like you in good ways – and probably a few not-so-

good ways. You gave me blue eyes and my hair colour and the fact that I think Marmite is revolting and the ability to do black ski runs and ... Well, apparently you also gave me a certain amount of moodiness – that's other people's opinion, by the way. Not mine.'

There was a little ripple of laughter.

'But mostly you gave me a family I didn't know I had. And that's cool. Because, to be honest, it wasn't going *that* well before they all turned up.' Her smile wavered.

'We're very happy *you* turned up,' Georgina called out.

I felt Sam's fingers squeeze mine. He wasn't meant to be standing so long but, typically, he refused to sit down. *I'm not a bloody invalid*. I let my head rest against him, fighting the lump that had risen to my throat.

'Thanks, G. So, um, Will ... *Dad*, I'm not going to go on and on because speeches are boring and also that baby is going to start wailing any minute, which will totally harsh the mood. But I just wanted to say thank you, from your daughter, and that I ... love you and I'll always miss you, and I hope if you're looking down, and you can see me, you're glad. That I exist. Because me being here sort of means *you're* still here, doesn't it?' Lily's voice cracked and her eyes filled with tears. Her gaze slid towards Camilla, who gave a small nod. Lily sniffed, and lifted her chin.

'I thought maybe now would be a good time for everyone to release their balloons?'

There was a barely perceptible release of breath, a few shuffled steps. Behind me the handful of members of the Moving On Circle murmured among themselves, reaching into the gently bobbing bundle for a string.

Lily was the first to step forward, holding her white helium balloon. She lifted her arm, then, as an afterthought, picked a tiny blue cornflower from one of her pots, and tied it carefully to the string. Then she raised her hand and, after the briefest hesitation, released the balloon.

I watched as Steven Traynor followed, saw Della's gentle squeeze of his arm. Camilla released hers, then Fred, Sunil, then Georgina, her arm linked with her mother's. My mother, Treena, Dad, blowing his nose noisily into his handkerchief, and Sam. We stood in silence on the roof and watched them sail upwards, one by one into the clear blue sky, growing smaller and smaller until they were somewhere infinite, unseen.

I let mine go.



CHAPTER THIRTY

The man in the salmon-coloured shirt was on his fourth Danish pastry, wedging great iced wads of it into his open mouth with chubby fingers, and periodically sluicing it down with a pint of cold lager. 'Breakfast of champions,' muttered Vera, as she walked past me with a tray of glasses and made a fake gagging noise. I felt a fleeting, reflexive gratitude that I was no longer in charge of the Gents.

'So, Lou! What does a man have to do to get some service around here?' A short distance away, Dad had perched himself on a stool and was leaning over the bar, examining the various beers. 'Do I need to show a boarding card to buy a drink?'

'Dad –'

'Quick trip to Alicante? What do you think, Josie? Fancy it?'

My mother nudged him. 'We should look into it this year. We really should.'

'You know, it's not a bad aul' place this. Once you get past the daft idea of actual kids being allowed in an actual pub.' Dad shuddered and glanced behind him to where a young family, their flight evidently delayed, had spread a mixture of Lego and raisins all over the table while they eked out two coffees. 'So what do you recommend, sweetheart, eh? What's good on the old pumps?'

I eyed Richard, who was approaching with his clipboard. 'It's all good, Dad.'

'Apart from those outfits,' said Mum, eyeing Vera's too-short green Lurex skirt.

'Head Office,' said Richard, who had already endured two conversations with my mother about the objectification of women in the workplace.

'Nothing to do with me.'

'You got any stout there, Richard?'

'We have Murphy's, Mr Clark. It's a lot like Guinness, although I wouldn't say as much to a purist.'

'I'm no purist, son. If it's wet and it says "beer" on the label it'll do for me.'

Dad smacked his lips in approval and the glass was set down in front of him. My mother accepted a coffee with her 'social' voice. She used it almost everywhere in London now, like a visiting dignitary being shown around a production line: *So that's a lah-tay, is it? Well, that looks simply lovely. And what a clever machine.*

My father patted the bar stool beside her. 'Come and sit down, Lou. Come on. Let me buy my daughter a drink.'

I glanced over at Richard. 'I'll have a coffee, Dad,' I said. 'Thank you.'

We sat at the bar in silence, as Richard served us, and my father made himself at home, as he did in every bar he ever sat in, nodding a greeting to fellow bar dwellers, settling on his stool as if it were his favourite easy chair. It was as if the presence of a row of optics and a hard surface on which to rest his elbows created an instant spiritual home. And at all times he kept within inches of my mother, patting her leg appreciatively or holding her hand. They barely left each other alone, these days, heads pressed together, giggling like teenagers. It was utterly revolting, according to my sister. She told me before she set off for work that she had almost preferred it when they weren't talking. 'I had to sleep with earplugs last Saturday. Can you imagine the horror? Granddad looked quite white over breakfast.'

Outside, a small passenger plane slowed on the runway and taxied towards the terminal, a man in a reflective jacket waving paddles to guide it in. Mum sat, handbag balanced on her lap, and gazed at it. 'Thom would love this,' she said. 'Wouldn't he love this, Bernard? I reckon he'd stand at that window all day.'

'Well, he can come now, can't he, now he's just up the road? Treena could bring him here at the weekend. I might come too if the beer's any good.'

'It's lovely what you've done, letting them come and stay in your flat.' Mum watched the plane disappear from view. 'You know this will make all the difference to Treena, with her starting salary and all.'

'Well. It made sense.'

'Much as we'll miss them, we know she can't live with us for ever. I know she appreciates it, love. Even if she doesn't always show it.'

I didn't really care that she didn't show it. I had realized something the moment she and Thom walked through my front door with their cases of belongings and posters, Dad behind them bearing the plastic crate of

Thom's favourite Predacons and Autobots. It was at that exact point that I finally felt okay about the flat Will's money had paid for.

'Did Louisa mention that her sister is moving down here, Richard?' My mother now operated on the basis that pretty much everyone she met in London was her friend, and therefore keen to hear all developments in the Clark household. She had spent ten minutes this morning advising Richard on his wife's mastitis, and couldn't see any reason why she shouldn't pop along and see his baby. Then again, Maria from the hotel toilets was actually coming for tea in Stortfold in two weeks' time, with her daughter, so she wasn't entirely wrong. 'Our Katrina's a great girl. Smart as a whip. If you ever need any help with your accounts, she's your woman.'

'I'll bear it in mind.' Richard's gaze met mine and slid away.

I glanced up at the clock. A quarter to twelve. Something inside me fluttered.

'You all right, love?'

You had to hand it to her. My mother never missed a thing.

'I'm fine, Mum.'

She squeezed my hand. 'I'm so proud of you. You know that, don't you? Everything you've achieved these past few months. I know it hasn't been easy.' And then she pointed. 'Oh, look! I knew he'd come. There you go, sweetheart. This is it!'

And there he was. A head taller than everyone else, and walking a little tentatively through the crowd, his arm braced slightly in front of him, as if he were wary even now that someone would bump into him. I saw him before he saw me, and my face broke into a spontaneous smile. I waved vigorously, and he saw me, and gave a nod.

When I turned back to my mother she was watching me, a small smile playing around her lips. 'He's a good one, that one.'

'I know.'

She gazed at me for the longest time, her face a mixture of pride and something a little more complicated. She patted my hand. 'Right,' she said, climbing off her bar stool. 'Time to have your adventures.'

I left my parents at the bar. It was better that way. It was hard to get emotional in front of a man who liked to quote sections of the managerial handbook for LOLs. Sam had a brief chat with my parents – my father kept breaking in with occasional *nee-naw* noises – and Richard asked after

Sam's injuries and laughed nervously when Dad mentioned that at least he'd done better than my last boyfriend. It took three goes for Dad to convince Richard that, no, he wasn't joking about Dignitas, and a terribly sad business it had all been. That might have been the point at which Richard decided he was actually quite glad I was leaving.

I extricated myself from Mum's embrace, and we walked across the concourse in silence, my arm linked in Sam's, trying to ignore the fact that my heart was thumping and that my parents were probably still watching me. I turned to Sam, faintly panicked. I'd thought we would have more time.

He looked at his watch and up at the departures board. 'They're playing your tune.' He handed over my little wheeled case. I took it and tried to raise a smile.

'Nice travelling threads.'

I looked down at my leopard-print shirt, and the Jackie O sunglasses I had tucked into my top pocket. 'I was going for a 1970s jet-set vibe.'

'It's a good look. For a jet-setter.'

'So,' I said. 'I'll see you in four weeks ... It's meant to be nice in New York in the autumn.'

'It'll be nice whatever.' He shook his head. 'Jesus. "Nice". I hate the word "nice".'

I looked down at our hands, which were entwined. I found myself staring at them, as if I had to memorize how his felt against mine, as if I had failed to revise for some vital exam that had come too soon. A strange panic was welling inside me, and I think he felt it because he squeezed my fingers.

'Got everything?' He nodded towards my other hand. 'Passport? Boarding pass? Address of where you're going?'

'Nathan is meeting me at JFK.'

I didn't want to let him go. I felt like a magnet gone awry, being pulled between two poles. I stood aside as other couples stepped towards Departures together, towards their adventures, or extracted themselves tearfully from each other's arms.

He was watching them too. He stepped back from me gently, and kissed my fingers before releasing my hand. 'Time to go,' he said.

I had a million things to say and none I knew how. I stepped forward and kissed him, like people kiss at airports, full of love and desperate longing, kisses that must imprint themselves on their recipient for the journey, the

weeks, the months ahead. With that kiss, I tried to tell him the enormity of what he meant to me. I tried to show him that he was the answer to a question I hadn't even known I had been asking. I tried to thank him for wanting me to be me, more than he wanted to make me stay. In truth I probably just told him I'd drunk two large coffees without brushing my teeth.

'You take care,' I said. 'Don't rush back to work. And don't do any building stuff.'

'My brother's coming to take over the brickwork tomorrow.'

'And if you do go back, don't get hurt. You are totally crap on the not-getting-shot thing.'

'Lou. I'm going to be fine.'

'I mean it. I'm going to email Donna when I get to New York and tell her I'll hold her personally responsible if anything else happens to you. Or maybe I'll just tell your boss to put you on desk duty. Or send you to some really sleepy station in north Norfolk. Or maybe make you wear bulletproof vests. Have they thought of issuing bulletproof vests? I bet I could buy a good one in New York if –'

'Louisa.' He pushed a lock of hair back from my eyes. And I felt my face crumple. I placed it against his and clenched my jaw and breathed in the scent of him, trying to embed some of that solidity into myself. And then, before I could change my mind, I let out a strangled 'Bye' that might have been a sob or a cough or a stupid half-laugh, I'm not sure even I could tell. And I turned and walked briskly towards security, pulling my case behind me, before I could change my mind.

I flashed the new passport, the ESTA that was my key to my future at a uniformed official, whose face I could barely make out through my tears. And then as I was waved through, almost on impulse, I spun on my heel. There he was, standing against the barrier, still watching. We locked eyes, and he lifted a hand, his palm open, and I lifted mine slowly in return. I fixed that image of him in my imagination – the way he tilted forward, the light on his hair, the steady way he always looked at me – somewhere where I could draw it up on lonely days. Because there would be lonely days. And bad days. And days when I wondered what the hell I had just agreed to be part of. Because that was all part of the adventure too.

I love you, I mouthed, not sure if he could even see the words from here. And then, holding my passport tight in my hand, I turned away.

He would be there, watching as my plane gathered speed and lifted into the great blue sky beyond. And, with luck, he would be there, waiting, when I came home again.

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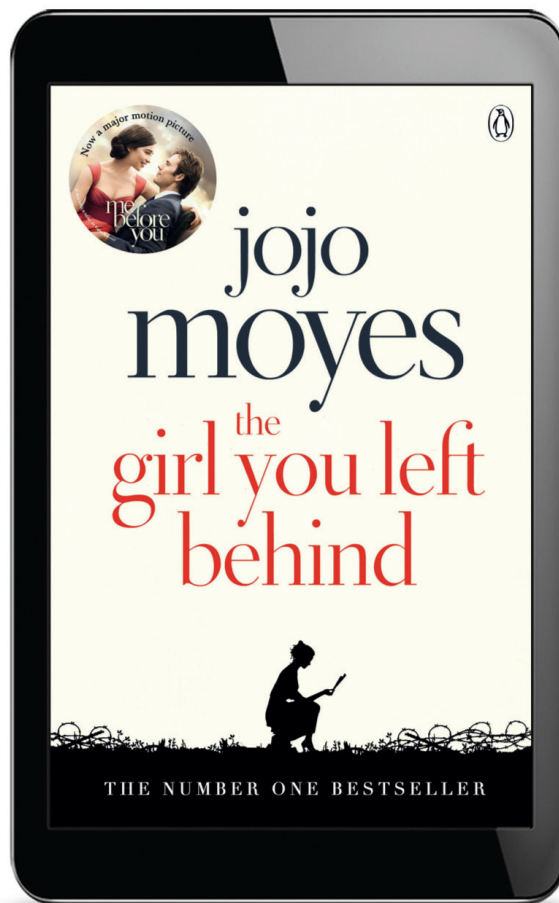
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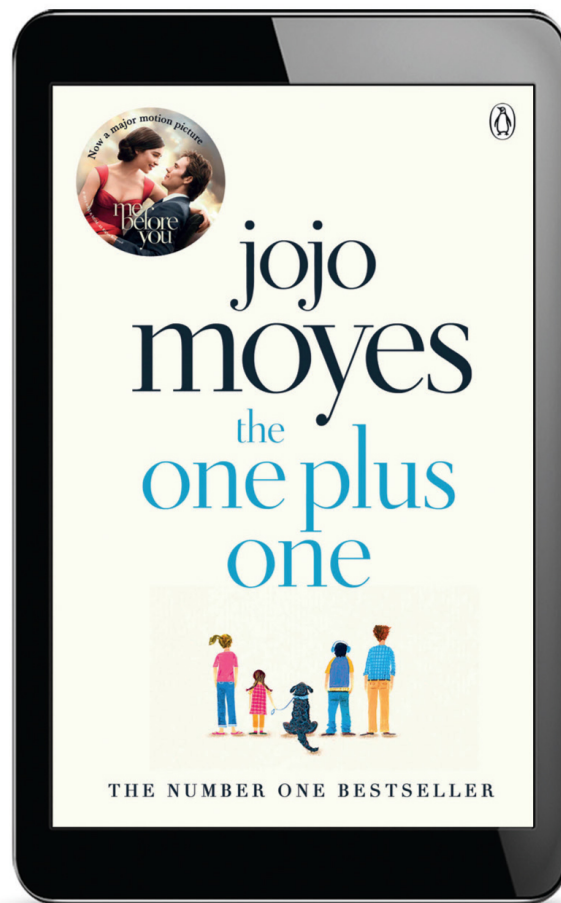


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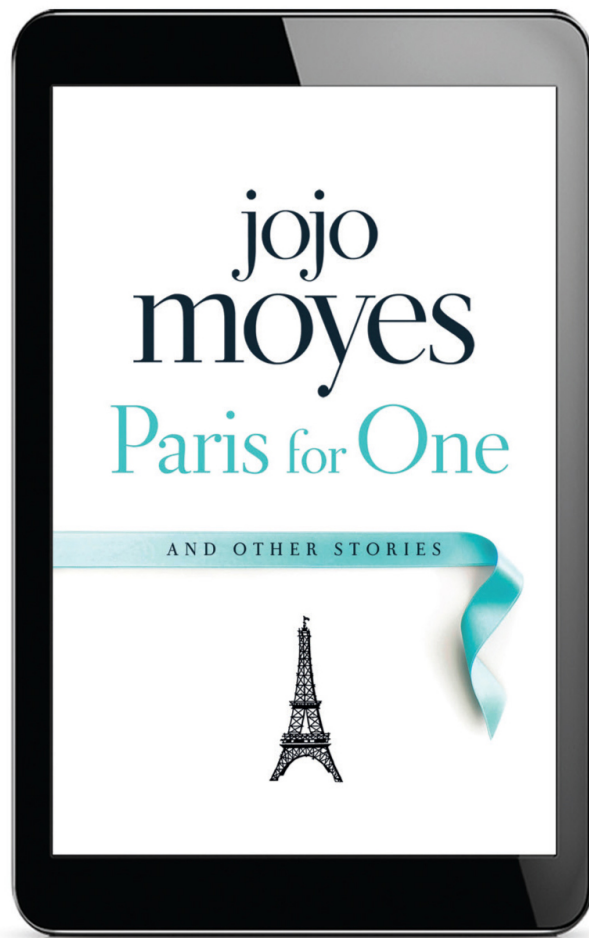


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